

Pure Dhamma

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Website : <http://www.puredhamma.net>

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Pure Dhamma

A Quest to Recover Buddha's True Teachings

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Welcome!

This is a site dedicated to explore the Dhamma or the “laws of nature” as discovered by the Buddha 2500 years ago. Even though I am a Buddhist by birth, I never bothered to look into the question of why I was a Buddhist. When I retired several years ago, I first started reading widely on many subjects, including science, philosophy, and religion.

- When I started to glean the deep message of the Buddha, I realized that I had not known much about my own “religion”, and that it had been “contaminated” over its long history. For the past several years, I have been working exclusively on trying to find the essence of the message of the Buddha. This is the result of that effort, which I wanted to share with the rest of the world.

There seem to be three types of people who become interested in “Buddhism”:

1. Those who have gone through hardships see that there is suffering “in this world”, and seeking solutions.
2. Those who are getting to the old age and are beginning to see that despite a lot of struggles,

there are signs that whatever that has been achieved so far is masked by possible problems looming in the future (aging, various ailments, not been able to get satisfaction from those things that provided satisfaction before, etc).

3. Those who are intellectually motivated. They have been exposed to Dhammapada verses or some other types of sayings by the Buddha which appear to provide a glimpse of a broader world view.

And some of those have been to meditation retreats and have realized that there is indeed a second option compared to seeking material wealth and indulging in sense pleasures. Especially for those people in categories 1 and 2, it becomes clear that indulging in sense pleasures does not have staying power. On the other hand, the sense of well-being achieved via meditation has the staying power, and does not go down as one gets old.

- I believe that for people in any category, it is a good idea to first understand what the Buddha's message was. Those who are intellectually motivated will be able to get a more complete picture, and thus a better intellectual satisfaction. For those in categories 1 and 2, a much better idea of how to focus their efforts will become clear with an insight into why focusing efforts on purifying the mind will be beneficial.

My belief is that anyone could benefit in some way by first getting a more complete overview of the Buddha Dhamma, which is about a "world" that is much more expansive and complex than the one we perceive with our senses.

This website got started in early January 2014. It may take several months just to publish the "essential material". I am still thinking about how best to present the material, so I may have to change this layout.

- Even though I discuss many "scientific aspects" (especially in the Dhamma and Science section) to illustrate that Buddha Dhamma is really a complete world view that has withstood all scrutiny for 2500 years, the my main goal is to convey the benefits of actual practice.

I have experienced much of what is discussed here, and the reason that I started this website is to share that experience with anyone who is interested. The "practice" part will come out as I lay down the basic ideas. To practice something, one needs to know what to practice. **(Note added 5/29/14: I have posted the first few essays on meditation under "[Bhāvanā \(Meditation\)](#)"; 11/6/14: The first 12 posts are completed in providing a meditation program that one could follow systematically; my own experience is briefly discussed in the 10th and 11th posts).**

- Buddha Dhamma is NOT a religion to be followed by following rituals or even blindly following precepts. It describes laws of nature that need be "grasped" and "lived". Dhamma means "to bear", to bear something it needs to be grasped (understood); then it becomes clear WHY one's life needs to be lived in a certain way.
- This is not a blog, but a Content Management System (CMS). The material does not belong to me, but to the Buddha. What I try to do is to keep the information accurate to the best of my ability. I will be making changes to the format and even the contents either to revise as needed or to present better. So, please make sure to go back and read "old topics" once-in-a-while.
- Also, one really needs to contemplate on the ideas presented; just quickly going through may not yield much benefit.

Another aspect that I try to highlight is the CONSISTENCY of Buddha Dhamma. You will see links from any given area to many other areas. The Buddha is called “Bhaghavath” because he analyzed the same thing in many different ways; AND they are all consistent internally as well as with the main axioms such as the 31 realms of existence, concept of kamma, and rebirth.

- As science has progressed, mainly over the past hundred or so years, the consistency with science is becoming apparent as well; but science has not grasped the importance of the mind (over matter) yet.
- Please send your suggestions/comments/questions and also let me know of any technical issues with the site using the “Comments” tab. I do not plan to have a discussion forum, so your comments will not be published. Since it takes too much time, I do not read comments that do not provide a return e-mail address. I will respond to comments, even though they are not published on the site.
- I normally write about ten essays a month and they are listed in the “New/Revised Posts” in the menu on the right. Interesting/relevant news articles are also added to that menu.

The Buddha said, “*Sabba dānan Dhamma dānan jināti*”, or “Gift of Dhamma excels all other gifts”. Please inform others about this site if you benefit from it.

However, we should only inform others. Mankind has suffered enough from those who have tried to force their views on others. As the Buddha said, “Come and see for yourself!”.

Note added 4/30/15: Several people requested the font size to be increased (not possible for me to do), and Seng Kiat Ng from Singapore suggested: [How to Zoom Text in Your Browser](#). Much merits to him and family for this simple solution!

There are two other possible solutions as well: 1. Each post can be printed using the PRINT button below that post. 2. All the posts at the site can be downloaded using three eBook formats and can be either printed or read on electronic readers like Amazon Kindle: [Pure Dhamma Essays in Book Format](#).

Continue to, “[What is Buddha Dhamma?](#)“

Buddha Dhamma

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What is Buddha Dhamma?

Introduction

1. Newton discovered the three laws of motion which helped describe gravity. Instead of re-discovering them, we learn them at school. We have to learn them from a teacher, who in turn had earlier learnt them from someone else. (Please excuse me for using “science examples”. You really do not need to know any science here; a science background may be helpful mainly in the “Dhamma and Science” section, but even there it is not necessary).
2. If we learn the laws of motion from someone who does not really understand them, it is harder to learn, and in some cases we may learn it incorrectly. This is definitely true for a bit harder subject, say, relativity. If the person who explains does not have a good understanding of the theory of relativity, then it is likely that the person who learns it will not learn much.
3. As I build up this site anyone will be able to see that Buddha Dhamma is the ultimate Grand Unified Theory. It explains everything not only that we can see, but also the existence of infinite number of worlds with living beings in 29 other realms of existence (other than the human and animal realms) that we cannot see.
 - Thus Buddha Dhamma is not a religion in the sense of providing salvation. The Buddha was not a God, a prophet or a messenger. He was a human being who purified his mind to perfection so that he could see the whole of existence. He was the perfect scientist, who investigated the problem of existence and found the complete solution. We all need to find our salvation by following the Path that he prescribed to purify our minds.
4. Thus Buddha Dhamma is the most complex theory of “this world”. It is called “*pubbe anusussetu dhammesu*” or a Dhamma (or a theory on nature) that is not known to the world before a Buddha comes along.
 - However, it has “evolved” in to many different versions since the Buddha Gotama revealed it to the world over 2500 years ago.
 - During the past 2500 years many different versions of “Buddhism” have emerged; see, “[Historical Background – Introduction](#)“. It is not possible for anyone to claim, “this is the original version that was delivered by the Buddha”. It is up to each individual to examine different versions and decide which version makes sense.
 - Thus it pays to spend some time and try to find the version(s) closest to the original. This is not an easy task these days. My goal is to present the closest version that I found. It is up to you to examine it and see whether you agree.
5. No matter which version (or a combination) you settle on, make sure to settle on some kind of a clear path. Many people try to follow many different paths (all labelled Dhamma or “Buddhism”), afraid that they may “miss out something”, or just follow whatever is recommended by a trusted person. That would be a waste of time. The way I handled this situation was to discard those versions that have contradictions; see, “[Dhamma and Science](#)“.
6. It is first necessary to find out what the main message of the Buddha was. Why did he say “this world is *dukkha*?”; see, “[Anatta and Dukkha – True Meanings](#)“. It is important to realize that ***dukkha*** is not the **feeling** of suffering; that is ***dukha***.

- If one did not know that he was talking about a much “bigger world” than the world we directly experience, one would think of that statement as nonsensical. The laws of kamma do not make sense unless one at least knows that the Buddha was talking about a rebirth process that has no beginning.

7. Thus one cannot even begin to follow Buddha Dhamma unless one learns about the basic concepts that are summarized in this column (see the other sections below) and “[Key Dhamma Concepts](#)“. It will be quite beneficial to at least scan through the other sections, especially the “[Moral Living](#)” section as well. In fact, the first stage of *Nibbana* (*Sotapanna* stage) is attained just by fully comprehending the “world view of the Buddha”, because then one clearly sees the fruitlessness of seeking lasting happiness in “this world” of 31 realms.

8. Many people, who have been exposed to a bit of Buddha Dhamma, see that there is something good about it. So, they just go to a meditation center and try to get a dose of Dhamma in a meditation retreat over several days. It is good to do that initially, but if one sees there is much more to Dhamma than to attain some temporary relief from the stresses of this life, then one needs to spend a bit more time and learn the full message of the Buddha.

9. For those who have not had much exposure to Buddha Dhamma, it is better to spend some time in the “[Moral Living](#)” and “[Working Towards Good Rebirths](#)” sections, while contemplating on the material in the other top level menus.

Overview

1. Before one embarks on a journey, one needs to know what the journey is about, and what the destination is, and whether it is worthwhile to undertake the journey. Please be patient and first find out what Buddha Dhamma is about, the big picture, first. Please spend some time learning about the key message of the Buddha, before undertaking the journey. If one does not know where one is going (or the terrain), how can one reach the destination?

- Buddha Dhamma describes the true nature of “this world”. But “this world” does not just mean our life as a human. “This world” is unimaginably complex. Scientists admit that they are aware of only 5% of the things in this universe; see, “The 4 Percent Universe: Dark Matter, Dark Energy, and the Race to Discover the Rest of Reality”, by Richard Panek (2011). Also see, “[Dhamma and science](#)” section for details.
- Please be patient and read through the following sections to get a brief idea first. Getting the “whole picture” will take time.

2. The next question (especially when one sees that it is indeed a complex picture) that comes to one’s mind is that “How do I know this picture is right?”. One makes that decision based on one’s own experience. But even before that, one could get an good idea by treating Buddha Dhamma as a scientific theory. This is why the section on “[Dhamma and Science](#)” is important. So, please go back and forth between that section and the current section until you get an idea of what I am talking about.

- Please pay special attention to the rebirth process. This is the key idea in Dhamma. Many people say that rebirth is not bad, but they do not realize that the chance of rebirth as a human is extremely rare.
- As we will discuss below, there are 31 realms (or different kinds of existence); we can see only the human realm and the animal realm. Most are reborn in realms below the human realm where suffering is much worse. Scientists estimate that at any given time, there are 1 quadrillion

(1000 trillion) ants living on Earth; this means for each human, there are million ants. Compared to about 7 billion of human population, unimaginable number of other living species live on this planet.

- Even on our bodies we carry a large number of sentient beings: see, [“There are as many creatures on your body as there are people on Earth!”](#).
- Human population is insignificantly small compared to the animal population. Statistically, that gives an idea of “probability of a human birth”. We do not see the much higher populations in the other lower three realms because our minds are covered by defilements; if one develops jhanas and acquires abhinna powers, one can see beings in some of those realms.

3. Thus there are other beings, especially below the human realm, that we cannot see: [“Consciousness – A Dhamma Perspective”](#). The Buddha said that most beings are trapped in realms below the human realm. That is why he said “this world is filled with suffering”, and we need to strive diligently to stop the rebirth process, and to attain *Nibbana*.

- This is also why he said it is rare to be born a human. He once told the *Bhikkhus* that if we compare all the beings to the volume of the Earth, the human population corresponds to only the amount soil one can pick with a thumb. And only a human possesses a mind that can be used to attain *Nibbana*. Therefore, we should not let this opportunity to attain *Nibbana* (at least the *Sotapanna* stage) in this very life pass by.

4. Many people think Buddha Dhamma is pessimistic. The Buddha just revealed the suffering in “this world”; that is the true nature of the world. More importantly, he showed that there is a better type of happiness, called *niramisa sukha*, that one gains as one moves away from “this world” towards *Nibbana*; see, [“Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?”](#).

- This *niramisa sukha* increases gradually as one starts on the Noble Eightfold Path, and makes quantum jump at the first stage of *Nibbana*, the Stream Entry (*Sotapanna*) stage. There are three more levels and at the final level, Arahant, one becomes totally free from “this world” (no more rebirths) and attains *Nibbana*.
- Thus *Nibbana* is not just a promise to be fulfilled at death; it can be experienced in this very life. Please take this journey with me for a while and see for yourself. As the Buddha said, “Come and see for yourself”.

5. My goal is to provide at least some details of the complex world view that was provided by the Buddha, which has been muddled and distorted within the past 2500 years.

- “Our world” is much more complex than what is grasped by our senses; see, [“The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma”](#).
- And our lives do not end with this one; see, [“Evidence for Rebirth”](#).
- Those two facts constitute the basis of the true nature of existence, and need to be thought about critically; one cannot comprehend the message of the Buddha until one at least has some idea about this “big picture”.
- Many questions people have on concepts like *kamma*, morality, *Nibbana*, etc, as well as philosophical questions like “why I am here?”, or “why is the world the way it is?”, will have answers within this big picture. It is a complete world view, but it is up to each individual to determine whether it makes sense. As the Buddha pointed out, the stakes are very high and it is a

good idea to take time and critically evaluate this big picture.

Next, “[Foundation of Dhamma](#)“,.....

Foundation of Dhamma

If you have not read the introductory post, "[What is Buddha Dhamma?](#)", please read that first. It describes the unique aspects of Buddha Dhamma, in the sense that it is not a religion by some definitions and the Buddha was not a savior.

1. There are two co-existing facets of Buddha Dhamma:

- The Buddha said, "This Dhamma is unlike anything that the world has ever seen". [It really needs a paradigm change to get into the "new perspective about this world view of the Buddha"](#). One needs to be able to put aside all preconceived notions to understand the core message.
- However, the Buddha also said, "My Dhamma is good in the beginning, good in the middle, and good at the end". [There is something to be gained from Buddha Dhamma for people who just come to know about it to those who have really grasped the core concepts](#). This is why I have separated posts into three categories on the site.
- Many important terms, even whole suttas, can be interpreted at several levels, ranging from superficial to very deep meanings. As I build the site, I will try to give some examples. For example, the five precepts have much deeper meanings than the ones that are apparent. It is gratifying, and exhilarating, to see deeper meanings as one progresses. Thus, there is something to be gained at any level.

2. There are three basic ways to practice Dhamma:

- At the very basic level (see, "[Moral Living](#)"), one can find happiness or misery in this life itself according to the way one lives one's life. One whose actions are harmful to oneself or the others will be living in misery. Someone may seem to be living in luxury, but could be living in misery. We know about many wealthy/famous people who even committed suicide.
- At the next level, one leads a moral life and accumulates good kamma that could lead to a good life in the next birth. However, we need to keep in mind that even if one does not commit a single bad kamma, the next birth could be a bad one due to "bad kamma seeds" from previous lives; see, "[Working Towards Good Rebirths](#)".
- At the highest level, one will act to remove all defilements from one's mind so that the mind becomes liberated from the body which causes all suffering. Thus one will be working to achieve Nibbana, the unconditioned, permanent happiness; see, "[Seeking Nibbana](#)".

3. The site is organized at those three levels:

- Most people intuitively know the benefit of a moral life. Dhamma will help understand why, and even point to some possible improvements.
- When one lives a moral life and EXPERIENCES the benefit of that, one will be automatically drawn to think about whether there is a life after death. One reads about the evidence for/against this possibility. If the answer is "yes", then one can find possible ways to work towards a better life in the next birth. This is not much different from the moral behavior in above. It is just that one will learn a lot about "the world" that we live in.
- Once the second stage is achieved, some may want to at least explore the third stage. This is THE message of the Buddha, that no matter where one is born in the next life, there are NO guarantees that the lives after that will be suffering free. This is the path to Nibbana, to cease

suffering permanently.

4. Going straight to the third level will be like trying to get into high school without finishing the primary and secondary schooling.

- However, even if one has not even heard anything about Buddha Dhamma before, some may be already at the second stage, and few may even be ready for the third stage. This life did not start at this birth. Each of us have come a long way and have molded our character through countless lives in the past. Thus, even if one is unaware of it, one may already be mentally prepared to tackle the third stage. So, please look around and find a starting point that you are comfortable with; see, "[Where to Start on the Path?](#)". Only you know about yourself!

5. It is critical to realize that "knowledge" is not perfect at any level as long as one remains "in this world". Even though he was not talking about that, the famous physicist Richard Feynman illustrates this point well in this video:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?feature=player_embedded&v=KLoNA9IMb6A&x-yt-ts=1422579428&x-yt-cl=85114404

Let us take his example of someone slipping on ice. A drunk person stepping onto ice-covered surface does not even realize that it is icy and slippery. At the next level, an alert person knows that the surface is slippery, and thus will be careful. But if one needs to know why the icy-surface is slippery, then a bit of basic physics is needed to understand "why ice is slippery". It is not necessary to understand "why ice is slippery" if one has an uncontaminated mind; a sober person with a calm mind will take precautions when stepping on a icy surface. More complex situations require the cleansing of an "average mind" further. This is where Buddha Dhamma makes a difference.

6. Even though humans have an innate sense of what is right and what is wrong, human mind is polluted by the five hindrances (see, "[Key to Calming the Mind – The Five Hindrances](#)").

- Once Dhamma Theory is understood, just that understanding leads to the clearing up of some of these hindrances; furthermore, the logic of a moral life comes naturally out the Dhamma Theory. This understanding of the Dhamma Theory or at least some idea of what the basic foundations of Buddha Dhamma is CRITICAL and should be done before one starts "practicing" Dhamma.
- If one living a moral life reads about the Dhamma Theory, he/she may be motivated to explore the second stage, i.e., to think about the validity of the process of rebirth, which is a major axiom of Buddha Dhamma.
- When one LIVES a life with the belief that what one does in this life will affect how one will fare after this life, then one may realize the danger in this traversing this endless cycles of rebirths. That will lead to exploring the third stage, which is THE real message of the Buddha.

[7. No one can take anyone else to any meaningful mundane happiness with niramisa sukha \(in this life or next\) or to Nibbana.](#)

- The Buddha said, "*Attā hi attano nātho, kō hi nāthō paro siyā*", or, "*One indeed is one's own refuge; how can others be a refuge to one?*".
- Each one has one's own mind. And that is what is needed to be purified in order to attain a peaceful life now, a better life in the next, or even Nibbana. But others CAN help.

- It is entirely up to the individual. This site will help one find the right path.

Next, “[The Importance of Purifying the Mind](#)“,

The Importance of Purifying the Mind

Analysis of a given situation always needs to be taken in the proper context. Let us again listen to Dr. Feynman's video that was in the previous post.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=x-yt-cl=85114404&x-yt-ts=1422579428&v=KLoNA9IMb6A&feature=player_embedded

It is worthwhile to discuss the case of an icy surface to look a bit deeper than even Dr. Feynman did. He merely pointed out that there is no end to the sort of questions especially when a child keeps asking: "what is the reason for that?" at every step: "Why is Aunt Mimi in the hospital?" leads to the answer, "She fell on ice". Then, "Why did she fall on ice?" leads to "Because ice is slippery", which leads to, "Why is ice (and not concrete) slippery?".

Up to this point, the child (or an average adult) can understand each answer, BECAUSE based on their life experiences all those answers make sense. But the last question cannot be answered to the complete satisfaction of a child or an average adult, who does not have a background in physics: Unlike most other solids, ice has this peculiar property that when water is cooled, it expands when turning into ice. So, when Aunt Mimi stepped on ice, the pressure of her weight caused ice to shrink (i.e., become water), and thus a thin layer of water was formed between her shoes and ice, which causes her to slide and fall. Other solids tend to get more hardened under pressure, so there no slipping due to that particular cause.

- Now one DOES NOT need to know that bit of physics to avoid falling on ice. What was needed to avoid falling was to have a keen sense of knowing that ice is slippery and needed to take necessary precautions.
- May be Aunt Mimi was in an agitated state of mind and hurried out of the door without realizing that there was a thin sheet of ice on the driveway. If she was drunk, that would have also lead to the same result. If she was in a calm, relaxed state of mind, she would have been more careful.
- An agitated mind can be caused by excess greed and hate too. Most people do not realize this, but if we think back each of us can remember instances where we made bad decisions because of greedy or hateful state of mind. This is why getting into heated arguments can be risky, and people even kill in a moment of rage.

What the Buddha tried to convey was that we can truly understand the real nature of "this world" by "clearing up our minds". There are five things called hindrances that cause our minds to be clouded; see, "[Key to Calming the Mind – Five Hindrances](#)". These have accumulated via bad habits that we have developed over countless lives; see, for example, "[The Law of Attraction, Habits \(Gathi\), and Cravings \(Asavas\)](#)".

- Each one has a different set of bad habits, but we all have them. Yet we can function "in this world" with that "baseline"(for example not fall while walking on ice), if we do not make it worse by substance abuse, making the mind agitated (by getting angry or overly greedy), etc.

Thus what all of us would normally do is to live our lives in this "baseline state of the mind" which does not allow us to see the true nature of "this world". We are just carried by the tide without us trying to examine whether it is good idea to "just go with the flow", do our best to make our lives better, and eventually die without knowing that all those life struggles were in vain at the end.

The worse thing is that the story does not end at death, but just moves on to another phase (rebirth),

where we will be doing exactly the same again.

- We have gone through this unending process for innumerable lives, and most those have been much worse than our current human life. When one “sees” the fruitlessness of our struggles to seek happiness in a “world” that is inherently not able to provide that, then one will seek to get out “this world” by following the Noble Eightfold Path of the Buddha, and achieve permanent happiness.
- **This is the crux of the message of the Buddha.**

We will be able to “see” the truth of what was said in the above paragraph (i.e., the true nature of “this world”), if we start cleaning our minds to get rid of the five hindrances (see, “[How to Calm the Mind](#)”).

But to do that, first we need to be able to look at the wider view of “this world” of the Buddha. Many people plunge into “practicing Dhamma” without even having an idea of the “world view” of the Buddha. **How can one practice, if one does not know what the goal of the practice is?** The goal could be three fold:

1. to gain some kind of a peaceful state of mind in this life
2. looking at a more longer range, to make sure one will have a better life also in the upcoming births,
3. to be released from this cycle of rebirths filled with dissatisfaction, and to seek permanent happiness, Nibbana.

If the goal is one of the above three (and especially if (ii) and (iii)), then one needs to know what the complete “world view” of the Buddha was: This is the Buddha Dhamma.

It has been over 2500 years since the Buddha declared his message about the previously unknown wider world view. This has been distorted over these intervening time, and my goal is to provide a more sensible, logical view that is based on *Theravada* version.

Since many are “just looking”, and have no reason to believe the truth of this world view, I am going to present it as a theory. We will be continually testing this theory to see whether it meets the established scientific standards, because that is what I am used to as a scientist.

- Many people, especially in the earlier times, made that decision on the enhanced EXPERIENCE as they followed the Path; as one moves along the Path, this EXPERIENCE starts to transcend the sensory experience. There is crucial difference between the empiricism based on the sensory experience (which was the philosophical doctrine promoted by John Locke and others in the early days of scientific revolution), and the **vastly enhanced experience of a purified mind.**

Now, once one understands what this wider world view is, then one can see that the solution to our problem existence does not depend on trying to probe deeper into “What is the reason for that?” at each step in an endless loop. We just do not have enough time in this life to learn all that.

- [Rather it is just a matter of purifying our minds](#), so that the mind can “see” through one’s own **refined experience as one follows the Path.**

Put succinctly, the Buddha discovered that the solution to the problem of the existence is to “see” the true nature of “this world”; this is even more complex than what the science is finding out.

- But one only needs to see that “whole picture” and to realize that no matter where we are born, we will never find long lasting happiness “in this world”, because “this world” is inherently of the nature of ever-changing.
- Everything “in this world” is in a constant flux, but we cannot “see” that because our minds are cluttered with the five hindrances.

Now let us take a look at the other approach for “finding out all about this world”. This is the scientific approach (There are other religious approaches too, but I am going to stay away from that subject). This scientific approach started with the ancient Greeks, about at the same time that the Buddha lived.

- So, we have two approaches: the Buddha’s is totally mind-based; the scientific method is matter-based.
- Currently, most scientists are trying to figure out how the mind works in terms of the workings of brain, thought of as a very sophisticated computer. **The Buddha Dhamma is completely consistent with the material aspects of science (as we will discuss), but in Buddha Dhamma, mind actually precedes matter; matter is secondary.**

Let us go back to the case of slipping on ice that was discussed in Dr. Feynman’s video. In order to cope with an icy surface, all we need to know is to have prior EXPERIENCE with such a surface, and an alert mind (that is not distracted by alcohol, anger, lust, etc) to use that experience to cope with the situation. This is the mind approach.

- When one carefully examines the “world view” within the Buddha Dhamma, one will be able to see that the problem of the existence is reduced to understanding the ever-changing nature of the world, without examining each part in minute detail. ALL PARTS of this world are of impermanent nature, and thus one can never maintain anything to one’s liking for long times.
- **That is all one needs to perceive, to really understand, not just to read about. This simple task is the hardest; that is what requires an effort. But first one needs to read about this “world view”.**

On the other hand, one could keep going down the line of questions probing deeper to the causes as to why ice is slippery, why does water expand when it is cooled, the nature of chemical bonds, about electrons and protons, about quarks that make up those protons, etc.

- It is quite true that this probing has led to many technological advances that we all enjoy today. I can write something on this site and get it to you within minutes; it is amazing and very beneficial. But my point is that all this “probing deeper” has not gotten us any closer to the questions on the existence. **Right now science is approaching the limits of this probing, because now we know that all matter is just energy.**
- And even though we may benefit from the technological advances, such benefits can be enjoyed only for a brief moment (about 100 years) in the [samsaric time scale](#). Buddha Dhamma provides a long-term solution.

What the Buddha stated 2500 years ago was that, in the end, there is no benefit in probing deeper into material properties as far as one’s existence is concerned. All one needs to realize is that no matter what we achieve, they are all transitory, not stable. This cannot be done without purifying one’s mind.

- When one truly comprehends the three characteristics of existence (see, “[Anicca, Dukkha,](#)

[Anatta – True Meanings](#)“), and thus the unsatisfactory nature of this existence, one will not seek to gain “material things” but will endeavor to achieve Nibbana. **This only requires purification of one’s mind. It does not require examining the outside material world in detail.**

- [When one goes deeper into the Buddha Dhamma, it becomes clear that mind energy is the basis of all existence.](#) But that is a long story. We first need to get started and see whether the “broader world view” of the Buddha makes sense.

Next, [“The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma”](#),.....

The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma

According to Buddha Dhamma EVERYTHING in existence can be put into four ultimate constituents (*paramatta dhamma*):

- Thoughts (*citta*)
- Thought qualities or mental factors (*cetasika*)
- Matter (*rupa*)
- *Nibbana*

These entities will be described in detail in the [Tables and Summaries](#) and *Abhidhamma* sections; see, “[Abhidhamma – Introduction](#)“.

- All existence “in this world” can be described in terms of the first three. And they are all conditional, i.e., each is born due to the existence of a cause. If there is no cause, none of these three will arise. This is a fundamental cause and effect (*paticca samuppada*) in Buddha Dhamma.

It must be noted that “thought” is not a good translation for *citta*. It takes billions of *citta* to produce a brief sense experience. What we experience comes in “bundles” of *rupa*, *vedana*, *sanna*, *sankhara*, and *vinna*, i.e., *pancakkhandha*: we may see, hear, smell, taste, touch (all those are *rupa*), we experience “bundles” of feelings, perceptions, other mental attributes (greed, hate, compassion, etc), and also *vinna* (awareness). Any of these “bundles” that we experience is the result of billions of *cittas*; see, “[1. Thoughts \(Citta\), Consciousness \(Vinnana\), and Mind \(Hadaya Vatthu\) – Introduction](#)“, “[Abhidhamma – Introduction](#)“, and the follow-up posts.

The *citta* arise and decay at a very fast rate: **billions of *citta* arise and pass away each second**; these are called thought moments (*cittakkhana*) (see, “A Manual of Abhidhamma” by Bhikkhu Bodhi (2000), p. 156). *Cetasika* are “embedded” in each *citta*. There are 89 types of *cittas* in all, and 52 types of *cetasikas*; see, “[Tables and Summaries](#)“. Thus the mental realm is very complex. **Think about the fact that all biological matter is constituted from just four bases of DNA, and all computer codes are based on two units, 0 and 1.** Thus, one could see how complex the mind is when there are 89 types of *cittas* and 52 types of *cetasikas* are involved!

Matter (*rupa*) is constituted of 28 basic units, of which only four are truly fundamental (the “four great elements” (Pali: *cattāro mahābhūtāni*) are Earth element (*pruṭṭhavī-dhātu*); Water (or liquid) element (*āpa-dhātu*); Fire element (*teja-dhātu*); Air (or wind) element (*vāyu-dhātu*)). However, the smallest indivisible unit that anything in this world is made out of is called a “*suddhashtaka*“; see, “[Rupa – Generation Mechanisms](#)“. These *suddhashtaka* have very long lifetimes of a half a Maha kalpa. Any “tangible thing” in the universe is made out of these *suddhashtaka*, and those “composite things” are called *sankata*.

All *sankata* (everything that we sense) in “this world” is in constant re-generation (except “*nama gotta*“; see below). Our senses cannot discern this because of the sheer rapidity. It is like watching a movie. When a movie is projected on a screen, static pictures are projected at a rate of about 30 frames a second, and we see the movie as a continuous progression of events. As I said, *citta* and *rupa* re-generate at BILLIONS of frames a second.

Therefore, there is NOTHING “in this world” that is permanent (except “*nama gotta*“; see

below). Everything is constantly re-generating, and as the underlying conditions change, they change. This is the fundamental reason why nothing in “this world” can be maintained to one’s expectations. Some things can last longer than others, but nothing is permanent. Everything is **CONDITIONAL**, i.e., arises due to causes. When the causes are removed, it does not arise. Thus it is said that everything “in this world” is **CONDITIONED**.

- The only exception is “*nama gotta*” which are the permanent records of a given “lifestream”; see, “[Difference Between Dhamma and Sankhara \(Sankata\)](#)“. This is how one with abhinna powers can go back and look at one’s past lives; some children can recall their past lives too. That record is permanent.

However, constant rapid re-generation does NOT necessarily mean **RAPID** change. Different *sankata* have different lifetime. Thus a gold bar will not change significantly for millions of years. Significant changes in a human being occurs over several years, and a caterpillar changes to a butterfly over several days, etc. Still **NOTHING** in “this world” **REMAINS** the same forever.

Many people confuse “*udayavaya*” or formation and breakup of *sankata* means anything, including *suddhashtaka*, is incessantly in flux; they try to tie this with “impermanence” which they incorrectly translate *anicca* to be. In the contrary, *suddhashtaka* have very long lifetimes. It is only those “composites” such as humans, animals, trees, etc, that undergo decay and death at time scales that are discernible to us; a gold bar, does not decay for a very long time.

The “end result” of this *udayavaya* nature of all *sankata* was summarized by the Buddha as the Three Characteristics of “this world”: *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. But *anicca* is NOT impermanence, and *anatta* is NOT “no-self”; see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations](#)“. Briefly, (i) it is not possible to find AND maintain happiness in anything in “this world”, (ii) because of that we become distraught and suffer, and (iii) thus one becomes helpless (not in control). It is important to realize that these characterize not just this life, but our beginning-less rebirth process in “this wider world” of 31 realms described below.

- And all this is due to “*udayavaya*” of *sankata*, all that we experience; see, “[Root Cause of Anicca – Five Stages of a Sankata](#)“.
- *Nibbana*, on the other hand, is **UNCONDITIONED**. *Nibbana* is attained when all the causes are eliminated; thus is it permanent. When there is no arising, i.e., no existence in “this world”. *Nibbana* is attained at four steps or stages: Stream Entry (*Sotapanna*), Once-Returner (*Sakadagami*), Non-Returner (*Anagami*), *Arahant*. At each stage, a being is partially “removed” from ‘this world’, and is totally removed at the *Arahant* stage. However, an *Arahant* lives as a normal human being until death, and is not reborn anywhere in “this world” at death. We will discuss these in depth later, but let us first examine what the Buddha meant by “this world” in the next section.

Thirty One Planes of Existence

Here is a video from Carl Sagan to get an idea how vast our “detectable universe” is:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?x-yt-cl=85114404&feature=player_embedded&x-yt-ts=1422579428&v=5Ex_M-OwSA

The “world view” of the Buddha is not merely about the living beings on this planet. Our Solar system is one of an infinite number of “world systems” (planetary systems). In **EACH** planetary system with life (scientists have not found even one yet; but they are out there!), there are 31 “planes

of existence”. As we find out below, we can “see” only two of these realms: our human realm and the animal realm. Thus our “world” is much more complex than even the present-day science believes.

As some of you may already know, science cannot account for 95% of the mass of the universe, which they label “dark energy” and “dark matter”; see, “The 4 Percent Universe” by Richard Panek (2011), or do a Google search on “dark energy and dark matter”. This is why I say that the Buddha transcended “this world”; see, “[Power of the Human mind – Introduction](#)“. He was able to “see” the whole of existence: see “[Godel’s Incompleteness Theorem](#)” under “[Dhamma and Science](#)”.

A being in a given plane of existence is reborn in any of the 31 realms at death; this happens instantaneously and support for such a mechanism is slowly emerging from quantum mechanics; see, “[Quantum Entanglement – We are all Connected](#)“.

The Buddha has described these different realms of existence in many suttas, and a convenient summary has been presented at: “[The Thirty-one Planes of Existence](#)“. Now, it is not easy to describe in detail the 31 planes of existence in a short essay, and I will describe their various characteristics as needed in other posts. In the following I will use a visual to simplify things a bit and to provide a simple description of Nibbana with respect to this “wider world of existence”.

Imagine a sphere with 31 shells, with a small sphere in the middle. Thus the total volume of the big sphere is completely filled by the center sphere and surrounding shells. The 31 sections represent the 31 planes of existence. I emphasize that this is just a visual. The reality is different. For example, animal and human realms co-exist in reality. Also, both time and space are infinite in reality.

1. The innermost 11 shells represent the kamaloka, where all five physical sense faculties are present.
 - The innermost sphere represent the Niraya (hell) where there is non-stop suffering; next is the animal realm. Going outward there are two more realms where suffering is higher than at the human realm.
 - Human realm is the fifth shell. This is the last realm where greed, hate, and ignorance all prevail. However, this is unique in the sense that humans can also get rid of all those three and attain Nibbana.
 - The sixth through eleventh shells represent the realms of the devas (wrongly translated as gods by many). The Devas do not have dense bodies with flesh and blood, and thus they do not have the physical ailments. They do not generate greedy thoughts.
2. The next 16 shells represent realms where only two physical sense faculties (eye and ear) are active. These beings have very fine bodies, even less dense than Devas. These are called rupa lokas.
3. The last 4 shells represent the arupa lokas, where beings have ultra fine bodies and only the mind faculty; no physical senses.
4. In rupa and arupa lokas, the beings are in jhanic states, and those beings do not have either greed or hate.
 - These states can be attained by humans and thus a humans can “temporarily live” in those lokas by attaining jhanas; see, “[Power of the Human Mind – Anariya or Mundane Jhanas](#)“.
 - The 16 realms in the rupa loka correspond to the four lower jhanas, and the 4 realms in the arupa loka correspond to the four higher jhanas.
5. Now, a lot of you may be thinking “How do I know all this is true? Is there any evidence?”. There

are a lot of things we do not know about “this world”. We cannot rely on just science to verify/confirm these.

- Only within the last 50 years or so that science has accepted that our world is bigger than a few galaxies (now science has confirmed that there are billions of galaxies, AND there could be even multiple universes!).
- Furthermore, the newest findings (yet unconfirmed) in string theory indicate that we live in a 11-dimension world, not a 4-dimension world. For a fun look at different dimensions, see, [“What Happens in Other Dimensions”](#).

6. Any living being (including each of us) has been in all realms in this beginning-less sansara. We have been in the niraya (hell) and we have been at the highest (except on arupa loka which can be accessed only by Anagamis or Non-Returners). One time the Buddha pointed to a bunch of ants on the ground and told bhikkhus that each of those ants had lived in a Brahma loka. The sansara is that long; there is no discernible beginning.

7. Above the human realm, there is relatively less suffering (except at death, which is inevitable). However, unless one has achieved at least the Stream Entry (Sotapanna) stage, even a being at the highest level can fall to any lower level, and thus will end up in the niraya (hell) at some point; once there one will spend a long agonizing time there and eventually come out. Each of us have done this many times over. The cause of births in different realms can be explained in terms of “kamma seeds”; see, [“Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka”](#)).

8. So, each living being just moves from one realm to another, but spends most time in the four lower worlds, mainly because once fallen there it is hard to come out. This “sansaric wandering” is the critical point to think about and comprehend.

9. As one moves away from the center the level of suffering decreases, and level of mundane pleasure increases up to the 11th realm. After that in the rupa and arupa lokas it is mainly the jhanic pleasures, not the sense pleasures; see, [“Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?”](#).

10. The human realm and the animal realm are the only ones where a being is born to parents. In all other realms, beings are born instantaneously, formed fully, within an instant (cittakkhana) of dying in the previous life. *This is an opapatika birth*. This is why the Buddha said, “*mano pubbangama dhamma.....*”. The mind is the root cause, not matter.

11. A person who becomes an Arahant or attains Nibbana, will not be reborn in any of these 31 realms. Thus, Nibbana is not difficult to understand, and it can be looked at from different angles: see, [“Nibbana – Is it Difficult to Understand?”](#), and [“What are Rupa? Relation to Nibbana”](#).

- Nibbana, in the present model, corresponds to getting out of all 31 shells, out of the big sphere; no more rebirth in any of the 31 realms. Nibbana is where the permanent sukha or niramisa sukha, is.
- When one attains Nibbana or Arahant hood, he/she looks just like any other human, but has no attachments to any worldly things. He still has some kamma vipaka to pay off from the kamma seed that he was born with. When that kammic power is used up, he dies and is not reborn because there are no kamma seeds left to start a new birth. He/she is in Parinibbana with niramisa sukha.

12. Why are we trapped in the 31 realms? Because we perceive that there is happiness to be had in

“this world”. We are not aware that there is much suffering in the lower four realms; many people look at their lives and say, “where is this suffering the Buddha was talking about?”: It is the hidden suffering that is there not only in this world, but mostly in the lowest four realms. The problem is that once fallen there, it is hard to come back up, since in those realms – animal realm included – beings are more like robots; they do not have developed minds like humans and it is too late then.

- No one or no external force is keeping us in “this world” of 31 realms; we are content with sense pleasures, do not see the suffering “in the long term” (even in this life as we get old), thus **we are clinging to everything in this world like an octopus grabbing its prey with all eight legs**. And we are not aware that there is a better kind of pleasure in Nibbana, in detaching from “this world”; see, “[Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)”. (Also, unless a Buddha comes along, we do not know about the 31 realms and are not aware of the suffering in the lower four realms).

13. Can we taste Nibbanic “pleasure”? Yes. We can taste it in increments, even below the Stream Entry (Sotapanna) stage; see, “[How to Taste Nibbana](#)“. This is niramisa sukha, the “pleasure of giving up worldly things”. This niramisa sukha has “quantum jumps” at the four stages of Nibbana: Stream Entry, Once-Returner, Non-Returner, Arahant. Thus when one is on the Path, one can experience niramisa sukha at varying degrees, all the way to Nibbanic bliss, during this very lifetime; see, at the end of “[The Four Stages in Attaining Nibbana](#)“.

14. All these 31 realms are located in our solar system (Chakkawata), and are associated with the Earth. There are a great number of such Chakrawata (planetary systems) in existence at all times with living beings. These are in clusters of small (galaxies?), medium (universes?), and large (multiverse?) “world systems”. But none is permanent. They come into being and eventually perish. Within the past 100 years or so, scientists have confirmed the existence of billions of planetary systems within galaxies in our universe.

The other big factor to take into account is that we have been born in almost all of these realms in our sansaric journey that has no traceable beginning. All of us have been bouncing around “inside the sphere” (mainly in the inner ones) from a beginning that is not even discernible to a Buddha.

Next, “[Sansaric Time Scale](#)“,

Sansaric Time Scale

1. In order to really understand the Buddha's message, one needs to grasp the unimaginable length of the sansara (the rebirth process). The Buddha said that there is no discernible beginning to life. It always existed, and it will exist until one attain Nibbana.
2. This a bit difficult concept for many, because many cultures/religions have the concept of a set time of Creation. If there is a First Cause (such as Creation), then there must be a time that everything got started. But if there is no Creation, then there cannot be a set time for a beginning.
3. Even as recently as at beginning of the 1900's, Lord Kelvin, one of the top scientists of the day, estimated that the age of the Sun was < 40 million years based on gravitational contraction (atomic structure was not known at that time), and our knowledge of the universe was pretty much limited to the Solar system.
4. Vindication of the Buddha's teachings on the long sansara started at the beginning of the 1900's with the advent of quantum mechanics and relativity: Discovery of radioactivity in 1898 by Bequerel and Einstein's explanation of the photoelectric effect in 1905 led to the quantum theory of atomic structure, which in turn led to the correct picture of atomic fusion as the source of solar energy. So, by 1956, the age of the solar system was known to be > 4 billion years. Yet, even billions of years is hardly the same as "beginning-less time"!
5. But there was more to be discovered. By 1929, Edwin Hubble proved that the distant galaxies are moving away from each other and from our galaxy, and that our galaxy is but just one of many galaxies. This was a vast understatement since now we know that there are billions of galaxies in our observable universe! And they are flying away from each other, i.e, the universe is expanding.
6. The discovery of the microwave background radiation in the 1960's led to the conclusion that our universe started off with the "Big Bang".
7. The mostly accepted theory for the "big bang" is the inflationary theory of Alan Guth (see, "The Inflationary Universe" by Alan Guth, 1997). In the inflation theory, if one "Big Bang" is possible, then it is a given that many other "Big Bangs" are possible. The total energy of our universe is completely consistent with adding up to zero. If the universe requires a sum total of zero energy to produce, then "the universe is the ultimate free lunch", as Guth explains in his book (pp. 247-248). Thus, implied in the inflation theory is the existence of multiple universes.
8. There are several theories currently being explored in quantum mechanics that are related to cosmology. There is one theory that requires a universe being existing for each possible event! So, there may be infinite number of parallel universes. For example, see "The Beginning of Infinity" by David Deutsch (2011). In all these theories there are multiple universes that always exist.
9. While there is no "accepted theory" yet, it seems clear that any type of explanation is likely to be consistent with an existence of multiple universes, or universes that support life at all times (for example, no "material world" with tangible matter is needed to support beings in the *arupa loka*).
10. I would like to close this essay with a simile from the Buddha that he used to describe the unimaginable length of sansara, and to point out that our time in this life is less than a blink of an eye compared to the length of sansara. The Buddha used a great aeon as the measurement unit to help his followers visualize the enormous length of sansara. The length of a great aeon (maha kalpa) is said by the Buddha to be longer than the time it would take a man to wear away a mountain of solid granite

one yojana (about 7 miles) around and one yojana high, by stroking it once every hundred years with a silk cloth. These days scientists use the word “aeon” to denote the duration of a universe (from the “big bang” either to a “big crunch” or just fading away).

11. Just for fun, I estimated the mass of the material that needs to be removed by the silk cloth each time (this happens every 100 years). Using a 7 mile cube of stone with a density of 2515 kg per cubic meter, I calculate the mass of the mountain to be 3.5×10^6 kg. Assuming the lifetime of our universe to be 30 billion years, I calculate the mass removed by each stroke is about 12 grams or about 0.4 ounces. This appears to be a reasonable number! So, a maha kalpa in Buddhism turns out to be approximately an aeon as perceived by the scientists. When we try to visualize the wearing off a mountain we can imagine how long a time period that is.

12. Yet, that is still nothing compared to the length of the sansara. Infinity is a concept that is hard to wrap one’s mind around; see, “[Infinity – How Big Is It?](#)”.

One day the Bhikkhus asked the Buddha how many great aeons had already passed and gone by. The Buddha told them, “Suppose, Bhikkhus, there were four disciples here each with a lifespan of hundred years, and each day they were each to recollect a hundred thousand great aeons. There would still be great aeons not yet recollected by them when those four disciples pass away at the end of hundred years. Because, Bhikkhus, this sansara is without discoverable beginning”.

Next, “[Evidence for Rebirth](#)“,

Evidence for Rebirth

One needs to look at the mounting evidence without any preconceived ideas. There is no plausible way to explain these accounts from a purely “materialistic” point of view, i.e., that consciousness arises from inert matter.

Rebirth Accounts

The late Professor Ian Stevenson at the University of Virginia conducted over 20 years of research on the authenticity of rebirth accounts, which is being continued by Professor Jim Tucker. Several books about rebirth have been written by these two professors. A good book is “Twenty Cases Suggestive of Reincarnation” by Ian Stevenson. By the way, Professor Stevenson became a Buddhist later on in his life presumably because of his studies (see, “Rebirth as Doctrine and Experience” by Francis Story (2003); first edition 1975). He mentions this in the Introduction he wrote to this book by Francis Story; I have scanned that introduction: “[Introduction to “Rebirth by Francis Story – Ian Stevenson”](#)”.

Here is a video that discusses the work of the late Dr. Ian Stevenson, Dr. Jim Tucker, and colleagues at the University of Virginia:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?x-yt-cl=85114404&v=9w2MCpzE8u0&x-yt-ts=1422579428&feature=player_embedded

In their book, “Soul Survivor: The Reincarnation of a World War II Fighter Pilot”, by Bruce and Andrea Leininger detail the amazing story of their son’s recount of a past life, mentioned in the above video. Here is a ABC News report on the story:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Uk7biSOzr1k&x-yt-cl=85114404&x-yt-ts=1422579428&feature=player_embedded

Here is another story of the rebirth of a Civil War General:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?x-yt-cl=85114404&v=aQHp9bGVDB8&x-yt-ts=1422579428&feature=player_embedded

Here is a three-year old chanting Buddhist suttas (and doing a very good job). Can a three-year old memorize such complex lines of suttas?

https://www.youtube.com/watch?feature=player_embedded&x-yt-ts=1422579428&v=jGHDpgBc9Dk&x-yt-cl=85114404

Child Prodigies

Another piece of evidence comes from child prodigies. Here is the story about Jake Barnett from a 60 Minutes report:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?x-yt-cl=85114404&x-yt-ts=1422579428&v=g91IQsS2spA&feature=player_embedded

1. Many people say that direct “proof” for rebirth cannot be given; it is actually the other way around: If someone can convince oneself that just one of those rebirth accounts MUST BE TRUE, then there is no way to explain it by any other way.

2. There is a way one could actually recollect one’s own past lives going back to many lives. This is possible by developing the fourth jhana and then cultivating extrasensory powers; see, “[Power of the](#)”

[Human Mind – Anariya or Mundane Jhanas](#)“.

3. However, when one attains the Arahant stage, certain “extrasensory powers” are gained; [the ability to “see” previous lives \(pubbe nivasanussati nana\) is one of them.](#)

4. Also, it is by having this presumption of rebirth that all of the seeming anomalies and inequalities of life can be explained; see, “[Vagaries of Life and the Way to Seek Good Rebirths](#)“.

- And how could we ever explain the birth of such prodigies as Jeremy Bentham, who already in his fourth year could read and write Latin and Greek; or John Stuart Mill, who at the age of three read Greek and at the age of six wrote a history of Rome; or Babington Macaulay, who in his sixth year wrote a compendium of world history; or Beethoven, who gave public concerts when he was seven; or Mozart, who already before his sixth year had written musical compositions; or Voltaire, who read the fables of Lafontaine when he was three years old.
- Does it not seem infinitely more probable that all these prodigies and geniuses, who in many cases came from illiterate parents, had already in previous births laid the foundations for their extraordinary faculties?

Here is a list of child prodigies from Wikipedia. You will recognize many of the names:

[List of Child Prodigies](#)

Here is the link to Wikipedia article on child prodigies:

[Child Prodigy](#)

Healing with Hypnosys

The late Dr. Richard Feynman was sceptical about the claims in hypnosis studies until he subjected himself to hypnosis in two different occasions. In both instances he verified for himself that if done correctly hypnosis works. He describes these two cases in his book, “Surely You’re Joking, Mr. Feynman!” (1985), pp. 66-68.

Hypnosis provides yet another set of “supporting material”. There are many cases of people remembering past lives when hypnotized. It is hard to evaluate the validity of most such cases. However, there is a branch of hypnosis that uses it as therapy. Some people seem to have “phobias” based on a horrific event from a past life. They cannot figure out why they have these phobias, but when a hypnotist brings out that experience, they become cured. Here is a 20/20 documentary of three such cases, where they vouch for the authenticity of the therapy sessions:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?x-yt-cl=85114404&v=hMfsjXiZGis&x-yt-ts=1422579428&feature=player_embedded

There are hundreds of youtube videos on rebirth stories and also many on child prodigies and hypnosis-based curing of certain ailments.

Following books are also good reads:

- “Many Lives, Many Masters”, by Brian Weiss (1988).
- “Many Mansions: The Edgar Cayce Story on Reincarnation”, by Gina Cerminara (1988).
- “Children’s Past Lives: How Past Life Memories Affect Your Child” by Carol Bowman (1998)
- “Return to Life: Extraordinary Cases of Children Who Remember Past Lives”, Jim B. Tucker

(2013).

OBE and NDE Studies

There is an ever-growing reports on Out-of-Body Experiences (OBE) and Near-Death Experiences (NDE) that not only support rebirth, but also are consistent with the concept of a “manomaya kaya”; see, “[Manomaya Kaya and Physical Body](#)” and other related posts.

There are many youtube videos, but here are three recent books on these two subjects:

- “Consciousness Beyond Life”, by Pim van Lommel (2010) gives detailed accounts of case studies by a renowned cardiologist.
- “Brain Wars” by Mario Beauregard (2012) is a book by scientist on NDE, OBE, and the mind-body problem in general.
- “Dying to be Me: My Journey from Cancer, to Near Death, to True Healing”, by Anita Moorjani (2012) is a personal story of a cancer survivor who had been diagnosed to die within a few weeks but had an “unexplainable recovery” within days during which time she had an out-of-body experience.

Discussion

1. Some of you may be wondering whether there is a inconsistency here. I have repeatedly mentioned that the Buddha clearly stated that it is extremely rare to be born a human. Yet, from the above rebirth case studies it appears that people have been born in human realm in successive lives. If it is so hard to attain a human birth, how can this be?

2. There is nothing inconsistent. The key problem here is another misinterpretation. “Bhava” or an existence is not the same as a “jathi” or a birth; see, “[Patipicca Samuppada – “Pati+ichcha”+“Sama+uppada”](#)“, and subsequent posts. A living being, upon exhausting the kammic energy for one existence, grabs hold of another strong kammic potential for the next existence. If the energy of that kammic potential is large, the being may be reborn many times in that existence until that kammic energy is exhausted (life span of a certain existence is limited; maximum of 120 years for a human, about 20 years for dog, etc.).

3. Thus, if one has done a highly meritorious deed, and at some point in sansara latches on to that “kamma seed” (see, “[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka](#)“), that energy may be able to sustain that existence for many rebirths.

- In these cases, when physical death occurs BEFORE exhausting the energy of the kamma seed, the manomaya kaya (called gandhabbaya) leaves the dead body and waits until a suitable womb is ready; see, “[Manomaya Kaya and Physical Body](#)“. In this case, the gandhabbaya may carry the physical resemblance to the next life, including scars of any significant wounds, birth marks, etc.
- When rebirth takes place there, the new physical body could have many resemblances to the old body. In many rebirth cases, such physical resemblances have been confirmed (as in the case of the civil war general in one of the above videos).

4. In summary, it is important to remember that in Patipicca Samuppada, it is “upadana paccaya bhavo”, i.e., grasping (upadana) leads to existence (bhava); for example, existence as a dog. That existence (bhava) may have enough kammic energy to support several repeated births as a dog. Therefore,

once a given bhava or existence is grasped, the next step of “bhava paccaya jati”, will lead to reaped births as a dog until that kammic energy is exhausted; see, “[Bhava and Jati – States of existence and Births Therein](#)”.

5. On the other hand, if the kammic energy for that “bhava” has run out by the time death occurs, then a new “bhava” will be grasped at the death moment, and the resulting gandhabbaya that comes out will be quite different. For example, if a human has exhausted the kammic energy for that human existence (bhava) and a kammic seed for a bhava (existence) of an elephant is grasped, then the gandhabbaya that results will have the “imprint” for an elephant, and will find an elephant womb to be born in the next life.

6. It may be difficult to grasp these concepts initially. One needs to look up the links given and may need to go back several layers to grasp these ideas. It is not possible to explain everything in one post. Buddha Dhamma can be very deep, if one wants to really comprehend how the nature works.

Next, “[The Four Stages in Attaining Nibbana](#)“,

The Four Stages in Attaining Nibbana

1. The 31 realms discussed above are divided into three main categories based on the sense faculties and the level of suffering:
 - The lowest eleven realms belong to the “*kāmaloka*”, where all five physical sense faculties are present; “*kāma*” is the indulging in the five sense faculties.
 - Beings in the next sixteen realms have only two physical senses: vision and hearing. They have less-dense bodies, and this subset of realms is called the *rūpa loka*. In *rūpa loka* there is mainly jhanic pleasures corresponding to the first four mundane jhanas that are achievable by humans. There is relatively less suffering in the *rupa lokas*.
 - The highest four realms correspond to the higher *arūpa* jhanic states (jhanic levels five through eight) that are also attainable in the human realm. Thus there is mainly jhanic bliss in these realms, and relatively less suffering. These realms are commonly known as *arūpa loka*, because the beings have very fine bodies with no physical senses and only the mind.
2. The lifetimes of the beings in the *rupa loka* are very long, and those in the *arupa loka* are even longer. Lifetime in the highest *arupa lokas* are so long (84,000 aeons or *maha kalpas*), that it is beyond comprehension to us.
 - This is why the ancient yogis mistakenly thought that such realms correspond to Nibbana. But the Buddha (or rather Sidharata Gotama), who attained the eighth jhana within months after leaving the palace to become an ascetic, realized that this realm is also subjected to the transient existence, i.e., does not correspond to permanent happiness. Also, even this long time is insignificant in the [samsaric time scale](#) (see, “[Samsaric Time Scale](#)”), which is infinite (see, “[Infinity – How Big Is It?](#)”).
3. One in the human realm can experience the jhanic pleasure of both *rupa* and *arupa* lokas by attaining such jhanic states via samatha meditation.
 - Furthermore, it is possible to gain access to both *rupa lokas* and *arupa lokas* in the next birth by developing the corresponding jhanas and by being in a jhanic state at death. As I understand, this is the goal of most Hindu practices.
4. *What the Buddha pointed out was that even the highest jhanic state is impermanent, and once that kammic energy is exhausted, it is possible to be born in any of the 31 realms. In fact, unless the being had not attained at least [the Sotapanna stage](#), it is guaranteed that at some point in the future rebirth in one of the lowest realms is inevitable.*
 - He said that many of the beings still in the rebirth process (*samsara*), i.e., we all, are likely to have been born in the higher *arupa lokas*, as well as the lowest realm (*niraya*) in the past. The *samsara* is that long.
5. From this discussion it is clear that the actual suffering is mostly in the *kamalokas*. But the problem is that beings spend most time in *kamalokas* in their beginning-less journey in the *samsara*.
 - The Buddha gave a simile to describe this situation. We leave home only to go on short, or may be even extended, trips; but we always come back home. **The Buddha said that the four lowest realms (the *apayas*) are the home base for most living beings.**

Suffering in the Kamaloka

1. Suffering in the *kamaloka* ranges from unfathomable suffering in the lowest realm, the *niraya* (hell), to relatively little suffering and highest sense pleasures in the Deva lokas (the highest six realms in the *kama loka*).

- Just below the *deva lokas*, there is the human realm with both suffering and sense pleasures at about equal levels.
- Below the human realm, there is *preta* loka (hungry ghosts), *asuras*, animal realm, and the *nirayas*, and the level of suffering generally increases in that order.

2. The lowest four levels in the *kama loka* are collectively called the *apayas* (the undesirable realms). **More than 99% of the beings are trapped in these four realms.** The problem is that once born in any of those four realms, it is virtually impossible to get out.

- This is because these realms are such that one is forced to commit *apunnabhi sankhara* or evil actions (see, “[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka](#)”) by the very nature of that existence. For example, in the animal realm, most animals have to kill others for survival. In the *niraya*, virtually every thought is of hate, because of the incessant suffering.

3. Just as it is likely that we have been born in the higher *rupa lokas* in the past, it is even more certain that we ALL have been in the *apayas*. Luckily we do not remember those past lives.

- But in certain realms (particular the *preta realm*) beings do remember their past lives and that increases the level of suffering.

Why We Need to Strive Now

1. From the above discussion it is clear that most suffering is in the four lowest realms, below the human realm which is the fifth realm. Essentially, there is relatively less suffering above the human realm, starting with the *deva loka* which is the highest realm in the *kama loka*.

2. Even though the suffering is highest in the lower four realms, the beings there are helpless to do anything about the suffering. Their limited minds are not capable of grasping the causes that lead to suffering.

- **Many people wrongly believe that one needs to feel suffering in order to understand it, and to get an incentive to seek Nibbana. But when one really suffers (say, when one gets too old) it is NOT possible to clearly contemplate the deep concepts of Dhamma.**
- The Noble truth on suffering needs to be seen with wisdom (*panna*), not via feelings (*vedana*), i.e., by understanding the complete world view AND the Three Characteristics of this “wider world”: *anicca, dukkha, anatta*.

3. Beings in the realms above the human realm, the 26 realms starting with the *deva* realms, do not even feel much suffering. **This is the other extreme; there is no incentive for them to be concerned about suffering.** The only real suffering there is that when their lifetimes get near to the end, they do realize that and become distraught.

4. Thus it is only at the human realm that one is at least exposed to the suffering, even if one may not be subjected to much suffering. Furthermore, the human mind is the best suited for grasping the true nature of “this world of 31 realms”, i.e., the Three Characteristics (see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta](#)”). **This is why the Buddha said that a human should not miss this opportunity to attain Nibbana.**

The Four Stages of Attaining Nibbana

1. The first stage of Nibbana, is attained by “seeing” (**not just reading about, but actually grasping**) the true nature of the existence: *anicca, dukkha, anatta*.

- Thus one needs to first learn from someone (like from this website), the nature of existence with the 31 realms, the aimless wandering of a being through endless rebirths (*sansara*), the reasons for the rebirths, etc.
- Thus the key areas to understand are the Three Characteristics, the Four Noble Truths, and the Noble Eightfold Path. No one but a Buddha is capable of finding these and this is why it is important to have exposure to the PURE DHAMMA.

2. At the first stage (*Sotapanna* or Stream Enterer), one partially comprehends the validity of the Buddha’s world view. This is called attaining *Samma Ditthi* (elimination of defilements through clear vision) to a significant extent. He/she understands the “true nature” of existence: significance and true meaning of the Three Characteristics of Existence (see, “[anicca, dukkha, anatta](#)”).

3. The realization that it is not worthwhile or fruitful to stay in any of the 31 realms in the long run, makes one to conduct oneself in a moral fashion; one’s mind makes the decision that it is not worthwhile for beneficial to do those actions that destine oneself to birth in the lower four realms.

- This realization leads to a *Sotapanna phala citta* (one thought moment of realizing [the Sotapanna stage](#)). When that is achieved, one will never again be reborn in the lower four realms; why this is so is explained in, “[Akusala Citta – How a Sotapanna Avoids Apayagami Citta](#)”.

4. At this stage one has realized the First Noble Truth of suffering (*dukkha*), and one earnestly starts on the Noble Eightfold Path. At this stage he still has greed and hate left in him to some extent, but at the next stage (*Sakadagami* or “Once-Returner”), he loses more of the strength of such greedy or hateful thoughts. A *Sakadagami* will be returned to the human realm at most only once, thus the term “once-returner”.

5. When the third stage of *Anagami* (Non-Returner) is attained, the mind loses any desire to be born in the *kama loka*. One is not capable of generating any greedy or hateful thoughts belonging to the *kama loka* and he will be born only one time more in a higher *Brahma* world reserved for the Anagamis.

6. All through these three stages, *avijja* or ignorance gradually diminish. But it is completely removed only at the *Arahant* stage.

- Once the *Arahant* stage is reached, the mind becomes totally pure (*anidassana vinnana* or *panna* is attained), and is incapable of desiring anything “in this world of 31 realms”. Thus there is no more rebirth, and one attains the perfect happiness the peak of *niramisa sukha*.

Also, see “[Nibbana](#)” and “[The Way to Nibbana – Removal of asavas](#)”.

Why Living a Moral Life Would Not Prevent a Birth in the Four Lower Realms

1. We desperately cling to “things in this world” because we have the perception that lasting happiness can be achieved. We crave the sense pleasures. As mentioned before, there is nothing or no one holding us in this world of 31 realms. We cling to existence in these realms like an octopus grabbing its prey with all eight legs.

2. Even some Buddhists would, in the back of their minds, like to stay in this world a bit more. They do not realize the level of happiness associated with the Nibbanic bliss; see, “[Three Kinds of](#)

Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?”.

- A popular blessing given by some Buddhist monks even today goes like, “May you be reborn in prosperous (deva or human) realms AND THEN attain Nibbana”. Even they do not understand the permanent happiness associated with Nibbana or the possibility of much suffering even in the next birth.

3. The danger in such thinking is due to the following reason: We all have done both good and bad deeds in the lives before and have acquired uncountable kamma seeds both good and bad; see, “[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka](#)”. **At death it is possible for any one of those seeds to bear fruit: if it is a good kamma seed, one will get a good birth, but if it is a bad kamma seed one will get a bad birth.**

4. Our future births are not necessarily determined by how we live this life, because we have done uncountable number of both good and bad kamma in previous lives.

- This is why the Buddha said that even if one lives a perfectly moral life he cannot say that one will get a good rebirth, UNLESS one has attained at least [the Sotapanna stage](#): A Sotapanna has made ineffective all those bad kamma seeds that could give a birth in the lower four realms.
- The Buddha also said that even if one lives immorally that also does not necessarily lead to a bad life in the next birth unless a *anantariya kamma* (an extremely bad kamma like killing one’s parents) was committed; however those bad acts will bear fruit at some point in the future. It is just that there are many good seed as well as bad seeds with any life stream; see, “[What is Kamma? Is Everything Determined by Kamma?](#)” .
- Thus the goal of this life should be to attain at least [the Sotapanna stage](#) of Nibbana.

A different analysis on *Nibbana* can be found at, “[Difference Between Giving up Valuables and Losing Interest in Worthless](#)“,

Next, “[Niramisa Sukha \(Happiness Arising from Dissociating from the 31 realms\)](#)“,

Niramisa Sukha

1. Another critically important aspect of Buddha's teachings that has been lost, is the importance of the niramisa sukha. There is happiness in giving up sense pleasures, giving up hate, and giving up ignorance (by learning Dhamma), and that is called niramisa sukha. This is a part of Dhamma that many people do not realize.

2. Contrary to another misguided perception we have today, the Buddha never said that there is no amisa sukha (sense pleasure) to be had. The only reason why people cling to this world is BECAUSE of the sense pleasures that are available.

- What the Buddha said is that such sense pleasures are transient, not lasting. Even if one inherits a fortune and lives in luxury the whole life, the suffering is inevitable in the next life or next lives. The real suffering (dukkha) is in the four lowest realms (apayas).
- Niramisa sukha is present where there is no suffering.

3. The niramisa sukha has a different quality compared to amisa sukha or the pleasures from the senses that we all enjoy. It is also different from the jhanic pleasures in quality. Jhanic pleasure is better than the sense pleasures (as the meditators know), and niramisa sukha is of even better quality.

- Both amisa sukha and jhanic pleasures are transient, not lasting.
- The niramisa sukha starts increasing as soon as one starts on the Noble Eightfold Path, and becomes permanent at the Arahant stage. Furthermore this whole progression up to the Arahant stage can be attained in this very life.

4. It is important to realize that niramisa sukha cannot be attained by “just giving up things” or by leaving everything behind and going to seclusion. This is another misconception that many people have.

- The Buddha never asked anyone to give up their lifestyle. There were wealthy people and even kings who attained [the Sotapanna stage](#) and up to the Anagami stage while living a “householder life”.
- There is no point in giving up everything; even when one gives to charity, one needs to make sure one has enough left for oneself and one's family. Fulfilling one's responsibilities is as important as being charitable.

5. The “giving up worldly things” needs to come through true understanding of the real nature of “this world”. Many people did give up worldly things and became bhikkhus, but only after they saw the fruitless of craving for worldly things.

6. It is the nature of the mind that it has to see the benefit or pleasure of something before embracing it.

- One may force the mind to “give up” some sense pleasures, but that cannot be sustained. Most people who try to do that out of ignorance (misunderstanding of Dhamma) actually end up becoming dissatisfied and giving up the effort.
- The mind has to “see” that there is a better option compared to the amisa sukha or sense pleasures. When one starts on the Path and start living a moral life one will gradually see the niramisa sukha emerge.

7. The Buddha gave a simile to explain this effect. In the old days, when people took to the oceans to look for new lands, they took caged birds with them. When they were lost or wanted to find whether they were close to land, they released a bird. The bird would fly around and come back to ship if no land is found. The same is true for the mind. It will not latch on to something new (niramisa sukha) unless it is better than the one it already has (amisa sukha).

8. Yet, in the beginning it takes some time for the niramisa sukha to be noticeable. We have lived with clouded minds for so long, that it takes a little while to “clean things up”.

- It is like developing a new technology these days. Initially it is difficult to get started; one has to make a concerted effort just to “stay in”. But once the benefits of the technology is realized by the public, it starts to take off: http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Technology_life_cycle
- But unlike a new technology, once the niramisa sukha starts increasing it never comes down ever (after [the Sotapanna stage](#) is reached).
- It makes “quantum jumps” at [the Sotapanna stage](#) and other three subsequent stages, and becomes complete and permanent at the Arahant stage. However, even an Arahant will experience the results of previous kamma vipaka and will have PHYSICAL ailments that will still cause suffering until the life comes to an end.

Next, “[What are Rupa? Relation to Nibbana](#)“,

What Are Rupa? (Relation to Nibbana)

1. In Buddha Dhamma, everything in “this world” of 31 realms can be put into two categories: manasa (mind) and rupa (material form).
 - Mind is citta (thoughts) and the mental properties in the thoughts, cetasika.
 - Everything else is rupa (material forms).
2. Now let us look at rupa: Many people think rupa is just the body or “material things”. A better translation for rupa is “matter and energy”. As stated in #1 above, everything else that is not citta or cetasika is rupa. There are five types of rupa that we experience with our five senses: with eye (cakkhu), we experience vanna rupa (whatever that is visible); with ear (sota), we experience sounds (sadda); with nose (ghana), we experience smells (gandha); with tongue (jivha), we experience taste (rasa); with body (kaya), we experience touch (pottabba).
3. We can see that smells are due to tiny material particles that enter the nose; taste is also due to food and drinks that touch the tongue; touch is also contact between “material things”. But what about visible objects? We need light to see any objects; without light we cannot see. Thus “seeing” involves matter and energy. Same for sound. Thus rupa in Dhamma is really “matter and energy”, which in the end is just energy. Since the turn of the 20th century, **science has confirmed that matter is just energy**: they are related by Einstein’s famous formula of $E = mc^2$.
4. Thus the rupa can vary in “density” from almost pure energy to the solid objects that we can see with our eyes. They go through three stages: At the “gathi” stage, they overlap with energy; in the “bhuta” stage, they are more solidified but the human eye still cannot see (this is why some beings that the humans cannot see are called “bhuta” in Pali or Sinhala); it is only in the “dhathu” stage that the human eye can see. At Parinibbana (death) of an Arahant, the mind is not attached to a rupa in any of the three forms: dhathu, bhuta, or gathi.
5. When one is born anywhere in the 31 realms, it is the vinnana (impure consciousness) that keeps the mind bound to a material body. As the purity level of the mind goes higher one moves up from the lower realms with dense bodies to higher realms with less dense bodies.
 - In the **lower realms**, the mind is normally attached to a dense body that the human eye can see (at or below the human realm, which is the fifth realm). This is **dense dhatu form**.
 - In the **deva lokas** (realms 6-11), the bodies are finer; their minds are devoid of hate and thus are more pure. In the realms 1-11, the bodies are made of rupa still in the **“dhatu” form, but less dense**.
 - In the **rupalokas and arupalokas**, the mind is devoid of both hate and greed, and are thus even more pure. In the rupaloka (realms 12-27), the bodies of the beings are much more less dense than the devas, and are in the **“bhuta” form**.
 - In **Arupa lokas** (realms 28-31) there are no rupa even in the sense of bhuta. But the **four maha bhuta are still associated with those being’s “gathi”** (Kevaddha Sutta in Digha Nikaya); there rupa can be thought of as indistinguishable from energy.
 - **When the mind becomes purified**, vinnana becomes “anidassana vinnana”, which is the vinnana of an Arahant (also called panna). **Here there is no association of the mind with even fine rupa associated with “gathi”**; the mind is completely detached from rupa. The mind becomes

pure and free. When one attains Aranthood, one still lives with the “solid body” of a human being until death. At Parinibbana, the mind becomes completely free of rupa.

6. Thus to attain Nibbana is to attain the perfectly purified mind, which refuses to be burden with a physical body that leads to decay and rebirth repeatedly (and thus to dukkha).

7. In the 31 realms, one is born with a dense body (kama loka), fine-material body (rupa loka), or only a trace of “matter” in the form of “gathi” (arupa loka). Nibbana is attained when the mind becomes free of a body anywhere in the 31 realms. [Thus Nibbana is not a hard concept to understand.](#)

8. In Buddha Dhamma, any given thing or concept can be looked at from many different angles. They are all consistent. It is a complete “world view”. Some people think, why do we have to worry about 31 realms, etc., but the world is very complex. Scientists are just beginning to appreciate this complexity. The amazing fact is that the Buddha discerned all this with his mind, and was able to present it all in a coherent manner.

9. Please re-read and contemplate on the above. In the long run, it will be very helpful. If you do not really understand it now, you may be able to understand it later, when you get familiar with other concepts discussed in other posts. Everything at this site is inter-connected, and it may take some time to “fill-in-the-blanks”.

Next, “[Power of the Human Mind – Introduction](#)“,

Power of the Human Mind – Introduction

1. Most people know about Buddha Gotama as a very intelligent and compassionate human being. In “[Dhamma and Science – Introduction](#)“, I pointed out the similarities and differences between a scientist and a Buddha. Here I want to discuss in detail the incomprehensible complexity of a human mind, and how a Buddha achieves the peak performance of that complex entity.
 - As I pointed out in “[Gödel’s Incompleteness Theorem](#)“, a normal human mind works within the sense sphere of a normal human and thus inherently incapable of providing a complete theory about our world; but the mind of a Buddha can transcend our sensory experience and see the whole of existence.
 - Here I point out, in a systematic way in a series of posts, the progression of the human mind to higher levels achieved [by purifying the mind \(not by merely learning\)](#), and why a Buddha is at the very pinnacle. At the end of this series you will see why no other human being, no matter how intelligent, can even remotely approach the mind of a Buddha.
2. In the “[Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)“, we discussed the 31 realms of existence as laid out by the Buddha.
 - Out of these, the human realm is at the fifth level (and our knowledge base is limited to our sensory experience within it, and Gödel’s Incompleteness Theorem applies to any theory derived within it), and there are four realms below the human realm.
 - Out of the 31 realms, we can see only the human realm and the animal realm (which is one four lower realms or the apayas). But we can access the thoughts enjoyed by the beings in the higher realms, AND we can access the transcendental (lokottara) cittas too. [Please do not put too much significance initially to the number of cittas in each realm, etc. Be patient with me as I need to lay out the “big picture” first.](#)
 - As we proceed systematically in a few posts, you will see various connections to other concepts discussed in other parts on the site, and eventually all fit together. This is why I keep saying that it is a complete and self-consistent world view on a scale unimaginable to a normal (unpurified) human mind.
3. The types of thoughts (cittas) that can be experienced in the whole of existence (31 realms) is 89 (or 121 depending on the scheme); see, “[The 89 \(or 121\) Types of Cittas](#)“. In the three main lokas (or planes) of kamaloka, rupaloka, and arupaloka, different types of cittas are of common occurrence. **While most of the 89 cittas are possible in all three lokas, normally a subset of cittas operate mostly in a given realm.**
 - For example, in the kamaloka, only 54 cittas are mainly experienced. The kamaloka consists of the lower eleven realms, with sixth through eleventh shells representing the realms of the devas. Beings in these 11 realms have all six sense bases, and in the deva realms the sense pleasures are higher than in the human realm.
4. Out of all 89 types of thoughts, only 12 are immoral or *akusala* cittas and these are experienced only in kamaloka; see, “[Akusala Citta and Akusala Vipaka Citta](#)“.
 - [In the higher 20 realms belonging to the rupaloka and arupaloka, only jhanic cittas are mostly present, and *akusala* cittas normally do not arise.](#)

- So, as one can imagine, the beings in the lower realms entertain more immoral cittas, and with higher frequency too. It is said that the beings in the lowest realm, niraya (hell) experience mostly the two immoral cittas based on hate, because of the high degree of suffering there.

5. The human realm is unique in that the human mind can access not only the cittas in the rupa and arupa lokas, but also the eight types of cittas that transcend the 31 realms. These cittas are the four path (magga) cittas for the four levels of Nibbana (Sotapanna, Sakadagami, Anagami, Arahant), and the corresponding resultant (phala) cittas. [Thus all 89 types of cittas are possible for a human.](#)

- Furthermore, most potent cittas, those with highest javana (impulse) power are accessible only by humans; see, [“Javana of a Citta – Root of Mental Power”](#). More posts will follow in the future.
- **This is the basis of the power of the human mind.** It is possible for a human to attain the mindset of a being in the lowest realm (niraya) and it is possible also to go all the way up to the mindset of a Buddha.

6. The cittas in the rupaloka and arupaloka are easily categorized according to the jhanic states. [These are the same jhanic states attained by people via meditation.](#)

- A human can attain all eight jhanic states, and the lower four correspond to the rupaloka and the higher four to the arupaloka.
- Each jhanic state correspond to three types of cittas: wholesome (sobhana) citta and the corresponding vipaka (resultant) citta are two; when the same jhanic sobhana citta experienced by an Arahant it is called a kriya (functional) citta, because it does not lead to a vipaka citta.

7. In the 16 realms belong to the rupaloka, where only two physical sense faculties (eye and ear) are active. These beings have very fine (less dense) bodies.

- In rupaloka 15 types of thoughts (cittas) are mostly experienced corresponding to the five jhanic factors: vitakka, vicara, piti, sukha, ekaggata; see, [“Power of the Human Mind – Anariya or Mundane Jhanas”](#). These are the lower five jhanic sobhana cittas, corresponding five vipaka cittas and five kriya cittas (the last five are effective only for the Arahants who get into these jhanic states).
- The highest four realms represent the arupa lokas, where beings have ultra fine bodies and only the mind faculty; no physical senses. Here there are only 12 types of jhanic cittas mainly present. These are the higher four (fifth through eighth) jhanic sobhana cittas, corresponding four vipaka cittas, and corresponding four kriya cittas (which are effective only for the Arahants who get into these jhanic states, which do not have corresponding vipaka citta).

8. The rupaloka and arupaloka are collectively known as Brahma realms, which comprise the higher 19 realms. In the Brahma realms, beings are mostly devoid of both greed and hate, but they have dormant ignorance (moha) in their kamma seeds; see, [“Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka”](#). In the deva worlds (which belong to kamaloka), those beings are mostly devoid of hate-rooted cittas, but have greed-rooted cittas since they enjoy sensual pleasures.

- It is possible for a human to attain any of those jhanic states via samatha meditation, and one does not have to be a Buddhist to attain those mundane or Anariya jhanic states.
- Those anariya jhanic states are temporary; a yogi in a jhanic state can be “taken out” of the

jhana; see the next post. They may be lost if one does not keep practicing, and the ability to enter such jhanas is lost when one dies, i.e., he/she may not have the ability to get into jhanas in the next life, even if they are born human.

- **However, if one dies while in even an anariya jhanic state, he/she will be born in the corresponding rupaloka or arupaloka.** Yet, a being who gets into even the highest arupaloka via anariaya jhanas will end up eventually in the four lower realms (apayas).
- However, Ariya jhanas are more permanent. Once one gets into an Ariya jhana, it cannot be shaken by any external disturbance. Furthermore, Ariya jhanas attained by a Sotapanna is NEVER lost, even in future lives; see the next post.

Next, “[Power of the Human Mind – Anariya or Mundane Jhanas](#)“,

Power of the Human Mind – Anariya or Mundane Jhanas

1. The 54 types of *cittas* (thoughts) belonging to the *kamaloka* (called *kamavacara cittas*) are not very strong; they can just have enough power to grasp the thought object (*arammana* in Pali or *aramuna* in Sinhala).

- The power of a thought comes from *javana*; see, “[Javana of a Citta – The Root of Mental Power](#)” for an analysis based on *Abhidhamma*.
- But the *jhanic cittas* belonging to the *rupaloka* and *arupaloka* have much more power and have a firm grasp of the object. This is why it is possible for someone who can get to the fourth *jhanic* state to acquire some capabilities that exceed the “normal” human potential, like telekinetic or the ability see or hear from long distances; see below.
- The Pali word “*jhana*” has two roots: “to concentrate” and also “to burn up”. They are related since concentration is achieved by burning up the five hindrances (*nivarana*) that cloud the mind; see, “[Key to Calming the Mind – The Five Hindrances](#)”.

2. The *Anariya* or mundane *jhanas* are attained simply by SUPPRESSING the five hindrances. One simply focuses the mind forcefully onto one thought object, not letting those five hindrances come to surface.

- Since there is only one *citta* at a time (even though there are billions of *cittas* a second), when one forces the mind to one thought object, the five hindrances are kept at bay, and one feels the serenity of a mind unpolluted by the hindrances. **This is called *samatha* meditation.**

3. Thus attaining mundane *jhanas* is purely a mechanistic process. While some Buddhists use them to calm the mind before getting into insight (*vipassana*) meditation, it is used widely by the Hindus. Even before the Buddha, there were many Hindu *yogis* who could attain the highest *jhanas*.

- There are many reports of people of other faiths also attaining such jhanic states (see, for example, “Interior Castle” by the Christian nun St. Teresa of Avila; edited by E. Allison Peers, 1946, for a fascinating description of “seven mansions” which seem to correspond to these jhanic states).
- But such *jhanic* states are not permanent; one could lose them in an instant, if the moral conduct is broken and defiled thoughts (*anusaya*) come to the surface.

4. There are many techniques for conducting such *samatha* meditation. The popular ones are breath (whether focusing the mind on the breath at the nostrils or on the rising/falling of the stomach) and *kasina* meditation (where a certain object, for example a colored disk is used to focus the attention on). As one’s mind gets absorbed in that object, the five hindrances are suppressed, and the mind advances to higher and higher calm states.

- Obviously, it is easier to attain *jhanic* states via *samatha* meditation if one follows at least the five precepts (not killing, stealing, sexually misbehaving, lying, or taking drugs or alcohol). This is because the greedy and hateful thoughts are at a lower baseline state for a person observing the five precepts.
- If one abstains from all ten immoral acts (*dasa akusala*), then it is even easier to calm the mind and to attain these *jhanic* states; see, “[Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)](#)”.

5. The five *jhanic* states corresponding to the *cittas* in the *rupaloka* themselves are related to the five

hindrances. To get to the first *jhanic* state, one needs to suppress the five hindrances; this is done by developing five *sobhana* [beautiful qualities of consciousness] mental factors (*sobhana cetasika*) to counter the five hindrances:

- *Vitakka* inhibits the hindrance of sloth and torpor (*thina middha*). This is how one trains to direct the mind to one thought object, say the breath. *Vitakka* is normally translated as “initial application”, but it comes from “*tharka*” or going back and forth among many *arammana* (thought objects); when this is stopped one has “*vitharka*” or *vitakka*, i.e., staying on one thought object, for example, breath or a *kasina* object.
- Sustained application (*vicara*) is the continued presence of the mind on that object, i.e., maintaining concentration on that object; *vicara* comes from stopping “*chara*” or moving around. *Vitakka* and *vicara* are compared to a bee flying towards a flower and then buzzing and hanging around the flower while extracting honey from it. *Vicara* serves to temporarily inhibit the hindrance of *vicikicca*.
- As the mind gets absorbed in the object, thoughts of ill will are suppressed and zest or mental happiness (*piti* or “*preethi*”) arises in the mind. This is the *jhanic* factor of *piti*, and it suppresses the hindrance of ill will (*vyapada*). This happiness is felt mainly on the face.
- The body becomes light due to physical happiness (*sukha*). This *jhanic* factor counters the hindrance of restlessness and worry (*uddhacca kukkuc*).
- Thus the mind now becomes totally absorbed in the thought object, and one has one-pointedness (*ekaggata*). This is the primary *jhanic* factor in all *rupaloka jhanic* states and the essence of concentration (*samadhi*). This one-pointedness temporarily inhibits sensual desire (*kamachanda*).

When all five *jhanic* factors are present, the five hindrances are temporarily suppressed, and one is in the first *jhanic* state.

6. The higher *jhanas* are attained by **successively eliminating** the grosser *jhana* factors and by refining the subtler *jhana* factors through sustained concentration.

- Thus in the *Abhidhamma* it is stated that there are five *jhanic* states, where the last four are attained by the elimination of a *jhana* factor at each stage; thus in that method, the second *jhana* is attained by removing *vitakka*. But in the suttas, the Buddha expounds the *jhanas* as fourfold, where both *vitakka* and *vicara* are removed to get to the second *jhana*. Therefore the difference comes in at the second *jhana*.
- For someone cultivating *jhana*, this is not of any practical concern. In practice, it is not easy to distinguish between two steps of removing *vittakka*, *vicara*; they seem to go away together. That is probably why the Buddha just combine them into one *jhana* in the suttas.

Possible Perils of Mundane Jhanas

First of all, the *anariya* (mundane) *jhanas* are not stable as *Ariya jhanas*. A *yogi* can be taken out of the *jhana* by the *anusaya* (temptations) triggered by an external stimulus, for example seeing an attractive woman or hearing a seductive voice; see, “[Gathi \(Character\), Anusaya \(Temptations\), and Asava \(Cravings\)](#)”.

- There is this story about a *yogi* who was travelling by air with *abhinna* powers and saw a flower in the shape of a woman (called “*nārilathā*”) and lost the *jhanic* state and came down; there is

another such story where the *yogi* heard the singing of a woman and had to face the same fate.

- In contrast, when someone gets into an *Ariya jhana*, that *jhana* cannot be broken by any such influence even though the *yogi* may see or hear such external stimuli; see, “[Power of the Human Mind- Ariya Jhanas](#)“, and “[Ariya Jhanas via Cultivation of Saptha Bojjanga](#)“.
- Thus even though the *yogi* may have not removed some *asavas*, the *anusaya* are PREVENTED from arising in an *Ariya jhana*; this is because the object of concentration (*arammana*) in an *Ariya jhana* is not a mundane object, but *Nibbana*.

1. There are many people even today, who can get into these mundane *ghanas*. But it is not a good idea to attain such mundane *ghanas* at or above the fifth *jhana*.

- This is because, if someone dies while in such an *arupa jhanic* state, he/she will be born in the *arupa loka*: it is not possible to attain [the Sotapanna stage](#) in the *arupa loka* because the eye and ear faculties are not present (so one could not learn Dhamma), and thus cannot become a *Sotapanna*. Thus one would spend a very long time there, and has to start all over when one returns to the human world. Once in the human world, it is possible that one could accumulate bad *kamma vipaka* and be destined to the *apayas*.
- Thus it is better to make the effort to become a *Sotapanna*, rather than seeking any *jhana*. A *Sotapanna* will never be born in the *apayas* (lowest four realms).

2. There is yet another danger in attaining these mundane *ghanas*. Even before the *ghanas*, one could start seeing objects of one’s liking (such as religious figures of any religion, religious symbols, colorful lights, etc).

- Thus many people tend to believe that they have attained some of sort of advancement in meditation or in their belief system; some Buddhists may believe they have attained *Nibbana* or something close to it. It could be dangerous to play with such illusions. **When such lights or other images appear, one should completely ignore them.** I used to see them too, but luckily I found my teachers before getting heavily involved with these illusions.

3. It is said that in some rare instances, lowly spirits try to convince meditators that they are *devas* or *brahmas* (beings in the realms higher than the human realm). It is dangerous to get involved with them too. It is possible that some of the horror stories we hear from time to time about people killing their own families were committed under such influences.

Extrasensory Perceptions and Powers (Abhinna)

1. When one attains and perfects the fourth *jhana*, one could start developing several extra sensory perceptions and powers, which could take considerable effort. No reports are available on anyone with ALL these abilities at the present time. However, when one attains the *Arahant* stage, certain extra sensory powers are attained, including the last one on the following list, the ability to “see” the past lives:

- [Psychokinesis \(iddhividha\)](#) or various manifestations of the “power of will”.
- Clairaudience (*dibbasota*), the faculty of perceiving sounds even at long distances, far beyond the range of ordinary auditory faculties.
- [Clairvoyance \(dibbacakkhu\)](#), which enables one to see far events as well as heavenly worlds (i.e., other beings that are not visible to normal human eye).

- Telepathy (*cetopariyanana*), which enables one to comprehend the general state as well as the functioning of another's mind.
- Ability to recollect one's own past lives (*pubbenivasanussatinana*).

2. It is possible for a *yogi* to develop the *abhinna* to the extent that he/she can see past lives through half of a *Maha Kalpa* (which can be taken to be roughly 15 billion years). The ancient *yogis* with such power saw that the *Maha Brahma* has been there all through that time period. Therefore, they came to the wrong conclusion that the *Maha Brahma* was the one who created the world at that time in the past.

- Those *yogis* who are born in the *asanna* realm spend 500 *Maha Kalpas* there like a lifeless log (no thinking, that is what *asanna* means). When they exhaust that lifetime, they normally are reborn in the human realm, and because of this past "*gathi*" to cultivate *jhanas*, they may again develop *abhinna* powers. Now they look back at past lives, but do not see any because they can look back only half of a *Maha Kalpa*, which is only a thousandth of the duration of the past life. Thus, they also conclude erroneously that they are "new" beings, who did not have any past lives.
- The Buddha, upon his Enlightenment, could see thousands of *Maha Kalpas* in the blink of eye. This is why he said there is no discernible beginning to life.
- An *Arahant* **with *abhinna* powers** can see back through numerous *Maha Kalpas* since *Ariya jhanas* are much more powerful.

3. Further details can be found in:

- "The Manuals of Dhamma", by Ven. Ledi Sayadaw (2006), p. 105.
- "Abhidhammattha Sangaha – Comprehensive Manual of Abhidhamma" by Bhikkhu Bodhi (1999), p. 344.

4. These kinds of direct knowledge are all mundane and are dependent on the mastery of the fourth *jhana* and focusing attention on these tasks. [The Buddha discouraged bhikkhus from pursuing these mundane powers, and also prohibited bhikkhus from public display of such powers, calling them "childish"](#). That is because all these powers are temporary. Since one has not removed *avijja* (ignorance) and has only suppressed greed (*lobha*) and hate or ill will (*dosa*), they can resurface any time and remove all those achievements.

- One good example from the Buddha's time was Devadatta, who was a brother of princess Yasodhara. Devadatta became a monk and developed the mundane *jhanas* and attained those direct knowledges described above. He could perform many "miracles", and one time he appeared in the bedroom of Prince Ajatasattu to impress him. But when Devadatta went against the Buddha and at one time injured the Buddha, he lost all his mundane powers and ended up in the lowest realm (*avici niraya*) because of those offenses.

By now one should be able to get a sense of the potential of the mind. With even these mundane *jhanas*, a human can access the higher realms of existence and also attain super normal powers, but these mundane *jhanas* are at a much lower level than *Ariya jhanas*.

Next, "[Power of the Human Mind- Ariya Jhanas](#)",

Power of the Human Mind – Ariya Jhanas

1. We saw in the previous post that *Anariya jhanas* are attained via focusing the mind on ANY thought object (*vitakka*), whether it is breath, a *kasina* object, or any other religious symbol of any religion, and then keeping the mind there (*vicara* or sustained application).

2. Whereas the *Anariya* or mundane *jhanas* are attained by SUPPRESSING the five hindrances via concentrating on mundane objects (breath, a *kasina* object, etc) , *Ariya jhanas* are attained via using *Nibbana* as the *arammana* (thought object); actually, *Nibbana* is not “an object” in this world, so what is meant here is to recall some “cooling down” that one has experienced.

- When one comprehends the Three Characteristics (*Tilakkhana*) of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* at least to some extent, there is definitely some tangible “cooling down” over time. One can look back and notice such a “cooling down”. For example, one may not “flare up” at the slightest provocation as one used to, or one may have lost cravings to some extent, etc. That is what needs to be recalled while cultivating *Ariya jhana*; see #4 below for the *kammatthana*.

3. Thus the key is to first experience some “cooling down” by comprehending the Three Characteristics of “this world” of 31 realms. One examines the real life situations and understands that no lasting happiness is possible, either in this life or anywhere in these 31 realms; see. “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta](#)“, and “[Why is Correct Interpretation of Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta so Important?](#)“. This gives rise to *niramisa sukha* (see, “[Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)“) of *Nibbana*, i.e., some sort of a “cooling down”, over time. How long it takes to experience some “cooling down” will depend on the person.

4. When one has experienced some “cooling down” that one can recall, then one can use it in a *kammatthana* to cultivate *jhana*. One can sit in a quiet place and recite the following *kammatthana*:

- “*Ethan santhan ethan paneethan, sabba sankhara samatho, Sabbhupathi patinissaggo, tanhkkhayo, virago, nirodho, Nibbanan ti*“, which means, “It is the only peace, the only happiness: prevent *sankhara* from arising (via) eliminating *tanha* and excess greed, and thus stopping the arising of defilements, which is *Nibbana*“. This needs to be done while recalling an instance of one’s own “cooling down”; see #3 above.
- However, the above procedure is not much effective unless one has at least some understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* and has experienced some “cooling down”; it can be used to quickly enter a *jhana* that had been cultivated.

5. Thus the difference between the mundane and *Ariya* versions of *samatha* meditation is the meditation object, and this is the reason that *asanna jhanas* are avoided in the *Ariya* meditation. In the former, one can focus on ANY object; in the latter one focuses on *Nibbana*. **Thus, *vitakka*, *vicara* for *Anariya samatha* meditation becomes *savitakka*, *savicara*, emphasizing the focus on *Nibbana*, with the prefix “sa”.**

- “*Ethan santhan ethan paneethan,*” cannot be used just as a chanting without understanding what is meant by heart. Thus the chant (one does not chant out loud; one could just say it in the mind to oneself or say it very quietly meaningfully) will become more and more effective as one starts feeling the *niramisa sukha* at least to a certain extent. One could also start with any *Anariya samatha* meditation (the breath meditation is easy to do), and once starts feeling the calmness and early stages of *niramisa sukha*, one could permanently switch over to the *Ariya* version, by contemplating on *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* and recalling one’s own “cooling down”.

6. Another thing to remember is that *niramisa sukha* has no equivalent sensation in any type of *amisa sukha* or sense pleasures that are available with the five physical senses. It is more like a relief sensation. When one has a headache and it goes away, one feels a relief, a calmness, a peace of mind. The *niramisa sukha* is something like that. The more *niramisa sukha* one feels one becomes calm inwardly AND outwardly.

- In the post, “[Akusala Citta – How a Sotapanna Avoids Apayagami Citta](#)“, I have explained how a *Sotapanna* automatically removes the five types of citta that are responsible for rebirth in the *apayas* (the lowest four realms). In that discussion, it was also shown how *vicikicca* is responsible for such bad kamma, and how contemplation on *Tilakkhana* (*anicca, dukkha, anatta*) can remove *vicikicca*, and also four other greed-rooted *cittas* that arise because of the wrong views.

7. Thus as one contemplates on *anicca, dukkha, anatta*, one automatically starts **reducing, not just suppressing the hindrances**. By the time one attains [the Sotapanna stage](#), these five hindrances are reduced to a level that is sufficient to attain the first *Ariya jhana* with the *jhana* factors of *savitakka, savicara, piti, sukha, ekaggata* fairly easily.

- As pointed out above, the hindrance of *vicikicca* is removed at [the Sotapanna stage](#). The other four hindrances are removed in stages as one moves to higher *Nibbanic* states.
- For example, as one progresses from [the Sotapanna stage](#) to higher *Nibbanic* states, all *jhanic* factors are automatically fulfilled: The two hindrances of *kamachanda* and *vyapada* were reduced to *kamaraga* and *patigha* levels at [the Sotapanna stage](#). *Kamaraga* and *patigha* are reduced further at the *Sakadagami* stage, are removed at the *Anagami* stage. Thus an *Anagami* is left with *rupa raga* and *arupa raga*, and thus one has only attachment for *rupa loka* and *arupa loka*.
- On the other hand, the hindrance of *thina middha* is easily overcome by *savitakka*, i.e., when the mind is focused on *Nibbana* (*anicca, dukkha, anatta*). Thus any sleepiness or lethargic feeling cannot survive and one feels energetic. A *Sotapanna* is at the entry level of comprehending *anicca, dukkha, anatta*, and the understanding gets progressively better as one moves to higher stages and becomes complete only at the Arahant stage.
- The hindrance of *Uddacca* also decreases by stages and is completely removed only at the Arahant stage.
- Thus we can see that even without cultivating *jhanas*, an *Arahant* automatically removes all five hindrances. As one moves to higher stages of *Nibbana*, it should become easier to attain *jhanas*.

8. In summary, *Ariya jhanas* are more permanent in nature compared to *Anariya jhanas*. Thus a *Sotapanna* will be able to easily get to the first *Ariya jhana* in any of the future lives, because some of the five hindrances have been permanently reduced, and *vicikicca* permanently removed. Even in a noisy environment, *Ariya jhanas* (especially second or higher) can be summoned at will.

- The clearest distinction of an *Ariya jhana* is that once in the *jhana*, the *jhana* cannot be interrupted by *anusaya* or a lustful or a hateful thought. Even if one forcefully tries to think about such a thought, it does not “stick”; the mind rejects it; see, “[Ariya Jhanas via Cultivation of Saptha Bojjanga](#)“.
- One can think about anything while in a lower *jhana*. Doing insight meditation (contemplating on *anicca, dukkha, anatta* or any Dhamma concept) can be done with a clear, bright mind.

- All *jhanas* are mundane in the sense that they provide the jhanic experience in the *rupaloka* and *arupaloka*, which still belong to the 31 realms of existence. The *Nibbanic* bliss is the ultimate bliss.
- It is said that the *nirodha sammapatti* that can be attained by an *Arahant* is incomparably better compared to any *jhana*. It is said that an *Arahant* can enjoy the sensation of Nibbanic bliss continually for up to seven days in *nirodha sammapatti*.
- Thus ultimately what is most important is the purification of one's own mind; see, "[The Importance of Purifying the Mind](#)".

Next, "[Transfer of Merits \(Pattidana\) – How Does it Happen?](#)",

Transfer of Merits (Pattidana) – How Does it Happen?

1. Even some Buddhists are skeptical that merits can be “transferred” to other beings: It does not appear to be “scientific”. However, Buddha Dhamma is far ahead of science, and this is another example. Even though the vocabulary is different, mechanisms of “energy transfer” (mental energy) has been described in Dhamma.

- Not only the merits of a good deed, but also many other versions of “mental energy” can be transferred, as we discuss below.
- **The basic idea can be thought of as follows:** If one has an oil lamp that is lit, and if others have oil lamps that are not lit and they do not have a way to light them, wouldn’t it be better for everyone to let others use one’s lamp’s flame to light their lamps?
- Thus while it is not possible to “create” many oil lamps starting with one, it is possible to make thousand other lamps to become useful by sharing the light. In the same way, the receiving person needs to have a basic ingredients to reap the benefits, as explained below. But since all those lamps will be useless without a way to light them, the person providing the light is doing a great service.

2. First of all transfer of merits is the correct phrase, but “*punna anumodana*” is not. *Anumodana* means the receiving mind becoming joyful with the merits it received (“*anu*” + “*mödanä*”). The giver is giving (“*dāna*”) the “*paccayā*” or the auxiliary causes. (The common word is “*pratyaya*” but that is the incorrect Sanskrit word; the correct Pali word is *paccaya*). It is *paccaya* that represents “*patti*” in “*pattidana*” (pronounced, “*paththidāna*”).

- Other than in direct giving (see below) the giver cannot make the receiving party “receive what is intended” unless the person receiving has a mindset that is attuned to receiving.
- It is the receiving person that is doing the “*punna anumödanä*”, i.e., gladly receiving the *pattidana* of the giver and becoming joyful with the merits received.

3. Giving and receiving can be done in many ways:

- The direct way of giving/receiving is when one gives money or something material. It is deducted from the giver’s ledger and is added to the receiver’s: it is fully transferred.
- When a teacher teaches a classroom full of kids, he/she is teaching the same way to all the kids. But how much a particular kid “receives” or comprehends depends on that particular kid’s ability to receive.
- A radio/television station is broadcasting a program. But the reception of the program by a radio/TV depends on the quality of that device and also whether it has been “tuned” to the correct station.
- This transfer can happen instantaneously or with a time lag, because that mental energy is in the “*nama loka*” and is accessible at any time; see, “[Memory, Brain, Mind, Nama Loka, Kamma Bhava, Kamma Vipaka](#)”.

4. Therefore, only in “direct giving”, the amount received is the same as given. The amount received in the other other two “indirect giving” methods depends on the receiver. A similar mechanism is at work when one does a good deed and “transfers merits” to another person who may be far away.

- All intentions have *kammic* energy. You may remember that the Buddha said, “*Cetana ham bhikkave kamman vadami*”, or “Bhikkhus, I say intention is *kamma*”. **And kamma is the fundamental potential energy for everything in this world.**
- People very much underestimate the power of the human mind. Those who have experienced at least anariya jhanas can sense at least a little bit about the power of the mind; see, “[Power of the Human Mind – Introduction](#)” and the two follow-up posts.
- Direct giving is “*dāna*”; indirect giving is “*pattidāna*“. These are two of the ten meritorious deeds (*punna kamma*); see, “[Ten Moral Actions \(Dasa Kusala\) and Ten Meritorious Actions \(Punna Kriya\)](#)“.

5. One such mechanism is the *annantara-samanantara paccaya*; see “[Annantara and Samanantara Paccaya](#)”. This is a universal law governing the *kamma niyama*. Many people pronounce “*niyama*” as “*niyaama*”, but “*niyama*” is the Pali or Sinhala word for “principle”. Thus *kamma niyama* is the universal principle of *kamma* (like the law of gravitation).

6. When one is “transferring merits” by sincerely saying that “May so and so receive merits from this good deed that I have done”, or doing metta bhavana by saying, “May all beings be free from the suffering in the *apayas*” or some version of it, one is BROADCASTING one’s intention.

- However, just because one is doing such a “giving”, the intended recipient may not receive the benefits UNLESS the receiver has a matching mindset; it is just like the case of a radio/TV, where the receiving device need to be set to the “right frequency” to receive the signal.
- This is explained in the post, “[Annantara and Samanantara Paccaya](#)”. Don’t be discouraged by those Pali words; sometimes, as in the case of *paticca samuppada*, it is best to use the Pali words, because it is not possible to find an English word that can convey the same meaning.

7. Transfer of merits is efficient when the giver and the receiver are together and each is aware of the other’s intention. For example, in Asian countries it is customary to transfer merits to deceased relatives. Alms giving to the *Sangha* or similar meritorious deed is done and *pattidana* is offered to the deceased relative. If the deceased party is in a state where it can receive merits (such as a *gandhabbaya* state), then that *gandhabbaya* will be there anxiously awaiting to receive such merits.

8. It is possible to “give Dhamma” or to “give *kusala*” too. In fact the Buddha said, “*sabba danan Dhamma danan jinati*” or, “from all kinds of giving, Dhamma giving is the most meritorious”.

- When the Buddha gave a discourse, those who were listening “received” Dhamma or *kusala* in varying degrees. Some became *Arahants*, some attained *Sotapanna* stage, etc during the discourse itself and there were others who did not attain any stage but possibly still accumulated *kusala*. *Kusala* (“*ku*” or “*kunu*” or “dirty”+“*sala*” or “remove”, and thus shedding impure things from the mind) thus means absorbing wisdom, non-greed, non-hate AND discarding greed, hate, and delusion.
- During such a discourse it is mainly the delusion that is removed (and wisdom that is gained), which in turn results in discarding greed and hate to the extent of how much delusion was removed.

9. How much a given person receives in such an occasion depends of course on the intellectual level (and the state of mind) of the person. But it is not possible to quantify the intellectual level using modern standards of “book knowledge”. For example, it is not directly related to one’s formal

education. It is easier to give some examples.

- Ven. Ananda was highly literate, a former prince, and had an amazing memory power. He had the whole *sutta pitaka* in his memory. And he was with the Buddha for many years, but attained the *Arahanthood* only after the *Parinibbana* (passing away) of the Buddha.
- Suneetha was of low-caste, and was carrying buckets of feces when the Buddha met him. The Buddha with his supernormal powers, saw that Suneetha was capable of comprehending Dhamma and asked Suneetha to become a *bhikkhu*. Ven. Suneetha became an *Arahant* within seven days.

10. Even the same person may be receptive to “receiving Dhamma” at times when his mind is in a calm state, but may not comprehend anything when his mind is excited, or is distracted. This is the same as saying that the five hindrances are active; see, “[Key to Calming the Mind – Five Hindrances](#)”. Therefore, it is IMPORTANT to have a correct mindset when learning Dhamma, whether by listening or reading.

- Therefore, try to read these posts at quiet times, when the mind is receptive, and NOT during the brief breaks at work when the mind is occupied with other matters.
- In Asian countries, this is a major reason for going to the temple and making offering of flowers to a statue of the Buddha or the *Bo* tree at the temple. Such activities get the mind into a calm, peaceful state suitable for listening to a Dhamma discourse afterwards.

11. Therefore, it is important that both *annantara* and *samanantara* are optimized in order to make all these activities efficient.

- Of course if one is not learning the true Dhamma, *annantara* is not good and one is wasting one’s time. However, even if the Dhamma is good, if *samanantara* is not good, i.e., if the receiver’s mind is not receptive, then again it is a waste of time.
- This concept is easily grasped with the following example; A seed is the *anantara* or what is given. The mind state of the receiving party is like the field that the seed is planted. Unless that field is moist, has nutrients, and is exposed to sunlight, the seed cannot grow. Just like that the mindset of the person receiving merits (or Dhamma in the case of learning) needs to be in a receptive state. On the other hand, the giver (one doing *pattidana* or delivering Dhamma) needs to “give” potent seeds.
- It is only when both *ananantara* and *samanantara* are optimized and matched that full benefits result.

12. There is a type of “*anumodana*” that happens in day-to-day life too. Suppose X starts a project to feed the hungry. Many poor people benefit from it. When Y sees that Y may become joyful seeing the hungry getting fed, and may thank X for doing it. This joy of heart, even if Y did not contribute, counts as “merits”; it becomes a good *kamma vipaka* for Y. That does not take any merits away from X.

- It is not possible for something to come out of nothing. So, where do those kinds of merits come from? It comes from the mental energy of Y who became joyful upon seeing the good act. This is part of the mental energy (*javana*) that a human possesses; see, “[Power of the Human Mind](#)”.
- It is also possible for the effects of immoral acts to be transferred too. Suppose X is beating up

Y. Person Z may be glad to see that and may encourage X to beat up Y. Now, suppose Y dies as a result of the beating. Then not only X, but Z also gets bad *kamma vipaka* for that immoral act.

- In our societies also, the same principle applies. If the police investigating the death of Y has evidence that Z also encouraged the killing, Z as well as X could be prosecuted.
- Thus our feelings (good or bad) play an important role in accumulating good and bad *kamma vipaka*.

First Noble Truth is Suffering? Myths about Suffering

Most people believe that the First Noble Truth just says there is suffering. Some also think that it is possible to “remove” this existing suffering by following extensive and elaborate meditation techniques.

1. The Buddha said, “My Dhamma has not been known in this world. It is something people have never heard of previously”. So we should carefully examine to see what is really new about the suffering that he talked about.

- What is new about knowing that there is suffering around us? Everybody knows that there is suffering with old age, diseases, poverty, etc.
- And it is possible to REMOVE existing suffering by doing meditation? For example, if one has come down with a disease, can one overcome that by doing meditation? If someone is getting old and is feeling the pains and aches of old age, can that be PERMANENTLY removed by doing meditation? Even though some issues can be handled due to special reasons, in most cases we CANNOT change such EFFECTS or end results.

Let us discuss these two points one at a time.

3. Let us first see whether it is possible to REMOVE the existing suffering.

- For example, if someone has aches and pains due to old age, it is not possible to get rid of them other than to use medications or therapy to lessen the pain and manage it. If someone gets cancer, it is normally not possible to get rid of it by meditation. It may be handled by medication. Even the Buddha had pains and aches due to old age, and had a severe stomach ache at the end.
- In the context of that last sentence, It must be noted that there are two types of vedana (feelings): those due to kamma vipaka and those due to sankhara (attachment to sensual pleasures), and an Arahant gets rid of only the second kind until the Parinibbana (death); see, “[Vedana \(Feelings\) Arise in Two Ways](#)”.
- In fact, it may not even be possible to do meditation under any of such conditions. Even someone who has developed jhanas, may not be able to get into jhanas if the pains are too distracting.
- The purpose behind Buddhist meditation is to contemplate on the true nature of the world and find the CAUSES of such suffering, so that those causes can be stopped and FUTURE suffering can be stopped.
- It is true that one can get a relief from day-to-day stresses by doing different kinds of meditation. And it is good to do them. But such practices were there even before the Buddha. There was no need for a Buddha to reveal to the world that one could get some “calming down” by doing breath meditation or kasina meditation.
- In a way, such “samatha” meditations are comparable to taking an aspirin for a headache. One can get relief in the short term but it is temporary. But the problem that the Buddha addressed involved a much longer time scale, and will lead to a niramisa sukha that is permanent.

4. So, what was the “never heard truth about suffering” that the Buddha revealed to the world? In short it is the “suffering that is hidden in sense pleasures; the suffering that WILL ARISE in future lives”.

- Let us take an example to get a simple version of this “new idea”.
- When a fish bites the bait, it does not see the suffering hidden in that action. Looking from the ground we can see the whole picture and we know what is going to happen to the fish if it bites the bait. But the fish is unable to see that whole picture, and thus does not see the hidden suffering. It only sees a delicious bit of food.
- In the same way, if we do not know about the wider world of 31 realms (with the suffering-laden four lowest realms), and that we have gone through unimaginable suffering in those realms in the past, we only focus on what is easily accessible to our six senses.

5. **Seeing this hidden suffering is indeed difficult.** It is not possible to convey the whole message in one essay, but I will try to get across the main idea. One really needs to spend some time thinking through these issues. When the Buddha attained the Buddhahood, it said that he was worried whether he could convey this deep ideas to most people.

- Everything happens due to one or (usually) many causes. The famous Third Law of motion in physics says that every action has a reaction; and the First Law says that an object will not change its status unless a force acts on it. It is easy to see these “cause and effect” principles at work in mechanical objects. If something needs to be moved, it needs to be pushed or pulled. If a stone is thrown up, it must come down if there is gravity pulling it down.
- We seek pleasures that are highly visible. But if we gain such pleasures with immoral acts, the consequences of such immoral acts are not apparent. We can see a stone thrown up coming down, but we cannot see any bad consequences to the drug dealer who seems to be enjoying life.

6. **The main problem in clearly seeing the “cause and effect of mind actions” is that the results of those actions have a time delay and that time delay itself is not predictable.** In contrast, it is easy to predict what is going to happen with material things (moving an object, a vehicle, a rocket, etc). The success of physical sciences is due to this reason. Once the underlying laws are found (laws of gravity, laws of motion, electromagnetism, nuclear forces, quantum mechanics, etc), one has complete control.

- But the mind is very different. To begin with, no two minds work the same way. Under a given set of conditions, each mind will chose to act differently. With physical objects, that is not so; under a given set of conditions, what will happen can be predicted accurately.
- Effects of some actions (kamma) may not materialize in this life and sometimes it may come to fruition only in many lives down the road (but with accumulated interest).
- Even in this life, mind phenomena are complex: This is why economics is not a “real science”. It involves how people act sometimes “irrationally” for perceived gains. No economic theory can precisely predict how a given stock market will perform.

7. When mechanical systems have time lags, those are predictable. We can set off a device to work in a certain way **AT A CERTAIN TIME**, and we know that it will happen at that time if all mechanical components work properly. Not so with the mind. When we act in a certain way, the **RESULTS** of those actions may not be manifested for many lives. This is a key point to contemplate on.

- But cause and effect is a nature’s basic principle. **When something is done, it will lead to one or more effects.** In mind-related causes, the effects may take time, sometime a long time over many lives, to trigger the “corresponding effect”.

- Thus it should be clear that “action and reaction” associated with mind effects REQUIRE the rebirth process. It is not readily apparent and is an essential part of the “previously unheard Dhamma” that the Buddha revealed to the world.
- **This “cause and effect” that involves the mind is the principle of kamma and kamma vipaka in Buddha Dhamma.**

8. The life we have as a human is a RESULT of a past good deed. The life of a dog or an ant is the result of a past deed by that sentient being.

- And what happens to us in this life is a COMBINATION of what we have done in the past (kamma vipaka) AND what we do in this life.
- What happens to an animal is MOSTLY due to kamma vipaka from the past.
- The difference between a human and an animal is that the animal does not have much control over what is going to happen to it. But human birth is a special one: We have a higher level mind that CAN change the future to some extent, and with possible enormous consequences.

9. What can we change and what cannot be changed?

- We are born with a certain kamma vipaka built in. Our body features, major illnesses (such as cancer) are mostly, not completely, built-in. We can avoid many kamma vipaka by acting with mindfulness, i.e., by planning well, taking precautions, etc.
- But we CANNOT change the fact that we are going to get old and eventually die, no matter what we do. Our life a RESULT.
- What we CAN change are the CAUSES for future lives.
- Even though meditation cannot relieve us of most of the pre-determined suffering, proper meditation CAN provide temporary relief, as well as PERMANENTLY removing future suffering.

10. The second Noble Truth describes those CAUSES that we need to work on. The root causes are greed, hate, and ignorance, but they need to be removed mainly via understanding the Three Characteristics (see #12 below) and also via removing our bad sansaric habits; see a series of posts starting with, “[Habits, Goals, Character \(Gathi\)](#)” to “[The Way to Nibbana – Removal of Asavas](#)”.

11. The Third Noble Truth is about what can be achieved by systematically removing those causes. Niramisa sukha increases from the point of embarking on the Path, and has four levels of PERMANENT increases starting at the Sotapanna stage and culminating at the Arahant stage; there are several posts starting with, “[Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)”.

12. And then Fourth Noble Truth is the way to attain niramisa sukha and then various stages of Nibbana. Niramisa sukha starts when one lives a moral life (see, “Ten Immoral Actions (Dasa Akusala)” and follow-up posts). The root causes of immoral behavior are greed, hate, and ignorance. Ignorance can be reduced to the extent of attaining the Sotapanna stage just via comprehending the Three Characteristics of “this world of 31 realms”, i.e., *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*; see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations](#)”, and the follow-up posts. It is that powerful.

- Once one attains the Sotapanna stage, one can find the rest of the way by oneself.

13. There are many different ways to describe and analyze what I summarized above. Different people can grasp Dhamma by looking at it from different angles. That is what I try to cover with sections like

“Dhamma and Science”, “Dhamma and Philosophy”, and for those who like to dig deeper into Dhamma, the section on “Abhidhamma” which means “Higher or Deeper Dhamma”.

- My goal is to provide a “wide view” that accommodates most people. Even though I cannot even begin to cover even a significant fraction of Buddha Dhamma, one does not need to understand “everything” even to attain the Arahant hood. The Buddha has said that one could attain all four stages of Nibbana just via comprehending *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* at deeper and deeper levels. This is because with deeper understanding, one’s mind automatically directs one in the right direction.
- Another reason that I try to cover many topics is to illustrate the point that Buddha Dhamma is a complete description of nature.

Next, [Vinaya – The Nature Likes to be in Equilibrium](#) ...

Vinaya – The Nature Likes to be in Equilibrium

Nature is the final arbitrator. A criminal may be able to get away with a crime by hiring a good lawyer, but will have to pay for the crimes in the nature's court. Similarly, when we do something good, we will get the rewards regardless of whether we wish for anything in return or not. Most people do not realize this because of the time delay between the act (*kamma*) and its result (*kamma vipaka*).

1. When we do either a moral or an immoral act, that is done with an intention and has some energy associated with it. This is called *kammic* energy. That energy resides in the universe until spent or otherwise reduced by some means (this is related to quantum entanglement; see, "[Quantum Entanglement – We are All Connected](#)"). It is really the principle of energy conservation in physics.

- We can become indebted to a living being or to the “world as a whole”.
- There were no *vinaya* rules in Buddha *sāsana* for about 20 years after the Buddha attained Enlightenment. When Buddha Dhamma started flourishing, unscrupulous people started becoming monks to live a comfortable life depending on the kindness of the devotees. The Buddha admonished them about the consequences of becoming indebted and started setting up the *vinaya* (“vi” + “naya”, where “*naya*” in Pali or Sinhala is debt) rules to rein in those people.

2. When there is an energy imbalance, nature tries to bring it to balance. For a given individual (in the conventional sense), i.e., a life stream (absolute sense), the biggest imbalances are settled first.

- Thus at death when *patisandhi* takes place, the biggest *kamma* seed with highest imbalance come into play, and releases that energy by initiating the next birth in the corresponding “*bhava*”; see, “[Bhava and Jati – States of Existence and Births Therein](#)”. Thus the next “*bhava*” is determined by the biggest *kammic* seed at the end of the current “*bhava*” (this is really a simple interpretation of a complex process).
- During a lifetime (*pavutti vipaka*), in addition to the energy content, the prevailing conditions also come into play for delivering *kamma vipaka* or the release of *kamma* seeds. This is why we can prevent many bad *kamma vipaka* from come to fruition by acting with *yonisao manasikara* or by “being mindful”; see, “[What is Kamma? Is Everything Determined by Kamma?](#)”.
- In both cases (*patisandhi* and *pavutti vipaka*), “matching conditions” plays a big role; see, “[Annantara and Samanantara Paccaya](#)”. For example, a seed does not germinate if it is in a dry place; it needs to be in the ground with water and sunlight in order to germinate.

3. Getting back to the issue of coming to equilibrium, a stone is in equilibrium when it stays on the ground. If we pick it up and throw it up it goes up because we gave it some energy. But now it is not in equilibrium, and it will fall down to find its equilibrium position on the ground. The only difference with *kammic* energy is that the *kammic* energy could be released much later; it has to find suitable conditions to release that energy; see, “[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka](#)”, and “[Paticca Samuppada – Overview](#)”; Thus the release of *kammic* energy is more akin to the process of germination of a seed; there is a time lag until suitable conditions appear.

- A seed, when placed in the ground, germinates and becomes a tree by releasing the energy that was trapped in the seed. When the energy is all spent, the tree will die. Unless the tree itself made more seeds during its lifetime, that tree is the only “result” of that original seed.

4. Through numerous lives in the past we have accumulated innumerable number of both good and

bad kammic energy packets, or kamma beeja, or kamma seeds and we keep producing them in this lifetime too; some are big and some are small (actually, those done beyond 91 maha kalpas have lost their energy; like everything else in this world, kammic energy is not permanent either). The small kammic seeds bring in results (vipaka) during any lifetime, and the really big ones (kamma patha) are the ones that determine “bhava” for a new life at the cuti-patisandhi moment.

- Does that mean we have to remove all *kamma* seeds to stop rebirth, i.e., to attain *Nibbana*? No. A new “bhava” is grasped at the “*upadana paccaya bhavo*” step in the *paticca samuppada* cycle; see “[Akusala-Mula Paticca Samuppada](#)“. If one has removed ignorance (*avijja*) and understood the true nature of the world, then there is no “*tanha*” and thus there is no *upadana* at the “*tanha paccaya upadana*” step, and thus no “*bhava*”, and no “*jati*” or birth.
- However, in order to remove ignorance (*avijja*), we have to purify our minds. For that we need to understand the true nature of “this world”, i.e., *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. For that we need to get rid of the five hindrances (*panca nivarana*) that are covering our minds and not letting the mind comprehend *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. That is where the removal of bad kamma seeds and accumulation of good *kamma* seeds become important.

5. The point is that every time we do a moral or an immoral act we generate a *kamma* seed that embeds the “*javana* power” of the thought that led to the act; see, “[Javana of a Citta – The Root of Mental Power](#)“. The kammic power associated with a moral act can be considered surplus in one’s “account” that can be used to enjoy things in life; an immoral act leads to a debt, i.e., it appears on the negative side of the ledger. If one does an immoral act against another living being, then one be in debt to that being until it is paid off; see, “[Kamma, Debt, and Meditation](#)“.

6. The nature tries to keep things in balance: the good *kamma* bring good results and bad *kamma* brings bad results when the nature implements this balancing act. In both cases, we can take advantage of this by arranging conditions for good *kamma* seeds to germinate and not letting bad *kamma* seeds to germinate; see, “[What is Kamma? Is Everything Determined by Kamma?](#)“. The development of good habits and getting rid of bad habits go along with this process; see, “[Habits and Goals](#)“, and “[Sansaric Habits and Asavas](#)“. Please review these links carefully. All these tie up together.

7. Thus we are bound to this *sansara* or the cycle of rebirths because we do things to make an “imbalance” either via moral or immoral deeds: good deeds lead to good rebirths and bad one to bad rebirths. They both extend the sansaric journey. However, it is essential to engage in moral deeds in order to avoid birth in the four lowest realms (*apayas*), where the suffering is great AND also there is no opportunity to moral deeds. Thus one MUST do moral deeds until one attains *Nibbana*.

- Moral deeds WILL have their consequences (they add up in the “plus side of the ledger”), whether or not one wishes for anything in return, i.e., the nature will pay back. However, if one does a moral deed AND wishes for something other than *Nibbana*, then that is done with greed, and thus one is simultaneously doing an immoral act.
- Only an Arahant does not do any moral or immoral deeds that have *kammic* consequences that are potent enough to bring rebirth. All an Arahant does is low-level *sankhara* or “*kriya*” (like walking and talking), and is “in equilibrium” with nature.

8. When one goes “off the equilibrium”, greed and hate intensify and one is likely do immoral acts to become indebted. On the other hand, when one is in some kind of a *samadhi*, the mind is close to equilibrium, and thus greed and hate are under control. If one attains *rupavacara* and then *arupavacara* jhanas then the mind gets even more closer to equilibrium. *Samadhi* attains perfection

when one becomes an *Arahant*.

- This is why one needs to stay away from doing immoral acts, if one wants to get results in meditation. A purified mind can easily get to *samadhi*; see, “[The Basics in Meditation](#)”.
- One becomes indebted via greed, hate, or ignorance (here ignorance means not knowing the true nature of the world or *anicca, dukkha, anatta*); thus there is *lobha vinaya*, *dosa vinaya*, and *moha vinaya*.

Key Dhamma Concepts

Within thousand years of the Buddha's Parinibbana, certain key concepts became distorted. For many years, I had nagging questions on the compatibility of certain concepts that are widely published in "Buddhist literature", including Theravada literature. For example, explanations of *anicca*, *anatta*, *sunyata*, did not make sense to me. Furthermore, I got lost in a myriad of explanations for terms like *sankhara*; there are three different meanings for that word in standard Theravada texts.

When I started listening to the *desanas* by the two *Theros* in Sri Lanka, it became immediately apparent to me that "this was the true Dhamma". Furthermore, concepts like *sansara*, *samma*, *sankhara* became crystal clear while I was just listening. I hope I will be able to convey this information as clearly below.

Continue to "[What is "San? – Meaning of Sansara \(or Samsara\)".....](#)

San

[What is “San”? Meaning of Sansara \(or Samsara\)](#)

[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka](#)

[Sankhara – Life is a Bundle of Sankhara](#)

[Difference Between Dhamma and Sankhara \(Sankata\)](#)

What is “San”? Meaning of Sansara (or Samsara)

1. A key word, the meaning of which has been hidden for thousands of years, is “*san*” (pronounced like son). “*San*” is basically the term for “good and bad things we acquire” while we exist anywhere in the 31 realms; see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”.

2. There is also a reason for calling what we “pile up” as “*san*”. In Pali and Sinhala, the word for numbers is “*sankhyā*”, and *sankhyā* = “*san*” + “*khyā*”, meaning (add & multiply) + (subtract & divide), i.e., *sankhya* is what is used for addition, multiplication, subtraction, and division. From this, “*san*” gives the idea of “piling up” (addition and multiplication); “*khyā*” gives the idea of “removal” (subtraction and division).

- Therefore “*san*” is used to indicate things we do in the *sansaric* journey; see below for examples.
- “*Khyā*” or “*Khayā*” is used to indicate removal. *Nibbana* is attained via removal of defilements (*raga*, *dosa*, *moha*), and thus *Nibbana* is “*ragakkhaya*”, “*dosakkhaya*”, and “*mohakkhaya*”.

Just by knowing this, it is possible to understand to root of many common words, such as *sankhara*, *sansara*, *sanna*, *samma*, etc. Let us analyze some of these words.

3. However, a distinction needs to be made between *sankhara* and *abhisankhara*. *Sankhara* includes EVERYTHING that we do to live in “this world” of 31 realms; these include breathing, walking, eating, pretty much everything. Even an Arahant has to be engaged in *sankhara* until *Parinibbana* or death. Some *sankhara* arise from with *alobha*, *adosa*, or *amoha* as a root cause; see, “[Kusala-Mula Paticca Samuppada](#)”. The other types of *sankhara* arise from *avijja* (ignorance), and have *lobha* (greed), *dosa* (hatred), or *moha* (delusion) as a root cause; see, “[Akusala-Mula Paticca Samuppada](#)”.

- The prefix “*abhi*” means “stronger” or “coarse”. *Sankhara* become *abhisankhara* by engaging in the “wheeling process”; see, “[Nibbana – Is it Difficult to Understand?](#)”. **The *sansaric* process or the rebirth process is fueled by *abhisankhara*.**
- The bad things we acquire – with *lobha* (greed), *dosa* (hate), *moha* (delusion) – contribute to rebirth in lower four realm; these are ***apunnabhi sankhara***. The good things we acquire via *alobha*, *adosa*, *amoha* help gain rebirth in human realm and above; these are ***punnabhi sankhara***. Thus, both kinds contribute to lengthening the rebirth process, but we DO need to acquire good things for two reasons: (i) it prevents us from doing bad things, (ii) done with right intention, it will help purify our minds.

4. Another important term is “*ma*”, which means “to become free of”. For example:

- “*Ma hoti jati, jati*”, means “may I be free of repeated birth”.
- “*Ma mé bāla samāgamō*” means “may I be free of association with those who are ignorant of Dhamma”.

5. Knowing the correct meaning of such terms, leads to clear understanding of many terms:

- *Sankhara* = *san* + *kāra* = actions done while in existence anywhere in the 31 realms. All actions are ceased only at *Parinibbana*, i.e., when an Arahant dies.
- *Abhi sankhara* = “*Abhi*” + *sankāra* = strong/repeated actions for prolonging rebirth process.

Please note that even meritorious actions are included here.

- *Sansāra* (or *samsara*) = *san* + *sāra* = perception that “*san*” are good, fruitful. Thus one continues in the long rebirth process with the wrong perception that it is fruitful.
- *Sammā* = *san* + *mā* = eliminate or route out “*san*”. Thus *Samma Ditthi* is routing out the wrong views that keeps one bound to *sansara*.
- *Sannā* = *san* + *nā* = knowing or understanding “*san*”. This actually happens when one attains *Nibbana*. Until then the *sanna* is clouded or distorted. When we identify some object, say a rose, we just identify it in a conventional way as a flower. We do not “see” the true nature of anything until *Nibbana* is attained. Thus it is said that until we attain *Nibbana*, we have distorted (*vipareetha*) *sanna*.
- *Sandittiko* = *san* + *ditthi* = ability to see “*san*”; one becomes *sanditthiko* at the *Sotapanna* stage. Most texts define *sandittiko* with inconsistent words like, self-evident, immediately apparent, visible here and now, etc.
- *Sangayānā* = *san* + *gāyanā* = recite and categorize “*san*” (and ways to remove them) in organizing Dhamma for passing down to future generations. The first *Sangayana* was held to systematize his teachings, just 3 months after the *Parinibbana* of the Buddha.
- *Sanvara* = *san* + *vara* = Eliminate “*san*” via moral behavior. “*Sanvarattena seelan*” means *silā* is moral behavior. It is to be cultivated 24 hours a day, not just on specific days. “*Yam samadanan tam vathan*”, means observing the five precepts or eight precepts on specific days is just a ritual, or “*vatha*”. Such rituals are good starting points, but need to be discarded as one gains wisdom.
- *Sanvēga* (or “*samvega*”) = *san* + *vēga* = forceful, strong impulses due to “*san*”
- *Sanyōga* (or “*samyoga*”) = *san* + *yōga* = bound together via “*san*”
- *Sansindheema* = *san* + *sindheema* = removing *san*, for example, via the seven steps described in the *Sabbasava Sutta*. This leads to *niramisa sukha* or *Nibbanic bliss*.
- *Sansun* = *san* + *sún* = when “*san*” is removed (“*sûn*” rhymes like soup) one’s mind becomes calm and serene.

6. A nice example to illustrate the significance of “*san*”, is to examine the verse that Ven. Assaji delivered to Upatissa (the lay name of Ven. Sariputta, who was a chief disciple of the Buddha):

“*Ye dhamma hetu pabbava, te san hetun Thathagatho aha, Te san ca yo nirodho, evan vadi maha Samano*”

Te = three, *hetu* = cause, *nirodha* = *nir*+*uda* = stop from arising

The translation is now crystal clear:

“All dhamma (in this world) arise due to causes arising from the three “*san*”s: *raga*, *dosa*, *moha*. The Buddha has shown how to eliminate those “*san*”s and thus stop dhamma from arising”

7. We will encounter many such instances, where just by knowing what “*san*” is, one could immediately grasp the meaning of a certain verse. Most these terms are easily understood in Sinhala language. **Contrary to popular belief, it is NOT Sanskrit that is closely related to the *Maghadhi* language that the Buddha spoke, it is Sinhala (or Sinhalese) that is closely related to *Maghadhi***

(*Maghadhi*= “*maga*” + “*adhi*” = Noble path).

- *Tipitaka* was written in Pali with Sinhala script; Pali is a version of *Maghadhi* suitable for writing down oral discourses in summary form suitable for transmission.
- Each Pali word is packed with lot of information, and thus commentaries were written to expound the meaning of important Pali words.
- A good example is the key Pali word “*anicca*“. In Sanskrit it is “*anitya*“, and this is what normally translated to English as “impermanence”. But the actual meaning of *anicca* is very clear in Sinhala: The Pali word “*icca*” (pronounced “*ichcha*”) is the same in Sinhala, with the idea of “this is what I like”. Thus *anicca* has the meaning “cannot keep it the way I like”.

Continue to “[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka](#)“.....

Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka

There is much confusion about these words. These are key Dhamma concepts, and one needs to sort them out in order to really understand other key concepts like rebirth and *Paticca Samuppada*. Please read the post, “[What is “San”? – Meaning of Sansara \(or Samsara\)](#)” before reading this post.

Sankhara (what we accumulate)

1. “*Punnabhi sankhara, apunnabhi sankhara, anenjabhi sankhara ayan vuccathi avijja pacca sankhara*“. This is how the short verse of “*avijja paccaya sankhara*” in *akusala-mula paticca samuppada* is explained in detail.

- Thus only *abhisankhara* (“*abhi*” means higher or stronger), those *sankhara* done with *avijja*, lead to the rebirth process.
- Note that *punnabhi sankhara* is *punna+abhisankhara*, and similarly the other two are also *abhisankhara*. Also, “*punna*” means moral, “*apunna*” means immoral, and “*anenja*” means “*jhanic*”. Thus any kind of *abhisankhara* is done with ignorance (*avijja* or not knowing the real characteristics of this world: *anicca, dukkha, anatta*). However, we will see below that we do need to accumulate *punnabhi sankhara* in a strategical way, mainly to avoid rebirth in the *apayas* (lowest four realms) until we attain Nibbana.

2. As we saw above, “*san*” is what one acquires when one does anything with *sancetana* (“*san*” + “*cetana*”). *Sankhara* (*san+kara*) is simply actions that lead to acquiring “*san*“. **However, it is only “*abhisankhara*” or *sankhara* that arise through *avijja* that can lead to rebirth.** There is a difference between *sankhara* and *abhisankhara*:

- When deeds are done to live in this world, one has to do *sankhara*. They become *abhisankhara* when those are done with greed, hate, and/or ignorance. *Sankhara* become *abhisankhara* when one starts generating further thoughts about the picture, sound, taste, etc ; see #9 on “[Nibbana – Is It Difficult to Understand?](#)“.
- Thus an *Arahant* does *sankhara* to live; even breathing is *kaya sankhara*. But an *Arahant* has stopped the “wheeling process” or form an attachment to what is seen, heard, etc. It is that “wheeling process”, which is detailed in the *Paticca Samuppada* section that leads to *abhisankhara*.

3. *Abhisankhara* are three kinds as mentioned above:

- There are actions that lead to bad consequences during life and also to bad rebirths. These are “*apunnabhi sankhara*” or immoral deeds.
- Actions that lead to good consequences in life and also to good rebirths are called “*punnabhi sankhara*” or meritorious deeds; these lead to birth in good realms, thus avoiding rebirth in bad realms where one could get trapped for many aeons. Thus it is important to accumulate *punnabhi sankhara*; more on this below.
- When one cultivates “*lokiya jhanas*” or mundane meditative states, via breath meditation for example, one is able to be reborn in higher Brahma worlds. These also prolong *sansara*, and are called “*anenjabhi sankhara*“.

Therefore, it is easy to remember *abhisankhara* as those actions that lead to prolonging *sansara*, the cycle of rebirths. There is a “latent energy” that is produced by each such action (*abhisankhara*) that

will give fruits at a later time.

4. Such “actions” can be done via the mind, speech, or the body; these lead to *mano sankhara*, *vaci sankhara*, and *kaya sankhara* respectively.

5. Does this mean one should not do meritorious deeds because those also prolong sansara? No. The Buddha emphasized that one should not shy away from doing meritorious deeds.

- There is a way to do meritorious deeds without prolonging sansara, and that is detailed in the **“[Kusala-Mula Paticca Samuppada](#)”, an important part of the Buddha’s *Paticca samuppada* doctrine that has been hidden for thousands of years.** But one needs to stay away from wishing for “things in return” for such meritorious deeds, because such thoughts are based on greed. **[Any good deed will have its good consequences whether one wishes or not.](#)** By wishing for “material things” or “jhanic pleasures” one turns a meritorious action to an *apunnabhi sankhara*. We will discuss that below.

Kamma (Actions to Prolong Sansara)

Kammic energy is generated when one turns *sankhara* to *abhisankhara* by the “wheeling process”; see above. For example, when one sees an object, that is just *sankhara* due to a *kamma vipaka*. However, if one then starts thinking about how good it is, or think about how to acquire it, then it becomes *abhisankhara*; **here one now has INTENTIONS about that object, one is hoping to get something.**

That is why the Buddha said, “*cetana ham Bhikkhave kamman vadami*“, i.e., “I say that intention is kamma”.

So it is important to remember that kamma is action, and even though it can be done by the mind, speech, or the body, all those have their root in the mind. We cannot say anything or do anything without a thought in the mind to do so (see the Abhidhamma section for details).

Kamma Beeja (Kamma Seeds) or Kamma Bhava

When a kamma (*abhisankhara*) is committed, the kammic potential of that kamma is deposited in a *kamma beeja* (kamma seed); kamma seed is NOT a physical entity, it is an “energy” or “potential” to bring about an effect in the future. It can also be called a “*kamma bhava*“.

- A kamma seed can be compared to a normal seed, say for example, a seed of an apple tree. The potential to bring about a fully grown apple tree is in the apple seed. However, if the seed is kept in a dry place with no contact with soil, it does not get to germinate. It will germinate if placed under soil and fed with water and nutrients. Then it can grow to an apple tree which can yield thousand more seeds.
- **Similarly, a kamma seed has the POTENTIAL to germinate or come to fruition if suitable conditions appear.** It can then yield results with an impact that is many times the impact of the original deed (this holds true for both good and bad); the results are the *kamma vipaka*; see, **[“What is Kamma? – Is Everything Determined by Kamma?”](#)**.

Nothing in this world is permanent (but that impermanence is not *anicca*); kammic energy in a kamma seed also eventually loses its power, and the “staying power” depends on the strength of the particular kamma. For example, those seed corresponding to “*anantariya akusala kamma*” such as killing one’s parents or an *Arahant*, will bring fruits without delay (i.e., in the very next birth) before

they lose their power.

Kamma Vipaka (Results of a Kamma Seed or Kamma Bhava)

So it is important to distinguish between kamma and kamma vipaka: the first is the action, second is the consequence. When someone laments “this is my kamma” when he/she faces a bad situation, what is really meant is that this happens “because of what I had done in the past”. It is a kamma vipaka.

When one does something good or bad that kammic energy is deposited as a *kamma beeja* (seed), which is also called a *kamma bhava*. Then that kammic energy can give rise to kamma vipaka in the future when suitable conditions materialize.

Kamma vipaka (from the germination of seeds) lead to two main consequences:

- They can lead to consequences during a lifetime (either the present or a future life). These are called “***pavutti kamma bhava***”.
- Some strong kamma vipaka give rise to new existence (in the rebirth process). These are called “***uppatthi kamma bhava***”.

In either case, kamma vipaka are NOT deterministic. Both types can be reduced in strength or even be made ineffective. This can be done via several ways:

- When one becomes an *Arahant*, since there is no more rebirth, all kamma seeds that do not get to come to fruition before the death of an *Arahant* become ineffective in producing a rebirth: Because an *Arahant* has removed *avijja*, the “*akusala-mula paticca samuppada* cycle” becomes ineffective and thus “*bhava paccaya jati*” does not get to initiate a new birth.
- However, even an *Arahant* is subjected to any kamma vipaka that get a chance to emerge during the current life, especially the strong ones. Even the Buddha suffered from physical pains during the last years of his life.
- We all have done innumerable kamma in this long sansara. Thus many kamma seeds are waiting to “bear fruit” under right conditions. This is a key point one really needs to digest. Just like a seed can lay dormant for long times, and start germinating only under the right conditions (soil, water), a kamma vipaka bears fruit only when the conditions become right.
- **Thus most kamma vipaka can be suppressed and avoided (not letting them germinate) by acting with mindfulness (*yoniso manasikara*).** This is where a calm mind helps. An agitated mind is not able to make rational decisions. See, “[Key to Calming the Mind](#)“. As mentioned there, working on the Five Hindrances (*panca nivarana*), that covers a mind, is important.

How to do Meritorious Deeds without Accumulating *Abhisankhara*

Most people, even born Buddhists, do not get this right. They think Nibbana can be attained by just doing meritorious deeds. Here are some key points to consider:

1. One definitely needs to avoid *apunnabhi sankhara* (unmeritorious deeds) that will lead to bad life events and/or bad rebirths, i.e., the four lower realms; see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of the Dhamma](#)“. They are “*akusala*” by definition, but ones of the worst kind; these are called “*pāpa*” in Pali and Sinhala and “*paw*” (rhymes with “cow”) in Sinhala. This is what one needs to avoid in leading a moral life; see, “[Moral Living](#)”.

2. *Punnabhi sankhara* (meritorious deeds) can be accompanied by *apunnabhi sankhara* if one’s

intention is not good. If one does a good deed AND wishes for something in return, that wishing is done with greed. Any good deed WILL produced good results whether one wishes or not. They actually lead to good life events and good rebirths (at or above human realm). **Thus *punnabhi sankhara* can help in pursuing Nibbana, and should be done without greedy intentions. A Sotapanna automatically does meritorious deeds with such understanding; we will discuss this in the “[Kusala-Mula Paticca Samuppada](#)”. Thus the Aryan way is to do a good deed and share the merits of that deed with all beings, instead of wishing for something in return.**

- Thus one needs to be careful here because one may be acquiring apunnabhi sankhara at the same time. This is a bit complex and is best illustrated with an example. Suppose one donates a meal to a hungry person. That act is inherently one that will produce a good outcome. However, if the person “makes a wish” such as “may I get delicious foods in the future because of this good deed”, that is a greedy thought, a greedy intention (cetana). Thus while this does not negate the good deed, it also could produce ANOTHER *kamma vipaka* leading to bad life events.
- This pitfall can be avoided by doing the good deed with a pure intention, that is not associated with greed, hate, or ignorance. One gives a meal to hungry person out of compassion; to quench the hunger. That is all. Here one does not lose any possible benefits of the act.
- One reaps the best outcome by additionally doing a mental act to quench the potential of previous bad kamma seeds. This is called “giving of merits” or “pattidana” which is mislabelled as “*punna anumodana*” frequently; see, “[Ten Moral Actions \(Dasa Kusala\) and Ten Meritorious Actions \(Punna Kriya\)](#)”. One could wish that the merits of this good deed be shared with all other beings. We have built-up debts with all the beings in this long sansara, that needs to be paid off (see, “[Kamma, Debt, and Meditation](#)”). Thus, sharing the merits actually becomes a “*visankhara*” or “unwinding the power of previous sankhara”. This is thus one way to lessen the impact of the previous bad kamma vipaka.
- **The Buddha said that one always need to do good, meritorious, deeds. Giving is especially encouraged.** One could turn these deeds to *visankhara* by sharing the merits. **By the way, sharing merits does not remove any possible good outcomes to oneself. Those were already acquired in the original act itself.** The key here is not to wish for “profits in return”, because such thoughts are associated with greed.

3. The third kind of *abhisankhara*, “*anenjabhi sankhara*” are associated with jhanic states attained via *samatha bhavana*, such as breathing meditation or kasina meditation. They are pursued in order to achieve higher meditative states, and thus are pursued with a greedy thought (pleasure). These meditation techniques do not help with the cleansing of the asavas; see, “[Samsaric Habits and Asavas](#)”, and “[The Way to Nibbana – Removal of Asavas](#)”.

4. *Lokottara* (transcendental) jhanic states are achieved automatically when pursuing Nibbana. The goal here was to achieve Nibbana, and thus no sankhara are accumulated in this process. This brings up another question: Is [seeking Nibbana](#) another type of craving (*asava*)?

- Nibbana is attained via removing craving for everything in this world, and thus NOT via craving for anything: “*ragakkhayo Nibbanan, Dosakkhayo Nibbanan, Mohakkhayo Nibbanan*”.
- Thus in [seeking Nibbana](#), one is not craving for anything. One is working diligently to comprehend the true nature of the world, and with that wisdom gained, the mind automatically gives up craving for anything.

Next, “[Sankhara – Life is a Bundle of Sankhara](#)“,

Sankhara – Life is a Bundle of Sankhara

In the previous introductory post, “[What is “San”?](#)”, we introduced the term “*sankhara*”, and in the next post *sankhara* was discussed in somewhat technical terms. Since it is such an important term, in this post I will discuss it in a bit more detail.

1. Buddha Dhamma is based on the fact that all “*sankhara*” are done in vain: “*sabbe sankhara anicca*”.

- As we saw in the previous post, *sankhara* (“*san*” + “*kara*” or actions) are anything (thought, speech, bodily actions) done while living in “this world” of 31 realms. This includes breathing, walking, or thinking about the chores for the day.
- Thus even an *Arahant* does *sankhara* until death. But an *Arahant* does not do *abhisankhara*, a “stronger version” of *sankhara* that will lead to accumulating mental energy (*kamma*) for future repercussions (*kamma vipaka*) until that *kammic* energy is exhausted.
- In order for a *sankhara* to become an *abhisankhara*, one of the six root causes (greed, hate, ignorance, generosity, kindness, wisdom) need to be involved.

2. If the “bad roots” of greed, hate, and ignorance are involved, then those thoughts, speech, actions will create *kamma beeja* (or energy seeds) that either lead to bad outcomes during a life or to rebirth in the lowest four realms (*apayas*). These are *apunnabhisankhara* (“*apunna*” + “*abhisankhara*” where “*apunna*” means non-meritorious).

- On the other hand, *abhisankhara* done with the “good roots” of generosity, kindness, wisdom either lead to good outcomes during a life or to rebirth in the realms at or above the human realm. These are *punnabhisankhara* (“*punna*” + “*abhisankhara*” where “*punna*” means meritorious).
- If no roots are involved, they are just *sankhara*, and their *kamma* seeds are duds; there is no energy in them. Basically one can say, *sankhara* (that are not *abhisankhara*) do not generate *kamma* seeds.

3. Let us take some examples. When we see someone is walking with a knife in hand, we cannot come to a conclusion about what kind of *sankhara* is that person is generating.

- He may be just taking the knife from one place to another, in which case, it is just *sankhara*.
- If he is planning to stab someone, then he is generating *apunnabhisankhara*.
- If he is planning to rescue an animal who got entangled in a trap, then he is generating *punnabhisankhara*.
- In any type of speech or bodily action, what really matters is the INTENTION behind the speech or action.

4. In another example, we may see two people have built and donated two hospitals for the poor. Even though both seem to be “good actions”, we cannot say both had *punnabhisankhara*. One could have had an ulterior motive of getting elected in an upcoming election, rather than thoughts of loving kindness for poor people. In that case, he would be generating mostly *apunnabhisankhara*, even though there may be some *punnabhisankhara* involved too.

- This is why sorting out *kamma* is impossible for anyone but a Buddha. Some of our actions could involve both kinds of *abhisankhara*. For example, if we see a bird digging up a worm and

chase the bird away, we would have done both kinds of *abhisankhara*: Saving the life of the worm is a *punnabhisankhara*, but we also did an *apunnabhisankhara* because we denied the bird of its meal. Both types of *abhisankhara* can bear fruits (*vipaka*) in the future.

5. There is this famous “trolley problem” in ethics, where one could save five people from death by sacrificing the life of a single person; see, http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Trolley_problem

This “thought experiment” has been debated for many years. We can make the following observations based on Buddha Dhamma:

- If one decides to take action (i.e., save five by sacrificing one), then one will acquire “good *kamma*” for saving the five lives, and “bad *kamma*” for killing the other person. Both types can bear fruits in the future.
- But it goes even deeper. What if the person that we sacrificed was an *Arahant* or at least a *Sotapanna*, and the other five were normal people or even criminals? Then we would have acquired much more bad *kamma* than good *kamma*.

6. When someone is talking or doing some bodily action, we can at least try to guess what kind of *sankhara* are involved. But if a person is just sitting down quietly, he/she could be generating any kind of *sankhara* ranging from just thinking about whether or not go out for a walk (just *sankhara*) to planning a murder (worst kind of *apunnabhisankhara*).

- We generate more *abhisankhara* via thinking than via speech or actions.
- When we have disagreement with other people, we normally do not hit the person or even refrain from saying anything. But depending on the purity of our minds, we may be generating a little to unimaginable amounts of *apunnabhisankhara*. This is a key factors that most people tend to disregard.
- If someone’s outward actions/speech seem to be “disciplined”, we automatically assume that he/she is a good person; and the person may be trying to fool himself/herself by displaying that outward appearance. But if the mind is impure, there could be a lot of hateful/greedy thoughts in that mind. Whether or not any verbal or bodily actions are committed, those thoughts still accumulate *kamma* seeds.

7. Therefore, it is utterly useless to judge other people. Each person has true awareness AND control only over one’s own thoughts, speech, actions, which are ultimately based on the intentions.

- **But we know exactly what our own intentions are.** And that is what really matters. We may be able to fool a court of law by hiring a good lawyer, but we will have to reap the results of what we sow in the future at some point.

8. This is the basis of *anapana* meditation, to be aware of the types of *sankhara* involved in a given action; see, “[What is Anapana?](#)“. If someone asks us to join in fishing trip, we need to think what kind of *kamma* will be associated with killing fish for our pleasure; this is the basic form of “*kayanupassana*”. Contemplate on any bodily action one is about to do and abstain from doing it if it involves *apunnabhisankhara* (in this case taking the lives of several fish for our pleasure).

- Bodily actions are easier to prevent, because they take time and we have time to contemplate.
- Speech is a bit more tricky, because speech comes out faster than carrying out bodily action. Still one can stop oneself even after uttering a few sentences.

- Thoughts are the hardest, and that is why “*cittanupassana*” comes after one has practiced “*kayanupassana*”.

9. If one wants to start doing *anapana* meditation, one should first control one’s bodily actions, and the more one does it, the easier it becomes. And then it also becomes easier to control one speech. When both actions and speech are brought under control, one’s thoughts will be easier to control too.

- Furthermore, willfully engaging in *punnabhisankhara* also helps to keep *apunnabhisankhara* at bay. By concentrating on meritorious deeds, one’s mind is automatically turned away from thinking about unmeritorious deeds.
- This is why real Buddhist meditation is much more than just formal sitting meditation. **The key is to purify the mind, and avoid defiling the mind at anytime. One could be doing the breath meditation for a lifetime, but may not get anywhere in purifying the mind.**

10. Nibbana is attained not by abstaining from both *punnabhisankhara* and *apunnabhisankhara* as some suggest. On the way to *Nibbana*, one needs to do *punnabhisankhara* AND also engage in learning Dhamma so that one could comprehend the true nature of all types of *sankhara*, i.e., that all *sankhara* are *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. This leads to the purification of the mind; just by doing *punnabhisankhara* is not enough to purify the mind.

Next, “[Difference Between Dhamma and Sankhara \(Sankata\)](#)“,

Difference Between Dhamma and Sankhara (Sankata)

First, it is important to remember that the word “dhamma” can mean somewhat different things in different contexts. In ‘Buddha Dhamma’, it means the “Buddha’s world view”; but below “dhamma” is used in the sense of “things” and “actions” and “concepts”, or basically everything in this world of 31 realms.

1. There is confusion about the terms sankhara and dhamma in the Dhammapada verses 277, 278, and 279; the first line in each of those three are:

“**Sabbe sankhara anicca**” or “all sankhara are *anicca* (cannot be maintained to one’s satisfaction)”

“**Sabbe sankhara dukkha**” or “all sankhara eventually lead to dukkha”

“**Sabbe dhamma anatta**” or “all dhamma are without substance”

- It must be noted that “*sankhara*” here means any action, speech, or thought that can give rise to a *sankata*. Anything that we experience in this world is a *sankata*, and they all undergo unpredictable change and eventually are destroyed. The only thing that is not destroyed is *nama gotta*, which are just records of any given lifestream.
- Ven. Walpola Rahula Thero, in his popular and otherwise excellent book, “What the Buddha Taught” did not get it right when he interpreted those verses; he included Nibbana in dhamma (p. 57 of 1974 edition). **He took the difference between dhamma and sankhara to be Nibbana.** But to say *Nibbana* is *anatta* is an extremely bad mistake. This error resulted because, as with millions of people over hundreds of years, he had been misled by the wrong interpretations of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.
- The problems with the traditional interpretation of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* are discussed in, “[Anicca, Dukka, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations](#)“, and “[Anicca, Dukka, Anatta – True Meanings](#)“.

2. When we do sankhara, that lead to the formation of sankata at some time in the future. And **nama gotta (pronounced “näma goththä)** are just records of what happened. Thus dhamma is sankhara, sankata, and nama gotta. Here dhamma is absolutely everything in this world (Nibbana does not belong to this world of 31 realms).

- Unlike sankhara, *nama gotta* are PERMANENT. This is why someone with abhinna powers can go back at any point in time to recall past events; also see, “[Recent Evidence for Unbroken Memory Records \(HSAM\)](#)“.
- Whenever we do something (a sankhara) an “imprint” (“*näma satahana*”) is made. Thus for a given sentient being, a record of all activities from the beginning-less time survives, and is one’s *nama gotta*. All previous lives and all activities of previous lives are in that “record stream”, like a movie reel (not physical of course).
- Someone who has developed abhinna through anariya jhanas can trace back the *nama gotta* for a limited time; but if the abhinna powers were developed with Ariya jhanas, a much deeper history can be probed. A Buddha can trace back as far back as he pleases with astonishing speed (and yet he could not see “a beginning” to any sentient being’s *nama gotta*).

3. It is easier to explain this “nama gotta” with an example. Let us take two popular US presidents, John Kennedy and Ronald Reagan. Their “physical bodies” are no longer with us, i.e., their “rupa” or

physical bodies have decayed long ago. But their *nama gotta* are with us to a certain extent. How much of their memories or “nama gotta” remains with a given person depends on how closely that person associated with them. The moment we say, “John Kennedy” or “Ronald Reagan”, their picture comes to our mind. Not only that, those who met them may remember that vividly and probably can recall that event just like watching a movie.

- Similarly, we can recall many of the “events” of our lives or parts of our “nama gotta”; some young children can recall some events in their “nama gotta” in their previous lives.
- What can be done with abhinna powers is very similar. The abhinna powers enormously stretch the memory or the ability to “look back” at past events in one’s *nama gotta*.

4. **Since *nama gotta* do not decay, the definitions of *anicca* (“cannot be maintained to one’s satisfaction”) or *dukkha* (“eventually leads to suffering”) do not apply.**

- But there is nothing substantial to be had with *nama gotta* too. **Thus they are *anatta*.**
- Therefore, *nama gotta* do not have the characteristics of *anicca* and *dukkha*, but they are also *anatta*, without any real substance.

5. The Buddha’s last words were, “*vaya dhamma sankhara, appamadena sanpadeta*“, or “all dhamma that are destroyed are sankhara, sort out such “san” without delay”.

- “Vaya” means destruction or decay; thus sankhara (sankata) are the dhamma that “get destroyed”.
- Sankhara are those actions that lead to “san” for extending sansara; see, “[What is “San”? – Meaning of Sansara \(or Samsara\)](#)“.
- Thus the Buddha was admonishing the bhikkhus that all sankhara (sankata) are “vaya dhamma”, and thus to clearly comprehend what sankhara are.

6. In the Najeerati Sutta, the nature of *nama gotta* is clearly stated:

- “*rupan jeerati maccanan, nama gottan najeerati*“, or, “material things are subject to decay or jeerati (pronounced “jeerathi”) and death or destruction (maccanan; pronounced ‘machchānan’), but *nama gotta* do not decay.
- The “rupa” of those two US presidents we mentioned earlier have decayed and gone. But their *nama gotta* remain with us, because they are mixed in with our *nama gotta* at some points and we can access our *nama gotta* with memory. Someone with abhinna powers can look at a complete *nama gotta* not only spanning a complete life, but also going back to many lives. All of our *nama gotta*, back to beginning-less time, are there whether accessed or not.

Nibbana

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Nibbana – Is it Difficult to Understand?

I advise reading through any post one time without clicking on the links first; once you get the main concept, then the links can be used to clarify the other related key concepts.

1. The Buddha said we suffer because of the defilements we have in our minds : greed, hate, ignorance, and other mental qualities that arise from them. *Nibbana* has many synonyms, and “*Nivana*” (“cooling down”) is one that conveys the above idea better; *Nivana* , which is also called “*niveema*“, conveys the same idea as *niramisa sukha*.

- As one moves away from hate, greed, and ignorance, one can feel oneself “cooling down” INSIDE. Nibbana (“*Nib*+“*bāna*“, where “*bāna*” means bonds) and thus *Nibbana* means break free of bonds that makes one bound to the 31 realms.
- I like the word *Nivana* or *niveema*, because it conveys the benefits of the Path as one experiences gradual “cooling down” until it becomes complete at Nibbana; see, “[How to Taste Nibbana](#)“.

2. The key point is that one CAN start feeling “*nivana*” RIGHT NOW. *Nivana* is experienced by giving up the ten defilements (see, “[Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)](#)“). One does not have to get rid of all of them at once, and that is not advised either. One should get rid of the BIGGEST ones that can be easily gotten rid of.

- Killing, stealing, lying (and gossiping, slandering, verbally abusing), engaging in sexual misconduct, and being intoxicated (not just with alcohol or drugs, but also with wealth, power, etc.) are the first to be considered.
- Just abandon the relatively easy ones first for a few weeks and experience the “*nivana*“, the ease of mind, the “inner peace”, that comes from that. That is the biggest incentive to continue on the Path.
- One needs to understand the relative weights associated with dealing with animals and humans, and also there are different levels among the humans. For example, it is very difficult to be born human; thus even saying a hurtful thing to a human (especially to an *Ariya* or a Noble One), could have thousand-fold kammic weight compared to killing an animal; see, “[How to Evaluate Weights of Different Kamma](#)“.
- Another key concept is that one does NOT need to worry about the past kamma. The role of *kamma* has been exaggerated; see, “[What is Kamma? Is Everything Determined by Kamma?](#)“. *Nibbana* is not attained via removal of kamma, but removal of *asavas* or cravings; see, “[The Way to Nibbana – Removal of Asavas](#)“.
- The main thing is not to repeat the same mistakes. The more one stays away from the ten defilements, it automatically BECOMES easier. It is like pushing a stalled car: initially hard, but becomes easier when it starts moving.

3. Nibbana is NOT removing everything from the mind, just removing the defilements: Nibbana is *ragakkhaya* (greed elimination), Nibbana is *dosakkhaya* (hate elimination), Nibbana is *mohakkhaya* (delusion elimination); those three are more synonyms for Nibbana.

- **Thus one sees *Nibbana* with a thought** (*citta*, pronounced *chittha*; see, “[Pali Glossary and Pronunciation](#)“) **that is devoid of *raga* (greed), *dosa* (hate), *moha* (delusion).** This PURE

MIND does not want to be burdened with a “material existence” anywhere in the 31 realms; see, [“What are Rupa? Relation to Nibbana”](#).

4. The suffering is a direct result of having a “material aspect” associated with the mind: [that material body is subject to decay and death](#). **The mind gets associated with a body that it gets “attached” to with greed, hate, and ignorance.** If you look at the 31 realms of “this world” (see, [“The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma”](#)):

- it is clear that suffering is highest in the lowest 5 realms where all three (greed, hate, ignorance) are present; the bodies of beings in these realms are, in general, dense and are subject to decay and diseases. Of course there is much suffering in the lowest 4 realms.
- However, human realm (#5) is unique, because one COULD attain *Nibbana* as a human, even though they are also subject to bodily pains, decay, and diseases.
- In the *Deva lokas* (realms 6-11), hate is not there and suffering is less. And the bodies of *devas* are less dense and not subject to physical ailments (until death of course).
- In the *Brahma lokas* (realms 12-31), both hate and greed are absent, and suffering is even less; they have very fine bodies and no physical ailments.
- However, since ignorance is there in all 31 realms, complete, absolute state of happiness is absent anywhere in the 31 realms. Even if one is born in a deva or Brhama world, one will eventually end up in the lowest four realms.
- This is the key message of the Buddha: He said that suffering never ends as long as one keeps coming back to “this world of 31 realms” when one dies (i.e., unless one attains *Nibbana*); and the suffering could be unimaginably intense in the lower realms.

5. Therefore, one could visualize a gradual decrease of suffering as one gets rid of hate, greed, and ignorance in that order. And one CAN experience this happiness called *niramisa sukha* in this human life itself, all the way to up to *Nibbana*; see, [“Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha”](#). That is the uniqueness of a human birth.

6. When the mind “starts thinking” about a given thought object (*arammana*), say a visual object, it starts as “just seeing”; this is the *citta* stage. But within a fraction of a second, the mind starts adding defilements (based on greed, hate, ignorance), if that object is “of interest”.

- It develops further thoughts defiled by greed, hate, ignorance (possibly a combination) by going around and around that thought object and ends up in the “defiled thought” (*vinnana*) stage even before one realizes it; this is described in *paticca samuppada*; see, [“Paticca Samuppada – “Pati + ichcha” + “Sama + uppada”](#), and the links below that. *Vinnana* is a *citta* that is **defiled** by *raga* (greed), *dosa* (hatred), *moha* (ignorance).
- *Paticca samuppada*, which is Buddha Dhamma, is discussed in detail in the series, “*Paticca Samuppada in Plain English*”.

7. When *raga*, *dosa*, and *moha* are removed from the mind, *cittas* become *pabhasvara* (bright); there is no more defilements there clouding the *cittas*. **At this stage, it is said that the pure *citta* “sees Nibbana”.**

- After one attains *Nibbana* with one *citta*, the *cittas* fall back to the “normal state” and the person lives like a normal human (but without doing anything with greed, hate, and ignorance) until the

kammic energy of the *kamma* seed that started the present life is exhausted.

- At death (called *Parinibbana*), the mind of an Arahant does not grab (*upadana*) another *kamma* seed (even if there may be many *kamma* seeds), and thus there is no further rebirth. The mind becomes free of a “body” that can be subjected to decay and death. That is *Nibbana* or “complete *Nivana*” or “complete cooling down”.

8. *Raga* was there because of a cause (*raga*, *dosa*, *moha* or “*san*”; see, “[What is San?](#)”); when that cause is removed, now *raga*, *dosa* and *moha* are not there to get into *cittas*. When the mind is devoid of *raga*, *dosa*, and *moha*, the mind (and thus *cittas*) become devoid (*sunya*) of them; that is the purified state of a *citta*, ***anidassana vinnana* (consciousness devoid of defilements) or *panna* (wisdom)**.

- The forefathers of *Mahayana* Buddhism could not grasp the concept of *Nibbana*, so they came up with misleading descriptions including that of *Sunyata*: see, “[What is Sunyata or Sunyata \(Emptiness\)?](#)”.

9. When *raga*, *dosa*, *moha* are removed, a *citta* stops going around and around a given thought object (*arammana*). **This “wheeling” is what fuels the sansaric journey.** Thus stopping this process is called “taking off the wheels of the sansaric vehicle”.

- The Pali (and Sinhala) word for vehicle is “*riya*”, and stopping of the “*riya*” is called “*Ariya*”; one who has taken the wheels off the vehicle for the *sansaric* journey is called an “*Ariya*”. Thus contrary to popular usage, “*Arya*” is not the word for a Noble Person, it is *Ariya*.
- **Therefore, it is clear that “*Ariya*” has nothing to do with a race, “*Arya*”.**

10. Anyone who has at least attained the first stage of *Nibbana*, i.e., *Sotapanna*, can be called an *Ariya*, or a Noble Person. This is because the “*asavas*” or deep-seated cravings that a *Sotapanna* has removed stay permanently removed even in any future lives.

- All the *asavas* are removed at *Nibbana*; thus “*Asavakkhaya*” (elimination of *asavas*) is another synonym for *Nibbana*. People who had been in the lowest social ladder or lowest caste at the time of the Buddha were able to become *Ariyas* or Noble Persons.

11. When one sees *Nibbana*, one’s mind does not crave for anything “in this world” of 31 realms. There is nothing for the last *citta* (*cuti citta*, pronounced “chuthi chittha”) of this life (at death) to grab (nothing to *upadana*) and to start a new birth in “this world”, and the mind becomes totally free.

Thus an Arahant will not be reborn in “this material world” of 31 realms (see “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”), i.e., one attains *Parinibbana*. He/she is simply “gone” from “this world” of 31 realms. The suffering stops permanently. The mind become PERMANENTLY pure. **The mind become PERMANENTLY pure and be detached permanently from any type of physical body, dense or fine.**

- Thus it is quite clear WHAT *Nibbana* is: it is the stopping of the rebirth process in the material world. What is hard to understand is WHY stopping the rebirth process can relieve one of all suffering.
- No matter how much hardship one has endured, one likes to live. This is true for a human or a lowly worm. For any living being, the most precious thing is life. When one starts understanding the “big picture of the Buddha”, one will slowly start seeing the dangers of staying in this endless rebirth process.

Other analyses of *Nibbana* can be found at, “[Nirodha and Vaya – Two Different Concepts](#)” and “[Difference Between Giving up Valuables and Losing Interest in Worthless](#)“,

Continue to “[What is San?](#)“

Does the First Noble Truth Describe only Suffering?

I advise reading through any post one time without clicking on the links first; once you get the main concept, then the links can be used to clarify the other related key concepts.

Buddha Dhamma describes nature's laws. **Many people think that *dukkha sacca* (the first Noble Truth) says everything is suffering.** That is not true; there is a lot of apparent happiness which makes people unaware of the hidden suffering until it is too late. The key is to develop *panna* or wisdom to see the *dukkha* that is hidden. And one does not necessarily need to feel suffering in order to understand the *dukkha sacca*, even though it may motivate one to investigate. There is a difference between suffering (the feeling) and the ability to understand the causes for it (*panna* or wisdom).

- It is obvious that there are bouts of happiness everywhere. If everything FELT LIKE suffering, everyone will be seeking Nibbana. The reality is otherwise. It is hard for people to even see the real suffering out there.
- Whatever suffering is out there, it is hidden. In the HUMAN REALM, suffering and happiness are mixed together; one can see both.
- In the realms higher than the human realm, suffering is relatively much less, and that is why it is hard for Devas to even think about Nibbana. However, even those *Devas* and *Brahmas* end up eventually in the lowest four realms, and will be subjected to suffering.
- Beings in the lowest four realms are the ones who really feel dukkha. Of course they have no idea about the *dukkha sacca*. Only at the *Sotapanna* stage one is able comprehend *dukkha sacca* at least partially.

In the human realm (what we experience), is both suffering and happiness; some people are happier than others. Thus we have the ABILITY to see AND examine (i.e., spend some time investigating), because we CAN see there is suffering out there even if we may not be experiencing it at the moment. But EVERYONE experiences it as they get old; decay and death are inevitable.

Let us see how the Buddha described the First Noble Truth on suffering in the *Dhamma Cakka Pavattana Sutta*:

Idam kho pana, bhikkhave, dukkham ariyasaccam:

Jati'pi dukkha, jara'pi dukkha, vyadhi'pi dukkha, maranam'pi dukkham, appiyehi sampayogo dukkho, piyehi vippayogo dukkho, yamp'iccham na labhati tam'pi dukkham, sankhittena pancupadanakkhandha dukkha.

What is the Noble Truth of *Dukkha*?

1. In the first part it says, “*jathi pi dukkha, jara pi dukkha, vyadhi'pi dukkha, maranan pi dukkha.....*”. **Most people translate this incorrectly as, “birth is suffering, getting old is suffering, sickness is suffering, death is suffering”.**

- Does one suffer when a baby is born to the family? Do we not celebrate births (of loved ones), and even celebrate birthdays? So it is incorrect to interpret “*jathi pi dukkha*” literally as “birth is suffering”.
- When person A gets old or sick or die, that causes suffering for A's friends and family, but may cause happiness among A's enemies. Thus, such literal interpretation is NOT correct.

- Another important thing to remember is that the suttas are CONDENSED versions, formulated for easy recitation and transmission. A sutta that was delivered over many hours is condensed into a few pages of text. I will write more about this later.

2. “Jathi pi dukkha” is shortened for the verse; it is **“jathi api dukkha”**; the other two **“jara pi dukkha, maranan pi dukkha”** are meant to have the **“pi”** suffix. Be patient and read through carefully:

“pi” in Pali or “priya” in Sinhala is “like”, and “api” in Pali or “apriya” in Sinhala is dislike. Thus, “jathi api dukkha” means “birth of something that is not liked by one causes suffering”. “Jara pi dukkha” means, “decay of something that is liked causes suffering”, and “maranan pi dukkha” means, “Death of a liked causes suffering”. One can look at each case and easily see which one to use; see #5 below.

- The reverse is true too: “Birth of something that one likes causes happiness”, “decay of something that is hated brings happiness” and “death of a hated person brings happiness”. *You can think of any example and this is ALWAYS true. It brings happiness to many people to hear about the destruction of a property of an enemy.*
- In a war, one is happy about the loss of lives on the other side but heartbroken by the deaths on one’s own side.

3. The Buddha further clarified “pi” and “api” in the next verse, where he explicitly said: “piyehi vippayogo dukkho, appiyehi sampayogo dukkho” means “it brings sorrow when a loved one has to depart, and it also brings sorrow to be with a hated person” (“piya” is same as “pi”, and “apiya” is same as “api”). We all know the truth of this first hand. When a man dies of in a plane crash, it causes great suffering to his family; less to his distant relatives; even less to those who just know him informally; and for someone at the other end of country who has had no association with him, it is “just some news”.

- Of course the reverse of those are true too: “it brings happiness when a hated person has to depart, and it also brings happiness to be with a loved one”.

4. Then comes, “yamp’iccham na labhati tam’pi dukkham”. Here we see, “ichcha” that we encountered in both *anicca, dukka, anatta* and also in *paticca samuppada* (“pati+ichcha” “sama+uppada”). And “labhati” means “get”, and “na labhati” means “not get”. Thus, “If one does not get one likes, that leads to suffering”.

- Again, the reverse is true too: “If one gets one likes, that leads to happiness”.

5. The Buddha never said there is only suffering in this world. It is these bouts of “apparent happiness” that keeps the real suffering hidden. We always try to look at the bright side, and our societies also try to “cover up” most of the suffering that is out there.

- Therefore, there is both suffering and happiness out there. **The key is to see the suffering that is hidden in apparent happiness.**
- When a fish bites the bait, it sees only a bit of delicious food and does not see the hook, the string, and the man holding the fishing pole. It is not capable of seeing that “whole picture”, with the suffering hidden (the hook). In the same way, humans cannot see the suffering hidden in apparent sense pleasures until a Buddha comes to the world and reveals it.
- On television we see mostly the glamorous people. Yet, look at what happens to such glamorous people when they get old: http://www.ranker.com/crowdranked-list/18-celebrities-who_ve-aged-horribly?format=SLIDESHOW&page=1.

- We need to realize that we all will go through such inevitable changes as we get old; no matter how hard we try, it is not possible to maintain ANYTHING to our satisfaction in the LONG-TERM.
- Furthermore, there is both suffering and happiness in the wider world of 31 realms. There is actually much more happiness in the realms above the human realm. And there is unimaginable suffering in the lower four, especially in the lowest. We can see some of this suffering in the animal world, but even then the television programs highlight the “beauty” of wild life. We do not think how much suffering is in the animal world; may be not in domesticated animals, but in the wild.

6. The verses discussed in #4 and #5 above describes *anicca*. In the long run “we cannot maintain things to our satisfaction and that leads to suffering”; This is “*ya da niccam tan dukkahan*” that was discussed in, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations](#)”.

- Later in the sutta it says, “.....*dukkho anariyo anatta sanhitho*“. One becomes *anatta* or helpless because of that. That is, “*tan dukkam ta da natta*” that was discussed in, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations](#)”.
- In the second sutta that was delivered after the *Dhamma Cakka Pavattana sutta*, the *Anatta Lakkhana sutta*, these concepts were further detailed.
- *Anicca, dukkha, anatta* are thus the foundational “vision” that can be achieved only by a Buddha. It is “*pubbe ananussutesu dhammesu...*” as emphasized at the beginning of the *Dhamma Cakka Pavattana sutta*.

7. This is why it is imperative to understand the “big picture” of “this world” with 31 realms, the process of rebirth, laws of kamma, and most importantly, paticca samuppada. Then we realize that most beings, due to their ignorance, are trapped in the lower four realms.

- There are only 7 billion or so people on Earth, but each of carry in/on our bodies millions of living beings; see, “[There are as many creatures on your body as there are people on Earth!](#)”
- A household may have 4-6 people, but how many living beings are there in that house and in the yard? Millions, possibly billions. In a single scoop of dirt there are thousands of tiny creatures.

8. Finally, **the end result is suffering (even though there may be bouts of happiness in between)** from the things one craves (*upadana*) for. This is the last line: “*sankhittena pancupadanakkhandha dukkha*”.

- Here, “*sankhittena*” (“*san*” + “*kitta*” or “*kruthya*” or “*kriya*”) means acts of accumulating “*san*” via the three defilements; see, “[What is “San”? Meaning of Sansara \(or Samsara\)](#)“. Because of that, people crave *rupa, vedana, sanna, sankhara, vinnana* (*pancakkhandha* or “five heaps”), and get bound to “this world” by doing things to accumulate “*san*“. And that inevitably leads to suffering IN THE LONG TERM, especially in the *sansaric* time scale.
- We stay in “this world” of 31 realms not because anyone or anything is forcing us, but because we cling to things (*pancupadanakkhandha* = *panca upadanakkhandha* = “five heaps that we cling to”) like an octopus clinging to its prey with all eight legs. This is done because of the ignorance of the true characteristics of “this world”: *anicca, dukkha, anatta*.
- We do that because we do not see the suffering hidden in anything in this world. Just like the fish does not see the danger in the “tasty worm”, we do not see the suffering hidden in the apparent pleasures.
- The realization of the true characteristics leads to giving up craving (*upadana*), which in turn

leads to the release from the 31 realms, i.e., Nibbana. The *pancupadanakkhandha* becomes just *pancakkhandha* (i.e., no attachments even if the “world exists as before”) when “*sankittena*” is not there. Don’t worry too much if you don’t quite understand what is meant by that.

- But it is important to realize that this craving cannot be removed by force. The mind needs to see the benefits of that through the cultivation of wisdom via comprehending *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*; see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – True Meanings](#)”.
- Another key concept to understand is the benefits one gets by the removal of craving for worldly things; see, “[Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)”.

Nirödha and Vaya – Two Different Concepts

1. I know of several “Buddhist” groups who try to “stop” thoughts, believing that is what happens at the Arahant stage of Nibbana, i.e., they believe that the Buddha spent 45 years of his life trying to teach people how to stop thoughts, which is an even worse interpretation of Nibbana than the Mahayanists.

- When we are in deep sleep or are unconscious, we do not “think thoughts”. Does that mean we attain Arahant hood during such times?
- What the Buddha advised was to stop immoral thoughts, and to ENCOURAGE moral thoughts; that is how one purifies the mind. This is what one does in the correct anapana meditation too; see, “[What is Anapana?](#)”.
- The reality is that an Arahant’s thoughts are crystal clear (and pure), because they are devoid of defilements. Their memory is actually enhanced.
- Stopping all thoughts can lead to loss of perception and memory.

2. Many misconceptions about Nibbana arise because the true meanings of some key Pali words that the Buddha used are misunderstood. We have discussed how Mahayana forefathers twisted the concept of sunyata (emptiness) because they could not understand the concept of Nibbana; see, “[What is Sunyata or Sunnata \(Emptiness\)?](#)”.

3. There are several key words in Buddha Dhamma that need to be comprehended without even the slightest change. Most of these misconceptions arise because such key Pali words are misinterpreted and also mis-translated. Buddha’s teachings were delivered in Maghadhi language and made to a form suitable for verbal transmission in the Pali language (“Pali” means “lined up”). Many times problems arise when people try to use Sanskrit translations as originals and try to interpret those Sanskrit words.

4. Three such words are *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*: see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations](#)”. Three more such words are *nirodha*, *khaya*, and *vaya*. In this case the three words have apparently similar, but very different meanings. Let us look at the origins of these words:

- **Nirödha** comes from “nir”+“udaya”, where “nir” means stop and “udaya” means “arise”. Thus *nirodha* means stop something from arising. In Buddha Dhamma anything happens due to one or more causes. Thus if one does not want something to happen, one should remove the causes for it, and thus stop it from arising.
- “**San**” causes anything in this world to arise via “sankhara”; see, “[What is “San”? – Meaning of Sansara](#)”. However, anything that arises is subjected to the natural law of decay; **this “khaya”**.
- “San” and “khaya” go together: As explained in “[What is “San”? – Meaning of Sansara](#)”, “sankhya” in Pali or Sinhala means numbers, and “san” means adding (or multiplying) thus contributing to “building or arising” and “khaya” means subtracting (or dividing) and thus leading to “decay or destruction”.
- Things that undergo this “arising” and “destruction” are called “**sankata**”. Everything in this world is a *sankata*.

5. Anything that arises in this world (a *sankata*) starts decaying (“khaya”) from the moment it starts

arising. For example, when a baby is born, all the cells in the baby's body would have died in a couple of months, but more cells are born than those died; until that baby becomes a young person of around twenty years of age, more cells arise in a given time than decayed. Thus the baby "grows" into a young person, and then things are sort of in balance until about forty years of age, and then the "khaya" process starts dominating and person slowly starts to get weaker. Eventually, that person dies or is destroyed; **this is "vaya"**.

- Once it starts arising, a sankata cannot be stopped; it needs to undergo its natural process of growing, come to an apparent stationary state (but not stationary even momentarily), and eventually is destroyed. If someone commits suicide, this life may end, but that unspent energy starts a new life right away. Thus all one can do is to stop something from arising. **This stopping of a sankata via removing its causes is called "nirōdha"**.

6. A "sankata" is anything in this world that arises due to "san" and decays inevitably (khaya), and is eventually destroyed (vaya). Any living being is a sankata and arises due to "san". We acquire "san" via "sankhara" because we do not comprehend the true nature of the world (avijja or ignorance) and thus cling to things in this world with "tanha"; see, "[Tanha- How we Attach via Greed, Hate, and Ignorance](#)".

- We can begin to see with clarity when we get rid of tanha and avijja via removing lobha (greed), dosa (hatred), and moha (delusion) from our minds gradually; this is also a "khaya" process for such defilements ("asava"), where we gradually remove these three defilements (asava) from our minds; see, "[The Way to Nibbana – Removal of Asavas](#)". When a mind is pure (i.e., all asava are removed), it does not do any sankhara and thus no "sankata" can arise. At that stage, one has attained "nirodha" of any future "arising", i.e., one has attained Nibbana.

7. Now let us take some famous verses from the Tipitaka and see how the meanings come out naturally, without effort:

- The third Noble truth is "dukkha nirodha sacca", i.e., that suffering can be stopped from arising. Most people misinterpret "dukkha nirodha sacca" as "existing suffering can be stopped". Our current life is a sankata that was caused by PREVIOUS causes; this life and any associated suffering CANNOT be stopped, and need to undergo its natural course until death. That is why an Arahant (or even a Buddha) feels suffering due to past kamma (old causes).
- However, an Arahant has stopped FUTURE suffering from arising. This is indicated by **another meaning of nirodha: "ni" + "rōda", where "rōda" means wheels; this nirodha also means "taking the wheels off of the sansaric (rebirth) process"**. There is no rebirth with a physical body that could result in old age, sickness, and death. Thus Nibbana is removal of the causes that could lead to future suffering.

8. This is why the Nibbana is of two kinds: "saupadisesa Nibbana" and "anupadisesa Nibbana".

- When a person attains Nibbana, it is called saupadisesa Nibbana because that person is still "in this world of 31 realms"; he/she still has a body that needs to undergo its natural destruction; but one can still experience the Nibbanic bliss by getting into nirodha samapatti for up to 7 days at a time.
- When that person dies, there is no rebirth and Nibbana is "complete"; this is called anupadisesa Nibbana. Suffering ends permanently.

9. Finally, not absolutely everything in this world of 31 realms is sankata or sankhara. Absolutely

everything is denoted by “dhamma”, which includes sankata (sankhara) AND *nama gotta*. Here *nama gotta* are the “records” of all events of all beings in the mental plane that are truly permanent; see, [“Difference Between Dhamma and Sankhara \(Sankata\)”](#).

- This why the Buddha’s last words were, “*vaya Dhamma sankhara, appamadena sampadetha*“, or “All perishable Dhamma are sankhara (or sankata); thus strive diligently and identify “san” (“san” + “pä” “détha”)”.
- From beginningless time, we all built a new sankata each time the old sankata got destroyed. We do this uncountable times DURING each lifetime and also at death: we have been brahmas, devas, and humans countless times, but we have spent much more time in the four lowest realms. Thus in his last words the Buddha advised us to stop this senseless rebirth process which is filled with so much suffering, and to attain the permanent happiness of niramisa sukha in Nibbana.
- By the way, Nibbana is the only “entity” that does not ARISE due to causes; it is “asankata” (“a” + “sankata” or “not sankata” or “not conditioned”) because it does not have causes. It is reached via ELIMINATING THE CAUSES for everything that arise due to causes, i.e., nirodha of sankata automatically leads to Nibbana.

Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta

[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations](#)

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[How to Cultivate the Anicca Sanna](#)

[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – According to Some Key Suttas](#)

[If Everything is Anicca Should We Just give up Everything?](#)

[The Incessant Distress \(“Peleema”\) – Key to Dukkha Sacca](#)

Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations

No other factor has contributed to help keep Nibbana hidden in the past many hundreds of years than the incorrect interpretations of *anicca* as “impermanence” and *anatta* as “no-self”. If one can find even a single instance in the *Pali Tipitaka* (not translations) that describe *anicca* and *anatta* that way, please let me know at lal54@hotmail.com. There is NONE.

I consider this series of posts on “*anicca, dukkha, anatta*” to be the most important at the website. Reading the posts in the given order could be very beneficial.

It is said that a Buddha comes to this world to reveal three words and eight letters (in Pali): “*Attakkara theenapada Sambuddhena pakasitha, na hi sila vatan hotu uppajjatthi Tathagata*“, which means, “a Buddha (*Tathagata*) is born NOT just to show how to live a moral life, but to reveal three words to the world“.

These three words are: *anicca, dukkha, anatta*. That is how important these three words are. A Buddha comes to the world to reveal the true nature of the world. Any moral person instinctively knows (and most religions teach) how to live a moral life.

This is why these “three characteristics of this world” were clarified in the very first suttas delivered by the Buddha; see, “[Does the First Noble Truth Describe only Suffering?](#)“.

Anicca is pronounced “anichchä”, rhymes with “picture” . *Dukkha* is pronounced similarly, duk+kha. *Anatta* is pronounced “anaththä”, see, “[Pali Glossary and Pronunciation](#)“.

1. These are the three characteristics of “this world”. The Buddha stated that if one really comprehends the true nature of “this world”, as codified in these three words, then one would attain the Stream Entry (*Sotapanna*) stage of Nibbana; see, “[Why is Correct Interpretation of Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta so Important?](#)”.

2. Therefore, a good understanding of the words *anicca, dukkha, anatta* is critical. If one sticks to incorrect interpretation of these three words, no matter how much effort one exerts, there is no possibility of attaining the *Sotapanna* stage. These three words are commonly interpreted as impermanence, suffering, and “no-soul” or “no-self” even in most *Theravada* texts. First let us examine these three terms.

3. The Pali word for impermanence is NOT *anicca*, it is *adduwan* or *aniyatan*. For example, “*Jeevitam aniyatam, maranan niyatam*” means, “life is not permanent, death is”.

“*adduwan jeevitam, duwan maranan*” means the same thing.

Therefore, the key mistake was in translating the original Pali word *anicca* to Sanskrit as “*anitya*”, which does mean impermanence.

4. Now let us see the damage done by translating the original *Pali* word *anatta* to Sanskrit as “*anāthma*”.

Just as these days, there were two opposing views on the idea of a “soul” in the time of the Buddha. One camp insisted that there is an unchanging “soul” (*āthma*) associated with a being. This camp thus corresponds to the major religions of the world today with the concept that when one dies one’s soul goes to heaven or hell.

The opposing camp argued that there is “no-soul” (*anāthma*), and that when one dies, there is nothing

that survives the death. This camp thus corresponds to the materialistic scientists today, who believe that our minds arise from matter and thus when we die, there is nothing that survives the death.

The Buddha said it was neither. There is NOTHING that is permanent associated with a living being: both the mind and the body are in constant flux (see the Section on “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”), and thus there is no “soul” or an “unchanging self”. On the other hand, there is continuity at death based on cause-and-effect (*paticca samuppada*; see, “[Paticca Samuppada – Introduction](#)”). Thus it is ALSO incorrect to say that there is “no-soul” and that death is the end of that living being. The new being is a continuation of the old being, just as an old man is a continuation of the process from the baby stage. There is change at every MOMENT, but it is based on cause-and-effect; the “new” is dependent on the “old”. Also see, “[What Reincarnates? – Concept of a Lifestream](#)”.

5. In the *Ajjhattanica Sutta* in the *Samyutta Nikaya*, the Buddha stated that the three characteristics of “this world” are RELATED to each other:

“*ya da niccam tan dukkham, tan dukkham ta da natta*”, or,

“if something is not *nicca*, *dukkha* arises, therefore *anatta*”.

6. Now let us see what happens if we take *anicca* to be impermanent and *anatta* to be “no-soul”. Then the above verse reads, “if something is not permanent, suffering arises, and because of that one becomes “no-self””.

Many people just take a human body as “it”, and say that since the body is impermanent, suffering arises. But “it” can be anything in “this world”; the characteristics are about ANYTHING in “this world”. Thus if a headache does not become permanent, it is meaningless to say it has no self.

But there are many things in the world, if become permanent, would lead to happiness: health, wealth, association with someone liked, moving away from someone disliked, etc.

Now the opposite of the above statement must be true too: “if something is permanent, happiness arises, and because of that it implies a “self””.

If one has a permanent headache or a sickness, how can that lead to happiness? And in what sense a “self” arise?

There are many things in this world, if become permanent, would lead to suffering: a disease, poverty, association with someone disliked, moving away from someone liked, etc. **If suffering is permanent, how can one attain Nibbana?**

Thus we can clearly see that *anicca* and *anatta* cannot be translated as impermanence and “no-self”.

7. Permanence/Impermanence are PROPERTIES of “things” (living beings and physical things) or “events”. On the other hand, *nicca/anicca* are PERCEPTIONS IN ONE’S MIND about those “things” and “events”.

We cannot maintain anything to our satisfaction (including “our” own body) in the long run and that is *anicca*. And because of that we become distraught and that is *dukkha*. And since we are truly helpless in preventing this sequence of events, we are truly helpless in the long run, and nothing is with any real substance in the end; that is *anatta*.

Here is a video that illustrates the concept of *anicca* clearly:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?feature=player_embedded&v=4qILUJo4eLE

We need to realize that we all will go through this inevitable change as we get old; no matter how hard we try, it is not possible to maintain ANYTHING to our satisfaction. It is the nature of “this world”: *anicca*.

Now, of course any of these celebrities (or their fans) will be saddened to see the comparison; they have not been able to maintain their bodies to their satisfaction. However, a person who is in bad terms with any of these celebrities could be happy to see the picture, because that person's wish is to see something bad to happen to the celebrity (in this case to lose their "looks").

Thus "impermanence" is something that is inevitable; it is a property of anything in this world. **But "*anicca*" is a perception in someone's mind; and that perception CAN be changed; that is how one gets rid of suffering.**

In the above case, celebrities bodies ARE impermanent; but that did not necessarily cause suffering to ALL. It caused suffering to only those who did not like them getting old; if they had any enemies, they would be happy to see them losing their "good looks".

Impermanence is a fact; see, "[Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)". But impermanence is NOT the MEANING of *anicca*.

These pictures provide the visual impact that we do not normally get. We don't see changes in ourselves because the change is gradual.

8. Finally, the Buddha has said, "*Sabbe Dhamma anatta*". So, what does "all dhamma are "no-self"" mean? Dhamma includes everything, that means inert things too. Does it make sense to say, "a tree has "no-self"" or "a mountain has "no-self""?? On the other hand, nothing in this world is of any real substance in the end; they all come into being and are destroyed in the end: and that is *anatta*.

Next, "[Anicca – True Meaning](#)",

Anicca – True Meaning

1. It is best to start with the opposites: nicca, sukha, atta.

- The Pali word “*icca*” (pronounced *ichchä*), means “liking”. We encounter this word also in the correct explanation of *paticca samuppada*, the causal theory of [Buddha Dhamma](#); see, “[Paticca Samuppada – Introduction](#)”.
- Nicca (pronounced *nichchä*) is the PERCEPTION that one can maintain things that one likes to one’s satisfaction. If this is indeed the case, then one is happy, i.e., *sukha* arises. In that case one is in control, and there is something fruitful to be had, i.e., *atta*. Thus even if one needs to work hard to get something that can be maintained to one’s satisfaction, at the end one can find permanent happiness, and one is in control of one’s own destiny.
- If something is not to one’s liking it is “*anicca*” (pronounced *anichchä*).

2. The reality is that EVERYTHING in “this world” is in constant flux. There is nothing in “this world” that can be maintained in a stable state in the LONG TERM. Of course, we can maintain a car for a long time (with constant repairs), but there comes a point when that car dies. Even if some things appear to last long, say a valuable gem, the owner has to give it up when he/she dies. Thus the reality of this world is *anicca*.

- In the *Dhamma Cakka Pavattaana Sutta*, The Buddha said, “*yan piccham na labathi thampi dukkham*”, or “if one does not get what one likes or wants, then that leads to dukha”. If the “want” is not there, there will be no suffering.
- Thus the cause of suffering is NOT impermanence, but the inability to perceive the consequence of that in one’s mind. In a world that IS inherently impermanent (see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”), one CAN avoid suffering by comprehending *anicca*, and by not struggling to achieve the impossible.
- Impermanence by itself does not lead to suffering. If that is the case, since no one can change that fact, no one will be able to end the suffering (and to attain *Nibbana*). But it is the wrong perception of nicca that leads to suffering. The correct perception of *anicca* (once accepted by the mind), will lead to cessation of suffering.

Also see, “[Does Impermanence Lead to Suffering?](#)”,

3. When one realizes that one cannot maintain something that desired after a long struggle, one becomes distraught, depressed, unsatisfied. Thus the wrong perception of *nicca* (or a sense of possible fulfilment of one’s desires) ALWAYS leads to *dukha* or suffering at the end.

- The mindset is that even if something is not permanent and breaks down, one can always replace it with a new one and get the sense fulfilment one desires. It is not the impermanence that gives sense of invincibility but the mindset that one can always find a replacement for it and maintain one’s happiness.
- But if one carefully examines the wider world view of the Buddha, one can easily see that this mindset of the possibility of “long lasting happiness in this world” is an illusion.
- No matter what we achieve in this life, we HAVE TO leave it all behind when we die.
- And in the new life, we start all over; this is what we have been doing from beginningless time.

4. When one realizes that one is not in control of one's own affairs in "this world", i.e., one realizes that one is truly helpless. This is *anatta*. Thus the perception of *atta* is an illusion, the reality is *anatta*.

- The Buddha said, "*asarattena anatta*", or, "*anatta* means there is nothing substantial, nothing fruitful to be had", meaning all life struggles within "this world" are in vain at the end. Then we start a new life and do it all over again, and so on...

5. Now let us go back to the relationship among *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* with the correct interpretations:

"*ya da niccam tan dukkham, tan dukkham ta da natta*", or,

- **"if something cannot be maintained to one's satisfaction, suffering arises, therefore one is helpless in the end".**

- And the reverse of it:

"if something can be maintained to one's satisfaction, happiness arises, therefore one is in control".

6. Let us think about some situations:

- We can get something done the way we want, say doing a repair, passing an exam, or even building a successful business, we become happy, and feel that we are "in control".
- We can keep our body in good condition for times, especially when we are young, and we are happy and feel that we are in control. There are many examples where the second statement holds.
- In some cases, each statement can hold true depending on who it is. For example, when Bin Laden was killed second statement held true for many people and they were happy; but for the followers of Bin Laden, the first statement was true.
- But we cannot even keep our hair the way want in the long term: hair will begin greying and will fall off if one lives long enough.

So the problem is that the second statement does not hold OVER LONG TERM for anyone. You can check with any situation that you encounter. That is the true nature of "this world" described by the three characteristics: *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.

7. Permanence/Impermanence are PROPERTIES of "things" (living beings and physical things) or "events". On the other hand, *nicca/anicca* are PERCEPTIONS IN ONE'S MIND about those "things" and "events".

- Here is an interesting set of pictures that describe the concept of *anicca* clearly:
http://www.ranker.com/crowdranked-list/18-celebrities-who_ve-aged-horribly?format=SLIDESHOW&page=1
- We need to realize that we all will go through this inevitable changes as we get old; no matter how hard we try, it is not possible to maintain ANYTHING to our satisfaction. It is the nature of "this world".
- Now, of course any of these celebrities (or their fans) will be saddened to see the comparison; they have not been able to maintain their bodies to their satisfaction. However, a person who is in bad terms with any of these celebrities could be happy to see the picture, because that

person's wish is to see something bad to happen to the celebrity (in this case to lose their "looks").

- Thus "impermanence" is something that is inevitable; it is a property of anything in this world. But "*anicca*" is in someone's mind. In the above case, celebrities bodies ARE impermanent; but that did not necessarily cause suffering to ALL.
- These pictures provide the visual impact that we do not normally get. We don't see changes in ourselves because the change is gradual.

8. The key to attaining [the Sotapanna stage](#) is to contemplate on these concepts, using real life examples. This is true meditation. When one's mind accepts that there is no lasting happiness anywhere in the 31 realms of "this world", one loses the desire to crave for "things". One becomes determined to get out of "this world" as soon as possible, and to attain permanent happiness, *Nibbana*.

- This point is analyzed further in simpler terms in, "[Difference Between Giving up Valuables and Losing Interest in Worthless](#)".
- The Buddha gave us various different methods of analyzing a given concept. A discussion of the origin of *anicca* based on *sankata* is presented at, "[Root Cause of Anicca – Nature of Sankata](#)".

9. No one in "this world" is exempt from these three characteristics. Even though one may be able to find happiness at certain times, nothing we do can get us out of the realities of getting old, sick, and finally dying. Then the cycle repeats in the next life, and next,

- Furthermore, any such "happy times" are insignificantly small in the [samsaric time scale](#); see, "[The Four Stages in Attaining Nibbana](#)", and "[How the Buddha Described the Chance of Rebirth in the Human Realm](#)".

10. But the good news is that we can gain a kind of happiness that will not go away, especially if one attains at least [the Sotapanna stage](#) of *Nibbana*; see, "[Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)", and "[Nibbana – Is it Difficult to Understand?](#)".

11. In the Tipitaka, *Anicca* has been explained in many different ways. Another way is discussed in, "[Anicca – Repeated Arising/Destruction](#)".

["Anatta and Dukka – True Meanings"](#)

Next, "[Anicca – Repeated Arising/Destruction](#)",

Anatta and Dukkha – True Meanings

What really matters in the end is one comprehends, not words. The way different people interpret “no-self” could be different, even though the concept of a “self” is very clear.

- If *anatta* means “no-self”, then there is nothing that can distinguish person A from person B. So, if A takes something belongs to B, he can say, “there is no “me” and there is no “you”; what is wrong in me using “your” stuff?”. If B believes in “no-self” can he argue with A?
- Similarly, there are many other contradictions: If there is “no-self”, (i) who attains Nibbana?, (ii) who does moral or immoral acts?, etc.

1. Let us look at the two words the Buddha used: “*āthma*” and “*anāthma*”. In the Brahmajala sutta, the Buddha definitely said both those are not correct. The best translation of those two terms to present day, I believe, are “soul” and “no-soul”:

- “Soul” in the sense of an unchanging entity; for example, most religions believe one’s soul goes to hell or heaven and then that “soul” is forever in that state.
- “No-soul” in the sense interpreted by a materialist, i.e., “a person” is just the body (with thoughts arising from the material brain), and when one dies that is end of story; nothing survives physical death.
- Those were the two extremes rejected by the Buddha as “*athma*” and “*anathma*”.

2. The real confusion arose when the Pali word “*anatta*” was translated to Sanskrit as “*anathma*”. Subsequently, the Sanskrit word “*anathma*” was translated to English as “no-self”. This was done at the same time when ‘*athma*’ was translated as “soul”.

3. The real question is when one says, “there is “no-self””, does one imply that there is no “soul”, i.e., no “*athma*”? There are two possibilities. Let us look them carefully:

- If one means by “no-self” that when one dies that is the end of story, i.e., there is no rebirth process, then this is same as “no-soul”.
- Or, it is possible that some people may have the idea of a “changing personality” rather than the above materialistic view of nothing surviving the death, i.e., one believes that a human can be reborn an animal. Then one has the right concept of *anatta*.
- One needs to contemplate on this and clearly distinguish between the two possible interpretations.

4. But I have seen many people just use the phrase “no-self” in the wrong way.

- Some say, ‘The Buddha told us that there is “no-self”. So, what is the point of going through learning Dhamma etc., because there is no “me”’.
- Others say, “Even if I die and get reborn as an animal, it will be not “me”, because there is “no-self”’.
- They are both wrong by talking about a “no-soul”. What I ask them is, “If there is no “me”, would it be OK if someone hits you hard with a stick or worse?”. Then of course they realize that there is a “me”. **That is the “me” who learns Dhamma or who could be reborn an animal.**

5. We can take a simple simile to get an idea of these two extremes of “self” and “no-self”. We have

all seen shapes and colors created by water fountains. Here I have trimmed a video for just 10 seconds to show a couple of such shapes (if you re-play, it will play the whole video; if need to see the short piece, need to re-load the page).

https://www.youtube.com/watch?feature=player_embedded&v=0f33d6_inpw

- We all know that the “tree” that was created by water was not real. But we cannot say it did not exist.
- In the same way, since we cannot say that a person does not exist. However, there is nothing that exists permanently, it is just transitory. Thus both “self” and “no-self” are wrong perceptions.
- Just like we can create different shapes and figures using that water fountain, we all go through various lifeforms in the rebirth process.
- However, the suffering (or the intermittent happiness) is real.

6. This is a deep concept. We cannot deny that we have the inner perception (*sanna*) of a “me” (unless one is an Arahant). That is also THE reason also that we go through this rebirth process. But that *sanna* CANNOT be gotten rid by forcing the mind to accept that there is no “me”. THAT DOES NOT WORK. When one starts learning the true nature of the world by understanding the real meanings of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, the mind gradually realizes that there is no real “me”, but just a ever-changing “lifestream”.

- Thus one could meditate for thousand years muttering to oneself, “it is *anāthma*” or “there is no-self”, or anything equivalent with the meaning “there is no “me””, and would not get anywhere close to [the Sotapanna stage](#) or even any [niramisa sukha](#).
- Instead one needs to comprehend that “there is nothing fruitful to be had in this world in the long run”, or “one is really helpless in this rebirth process”; that is the concept of *anatta*.

7. In other words, **“there is a “me” as long long as one craves for things in this world”**. Denying that perception is not the solution. One craves for things in this world because one believes there is happiness to be had by seeking “things” in this world. That tendency to seek things will not reduce until one understands that it is fruitless to strive for such things in the long term. And that is a real meaning of *anatta*.

- But that cannot be grasped just by reading about it. One needs to contemplate (meditate) using real examples from one’s life. One will know that one is starting to get the concept when one starts realizing that one’s cravings for things in this world is gradually waning.

Why Dukkha is not Merely Suffering?

1. There is confusion about what the Buddha said about suffering because most cannot distinguish between *dukha* and *dukkha*. But the Pali word for suffering is *dukha*. *Dukkha* (*dukha*+*khyā*) means there is hidden suffering AND that suffering can be eliminated (*khyā* is removal; see, “[What is San? – Meaning of Sansara \(or Samsara\)](#)”).

2. *Dukha* is a *vedana* (feeling). Anyone, and even animals feel *dukha*. No one has to convince anyone there is *dukha* in this world. If anyone can attain *Nibbana* by realizing *dukha* in this world, then

animals would attain *Nibbana* first, because they know *dukha* very well.

- However, *dukkha* is the First Noble Truth. It says there is “hidden suffering” behind all this apparent happiness or the illusion of a future happiness that can be achieved by “working hard”.
- In order to comprehend *dukkha*, one needs to understand the wider world view of the Buddha and see that most suffering will be in future rebirths unless one attains at least the Sotapanna stage of *Nibbana*.
- That is why it takes a lot of time and effort to gain wisdom (*panna*) and truly start on the Path. Since our senses cannot sense other realms, including the suffering-filled lowest 4 realms (except the animal realm), it is not a trivial matter to understand and truly believe the message of the Buddha.

3. This wrong conception has also led to the popularity of “breath meditation” (the incorrect anapana meditation) as a way to remove “suffering”.

- It is true that one could get “temporary relief” and even *jhanic* experiences using the breath meditation. But that does not solve the problem of “long-term *sansaric* suffering” emphasized by the Buddha.
- When one cultivates the true “*anapana* meditation” (see, “[What is Anapana?](#)”), one can achieve temporary relief AND work towards “long-term happiness” of *Nibbana*.

4. Most people have the perception that Buddha Dhamma is pessimistic, because it emphasizes suffering. Actually, it is quite the opposite.

- The Buddha was just the messenger of the bad news. He DISCOVERED the true nature of this world: No matter where we are reborn within the 31 realms, we will not find happiness and in the LONG RUN, suffering prevails; see, “[The Four Stages in Attaining Nibbana](#)”.
- A world which is based on constant change (impermanence) is inherently incapable of providing stability (thus *anatta* is not impermanence, but *anatta* arises out of impermanence).
- Yet, we have the PERCEPTION that we can somehow “beat the system” and find happiness. That is the wrong perception of *nicca*. Once we truly realize *dukkha*, we will see that anything in this world has the *anicca* nature; nothing in this world can provide long-lasting happiness in the long term.
- 5. The Buddha not only discovered that “this world” cannot provide us with stable and lasting happiness. He also found the way to get out of this inherently unstable, and thus unsatisfactory nature of existence. This is the Noble Eightfold Path.

6. **Thus it is important to realize that *dukkha* has embedded in it the only optimistic message anyone can deliver: That we can overcome this inevitable suffering.**

- **When one truly realizes the true nature of “this world”, one voluntarily gives up struggling in vain to achieve the impossible, and that automatically leads to a state of happiness in one’s mind even before the *Sotapanna* stage.**

- This particular happiness, *niramisa sukha*, is different from the sense pleasures and one can experience it more and more as one follows the Path, and culminates in *Arahantship* or unconditioned happiness; see, “[Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)“. One can experience this *niramisa sukha* all the way up to its peak at *Nibbana* during this very life.

7. Another important thing to realize is that there are only two ways that anyone’s destiny works out:

- One waits until one gets really old to EXPERIENCE the suffering even in this life itself. It does not matter how much money one has: One will NOT be able to enjoy the sensual pleasures as one used to in the younger ages: all sense faculties degrade including culinary pleasures, visual, auditory, sex, etc. And if one gets a major illness it will be worse. The absolutely worse thing is that by that time it will be too late, because even the mind starts to degrade, and one will not be able to make any spiritual progress.
- The other and the ONLY reasonable option is to develop insight NOW. The Buddha had revealed the true nature of ‘this world’ of 31 realms. At least one should examine the big picture laid out by the Buddha to see whether that picture makes sense, and if it does to work towards getting out of ‘this world’.
- People commit suicide thinking that it will end the suffering. It does not. The only way to stop suffering is to stop rebirth. There is nowhere to be found in the 31 realms that will end the suffering. One may find relatively long periods of happiness in the higher realms, but in the [samsaric time scale](#) that will only be a blip; see, “[Samsaric Time Scale](#)” and “[Infinity – How Big Is It?](#)“.
- And one can test the path prescribed by the Buddha. As one experiences the *niramisa sukha* by removing greed, hate, and ignorance, one can start feeling the “cooling down”, the early stages of *Nibbana*; see, “[How to Taste Nibbana](#)“. This will accentuate one’s liking of Dhamma (*chanda*), enhance one’s determination (*citta*) and effort (*viriya*) to seek insight (*vimansa*); see, “[Four Bases of Mental Power \(Satara Iddhipada\)](#)“.

Anicca – Repeated Arising/Destruction

1. *Anicca* has been analyzed in several different ways in the *Tipitaka*. In the *Patisambidha Magga Prakarana* in the *Tipitaka*, it is explained as,

“*uppada vayattena anicca*”,

which means “(this world is) ***anicca*** because we just keep going through the birth (arising)/ death (destruction) process”.

- Of course, in between birth and death there is mostly suffering (in the realms at and below the human realm, where most beings spend time). This is the ***dukkha*** characteristic.

2. This is what we have been doing for an unimaginably long time (beginning-less), there is no break from it until one attains *Nibbana*.

- We see some people committing suicide hoping to end it all; but ending this life does not solve the “problem”. In fact, it may lead to a birth in a lower realm, which will only increase the suffering.
- Thus continuing this ceaseless birth/death process is ***anatta***, i.e., it is fruitless, burdened with suffering, and thus one is truly helpless.

3. We can see the Three Characteristics (*Tilakkhana*) of this world by carefully examining the fate of anything that arises in this world, which goes by the name *sankata*.

- Whether it is a living being or an inert thing any *sankata* arises, lasts for a certain time, and then perishes.
- For an inert object, the process stops at the destruction step, and it does not feel anything as it goes through the process.
- But for a living being, there is (mostly) suffering during arising/living/death, even though there may be spurts of “happiness” if one is fortunate enough to be born in human realms or the realms above it.
- And the process does not stop at death unlike for an inert object. It just keep repeating.

The arising/destruction of a *sankata* is described in, “[Root Cause of Anicca – Five Stages of a Sankata](#)“, and in “[Nirödha and Vaya – Two Different Concepts](#)“.

4. A living being’s suffering is also enhanced by the “*sankata* characteristics of inert objects” too. We work hard to acquire “things” but either they get run down/destroyed (houses, cars, furniture,...) or we die leaving them behind. Then if we are lucky to be born human in the next birth we just start this “accumulation process” and get distraught at death again....

- If we think through logically (and this is real meditation), we should be able to grasp this main concept of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.
- Through the ages, philosophers (as well as most people) have wondered, “What is the meaning of life?”. And they normally think about just this present life; see, “[“Why Does the World Exist?” by Jim Holt](#)“

5. Someone who has accomplished something significant may think otherwise at the moment of that accomplishment. But it lasts only a short time; at death, it is all gone. If he/she wanted to accomplish

something significant in the next life (provided one is lucky to be reborn human), then one has to start all over.

- This point becomes poignantly clear, if one takes a little time and think about the life of any famous personality (emperors, kings, politicians, movie stars,...from times past to the present). Most of them are bound to be born in lower realms because of the heinous acts they did to get some of those positions.
- If one knows the “big picture” about the wider world and the beginning-less journey we have made, it becomes clear that all through uncountable number lives we have struggled in vain “seeking an elusive happiness”. There is no meaning to life in the long run, AND it makes one suffer, and this is the nature of this world: *anicca, dukkha, anatta*.

6. If there is a birth, there MUST be a death. There is no exception, other than *Nibbana*.

This is the “*akalika*” or “timeless” quality of *Nibbana*.

- All *sankata* operate on the basis of *kamma vipaka*, which normally take time to bring their fruits. This is why people are unable to “see” the working of *kamma*. There may be drug dealers who live like kings, but they will be paying with interest in the future.
- *Nibbana* brings fruits instantaneously, there is no time gap involved (it is “*akalika*”), unlike a *sankata*. Furthermore, once attained there is no time duration after which it is destroyed; it is forever.
- The *magga phala* (*Sotapanna, Skadagami, Anagami, Arahant*) are attained in one *citta* (lasting less than a billionth of a second). And since they were attained via ELIMINATION OF CAUSES, there is no destruction associated with them. i.e., they are forever.
- In comparison, a living being arises DUE TO CAUSES, and when the underlying cause or the fuel is spent, the living being dies. But the process does not stop, because the being had acquired NEW CAUSES (new *kamma*) during that life or in the previous lives.

7. In the *Dhamma Vandana*:

“*Svâkkhatö Bhagavatä Dhammö Sanditthikö Akälikö Ehi-passikö Opanâyikö Paccattam veditabbö vinnuhiti*”,

the quality of *Dhamma* that is described by “*akälikä*” is that it leads to effects that do not depend on time.

- And that is achieved via the quality listed before that: “*sanditthikö*”. *Dhamma* explains and clarifies “*san*” that are the causes (*avijja* and *tanha*) for arising of *sankata* (whether they are living or inert); see, “[What is “San”? Meaning of Sansara \(or Samsara\)](#)”.
- And most people say, “*Bhagavata Dhammo*” means “*Buddha’s Dhamma*”. But this *Dhamma* was only DISCOVERED by the *Buddha Gotama*, as had countless other Buddhas before him. “*Bhagavata*” (“*bhaga*” + “*vata*” where “*bhaga*” means divide and “*vata*” means “[the process](#)” that looks like a “[living being](#)”) means this *Dhamma*, by analyzing a “person” in terms of “actions”, illustrates that there is no enduring entity in a “living being”.
- And this process is “*svakkhato*” (“*sva*” + “*akkata*” where “*sva*” means “self” and “*akkata*” means not possible to do) means this *Dhamma* cannot be changed by anyone, it is nature’s way. Even a Buddha just discovers this *Dhamma* or the Laws of Nature at the very fundamental level,

a level much deeper than is studied by contemporary science.

Next, “[If Everything is Anicca Should We Just give up Everything?](#)“,

How to Cultivate the Anicca Sanna

1. Many people tell me, “I think I understand what *anicca* means. But then what?”.

- That statement itself says that person has not yet understood *anicca* at least to some extent. I am not saying this in a derogatory manner. Even a *Sotapanna* is supposed to have comprehended *anicca* only to a certain extent. Thus if one gets at least a glimpse of what is meant by *anicca*, that goes a long way. And that is not hard, if one can just contemplate on it seriously.
- When reading about it, it may make sense that *anicca* means, “that we cannot maintain anything to our satisfaction”. And from the examples given, one can see that truth of that statement. **But that is just the start.** One just has just been informed of what *anicca* is. **Now one has to “see it with wisdom”.** This is what is called “*dassanena pahathabba*” or “start seeing things as they are”.
- One needs to develop the “*anicca sanna*”; the mind needs to grasp the essence or the correct perception of what *anicca* implies. **Book knowledge is one thing, and “grasping it with the mind” is much more deeper.**

2. Let us take an example to illustrate this important difference. Suppose a person from a remote region in the Amazon forest, who has never seen an apple, is shown an apple. He would not know what it is. If we give him the apple to hold and teach him the word “apple”, now he knows what an apple is, but only in the sense that if he is shown an apple again, he will say “that is an apple”. But he would still not know how it tastes. He will have to eat some apples to get an idea of its flavor. He may still not know how to identify a “mature apple” that will taste better, etc. All that comes when he gets to experience apples at various stages of “ripeness” and even different varieties.

- Hearing or reading about *anicca* is similar to just seeing an apple. That is just the starting point of finding out what *anicca* is. Just like for someone who has not tasted an apple would not have any sense of its taste, just reading about *anicca* may not mean much to the mind (but for some people, the idea may sink in right away if they had developed the “*anicca sanna*” to some extent in recent previous lives).
- The perception of *anicca* needs to sink in the mind; this is what is called the “*anicca sanna*”.

3. In another example, if we see someone at work regularly at a distance, we can recognize him as X if we meet him at the market. But we would not know much ABOUT him. However, if we get to associate with him and start doing things together, pretty soon we will know much more about him.

- At that point, when we even catch a glimpse of him, everything about him comes to our mind. If we wanted, we can recall how many kids he has, where he went school, etc.
- Thus “*sanna*” can be at different levels. The more one gets to associate with someone or something, then our “*sanna*” on that person or concept will grow.
- **However, it is possible that our “*sanna*” about person X may not be really correct.** One day, police find video evidence that X is a child molester, and it becomes clear that there is no doubt about it. At that moment, our “*sanna*” or perception about X is altered permanently. We will no longer let him even come close to our children.

4. The Buddha said our “*sanna*” about “this world” — that it can provide happiness — is a “*vipareetha sanna*”, i.e., it is a distorted or wrong perception. If one carefully examines the rebirth process in the 31 realms, it has provided us with mostly suffering in the long run.

- When we realize the “*anicca* nature” of this world to some extent, our wrong perception will

change. That is when one really sees “*Samma Ditthi*” or “correct vision” about this world. One becomes a *Sotapanna*.

- Just like a fish does not see the “hidden hook” and that it will undergo unbearable suffering by biting the tasty worm, we normally do not “see” the suffering hidden in the “tasty materialistic things”. **A fish will never be able to figure that out, and as normal human beings we cannot figure it out ON OUR OWN either.** Only a Buddha can figure it out, and a Buddha can TEACH us, and we can figure it out by spending some time contemplating on it.

5. Therefore, one should not be discouraged if one does not even realize “what the big deal is” about *anicca*. Like everything else, understanding comes with repeated application and by thinking about it. If one can see that “it makes sense” to say, “*anicca* describes the inability for us to maintain to anything to our satisfaction in the long term” that is a good start. Then one should start checking the validity of that concept at every opportunity in real life.

- *Anicca* is not merely, “the inability for us to maintain to anything to our satisfaction in the long term”. There are many other implications that arise because of this characteristic of *anicca*. **Another way the Buddha described *anicca* was to use the term “*atteeyathi*”; i.e., “it is like a dog chewing on a meatless bone”.** The dog thinks very highly of the bone, and values its “taste”. But there is not even any real taste in that bone. It is taste that its mind made up, but sometimes, its gums start bleeding and it may taste its own blood.

6. Just like a dog will spend hours and hours chewing its “highly valued” bone, we also give much value to sense pleasures that are fleeting in nature. We do get brief instances of real pleasure, **but we do not realize the effort and suffering that we go through to get that brief sense of pleasure.** Most of the time, the pleasure is a “pleasure of anticipation”. We trudge through hard work with the mind cheering on showing the “possible pleasures to be had”.

- The Buddha likened this to a cow (in the old days) who drags a heavy cart with eagerness to get to the pile of straw being held in front of it by a pole. It does not realize the futility of its efforts because it is only thinking about the “prize” being held in front of its eyes. It does not even feel the burden of the heavy load, or even if feeling it, just disregards that pain in anticipation of the “reward” that it thinks can be had by “just taking a few more steps”.
- Most our pleasures are short lived and arise just out of putting down the “fires” or distresses. The water tastes best when we are thirsty. Think about how you felt when you were very thirsty; the first sip of water was heavenly. But as the thirst went down with drinking more water, the “sense of pleasure” went down as well. After at most two glasses, the “feeling of pleasure” turns to a discomfort.

7. Same thing applies in any of the sense pleasures. We are constantly under pressure from the mind to “provide relief to one or another sense faculty”; this is *dukkha dukkha* that we discussed elsewhere. If we have not eaten anything for a while, we get the urge to eat something tasty. If we have not listened to some good music for a while, that urge kicks in. If you think about any sense pleasure, this is true.

- Many people value sex very highly. But how long can one keep that pleasure going? Most of the sexual pleasure is gained by just thinking about it; it is mostly mind-made.
- Even if we eat the most delicious food in the whole world, it will not taste good after the stomach gets full.
- This “feeling of unsatisfactoriness” or even feeling of “something is missing” is “*atteeyathi*”. The dog may get tired of chewing the bone and may leave it alone, but after a while the urge

comes back and he is at it again.

- Even if we are fully content and lying on a comfortable couch, we may get a “feeling of unfulfillment”, that something is “missing”. We then get the idea, “to go and watch a movie” or to “drop by a friend’s place to chat”. Then we have to get in the car and drive there. We do not even feel the burden associated with getting dressed and driving because our minds are focused on the pleasure of “watching the movie” or “having a good time with the friend”. And after that session, we have to drive back and if it was a bad movie we might even get a bit depressed.
- This is “*atteeyathi*“. Just like a dog that incessantly is chewing on a dry bone to get a mental satisfaction and eventually gets tired doing it, this is what we have been doing life after life (if born in the human realm). Many people eventually realize this at old age, but then it could be too late to do anything about it.
- As one gets old, the ability to derive pleasure from such activities goes down. If you have friends, relatives, parents, or grandparents who had enjoyed life at younger age, but now are in distressful situations it is easy to see what happened to them over the years. Now they do not have the energy to try to do all those activities and even if they do to some extent, their sense faculties have degraded to the point of not providing much sense pleasures.

8. This is a key concept to meditate (or contemplate) on. This is real *vipassana bhavana*.

- However, it is important to make sure one starts abstaining from at the least the conventional five precepts and possibly the “BIG EIGHT” discussed in the [“2. The Basics in Meditation”](#). Otherwise, the mind will not be calm enough to grasp these concepts. The difference between “book knowledge” and “developing *anicca sanna*” will become slowly clear as one proceeds.
- And with time, one will be able to grasp it better. One will “start feeling” things in one’s own body; see, [“11. How to Select and “Grow” Meditation Procedures for Magga Phala”](#).
- This is a process that goes all the way to the *Arahanthood*. It is said that one truly understands *anicca* only at the *Arahant* stage. But our goal here is to at least to get to the *Sotapanna* stage. And that CAN BE DONE in this very life, as I discussed my own experience in the above post.

9. Some of you may think that this is all “pessimistic thinking” and will lead to depression. I can assure you that the result will be quite the opposite.

- When one begins to realize that one has been under so much stress due to fruitless and meaningless struggles, one’s mind starts feeling the “*niramisa sukha*“. And one realizes that permanent happiness is indeed possible.
- As one comprehends the true nature of this world, one’s mind becomes alert and energized. These days, I meditate for one to two hours on these these concepts lying on a reclined sofa right after lunch and do not fall asleep. Rather, I get up with renewed energy.
- The hindrance of *thina middha* (heaviness of the mind and the tendency of the mind to get stuck at something) goes away as one comprehends the true nature of this world.
- In fact, this is good way to measure one’s progress. In the beginning, it is a bad idea to try meditate sitting in a comfortable sofa right after lunch. So, initially one should just sit in a regular chair away from disturbances and at a time when one’s mind is alert. But as one starts getting “feeling of an alertness” one should be able to meditate anywhere anytime.

10. As the mind realizes the burdens of the “incessant distress”, and that one has endured all that for no real benefit, it will gladly give up those burdens and the mind will start losing those cravings automatically. This is the key to “giving up unnecessary attachments” and is discussed in the next post

in the series (see the link below).

- That post discusses how we encounter suffering when *anicca* inevitably leads to unexpected “changes” in things we value; this is *viparinama dukkha*. We encounter more suffering by trying to overcome the effects due to *viparinama dukkha* by doing more *sankhara*, and that is *sankhara dukkha*. And if we do “bad types of *sankhara*” or *apunnabhi sankhara*, they lead to rebirths in realms where direct suffering or *dukkha dukkha* is unbearable. Thus all types of sufferings eventually arise due to *anicca*.

11. Finally, if anyone has spent long times — may be years — meditating on “impermanence” without results, it would be worthwhile to spend some time meditating on the “*anicca*” nature. I know by experience that will make a big difference if one does it right.

- I spent 4-5 years contemplating on wrong *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anatta* (and a few other things like the wrong *anapana sati bhavana*). I really believe that the very first *desana* that exposed me to correct interpretation of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* changed my progress instantaneously. It was a profound effect. Not everyone may experience such a dramatic effect, but I am convinced it will be effective if one puts one’s mind to it.
- And I would really appreciate if anyone genuinely who felt a difference (with either *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* or the *anapana bhavana*) could let me know by sending a comment.

Next, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – According to Some Key Suttas](#)“,.....

Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – According to Some Key Suttas

The key to understanding the First Noble Truth (*Dukkha Sacca*; pronounced “dukkha sachcha”) is to understand the Three Characteristics of “this wider world of 31 realms”, i.e., *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. Let us discuss how these concepts are presented in some key *suttas*.

Dhamma Cakka Pavattana Sutta

1. How suffering arises from *Anicca* is explicitly described in the very first *sutta*, *Dhamma Cakka Pavattana Sutta*. Here is the text from the *sutta*:

Idam kho pana, bhikkhave, dukkham ariyasaccam:

Jati’pi dukkha, jara’pi dukkha, vyadhi’pi dukkha, maranam’pi dukkham, appiyehi sampayogo dukkho, piyehi vippayogo dukkho, yamp’iccham na labhati tam’pi dukkham, sankhittena pancupadanakkhandha dukkha.

2. Bhikkhus, What is the Noble Truth of Suffering?

- “*jathi api dukkha*” means “birth of something that is not liked by one causes suffering”. “*Jara pi dukkha*” means, “decay of something that is liked causes suffering”, and “*maranan pi dukkha*” means, “Death of a liked causes suffering”.
- Then comes, “..*appiyehi sampayogo dukkho, piyehi vippayogo dukkho*” meaning, “it brings sorrow when a loved one has to depart, and it also brings sorrow to be with a hated person”.

3. And then the summary of all that: “*yamp’iccham na labhati tam’pi dukkham*”. Here we see, “***ichcha***” that we encountered in both *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* and also in *paticca samuppada* (“*pati+ichcha*” “*sama+uppada*”). And “*labhati*” means “get”.

- Thus, “**If one does not get one likes, that leads to suffering**”. This phrase has everything condensed. This is ***anicca***. It does not say suffering arises because of impermanence.
- This is explained in more detail in “[Does the First Noble Truth Describe only Suffering?](#)”.

Anatta Lakkhana Sutta

1. In the second *sutta*, the *Anatta Lakkhana Sutta* (which was also delivered to the five ascetics within a fortnight of the first *sutta*), the questions that the Buddha was asking the ascetics and their responses are given:

“Tam kim mannata, bhikkhave: rupam niccam va aniccam va ti?”

– Aniccam, Bhante.

Yam pan aniccam dukham va sukham va ti?”

– Dukkham, Bhante.

Yam pan aniccam dukham viparinama dhamman, kalam nu tam samanupassitum: ‘etan mama, éso hamasmi, éso mé attati?’

– N’ hetum, Bhante.”

2. The first question was, “*Bhikkhus: is any rupa nicca or anicca?*” or “*Bhikkhus: can any rupa (material entity) be kept to one’s satisfaction or it cannot be kept to one’s satisfaction?*”

And the *bhikkhus* answer: “It cannot be kept to one’s satisfaction, Venerable Sir”.

- Here it is to be noted that “*rupa*” can be either internal or external. There are many *rupa* in this world that are “permanent” at least compared to our lifetimes. For example, an item made of gold or a diamond can last millions of years. But neither can be kept to “our satisfaction” since we will have to give them up when we die.

3. The second question is: “Will such an entity lead to suffering or happiness?” And the *bhikkhus* answer: “Suffering, Venerable Sir”.

- Here it is important to see that if an entity is not permanent, whether that will lead to suffering: How many people suffered when Bin Laden got killed? Only those who liked him to live! Many people rejoiced in his demise; this is also discussed in detail in “[Does the First Noble Truth Describe only Suffering?](#)”.

4. The third question is: “Will such an entity that cannot be kept to one’s satisfaction, that leads to suffering, and is a *viparinama dhamma*, should be considered as “myself or mine, or has any **substance**?” And the *bhikkhus* answer: “No reason to think so, Venerable Sir”.

5. Here we need to pay attention to the sequence of the three questions. The Buddha was pointing out that no “*rupa*” can be kept to our satisfaction, therefore that (i.e., forming attachment to such *rupa*) will lead to suffering, and therefore there is no reason to consider of them having any substance. **Anicca leads to dukkha and to anatta.**

- This was pointed out as “*ya da niccam tan dukkham, tan dukkham ta da natta*” in the *Ajjhattanicca Sutta* in the *Samyutta Nikaya* as was pointed out in “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations](#)”.

6. The Buddha was talking about “*rupa*” in general, which could be external objects or one’s own body (which are included in the *pancakkhandha* or the twelve *ayatana*s, i.e., anything in the “whole world”).

- The second question is, “any such entity, whether in one’s own body or in the outside world will eventually lead to suffering or happiness?”, and the *bhikkhus* answer “Suffering”.
- Then the third question is “If my body is such an entity, is it suitable to call it mine? if an external object is such entity, is it suitable to be called mine? and is there any **substance** in any of those?”
- Thus “*atta*” at the end meant “**substantial or fruitful or worthy**”. Thus what is meant is EVERYTHING IN THIS WORLD is without substance, i.e., *anatta*, which is the opposite of *atta*. This is why it is “*sabbe dhamma anatta*”, even the *nama gatta* that do not decay do not have any substance; see, “[Difference Between Dhamma and Sankhara \(Sankata\)](#)”

7. Thus it is important to realize that the Buddha was not referring to just one’s body; *anicca* applies to all *sankhara* and *sankata*. Nothing in this world can be kept to our satisfaction: “*Sabbe sankhara anicca*”.

- This becomes clear when we think about it in depth. There are many external objects in this world that do not decay within our lifetimes: gold or diamonds are two good examples.
- We may not be able to keep a gold necklace to “our liking”, for example if have to sell it raise money if we go bankrupt. But the point is that even if we do not lose it due to such an event, we WILL lose it when we die. Either the desired object or our body WILL BE lost, i.e., we do not have the ability to maintain ANYTHING to our satisfaction.
- Thus *nicca/anicca* is not “permanent/impermanent”, rather “can be /cannot be kept our satisfaction”. If suffering arises because of impermanence, then suffering cannot be stopped

from arising, because impermanence is a fact of nature and CANNOT be altered.

- The “*anicca*” character does not reside in the object or the *rupa*. It is in our mind. We CAN remove the wrong perception of *anicca* from our minds and CAN stop suffering from arising in future rebirths.
- **Then the same set of questions are repeated for *vedana*, *sanna*, *sankhara*, and *vinnana*.** None of those can be maintained to our satisfaction, i.e., they all are *anicca*. Thus we eventually suffer, and thus all struggles to keep them to our satisfaction are in vain and therefore, we are helpless in this rebirth process. This is *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.

8. We strive to accumulate “good stuff” but will have to leave them all behind at death. When we go through the rebirth process, we just repeat this process in each life.

- In most rebirths the suffering is great, and in some there is happiness (human, *deva* and *brahma* realms), but such “good rebirths” are encountered very rarely. The Buddha said that the lowest four realms are the “home base” for the living beings; they may visit other realms once-in-a-while, but always have to come back and spend most time in the home base.
- This is why the Buddha said this never-ending process of the cycle of rebirths, where we suffer so much, is fruitless and one is truly helpless. This is *anatta*.
- It does not make sense to say because of *anicca* and *dukkha*, we have “no-self” or “no-soul”. Rather, as long as we have the wrong perception of *anicca* about anything in “this world”, we are subject to suffering and thus we are truly helpless, *anatta*.

Girimananda Sutta

1. This is another key *sutta* in the *Tipitaka* that describes *anicca* in the deepest sense. The Buddha delivered this *sutta* to Ven. Ananda (for him to recite to Ven. Girimananda who was in pain due to an ailment). Here is a key phrase (in the middle of the *sutta*):

“*Katamā ca Ananda sabba sankhārésu anicca sannā?*”

Idhī Ananda bhikkhu sabba sankhārēhi atteeyati harāyati jigujjati

Ayaṃ vuccati Ananda sabba sankhārésu anicca sannā”

Translated:

“Ananda, What is the (correct) perception of all *sankhara*?”

Ananda, all *sankhara* are like meatless bones, without substance, to be rejected like urine and feces

That is Ananda, how one should perceive all *sankhara*“

2. Here the Buddha is describing the characteristics of any and all *sankhara* (“*sabba*” is “all”).

- “*Atti*” is “bone”. A dog really enjoys chewing a bone. But a bone has no nutrition or taste. Most of the time, the dog’s gum starts bleeding and that is what it tastes. But the dog does not realize that and values a bone very highly.
- “*Hara*” is “substance”, and “*harayati*” is without substance.
- “*Jee*” and “*goo*” are the Pali and Sinhala words for “urine” and “feces”. Thus “*jigujjati*” means things to be treated as such.

3. Another key point here is to note that the Buddha was talking about the “*anicca sanna*“, where *sanna* or perception is one of the main mental factors or *cetasika*. **Anicca** is a **perception** in our minds as we pointed out in the discussion on the *Anatta Lakkhana Sutta* above.

- Impermanence is a physical reality of anything in the universe. Scientists know quite well that **nothing** in our universe, including the universe itself, is permanent; but that does not provide them with the perception of *anicca*. No scientist can attain *Nibbana* via comprehending impermanence.

4. **Thus it is quite clear that *anicca* has nothing to do with “impermanence”.** Once one understands the true nature of the world, one will realize that any *sankhara* (thought, speech, and action that is focused on attaining pleasurable things) is not to be valued, because none can be maintained to one’s satisfaction and will only lead to suffering at the end.

- Actually, the fruitlessness of ALL *SANKHARA* is perceived only at the *Arahant* stage. We cannot even beginning to comprehend that yet. This is why an *Arahant* is said to see the burden associated with even breathing (which is a *kaya sankhara*). Anything we do to live in this world is a *sankhara*.
- **Initially, we should try to comprehend the unsuitability of *apunnabhi abhisankhara*, those associated with immoral actions. Since we can grasp the consequences of such immoral actions, we CAN get our minds to reject them. This is enough to get to the *Sotapanna* stage.**
- Once we do that, our cleansed minds can begin to see the fruitlessness of *punnabhi abhisankhara*, and then even the pleasures of *jhanic* states (*anenjhabhi abhisankhara*).

The Key Problem with Sutta Interpretations

There are many, many *suttas* in the *Tipitaka* that describe *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. But if one starts off with the wrong interpretations, some of those *suttas* can be interpreted the wrong way, because the *suttas* themselves are not designed to describe the concepts in detail. Rather the *suttas* provide brief descriptions or the *niddesa* version, and commentaries (Sinhala *atthakatha*) were supposed to provide the detailed (*patiniddesa*) descriptions; see, “[Sutta – Introduction](#)”.

- The root cause for the confusion has been the acceptance of the *Visuddhimagga* by Buddhaghosa as THE key commentary by the *Theravada* tradition.
- Nowadays, most *bhikkhus* do not read the *Tipitaka* or the remaining three original commentaries that are in the *Tipitaka*; they just follow what is in the *Visuddhimagga*. This has been the single-most obstacle for people attaining *Nibbana* for the past many hundreds of years.
- Luckily, we have three of the original commentaries (Sinhala *atthakatha*) preserved in the *Tipitaka*; see, “[Misinterpretations of Buddha Dhamma](#)” and “[Preservation of the Dhamma](#)”.

If Everything is Anicca Should We Just give up Everything?

1. Anicca means “we cannot maintain anything to our satisfaction in the LONG RUN”. The time scale of existence is an important factor when we contemplate the significance and implications of this fundamental characteristic of nature.

- So, the question is, “if nothing can be maintained to our satisfaction, what is the point in spending so much time in learning, getting a decent job, making plans for businesses, etc.?”. The question seems to be reasonable until we look at the “big picture”.

2. During the life, we do see many instances where we can attain certain things (pass exams, get jobs, initiate successful businesses, have a comfortable life, etc) and be happy about such achievements; of course there are many times we encounter unexpected things too (coming down with health problems, traffic accidents, floods, hurricanes, loss of jobs, etc).

- That is the nature of existence as a human. It is a mixed bag, at least until we get to the old age; then it becomes increasingly difficult to maintain things (especially our bodies) to our satisfaction, and of course at death we have to leave everything behind whether we like it not.
- In the realms above the human in fact, life is even more predictable and enjoyable, that is of course until death comes calling.
- But the real problems encountered in the four realms below the human realm. It is increasingly difficult to “maintain things to one’s satisfaction” in lower realms. Animals are truly helpless, especially the vast majority that lives in the wild. There are no “old animals” in the wild; they either get sick and die or even worse: they get eaten up as soon as they slow down a bit.
- There is no happiness at all in the lowest realm, the *niraya* (“*ni*”+“*ra*” means without ANY happiness).

3. Thus the main reason why “we cannot maintain things to our satisfaction in the LONG RUN” is because all beings spend most of their lives in the lower four realms; see, [“How the Buddha Described the Chance of Rebirth in the Human Realm”](#).

4. Now we can examine the question in terms of this “big picture”. If we do give up everything, we will probably die a miserable death (because we will be poor, unhealthy, etc because we would not be able to even support ourselves), and be born most likely in a lower realm. That it will make the situation much worse.

- We do need to contemplate on this situation. If one thinks through this line of thoughts, one can see that one is really helpless in this cycle of rebirths, which is the third characteristic of existence, *anatta*. Until a Buddha comes to this world and shows humans this “big picture”, AND shows how to get out of it, no one is able to escape this trap.
- The only solution is to at least attain [the Sotapanna stage](#) of *Nibbana* in this life. We MAY have some *kammic* energy left for one or more human lives (see, [“Bhava and Jati – States of Existence and Births Therein”](#)), but this COULD BE the last for a long while, which could be billions of years. Even if we get another human birth, we do not know under what circumstances; it could be somewhere Buddha Dhamma is not readily accessible.

5. There is another point that we need to consider regarding this question. We have become indebted to numerous beings in this journey of rebirths, and thus we have debts to pay back. Having all these

debts is a hindrance to attain any stage of *Nibbana*; see, “[Kamma, Debt, and Meditation](#)”.

6. Therefore, instead of abandoning our families (to whom we owe the most), we need to do our utmost to make sure they are well-off. We also need to make sure that we do not become dependent on the society (and thus accumulate more debt). Even in this life, we depend on others for so many things: we are indebted to our teachers, friends, as well to many unknown people who contribute to providing us with essentials to sustain life; we all are interconnected, and have responsibilities for each other. We have “to do our part” to live in a society.

- Therefore, part of the solution is to first prepare oneself (or one’s children if one is a parent) with a good education so that supporting oneself (and a family) is possible. Furthermore, a good education helps with understanding Dhamma too. And if one can make a lot of money (by honest means) then one can do many meritorious deeds too, thereby helping oneself spiritually as well.
- In any case, giving up everything and hiding in a forest will not solve the problem of existence. But there are some who have a *sansaric* tendency to abandon the “householder life”. What I am saying here is for the majority of people, not for everyone: Of course we need to sustain the *bhikkhus* who spend all their time for the benefit of others as well as themselves.

7. Therefore, what needs to be done is to understand the true nature of existence and realize that the ONLY solution is to try the best to attain at least [the Sotapanna stage](#) of *Nibbana*. Then one becomes free of rebirths in the lower four realms forever. This is THE solution to the problem.

In order to do that we need to,

1. Fulfil our obligations to our families, friends, and the society in general,
2. Make our best effort to learn pure Dhamma and attain [the Sotapanna stage](#) of *Nibbana*.

When one does this, one will become happy, not depressed, about the outlook. One has understood the problem and knows what to do about it. And when one starts working on it, one’s confidence will grow because one can feel the difference in oneself. One will become even more determined AND energetic, not just to save oneself, but also to help out the others.

The Incessant Distress (“Peleema”) – Key to Dukkha Sacca

This post may not be suitable for those who are starting out. It could be really helpful to someone who has some level of understanding on *anicca, dukkha, anatta*.

Most people think that the first Noble Truth on suffering is the suffering itself, i.e., they associate it with the *vedana cetasika*. However, the Buddha said, “This Dhamma is unlike anything that the world has ever seen”. The real truth on suffering is the suffering that is hidden in what everyone perceives to be happiness. It needs to be seen with the *panna (wisdom) cetasika*.

- In fact it is difficult to understand the first Noble Truth on suffering for someone who is feeling the suffering. When someone is hurting with an ailment or when someone’s mind is too weak at old age, it is not possible to contemplate on the deep message of the Buddha, as we will see below.

Dukkha sacca (**pronounced, “sachcha”**) is the Truth of Suffering; *sacca* is truth.

- “*Peleema*” is the Pali (and Sinhala) word for distress, or hardship, where the first part “pe” rhymes like “pen”. This is part of the suffering we undergo even without realizing.

This is the kind of meditation (contemplation) one needs to do initially, even before starting on the *Ariya Anapanasati bhavana*. I cannot emphasize enough the importance in understanding the real message of the Buddha first.

1. Even though we do not realize it, we are stressed out ALL THE TIME, due to our desire to keep our six senses satisfied. Anyone who has had a *jhanic* experience knows this. Only when one gets into a *jhanic* state (where the focus is held on a single object) that one realizes that one had been under incessant stress all life.

- We do not realize this because this is the “baseline” for existence (our “comfort zone”); this is what we have done over innumerable rebirths.
- In order to get some relief from this incessant stress, we constantly think about ways to bring about periods of happiness. We are constantly thinking of ways to get a better house, car, or zillions of other “things” that are supposed to provide us with happiness, i.e., we are ALWAYS stressing out in order to adjust this “baseline comfort zone”. We move to a bigger house, buy a set of new furniture, work harder to get a better job etc.
- Furthermore, when we go a little bit below the current “comfort level”, we need to do work (*sankhara*) to remedy that. For example, when we get hungry, we may have to prepare a meal or walk/drive to a restaurant to get a meal.
- Or, we may be sitting at home, satisfied after a meal, but then all of a sudden we again go “below the comfort level” for no apparent reason; we just become “bored” sitting at home, and think about going to movie. So, we get in the car drive to a movie theatre.
- I am sure you can think about zillion other things we do all day long.

2. **This unending “urges” we constantly get is one type of *dukkha*: *dukkha dukkha*.** This is the repeated, unending bouts of suffering due to our desire to satisfy the six senses:

- Our senses are constantly asking for enjoyment: the eye wants to see beautiful things, the ear wants to listen to pleasurable sounds, the nose wants to smell nice fragrances, the tongue wants

taste sumptuous foods, the body wants luxurious touch, and the mind likes to think about pleasing thoughts. We have to WORK (*sankhara*) to satisfy these needs. **This is a second type of *dukkha*: *sankhara dukkha*.**

- In addition to doing work going to restaurant, travelling to a cinema, etc, we also need to do a job to make money for all those activities. This is doing constant work (*sankhara*) to keep afloat.
- Most times, we get one urge on top another: we may want to eat and drink, we may want to watch a movie, but also may want company (gather friends).
- **We do not realize this suffering because our minds are focused on the end result, the pleasure we get after doing all that work.**
- You may be thinking, “What is he talking about? Isn’t this what the life is supposed to be?”. Exactly! We do not even realize this, because this is our “baseline” of existence. We have done this over and over extending to beginningless time, and we PERCEIVE this to be “normal”.

3. What we perceive as happiness actually comes from the relief we get when the distress level is subdued via our efforts. All we do is to suppress the incessant “imbalances”. This is illustrated by the following example:

- Suppose a person has his hands bound behind him. Then someone hits him hard with a stick. He feels the pain. This is analogous to *dukkha dukkha*, the incessant battering imparted by nature.
- If someone starts massaging the place that was hit, the person feels good, and asks to be massaged more. But work must be done to impart this happiness. This is compared to the *sankhara dukkha*. In this example, someone else is doing this work, but in real life each person is doing this extra work for himself. For example, when one is hungry, one needs to prepare food. Then he becomes happy after eating the food.
- Now if we ask this person if we should hit him again so that he can get the pleasure of the massage again, of course he will refuse. This is because he KNOWS the pain associated with the hit.
- On the other hand, we seek pleasure by working to satisfy our senses because we DO NOT know that there is a root cause for the baseline distress, and we DO NOT even realize that there is such a “baseline suffering” until a Buddha discovers it. This can be compared directly to the above example, if we can impart a hit on the person while he is under anesthetics. In that case, when he comes out of anesthesia, he feels the pain, but does not know what caused it.

4. The reality is that no matter what we do to please the senses, those pleasing moments are limited. Even if we can maintain that sense input for long times, the senses get tired after a while, and ask for a different kind of experience. Let us look at some examples:

- We can be lying in the most comfortable bed, but sooner or later, we start shifting and rolling trying to find a better posture, and eventually cannot stay in bed anymore.
- Even the most delicious food, we can eat only so much at a time. Not only that, if we eat the same kinds of foods for a week, we get tired of it regardless of how good they are, and want to try a different type of food.
- **This is called *viparinama dukkha*, another kind of *dukkha*.** This arises because NOTHING we do can maintain the status quo, anything that brings us pleasure is destroyed eventually.
- Many people think *viparinama dukkha* arises due to change or “*anitya*“. **But “change” is**

“parināma”; **“viparināma”** is the **“unexpected change”**. If something changes as expected, that is easier to handle mentally; but due to **“anicca nature”** things happen unexpectedly and that causes **“viparinama dukkha”**.

5. In summary, (i) we are under constant stress due to ever-present demands to satisfy the six senses (*dukkha dukkha*) mainly due to *kamma vipaka*, (ii) we suffer more by working to get relief from such demands (*sankhara dukkha*), and (iii) whatever satisfaction we get ends, either due to that “sense fulfilling process” breaking down unexpectedly OR us getting bored with it (*viparinama dukkha*).

- **However, the longing for such temporary bouts of happiness keeps all three types of suffering hidden. The Buddha gave the following simile: if you attach a pile of straw in front of an ox is pulling a cart, the ox will keep moving forward eagerly trying to get to the straw; it does not even feel its effort, because it is only thinking about the reward that it thinks it is hoping to get very soon.**
- This is our ignorance. We do not realize that no matter what we do, it is not possible to maintain anything to our satisfaction for long times. This is the characteristic of *anatta*, i.e., one is helpless in this rebirth process.

6. The worse part is that in the lowest four realms, beings become truly helpless. There is very little a being can do (*sankhara*) in order to make amends for the incessant *dukkha dukkha* in those realms. For example, a wild animal has very few choices when it gets hungry. If food is not found, it will go hungry for days with much suffering and eventually become prey to a stronger animal when it gets weak. In the wild, you do not see any old, sick animals; just as they get weak, they are eaten by bigger, stronger animals. This is the true meaning of *anatta*.

7. There is nowhere in the 31 realms where *dukkha* is absent. The three types of *dukkha* are present in the 31 realms in varying degrees:

- In the lowest realm, the *nirayas*, *dukkha dukkha* is predominant; there is only suffering, and no way to get relief by doing *sankhara*. Even in the animal realm there is relative little *sankhara dukkha*; they just suffer directly as pointed out above.
- In the higher realms (above the human realm), there is very little *dukkha dukkha* because those are “good births” that originated due to meritorious *kamma*. In these higher realms, it is the *viparinama dukkha* that ends the life there. Also, any *Brahma* has not overcome suffering in the lowest four realms in the future, unless the *Sotapanna* stage has been attained.
- It is in the human realm that all three types of *dukkha* are present at significant levels; also, the *sankhara dukkha* is highest compared to all the realms.

8. This is the First Noble Truth, *Dukkha Sacca*, that there is hidden *dukkha* even in bouts of apparent happiness, and that there is no place within the 31 realms where *dukkha* can be overcome permanently.

What is Avijja (Ignorance)?

1. People engage in immoral actions because they highly value the sense pleasures, and are unaware of a better type of happiness called *niramisa sukha*; see, “[Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)”.

Therefore, they are willing to do even immoral things in order to gain sense pleasures. They do not realize two drawbacks associated with such actions:

- If they hurt others in trying to get what they want, they will have to pay for the consequences with very high interest (law of kamma); these are the immoral acts that could lead to rebirth in the *apayas* (lowest four realms)
- Whatever enjoyment one gets from such sense pleasures are temporary.

These facts come out naturally from the true nature of the world that include the non-stop rebirth process that involves 31 realms and the law of kamma and the causal principle of *paticca samuppada*. It is not possible for anyone to realize these facts by oneself. One has to learn those from a Buddha or a true disciple of a Buddha.

2. What is *avijja*? It is basically the ignorance of those two facts, even though there is a whole framework of a “world view” behind them. The key ingredients of this “wider world view” are:

- “This world” is much more complex than what is readily observed with our five physical senses, i.e., there are 31 realms instead of the just the two (human realm and the animal realm) that are apparent to us; see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”.
- That the true nature of existence in any of the 31 realms is *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*; see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta](#)”.
- That most suffering is encountered in the lowest four realms (*apayas*).
- And this perpetual birth/rebirth process has no beginning (see, “[Infinity – How Big Is It?](#)”) and the only way to stop it is to attain the Arahant stage of Nibbana.
- But by reaching the Sotapanna stage of Nibbana, one can be assured that rebirth in the *apayas* (lowest four realms) is permanently stopped; see, “[Why a Sotapanna is Better off than Any King, Emperor, or Billionaire](#)”.

3. [The definition of avijja is not understanding the Four Noble Truths](#). But to understand the Four Noble Truths one needs to see the “true nature of the world”, the three characteristics of this world: *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.

4. In brief, *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* mean:

- There is NOTHING in this world that can be maintained to our satisfaction in the long run (*anicca*); thus, after much struggle we only end up with suffering (*dukkha*); thus, all these struggles are in vain and one is helpless (*anatta*).
- The above three characteristics are not just for the human realm: One cannot find any panacea by seeking a better rebirth (even though the realms at and above human realm have less suffering), i.e., none of the 31 realms can provide any lasting happiness, and we are truly helpless (*anatta*).

- In particular, if one does IMMORAL things (killing, stealing, etc) in seeking this illusory happiness, the more one gets trapped in lower realms filled with suffering.
- Unfortunately, the true meanings of *anicca* and *anatta* have been wrongly interpreted as “impermanence” and “no-self”; see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations](#)“, and the follow up posts on the correct interpretations.

5. For anyone willing to dig deeper: *anicca*, *dikkha*, *anatta*, are manifestations of the impermanence nature “of this world” as described in many ways:

- In *Abhidhamma*, it is explained how this world is “mind based”, and how both the mind and the material phenomena CHANGE with incredible speed.
- This “change” is not random, but is dictated by “cause and effect” or *paticca samuppada*.
- These and others relevant material is discussed at different sections on the site.
- However, it is NOT necessary to learn all those details to achieve some “cooling down” or ‘niveema’ or even various stages of Nibbana. One can grasp the concepts of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* via meditation or contemplation on one’s own life experiences.

6. When one does not comprehend this “big picture”, one makes bad decisions.

- For example, a fish does not see the string or the hook, only sees the worm, and gets into trouble. If it saw the whole picture, with the string and the hook, it may realize that there is something wrong and would not try to grab the worm.
- Just like the fish in the above example, we only see the pleasures to be had in this human life, but do not realize that because of this “apparent pleasures” we are grabbing hold of a world that also include unbearable suffering in the lowest four realms, not to mention the hidden suffering in this life.
- Only a Buddha can see this “bigger picture” and he has shown us not only that bigger picture, but also the reasons why we should believe in that bigger picture. In this website, I hope to provide this evidence in a systematic way.

7. That complex world view (**everything changing moment-to-moment everywhere in those 31 realms**) can be grasped only by a Buddha with a highly-purified mind. Other than a Buddha, a normal human being (no matter how intelligent) is incapable of seeing that whole world view; see, “[Godel’s Incompleteness Theorem](#)“.

- Thus *avijja* cannot be dispelled by “book knowledge”. One needs to comprehend the “true nature of this complex world”.
- Even when we are told about it, it is not easy to grasp it, because our minds have been covered with defilements that have been accumulating from an untraceable beginning; see, “[Key to Calming the Mind](#)“.

8. Another important factor that keeps many people “in the dark” or “in ignorance” is the wrong impression that Buddha Dhamma is a pessimistic world view. With the pure Dhamma hidden for over a thousand years, several important facts about the Four Noble Truths got distorted:

- When the Buddha said “this world” is filled with suffering he meant the wider world of 31 realms. Also, he did not say, there is suffering ALL THE TIME or in all the realms of existence. In higher realms (realms 6-31), there is actually much more happiness than suffering. Even in

the human realm (the 5th realm), there is more happiness than suffering for many people. That is why it is hard for many people to get motivated to examine the message of the Buddha.

- Yet most beings spend most of the time in the lowest four realms (*apayas*). This is why, ON AVERAGE, the suffering in the sansara (cycle of rebirths; see, “[Evidence for Rebirth](#)”) is much higher compared to any kind of happiness that can be experienced in any realm.
- Together with the wider “world view”, the concept of an unimaginably long rebirth process got lost; see, “[Sansaric Time Scale](#)“. The fact that it is not possible to trace a beginning to this rebirth process is not widely known. In the scale of the [sansaric time scale](#), this lifetime of a hundred or so years is negligible. Thus whatever “accomplishment” one achieves, it has a very short duration in the [sansaric time scale](#).
- Also, Buddha was just the messenger who conveyed these dismaying FACTS about nature. He discovered the nature’s laws, which clearly illustrate that it is not possible to find any LONG-LASTING happiness ANYWHERE in these 31 realms. But he also pointed out how to find a better and permanent kind of happiness.

9. The most important fact that has been lost for hundreds of years is that there is a happiness of a better quality that also is PERMANENT. This is the Nibbanic bliss or the *niramisa sukha*; see, “[Three Kinds of Happiness](#)“, “[How to Taste Nibbana](#)“, and “[Nibbana – Is it Difficult to Understand?](#)“. And one can start experiencing this niramisa sukha even before attaining the Sotapanna stage of Nibbana; see, “[Key to Calming the Mind](#)“. For more details, see, “[Niramisa Sukha](#)“.

- Not knowing any of those (and related facts) is *avijja* (ignorance). If one does not know about those facts, then how can one find a solution to the problem of suffering? Also, since only a Buddha can discover these laws, without hearing the message from another person (or a website!), there is no way anyone can learn all this by oneself, no matter how intelligent one is.

10. The key point is that *avijja* can be compared to darkness. The ONLY WAY to get rid of darkness is to bring in a light; [no matter what else one does, it will not get rid of darkness. Here light is wisdom or panna, understanding the true nature of the world, i.e., anicca, dukkha, anatta.](#)

Next, “[Two Types of Vedana \(Feelings\)](#)“,

Bhava and Jati – States of Existence and Births Therein

There is much confusion about the terms “*bhava*” and “*jati*” (pronounced “*jāthi*”). But that does not need to be the case. Here we will clarify these two important terms in the *paticca samuppada* (PS) cycles.

1. In both Pali and Sinhala, *jati* means birth; *bhava* means “*tibena bava*” in Sinhala, or an state of existence.

- Also, “*bha*” means “establish”. When we have strong feelings about something, say we like something and “wheel around” in our mind about how to get it, that is very potent *abhisankhara*; this mental power gets established in the “*kamma bhava*” as a *kamma beeja* (seed).
- This is also why it is easy to make *kamma beeja* or *kamma bhava* based on our *gathi* (habits/character). Each person likes certain kinds of things. So, we keep strengthening existing *kamma beeja/kamma bhava*, which, if strong enough, can lead to a rebirth with such “*gathi*” or “*bhava*”.

2. Let us take some examples.

- An alcoholic drinks habitually, and thus people refer to him as a drunkard. He has a drinking habit (*gathi*) and a craving (*asava*) for it. But he is not in a state of intoxication all the time, only when he is drunk, i.e., only when he is born in that “*jati*”. The mindset of liking for a state of intoxication is the “*bhava*” is his “*gathi*” (habit); he has that *gathi* or *bhava* and thus he can be “born” (*jati*) in that state easily. **This is the “*bhava paccaya jati*” step in the PS cycle.**
- On the other hand, someone who does not like to drink may even have an aversion for drinking alcohol. That person does not have “*gathi*” or “*bhava*” for intoxication and thus it is improbable that he will be “born” in that state; thus it is unlikely that he will get drunk, or “be born” in that condition. The “*bhava paccaya jati*” step in the PS cycle does not happen here, because the condition or the cause, *bhava*, is not there.
- A person who has a really bad temper has a “*gathi*” or “*bhava*” for that, and thus may be born in that, i.e., may flare up with the slightest provocation. Another may have a less strong “*bhava*”, and a third person who is very calm may have only a trace of that “*bhava*”. The stronger the “*bhava*”, the easier it is to be born (*jati*) in that “*bhava*”.
- Similarly, a person who may have excess greed will have a “*gathi*” or “*bhava*” for that. And such a “greedy *bhava*” may have focused areas: some are greedy for food, some for power, some for fame, money, etc.

3. ***Bhava* is intimately connected to *gathi* (habits).** One “builds up” a given *bhava* by engaging in activities that cultivate that *bhava*; this happens via repeated *paticca samuppada* cycles. An alcoholic does this by associating with friends who are alcoholics, frequenting places where they all hang out, etc. This is discussed in the “[Akusala-Mula Pavutti \(or Pravutti\) Paticca Samuppada](#)”.

4. **The above examples describe how “*pavutti kamma bhava*” are made,** i.e., how one prepares a certain *bhava* via engaging in relevant *sankhara* or *kamma* repeatedly. An alcoholic does this via *mano*, *vaci*, and *kaya* *sankhara*: he thinks about such activities (*mano sankhara*), plans them (*vaci sankhara*, i.e., engages in *vitakka* and *vicara* that are focused on drinking activities), and then physically engages in such activities (*kaya sankhara*). The more he does those, the stronger the

“drinking *bhava*” or “drinking habit” becomes.

- Someone who has cultivated such *kamma bhava* can be easily born in that state DURING a life time; this is the *pavutti bhava* described in the “[Akusala-Mula Pavutti \(or Pravutti\) Paticca Samuppada](#)”.
- Let us take another example. A child gains pleasure by torturing a cat or a dog. If this habit is not stopped, he may start gaining pleasure by torturing humans too. The “*pati+ichcha sama+uppada*” cycle will take him to an extreme if not disrupted early enough. He will build a habit for it during the same lifetime.

5. **Such *kamma bhava* can get strong enough to become “*uppatti kamma bhava*”.** This is the real danger. People with similar habits (“*gathi*”) tend to “hang together” (see, “[The Law of Attraction, Habits \(Gati\), and Cravings \(Asavas\)](#)”). In the same way, at the dying moment one will be drawn to an environment that is compatible with ones prominent habits (*gathi*) or *bhava*. Because one got attached willingly, a similar *bhava* will result: i.e., *pati+ichcha* leading to *sama+uppada* or PS.

- Thus an alcoholic is prone to be born to family where the father or mother (or both) are alcoholics.
- One who enjoys torturing animals/humans may be born in niraya (hell) where there is incessant torture. Depending on the nature of the *bhava* one could be born there to impart torture on others or to be subjected to torture.
- One who has benevolent qualities of a deva (i.e., *deva bhava*) could acquire “*deva bhava*” and be born a deva; one who has cultivated compassion for other beings (i.e., *brahma bhava*) may acquire “*brahma bhava*” and be born a brahma. Similarly, one who has developed disgraceful qualities of dog may be acquire a “*dog bhava*”, and be born repeatedly a dog until that kammic energy is spent. It is the universal principle of “*pati+ichcha sama+uppada*” working to yield an existence that is similar to the actions that was the cause for that existence; see, “[Akusala-Mula Pavutti \(or Pravutti\) Paticca Samuppada](#)”.

6. Thus a *bhava* is really synonym for a *kamma beeja* (seed); when one develops a habit (*gathi*) by keep doing it over and over, that seed gets bigger. A *kamma* seed is germinated (gives birth, i.e., “*bhava paccaya jati*”) under suitable conditions.

- An alcoholic with a *kamma* seed (or *bhava*) for intoxication is easily germinated; all needed is a suggestion by friend, or even the sight of a bar at a suitable time. This is an example of a *pavutti kamma bhava*.
- In the case of the person who developed a *bhava* for torturing other living beings may have that *kamma* seed being the one selected for next *bhava* upon death from a *bhava* that had exhausted all its kammic energy. In that case, he may be born in the niraya repeatedly (many *jati*) until the kammic energy for that *kamma* seed is spent. This is an example of an *uppatti kamma bhava*.

7. Thus it becomes clear that one needs to look at the root cause for having certain habits or behavior patterns. There is a reason for that described by PS; we can go backwards in the PS to find the causes. To be born in a drunken state, one needs to have a *bhava* of an alcoholic; that *bhava* was conditioned via *upadana* (willing and forceful embracing), which in turn was due to *tanha* (getting attached to drinking), which was due to feeling (i.e., he got to like the “drunk” feeling, the state of intoxication), which was due to (*san*)*phassa* or contact, *salayatana* (using the six senses inappropriately), *namarupa* (associated visuals of names and things), *sankhara* (*kaya, vaci, and mano sankhara* for that activity),

and of course the starting point of *avijja* (ignorance). By examining these steps, we can see that the whole cycle can be stopped at any place:

- By contemplating on the adverse consequences of drinking, he could remove ignorance, and make a firm decision to stop.
- If he is mindful, whenever a thought about drinking comes to the mind, he can stop “wheeling around” (stopping *mano/vaci sankhara*) and thus stopping multiple PS cycles.
- The less he goes through such PS cycles, the weaker the *vinnana* or the mindset for drinking will get.
- Then he will make less and less associated *namarupa*, less *salayatana*, less contacts, and thus experience less of that feeling. This will further propagate to less *tanha*, *upadana*, *bhava* or habit formation, and thus will be less likely to be “born” in that state.

8. If he is able to get rid of that drinking habit (*gathi*), he would have removed that *bhava* (or the kamma seed). Then it is unlikely that he will be born (*jati*) in that intoxicated state. The “trigger level” needed to generate a birth will be higher if the *bhava* (or habit) is not strong. When he had a strong habit for drinking (strong *bhava*), all needed was a suggestion from a friend to “go and have a drink”.

9. All above is valid for “good *bhava*” or “good habits” too. In order to cultivate that *bhava*, one needs to be engaged in as many PS cycles as possible. The more the cycle gets repeated, the stronger each step becomes (the neural connections in the brain for that habit will strengthen, in term of modern science; see, “[How Habits are Formed and Broken – A Scientific View](#)”).

- It is easy to see from the above discussion why it is important to instill good habits in children and also to break any bad habits that they start developing. It is much more easier to stop forming a *bhava* or habit (*gathi*) at early stages; once the habit takes hold, it becomes harder to remove. And that is true for adults too.

10. I hope that I was able to convey the distinction between *bhava* and *jati*. For example, if an animal has exhausted kammic energy of that “animal *bhava*“, and if it has a dominant kamma seed suitable for a human, it may come to forefront at the dying moment. Then, the animal to human transition (*cuti-patisandhi*) takes place in the last *citta vithi* of the animal.

- Now this new “human *bhava*” may have enough kammic energy for many human births, say, 1000 years worth. In that case, this “human *bhava*” will last for 1000 years unless he commits a very strong kamma, good or bad. So, he could have 10 consecutive births (*jati*) in the human realm each lasting 100 years. At the end of his first *jati*, the last *citta vithi* will not have a *cuti-patisandhi* transition; the *gandhabbaya* will come out the dead body and will seek a new human womb to enter; see, “[Manomaya Kaya and Physical Body](#)“.
- It is not easy to find a suitable womb right away, so the *gandhabbaya* may have to wait a frustratingly long time, some time many years, before a suitable womb becomes available. This is why there is a gap between consecutive lives in most rebirth accounts.

11. There are several key words associated with “*bhava*“.

- A person who is working to eliminate “*bhava*” and attain Nibbana is a “*Bhauddhaya*“; see, “[A Buddhist or a Bhauddhaya?](#)“.
- “*Bhikkhu*” has a similar meaning: “*bhava*” + “*khaya*“. Normally the word “*bhikkhu*” is a

stronger word, and is used to indicate a “dedicated *Bhauddhaya*“. Nowadays, “*bhikkhu*” is used exclusively for those who have given up the “householder life”.

- A “*Buddha*” is someone who has removed “*bhava*“. This can be done via three ways as described in “[Saddharma Pundika Sutra \(Lotus Sutra\) – A Focused Analysis](#)“.

Also see, “[How Character \(Gathi\) Leads to Bhava and Jathi](#)“,

Annantara and Samanantara Paccaya

1. These are two important “paccaya” or relations in Buddha Dhamma. Anything in this world happens due to a reason (hetu, pronounced “héthu”). But just because there is a hetu (cause), the appropriate result (or the effect) may not occur until suitable conditions are realized.

2. This is the reason why kamma is not deterministic. In the post, “[What is Kamma? – Is Everything Determined by Kamma?](#)”, I stated this fact and here we will see the reason for it.

- When we commit a good or a bad deed, the kammic potential or energy associated with that deed is deposited in a kamma beeja or a kamma seed. We will eventually get to the question of “where it is stored”, but we just need to keep in mind that a kamma seed is not a physical seed, but is an energy or a potential. This concept is described in the post, “[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka](#)”.
- The germination of a kamma seed, though, has some similarities to the germination of a physical seed, for example, an apple seed. The apple seed has the potential to bring about an apple tree, but the seed will not germinate until suitable conditions for germination are realized: the seed needs to be in soil, and water and sunlight are also needed to be provided for germination to take place.
- In the same way, kamma vipaka (result of a past kamma) can come to fruition only when right conditions for the corresponding kamma seed to germinate are realized.

3. Let us look at the annantara and samanantara relations as discussed in the Pathāna Dhamma (book on “Conditional Relations” in Abhidhamma):

- “An” means food or in this case the kamma seed; “antara” means in storage, waiting to bear fruit.
- Thus, annantara means basically a kamma seed waiting to be germinated.
- “Sama” means equal or similar. Thus samanantara (“sama” + “annantara”) means “matching conditions” with the annantara.
- Therefore, annantara and samanantara go together. There must be an [annantara \(basically a cause or an stored energy in a seed\)](#) for a samanantara to be effective. On the other hand, if [samanantara \(right conditions for that cause to take effect or for the seed to germinate\)](#) is not there, a kamma seed at annantara cannot bear fruit.

4. Here is one example the Buddha gave: If one prepares a plot by preparing the soil, providing water, and if sunlight is also available, the samanantara for a seed to germinate is there. However, unless one starts off with an apple seed (annantara condition not met), an apple tree will not grow.

- On the other hand, if one keeps the apple seed in a cool, dry place, it will not germinate, i.e., the samanantara condition is not met
- When both annantara and samanantara conditions are met, i.e., when one plants an apple seed in a suitable plot, it will germinate and become an apple tree.
- However, when an apple seed is planted a mango tree will not result from that but only an apple tree: thus samanantara will give rise to an effect that matches the “seed” that was in annantara.

5. More examples can be given these days that are related to modern technology. If a radio station is

broadcasting a radio program, that can be taken as the annantara: the seed energy is available anywhere within a certain range. But one cannot listen to the program without a radio; even if someone has a radio, one cannot listen to the program unless the radio is “tuned” to the correct frequency. When those conditions are met, one could hear the program even many miles away. The delay between the broadcast and reception is a very short time.

- Kamma vipaka can be thought of bringing fruit via “instant communication” when the conditions become right. All kammic potentials are in “instant contact” with us via a concept similar to that described in quantum entanglement: see, “[Quantum Entanglement – We Are All Connected](#)”. **Thus all potential kamma seeds are waiting in annantara and can bring about instant results when right conditions (samanantara) appear.**

6. By being mindful, we can avoid many past bad kamma seeds from coming to fruition. We just make sure that samanantara conditions are not present. If one goes out at night in a bad neighborhood that is providing fertile ground for a past bad kamma seed to germinate and the kamma vipaka to take place.

- In the same way, we can force good kamma seeds to germinate by providing the right conditions. For example, even if we have enough merits (a good kamma seeds) that could make us pass a test or get a job, unless we make right conditions (i.e., prepare in advance), we may not get the results.
- But sometimes one gets an unexpected promotion or get better results than anticipated in a test if the kamma seeds are strong.

7. From our past innumerable lives we have accumulated innumerable kamma seeds both good and bad. Some of the stronger ones bear fruit no matter what we do, especially the anantariya kamma vipaka.

- But in general, by being mindful (i.e., by NOT providing appropriate conditions), we can avoid many bad kamma vipaka; by making right preparations (i.e., by optimizing samanantara conditions), we can exploit those good kamma seeds.
- A particularly important case is the bringing up a child. The parents and teachers have a huge responsibility for providing right conditions for that young mind to develop. In particular, association with bad friends can direct a young life in the wrong direction; in the same way, association with good friends, a nurturing environment, can bring about a productive, responsible adult.

8. One important cross-connection is matching “gathi” with similar ‘gathi” that we have discussed before; see, “[Habits and Goals](#)”, and “[Sansaric Habits and Asavas](#)”.

- For example, when a gandhabbaya is waiting for a suitable womb, the annantara-samanantara paccaya come into play. A gandhabbaya, who in the previous lives had developed a certain habit, say heavy drinking, is attracted to a womb of a woman with similar habits, possibly an alcoholic or a drug user. The concept of a gandhabbaya is described in, “[Manomaya Kaya and Physical Body](#)“, and “[Manomaya Kaya and Out-of-Body Experience \(OBE\)](#)“.
- Similarly, a gandhabbaya, who in previous lives led moral lives, is bound to be attracted to a womb of the mother in a moral family. Just like in the above case, here also the samanantara for the gandhabbaya (where it can establish itself) is an environment that matches its own “gathi”.

- However, no matter how one is born, one can still change one's own destiny by making conditions for other good *kamma vipaka* to come to fruition and also by making sure not to make conditions for bad *kamma vipaka* to come to fruition.

In other posts we will discuss further applications of annantara-samanantara relations. One important application is in, “[Transfer of Merits \(Pattidana\)- How does it Happen?](#)”.

Next, “[Difference Between Dhamma and Sankhara](#)“,

Mind and Consciousness

[What is Mind? How do we Experience the Outside World?](#)

[What is Consciousness?](#)

[1. Thoughts \(Citta\), Consciousness \(Vinnana\), and Mind \(Hadaya Vatthu\) – Introduction](#)

[2. Vinnana \(Consciousness\) can be of Many Different Types and Forms](#)

[3. Vinnana, Thoughts, and the Subconscious](#)

What is Mind? How do we Experience the Outside World?

1. This world of 31 realms is very complex. But many versions of “Buddhism” that we have today make it much more complex than it really is. The Buddha had given us only the essential knowledge base that is required to attain *Nibbana* (actually, one does not need to understand all these minute details: if one can feel the enhanced niramisa sukha from getting rid of greed, hate, and ignorance, one can just follow the Noble Eightfold Path without knowing any details of how the mind works, etc).

- People who could not understand Buddha Dhamma kept inventing terms/concepts like *bodhicitta* and emptiness to try to make sense of what they could not comprehend. And many people in the old days “fell for” those fancy terms. But now, with science clarifying many concepts independently of Dhamma, those concepts are showing their true colors, i.e., they are just a lot of empty words.

2. Please take time and read the following (or any post) very carefully. There is a lot of basic information that could be useful in “putting the whole picture together”. Most posts are supposed to be read again (after reading other related posts), because sometimes a little bit of information gleaned from one post can “fill in the blanks” in another post.

- Dhamma has to be complex to describe a complex world, and even though the Buddha has made it as simple as possible, it takes time to see how all the pieces of the puzzle fit in. And they do. If anyone can find any inconsistencies, anywhere on the website, please send me a comment.

3. Everything that we experience comes through six “doors” or “*ayatana*” we have to the outside worlds: eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and the mind. Through those six doors we can see pictures, hear sounds, smell odors, taste food, feel things physically by touch, and be aware of concepts (say, mundane things like remembering past events or make plans about future events, or think about a black hole in the middle of the universe or a mathematical concept).

- The six sense faculties (and the corresponding six external “*ayatana*” which are *rupa*, *sadda*, *gandha*, *rasa*, *pottabba* or visuals, sounds, smells, tastes, touches, and concepts) are what the Buddha called “*sabba*”, or “everything”. These are 12 *ayatanas* (6 internal and 6 external).

4. All those are done with *citta* or thoughts. But this is probably not a good translation. We normally associate a “thought” with an idea or one visual event, etc., a moment of “experience”. But *citta* is very fast and no one can experience a *citta* which lasts a billionth of a second or less; see, “[What is a Thought?](#)”.

5. When we look at an object, the “eye” generates visual consciousness (*cakkhu vinnana*): Comprehending what is seen is accomplished via a series of very fast thought processes. [There are billions of thoughts per second, so each citta or thought moment is billionth of a second; see, “The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma”](#). Let us see how the mind “sees” an object in a series of very fast “snapshots” alternating between the “eye” and the “mind”:

- The “eye” captures a snapshot of the object and the brain transfers that captured information to mind: that process takes 17 thought moments or *cittas* (let us abbreviate it as TM); this series of TM is called a “**sense input *citta vithi*” (or *pancadvara citta vithi*)**. Next the mind analyzes that “imprint” with three *citta vithi* that involve only the mind. These latter “**mind-only *citta vithi*” (*manodvara citta vithi*)** are shorter, around ten TM, and try to discern what the object is. It may first try to discern the color of the object for example.

- Then the “eye” takes another snapshot and transfers that “imprint” to the mind, which in turn receives it in a *pancadvara citta vithi* containing 17 TM, analyzes that in 3 more *manodvara citta vithi* containing about 10 TM, and makes better sense of the color. This “back and forth” process goes on until the object is determined.
- This process is slowed down only due to the time needed for the brain to put together the information captured by one of the five sense faculties (*pancadvara*), for example, the eyes. This time is of the order of 10 milliseconds, which I will discuss in the separate post. Thus there can only be about 100 or so “sense events” per second; see, [“What is a Thought?”](#).

6. Since these *citta vithi* run very fast, once the brain sends an “information packet” to the mind it is processed very quickly, within billionth of a second. Thus the process is slowed down only by the brain. **Still, everything about the object is grasped in a small fraction of a second.**

- Now, many of you may be thinking, “this looks like some far off theory made up by someone”. The Buddha said he experienced everything that he taught. Phenomena in this fast time scale are discernible only to a Buddha.
- Once the Buddha explained the key aspects to Ven. Sariputta, it was Ven. Sariputta and his group of *Bhikkhus* that developed the Abhidhamma, where all these details were worked out. It took generations of *bhikkhus* to develop the Abhidhamma to the final form that was recited at the Third *Sangayana* (Buddhist Council) and was written down in the Tipitaka in 29 BCE (we know that there were many *Arahants* before 100-200 CE; see the timeline in [“Theravada: Problems with Current Interpretations of Key Concepts”](#)). For us, the truth of these minute details become apparent as all observable phenomena are EXPLAINED using all three forms of Dhamma in the *Tipitaka: Sutta, Vinaya, and Abhidhamma*).

7. As all this information comes in, the mind recognizes the object; this is **sanna or perception**. Based on that recognition **feelings (vedana)** are generated (for example when we see a friend we generate a happy feeling; if it someone we don’t like, it is a unhappy feeling, etc).

- Once everything about the object is grasped, then if it is an “interesting object”, the mind may start its own “wheeling around” process: the “*pati + iccha sama + uppada*” or *paticca samuppada* process leading to the **accumulation of sankhara**: see, [“Paticca Samuppada – Introduction”](#), [“Nibbana – Is it Difficult to Understand?”](#), [“Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka”](#), and other related posts. All these tie up together, but one needs to be a bit patient since there are many inter-coupled concepts.

8. Thus experiencing a visual object in the above example generates all kinds of mental phenomena: *vedana*, *sanna*, *sankhara*, and during this whole process we have the *vinnana* or *citta* flowing. *Vinnana* is the momentary consciousness, a *citta*. In the above example, it alternates between visual consciousness (*cakkhu vinnana*) and the mind consciousness (*mano vinnana*).

- The baseline state of a *citta*, i.e., when the mind is not looking at an external object or thinking about it, is called “*bhavanga*”. Here we do not “feel” anything, for example when we are in deep sleep. The mind falls back this *bhavanga* state even in between *pancadvara citta vithi*.

9. Same kind of process happens with any of the five physical senses (the “back and forth switching” between the sense faculty and the mind). **When someone is just remembering a past event or planning something, those are exclusively mind processes (only *manodvara citta vithi* take place).**

Now let us look at some details on how the mind processes all the “signals” from the real world

where multiple “signals” come in.

- When we watch a movie, what happens is the projector projects about 30-50 static pictures per second on the screen; a movie is a series of static pictures. When the projects rate is above 30 frames a second or so, our eyes see a continuous movie, not individual frames. **Thus even though cittas run at billions per second, we do not “experience” them individually, not even close.**
- This fast rate of *citta vithis* (which, as we saw above run at about 100 citta vithis per second) also make it possible to perceive all six inputs from the outside world “simultaneously”; at least we experience them as “simultaneous”. For example, we can be watching a movie and enjoying some popcorn; so we see and hear the movie, and taste popcorn and feel the popcorn cup, and also may be thinking about something related to the scene on the screen; all at the “same time”.
- *Citta vithi* just alternate among the six sense inputs; it is possible only because there are hundreds of citta vithi per second. Since it happens so fast, we experience them all as “simultaneous”.
- Not only that, but the mind can ignore a multitude of “signals” that are of no interest to one’s own habits (“*gathi*”) or cravings (“*asavas*”). And those depend on the individual. Two friends could be walking on the street, and one (woman) stops abruptly and starts looking at a dress on a shop window. The other (man) looks at it, shrugs, and wants to move on; he would not have even noticed it.

10. As we saw, information to the mind comes via the brain. All five physical sense inputs (vision, hearing, smell, taste, touch) come through the brain. Thinking about concepts involves the brain too (those involve only the *manodvara citta vithi*), and that happens much faster compared to the processes associated with the five physical senses; we will discuss that later.

- When someone gets old, the brain starts functioning less efficiently; see, “[Manomaya Kaya and Out-of-Body Experience \(OBE\)](#)“. Or, the brain may get damaged due to a *kamma vipaka*; for example, getting Alzheimer’s disease is a *kamma vipaka*.
- As the body gets old, various other body parts also start functioning less efficiently and are also vulnerable for many *kamma vipaka* to come to fruition. *Kamma vipaka* are not deterministic; they come to bear fruit only when conditions become suitable (see, “[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka](#)“). Thus meditation and regular exercise help keep both the body and the mind (through an efficiently working brain) in good condition.

11. In any case, the mind goes to the “baseline or dormant state” called “*bhavanga*” even in between these *citta vithi*. When the mind is fairly inactive, say when someone is dozing off, the mind is mostly in the *bhavanga* state. When someone is unconscious or in deep sleep, it is in the *bhavanga* state for the whole duration. When seeing a dream, the mind is active.

- Even when *citta vithis* run at a fast rate of about 100 per second (say, while watching a movie or while playing a competitive sport), the mind drops to the *bhavanga* state while the brain is processing those “10 millisecond information packets”, as discussed above.
- The above discussion is all about receiving information from the outside world and then getting attached to “things” (“*tanha*”), generating *mano sankhara*, etc.

12. Based on that process, we may decide to take further action too, either verbally or bodily, thus

generating *vacī saṅkhara* and *kāya saṅkhara*: We may speak or do some physical activity. All those are done with the mind too, and each action done with thought process or *citta vithi*.

- This is why the Buddha said, “*mano pubbangama dhamma*, ,,,,”, i.e., “mind precedes everything that we do...”. **We cannot even lift a finger without generating a *citta vithi*, i.e., without the initiation by the mind.** The physical body, with the brain acting as a “sophisticated control center”, helps the mind to achieve whatever physical activity it wishes; see, “[Neuroscience says there is no Free Will? – That is a Misinterpretation!](#)”.

Further reading: “A Comprehensive Manual of Abhidhamma”, by Bhikkhu Bodhi (2010). This book has summarized *citta* and *cetasika* very well. But discussions on *paṭicca samuppāda* or *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* are not correct.

Next, “[The Law of Attraction, Habits \(Gathi\), and Cravings \(Asavas\)](#)“,

What is Consciousness?

1. Philosophers through the ages have struggled to figure out how consciousness arises in a human being. For “materialists” everything that makes a human being originates in the body, and they have been trying to explain consciousness in terms of something that comes out from the workings of the brain. For the “dualists” consciousness is totally distinct from the material body, and falls into the realm of theistic religion (related to a “soul”). According to the Buddha, consciousness, together with the body, are two of the five “aggregates” that a human being consists of. **And Consciousness does not arise from the body, but arises with the body at the conception.**

2. First of all, let us define consciousness.

- The Buddha said that being conscious is “being aware”.
- There are several definitions of consciousness in modern science, but the general consensus among the scientists and philosophers is that the state of being conscious is a condition of being aware of one’s surroundings as well as one’s own existence (or self-awareness).
- Therefore, we could say that science and Buddhism are attributing essentially the same meaning to the word “consciousness”. However, the Buddha’s definition of consciousness involves the mind, because the mind, in Buddha Dhamma, is necessarily involved in the six forms of awareness, whether it is visual, auditory, etc.

3. As to the origins of consciousness, we have three “theories”:

- Contemporary science is totally matter-based: the universe started with the “big-bang” which created all existing matter, and all living beings “evolved” from this inert matter, and thus consciousness also evolved by some (yet unknown) manner.
- The theistic religions believe, of course, that humans were created with built-in consciousness by an Almighty-God and animals were also created (sans consciousness).
- The Buddha’s is different from both above: It states that living beings (humans and animals) with built-in consciousness are different from inert matter, but they were not created. Rather, there is no traceable beginning to life; life always existed, and it will exist forever. Everything has a cause, so does life.

4. Consciousness is more than registration of a visual event, or an auditory event, for example.

- A camera captures an image of a cat, but it is not aware of the presence of the cat. On the other hand, a dog sees a cat and becomes aware of its presence. It not only sees the cat, but knows exactly where it is and try to catch it.
- Have you ever thought about how we can not only see things, but know exactly where they are? Without this ability, we can not even walk without bumping into things. How do we know that the person in front of us is only a few feet away? Consciousness is associated with a sentient being with a MIND. Science cannot yet explain this capability.

5. There is also the issue of the phenomenal quality of the conscious experience: qualia, subjective feelings, the redness of red, the warmth of warmth, etc. How do these arise in a being made up of inert atoms? There are basically two approaches to solve this problem in modern philosophy and science:

- One is that it arises as an emergent property in the neuronal activities in the brain. The other is the proposal of duality by Rene Descartes in the 17th century that persists to the present; see, for example, David Chalmers, “The Character of Consciousness”, (2010).
- A subset of these scientists believe that consciousness is associated with the microtubules in a cell (for example, see “The Emerging Physics of Consciousness” Ed. by Jack A. Tuszynski (2006) and John Smythies, “Brain and Consciousness: The Ghost in the Machines”, Journal of Scientific Exploration, vol. 23, No. 1, pp. 37-50, (2009)). Such theories are still in infancy and there is no consensus at this early stage.
- However, just because a cell responds that does not necessarily mean it has consciousness; the cell can expand and contract (chemical reactions) in response to environmental stimuli. In a way, something similar happens when a plant turns towards sunlight; of course, plant life is not sentient. Thus, just because an entity responds to outside influence does not necessarily mean the entity is “mentally aware” of the outside influence, i.e., that it is conscious.

6. Therefore, all these scientists and philosophers are long way off of solving the issue of the four mental aggregates of feelings, perceptions, volitional formations, and consciousness that make up the mental aspects of a human being. They are mainly focusing on consciousness and perception at this early stage, and even then are totally disregarding the intrinsic mental nature. It will be interesting to see what progress they can make by just taking a totally materialistic approach.

7. There is evidence, though, that some leading scientists are beginning to suspect that a complete “world view” cannot be achieved without taking into account the mental aspects. This trend started with the invention of quantum mechanics at the beginning of the 20th century, and is gaining traction slowly. Some interesting ideas are discussed in a number of books including “Wholeness and the Implicate Order” (by David Bohm, 1980), “Quantum Enigma” (by Bruce Rosenblum and Fred Kuttner, 2006), “Biocentrism” (by Robert Lanza, 2009).

8. However, consciousness (vinnana) discussed in this section does NOT take account the fact that consciousness of any living being (other than an Arahant) is contaminated by defilements. This our awareness is not pure; it is like looking through a foggy window. This is discussed in the “[Vinnana \(Consciousness\)](#)” and “[Expanding Consciousness by Purifying the Mind](#)”.

Next, “[What Happens in Other Dimensions?](#)“,

What Happens in Other Dimensions? (Consciousness Dependence on Number of Dimensions)

For an introduction to consciousness, see, "[What is Consciousness?](#)".

1. When we look deeply into the issue of consciousness, we come to realize the unimaginable possible varieties of life. Let us start with the issue of dimensionality. Humans live in a four dimensional world; in other words, humans are aware of four dimensions -three dimensions of space plus time.

- Even though we used to think time being different from spatial dimensions, with his Theory of General Relativity, Einstein demonstrated that space and time are interrelated. He showed that the force of gravity can be explained as perturbations in the space-time fabric due to mass.
- Can there be beings existing in higher dimensions that we are not aware of?

2. Of course, we cannot even begin to imagine more than four dimensions (or more than three spatial dimensions). However, it is easier to think of, and visualize, lower number of dimensions.

- Imagine a two-dimensional creature living on your kitchen table. An ant would be the closest real example, if we imagine that the ant cannot see above the table (a real two-dimensional creature would have only a length and width and no height). Now if we put a hand on the table, the 2D creature could see part of the projection of the hand on the table. Now if we take the hand off the table, as far as the 2D creature is concerned, the "hand" disappeared; it cannot "see" any part of the hand if it is off the table, and thus it has no "awareness" of that hand existing anywhere. It does not exist in its "2-D universe"
- For an amusing story of a 2D creature, see "Flatland: A Romance of Many Dimensions" by Edwin A. Abbott (2002). It was written in 1884 by Abbott, a mathematician.
- Here is a "fun video" from Dr Quantum which illustrates the idea:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?feature=player_embedded&v=B5yxZ5I-zsE

3. Therefore, the "awareness" of the 2D creature on the kitchen table surface is limited to its 2D world. It is not aware of anything outside the surface of the table (if it is a "2D world" the surface can extend to infinity and as far as our 2D creature is concerned it would not have "an end"). Furthermore, a 1-D world embedded in that 2D world would be a line on that surface. A 1-D creature in that 1-D world will not see anything that lies outside the line. Thus, the 2-D creatures can go in out of the 1-D world by crossing that line!

- It is clear that the consciousness of a 1-D creature is very limited, not necessarily by its mental capabilities, but just by the dimensions of the "world" that it is in. A 2-D creature has an expanded consciousness compared to the 1-D creature. We in the 3-D world have even farther expanded consciousness. (It must be kept in mind that one needs to incorporate the time dimension in all the above cases where only the space dimensionality was considered).

4. Therefore, if our world has more than three spatial dimensions, there may be other worlds that we are not aware of, since our consciousness is limited to the three spatial dimensions.

- Thus, there may be beings in different dimensions that we are not aware of. We may be able to see "projections" of them if there is some overlap in 1, 2, or 3 dimensions. If there is no

overlap at all, then we will not be able to see them at all, i.e., we will not be “conscious” of the presence of them.

- For example, in the low dimensionality case we considered above, if a 2-D creature crosses over the “1-D line world”, the 1-D creature will see a “dot” during the time when there is an overlap of the 2-D creature with the line. Yet, if the “1D world” lies above the table top, there is no overlap and the both creatures will not be conscious of the presence of each other’s worlds.

5. It is possible the “see” beings other than humans and animals by developing certain jhanic (abhinna) powers. There were many yogis even before the Buddha who could access and interact with such beings. One does not have to attain Nibbana to do that, and there are Arahants who have not developed such powers. In fact, the Buddha discouraged people from interacting with such beings, particularly with those in the lower realms.

- “Our world” is much more complex than what is grasped by our senses; see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”.
- And our lives do not end with this one; see, “[Evidence for Rebirth](#)”.
- Those two facts constitute the basis of the true nature of existence, and need to be thought about critically; one cannot comprehend the message of the Buddha until one at least has some idea about this “big picture”.

Next, “[Six Kinds of Consciousness in our 3-D World](#)”,

1. Thoughts (Citta), Consciousness (Vinnana), and Mind (Hadaya Vatthu) – Introduction

It will be beneficial to read this post even if one is not interested in learning *Abhidhamma*.

1. After writing a few posts in the *Abhidhamma* section, I realized that it is a good idea to write introductory posts on English meanings of some *Pali* key words related to the mind. **In the end, words do not matter and what matters is grasping of the concepts involved.** But conveying the concept correctly REQUIRES the use of right words.

- This is a bit of a problem because there are no words in English that truly conveys the meaning of some *Pali* key words when talking about the mind (like *mano* and *vinnana*). Thus what I need to do is to write several introductory posts describing such keywords (like what I did for *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*).
- More details will be given in the *Abhidhamma* section, but the posts that appear in this section provide just the basics.

2. A *Citta* (pronounced “chiththa”) is widely translated as a “thought”, *vinnana* as “consciousness” and *mano* as “mind”. **I am going to keep using the former two, but am going to use “*hadaya vatthu*” as the *Pali* word for mind.** Let us first discuss the reason for using this term for the mind.

- *Hadaya vatthu* is where *citta* (thoughts) arise; thus it is appropriate to call it the mind or even more appropriately “seat of the mind”. ***Hadaya vatthu* is the “link” between the “*mano loka*” (mind plane) and the “material plane” whether it is in *kama loka*, *rupa loka* or *arupa loka* (i.e., anywhere in the 31 realms).** Mind or the *hadaya vatthu* is a very fine *rupa* (matter); in technical terms, *hadaya vatthu* is formed at *patisandhi* as a *vatthu dasaka*.
- By the way this *hadaya vatthu* is the only trace of matter associated with a living being in the *arupa loka*. It is much smaller than an atom; only a form of “*suddhashtaka*” in the form of a “*dasaka*”.
- For example, if a *cuti-patisandhi* transition occurs from a cat to a human, then the “cat *hadaya vatthu*” dies and a “human *hadaya vatthu*” is formed and the very next *citta* arises in the “human *hadaya vatthu*” or the “human mind” in the “human *gandhabbaya*”; see, “[Cuti-Patsandhi Transition – Abhidhamma Description](#)”. With that in mind, let us discuss the ultimate “primary elements”.

3. In the absolute sense (*paramatta*), there are four entities: *citta*, *cetasika* (pronounced “chetasika”), *rupa* (pronounced “rüpa”), and *Nibbana*. The last one, *Nibbana*, does not belong to “this world” of 31 realms. Therefore, there are only *citta*, *cetasika*, and *rupa* that are in anything and everything in this world.

- *Citta* and *cetasika* are “*nama*” and all tangible things are made of “*rupa*”.
- There are 89 (or 121) types of *citta*; 52 kinds of *cetasika*, and 28 kinds of *rupa*. These are all listed in the “[Tables and Summaries](#)” section.

4. A *citta* (thought) does not arise by itself, but arises with a number of *cetasika* (mental factors). There are 7 *cetasika* that arise with ANY *citta*, and normally there are other *cetasika* that arise in addition to those seven. This is discussed in “[Cetasika \(Mental Factors\)](#)”.

- There are “good” and “bad” *cetasika*. The familiar ones are *lobha*, *dosa*, *moha* and *alobha*, *adosa*, *amoha*, but there are many others. These determine whether a given *citta* is a “good”

(*kusala*) citta or a “bad” (*akusala*) citta. There are only good or bad *cetasika* in a given *citta*; they do not mix.

5. Even though a *citta* arises and perishes within less than billionth of a second, it gets contaminated during its lifetime. Starting as a “pure *citta*” (“*pabasvara citta*” which is also called “*prabhasvara citta*” in Sanskrit) with those 7 universal *cetasika*, it gradually degrades by incorporating many other *cetasika* into a “contaminated *citta*” or *vinnana*. Without going into details, the nine steps are:

- *citta, mano, manasan, hadayan, pandaran, mana indriyan, manayatan, vinnana, vinnanakkhandhō*. But this happens during the life of the *citta* itself (in billionth of a second) according to the “*gathi*” that we have. **This is why we cannot control our initial thoughts; but as those initial thoughts turn to speech and bodily actions, we may have time to control them.**
- But we still use the term “*citta*” to denote the final outcome; in order to differentiate the one that the sequences started off, we call it a “pure *citta*” or a “*pabasvara citta*”.
- What we end up is basically what we call *vinnanakkhandha*, and all this happens within a billionth of a second. This “contamination process” cannot be controlled willfully at that early stage; it happens automatically based on one’s “*gathi*”. **The only thing we can do is to change our “*gathi*”.**

6. We can use the following analogy: If we start off with a glass of pure water that can be compared to a pure *citta* with just the 7 universal *cetasika*. If we add a bit of sugar (*mano*), salt (*manasan*) it gets a bit contaminated but we cannot see the contamination. Now we add a bit of brown sugar and we can see the water turning to brown; this is like the *hdayan* stage. The we keep adding chocolate, milk, etc, the water gets really contaminated; but it is still mostly water. A contaminated *citta* is like at the *vinnana* stage; it is a *citta* that is contaminated.

- The *citta* of an *Arahant* does not contaminate beyond the *masanan* stage (While in the “*Arahant phala samapatti*” enjoying *Nibbanic* bliss, an *Arahant* has the *pabasvara citta* or the pure *citta*). All others get to the *vinnana* stage, but of course the “level of contamination” is much lower even by the time one gets to the *Sotapanna* stage, because one has gotten rid of any “*gathi*” associated with the *apayas*.
- As we can see, it is not possible to control such a fast process by sheer will power; it is a matter of “cleansing the mind” progressively of the contaminants of greed, hate, and ignorance.
- Now we can see why “*mano*” cannot be the mind. “*Mano*” is just a bit “contaminated” *citta*. It gets progressively contaminated and by the time it comes to the “*vinnana*” step it has captured all relevant *cetasika* for that *arammana* or the “thought object”.
- **At the last step, a very profound thing happens.** The *manasikara cetasika* brings in to play all relevant past *vinnana* (which are fixed as “*nama gotta*”) as well as one’s “hopes and dreams” for the future that are relevant to the “event in question”. For example, if the thought occurs due to seeing a nice house, one may compare that house with houses like that one has seen before AND one’s “dream house” that one is hoping to build one day. Therefore, in the “final version”, a *citta* is a very complex entity that reflects not only the “nature of the object seen” but also one’s own likes/dislikes for it.
- This last stage of the *citta* or *Vinnana* is the “composite awareness” for that particular event, which also has one’s own likings, dislikings, etc for that particular event.

7. And we do not, and cannot, just perceive a single or even a few *vinnanakkandhō*; rather what we

“feel” as a “thought” is the sum of millions and billions of such *vinnanakkandhō*, and we still call that a “*citta*” or a “thought”; see, “[What is a Thought?](#)” and “[Citta and Cetasika – How Vinnana \(Consciousness\) Arises](#)”.

- We also alternatively call such sense experiences “*citta*”, “thoughts”, “consciousness”, and “*vinnana*”.
- Thus it is critical to understand that what we mean by *vinnana* in general is the sum total of billions of *cittas*; in *paticca samuppada*, at the “*avijja paccaya vinnana*“, *vinnana* means this sum total of billions of *cittas* or more accurately the sum total of billions of *vinnanakkhandhō*.

8. Now I would like to point out a few important conventions:

- It is important to remember that a thought can have many meanings even in English: <http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Thought>
- **Normally “*citta*” is used to denote a thought, and “*vinnana*” is used to denote the “awareness” associated with a thought.**
- And as you can imagine, such an “average of thoughts” may have many type of cognitions and underlying “awarenesses”, and we will talk about the different types of *vinnana* in the next post, “[Vinnana \(Consciousness\) can be of Many Different Types and Forms](#)”.

2. Vinnana (Consciousness) can be of Many Different Types and Forms

1. *Vinnana* is unique to sentient beings. Plants are alive but have no *vinnana*; they respond to the environments but are not capable of “thinking”. Sentient beings are aware that they are alive and just that basic awareness of “being alive” is not really a *vinnana*.

- This purest level of *vinnana* (the awareness of being alive) is called the “*citta*” (pronounced “chiththa”) stage.
- A *citta* arises with 7 concomitant “mental factors” (*cetasika*, pronounced “chetasika”), and this is described in “[Citta and Cetasika – How Vinnana \(Consciousness\) Arises](#)”. To emphasize, a pure *citta* arises with those universal *cetasika*; a *citta* always has those 7 *cetasika*.

However, the *citta* of a sentient being gets “contaminated” by other *cetasika* as soon as it arises. Within the lifetime of a *citta* (which is less than a billionth of a second), it progressively gets contaminated by “good” or “bad” *cetasika*, and this happens in nine stages! This was discussed in the previous post: “[Thoughts \(Citta\), Consciousness \(Vinnana\), and Mind \(Hadaya Vatthu\) – Introduction](#)”.

2. As discussed in “[Citta and Cetasika – How Vinnana \(Consciousness\) Arises](#)”, it is those additional *cetasika* that provide “color” to a *citta*: if a set of “good *cetasika*” arise with the *citta* it becomes a “good thought” or a “good *vinnana*”; if it is a set of “bad *cetasika*”, then the thought or the *vinnana* is bad (those *cetasika* do not mix). Also, there are neutral thoughts or neutral *vinnana* that are neither good nor bad.

- *Vinnana* can be experienced in many different ways; since it is hard to come up with different names for each case, they are all bundled together as *vinnana*. Words like *citta*, *vinnana*, *mano*, as well as *cakkhu vinnana*, *sota vinnana*, etc and *vipaka vinnana* are used in different contexts and that can be confusing to many regardless of whether their native language is English, Chinese, or even Sinhala, which is the closest language to Pali. But each term has its own “subtle identity” and as we discuss more, those subtle differences will become clear.

3. *Vinnana* is often translated as “consciousness” but *vinnana* can be used in many different contexts like “subconscious” or “layers of consciousness”.

- The same problem is encountered by those who speak *Sinhala*, because there the word “*sitha*” is used in many occasions to represent the Pali words *citta*, *mano*, and *vinnana*. Similarly, in Sinhala “*yati sitha*” is used to denote the subconscious.
- This “subconscious” in English (as introduced by Sigmund Freud) or “*yati sitha*” in Sinhala is not a separate *citta* (there can be only one *citta* at a time). But, each *citta* can have “layers of consciousness”; the *manasikara cetasika* plays a big role here.
- For example, at a given time we may have several “subconscious” *vinnana*: **we may have plans to buy a certain car, getting ready to go on a trip next week, in the process of building a house, etc; all these are in the subconscious, and in each *citta*.** If we see a car on the road that looks like the car we are interested in, the *vinnana* alerts you to it, and you take a good look at it.
- As the Buddha advised *bhikkhus*, what really matters is to convey the meaning. Just like in the

case of *paticca samuppada* or *tanha*, it is best to use the *Pali* words and comprehend their meanings; those key words convey deep meanings that may take several words or even sentences in any other language to get the idea across.

Types of Vinnana associated with Kamma and the Sense Doors

Vinnana is complex and can be presented in various different types and forms. We will start by looking at “two categories” of *vinnana*.

1. First, we can categorize them according to *kamma* (or *sankhara*) associated with the *vinnana*: ***Kamma vinnana*, *vipaka vinnana*, and *kiriya* (or *kriya*) *vinnana*.**

Let us describe in plain English what these terms mean.

- We can put *vinnana* into three categories in relation to *kamma*: Those *vinnana* that arise while doing a *kamma* (*sankhara*) is called a *kamma vinnana*. For example, when one steals something, one has an awareness of that; that is the “*vinnana* that one is stealing”.
- Then there are those that arise as *kamma vipaka*, and thus we do not have much control over them; they just happen to us and are called *avyakata vinnana* or *vipaka vinnana*. I like the term *vipaka vinnana* than *avyakata vinnana* because then it is easy to differentiate those two kinds. For example, when one is walking on the road and sees something valuable on the roadside; that is a *cakkhu vinnana* (seeing something) and also a *vipaka vinnana* (due to a *kamma vipaka*).
- The third type in this category are called *kiriya* (*kriya*) *vinnana*, and they are not connected to *kamma*. When we think, talk, or do something that does not involve *kammically* “good” or “bad”, those are done with *kiriya vinnana*. For example, when we think about the cleaning chores for the day, or ask someone what time it is, or walk to the kitchen to get a drink, all those are done with *kiriya vinnana*.

2. When we are travelling by a vehicle and are looking out of a window, we see many different things out there. But most of it we do not pay any attention, even though we are “aware” that we are seeing things. Those are *vipaka vinnana*, they are “presented to us”, but most of them may not interest us.

- Then all of a sudden we see something that “piques our interest”, say a nice house by the roadside. Then we fix our attention on that and even may keep looking at until it moves out of our range. That is a *vipaka vinnana* that triggered a “*gathi*” in us; it was of interest. And it could put us in a position to acquire more *kamma* by initiating a *kamma vinnana*.
- For example, if we really got interested in that house, we may start thinking about how nice would it be if we could build and live in a house like that. Now we are making *sankhara* (i.e., generating *kamma*) based on that “seeing event”. Thus such thoughts (or *vinnana*) that followed the initial *vipaka vinnana* of “seeing the house” are *kamma vinnana*.
- Our life experiences belong to basically one of those three categories.

3. All those *vinnana* may also be described in another totally different form; they can be differentiated into six categories, this time based on the sense door: thus we have *cakkhu vinnana* (vision consciousness), and *sota* (sound), *ghana* (smell), *jivha* (taste), *kaya* (touch), and *mano* (mind) *vinnana* (consciousnesses).

- In the previous example, the three types of *vinnana* were all initiated by *cakkhu vinnana*, a “seeing event or consciousness”. At the *kamma vinnana* stage, they became *mano vinnana*,

because those thoughts about acquiring a house originated in our minds.

- Then if another passenger touched us, we would turn and look at that person, because now we had a *kaya vinnana* (which was also a *vipaka vinnana*).
- If that touching turned out to be done by accident, we just let go of it, and it was just a neutral event of seeing someone (*kiriya vinnana*).
- However, if it was someone with whom we had a romantic relationship in the past, then we may start generating *kamma vinnana* (*mano vinnana*). In the same way, if it was someone with whom we have had a bad relationship, we may start generating another type of *kamma vinnana* (*mano vinnana*).
- Thus if you contemplate a bit on this, you can see that ALL our experiences can be put into either of those two “divisions”, i.e., we can analyze them to be in *vipaka vinnana*, *kamma vinnana*, and *kiriya vinnana* categories or the sense consciousness categories.

4. There are other types of *vinna* that we will talk about later, but for now let us discuss something that is really important to *paticca samuppada*.

- The *paticca samuppada* cycle starts with “*avijja paccaya sankhara*”, and “*sankhara paccaya vinnana*”. **This *vinna* is NOT a *vipaka vinnana* or a *kiriya vinnana*, but only a *kamma vinnana*.**
- When we see something, hear something, etc., those are things that HAPPEN to us. Thus there is no *avijja* (or ignorance) initiating that consciousness. There is no *paticca samuppada* cycle associated with such a consciousness (*vinna*).
- However, if we now decide to act on it (say, take another look at it because we like it), then we may be initiating a *sankhara* (*kamma*) event: now this new event initiates a (*pavutti*) *paticca samuppada* cycle with “*avijja paccaya sankhara*”, which leads to, “*sankhara paccaya vinnana*”, i.e., this *vinna* was initiated by a *sankhara*; thus it is a *kamma vinnana*.

5. Usually, what happens in our lives is that we are bombarded with sense inputs via all six senses. We tend to turn our attention to as many as we can because we are afraid that “we may miss out on something”. This is the root cause for the lack of “peace” in our minds, because we are constantly moving our attention among the six senses, going back and forth. If we have too many “likings” our mind will be pulled in all different directions trying to follow all those sense inputs.

- By avoiding busy environments (i.e., by going to a secluded place) we can reduce this effect. **But, we still cannot “turn off the sixth sense input”, i.e., the mind, unless we purify our minds.** This is the key to meditation. It is not possible to have a “peace of mind” if the mind is burdened with greed, hate, and ignorance (wrong vision or *micca ditthi*).

6. Thus an *Arahant* can have a peaceful mind even when in the busiest place. A *Sotapanna* can do that to a certain extent too.

- Even before any of the “*magga phala*” are attained, one can easily get to *samadhi* and then to *jhanas*, by gradually getting rid of the defilements associated with “wrong vision” just by learning Dhamma (mainly *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*).
- Then the number of different types of *vinna* going through the mind will be reduced (“Sounds like my neighbor’s car leaving, I wonder whether she is going to the mall?”, “I

wonder what (my enemy) is up to today?”, “I wish I could have a body like that!”, “How come I don’t have a nice house like that?”; these are all types of *vinnana* that we burden our minds with unnecessarily.

- And it is important to realize that it is not easy to just turn those off; they WILL BE turned off automatically when we purify our minds first by learning Dhamma (“What is the use of thinking about unnecessary things? There are better things to think about that provide lasting happiness”).

3. Vinnana, Thoughts, and the Subconscious

1. A thought (*citta*; pronounced “chiththa”) is on a specific thought object, say thinking about buying a car or going for a walk. There is only one *citta* at a time, but each lasts less than a billionth of a second and what we experience is millions of *cittas*. One can NEVER experience a single *citta*. Therefore, what we call a “thought” is the sum of millions of *cittas*.

- Each *citta* has many *cetasika* (mental factors) in it, including the all important *sanna*, *phassa*, *manasikara cetasika*. Then there are “good” and “bad” *cetasika* in a *citta* that describe the “mood” of the *citta*.
- When someone is angry most *cittas* **at that time** will have the hate (*patigha* and/or *dosa cetasika*). When the same person is feeding a hungry person his/her *cittas* **at that time** will have the benevolence and/or loving kindness *cetasikas*. For discussion on *cetasika*, see, “[Cetasika \(Mental Factors\)](#)”.

2. The *manasikara* and *sanna cetasika* is in each and every *citta*, and they carries all past memories, habits (*gathi*) and cravings (*asavas*) in them. The *gathi* and *asavas* may not be displayed in each *citta*; rather, they lie dormant, waiting for a “trigger” to come up. *Gathi* and *asavas* are carried from *citta* to *citta* (until they are removed), and new habits and cravings can be added at any time.

3. *Vinnana* is not a thought but it is in thoughts. *Vinnana* represents the overall experience of *cittas*, and is largely described by the *cetasika* in those *cittas*. Of course no one experience a *vinnana* due to a single *citta*; rather what one experiences is the average of millions or billions of *cittas*. A bunch or a heap is called *khandha* in Pali or Sinhala. Thus what we experience is a *vinnanakkhandha*, or the averaged value over a bunch or a heap of *cittas*.

- *Vinnana* is complex and multi-faceted. We may have *vinnana* of different types at the same time. Even though we are directly aware of one type of *vinnana* at a given time, there may be many types hiding beneath the surface. This is what Sigmund Freud called the “sub-conscious”.

4. A thought is what is occupying the mind at a given moment. When I am paying for my groceries, my thoughts are focused on that transaction. But there can be many types of *vinnana* working “in the background”. I may be building a house, studying for an exam, planning a trip, planning a birthday party for my child, etc. and all those “*vinnana*” are working in the background even though I am not thinking about any of them at the time I am paying for my groceries.

- However, any of those, and even some things that I had not been thinking about for a long time could be there further down in the “subconscious”. But there is no separate “subconscious” as such. All these different types of *vinnana* are there in a single thought (*citta*), and there is only one *citta* at a time; see, “[What is a Thought?](#)”. Then how is it possible for many types of *vinnana* to be lurking in the background?

5. It is those mental factors (*cetasika*) that makes it all possible. Several key such mental factors play key roles including memory (*manasikara*), contact (*phassa*), and perception (*sanna*). These key “universal *cetasika*” are in all the *citta* and embody all our desires as well as everything that has happened to us in them. Of course things happened recently are “closer to the top” compared to something that had happened a long time ago. And it also depends on how significant a certain event was. Some special events, even if they had happened a long time ago, are easier to remember.

- Memories are fixed; all our memories are kept intact as our *nama gotta*, in the mind plane; see,

“[Recent Evidence for Unbroken Memory Records \(HSAM\)](#)“. Of course what we can recall is limited by many factors including the state of the brain. As we get older the ability to recall gets weaker.

6. *Vinnana* is a sort of the “end result” of many memories as well as our *gathi* and *asavas*.

- The more one does something repeatedly, there starts a *vinnana* for that particular event or behavior. For example, when one starts smoking, a *vinnana* starts building, and the more one smokes, the stronger the *vinnana* gets. This is called “feeding the *vinnana*” by doing it again and again. In other words, habits are formed via repeatedly feeding the *vinnana* for that habit.
- When a certain *vinnana* is pleasing to the mind, that *vinnana* tries to get fed frequently. When someone has the habit of smoking the *vinnana* for that tries to deviate his/her attention to smoking at every possible opportunity. For example, if a smoker sees an advertisement for smoking, that “triggers” the liking or the *vinnana* for smoking that was in the subconscious.

7. But it works the same way for a *vinnana* that got initiated with a dislike also. For example, if someone did something really awful to you in the past, the hearing of his/her name will bring back that *vinnana*. This is why we get “attached” to things we like as well for things we dislike, and is the meaning of *tanha* (get bonded via greed greed or hate); see, “[Tanha – How We Attach Via Greed, Hate, and Ignorance](#)“.

8. Not all *vinnana* keep accumulating in the background. Those weaker ones, especially if don’t get fed, diminish and disappear. For example, suppose I had planned an overseas trip, and had been making preparations for it. The more preparations I make and more thoughts I have of the trip, those are “food for that *vinnana*”, and it grows. If I see a new article with that country’s name, I would immediately read the article. But suppose, a major war breaks out in that country before my trip; then I would cancel that trip right away. I will no longer be planning for the trip and my mind will “not be interested” in it anymore. Since that *vinnana* for “visiting that country” is not going to get fed anymore, it will be gone in a short time.

- We don’t even need to actually physically do the activity to “feed the *vinnana*” or make a habit stronger. There are studies that show that one could improve the game of basketball, for example, by just visualize practising, and getting the ball in mentally. These are called “*mano sancetana*”. Focusing the attention on a given task can be very powerful.

9. This is why *chanda*, *citta*, *viriya*, *vimansa* (*satara iddhipada* or the four bases of mental power) are critical for achieving goals. When one forms a strong liking (*chanda*) for a goal, one starts thinking often about it (*citta*), making effort (*viriya*), and constantly analyzing and trying to find related facts (*vimansa*) about how to accomplish that goal; see, “[The Four Bases of Mental Power \(Satara Iddhipada\)](#)“.

10. Our minds are very complex and powerful. And there are many different ways to analyze and examine concepts that are closely related. This is why there are so many different ways Buddha Dhamma can analyze a given situation and come to the same conclusion. It is all self-consistent.

- For example, suppose I thought about buying a silver car of model X several weeks ago; I have been thinking about it reading reviews and so on. I may be driving on the road just focusing on the road and driving with my thoughts and consciousness (*vinnana*) focused on driving. But now if I see a silver-colored car of model X, then immediately that will trigger my *vinnana* about “buying the car” and I may compare the silver-colored car with the car that I had in mind.

The mind likes to “feed the *vinnana*” that we have and the more it gets fed, it gets stronger. The more I think about the car, the stronger my intentions get about buying one.

11. There could be several such *vinnana* “in the background” or “in the subconscious” at any given time. For example, our *vinnana* keeps shifting as we keep moving from one task to another. But underneath, there may be several *vinnana* waiting for an opportunity to come up to the conscious level. Thus it can be “triggered” by a related event.

12. A built-up *vinnana* can form a habit; as the habit gets stronger, it can be carried over to the next life, possibly in two ways: a really strong habit could lead to a “*patisandhi vinnana*” at the dying moment and can lead to a corresponding “*bhava*”, and thus one could be born in the corresponding “*jati*”. For example, an extremely greedy person, may acquire a “*peta bhava*” at the dying moment and be born as a “*peta*” or a hungry ghost.

- On the other hand, if the same person had time left in the “human *bhava*” then that person will be feeding the “*pavutti vinnana*” of greed, and will always be looking out to acquire more “stuff” even at the expense of other people. Thus a “greedy *vinnana*” will grow as one keeps feeding that *vinnana*. He/she will never be satisfied even if what has been acquired is more than enough.

13. Thus *vinnana* is very complex; it is not just the “awareness”. It also has one’s “hopes and dreams” as well as “likes, dislikes, and habits”. It is a complex combination of the 52 *cetasikas*; of course not all *cetasikas* are involved in a given *citta* or in our thoughts.

Memory, Brain, Mind, Nama Loka, Kamma Bhava, Kamma Vipaka

There are many confusing terms like *citta* and *mano* which have been differently interpreted in different books. In order to clarify these concepts, I am writing a few posts in “Dhamma Concepts” section under “Mind and Consciousness” starting with: “[Thoughts \(Citta\), Consciousness \(Vinnana\), and Mind \(Hadaya Vatthu\) – Introduction](#)”.

1. Think about a past event that is still vividly there in your mind. You can visualize the whole “event” just like watching a movie; you can recall what those people looked like, what they said, etc.

- Suppose a 40-year old recalls an event where she was a 10-year old playing with her mother. She will recall the event just as it happened 30 years ago: she was young and her mother was 30 years old; it took place in her parents’ house which does not even exist now. But in the “playback” that exact same time sequence is played back with the 10-year old playing with her 30-year old mother in the same house that they lived in. It is not just a “summary” of what happened, rather an exact playback showing her young mother’s features at that time, what she said, etc.
- Recently, it has been reported that some individuals have an astounding capability to instantly recall past events (during this life) in vivid detail; see, “[Recent Evidence for Unbroken Memory Records \(HSAM\)](#)”.

2. Most scientists and philosophers believe that the memories are kept in the brain. Is this a realistic picture? They do not have any evidence to back this claim.

- How can all those details be “stored” in a biological membrane, ready to be retrieved at a moment’s notice? No one has explained a plausible mechanism yet.

3. Whatever we do with body, speech, and mind, a “record” (nama gotta) gets established (“bihiwelä pihitanava” in Sinhala) in the kamma bhava: In the word “bhava”, “bha” means “appear and gets established”; thus the act we did, i.e., kamma, gets recorded in the kamma bhava exactly the same way it happened.

- **Not only potent kamma, but ALL memories are stored intact in the nama loka.** Basically, the thought stream is recorded continuously like a movie recording and thus can be “played back”; see, “[What Reincarnates? – Concept of a Lifestream](#)”.
- [Thus while the “fruits of kamma” are embedded in kamma beeja \(seeds\) in the nama loka as kamma bhava, the movie like sequence is recorded in the nama loka as nama gotta.](#)
- Therefore, while kamma seeds in the kamma bhava can bring their results in the future, the *nama gotta* are just records without substance: see, “[Difference Between Dhamma and Sankhara \(Sankhata\)](#)”. Thus unlike anything else in this world (sankhara or sankata), *nama gotta* are PERMANENT.
- This is why the Buddha Gotama could recall the exact scene that happened billions of years ago, when he received the first confirmation (“niyata vivarana”) of his future Buddhahood by the Buddha Deepankara. At that time he was an ascetic by the name of Sumedha and the Buddha Gotama described the whole event that took place in detail; see, http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/D%C4%ABpankara_Buddha.
- In the same way, the kamma beeja stored in the nama loka are instantly activated when proper

conditions are realized; see, “[Anantara and Samanantara Paccaya](#)”. However, unlike *nama gotta*, kamma seeds fade away with time unless brought to bear fruit under right conditions.

4. Thus, memories (whatever the portion that is remembered) are played back in a “movie-like” manner, like in a dream. It is like a segment of a “movie recording”. It is not just a “gist” or a summary; we can recall the whole “sequence of events” like in a movie.

- This is why when someone describes an event by memory he/she always tends to tell the story sequentially: The person listening may not want to hear the whole story and could become impatient waiting for the narrator to “get to the point”, but for the narrator recalling the event, it is easier to go sequentially as the event is “played back” in his/her mind.

5. We cannot say where that memory is “located”, because they are not stored in the “physical space” or the “material world”; they are in the “nama loka” or “mental world”. In contrast what we experience through our five senses is the “rupa loka” or the “material world” that consists of 31 realms.

- This is also why scientists will not be able to describe the mind in terms of matter; see, “[The Double Slit Experiment – Correlation between Mind and Matter?](#)”. [Mind and matter belong to two distinct domains.](#)
- As I will clarify in detail in the future, this is related to the fact that there are six fundamental entities (six dhatus): patavi (hardness), apo (cohesiveness), tejo (vitality), vayo (motion), akasa (space), and vinnana (consciousness). The vinnana dhatu is associated with the “nama loka” and the other five dhatus are associated with the “rupa loka” or the “material world”. But we don’t need to worry about that right now. You will see other pieces falling into place in a “big jigsaw puzzle” as all these seemingly unrelated aspects come together to form a cohesive, complete picture of the “wider world”.
- Thus the way I interpret this is that there is a “mental world” or “nama loka” that is in a different dimension, yet instantly accessible to one’s mind.
- This could be related to the possibility of higher “curled up” dimensions that is being discussed in String Theory in physics; see, “[What Happens in Other Dimensions?](#)”.

6. We can normally access our own “information” from this life but some people, especially some young children, have the ability to recall *nama gotta* from past lives. Those who have abhinna powers can access such “information” or “nama gotta” of other people as well.

- We can retrieve this memory by thinking about it. There is a mechanism for that memory to be retrieved; the mind initiates the process, but the brain acts as the “receiver” for the incoming information.
- When we think about something that happened in the past, the mind sends mind rays out and they bounce off that specific target in the “nama loka” and the memory is reflected back. That retrieval process does not change the memory record, and the record stays intact. Thus one can go back and recall it again.
- When the retrieved information comes back, that signal is processed by the brain. Our whole body is prepared by the kamma seed that led to this human existence to limit/facilitate certain capabilities; thus what we can actually remember depends on the status of our brain. Our human bodies are generally setup (by kamma vipaka) to be able to retrieve only the strong memories

from the early days of this life and cannot access memories of previous lives. But few people can, and so can some children. Furthermore, if the relevant parts of the brain gets damaged, then the retrieval capability may be lost.

- Some beings in preta loka can remember past lives to impart more suffering on them. They can remember the bad deeds done by them that led to the birth in the preta world, and how long they will have to suffer to “pay back the debt”.

7. How much of that memory one actually recalls depends on two things: the health of the brain and the purity of the mind.

- If the brain is not functioning well, only bits and pieces of the memory will be actually experienced. When people get old, the brain’s efficiency goes down and thus memory will not work well. The brain is like a playback device and if it is defective, the display will be blurry or at worst no display will result.

8. Secondly, even a person with a healthy brain, may not be able to recall memories if the mind is “covered” by the five hindrances (panca nivarana); see, “[Key to Calming the Mind – The Five Hindrances](#)”.

- When there is kamachanda or vyapada, the mind is too much focused on those objects of thought (arammana). When there is thina middha, the mind is now “stuck” lazily at something (sleepy or just distracted), and will not retrieve the memory. With uddacca kukkucca, the mind is normally “intoxicated” with power, money, beauty etc is stuck at a “low level”. With vicikicca (which is due to micca ditthi or not knowing the true characteristics *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*), one engages in inappropriate acts and thus the mind is not “sharp”.
- Thus, any, some, or all of these five factors can affect the memory of even a person with a healthy brain. When we purify our minds of the panca nivarana, its ability to pinpoint a given “memory location” is improved.
- Furthermore, [when the mind is purified, that can make one’s brain to function better](#) by changing the conditions for better kamma vipaka to come to fruition; see, “[Anantara and Samanantara Paccaya](#)”. This “mind effect” on the brain and the body in general is being re-discovered by scientists; see, for example, “The Biology of Belief” by Bruce H. Lipton.

9. Someone with abhinna powers are said to be able to see portions of that “recorded movies” of other people too. This is why I believe that those memory retrieval process is associated with a “hidden dimension” that is easily accessible with a purified mind; see, “[Quantum Entanglement – We are all Connected](#)”.

10. Most scientists and philosophers believe that our memories are stored in our brains. There are key problems with that assumption:

- If that is the case, then the “state of the mind” should not be a factor in recalling a memory, because then it is like retrieving a sound track from a disc; the playback should be good as long as the “playing device” (i.e., the brain) is in good condition.
- It is astounding how much one can recall from the memory. And it comes out like a video clip; we can visualize and even recall the conversations that took place a long time ago in case of poignant memories. Can all those details be “stored” in a biological membrane?
- Even if it is possible to encode all that information (exact features of the 10-year old child and

her 30-year old mother, what they spoke at that time in the same tone, etc. in the hypothetical example of #1 above), how can it be recalled instantaneously?

11. Here is an article which discusses these unresolved scientific issues: <http://viewzone.com/memorytest1.html>

- Here is a good site if you need to dig in deeper: http://www.human-memory.net/processes_storage.html

Sorting out Some Key Pali Terms (Tanha, Lobha, Dosa, Moha, etc)

[Kama Tanha, Bhava Tanha, Vibhava Tanha](#)

[Lobha, Raga and Kamachanda, Kamaraga](#)

[Lobha,Dosa, Moha Versus Raga, Patigha, Avijja](#)

Kama Tanha, Bhava Tanha, Vibhava Tanha

1. As we discussed in a previous post, *tanha* (“*thán*” + “*hă*”, where “*thán*” rhymes like in “thatch” and means “a place; “*hă*” means getting attached or fused) is “getting attached to things in this world” via greed, hate, and ignorance; see, “[Tanha – How we Attach via Greed, Hate, and Ignorance](#)“. Note that “*tan*” in *tanha* is pronounced like in “thunder”.

2. We attach to things because of the ignorance that they can provide lasting happiness; this attachment first manifests in greed. But when someone or something gets in the way, we generate hate; now we attach to another thing via hate.

- For example, a teenager wants to get a car and generates greed; he is bound to that idea of getting a car. If a parent refuses, then he may generate anger and even hate towards the parent. Now he is bound in two places.

3. In ***kama loka***, where all five physical sense faculties are present. Getting attach to anything that is contacted via the five senses is *kama tanha*. However, attachment arising from the desire to enjoy taste, smell, and body touch are exclusively restricted to the *kama loka*.

- In the *rupa lokas*, *kama tanha* arise only due to eye and ear. Thus an *Anagami*, who will be born in a *rupa loka* has *rupa tanha*, *sadda tanha* because he/she may like to see a Buddha statue or listen to a discourse.

4. ***Bhava tanha*** arises from attachment to “any existence”. Thus *bhava tanha* is present in *kama loka*, *rupa loka*, and *arupa loka*, i.e., all 31 realms.

- Even in the *kama loka* there may be people who do not enjoy the “*kāma*” or sense pleasures; but they still want to live a quiet, peaceful life. They mostly have *bhava tanha*. They may like to be in a secluded place cultivating *jhana*; that is their desired “*bhava*”. If they develop *jhanas*, they will be born in *rupa loka* or *arupa loka* due to their new “*gathi*”.
- There are other subtle forms of “*bhava*” too. Some like to become famous, earn a title, to hold a certain office or a responsibility, etc. These are not associated with sensual pleasures and are due to *bhava tanha*.

5. ***Vibhava tanha*** arises from the wrong view of materialism (*ucceda ditthi* in the time of the Buddha; *ucceda* pronounced “*uchchêda*”). [One believes that at death one ceases to exist, i.e., one believes that the mind is a byproduct of the body \(brain\), and thus when the body dies, that is the end of story.](#) Thus one believes that one needs to just enjoy the pleasures of this life before dying. They obviously have *kama tanha* as well.

- It is easy to have *vibhava tanha*, especially when one has not heard about the Buddha’s message about a wider and more complex world with 31 realms and a rebirth process. Since our normal human senses cannot access such “hidden” aspects of this world, one just believes what one sees. It takes an effort to verify that indeed the wider world view is needed to EXPLAIN all that we can experience; see, “[Vagaries of Life and the Way to Seek “Good Rebirths”](#)”.
- Many immoral acts are done with *ucceda ditthi* (or materialism or nihilism) because one believes that everything in this world is for one’s enjoyment. Even though it is obvious that animals cry with pain when being killed, that is not of any consequences in their minds. The logic is that If this birth is the one and the last, there is no possibility that one could face the same fate in the future.

- The fact that there is a difference between cutting vegetables and killing animals for food should be given some contemplation. Obviously, the animal is feeling the pain. Then how is an animal different from us? They are different only at the intellectual level; but we have a higher intellectual level only because we have been fortunate to get this temporary human life of 100 years or so, because of a previous good deed. In the next birth we could be born an animal; it depends on the types of kamma that we have accumulated. It takes time to go through such an analysis, and to convince oneself of the ability of the Buddha Dhamma to provide “good explanations”, and many just do not take the needed time to do such an investigation.

6. Finally, let us see how each type of *tanha* is removed as one progresses on the Path.

- When one just starts on the Path and makes an effort to understand the message of the Buddha, one starts losing all three types of *tanha* gradually. With time one can feel that change and the resulting niramisa sukha that comes from it. It may take a few days, months, or even a year to feel a significant change depending on the individual.
- *Vibhava tanha* is removed at *Sotapanna* stage, since only someone with *micca ditthi* can have *vibhava tanha*. It is important to realize that one has *vibhava tanha* if one does not believe in the rebirth process.
- *Kama tanha* leads to various levels of attachment that are removed step-by-step in the four stages of Nibbana. *Kamachanda* is removed at the *Sotapanna* stage; *Kama raga* is reduced at the *Sakadagami* stage and is removed at the *Anagami* stage. This process is discussed in the next post, “[Lobha, Raga and Kamachanda, Kamaraga](#)”.
- As long as one is reborn anywhere in the 31 realms, one has *bhava tanha*. Thus, *bhava tanha* is completely eliminated only at the Arahant stage.

Next, “[Lobha, Raga and Kamachanda, Kamaraga](#)”,

Lobha, Raga and Kamachanda, Kamaraga

There are various names for greed in Pali. Each has a different meaning and the differences are significant.

1. Let us look at the the two terms “*lobha*” and “*raga*” first.

Lobha is the more stronger term of the two. In a deep sense, *lobha* (“*lo*” + “*bha*” where “*lo*” is for the *lokaya* or world and “*bha*” is for “*bihiveema*” (arise or establish) is the main reason how the material world is created and sustained with greed.

Lobha is the extreme form of greed, what is called a “*pāpa kamma*”, that makes one destined to the *apayas*. When someone has *lobha*, it is exhibited in two ways:

1. one wishes that all the “riches” should come to oneself and not to others (one may be already “rich”, but wants more for oneself).
2. one is not willingly to share some of the “excess” one has with others, and does not share with even the family.

It is hard to quantify these, but the idea is that “*lobha*” is manifestation of the overbearing attachment one has to worldly things.

- It must be noted that *lobha* is one of 52 *cetasika* (mental factors). It is reduced in stages: *kamachanda* removed at the Sotapanna stage, *kama raga* removed at the Anagami stage, and *rupa raga* and *arupa raga* removed only at the Arahant stage.

3. ***Raga*** (“*rā*” means wander around, “*ga*” means give priority) means one believes there is pleasures to be had in staying in *sansara* (rebirth process), and thus one likes to stay around and enjoy the worldly pleasures.

- When one is born rich (or acquires wealth), and enjoys life with sense pleasures, that is not *lobha*, that is just *raga*. Such a person is not doing harm to the others; but such a person COULD have *lobha* too. It is said that no matter how much one has, one wants more.
- When one has *lobha*, one could do things highly immoral acts (even if one is rich). If one is willing to kill, steal, lie, etc. to gain something one desires, then that is when one could acquire “*apayagami*” *kamma*. One does not necessarily has to carry out these acts or speech; just thinking about it and making *abhisankhara* (planning or even enjoying such thoughts) itself is *lobha*. Thus even the poorest person can have *lobha*.
- Even the Devas in deva loka have *raga*; they like to enjoy sense pleasures, but they don’t crave for what others have; they do not have *lobha*.

4. Then there is *kamachanda* and *kama raga*, another set of decreasing levels (in that order) of attachment to *kama loka*. *Kāma* means attachment to the sense pleasure available in the *kama loka*, i.e., those available for the gratification of the five senses.

- ***Kamachanda*** is the highest level of that attachment. Here one is willing to do abhorrent acts (killing, raping, etc) to satisfy one’s desires. When one has developed *kama* to the *kamachanda* level, one becomes unaware of the bad consequences of one’s actions; it is said that “one loses one’s mind” (*kāmachanda* = “*kāma*” + “*ichcha*” + “*anda*” where “*ichcha*” is liking and “*anda*” is becomes blind; thus *kamachanda* means blinded by attachment to sense pleasures).

- Thus, one needs to be mindful not to let one's kama raga develop into *kamachanda*, which is one of the five hindrances that "cover the mind".

5. When one has **kama raga**, one likes to enjoy sense pleasures, but not at the expense of others. Thus when husband and wife engage in sexual activity, that is due to *kama raga*.

- Inappropriate sexual activity (affairs outside marriage and rape) are done with *kamachanda*, i.e., *when one becomes blind with kama*.

6. It is also helpful to see how these different levels of greed are removed at various stages of Nibbana. This will give a better sense of differentiation.

- A sotapanna has permanently removed *kamachanda* and also does not have the worst level of *lobha*. Thus he/she will not engage in "*apayagami*" acts to gain sense pleasures. A Sotapanna has not given up *kama raga*.
- A Sakadagami also has *kama raga to a lesser extent*; this is why he could be reborn in the *kamaloka* for one more time.
- An Anagami has removed *kama raga*; he will not return to any of the 11 eleven kama loka realms, including the human and deva realms, and will be reborn in the *suddavasa* in the rupa loka, and will attain Nibbana there.

7. Some may have given up the desire to enjoy pleasures in *kama loka*, but like the jhanic pleasures. Thus they have **rupa raga** and **arupa raga** (or the liking to wander about in *rupa loka* and *arupa loka*). *Rupa raga* and *arupa raga* are removed only at the Arahant stage.

Next, "[Lobha,Dosa, Moha Versus Raga, Patigha, Avijja](#)",

Lobha, Dosa, Moha versus Raga, Patigha, Avijja

1. It was explained in the previous post that *lobha* is extreme greed. One is willing to do any immoral act to get what one wants. One can become blind by greed, i.e. *kamachanda* can arise.
 - *Dosa* (or *dvesha*) is the hate that arises due to *lobha* (*dvesha* comes from “*devana*” + “*vesha*” or second manifestation of *lobha*), especially when someone else is in the way of getting what wants.
 - And acts with *lobha* and *dosa* are done with *moha*. *Moha* comes from “*muva*” + “*hā*” which symbolizes a vessel with its mouth closed; thus one cannot see what is inside. In the same way, one acts with *moha* because one is totally unaware that such immoral acts will have very bad consequences; one’s mind is totally dark.
 - Any person who has not attained the *Sotapanna* stage are not free from *lobha*, *dosa*, *moha*. That does mean they all have *lobha*, *dosa*, *moha* all the time. Some people may go through their whole lifetime without generating any *dosa*, for example. But the POTENTIAL for them to arise is there.
2. Acts done with *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha* are called *pāpa kamma*, strong versions of *akusala kamma*. Such *pāpa kamma* make one eligible to be born in the lower four worlds.
 - Specifically, acts done with *dosa* are the worst with *niraya* (hell) as the possible destination, and *lobha* is cause for rebirth in the *preta* (*peta*) *loka* of hungry ghosts. Acts done with both *lobha* and *dosa* have all three “*san*” (since *moha* is always there), and thus lead to rebirth in the animal or “*thirisan*” (“*thiri*”+“*san*” or all three “*san*”) realm.
 - As one engages in moral actions and gets rid of one’s tendency (“*gathi*”) to do immoral actions, one starts “cooling down” and one’s likelihood of being born in the lower four realms diminish.
3. However, *Lobha*, *dosa*, *moha* are **permanently reduced** from one’s mind to *raga*, *patigha*, *avijja* levels only when one attains the ***Sotapanna*** stage.
 - Of course one is now able to “see” the real nature of the world (*anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*) to some extent (one is not totally blind) and thus *moha* is reduced to *avijja* level.
 - As explained in the previous post, *raga* is the craving for sense pleasures. Of course there are different levels here too, but in general this level of greed makes one eligible only for birth in the human and *deva* worlds. *Patigha* is a lower level of hate, more like “friction”. One may get annoyed when someone and even say something in return, but will never do anything “really bad” that makes one eligible to be born in the lower four realms.
4. At the next level of *Nibbana* of the ***Sakadagami*** level, *kama raga* and *patigha* are both reduced to the extent that one will not be reborn in the human level, but only *deva* or higher realms. *Kama raga* is the *raga* or craving for sense pleasures in the *kamaloka*.
 - Above the human realm (in *deva* and *brahma* realms) beings have very fine bodies that are not subjected to decay or diseases. Thus they never get sick or visibly old (but of course death is inevitable to anyone anywhere in the 31 realms). This is why a *Sakadagami* is said to be healthy forever (after the human life).

5. When one attains the **Anagami** stage, both *kama raga* and *patigha* are eliminated. Thus one will not even be offended by harsh words/acts and will not retaliate. An *Anagami* will never be born anywhere in the *kamaloka* including the *deva* worlds; they are reborn only in *brahma* realms.

- While a *Sotapanna* may still have some tendency to give priority to sense pleasures at certain times, all such tendencies are reduced at the *Sakadagami* stage, and removed at the *Anagami* stage.

6. For an *Anagami*, what is left of *raga* is only *rupa raga* and *arupa raga*, i.e., desire for *jhanic* pleasures in the *rupa* and *arupa* loka (the four *rupa jhanas* and four *arupa jhanas*). And he/she still has *avijja* left to a certain extent together with *māna* (some level of pride) and *uddacca* (some level of sense of superiority).

- All these are eliminated at the *Arahant* stage. An **Arahant** is free from even a trace of defilements and will never be reborn in “this world” of *kama loka*, *rupa loka*, or *arupa loka* (anywhere in the 31 realms).
- This is why it is not productive to meditate trying to get rid of the sense of “self” before the *Sotapanna* stage. Many people incorrectly interpret *anatta* as “no self”. But the feeling of “me” is removed only at the *Arahant* stage, after the *Anagami* stage. As long as *mana* and *uddacca* are there, the sense of “me” is still there.

7. What needs to be done to get to the *Sotapanna* stage is to realize the true meaning of *anicca* (that there is no point in hurting others to achieve temporary sense pleasures), and that until one has that mindset one is truly helpless in this round of rebirths (*anatta*).

- Until one realizes that one is prone to act with extreme greed (**lobha**) and can act like a hungry ghost (*peta*), then one has not been released from such a birth.
- Until one grasps the true meaning of *anicca*, one could still act with extreme hate (*dosa*) in the heat of the moment, and that can lead to a rebirth in the *niraya* (hell).
- Until one realizes the unfruitfulness of depending on others by cheating/stealing (without trying to make an honest living for oneself), one is not released from the *asura* realm.
- Until one gets rid of “animal *gathi*” such as having sex with young children like dogs or being able to kill others for one’s food or pleasure, etc., (i.e., both *lobha* and **dosa**) one is not released from the animal realm.
- Those are the four lower realms. Thus one will be truly helpless (*anatta*) unless one removes such bad habits (“*gathi*”). Thus until then *dukkha* (suffering) is going to be there in the long-term, if not in this lifetime. Those are the true meanings of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.

The Five Aggregates (Pancakkhandha)

[Five Aggregates – Introduction](#)

“[Sanna \(Perception\)](#)“

“[Vedana \(Feelings\)](#)“

“[Vedana \(Feelings\) Arise in Two Ways](#)“

Sankhara is discussed at, “[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka](#)“.

“[Vinnana \(Consciousness\)](#)“

“[Rupa \(Material Form \)](#)“

Next, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta](#)“,

Five Aggregates – Introduction

The five aggregates (*pancakkhandha*; **pronounced panchakkandhā**) are: *rupa* (material aspects), *sanna* (perception), *vedana* (feelings), *sankhara* (immoral/unfruitful activities; see, “[Avijja paccaya Sankhara](#)”), and *vinna* (consciousness). *Panca* is five and *khandha* is a heap (in Sinhala, a “*khandha*” is a hill); thus *pancakkhandha* is “five heaps”. Sometime it is called *pancaskhandha*, but that is the Sanskrit name and does not give the clear meaning.

1. Everything “in this world” is included in the five aggregates (*pancakkhandha*). That is everything that anyone CAN EVER experience. *Pancakkhandha* includes all material aspects and all mental possibilities. This will become clear as we discuss different components.

2. *Pancaupadanakkhandha* is a VERY SMALL subset of *pancakkhandha*. *Pancaupadanakkhandha* includes only those things and concepts in this world that a given person interacts with or has attachments for. This can be visualized easily as follows:

- If *pancakkhandha* is a huge wall, a fly landing on the wall makes contact or grasps that wall only with its six legs. Thus for that fly, what it touches with its tiny six feet (the contact area is minuscule) can be compared to *pancaupadanakkhandha*; the *pancakkhandha* is the whole huge wall.
- Just like the fly is holding onto the wall with its six legs, we are grasping (*upadana*) this world with our six senses: we see, hear, smell, taste, touch, and think about only a minuscule amount of things the world offers.
- Therefore, we are bound to “this huge world” only via a very few things, and that is all we have “give up” or discard in order to attain Nibbana. Please contemplate on this and come back and read this post once-in-a-while. It will sink in as one’s knowledge of Dhamma grows.

3. Each of the five components of *pancakkhandha* can be categorized in eleven ways: past, present, future, near, far, coarse, fine, internal, external, liked (*paneeta*), disliked (*appaneeta*). This is what I mean when I say it is unimaginably huge.

- For example, one component is the *rupa skandha* (collection of material forms). It is divided into two parts: internal (*ajjhaticca*) and external (*bahira*). Internal *rupa* are the five physical senses: eye (*cakkhu*), ear (*sota*), nose (*ghana*), tongue (*jivha*), and body (*kaya*). These are actually not the physical eye, ear, etc that we see, but very fine *rupa*.
- All other material “things” or *rupas* “in this world” belongs to the external *rupa* category: other people, houses, planets, galaxies, etc, i.e., absolutely everything else.
- And we need to remember that *rupa* include ALL material phenomena: *vanna* (pictures or things we customarily call “*rupa*”), *sadda* (sounds), *gandha* (smells), *rasa* (taste), and *pottabba* (touch).

4. We experience this outside world by seeing those objects, hearing sounds, smelling odors, tasting foods, touching objects, and also thinking about not only “physical things”, but also concepts. All that experience is included in the other four aggregates: we sense them (*sanna* or perception), we feel them (*vedana* or feelings), we accumulate *abhisankhara* (*kamma*) by attaching/rejecting them, and we “know about them” (*vinna* or consciousness).

- Thus it is clear that each of us experiences or grasps only a tiny fraction of *pancakkhandha*.

5. That is a brief summary of ***pancaupadanakkandha***, the five aggregates that is clung to. If we do not generate *sankhara*, then it becomes just ***pancakkhandha***.

- Please read the above carefully, until you see the difference between *pancakkhandha* and *pancaupadanakkhandha*. When an Arahant experiences any external object he/she does not generate any *abhisankhara*. Thus an Arahant does not have a *pancaupadanakkhandha*.
- Normally we just say *sankhara* in the place of *abhisankhara*. But it is only *abhisankhara* that lead to rebirth. Thus an Arahant does *sankhara*, but not *abhisankhara*. This is discussed in the posts on “san” and “sankhara”. Thus in the five aggregates, by *sankharakkhandha* we really mean *abhisankharakkhandha*.
- But an ordinary person generates greedy, hateful, or ignorant thoughts and generates *(abhi)sankhara* when experiencing external objects, and thus has *pancaupadanakkandha*.
- Thus, the difference between *pancakkhandha* and *pancaupadanakkandha* depends on the *(abhi)sankharakkandha*.
- Also, we see that each person has his/her own *pancaupadanakkandha*, because the *sanna*, *vedana*, *sankhara*, and *vinnana* (as well as the external and internal *rupa*) are going to be unique that person.

Sanna (Perception)

Sanna is, at the very fundamental level, the recognition of an external stimulus. But it is more than that. We not only recognize that a given object is, say, a dog. But some people may be able to categorize it as a bull dog. Thus sanna about a particular object depends on the person.

Same is true for other four senses. When we hear a sound, we recognize what it is, say a bird singing a song. Some may be able to say which bird it is, some may not be. Any smell, taste, or touch works the same way. Without sanna we cannot identify things around us, and also cannot communicate with each other meaningfully.

One of the 31 realms of existence is the “Asanna realm”. There, the beings have no perception. Thus in principle, those beings are without any awareness. Nothing registers in the mind. If anyone has attained the 7th jhana, the “Nevasanna Nasanna”, then that person knows what it is like to born in the Asanna realm.

Next, “[Vedana \(Feelings\)](#)“,

Vedana (Feelings)

Vedana (feelings) are **three kinds** : Sukha vedana (pleasant or joyful feeling), dukha vedana (unpleasant or painful feeling), and adukkhamā asukha (without being painful or joyful, just neutral).

It must be pointed out that upekkhā is not a feeling; it is a state of the mind (of neutrality, equanimity), and needs to be cultivated (one of the Saptha Bojjanga or Seven Factors of Enlightenment). Some translate upekkhā incorrectly as a neutral feeling.

Two Ways Vedana (Feelings) Can Arise

Vedana (feelings) *can arise in two ways*:

1. As a consequence of a previous kamma (i.e., a kamma vipaka). The kamma or sankhara could have been done many lives ago.
2. As a direct consequence of a sankhara (one could say an ongoing action or a way of thinking).

Vedana Arising from Kamma Vipaka

Kamma vipaka can happen to everyone, including Arahants. While everyone can avoid some kamma vipaka, there are others that are too strong to be able to avoid.

For example, the Buddha himself had physical ailments later in his life as kamma vipaka. Moggallāna Thero was beaten to death because of a bad kamma that he committed many lives before.

However, kamma vipaka are not certain to happen. Some can be reduced in power (we will discuss this under Vinaya and Metta Bhavana), all are reduced in power with time and some eventually die out if they did not get a chance to come to fruition within 91 Maha kalpas. Many can be avoided by not providing conditions for them to arise (see, the discussion on kamma beeja in , “[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka](#)”).

Vedana Arising from Sankhara

These are the vedanas that Arahants do not feel. Since they do not commit any sankhara, an Arahant avoids any kind of feeling arising from sankharas. The easiest way to explain this kind of vedanas is to give some examples:

1. Three people are walking down the street. One has ultra-right political bias (A), the second has ultra-left bias (B), and the third is an Arahant who does not have special feelings for anyone (C). They all see a famous politician hated by the political right coming their way. It is a given that the sight of the politician causes A to have displeasure and B to have a pleasurable feeling. On the other hand, the sight does not cause the Arahant to generate any pleasure or displeasure. Even though all three see the same person, they generate different types of feelings. *It is important to realize that the feelings were created by A and B by themselves.*
2. Two friends go looking for treasure and find a gem. They are both overjoyed. It looks quite valuable and one person kills the other so that he can get all the money. Yet when he tries to sell the “gem”, he finds out that it was not that valuable. His joy turns to sorrow in an instant. *Nothing had changed in the object, the piece of stone. It was the same piece of colored rock. What has changed was the perception of it (sanna).*
3. A loving couple had lived for many years without any problems and were happy to be together. However, the husband slaps his wife during an argument. The physical pain from the slap itself

did not last more than a few minutes. But for how long the wife would suffer mentally? Even the husband, who did not feel any physical pain, would suffer for days if he really loved his wife. *In both cases, the real pain was associated with the attachment to each other. The wife could have dropped something on her foot and would have suffered about the same amount of physical pain. But she would not have had any lingering mental pain associated with that.*

4. When the Buddha described dukha in the Dhammacakka Pavattana Sutta, it went like, “jathi pi dukkha, jara pi dukkha, maranan pi dukkha.....”. Most people translate this incorrectly as, “birth is suffering, getting old is suffering, dying is suffering,...”. However, even though the word “pi” is used for the verse, it needs to be taken either as “pi” (liked) or “api” (not liked) depending on the case. Thus, “jathi pi dukkha” in the verse means “birth of something that is not liked by one is suffering for one self”. “Jara pi dukkha” means, “decay of something that is liked is suffering”, and “maranan pi dukkha” means, “Death of a liked is suffering”. The reverse is true too: “decay of something that is hated brings happiness” and “death of a hated person brings happiness”. *You can think of any example and this is ALWAYS true. Many people were happy to hear about the death of Bin Laden, except his people who became sad.*
5. The Buddha further clarified this in the next verse: “piyehi vippayogo dukkho, appiyehi sampayogo dukkho” means “it brings sorrow when a loved one has to depart, and it also brings sorrow to be with a hated person”.

Thus all these feelings arise due to greed (craving, liking) or hate (dislike); all these are due to sankhara. The feelings reside INSIDE oneself. It does not come from outside. We use external things to CAUSE happiness or suffering by our own volition.

Next, “[Vinnana \(Consciousness\)](#)“,

Vedana (Feelings) Arise in Two Ways

Vedana (feelings) are **three kinds** : *Sukha vedana* (pleasant or joyful feeling), *dukha vedana* (unpleasant or painful feeling), and *adhukkama asukha* (without being painful or joyful, just neutral).

It must be pointed out that upekkha is not a feeling; it is a state of the mind, and needs to be cultivated (one of the Saptha Bojjanga or Seven Factors of Enlightenment). But most times upekkha is used to indicate a neutral feeling.

Vedana (feelings) can arise in two ways:

1. As a consequence of a previous *kamma* (i.e., a *kamma vipaka*). The *kamma* or *sankhara* could have been done many lives ago.
2. As a direct consequence of a making *sankhara* (because of *tanha* at the present time).

Vedana Arising from Kamma Vipaka

- *Kamma vipaka* can happen to everyone, including *Arahants*. While everyone can avoid some *kamma vipaka*, there are others that are too strong to be able to avoid.
- For example, the Buddha himself had physical ailments later in his life as *kamma vipaka*. Moggallana Thero was beaten to death because of a bad *kamma* that he committed many lives before.
- However, *kamma vipaka* are not certain to happen. Some can be reduced in power (see, [“Kamma, Debt, and Meditation”](#)); all are reduced in power with time and some eventually die out if they do not get a chance to come to fruition within 91 *Maha kalpas*. Many can be avoided by not providing conditions for them to arise, i.e., by acting with *yoniso manasikara* or just common sense. For example, going out at night in a bad neighborhood is providing fertile ground for past bad *kamma vipaka* to arise: We all have done innumerable *kamma* (both good and bad) in past lives; if we act with common sense we can suppress bad *kamma vipaka* and make conditions for good *vipaka* to arise.

Also see the discussion on *kamma beeja* in , [“Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka”](#).

We will discuss how this type of *vedana* due to *vipaka* (from deeds in the past) arise due to the *kusala-mula* and *akusala-mula* PS cycles in following posts. First let us look at the “suffering we are initiating at present moment via *sankhara*”.

Vedana Arising from Sankhara (“San phassa ja vedana” or “Samphassa ja vedana”)

We described the PS mechanism that generates this type of *vedana* in the previous post. The *vedana* occurs due to attachment via greed or hate, at that moment; see, [“Tanha – How we Attach via Greed, Hate, and Ignorance”](#).

These are the *vedana* (feelings) that *Arahants* do not feel. Since they do not commit any (*abhi*)*sankhara*, an *Arahant* avoids any kind of feeling arising from *sankharas*. The easiest way to explain this kind of *vedana* is to give some examples:

1. Three people are walking down the street. One has ultra-right political bias (A), the second has ultra-left bias (B), and the third is an *Arahant* who does not have special feelings for anyone (C). They all see a famous politician hated by the political right coming their way. [It is a given that the sight of the politician causes A to have displeasure and B to have a pleasurable feeling.](#)

On the other hand, the sight does not cause the Arahant to generate any pleasure or displeasure. Even though all three see the same person, they generate different types of feelings. *It is important to realize that the feelings were created by A and B by themselves.*

2. Two friends go looking for treasure and find a gem. They are both overjoyed. It looks quite valuable and one person kills the other so that he can get all the money. Yet when he tries to sell the “gem”, he finds out that it was not that valuable. His joy turns to sorrow in an instant. *Nothing had changed in the object. It was the same piece of colored rock. What has changed was the perception of it.*
3. What could happen if an Arahant found the same gem lying on the road? (he would not have gone looking for one). He might think of donating it to a worthy cause. During the process, if he found that it was not valuable, he would not have worried about it at all.
4. A loving couple had lived for many years without any problems and were happy to be together. However, the husband slaps his wife during an argument. The physical pain from the slap itself did not last more than a few minutes. But for how long the wife would suffer mentally? Even the husband, who did not feel any physical pain, would suffer for days if he really loved his wife. *In both cases, the real pain was associated with the attachment to each other. The wife could have dropped something on her foot and would have suffered about the same amount of physical pain. But she would not have had any lingering mental pain associated with that.*

Thus it is clear that in all the above examples happiness or suffering arose from **within one’s own mind**. And tanha (attachment via greed or hate) was the cause of it.

We will discuss more examples as we proceed, but you should think about how to analyze situations that you face everyday, or have experienced. Let us further analyze the actual words of the Buddha when he described *dukha* in the *Dhammacakka Pavattana Sutta*:

1. It says, “*jathi pi dukkha, jara pi dukkha, maranan pi dukkha.....*”. Most people translate this incorrectly as, “birth is suffering, getting old is suffering, dying is suffering,....”.

2. However, “*jathi pi dukkha*” is shortened for the verse; **it is “*jathi api dukkha*”**; the other two “*jara pi dukkha, maranan pi dukkha*” are meant to have the “*pi*” suffix.

“*pi*” in Pali or “*priya*” in Sinhala is “like”, and “*api*” in Pali or “*apriya*” in Sinhala is dislike. Thus, “*jathi api dukkha*” means “birth of something that is not liked by one causes suffering”. “*Jara pi dukkha*” means, “decay of something that is liked causes suffering”, and “*maranan pi dukkha*” means, “Death of a liked causes suffering”. One can look at each case and easily see which one to use; see #4 below.

3. The reverse is true too: “Birth of something that one likes causes happiness”, “decay of something that is hated brings happiness” and “death of a hated person brings happiness”. *You can think of any example and this is ALWAYS true. It brings happiness to many people to hear about the destruction of a property of an enemy . Many people were happy to hear about the death of Bin Laden, except his followers who became sad.*

4. The Buddha further clarified “*pi*” and “*api*” in the next verse, where he explicitly said: “*piyehi vippayogo dukkho, appiyehi sampayogo dukkho*” means “it brings sorrow when a loved one has to depart, and it also brings sorrow to be with a hated person” (“*piya*” is same as “*pi*”, and “*apiya*” is same as “*api*”). We all know the truth of this first hand. When a man dies of in a plane crash, it causes great suffering to his family; less to his distant relatives; even less to those who just know him

informally; and for someone at the other end of country who has had no association with him, it is “just some news”.

Thus all these feelings arise due to *tanha*, some form of attachment: greed (craving, liking) or hate (dislike); all these are due to *sankhara*. **The feelings (or rather the perceptions that give rise to feelings) reside INSIDE oneself. It does not come from outside.** We use external things to CAUSE happiness or suffering by our own volition. There is no inherent suffering or happiness in ANYTHING external; the sense contact with an external thing CAUSES suffering or happiness depending on our *gathi* and *asavas*. An *Arahant*, who has removed all *asavas*, will be free of such emotional responses.

Now this DOES NOT MEAN we should not love our family or friends. These associations did not come without a cause. We cannot eliminate the cause for the current life; it was done long ago. Now we have fulfill the obligations that resulted from the cause in the past, i.e., we cannot give up our families. We have families, children etc, BECAUSE we have debts to pay to each other; see, “[Kamma, Debt, and Meditation](#)”. What we need to do is to eliminate NEW causes: stop such relationships from formed in future births, i.e., work to stop the rebirth process, while making sure to fulfill our obligations.

Here again, many people freak out: “how can I do that? if I do not reborn what happens to me?” We have this mindset because we do not think life can be much worse than what we have. But it definitely can be much, much worse; see, “[How the Buddha Described the Chance of Rebirth in the Human Realm](#)”. **It is not possible to comprehend this fact without fully understanding the “world view” of the Buddha by looking at the wider world of 31 realms and the process of rebirth.**

- It is also clear how accumulation of *sankhara* via *paticca samuppada* leads to such varied feelings: If we attach to something with a “like” or a “dislike”, we generate a mindset accordingly. This is *paticca samuppada* (*pati* + *ichcha* leading to *sama* + *uppada*; see, “[Paticca Samuppada – Introduction](#)”). in the first case, we generate “positive” mindset towards the object that we liked; thus if everything goes well with the object, we feel happy and if things do not go well, we feel sad. It is the other way for the object that we had a bad impression in the first encounter; we made a negative mindset about the object.
- In either case, the strength of the feeling is also proportional to the strength of the “like” or “dislike”: ***Sama uppada* or *samuppada* means both in quality and quantity**; the higher the strength of “*pati* + *ichcha*”, the higher the strength in “*sama* + *uppada*”.
- This is how we form habits (“*gathi*”) too. A teenager tasting alcohol with a bunch of friends gets attached to that setting and looks forward to have the same experience again; the more he repeats, the more he gets “bonded”, and thus forms a drinking habit. See, “[Habits and Goals](#)” and “[Sansaric Habits and Asavas](#)”.

Thus all what we experience arise in a complex web of inter-related multiple factors. Only a Buddha can “see this whole picture” and condense it down to a form that can be comprehended by only a motivated human being. If one really wants to understand Buddha Dhamma, one needs to spend time contemplating on these multiple but impressively self-consistent key ideas of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, and *paticca samuppada*.

Now let us consider the *vipaka* cycles of PS is described in, “[Akusala-Mula Paticca Samuppada](#)”.

Next, “[Bhava and Jati – States of Existence and Births Therein](#)”,

Vinnana (Consciousness)

A. Base-Level of Vinnana

1. *Vinnana* is awareness: how one “sees” the world at a given moment; thus it is one’s experience at that moment. It also has some “expectation(s)” built in based on the experience.

Vinnana is “colored” by the mental factors, such as *vedana*, *sanna*, *cetana* (52 factors in all; see, “[Cetasika \(Mental Factors\)](#)”); when a number of people look at a given object, they have they perceive it in many different ways. We will discuss the major mental factors in this section. Like everything else, *vinnana* changes from moment to moment.

2. **There are different “base levels” of *vinnana*** according to the being’s existence (*bhava*). Thus the level of *vinnana* of a human being is much higher compared to that of an animal.

- Among humans, there are sub-levels too: *Vinnana* is not directly correlated to one’s “book knowledge”; it relates to the level of understanding of the “true nature of the world”. There are four definite levels of *Vinnana* according to the *magga phala*: *Vinnana* begins to ascend to higher levels starting at the *Sotapanna* stage, followed by the **Sakadagami**, **Aanagami** levels, and culminating at the *Arahant* level. At the *Arahant* level one has totally purified *vinnana* (*anidassana vinnana*), which is also called *panna* (wisdom).

3. Thus it is apparent why *vinnana* does not transfer from life-to-life. If a human dies and is reborn as a deer, that human level of *vinnana* (which was a result of the kammic potential of the *kamma* seed that led to that birth; see, “[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, and Kamma Vipaka](#)”) dies and a lower level *vinnana* associated with a deer becomes effective.

4. As long as one has not attained at least the *Sotapanna* stage, the “base level” of *vinnana* can be anywhere from that corresponding to the lowest realm (*niraya*) to the highest *Brahma* level. It is completely determined by the particular *kamma beeja* grasped at the moment of death.

5. The value of a life can be roughly categorized by the “base level” of *vinnana*:

- An *Arahant* is the highest since there are no defilements left. *Anagami*, *Sakadagami*, *Sotapanna* levels are successively lower. Those four are the highest any being can have.
- Beings in the four *arupa loka* and the 16 *rupa loka* have *vinnana* not contaminated by both greed and hate. Those are *jhanic* states. However, other than those who have attained *magga phala* (one of the four stages of *Nibbana*), beings in those realms have “*vinnana* levels” lower than that of even a *Sotapanna* (living in any of the realms).
- *Vinnana* of a *deva* in any of the six *deva lokas* do not have hate.
- *Vinnana* of a being in any of the four lowest realms (*apayas*) have all three kinds of defilements: greed, hate, and ignorance.
- A human being presents a special case. A human can have all three (greed, hate, and ignorance) or can get rid of all three and become an *Arahant*.

6. The *kamma vipaka* associated with the killing of a being will be different depending on the “level of *vinnana*” of the being. Thus killing of an *Arahant* is the worst, and then the severity of the *kamma* decreases through *Anagami*, *Sakadagami*, and *Sotapanna* stages.

7. It is important to realize that hurting the feelings of a human being could have worse consequences

than killing an animal. This does not mean it is OK to kill animals. Even among animals the level changes, but we do not have capability to assess such variations.

8. We need to be aware that our higher level of consciousness (*vinnana*) is limited to this life. In the next life, we could be at the same level, higher, or even as low as one in the *niraya*. Until *Nibbana* is attained, all beings just wander around all 31 realms.

B. Vinnana During a Lifetime

1. What we described above is only one way to look at *vinnana*, mainly referring to the “base level” for different realms of existence. The “*uppatti paticca samuppada*” cycle describes how this base level of *vinnana* changes from life-to-life; see, “[Akusala-Mula Paticca Samuppada](#)”.

2. But within a given lifetime, say the human life, *vinnana* is normally used to convey the ever-changing “awareness” or “experience” as one goes through living. There are two types of *vinnana* possible:

- *Vinnana* that arise due to past *kamma* (and the accumulated *avijja*) within a given lifetime. This is described in, “[Akusala-Mula Pavutti \(Pravurthi\) Paticca Samuppada](#)”. For example, when one SEES a eye-catching object, that is due to a *kamma vipaka*. Even an *Arahant* will see that it is a eye-pleasing object.
- This is also described under the sub-heading “*Vedana* Arising from *Kamma Vipaka*” in “[Vedana \(Feelings\) Arise in Two Ways](#)”. So, there are multiple ways to describe the same phenomenon; this is an example of the wonderful self-consistency of Buddha Dhamma.
- The other type of *vinnana* arises during a given lifetime when one is engaged in “making *sankhara*” via getting attached through greed and hate. In the above example of “seeing a eye-catching object”, one may generate feelings of attachment to that object and that would be making new *vinnana* via GENERATING *sankhara*. While we may generate such new *vinnana* based on the “seeing event”, and *Arahant* will not.
- This is described in, “[Vedana \(Feelings\) Arise in Two Ways](#)”, under the sub-heading, “*Vedana* Arising from *Sankhara* (“*San phassa ja vedana*)”).

Next, “[Rupa \(Material Form\)](#)”,

Rupa (Material Form)

Please see, [“What are Rupa? \(Relation to Nibbana\)”](#) for an introduction.

Most people have many misconceptions about rupa. So, we will systematically look at different kinds of rupa. Rupa are basically everything that the five physical senses sense: we see vanna rupa (physical objects that bounce light off; also called “*rupa rupa*” [or gross physical form, and *arupa-rupa*; subtle or abstract form]), we hear sadda rupa (sounds), we smell gandha rupa (odors), we taste rasa rupa (food), and we touch pottabba rupa (physical objects). Our internal senses that sense those external rupa are also fine rupa that are controlled by the mind. Those that are sensed by the mind are dhamma (concepts), and mind is not a rupa.

- Here is a simple way to figure out the five types of rupa: If we take a toasted slice of bread that is *rupa rupa* [or gross physical form, and *arupa-rupa*; subtle or abstract form] or a vanna rupa; if it is freshly toasted, when we break it, it will make a sound, which is a sadda rupa; the smell of that bread is a gandha rupa; when we taste it, we taste the rasa rupa in the bread; when we touch it, we touch the pottabba rupa in the bread.

There are many ways that rupa can be analyzed. The basic “building blocks” of all rupa are the four great elements (maha bhuta): patavi (element of extension with the characteristic of hardness), apo (The element of cohesion with the characteristics of cohesiveness and fluidity), tejo (the element of heat or heat energy with the characteristics of hotness and coldness), and Vayo (the element of motion or kinetic energy with the characteristics of pushing and supporting).

- It must be noted that in many cases, the Buddha took existing terms and redefined them to be consistent with Buddha Dhamma. The terms patavi (earth), apo (water), tejo (fire), and vayo (wind) were thought to be the basic building blocks for matter in the pre-Buddha era, including the Greeks.
- But those names have deeper meanings too, which we will get to later.

There are 28 types of basic rupas, and the other 24 are derivatives (upadaya rupa) of the four maha bhuta.

1. Rupa can be put into two categories regarding whether they are internal (ajjhattika) and external (bahira). **The internal rupa are the five pasada rupas associated with the physical body: eye (cakkhu), ear (sota), nose (ghana), tongue (jivha), and body (kaya).** Here are a few things to note:

- These five internal or pasada rupas are essential for experiencing the outside world. Without them, people will not be different from inanimate logs.
- It must be noted that these are NOT the physical organs that we see. These are fine rupas (matter) that stop being regenerated at death. Thus cakku is NOT the physical eye. FROM THE MOMENT OF DEATH, cakku is not there anymore. However, the physical eye is there and can be even used in another person’s body within 24 hours or so.
- Out of the six senses, only the five physical senses have a rupa associated with them. The mind is not a rupa, it is a nama dhamma. However, the brain does help with working of the mind.
- Other than those five pasada rupa, ALL OTHER rupas are external (bahira). Within our physical body, it is not possible to separate the internal pasada rupas (which are very fine) from the gross external rupas that constitute the body we see. At death, all internal rupas stop being

regenerated (see the lifetimes discussed at the end), so what remain is the external rupa that had been associated with the internal pasada rupas.

2. Out of all the external (bahira) rupas, seven are called gocara rupa or objective rupas because those are the ones that can be sensed by the five internal (pasada) rupas.

- These are: visible (vanna) rupa, sound (sadda) rupa, smell (gandha) rupa, taste (rasa) rupa, and tangible rupa (pottabbha). There are no separate rupas called pottabbha rupa; they are patavi, tejo, and vayo, three of the four great elements (maha bhuta). Thus things we see with our eyes are the visible (vanna) rupas; they are only part of the class of rupa.
- It is important to note that the gocara rupa or objective rupa are the only rupa that we EXPERIENCE with our five physical senses. For example the remaining great essential, apo, is not experienced by our senses.
- The five pasada rupas and the seven gocara rupas that are sensed by them are collectively called the olarika (gross or coarse) rupas because they can touch (strike) each other. The other 16 rupas are subtle or fine (sukhuma) rupas.

3. There are several fine rupas that are associated with our body.

- Hadaya vatthu (heart base) is spread in the blood in the heart.
- Jivitindriya rupa (vital force of kammaja rupa) is spread throughout the body.
- There are two bhava rupas that determine whether it is a male or a female: itthi bhava (femininity) and purisa bhava (masculinity). One kind is spread throughout a body.
- Ahara rupa (oja) are nutritive essence that sustains the body. It is extracted from the food we eat.

4. So far we have discussed five pasada rupas, seven rupas that constitute the external rupas (vanna, sadda, rasa, gandha, patavi, tejo, vayo) that are sensed by the pasada rupas, and the five other rupas (hadaya, jivitindriya, two bhava rupas, and oja) in #3.

5. The remaining maha bhuta or the great element is apo. It is the rupa that holds any structure together, but it is not sensed by the body (kaya) rupa. With the apo rupa, up to this point we have discussed 18 types of rupas. **These 18 types of rupas are called nippanna rupa (concretely produced rupas) because they are caused and conditioned by one or more of four things: kamma, citta, utu (tejo) and ahara (food);** thus they are suitable for contemplation by insight.

- The five pasada rupas, two bhava rupas, hadaya vatthu and jivitindriya rupas (9 in all) are produced by kamma and kamma alone.
- Sadda (sound) rupa are produced by citta and utu (tejo). Vocal sounds such as speech, laughter, whistling, etc are produced by citta. Non-vocal sounds, such as thunder and music from instruments are produced by utu.
- The different ways that kamma, citta, utu, and ahara produce the 24 types of rupas is summarized in the Tables and Summaries Section; see, [“Rupa – Generation Mechanisms”](#).

6. **The remaining 10 rupas are more abstract in nature. They are called anippanna rupa (non-concretely produced rupa).**

- Akasa dhathu (space element) is not so much “space”, but more like the inter-atomic space or intra-atomic space. It occupies whatever is not occupied by any other rupa. Thus it is

everywhere, even in the deep inter-galactic space where there is no “detectable matter”. Scientists are beginning to suspect that there is much more energy in the vacuum (zero point energy) than the energy that we experience. It is like the deep ocean and what we see are only the ripples.

- We communicate using two fine rupas: vinnatti rupa or material qualities of communication. We use both the mouth and the body to communicate with each other. Kaya vinnatti (bodily intimation) is gestures by hand, head, physical eye, leg, etc, to indicate one’s intentions to another. Vacī vinnatti (vocal intimation) is the movement of the mouth to produce vocal speech.
- There are three vikara (mutable) rupa that helps with the movements of the body. The lahuta (lightness or buoyancy) rupa suppresses the heaviness of a body. This make it possible for up jump, for example. Imagine trying to toss up an equivalent weight! Muduta (elasticity) removes the stiffness in the body. Kammannata (weildiness) gives strength to hold up body parts. All these make possible our body movements.
- Finally, there are four lakkhana (material qualities) rupa that are common characteristics of all rupas: Upacaya and santati rupas are associated with the arising of a rupa, jarata rupa is associated with the decay, and aniccata rupa is the dissolving stage. See the lifetime discussed below.

7. The four great elements (maha bhuta) are the primary rupas. Each of the four has its own character: patavi element of hardness; the apo element of fluidity and cohesion; tejo of heat; vayo of motion and pressure. As in many other cases, the Buddha took existing terminology of patavi (earth), apo (water), tejo (fire), and vayo (wind) and redefined them, so that he did not have to use new names.

8. The maha bhutas can never be detected separately. The eight rupas patavi, apo, tejo, vayo, are always found together with vanna, gandha, rasa, oja in inseparable units called **pure octads or suddhatthaka**, which are the fundamental units of matter. These eight rupas are inseparable and indivisible, and thus are known as avinibbhoga rupas. A

9. Each of these 28 rupas has a characteristic lifetime. They are measured in units of cittakkhana (thought moments). **There are billions of cittakkhana in a second.** Each thought moment can be divided into three minor units called khana; thus one cittakkhana is three khana. All lakkhana rupas, except jarata, have lifetime of a khana, and the lifetime of jarata rupa is 49 khana. Vinnatti rupas have lifetimes of one cittakkhana. Other 22 rupas have lifetimes of 17 cittakkhana.

10. It is not necessary to memorize all these details about different rupas. But it is good to have reference base to look up if needed. Abhidhamma goes to much more detail, and shows how the mind energy can form different kinds of rupas.

If you have not read about sankhara (the remaining one of the five aggregates):

“[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka](#)“,

The Cooling Down Process (Nibbana) – How Root Causes are Removed

1. One's material world exists because of the six roots causes: *lobha*, *dosa*, *moha*, *alobha*, *adosa*, *amoha*. Even though we may have bouts of happiness, we suffer much more than imaginable in the rebirth process because of these six causes.

- If there are six root causes, why did the Buddha say, “*ragakkhaya Nibbanan, dosakkhaya Nibbanan, Mohakkhaya Nibbanan*”? i.e., why are there only three causes to be removed to attain Nibbana? (By the way, *lobha* is a stronger form of *raga*, thus *ragakkhaya* means removing *lobha*).
- In fact, one needs to cultivate *alobha*, *adosa*, *amoha* in order to remove *lobha*, *dosa*, *moha*.
- As *lobha*, *dosa*, *moha* are removed gradually, the wisdom (*panna*) gained in that process automatically reduces *alobha*, *adosa*, *amoha* as needed. An Arahant has removed all six; *alobha*, *adosa*, *amoha* must be cultivated all the way up to the Arahant stage.

2. *Lobha* is the extreme of greed. (“*lo*” + “*bha*” where “*lo*” is for the *lokaya* or world and “*bha*” is for “*bihiveema*” (arise or establish) is the main reason how the material world is created and sustained with greed.

- Because of *lobha*, *kamachanda* (one of the five hindrances) arises. It is said that “one loses one's mind” when one acts with *kamachanda* (*kāmachanda* = “*kāma*” + “*ichcha*” + “*anda*” where “*ichcha*” is liking and “*anda*” is becomes blind; thus *kamachanda* means blinded by attachment to sense pleasures).
- When one blinded by *kamachanda* and when obstacles arise in the way, one develops *dosa* or *dvesa* (“*dvi*”+“*vésa*” or second manifestation of greed; see, [“Pali Glossary”](#) for the pronunciation key), i.e., hate for whatever gets in one's way.
- And one has *lobha* because one cannot see the truth about this world, i.e., because one has *moha*: *Moha* comes from “*muva*” + “*hā*” or literally “closed mouth”. Here what is meant is that if there is a vessel and if its mouth or opening is closed, then one cannot see what is inside. Thus when one has *moha*, one is ignorant about the true nature of this world, and thus acts blindly and foolishly, just based on the outward appearances.

3. One who has not heard about the Buddha's world view is likely to act with *moha* and thus in turn has both *lobha* and *dosa*.

- However, many people do not have strong versions of *lobha*, *dosa*, *moha* because they may have been exposed to Buddha Dhamma in recent previous lives and thus may be carrying over such habits (*gathi*) compatible with *alobha*, *adosa*, *amoha*. In fact, ANYONE is likely to have been exposed to Buddha Dhamma somewhere, sometime in the deep past; but the more time lag there is, one is likely to lose those qualities.
- In any case, it is clear that if and when one has *kamachanda*, one gets blinded by the urge to get possession of whatever the sense object in question at the time. We all have had instances of *kamachanda* taking over; anyone can possibly remember instances where “the ability to reason out” got lost, at least for a brief time. It is good to contemplate on such a past situation and verify this fact.

4. Long-lasting hateful situations (*dosa*) arise because of *kamachanda*. Again one can go back and

remember such situations. This is why *dosa* (or *dvesa*) is called the second manifestation of greed. At the extreme, *dosa* brings out the second of the five hindrances, *vyapada*. This word comes from “*vaya*”+“*pada*”, where “*vaya*” means decline and “*pada*” means walk towards; thus *vyapada* means one is on a (morally) declining path.

- When one gets extremely angry, one again loses control and this could be even worse than *kamachanda*; it is possible for one to kill another human being in a moment of rage. And when one habitually gets angry, one could be in a state of *vyapada* for longer times, and that could become “normal” state of affairs if one is not stopped, i.e., become a “*gathi*”. We can see people get into the “*vyapada* mode” during (political) debates on television, or during arguments.
- All five hindrances arise because of not seeing the futility of craving or hating. This “getting attached to this world” via greed and hate is called *tanha*; see, “[Tanha – How We Attach Via Greed, Hate, and Ignorance](#)”

5. *Avijja* (ignorance) and *tanha* feed off each other, but it is *avijja* that one needs to tackle first. This is because unless one’s mind sees the dangers hidden behind *tanha*, it is not possible to reduce *tanha*.

- When one starts learning Dhamma one begins to understand the nature of the wider world of 31 realms where beings move around birth to birth, how beings suffer mostly in the lowest four realms, that all actions have consequences, and why it does not make sense in the long run to act immorally to satisfy one’s immediate urges (the concept of *anicca*); see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations](#)”, and follow-up posts.
- When one truly understands *anicca*, one’s *avijja* starts to reduce first from the strong *moha* stage which contributes to *vicikicca* (acting without mindfulness); this in turn reduces greed and hate.
- Most people make the mistake of trying to get rid of greed and hate (via breath meditation), and that is NOT POSSIBLE; one needs to engage in the correct version of “*anapana*” meditation; see, “[Anāpānasati Bhāvanā \(Introduction\)](#)”.
- As long as one has a wrong world view and does not see the danger in having thoughts of excess greed and hate, it is not possible to FORCIBLY get rid of greed and hate; see, “[Difference Between Giving Up Valuables and Losing Interest in Worthless](#)”.
- This is why *Samma Ditthi* or the correct world view comes first in the Noble Eightfold Path.
- When one does the breath meditation, what one is doing is to forcibly SUPPRESS *kamachanda* and *vyapada*, and other hindrances.

6. When one attains the *Sotapanna* stage, one’s *lobha* is reduced to the *kama raga* level and one’s *dosa* reduced to the *patigha* level PERMANENTLY; The fifth hindrance of *vicikicca* is removed, and the other two hindrances reduced. *Patigha* is a lower strength of *vyapada*: “*pati*” + “*gha*” means bonding via friction or dislike; thus *patigha* is included in *tanha*.

- One can see now why a *Sotapanna* is incapable of doing extremely immoral acts that can result in a birth in the four lowest realms (*apayas*); one has removed *vicikicca* hindrance permanently, and one always acts with mindfulness. This higher level of *Samma Ditthi* or the correct world view is deeply ingrained in his/her mind, and even in a future birth that will not change. But one is still capable of acting with greed and hate to a certain extent.

7. When one attains the next level of *Nibbana*, the *Sakadagami* level, one permanently REDUCES *kama raga* and *patigha*. Because of this advancement, one will never be reborn in a realm where the

physical body can be subjected to ailments, diseases, and old age, i.e., one will be reborn above the human realm, which is the fifth realm.

8. At the *Anagami* stage *kama raga* and *patigha* are permanently REMOVED. Thus by the *Anagami* stage, one has completely removed any form of *dosa*, the second root cause; one does not get angry or hateful under any circumstance, and the *dosa cetasika* is permanently removed. Since *kama raga* is also removed now one has no desire to be born in any realm in the *kama loka*, including the *deva* worlds.

- Thus an *Anagami* has only *rupa raga* and *arupa raga*. This is mainly due to the desire of an *Anagami* to listen (and read) and contemplate on Dhamma concepts; there is no desire left for sense pleasures. Thus the *lobha cetasika* is reduced to a very low level.
- As for the *moha cetasika*, only a low strength remains as *avijja*.

9. Thus out of the ten *sanyojana* or *sanyoga* (“san” + “yoga” or bound via “san”), *saccaya ditthi*, *vicikicca*, *silabbata paramasa* (all due to strong *avijja*) are removed at the *Sotapanna* stage.

- This is an important point: One just needs to comprehend the true nature of this world via understanding *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* in order to become a *Sotapanna*.
- Just with this understanding, one removes *kamachanda*, *vyapada*, and *vicikicca*. This is why a *Sotapanna* is said to be “one with the vision” or “*dassanena sampanno*”.
- Once the Buddha took a bit of soil on his fingernail and told the *bhikkhus*, “if all the soil in this Earth can be compared to the defilements one needs to get rid of, a *Sotapanna* has left in him/her only an amount compared to this bit of soil on my fingernail”.
- This may sound astounding to some. But it is critical to understand that most heinous immoral acts are done because of one not having *Samma Ditthi* at least to a significant level.
- Of the remaining *sanyojana* (*sanyoga*), *kama raga* and *patigha* are reduced at the *Sakadagami* stage, and at the *Anagami* stage they are removed. The rest of the *sanyoga* (*rupa raga*, *arupa raga*, *mana*, *uddacca*, and *avijja*) are removed at the *Arahant* stage.

10. In the *kama loka*, we experience a form of *olarika sukha* (or primitive form of coarse sensations), where sense faculties and corresponding sense objects are dense. As attachment to pleasures from “dense matter” decreases, rebirth in the “denser worlds” is progressively eliminated (one exception is the *peta* realm where the bodies are fine, but that is done to impart an enhanced mental suffering).

- At the *Sotapanna* stage one is permanently released from the coarse forms of suffering in the lowest four realms. After the *Sakadagami* stage, rebirths do not occur even in the human realm where the relatively dense bodies still are subjected to physical pains and diseases. An *Anagami* is born only in the *suddhavasa rupa loka*, where there are only fine bodies with vision, hearing, and mind only. An *Arahant* will never be reborn anywhere in the 31 realms which have “some connection to matter”; see, “[What Are Rupa? \(Relation to Nibbana\)](#)”.
- Thus at the passing away of an *Arahant*, the mind is released from any attachment to the material world consisting of the 31 realms; no more suffering from physical pains, mental pains, or death. One has attained the state of *amaraneeya* (no death).

11. Another way to analyze the steps to *Nibbana* is to look at how the 12 *akusala citta* are removed stage by stage; see, “[Akusala Citta – How a Sotapanna Avoids Apayagami Citta](#)”.

12. Therefore, the four stages of *Nibbana* can be characterized via different ways, in terms of

hindrances, *sanyoga* (or *samyojana*), “density of matter”, *akusala citta*, and many other ways. They are all inter-consistent.

13. Even before the *Sotapanna* stage one can start feeling the *niramisa sukha*; see, “[Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)”, and “[Niramisa Sukha](#)”.

- *Niramisa sukha* can increase considerably if one can get to the *Ariya jhanas*.
- It is not necessary to attain *Ariya jhanas* to become a *Sotapanna*, but *Ariya jhanas* can be attained only if one is already a *Sotapanna* ; see, “[How does one know whether the Sotapanna Stage is Reached?](#)” (this became clear to me only recently and I have verified it in a *desana* from the Thero).
- Thus, If one can get to *Ariya jhanas* one can confirm the attainment of the *Sotapanna* stage. And it is possible to distinguish *Ariya jhanas* from *Anariya jhanas* easily since *Ariya jhanas* are immune to external influences or even forced defiled thoughts; see, “[Ariya Jhanas via Cultivation of Saptha Bojjanga](#)”.

Manomaya Kaya

[Manomaya Kaya – Introduction](#)

[Does any Object \(Rupa\) Last only 17 Thought Moments?](#)

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[Manomaya Kaya and Physical Body](#)

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Manomaya Kaya – Introduction

1. In Buddha Dhamma, mind precedes matter. In the conventional language we can say that as a living being traverses the sansara, it takes different physical forms in each life that match the “*gathi*” associated with *kamma bhava* for that existence.

2. For example, a being can be repeatedly born as a cow in several successive lives until the kammic energy of that existence is exhausted. At the end of that kammic energy (and the last life or *jati* as a cow), suppose the mind grasps a *bhava* (or *kamma* seed) that has “*gathi*” corresponding to a human (which is a very rare event).

- As explained in the post, “[Cutī-Patisandhi – An Abhidhamma Description](#)“, the transition from a cow to a human occurs in the last *citta vithi* of the “cow life”. At the end of that *citta vithi*, a *gandhabbaya* in the form a human comes out of the dead body of the cow. This *gandhabbaya* has a very fine body that cannot be seen, but it is a “blueprint” of the human body, except for the “gross physical features” that will be partially determined by the parents of the new life.
- This *gandhabbaya* now awaits a suitable womb to be available. Of course the *gandhabbaya* cannot decide on a womb; rather, when a suitable womb becomes available (i.e., matching the “*gathi*” of the *gandhabbaya*), then it will be pulled into the womb by the kammic energy.
- When a sperm fertilizes an egg in a womb, a single cell called a zygote results. But there is no life there until the *gandhabbaya* enters the womb and is incorporated with that zygote. Now the zygote becomes an embryo, then a fetus, and once out of the womb grows to a full-size human according to that blueprint in the *gandhabbaya*.

3. At the cow-human transition in the last *citta vithi* of the cow life, some very important changes occur in that lifestream. The concept of a lifestream, which is really a very basic introduction, is discussed at, “[What Reincarnates? -Concept of a Lifestream](#)“.

- Of course the biggest change is that now the lifeform has a mind that is at the human level, not at the animal level; the baseline “consciousness level” has shifted. This is expressed in several ways in the *manomaya kaya* or the *gandhabbaya*.
- At the *cuti-patisandhi* transition, the kammic energy creates three very fine *rupa* called *vatthu dasaka*, *kaya dasaka*, and *bhava dasaka*. **We will discuss these in detail later, but they basically correspond to the mind door (or the mind), the blueprint for the human body, and male or female character.**
- As the physical body grows, first inside the womb and then outside the womb, the fine body of the *manomaya kaya* expands with it; thus there is basically a physical body that we see, and overlapping that there is a very fine body (*manomaya kaya*) of the *gandhabbaya*. *Gandhabbaya* means the same as the *manomaya kaya*. Here the *gandhabbaya* is really like a “driver” driving or navigating the physical body; see, “[Ghost in the Machine – Synonym for the Manomaya Kaya?](#)“.

4. The fine body of the *gandhabbaya* or the *manomaya kaya* basically has all the components as the physical body. But all six sensory inputs of the *gandhabbaya* are physically located close to the heart of the physical body; they are not inside the heart, but are sort of overlapping the heart. This is why the *gandhabbaya* sometimes comes out of the physical body in traumatic situations like during heart operations; many such “out-of-body experiences” (OBE) have been reported; see, “[Manomaya Kaya](#)”.

and Out-of-Body Experience (OBE)“.

- The main thing to remember is that *hadaya vatthu* is the mind door, and it is surrounded by the five *pasada rupa* (*cakkhu*, *sota*, *jivha*, *gandha*, and *kaya*) which correspond respectively to the five physical senses of eye, ear, tongue, nose, and touch. Thus all six sense actions actually take place away from what modern science believe they take place.

5. The physical body is really a “shell” that is controlled by the mind (*hadaya vatthu*). The physical body is there to be subjected to the *kamma vipaka*; this is especially true for animals, because they do not have much control what happens to them. We humans, with the advanced mind, have the ability to avoid bad *kamma vipaka* and steer our lives in the direction we want to. We will get into those details later, but let us see how the *gandhabbaya* (or the mind associated with the *hadaya vatthu*) uses the physical body to experience the outside world and also to control the body movements.

6. The world is experienced through the physical body, and this basic interaction is slow compared to the fast pace of the *citta*. The sensory data are collected by the five physical senses of eye, ear, nose, tongue, and the body (skin). Then they are transmitted to the brain via the central nervous system, which takes times of millisecond scale.

- At the brain, data for a certain time interval (possibly around 50 milliseconds; see, “[Citta and Cetasika – How Vinnana \(Consciousness\) Arises](#)”) are processed and then converted to a format suitable for transmission to the five *pasada rupa* located close to the *hadaya vatthu*, via a fast “ray system” (called “*kirana*” in Pali or Sinhala).
- Individual “packets of information” from each of the five senses are then transmitted to the corresponding *pasada rupa* located on the *manomaya kaya*, which overlaps the physical body.

7. For example, let us consider a “packet of data” sent from the physical eye to the brain. This information is processed by the brain, converted to a “ray system” and is transmitted to the *cakkhu pasada*. Now the *cakkhu pasada* vibrates and hits the *hadaya vatthu* that is located close to it (*hadaya vatthu* is surrounded by the five *pasada rupa*); this causes the *hadaya vatthu* to vibrate 17 times, much like a gong hit by an iron rod vibrating for a certain fixed number of times.

- The 17 vibrations of the *hadaya vatthu* correspond to the 17 *citta* in a *citta vithi*. Such a *citta vithi* is called a *pancadvaravajjana citta vithi* because it is initiated by one of the five physical senses or *pancadvara* (“*panca*” or five + “*dvara*” or “door”).
- In other words, this information packet is received and processed by the *hadaya vatthu* within those 17 *citta*. The information is fully received by the fourth *citta* (vibration) and then the rest of the *citta* in that *citta vithi* deal with this information. This “information processing” by the *hadaya vatthu* will not be completed until three more *citta vithi* run by the *hadaya vatthu* itself. Such *citta vithi* initiated by the mind itself is called a *manodvara citta vithi*, where *manodvara* means the “mind door”.

8. Thus we can see that there is a **huge difference** in time between the physical body acquiring senses data (time of the order of 50 milliseconds) and the mind processing that information within a billionth of a second using one *pancadvaravajjana citta vithi* and three *manodvara citta vithi*.

- Even if the five senses keep sending data continuously, the mind is “just sitting there” most of the time. Let us examine this in a bit detail: Suppose the brain keep sending data from the eye non-stop; since each “packet” takes, say 50 milliseconds, then in a second there will be 200 “data packets” of vision coming in. If the brain is going at full speed, it can send at most 1000

(=200×5) “data packets” from all 5 physical senses in a second. Then the mind will be spending less than a millionth of a second in processing all that data, since it takes less than a billionth of a second to process one “data packet” (from previous bullet).

- Thus most of the time the mind is just sitting there, and this is called the “*bhavanga*” state of the mind. In this state, the mind is actually taking the object that came to the mind at the *patisandhi* (rebirth) moment in that last *citta vithi* of the last life. *Bhavanga* (“*bhava*” + “*anga*” or associated) denotes that this state of the mind is characteristic of this new life, in the present case as a human. Just like the eye cannot see itself, **the mind cannot see this “*bhavanga*”**, it is the present mind itself.

9. In the example that we started with, the “cow mind” has now switched over to a “human mind”, and that has the object taken at the *patisandhi* moment. This could be remembering a past *kamma* that led to this human life (for example, the new life may have started off with the image of a good deed done in a past life that came to the new mind at the *patisandhi* moment). But we do not become aware of what is in the *bhavanga*.

- You may remember that there are times when one just stares emptily “out into the space”, and if someone asked “what were you thinking about?”, we would be hard-pressed to recall anything that we were thinking about. Here the mind was mostly in the *bhavanga* state; we are aware that we were alive, but did not have “actual thoughts” going through the mind.
- In reality, even when we think we are fully engaged, the mind is mostly in the *bhavanga* state. As we discussed in a previous bullet, even if all five physical senses keep sending data about the outside world non-stop, the mind takes less than a millionth of a second to process those data coming in within a second!

10. However, the sixth sense or the mind itself is also initiating *citta vithi* either to process information from the five physical senses, or to “think about those senses inputs”. **Furthermore, it also initiates *citta vithi* to get the physical body to speak and to do any kind of work.**

- For example, if the mind gets interested in a sound that the ear sent, it may direct the body to walk towards the source of that sound. To do this, it sends the instructions to the brain via the same “ray system” almost instantaneously. The brain then decodes that information, and sends instructions to the muscles in the legs (via the nervous system) to move. These bodily movements take time, because the mechanical motions are comparatively slow.
- Speech is done in the same way: The mind sends the information to the brain and the brain gets the vocal chords to move to produce the sounds. Here is a short video showing how the muscle movements give rise to sounds:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?x-yt-ts=1422579428&v=Z_ZGqn1tZn8&x-yt-cl=85114404&feature=player_embedded

11. Thus we can see that the brain is just a very fancy computer, carrying out the instructions given by the mind.

- Now the question arises, “Why is nature going through all this trouble to give us a physical body that is sort of cumbersome and slow?”. The main answer is that this is to impart *kamma vipaka*.
- For example, a *deva* has a fine body that is not subject to aches and diseases as for humans; that

was acquired by a good *kamma vipaka*. On the other hand, there are some *petas* (hungry ghosts) who have large bodies, but a very small mouth to impart suffering from hunger.

- In the human realm, our individual bodies are “pre-designed” by *kamma vipaka* to impart varying degrees of suffering, and that is why some people are relatively healthy, while some have health problems. There are of course ways to reduce or even get rid of such problems by making suitable conditions (eating well, exercise, etc) for other good *kamma vipaka* to materialize.
- We do not realize the constant stresses that we are subjected to (both physical and mental), until we begin to experience at least some kind of *niramisa sukha* achieved by “liberating the mind from the cumbersome body with its aches and pains”. When one gets to *jhana*, this is further enhanced, and at higher *jhana* one sees quite significant relief from “dissociating from the body”. And one makes big jump in attaining the *Sotapanna* stage, and of course the full release at the *Arahant* stage of *Nibbana*.

It is possible that I may not have clearly explained some concepts. If you send me a comment referring to the corresponding item number, I can try to clarify it. This basic description is critical if one is really serious about learning *Abhidhamma*.

Next, “[Ghost in the Machine – Synonym for the Manomaya Kaya?](#)“,

Does any Object (Rupa) Last only 17 Thought Moments?

1. I recently watched a popular *Abhidhamma* program (in Sinhala) from Sri Lanka on the Youtube. It was very good in many aspects, but it had two fundamental problems:

- First, the incorrect interpretation of *anicca* and *anatta* as “impermanence” and “no-self”. I have many posts on this site explaining why those two interpretations are critically flawed.
- The second main problem that I noticed was the repeated statement that, “Anything in this world lasts only a brief moment. Any object is formed and destroyed within a short time of the order of a thought moment. Then it is re-formed and the process continues ceaselessly. What you see now is not the same thing that was there a thought moment before”.
- This “creation/destruction” process that is supposed to happen in a thought-moment was tied to the concept of “impermanence” mentioned above.

Here is a direct quote from another source, which is a popular book on *Abhidhamma*: “..a *rupa* is very short lived – it endures only for 17 conscious moments. What is formed is almost instantly gone”.

2. Since I have explained in other posts what the correct interpretations of *anicca* and *anatta*, let us focus on the second point, the claim that “any object lives only for 17 thought moments” in this post.

- Basically, a *sankata* arises due to causes and is destroyed when those causes are depleted. It is a bit more complex, but we will discuss under “*udayavaya*”.
- The arising of a *sankata* can be described with *paticca samuppada*; that is the “*udaya*” or “arise” part. Once formed, different *sankata* will have different lifetimes, and eventually decay; that is “*vaya*”. I will have a post on the “*udayavaya*” process in the future.
- *Udayavaya* describes the formation and destruction of a *sankata* (“*udaya*” means to arise, and “*vaya*” means destruction). But a *sankata* could last for long times.
- It seems to me that this misinterpretation could be due to incorrect understanding of the concept of “*udayavaya*” of a *sankata*. Any material object is included in the category of *sankata*. And it is true that all *sankata* are impermanent; nothing in this world is permanent. Even our universe is going to be destroyed in about 14 billion years.

3. Different *sankata* have different lifetimes. A fly may live for a few days, a human about 100 years, a building may last hundreds of years, the Earth will last about 4-5 billion more years, etc.

- An inert object, like a building, will start slowly decaying from the moment it is built. If a building lasts 1000 years, then each day, it will “decay” by a little bit, though the decay can be expected to accelerate towards the end.
- From the present time to the final destruction (or until death in the case of a living being), any given *sankata* will change. If we consider a baby born today, it will first grow to become a young person; then it will gradually start weakening while getting to be an old person and eventually die one day. Therefore, the key aspect is not destruction, but change. While the baby is growing, the cells in the body will multiply; but in an old person’s body, more cells will be dying.

4. This constant change is not discernible to us on a real time basis. A person does not age while we

are watching him/her. But we can see the change over several years, especially if they are very young or over the middle age.

- Mayflies have a lifetime of the order of a day (after the larva stage), and some live only several hours; here is a short video by the National Geographic channel:

<http://www.natgeotv.com/ca/great-migrations/videos/24-hour-lifecycle>

5. So, where does this incorrect statement, “.. *rupa* is very short lived – it endures only for 17 conscious moments. What is formed is almost instantly gone” comes from?

- Here what is described is how we EXPERIENCE a given *rupa* or an object. We experience the outside physical things in our world through our five physical senses. We see with eyes, hear with ears, smell with the nose, taste with the tongue, and touch with our body.
- However, our minds only catch a very brief (a thought-moment’s worth) of the seeing, hearing, etc experience at a time. *It is not that the object lives a short time, it is just that we sense it only for a brief moment at a time! Let us discuss this in detail.*

6. Each of these five sense events is accomplished via a thought, even though we may not perceive it that way. I will provide more details in the *Abhidhamma* section in the future, but here is a simple description:

- When we see an object, our eyes send the image of the object to the brain via the neurons that connect the eyes to the image processing part of the brain. Each image is of the order of 10 milliseconds (Buddha Dhamma does not provide these times; I am using the time period that scientists have discovered). In other words, when we watch something, what really happens is that the brain takes “snapshots” each of about 10 ms (milliseconds; a ms is one-thousandth of a second) duration. (It seems to me that this number could be much smaller; 10 ms is a recent preliminary finding).
- *But brain does not feel anything*; it is the mind that feels sensations.
- The brain processes that information and transmits it to the location of the mind (called *hadaya vatthu*) which overlaps the heart, **but not in the heart**. Now, it takes the mind 17 thought moments (or 17 *citta*) to process that information and identify the object and make decisions about it; this series of *citta* is called a “*citta vithi*”. So, each “snapshot” is processed by a *citta vithi* containing 17 *citta*.

7. By the way, there are many things that happens during that *citta vithi*: the mind recognizes the object, forms a like/dislike about it, decides to what to do, and lastly may do something about it. That is why there are 17 *cittas* in the series. Towards the end of the *citta vithi*, there are five *javana cittas* that carry out the actions or speech about the object based on the decisions made earlier part of the *citta vithi*. This is a very brief statement of what happens in that *citta vithi*.

- When we are having a conversation with someone, we can see her and hear what she says “at the same time”. But it only appears that we are seeing and hearing at the same time. The sights and sounds are received and processed by the brain in packets (of about 10 ms or so each) as we discussed above. But the mind processes each packet in less than millionth of a second in a *citta vithi*!
- If we are eating popcorn while watching TV, that taste also come in packets: the tongue sends about 10 ms worth of “taste information” to the brain and brain processes that information and

transmits to the mind. The same thing happens with sounds and body touches. As such “information packets” continuously come in we PERCEIVE that we are continuously experiencing such sensations. Only one packet is processed at a time, so there is at least a 10 ms delay between adjacent packets.

8. Therefore, we can be using all five senses at the same time, and all that information is processed in “10 ms packets”. Since there are 1000 ms in a second, we can say that maximum of about 100 such “information packets” are received by the mind each second.

- However, that is fast enough for us to PERCEIVE that we are experiencing all these sense inputs continuously. Now, the only part I borrowed from science is the estimated 10 ms duration for each information packet. These studies have been published only recently, and science of course is not aware of the role of the mind; as far as science is concerned brain does everything, and brain IS the mind. However, I believe that in the near future, scientists will have to change that theory.

9. In any case, what happens in the mind is analogous to what happens when we watch a movie. We perceive that we are watching a continuous movie. But in reality what happens is that the movie projector projects static pictures to the screen at a rate of about 30-60 frames a second. Here again each static picture is of 20-30 ms duration. But it is fast enough for us to perceive that we are watching a continuous movie.

- In the same way, our minds **perceive** that we are watching, hearing, smelling, tasting, and touching all at the same time. But each sensory event is brief lived. Even though each “information packet” sent by the brain is from a 10 ms “time slice”, the mind processes that information in a *citta vithi* that lasts only 17 cittas, and each citta lasts much less than a billionth of a second. **Thus each “snapshot” processed by the mind takes an unimaginably short time.**

10. Now if one thinks carefully, it is apparent that the mind just sits there most the time waiting for input signals from the brain. In a given second, there are only about 100 such “data packets” coming to the mind as we discussed above, and then the mind spends only 100 *citta vithi* for processing that information, *which takes less than a millionth of a second for the mind!*

- The rest of the time, mind is at what is called the “*bhavanga* state”. Thus the mind is mostly in the “*bhavanga* state”.
- I will discuss this in detail in the *Abhidhamma* section in the future, **but we can see that the mind is engaged in “experiencing the world” for very short times at a time.** Each perception event lasts only 17 thought moments, an unimaginably short time.

11. So, how does the mind keeps the continuity of perceiving continuously? It is done by several mental factors (*cetasika*) in each *citta*. In particular, the *manasikara cetasika* brings old memories, *sanna cetasika* recognizes, etc.

- Therefore, we can see that our experience of outside objects is really very, very brief. A snapshot of a picture, sound, etc comes to the mind and is gone in a very brief time. The perception of solid picture, sound, taste, etc is put together by the mind with the help of a set of *cetasika*, especially seven *cetasika* that are in any *citta*.

12. Now it should be clear where the misconception in the statement, “.. ***rupa* is very short lived – it endures only for 17 conscious moments. What is formed is almost instantly gone**” comes from.

- It is not that any *rupa* (or the object) is short-lived. It is just that the duration of experiencing that object is very short. We think we are seeing, hearing, tasting, etc all the time; but we are not. Just like we are only watching a series of static pictures while watching a movie, our mind is only experiencing a series of “snapshots”.
- The “*ghana sanna*” or the “perception of solid and continuous experience” is an illusion created by the mind. This is an important point. If it is not clear, re-read the above.
- You are always welcome to point out inaccuracies or unclear instances. My goal is not to just post essays but to make sure the content is understood. To comprehend Buddha Dhamma requires a lot of thought.

13. Therefore, objects around us do not necessarily change fast and definitely not that fast. **It is just that our experience of seeing it lasts less than a millionth of a second at a time; if we look at an object for a minute or 60 seconds, the mind sees it in about 1200 static frames each lasting less than a millionth of a second.** Out of those 60 seconds, the mind “sees” the object for less than a millionth of a second in total, but spread over the 60 seconds in “snapshots”; an unbelievably small time.

- For example, a gold bar is virtually unchanged during 17 thought moments. A gold bar lasts millions of years, so the change in the gold bar in a thought moment is insignificantly small. **Even in a mayfly that lasts only a day, the change within 17 *cittas* is unmeasurably small.** Thus the statement, “.. *rupa* is very short lived – it endures only for 17 conscious moments. What is formed is almost instantly gone” is **WRONG**.

14. Buddha Dhamma (i.e., the world) is complex enough; we need to be careful to not to make it anymore complex than necessary. Trying to imagine a person disappearing in a thought moment and reforming back into full form is unrealistic. Trying to imagine the same for the Earth is mind boggling, not to mention all those stars, galaxies, out there. Luckily that is not what really happens.

- That is not what was described by the Buddha when he said, “*ditté ditta mantan bhavissati*”, which can be translated as, “what is seen is only a trace”. *Mantan* is “*mātra*” in Sinhala or Sanskrit or a “trace of something”.

15. Even though we think we see a person all the time while we are looking at him, we really see only several “snapshots” of him.

- What about hearing? We normally speak 100 to 160 words per minute, which means we listen at the same rates. Thus we hear about two words per second. A word normally has less than 10 letters, and thus each letter is comprehended in about 50 ms. Therefore, our rough estimate seems to hold. We indeed hear only one letter at a time, but we think we hear whole words or phrases.

16. Other sense inputs work the same way: The Buddha also said, “*suté suta mattan bhavissati*”, “*muté muta mattana bhavissati*”, and “*vinnaté vinnata mattan bhavissati*”, where “*suta*” means hearing, “*muta*” is a collective word for taste, smell, and touch, and “*vinnata*” is for *vinnana*. All our sense inputs and our awareness are really small traces of sensations that flow, which the mind concocts as continuous and solid experiences. Think about the movie analogy again; a movie is a series of static “snapshots”. In the same way, our experiences are a series of “snapshots”.

- In Brahma worlds, there is only a “*manomaya kaya*” and no solid body like ours. There the sense experience more or less continuous (and good). There are some “hungry ghosts” (*petas*)

who also have only the fine “manomaya kaya” that imparts ceaseless suffering. Our physical body is there to impart suffering via various body ailments as well as “physical pleasures”; we will also discuss this important point in the future. Nature has many varieties of “body structures” for imparting different types of suffering/enjoyment according to kamma vipaka.

- This will become even more clear when we further discuss how the physical body is controlled by the “*manomaya kaya*”, the so-called “ghost in the machine”, which is introduced in the next post.

17. There is a lot of information to be absorbed in this post. **Our lives are just series of very brief sense experiences.** When the Buddha uttered those four phrases to the ascetic Bahiya Daruciriya, he contemplated on them right there and attained the *Arahantship*. He is considered to be the person spent the least time in attaining the *Arahantship*.

More on the formation and destruction of a *sankata* in, “[Nirödha and Vaya – Two Different Concepts](#)”.

Next, “[Ghost in the Machine – Synonym for the Manomaya Kaya?](#)”,

Ghost in the Machine – Synonym for the Manomaya Kaya?

1. The “mind-body problem” has been a central problem of philosophy since Descartes formulated it over 350 years ago. Descartes proposed that while the physical body is subjected to the physical laws, there is a soul associated with a human body which is normally called the “mind” and it is non-material; for him, having a mind amounted to having an immaterial soul, outside the physical space, whose essence consisted in thinking. This is the so-called “Cartesian dualism”.

- Here mind and body are on equal footing, each in its own domain.

2. Philosophers no longer take this “dualism” view seriously. Instead current philosophers have adopted a “material monism” that claim that our world is fundamentally material; this is materialism or physicalism. The only question they are debating on is how the “mental” arises from “material”, i.e., how thoughts arise in a material brain.

- We must note that the Buddha’s worldview is totally different from both the above. [It is “mental monism”, i.e., that our world is fundamentally mental.](#) This is why he said his Dhamma is “*pubbe anunussetu dhammesu*” or a Dhamma (or a theory on nature) that was not known to the world.
- This world view of the Buddha has been hidden for many centuries.
- This is of course a paradigm shift and a shocking one too at the first glance. But I hope to convince you with evidence gathered from various fields of study and illustrate the consistency across diverse disciplines.
- It must be mentioned that this monism is not the “mental monism” (or “idealism”) that a few philosophers have proposed. They say that material things are mere imagination. [On the contrary, the physical world is very real, it is just that it cannot provide any lasting happiness because of its transient nature.](#)

3. In 1949 Gilbert Ryle introduced the phrase “ghost in the machine” to ridicule the concept of Cartesian dualism in his book, “The Concept of Mind”. It is said that with that book, he put the final nail in the coffin of Cartesian dualism. Of course, the “ghost” is the soul or the mind and the machine is the body in “ghost in the machine”.

4. I think the ghost in machine analog is actually a good one to describe a human or an animal. The body actually plays a secondary role, and the mind is the controlling entity. **But the “ghost” or the manomaya kaya is NOT all mental**; it has a fine form of matter even though it would not be detectable by current scientific instruments.

I must emphasize that this concept is NOT a version of dualism. Mind and body are interdependent: “*vinnana paccaya namarupa*” and “*namarupa paccaya vinnana*”; a *manomaya kaya* has both *namarupa* and mind.

- This *manomaya kaya* is made by the last *citta vithi* of the previous existence (*bhava*), which is called *cuti* (pronounced “chuthi”) *citta*; see, [“What is a Thought?”](#) in the Abhidhamma section. [Thus this fine material form was PRODUCED by the mind.](#) This is why it is said, “*mano pubbangama dhamma....*”, i.e., “the mind precedes EVERYTHING...”.
- You probably have seen pictures of a “misty ghostly figure” rising out of a physical body in literature on “astral projection” or “out-of-body experience”. That is a good visual, but of

course only people with *abhinna* powers can see them.

- Many people have, though, experienced this out-of-body experience usually under stressful conditions. Most common is the case when a patient undergoes an operation and is unconscious, but recalls later how he/she was able to see the operation from above. This seems to happen more often to women than to men; see, “[Manomaya Kaya and Out-of-Body Experience \(OBE\)](#)“.

5. When one has cultivated *abhinna* powers, one can bring out the “ghost” or the *manomaya kaya* out of the physical body. Then the body is lifeless, until the “ghost” comes back into the body. The “ghost” or the *manomaya kaya* can now see and hear without the aid of a physical ear or eye. Thus it can “focus” on events happening far away, and can see and hear what is going on at that place.

- All this may sound very esoteric but there is a lot out there that is not “captured” by our five physical senses; see, “The 4 percent Universe : Dark Matter, Dark Energy, and the Race to Discover the Rest of Reality” by Richard Panek (2011).
- Our eyes can see only an infinitesimally small part of the electromagnetic spectrum from 390 nm – 700 nm. The human audible range is commonly given as 20 to 20,000 [Hz](#), though there is considerable variation between individuals. Modern scientific instruments can expand these, for example, to see in the infrared frequencies with infrared cameras, etc.
- The “ghost” does not need light to see or a sound wave to travel to hear.

6. The *manomaya kaya* has all six senses in the sense that all five *pasada rupa* corresponding to the five physical senses and also the *hadaya vatthu* that is the “seat of consciousness”. **The *hadaya vatthu*, where *citta* (thoughts) are originated, lines up with the physical heart, not the brain. Thus we can say that mind is located close to the heart, and is not in the brain; brain is like a computer that helps run the physical body; see, “[Neuroscience Says there is no Free Will – That is a Misinterpretation!](#)“.**

- The five *pasada rupa* in the *manomaya kaya* are also located close to the *hadaya vatthu*. Signals between the five physical sense faculties (eye, ear, etc) — called five *indriya* — and the five *pasada rupa*, and also between the (frontal cortex of the) brain and the *hadaya vatthu*, occur via a “ray system”, probably electromagnetic, and are thus very fast.
- However, the “eye” is not just the “eye ball” but includes associated processing units in the brain, which is the visual cortex. It is the visual cortex that sends the signal to the “*cakkhu pasada*” located close to the *hadaya vatthu*. When the *cakkhu pasada* receives a signal from the visual cortex (“eye *indriya*“), it hits the *hadaya vatthu* which in turn vibrates 17 times corresponding to a “*citta vithi*“.
- The same process occurs for the other four physical senses. The “motor cortex” sends/receives signals from all body parts using the central nervous system, and sends “ray signals” to the “*kaya pasada*“. I will discuss this in detail later.
- The five *pasada rupa* are located around the *hadaya vatthu* much like the five small balls (clappers) are situated around the “main clapper” in temple bells in Sri Lanka (I am not sure whether this true in other countries). Such a bell symbolizes the five *pasada rupa* around the *hadaya vatthu*.
- When the “ghost” is inside the physical body, it cannot see or hear without the aid of the physical senses of eyes and ears. Similarly, the mind cannot “think” without the aid of the brain.
- This is why the efficiency of all six senses degrade with time: Because the physical body

degrades. As we get old, all six physical sense faculties of eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body (outer skin), and the brain degrade, and lose their effectiveness.

7. Thus in the visualization as a “ghost”, the *manomaya kaya* has all six senses. But it cannot use the *kaya pasada* outside the physical body since not enough “matter” is in the “ghost” to “feel” the touching sensation. Similarly, the *manomaya kaya* (“ghost”) cannot taste or smell when it is outside the physical body.

- Thus the “ghost” can only see and hear when outside the physical body. And it can do those without any limitations imposed by physical eye or physical ear, i.e. it can see and hear things far away.

8. When a human dies, if there is still *kammic* energy left for the “human *bhava*”, i.e., the potential to be born as a human, then there is no *patisandhi citta* at death. A *patisandhi* (“pati” + “sandhi” = tie up in a new life) happens when a transition to a “new *bhava*”, for example to a “*deva bhava*” or an “animal *bhava*”, happens. If the “*bhava*” remains the same and the next birth is also human, the *manomaya kaya* (“ghost” in this new terminology) or the *gandhabbaya* just comes out and waits until a suitable womb becomes available. The old physical body is now lifeless and just decays.

9. If the *kammic* energy for the “human *bhava*” is exhausted at death, then in the last *citta vithi* the transition to a new “*bhava*” takes place. Then a new *manomaya kaya* for the new existence (*bhava*) is formed within that final *citta vithi*, and at the end of that *citta vithi*, the new *manomaya kaya* corresponding to the new life comes out of the dead body. If it is *deva*, then a new *deva* is instantly born in the *deva loka*. If it is an animal, say a dog, then a *manomaya kaya* (or “ghost”) that resembles the form of a dog comes out of the dead body and will wait until a suitable “dog womb” becomes available.

- As mentioned in other posts, births in 29 realms happen instantaneously, i.e. a fully formed figure is born at the very instant of death in the previous life. An intermediate “*gandhabbaya* state” with a *manomaya kaya* (a “ghost” in the current analogy) that needs to wait for a suitable womb is involved only for birth in human and animal realms.

10. There is another interesting facet: The *kammic* energy automatically prepares the “blueprint of the body” to deliver the *kamma vipaka* (consequences of previous actions). Thus the physical body has “built-in” defects and flaws that may become evident at birth or at different stages of life: for example a cancer may develop at latter stages of life. This is the reason why some people are born handicapped; some have healthy bodies, beautiful bodies, ugly bodies, and a healthy person may die suddenly too; the varieties are endless.

- Furthermore, the nervous system is also setup to induce various effects as *kamma vipaka*. The incessant “urge to do something” works at different levels for different people. This actually reveals a deeper meaning of the First Noble Truth of Suffering; if you are ready for a deeper analysis, see, “[The Incessant Distress \(“Peleema”\) – Key to Dukkha Sacca](#)”.

11. Therefore, the concept of a “ghost in the machine” may be useful to describe the *gandhabbaya* state or the separation of the *manomaya kaya* from the physical body in the cases of out-of-body experience (OBE), or with *abhinna* powers. However, it must be kept in mind that in this case, the “ghost” does not depict an unchanging soul and also it is not totally “mental”; it has very fine material (*rupa*) associated with it, that is invisible to the naked eye, but is visible to someone with *abhinna* powers.

- Contrary to the idea of a soul, the *manomaya kaya* will keep changing even during an given existence and will make a huge transition at a new existence, for example when an animal is

reborn a human or vice versa.

12. The main usefulness of this “ghost in the machine” concept is to accurately describe the physical body for what it really is: a temporary “residence” for the “ghost”. The “residence” decays with time and finally dies and then the “ghost” needs to find a new “residence”. The “ghost” derives its uniqueness or the “personality” via *sansaric* habits (*gathi* and *asavas*), and the “ghost” has the power to change those habits; see, “[Habits, Goals, and Character \(Gathi\)](#)”.

Further information can be found on several posts on the *manomaya kaya* and *gathi*. You can do a keyword search using the “Search” button on the top right.

13. Here is a recent article by the philosopher Colin McGinn on the current theories on the “mind body problem” (click to open the pdf):

[All machine and no ghost- McGinn-2012](#)

Next, “[Manomaya Kaya and Physical Body](#)“,

Manomaya Kaya and Physical Body

1. I gave a very crude explanation of the progression of a living being in the post, “[What Reincarnates? – Concept of a Lifestream](#)“. Here we go into a bit more details.
 - First, here *kaya* is pronounced “*kaya*” not “*kāya*”.
 - “*Kaya*” means “body”. “*Kāya*” means action or *kriyā*.
2. We actually have four types of bodies (*kaya*): *aharaja*, *utuja*, *kammaja*, *cittaja*.
 - The first two *kaya* (plural also *kaya*) are “physical”; they consist of *aharaja rupa* (*rupa* arising from food) and *utuja rupa*. These *utuja rupa* are produced by either *citta* or *kamma*, i.e., *utuja rupa* = *kammaja rupa* + *cittaja rupa*.
 - The physical body (*karaja kaya*) that we see is mostly from *aharaja rupa*; in the womb, it takes in food from the mother, and after birth almost all of the growth is due to the food consumed.
 - The other two *kaya* are *kammaja kaya* and *cittaja kaya*. These are both “*mano*” or “mind” related, and thus the combination of the two is called *manomaya kaya*. There are no gross *rupa* (matter) there, other than very fine *rupa*. *Kammaja kaya* has all the *kammic* potentials acquired up to the present moment, and the *cittaja kaya* is the stream of thoughts discussed in “[What Reincarnates? – Concept of a Lifestream](#)”.
 - The basis of all other three *kaya* is the *kammaja kaya*; it arises from the *kamma* seed responsible that particular *bhava* or existence. That *kammaja kaya* gives rise to an appropriate physical form (*aharaja kaya* and *utuja kaya*) and a thought stream (*cittaja kaya*).
3. Our physical body is a combination of *aharaja kaya* and *utuja kaya*. *Aharaja rupa* are the body mass built up by the food (*ahara*) we consume. A fetus in the mother’s womb grows to an adult by consuming food. Our thoughts (*citta*) and *kamma* also produce fine *rupa* called *utuja rupa*.
4. in the post, “[What Reincarnates? – Concept of a Lifestream](#)“, we mainly talked about the *cittaja kaya*, the stream of thoughts, and the physical body. We saw that, If an animal dies and is reborn a human:
 - The physical body in the animal realm is very different from that in the human realm.
 - The *cittaja kaya* or the stream of thoughts associated with the animal existence (*bhava*) is also very different from the *cittaja kaya* of the human existence (*bhava*). This is what is meant by “*bhava paccaya jati*” in the *Paticca Samuppada*: the birth is according to the *bhava* that latched on at the moment of death, i.e., “*upadana paccaya bhavo*”; see, “[Akusala-Mula Paticca Samuppada](#)”.
5. Thus it is clear that both the physical body and *manomaya kaya* make “quantum jumps” when switching from one existence (say an animal) to another (say a human); both those change drastically.
 - A new *kammaja kaya* acquired at the *cuti-patisandhi* determines the other three *kaya*, in particular the physical body and the *cittaja kaya* or the thought stream in the new existence. The *kammaja kaya* has all the *kammic* potentialities (*kamma* seeds) acquired up to any given time; see, “[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka](#)“, and “[Sansaric Habits and Asavas](#)“. But one of those seeds becomes operative for the “new *bhava*“, and becomes the “*bhavanga*” for that life. The remaining *kamma* seeds all “tag along” in the new *bhava*, and one of those will

rise to the next *bhava* or existence; same “*gathi*” are in all seeds. Thus, whether an animal or a human, the new life will display somewhat similar habits (*gathi*) and cravings (*asavas*).

- This is why “no-self” was not approved or rejected by the Buddha: the new life is not the same as the old life but it is not completely different either, because those *gathi* and *asavas* remain the same (but they all keep changing too). And similarly, “self” is not approved or rejected.
- A living being is a “lifestream” that changes even moment-to-moment based on cause and effect: *paticca samuppada*. Even though there is no “unchanging entity” such as a “soul”, the lifestream has its own characteristics (*gathi* and *asavas*), which also keep evolving.

6. We can further simplify the presentation by narrowing down to two bodies: the physical body and the *manomaya kaya*.

- **The physical body is the “material form” consisting of the *aharaja kaya* and the *utuja kaya*. This is the body that we see.**
- **Manomaya kaya is the “mental body”, consisting of the *cittaja kaya* (stream of thoughts) and the *kammaja kaya* with the *kamma* seeds, habits (*gathi*) and *asavas* (cravings); it also has some fine *utuja rupa* produced by *kamma* and *citta*. The *monomaya kaya* cannot be seen with a normal human eye.**
- **At death, the *monomaya kaya for the new life* separates from the dead physical body and if the next birth is in human or animal realm, it can survive in that form for even many years until a suitable “mother’s womb” can be found; this form of life is called a “*gandhabbaya*”; for a highly-technical analysis of this process, see, “[Cuti-Patisandhi – An Abhidhamma Description](#)”.**
- This *gandhabbaya* is described in the *Tirokudda Sutta* in the *Khuddaka Nikaya*, where it is called “*tirokudda*” or “*tirokuddya*”, instead of *gandhabbaya*.

7. We can easily see the role of the *manomaya kaya* with the actions by its two mental components:

- *Cittaja kaya* is what we EXPERIENCE moment-to-moment. We see, hear, smell, taste, touch, and think about concepts with thoughts: *cakkhu*, *sota*, *gandha*, *rasa*, *pottabba*, and *mano vinnana*.
- Those thoughts NORMALLY depend on our habits (*gathi*), *asava* (cravings), and *kamma vipaka*, all in the *kammaja kaya*; see, “[What is Mind? How Do We Experience the Outside World?](#)”.
- If thoughts arise ONLY DUE TO our past *kamma* and the habits and *asavas* acquired through them, then *kamma* would be deterministic and we will be like robots (and that is the case for many beings, like animals). **LUCKILY, we have the ability to THINK on our own (unlike animals), and to change our individual destinies.**

8. **That last sentence summarizes the message of the Buddha:** Do not lose this opportunity to get out of this *sansaric* suffering when we have this precious human life, which will last only about 100 years. Even if we are reborn human, what guarantees are there that we will get to even listen or read about Buddha Dhamma?

9. Thus if anything is “transferred” from one existence to another those would be the “*gathi*” and “*asavas*” of that lifestream; but they also keep evolving. If we do not act mindfully, if we let our mind to just “go with the flow”, then our actions will be determined by our *sansaric* habits. Then we will be only further strengthening such habits. This is why it is important to identify bad habits and get rid of

them, and ALSO to cultivate good habits.

- This is the process of mind purification called [bhavana \(meditation\)](#) detailed in such suttas as the *Satipattana*, *Anapana sati*, and *Sabbasava*. I will write about those first two suttas later. But I have written about the *Sabbasava sutta*: “[Habits, Goals, and Character \(Gathi\)](#)“, and a bit more deeper analysis in “Key Points in the *Sabbasava Sutta*” at the end of the post, “[The Sotapanna Stage](#)“.
- Also, see the post, “[The Importance of Purifying the Mind](#)“.

More on the *Manomaya kaya* at: “[Manomaya Kaya and Out-of-Body Experience \(OBE\)](#)“.

Next, “[Akusala-Mula Pavutti \(or Pravurthi\) Paticca Samuppada](#)“,

Manomaya Kaya and Out-of-Body Experience (OBE)

If you have not read the post, [“Manomaya Kaya and Physical Body”](#), you may want to read that before reading this post.

1. One could visualize the manomaya kaya as the “life giving energy field” (it has some fine rupa too) overlapping the solid physical body. **The working mind, cittaja kaya (thought stream) is in the manomaya kaya, and it is associated with a very fine rupa called hadaya vatthu, and that is where the thoughts arise.**

2. When the manomaya kaya is attached to the physical body, thoughts are generated in a mechanism that involve both the *hadaya vatthu* and the brain (together with the nervous system in the physical body). This is why the “thinking ability” degenerates as one gets old. However, the *hadaya vatthu* does not overlap the brain; it overlaps the physical heart.

3. Not only the mind, but the other five “internal senses” (*pasada rupa*) are born with the *manomaya kaya* at the time of rebirth (*patisandhi*). And all these are very fine rupa, that our eyes cannot see. Thus one can visualize the *manomaya kaya* as an “energy field” that overlaps the physical body and provides the vitality to the inert physical body.

- The Buddha compared the situation of a *manomaya kaya* separating from the physical body to a sword pulled out of its sheath, or a snake shedding its skin. Once the *manomaya kaya* comes out, the body is like an inert log. And that is exactly what happens when one dies; the vitality is gone the instant the *manomaya kaya* comes out.

4. [This manomaya kaya is called “gandhabbaya”](#). When a person dies, if he/she has more kammic energy left in the human “*bhava*”, then the *gandhabbaya* just comes out of the dead body. Until a suitable womb is found matching its kamma seeds (“*gathi*”), the *gandhabbaya* may stay in that form for even years.

5. The *gandhabbaya* also has the ability to see and hear, actually with much more flexibility; just like the “thinking ability” is downgraded by the physical brain, the capabilities of the eye and ear *pasada rupa* are diminished when working with physical eye and physical ear.

- When the manomaya kaya is separated from the physical body, “seeing” does not need light (one could look at things far away) and “hearing” does not need air as a medium for the sound to propagate (one could hear things far away). Both those are done via “rays” (similar to electromagnetic radiation). Furthermore, the *gandhabbaya* can “travel” very fast; it is not physical travel. For example, the suttas talk about the Buddha or Arahants with *iddhi* powers travelling to deva loka in a time comparable to the time taken to “stretch a bent arm”.

6. When the *manomaya kaya (gandhabbaya)* is merged with the physical body, “seeing” and “hearing” is also done in conjunction with the physical eye and the physical ear. Now, “seeing” is done with the help of the physical eye: the “eye” (eye indriya) of the *manomaya kaya* is well inside the physical eye, and objects are “seen” through the physical eye. Same with the ear. Now one can hear only sounds that are received by the physical ear. Therefore, the ability to see and hear also degrade with old age, as the physical eye and physical ear age. Furthermore, if any of these three “physical instruments” gets damaged, the ability to think, see, or hear can be degraded or lost.

7. However, most of the abilities of the eye and ear are still due to the two *pasada rupa* (internal eye and internal ear) associated with the *manomaya kaya*. For example, have you ever wondered how we

can judge the distances as we move around avoiding bumping in to things and each other? The physical eye does not have the capability to “judge distances”; see, “The Sense of Being Stared At” by Rupert Sheldrake (2003, p.12). Our eyes can see many things at the same time and judge relative distances of all things.

8. *Gandhabbaya* cannot smell, taste, or touch, because its body is very fine and thus no physical contact can be made. But it has a way of taking energy form “*gandha*” (aroma) and that is why it is called *gandhabbaya* (“*gandha*”+ “*abba*”, where “*abba*” means taking in).

9. The *hadaya vatthu* of the *manomaya kaya* (*gandhabbaya*) overlaps the physical heart when the two bodies are together. However, in some situations the *manomaya kaya* can separate from the physical body, and that is what is called the “out-of-body experience (OBE)”.

- Normally, it happens under stressful conditions (e.g., what people refer to as near death experiences (NDE) or when undergoing operations), but there are some cases, where people seem to be able to do it at will.
- A recent book, “Dying to be me: My Journey from Cancer, to Near Death, to True Healing”, by Anita Moorjani (2012), describes the OBE experience of her in detail.
- In his book, “Travels”, famous author Michael Crichton (1988, p. 307) mentions his ability to “shift my awareness out of my body and move it around the bedroom”, and he says, “..I didn’t think anything about it... I assumed that anybody could do it..”.
- A similar account has been given by a woman recently who also thought that “everybody could do it”: <http://abcnews.go.com/Health/woman-body-experiences/story?id=22825927>
- Of course there are many books written on OBE. And at least some of those can be true accounts.

Next, “[Gathi \(Character\)](#), [Anusaya \(Temptations\)](#), and [Asava \(Cravings\)](#)“,

Dhamma and Science

[**Dhamma and Science – Introduction**](#)

[**Neuroscience says there is no Free Will? – That is a Misinterpretation!**](#)

[**Quantum Entanglement – We Are All Connected**](#)

[**What is Mind? -How do we Experience the Outside World?**](#)

[**Good Explanations – Key to Weed Out Bad Versions of Dhamma**](#)

[**Godel’s Incompleteness Theorem**](#)

[**Consciousness – A Dhamma Perspective**](#)

[**Infinity – How Big Is It?**](#)

[**Truine Brain: How the Mind Rewires the Brain via Meditation/Habits**](#)

[**How Habits are Formed and Broken – A Scientific View**](#)

[**Second Law of Thermodynamics is Part of Anicca!**](#)

[**The Double Slit Experiment – Correlation between Mind and Matter?**](#)

Dhamma and Science – Introduction

1. Whether it is a scientist or a Buddha, each is “discovering” the way the nature works, i.e., reveal to the world what the fundamental laws of nature are. To appreciate what a Buddha does in comparison to a scientist, contemplate on the following: The scientific knowledge we have today is the CUMULATIVE effort of thousands of scientists, each one taking the knowledge a little further. As Newton said, “I was fortunate to stand on the shoulders of giants to see further”.

- Not all scientists make similar contributions. Galileo, Newton, and Einstein made “giant leaps” in comparison to the smaller steps taken by other scientists.
- Now with cumulative effort over many hundreds of years, science has made significant advance concerning understanding the some of the fundamental laws relevant to INERT MATTER. On the other hand, there is virtually no progress in understanding how the mind works; see, [“Cosconsciousness – A Dhamma Perspective”](#).

2. As I build up this site anyone will be able to see that Buddha Dhamma is the ultimate Grand Unified Theory. It explains everything not only the behavior of inert matter and living beings that we can see, but also the existence of infinite number of worlds with living beings in 29 other realms of existence (other than the human and animal realms) that we cannot see; see, [“The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma”](#).

- Buddha Dhamma is not a religion in the sense of providing salvation. The Buddha was not a God, a prophet or a messenger. He was a human being who purified his mind to perfection so that he could see the whole of existence.
- The Buddha was the greatest scientist, who investigated the problem of existence and found the complete solution. We all need to find our salvation by following the Path that he prescribed to purify our minds.

3. Newton could not have discovered the laws of gravity if it were not for the efforts of scientists like Brahe and Copernicus. Similarly, Einstein could not have discovered relativity without the knowledge passed down by other scientists. Quantum mechanics would not have been possible without the efforts of multiple scientists who moved forward with the evidence gathered by hundreds of other scientists.

- The Buddha in comparison, discovered the complete set of laws about the WHOLE EXISTENCE by his own efforts. This includes not only the way inert matter behave on this Earth, but all of existence in the 31 realms that science is not even aware of; this includes the way inert matter behaves in all 31 realms AND the minds of beings in those 31 realms.

4. We could say that minds of the caliber of Newton and Einstein appear roughly every 100 years. Mind of a Buddha is infinitely more advanced and appears once in many thousands of years if beings are lucky. Normally, the gaps are much more wider.

- There have been four Buddhas in this Maha kalpa (basically during the lifespan of the universe we live in, which was born about 14 billion years ago), but the last Buddha before them was born 30 Maha Kalpas ago, i.e., there was a gap of 30 Maha Kalpas (roughly a trillion years) without a Buddha appearing in this world.
- The Buddhas use a method that is totally different from the “scientific method” used by the scientists. Instead of conducting experiments on inert matter, they conduct mind experiments. Answers to ultimate questions on the existence of living beings who have complex minds can be

found only by PURIFYING a human mind to the ultimate level; that is what a Buddha does.

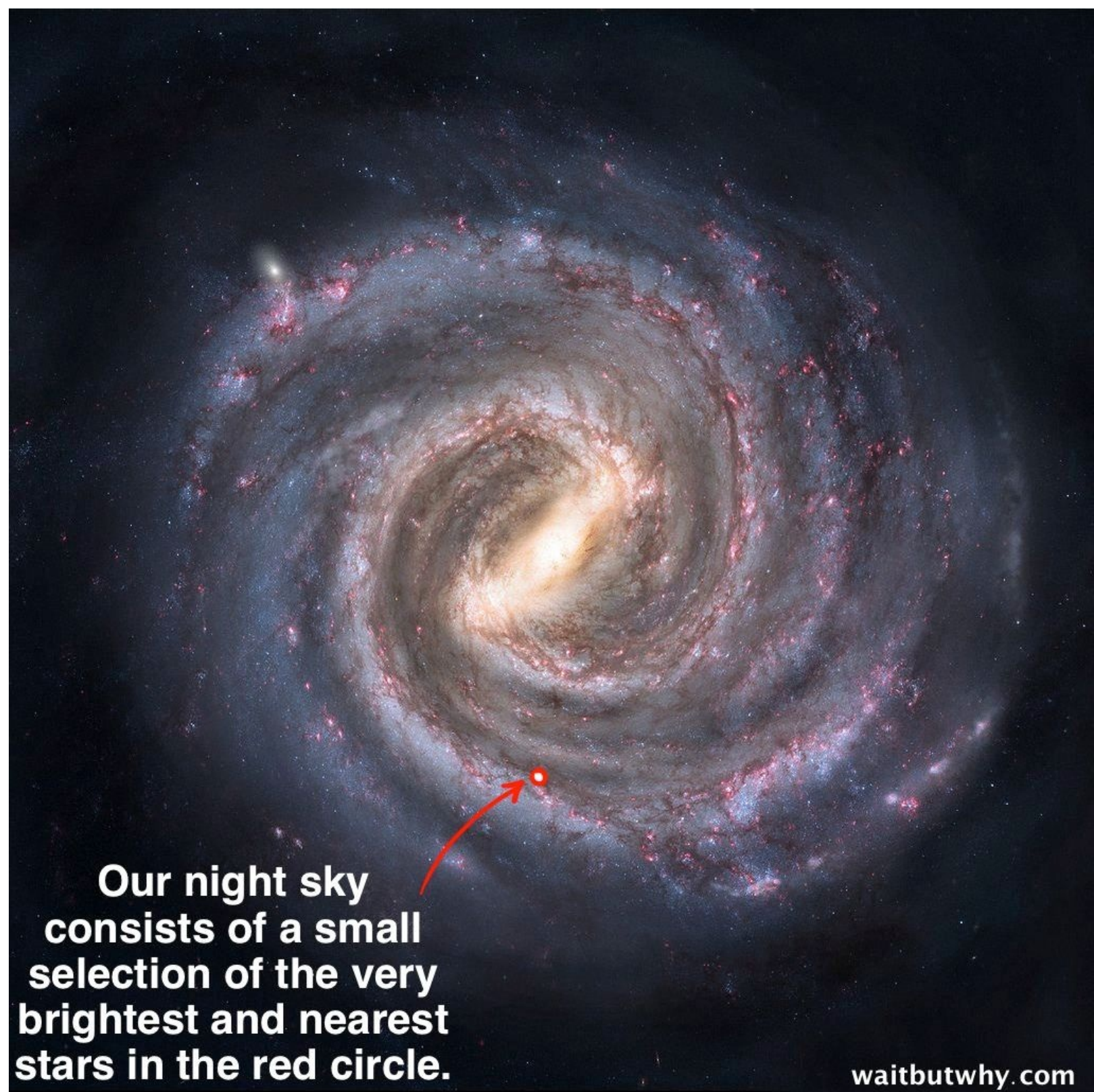
5. I will try to provide at least some details of the complex world view that was provided by the Buddha, which has been muddled and distorted within the past 2500 years.

- “Our world” is much more complex than what is grasped by our senses; see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”.
- And our lives do not end with this one; see, “[Evidence for Rebirth](#)”.
- Those two facts constitute the basis of the true nature of existence, and need to be thought about critically; one cannot comprehend the message of the Buddha until one at least has some idea about this “big picture”.

Now let us examine one case where it took 2500 years for science to come to be consistent with one part of Buddha Dhamma’s world view.

It Took 2500 Years.....

Here is a picture of our Milky Way galaxy. We can see only a couple of thousand stars, but there are hundreds of BILLIONS of stars in our galaxy, and there are about an equal number of GALAXIES in our universe. Thus for each star in our galaxy, there is a whole galaxy out there. It is truly mind boggling.



**Our night sky
consists of a small
selection of the very
brightest and nearest
stars in the red circle.**

waitbutwhy.com

1. Even a few hundred years ago, even scientists believed our Earth was at the center of the universe: http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Geocentric_model
 - Therefore, Buddha's view of the universe as consisting of innumerable "world systems" was not looked at favorably even a few hundred years ago. Of course that has changed now. His statement that "there is no discernible beginning to life" is also becoming vindicated with each new scientific discovery. With any of the scientific theories that are being evaluated now, the only difficulty lies in trying to comprehend how any Creator can keep up with the cosmic activity that is truly beyond comprehension.
2. In Buddha Dhamma, there is no First Cause (no Creator): Life always existed, and it will always

exist. Each living being has gone through innumerable birth-rebirth processes without a conceivable beginning. However, everything in the “world around us” is impermanent, including our own universe (a “major world system” in Buddha Dhamma).

- Everything is born, has a transient existence, and finally decays. And this includes our universe as well; universes, like everything else, are born and eventually fade away.

3. if there is no beginning to life, then where did life exist before the “big bang”, i.e., before our universe came into existence? (actually, life is believed to have evolved on Earth very much later). People who lived even a hundred years ago had to take Buddha’s words on this point solely on faith (or based on the overall picture – as described by the Four Noble Truths and the Noble Eightfold Path – one could believe that it must be true). But we are lucky to be assured by the fact that modern science to give us some rather persuasive reasons to believe that life existed forever. Let us look at the emerging evidence.

- Even as recently as at beginning of the 1900’s, Lord Kelvin, one of the top scientists of the day, estimated that the age of the Sun was < 40 million years based on gravitational contraction (atomic structure was not known at that time), and our knowledge of the universe was pretty much limited to the Solar system. So, this meant the age of our “known universe” was very short and thus the Buddha’s teachings on a beginning-less samsara seemed like a myth.
- Vindication of the Buddha’s teachings started at the beginning of the 1900’s with the advent of quantum mechanics and relativity: Discovery of radioactivity in 1898 by Becquerel and Einstein’s explanation of the photoelectric effect in 1905 led to the quantum theory of atomic structure, which in turn led to the correct picture of atomic fusion as the source of solar energy. So, by 1956, the age of the solar system was known to be > 4 billion years, and the age of the universe was estimated to be around 14 billion years. Yet, even billions of years is hardly the same as “beginning-less time”!

4. By 1929, Edwin Hubble proved that the distant galaxies are moving away from each other and from our galaxy, and that our galaxy is but just one of many galaxies. This was a vast understatement since now we know that there are 400 billion galaxies in our observable universe!

The real breakthroughs came close to the beginning of the 21st century, with a credible explanation to the beginning of our universe. The currently accepted theory on the “big bang” is the inflationary theory of Alan Guth (see, “The Inflationary Universe” by Alan Guth, 1997), which is a fascinating read. I will give but a single quotation from this book to drive home my point (pp.247-248):

- “Thus a region of false vacuum does not merely produce one universe, but instead produces an infinite number of universes! In the cosmic shopping mall, an infinity of pocket universes can be purchased for the price of one. Each pocket universe undergoes a big bang history, just as we believe that the observed universe is doing. Since each pocket universe goes through the process of inflation, it will become almost exactly flat. For a period far longer than 10 to 15 billion year history of our universe since the big bang, the evolution of each pocket universe will be indistinguishable from that of a flat universe. Ultimately, however, the deviations from the flatness will grow. Parts of each pocket universe will re-collapse into a crunch, while other parts dwindle off toward negligible mass density. On the very large scale, however, from a view that shows all the pocket universes, the evolution will strongly resemble the old steady state model of the universe. As the pocket universes live out their lives and re-collapse and dwindle away, new universes are generated to take their place. Although the ultimate fate our pocket

universe is more appealing in the inflationary scenario than in a simple big bang theory, the universe as a whole will regenerate eternally, forever producing new pocket universes. While life in our pocket universe will presumably die out, life in the universe as a whole will thrive for eternity.”

(Just recently, more evidence emerged to support the inflation theory: see, <http://www.nytimes.com/2014/03/18/science/space/detection-of-waves-in-space-buttrresses-landmark-theory-of-big-bang.html>, and “[First Direct Evidence of Cosmic Inflation](#)“).

5. This is a stunning example of scientific verification for the Buddha Dhamma. Life always existed in universes that are long gone, and will exist forever in future universes.

- By the way, there are several theories currently being explored in quantum mechanics that are related to cosmology. There is one theory that requires a universe being existing for each possible event! So, there may be infinite number of parallel universes. For example, see “The Beginning of Infinity” by David Deutsch (2011). In all these theories there are multiple universes that always exist.
- In any case, the Buddha of course did not say which of these theories is correct. He just said life always existed, and it always will. But he did say that universes come into being, exist for long times, and are destroyed at the end.

Now, let us analyze a set of recent experiments that some researchers erroneously interpreted to conclude that there is no free will:

Next, “[Neuroscience says there is no Free Will? – That is a Misinterpretation!](#)“,

Neuroscience says there is no Free Will? – That is a Misinterpretation!

1. In 1983, Benjamin Libet conducted an experiment that **apparently showed** that our brain makes decisions before we become aware of it. When a person moves a finger, the brain activity appears to start before the person actually makes that decision.

- There have been numerous experiments conducted since then, and all experiments seem to confirm this observation, even though the time delays vary.
- People are quite puzzled and some are very worried that we are just zombies run by a program in our brain.

2. Here is a video clip that illustrates the the basic experiment:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?x-yt-cl=85114404&v=-i3AiOS4nCE&x-yt-ts=1422579428&feature=player_embedded

Here is a recent youtube video (I have trimmed the video length to 5 minutes to give just the essential information):

https://www.youtube.com/watch?x-yt-cl=85114404&x-yt-ts=1422579428&v=VnGDrc_s6KA&feature=player_embedded

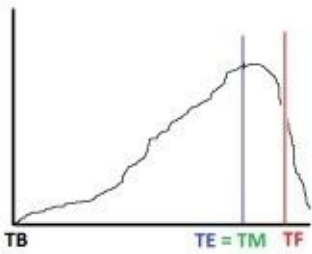
3. Scientists and philosophers have been debating whether these experiments show that man has no free will:

http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Neuroscience_of_free_will

4. The second recent experiment is a bit more refined. Let us summarize that experiment:

- The person randomly decides (no pre-planning) press a button at some time (let us take this time to be TM -M for the mind- making the decision)
- He presses the button, the time of which is recorded electronically: TF (F for using the finger to press the button).
- At the same time that he decides to press the button, he is watching the clock and makes a mental note of the “time” and after hitting the button, records that time too: TE (E for using the eye to see the time on the clock. It is important to note that TE is the time that the MIND says it saw the clock).
- Finally, his brain activity is recorded by the sensors attached to his head, and let us take the recorded start of brain activity to be TB.

Here is a summary from the researchers (you can click on the figure to expand and then hit the back button on the browser to get back):

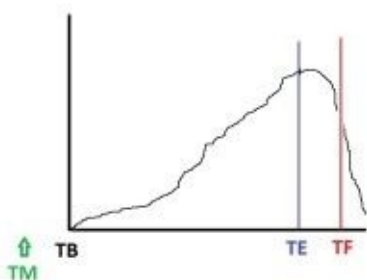


So, the researchers conclude that since brain activity started at TB before, either (i) him pressing the button (at time TF) , or (ii) him recording the “clock” **at the time TE when he made the decision**, the brain activity started before he made the decision.

- The problem is that **they ASSUME that the time, TE, that one gets off the clock is the same as the time, TM, that the mind makes the decision to press the button.**

5. In Buddha Dhamma, mind is the precursor to every action that we do with the body, and gets the brain to it. The brain is the control center for the mechanical body to carry out both these tasks **ASSIGNED BY THE MIND**. The brain gets the finger to push the button and the physical eye to look at the watch.

- **Now the mind is in the manomaya kaya and is lined up with the heart of the physical body; the mind and the brain are connected by signal system that is analogous to how television or radio signals are transmitted (possibly electromagnetic; that is very fast). The brain communicates with the five senses via the nervous system, and those communications are slower.**
- **Thus the brain gets the message from the mind to “press the button” and to “watch the clock”. Thus TB is ALWAYS later than TM.**
- Modern science has shown that, “It normally takes 0.4 – 0.6 seconds for the nervous system to activate available muscle motor units to contract,.....”. (see, at the very end of the article:http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Motor_control). The finger movement involves muscles in the arm, and the eye movement involves muscles in the head and the eye).
- Both actions of “watch the clock” and “press the button” are initiated by the brain per mind’s instructions via the central nervous system: The eye function circuitry can be logically thought to be a bit faster than the mechanical finger moving. Thus “watching clock” gets done first with the eye, and a little time later the finger has pushed the button. So, here is the time sequence per Buddha Dhamma (you can click on the figure to expand and then hit the back button on the browser to get back):



6. Any function of the body is controlled by the mind; here it is the mind that starts off the brain activity, i.e., TB is later than TM (the brain activity starts after the mind decides to take action because

the brain needs to get the signal from the mind – located close to the heart- via the central nervous system).

- Now the brain needs to carry out those two functions of pressing the button and look at the clock: since the vision circuitry is faster it gets done first; the mechanical movement of the fingers is slower and that gets done a bit later.

7. Now, let us go back to the first experiment. The only difference there is that the person is not recording the time. He just presses the left or right button. So, there are just two events recorded now instead of three events. All we have to do is to remove TE from the above two graphs.

- It is simpler: His mind decides to push the button; the mind directs the brain to push either the left or right finger; and it takes some time for the brain to mobilize the muscles to move the finger. So, the time sequence is the same as in the same figure: mind decides (TM), brain starts working on it (TB) and the sensors attached to his head record that brain activity (wiggly line), and finally the finger pushes the button (TF).
- As in the other experiment, **the mistake is to assume that finger pushing happens SIMULTANEOUS with the mind's decision.** But the mind only gets the brain (the computer) to initiate the complex sequence of events to work the muscles in the arm and hand to move the finger, and that is the lag time.

8. The body is like a mechanical instrument, say, a sophisticated tank that is used to fire at the distant object. The operator is like the mind. He aims the gun barrel using sophisticated circuitry, and then fires the gun. He can drive the tank where ever he wants. But things do not, **and cannot**, happen simultaneous with the operators decision; the gun needs to be moved into position before firing.

- The mind is controlling the body just like that. The finger (and the eye) in the above case(s) are just two instruments helping with the two tasks of pressing the button (and reading the clock), and the brain is the “control center” that oversees both those activities on the command of the mind.

9. The mind is in the manomaya kaya; the brain is “computer-like” and controls the physical body on the instructions given by the mind. At death, the manomaya kaya with the mind leaves the body and both the body and the brain become lifeless; see, “[Ghost in the Machine – Synonym for the Manomaya Kaya?](#)“, “[Manomaya Kaya and the Physical Body](#)“, and “[Manomaya Kaya and Out-of-Body \(OBE\) Experience](#)“.

- Therefore, it is clear that we are not robots controlled by a program running in our brain. The brain is just a sophisticated mechanical instrument that helps the mind with coordinating the tasks (like the computer in the tank in the above example that is helping the tank operator). But there are certain functions like breathing that the brain carries out without an input from the mind. We will discuss those in an upcoming post soon.
- Any person has the POTENTIAL to do things in a scale that is unimaginable to us. We just do not realize the power of our minds; see, “[Power of the Human Mind – Introduction](#)“, and the follow-up posts.

Next, “[Quantum Entanglement – We Are All Connected](#)“,

Quantum Entanglement – We Are All Connected

1. When we get deep into Buddha Dhamma we will see that EVERYTHING in this world is created by mind. This is why the Buddha said, “mano pubbangama dhamma.....”, i.e., mind is the precursor to everything. But let us proceed at a slow pace.

- By the way, dhamma is “what we bear” in this world (“darana deya” in Sinhala); this means absolutely everything in this world. And all dhamma are *anatta*, i.e., fruitless, or there is nothing substantial in any dhamma (it does not mean “no-self” or “anathma”); see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations](#)“, and “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – True Meanings](#)“.

2. There are five niyama Dhamma that control how anything and everything happens; see, “[What is Kamma? – Is Everything Determined by Kamma?](#)“. Also, this world is not four dimensional (3 space dimensions and time) as we experience, but is multi-dimensional; see, “[What Happens in Other Dimensions](#)“. This is why we see only two realms (human and animal) out of the 31 realms of existence; see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)“. Just because we cannot experience directly or is not proven by science YET is not reason to discard them (**but the current string theories do predict an 11-dimensional world**), because that complex model can explain EVERYTHING in this world.

- What can be explained with Buddha Dhamma? everything in this world. See, “[Vagaries of Life and the Way to seek “Good Rebirths”](#)“, for some examples.

3. Furthermore, science has been confirming many things that ordinary people rejected as “impossible” over the past few hundred years; and that activity started increasing over the past hundred years since the advent of quantum mechanics and relativity; see, “[Dhamma and Science – Introduction](#)“. This should give us more confidence on Buddha Dhamma. [This is saddha, or faith based on evidence.](#)

4. Here we will discuss yet another recent finding in science that makes the process of rebirth more easily “explainable”. **Please note that I am not trying to verify Buddha Dhamma by science. It is the other way around; I am saying that science is far behind Buddha Dhamma**, and is now trying to catch up just the material aspects of how this world works; science has not made any significant progress on how the mind works.

- In the essay, “[Evidence for Rebirth](#)“, we saw that a person who dies in one geographical location is reborn in another. Even though the consciousness is NOT transmigrated as is believed in some other religions, some form of energy must be leaving one place is instantly appearing at another.
- What about the speed of light barrier for anything or any information to travel, based on Einstein’s special theory of relativity? It turns out that again we are in a unique time in history, where the Buddha’s teachings are beginning to be, even if not absolutely confirmed, at least elevated to the level of possibility by Western science. For millennia, numerous people had strong enough faith to believe Buddha’s words and to commit their entire lives to pursue Nibbana. (Actually it is not blind faith, since if one studied the Dhamma/ Abhidhamma carefully, one could be convinced that it must be true).

5. In 1935, Einstein, Podolsky, and Rosen published a paper which showed that if quantum mechanics is correct, then a particle can somehow “know” what another particle, even if separated from it by a large distance, is doing. Einstein derisively called this “spooky action at a distance” and dismissed

the prediction (despite the fact that his theories led to the foundation of quantum mechanics, Einstein was firmly opposed to quantum mechanics throughout his lifetime).

- However, in 1964, physicist John Bell proposed an experiment to actually test this concept. In a number of experiments carried out since 1997, it has been shown that Einstein was wrong. The experimenters created “entangled particles” which shared a wave function. In 1997 Nicholas Gisin did the first experiment with entangled photons, in which they were sent seven miles apart via optical fibers. Reaching the ends of these fibers, the two photons were forced to make random choices between alternative, equally possible pathways.
- Since there was no way for the photons to communicate with each other, “classical” physics would predict that their independent choices would bear no relationship to each other. But when the paths of the two photons were properly adjusted and the results compared, the independent decisions by the paired photons always matched, even though there was no physical way for them to communicate with each other. The responses were instantaneous, even though even at the speed of light the two events were separated by about 26 milliseconds.

6. Since then that same experiment has been repeated with electrons and ions as well. This effect is called the “quantum entanglement”, and leads directly to other related concepts such as “holographic universe” and “interconnectedness”. **The conclusion seems to be that entangled particles can be interconnected even if they are situated across the universe!** By the way, we need to remember that our universe began its life with the “Big Bang” when everything in the universe sprang out of an unimaginably dense “point”; thus in a way we are all connected to each other and also to “everything” in this universe at a very fundamental level.

7. The following fun video by Dr Quantum illustrates the basic idea of quantum entanglement:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?feature=player_embedded&x-yp-ts=1422579428&v=X93XMwOG66E&x-yt-cl=85114404

8. Quantum entanglement could be intimately connected (and can be “explained” easier) with a universe that is multi-dimensional (like the proposed 11-dimensional string theory). If you have read the post on “[What Happens in Other Dimensions](#)“, it will be easier to follow my simple (and crude) illustration:

- Think about a two-dimensional “world”, say, the kitchen floor and consider an ant on the floor as a “two-dimensional being”; which means we assume that the ant can see only those things that make direct contact with the floor. If a chair is there, the ant can see only four “impenetrable circles” where the legs of the chair touch the floor. For the ant, those four “circles” are disconnected; they lie far apart from each other. However, if we lift that chair, all four “circles” will be removed simultaneously. For the ant, this means that the four “circles” were “entangled” or connected to each other; of course we can see that there were connected via the rest of the chair in the third dimension, above the floor.
- Same way, things that appear to us as “far apart” (say New York and Houston) may be connected via a dimension that we cannot see. A person dying in New York may be born instantaneously in Houston, because those two “places” may have a direct path via a hidden dimension.
- Those “entangled particles” in #5 above may travel far apart from each other, but may be connected via a hidden dimension. Just like the ant in the above example is not aware of the rest of chair, we are not aware of the existence of such hidden dimensions.

9. It must be noted that quantum mechanics is not restricted to working on “intellectual” problems such as above, i.e., what the man-on-the-street calls “abstract stuff”. Most of the “things” that we grow accustomed to, or which are familiar to us, varying from computers and cell phones to lasers and nuclear bombs, happen to be byproducts of quantum mechanics.

So, these new observations do indeed make more plausible the concept of a connection across the universe. As the Buddha admonished his followers, there is no point in wasting valuable time on trying to find answers to questions such as the end of the universe or beginning of life. He kept emphasizing that one is fortunate to be born in the human world (a very rare event; see, “[How the Buddha Described the Chance of Rebirth in the Human Realm](#)”), and thus one should diligently work towards achieving liberation (Nibbana). In realms below the human world life is too painful and life in heavenly worlds is too blissful for one to focus on working toward Nibbana.

Is the Universe Multi-Dimensional? – Another Emerging Possibility

It was Einstein’s dream to work out such a Grand Unified Theory, but he was unable to do so. Many scientists are trying to accomplish this goal, and the newest theories are called string theories. No Grand Unified Theory exists yet, but the closest is a version of string theory called the M-theory. M-theory says that ours is a 11-dimensional universe, even though we can see only four dimensions (including time). So, could there be life existing in other dimensions that we cannot observe? That is another possibility in addition to the possibility of life in other star systems in our Universe or other Universes. I briefly discuss this possibility under the heading, “[What Happens in Other Dimensions?](#)”.

Videos on Consciousness and Quantum Physics

Here is an interesting video (very long) on the history and science of consciousness:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fiastcpp6U8&feature=player_embedded&x-yt-ts=1422579428&x-yt-cl=85114404

Here is a short version of it:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?feature=player_embedded&v=gUyqfUut8lA&x-yt-cl=85114404&x-yt-ts=1422579428

Next, “[What is Mind? -How do we Experience the Outside World?](#)“,

What is Mind? How do we Experience the Outside World?

This world of 31 realms is very complex. But many versions of “Buddhism” that we have today make it much more complex than it really is. The Buddha had given us only the essential knowledge base that is required to attain *Nibbana* (actually, one does not need to understand all these minute details: if one can feel the enhanced niramisa sukha from getting rid of greed, hate, and ignorance, one can just follow the Noble Eightfold Path without knowing any details of how the mind works, etc). People who could not understand Buddha Dhamma kept inventing terms/concepts like *bodhicitta* and emptiness to try to make sense of what they could not comprehend. And many people in the old days “fell for” those fancy terms. But now, with science clarifying many concepts independently of Dhamma, those concepts are showing their true colors, i.e., they are just a lot of empty words.

Please take time and read the following (or any post) very carefully. There is a lot of basic information that could be useful in “putting the whole picture together”. Most posts are supposed to be read again (after reading other related posts), because sometimes a little bit of information gleaned from one post can “fill in the blanks” in another post. Dhamma has to be complex to describe a complex world, and even though the Buddha has made it as simple as possible, it takes time to see how all the pieces of the puzzle fit in. And they do. If anyone can find any inconsistencies, anywhere on the website, please send me a comment.

Everything that we experience comes through six “doors” we have to the outside worlds: eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and the mind. Through those six doors we can see pictures, hear sounds, smell odors, taste food, feel things physically by touch, and be aware of concepts (say, mundane things like remembering past events or make plans about future events, or think about a black hole in the middle of the universe or a mathematical concept). The six sense faculties are what the Buddha called “*sabba*“, or “everything”.

All those are done with *citta* or thoughts. But this is probably not a good translation. We normally associate a “thought” with an idea or one visual event, etc., a moment of “experience”. But *citta* is very fast and no one can experience a *citta* which lasts a billionth of a second or less; see, “[What is a Thought?](#)“.

When we look at an object, the “eye” generates visual consciousness (*cakkhu vinnana*): Comprehending what is seen is accomplished via a series of very fast thought processes. [There are billions of thoughts per second, so each citta or thought moment is billionth of a second; see, “The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma”](#). Let us see how the mind “sees” an object in a series of very fast “snapshots” alternating between the “eye” and the “mind”:

- The “eye” captures a snapshot of the object and that snapshot takes 17 thought moments (let us abbreviate it as TM); this series of TM is called a “*citta vithi*“. Next that captured image or “imprint” is transferred to the mind, and the mind analyzes that “imprint” with three *citta vithi* that involve only the mind. These latter *citta vithi* are shorter, around ten TM, and try to discern what the object is. It may first try to discern the color of the object; but one snapshot may be not enough.
- Then the “eye” takes another snapshot lasting 17 TM, and transfers that “imprint” to the mind, which in turn analyzes it and makes better sense of the color. This “back and forth” process goes on until the color is determined.
- Now the same “back and forth” process goes on until another aspect of the object is discerned,

say the shape of the object. The process keeps on until all needed information about the object is gleaned.

Since these citta vithi run very fast, **everything about the object is grasped in a small fraction of a second**. Now, many of you may be thinking, “this looks like some far off theory made up by someone”. The Buddha said he experienced everything that he taught. Phenomena in this fast time scale are discernible only to a Buddha. Once he explained the key aspects to Ven. Sariputta, it was Ven. Sariputta and his group of Bhikkhus that developed the Abhidhamma, where all these details were worked out. It took generations of bhikkhus to develop the Abhidhamma to the final form that was recited at the Third Sangayana and was written down in the Tipitaka in 29 BCE (we know that there were many Arahants before 100-200 CE; see the timeline in “[Theravada: Problems with Current Interpretations of Key Concepts](#)”). For us, the truth of these minute details become apparent as all observable phenomena are EXPLAINED using all three forms of Dhamma in the *Tipitaka: Sutta, Vinaya, and Abhidhamma*).

As all this information comes in, the mind recognizes the object; this is **sanna or perception**. Based on that recognition **feelings (vedana)** are generated (for example when we see a friend we generate a happy feeling; if it someone we don’t like, it is a unhappy feeling, etc).

Once everything about the object is grasped, then if it is an “interesting object”, the mind may start its own “wheeling around” process: the “*pati + iccha sama+uppada*” or *paticca samuppada* process leading to the **accumulation of sankhara**: see, “[Paticca Samuppada – Introduction](#)“, “[Nibbana – Is it Difficult to Understand?](#)“, “[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka](#)“, and other related posts. All these tie up together, but one needs to be a bit patient since there are many inter-coupled concepts.

Thus experiencing a visual object in the above example generates all kinds of mental phenomena: *vedana*, *sanna*, *sankhara*, and during this whole process we have the *vinnana* or *citta* flowing. *Vinnana* is the momentary consciousness, a *citta*. In the above example, it alternates between visual consciousness (*cakkhu vinnana*) and the mind consciousness (*mano vinnana*). The baseline state of a *citta*, i.e., when the mind is not looking at an external object, is called “*bhavanga*“. Here we do not “feel” anything, for example when we are in deep sleep. It is possible for the *bhavanga citta* to appear in between *cakkhu vinnana citta vithi* and *mano vinnana citta vithi*, especially when the subject is not interesting (like when the teacher tells a student, “you are not paying attention”).

Same kind of process happens with any of the five physical senses (the “back and forth switching” between the sense faculty and the mind). **When someone is just remembering a past event or planning something, those are exclusively mind processes (only the mind consciousness is active).**

Now let us look at some details on how the mind processes all the “signals” from the real world where multiple “signals” come in.

- When we watch a movie, what happens is the projector projects about 30-50 static pictures per second on the screen; a movie is a series of static pictures. When the projects rate is above 30 frames a second or so, our eyes see a continuous movie, not individual frames. **Thus even though cittas run at billions per second, we do not “experience” them individually, not even close.**
- This fast rate of cittas also make it possible to perceive all six inputs from the outside world “simultaneously”; at least we experience them as “simultaneous”. For example, we can be watching a movie and enjoying some popcorn; so we see and hear the movie, and taste popcorn

and feel the popcorn cup, and also may be thinking about something related to the scene on the screen; all at the “same time”. *Citta vithi* just alternate among the six sense inputs; it is possible only because there are billions of *citta vithi* per second. Since it happens so fast, we experience them all as “simultaneous”.

- Not only that, but the mind can ignore a multitude of “signals” that are of no interest to one’s own habits (“*gathi*”) or cravings (“*asavas*”). And those depend on the individual. Two friends could be walking on the street, and one (woman) stops abruptly and starts looking at a dress on a shop window. The other (man) looks at it, shrugs, and wants to move on; he would not have even noticed it.

The mind uses the brain. When someone gets old, the brain starts functioning less efficiently; see, “[Manomaya Kaya and Out-of-Body Experience \(OBE\)](#)“. Or, the brain may get damaged due to a *kamma vipaka*; for example, getting Alzheimer’s disease is a *kamma vipaka*. As the body gets old, various other body parts also start functioning less efficiently and are also vulnerable for many *kamma vipaka* to come to fruition. *Kamma vipaka* are not deterministic; they come to bear fruit only when conditions become suitable (see, “[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka](#)“). Thus meditation and regular exercise help keep both the body and the mind (through an efficiently working brain) in good condition.

In any case, the mind goes to the “baseline or dormant state” called “*bhavanga*” even in between these *citta vithi*. When the mind is fairly inactive, say when someone is dozing off, the mind is mostly in the *bhavanga* state. When someone is unconscious or in deep sleep, it is in the *bhavanga* state for the whole duration. When seeing a dream, the mind is active.

The above discussion is all about receiving information from the outside world and then getting attached to “things” (“*tanha*”), generating *mano sankhara*, etc.

Based on that process, we may decide to take further action too, either verbally or bodily, thus generating *vaci sankhara* and *kaya sankhara*: We may speak or do some physical activity. All those are done with the mind too, and each action done with thought process or *citta vithi*. This is why the Buddha said, “*mano pubbangama dhamma*, ,,,”, i.e., “mind precedes everything that we do...”. **We cannot even lift a finger without generating a *citta vithi*, i.e., without the initiation by the mind.** The physical body, with the brain acting as a “sophisticated control center”, helps the mind to achieve whatever physical activity it wishes; see, “[Neuroscience says there is no Free Will? – That is a Misinterpretation!](#)”.

Further reading: “A Comprehensive Manual of Abhidhamma”, by Bhikkhu Bodhi (2010).

Next, “[The Law of Attraction, Habits \(Gathi\), and Cravings \(Asavas\)](#)“,

Good Explanations – Key to Weeding Out Bad Versions of Dhamma

1. Today, we have many different religions, world views, cults, and even different versions of the Buddha Dhamma: *Theravada*, *Mahayana*, *Zen*, *Vajrayana* (Tibetan), etc. Actually, *Zen* and *Vajrayana* both originated from *Mahayana* (see, “[Historical Timeline of Edward Conze](#)”); thus *Theravada* and *Mahayana* are the two main categories. How could one decide which one to choose?

2. Here is a good example of an obvious inconsistency:

In *Mahayana* Buddhism, one is supposed to take a vow as to not to attain Enlightenment (*Nibbana*) until ALL BEINGS are ready to attain *Nibbana*. Whoever came up with this idea did not understand that there are an infinite number of beings. On this Earth alone, scientists estimate that there are 10 trillion of just ants (million ants for each human being!). It also displays a lack of understanding that most beings are incapable of attaining *Nibbana*, until a human or deva birth is attained, which are rare events; see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”.

- As the Buddha advised in the *Kalama Sutta*, everyone needs to examine the different options and choose the one that is without any contradictions.

3. In Buddha’s time, there was of course no “science” that educated the masses about the physical world. Even though the Buddha referred to the innumerable world systems and innumerable beings in them, people just had to believe those only based on faith. Today we are fortunate to have a well-established scientific method to rule out “bad theories” and to focus on “good theories”.

- This method cannot match the Buddha’s method of deciding by EXPERIENCE that he advised in the *Kalama Sutta* as mentioned above, but it gives a filtering mechanism to weed out the stuff that is clearly not worth pursuing. Thus the scientific method can be used as “pre-screening” to get rid of obviously unsuitable paths or “theories”.

4. What is the “scientific method”?

An acceptable “theory” must have,

- (1) power (ability) to explain as many things that we experience in this world,
- (2) consistency, i.e., not one explanation can be inconsistent with another within the same theory,
- (3) the power to predict, i.e., point out things that are still unknown but could be verified in the future.

5. If one would want to read more about the scientific method, I can recommend two books: “The structure of scientific Revolutions” by Thomas Kuhn is a classic; “The Beginning of Infinity” by David Deutsch is a recent and more easy-to-read book which also discusses infinity which is a key concept in Dhamma.

6. Thus explanatory power, consistency, and the power of prediction are the three measures of the validity of a scientific theory. Buddha Dhamma is a theory about existence for someone who has not yet “seen” its validity. My goal with this website is to present the Dhamma as a scientific theory. I will try to point out the explanatory power of the Dhamma, that there are no inconsistencies in Dhamma, and that many things in the Dhamma that were so far ahead of the times and only now are being confirmed by science. In the following video Dr. Deutsch explains the start of the scientific revolution on a few hundred years ago.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=x-yt-cl=85114404&x-yt->

- As explained above, science proceeds via conjectures (theories) that are continually tested. There are no conjectures in Buddha Dhamma. The truths revealed in Dhamma are still being re-discovered by science. The vagaries of life can only be explained in terms of Buddha Dhamma; see, “[Vagaries of Life and the Way to Seek Good Rebirths](#)”.

7. Buddha Dhamma is not a religion in the normally accepted sense of the word “religion”. The Buddha never said that he can take someone to “salvation” if someone believed in him. **One attains *Nibbana* by purifying ONE’S OWN mind.** The Buddha just showed WHY one should strive for *Nibbana* and HOW to purify one’s mind by following the Noble Eightfold Path.

- Buddha Dhamma is a complete description of existence, or nature. A Buddha appears in the human world after long times as a normal human, and by his own mental efforts discovers the laws of nature. It is for us to decide whether that world view makes sense to us, and then to use the Path he showed to attain *Nibbana*, the state of unconditioned, permanent happiness.

Next, “[Godel’s Incompleteness Theorem](#)“,

Gödel's Incompleteness Theorem

1. Mathematician Kurt Gödel, in his Incompleteness Theorem, proved that it is impossible to find complete “truth” or “complete explanations” of a system from WITHIN a system.
 - No theory that any scientist discovers is, thus, cannot be proven to be the “ultimate truth”. This is another way of saying that by examining the parts one cannot get the complete picture of the system, IF one is within the system.
2. The Buddha transcended “this world” by developing his mind; see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)” for a description of the 31 realms of existence.
 - This is again something that cannot be proven by a human being. One accepts, as I have, of the truth of that by examining the evidence: that the Buddha was able to explain so much about “this world” 2500 years ago. By “this world” it is meant not only the Earth or even this universe, but total existence.
3. The only way to disprove what I stated above is to find inconsistencies within the Buddha Dhamma (this is the same method used by the scientists in assessing scientific theories). I have not found any.
 - If you find anything inconsistent about the Buddha Dhamma, that is because there have been numerous “alterations” over the past 2500 years. But if you find any inconsistencies at this site, please let me know. If there are any, that is due to my possible carelessness or ignorance and I should be able to fix them.
 - In fact, this is the only way get rid any inconsistent “bits and pieces”. Just like if you have a piece of a puzzle at the wrong place that will only hinder the progress of solving the puzzle, having wrong information somewhere will only slow down our progress in “figuring out the pure version of the Buddha Dhamma”.
 - However, I do believe that the “big pieces of the puzzle” are in correct places here.
4. Kurt Gödel would have really enjoyed Buddha Dhamma. It would have been tremendous if he was alive to go through the material here and point out any inconsistencies. Many of the scientists that I admire, including Einstein, Feynman, Gödel, Heisenberg, de Broglie, Sagan, and many more would have been able to easily grasp the message of the Buddha, but unfortunately they never came across the pure Dhamma; David Bohm came close.
 - I hope the current generation of scientists and philosophers will get an opportunity to examine the pure Dhamma.
5. I do not want wrong impressions to come out of this post. I love science and physics in particular. Before discovering the pure Dhamma, physics was my passion and I still try to keep up with new findings.
 - Yet I have realized that discovering how inert matter behave is a minute fraction of the knowledge about the whole existence. We cannot even discover everything about matter, until we start finding out more about the mind. The Buddha said, “*mano pubbangama Dhamma...*“, or “the mind precedes everything in this world....”.
6. Let me give some examples. Albert Einstein introduced his Special Theory of Relativity in 1905 and his General Theory of Relativity in 1915. The first showed that Newton's Three Laws of Motion were only approximately correct, breaking down when velocities approached that of light. The second showed that Newton's Law of Gravitation was also only approximately correct, breaking down when gravitation became very strong.

- We could not see anything wrong with Newton's laws of motion until we developed technologies that transcended our "level of consciousness"; see, "[Expanding 'Consciousness' by Using Technology](#)". They worked well within our "probing sensitivities". Even today, scientists do not use relativity equations to map out rocket trajectories to the Moon; Newton's equations are good enough to that.
- In the same way, everything that science discovers just expands our horizons, but never will provide the "ultimate answers". We can find "everything about this world" just by purifying our minds; see, "[Expanding 'Consciousness' by Purifying the Mind](#)".
- The above statements may not mean much right now. However, I ask you to be patient and go through the material at the website, and gradually you may realize what I am trying to say.

7. A "good theory" is all about "testable predictions". As I stated on the home page, I try to present material on Buddha Dhamma as a "theory on how the nature works". As I pointed out in many essays, many of the "predictions" or "statements" about the nature of this world have proven to correct by science over the years, especially during the past few hundred years.

- I can make another prediction just for the records. Darwin's theory of evolution will be proven to be only partly correct, and only for limited spans of time. The theory of evolution is correct only over the recent past of this planet, where we can trace the past events using techniques such as radiocarbon dating; the oldest dates that can be reliably measured by radiocarbon dating go back to around 50,000 years ago. Even if we put the limit at a million years, that is only a tiny fraction of over four billion year lifespan of the planet.
- What is correctly stated in the theory of evolution is that species arise when conditions become suitable for them to arise AND for them to survive.

8. However, it is dangerous to talk about concepts that are not amenable to our minds. That will lead only to "loss of faith". It would be impossible to explain to someone who time traveled to the present time from several hundred years ago, how a light bulb can light up just by flipping a switch. There is no way for that person to "grasp" the concept of an electric current; he/she would believe it to be a "magic trick".

- The Buddha never revealed any details of the nature that were not discernible to at least his top disciples at that time. Let me give an example from the *Tipitaka*. One time Ven. Moggallana, who was only second to the Buddha in *Abhinna* (supernormal) powers, saw a large number of beings in the *peta* realm near the Gijjakuta mountain. Beings in the *peta* realm have very fine bodies that can be seen by those with *abhinna* powers, and some varieties have such fine bodies that only a few people with highly-developed *abhinna* powers can see them.
- So, none of the *Arahants* that were there who had *abhinna* powers, could see them and they told Ven. Moggallana, "how come we cannot see them?". Ven. Moggallana told them to ask the Buddha. The Buddha told those *Arahants* that he had actually seen them previously. When the *bhikkhus* asked why the Buddha did not mention it to them, he told them that, "If I tell you something that you cannot verify by yourselves, that will only lead to doubts. That is why I did not mention it. But now that Moggallana has seen them, there is at least one person there to confirm it".

9. Even today there are people with *abhinna* powers that can see some of these beings in other realms. My teacher Theravada say they can see them and I have no reason to doubt them. Developing *abhinna* powers requires being able to get to the fourth *jhana* AND then working to develop those powers. So, it is not an easy task. If I ever get to that stage, I will mention that here.

- Developing *abhinna* powers or even *jhanas* is not necessary to attain *Nibbana*. One can even attain the *Arahanthood* without developing any *jhana* ahead of the time.
- What is important is to experience the “cooling down” of *Nibbana* even without getting to the *Sotapanna* stage. That itself provides incentive to continue with the practice; see, “[How to Taste Nibbana](#)”.

References

For those who would like to read more on this subject, the following references could be useful. However, I do not encourage anyone to “go off the track”. I included this section to make the point that all existing scientific theories are incomplete, because they all were generated within the system. The Buddha was able to transcend “this world” and thus was able to provide a complete world view.

“Gödel’s Proof”, by Ernst Nagel and James R. Newman (2001).

“Gödel – A Life of Logic”, by John L. Casti and Werner DePauli (2000).

“Incompleteness: The Proof and Paradox of Kurt Gödel”, Rebecca Goldstein (2005).

“There’s Something about Gödel”, Francesco Berto (2009).

“Gödel, Escher, Bach – An Eternal Golden Braid”, by Douglas R. Hofstadter (1979).

Next, “[Consciousness – A Dhamma Perspective](#)“,

Consciousness – A Dhamma Perspective

[What is Consciousness?](#)

[What Happens in Other Dimensions?](#)

[Six Kinds of Consciousness in Our 3-D World](#)

[Expanding “Consciousness” by Using Technology](#)

[Expanding “Consciousness” by Purifying the Mind](#)

Consciousness Dependence on Number of Dimensions

For an introduction to consciousness, see, "[What is Consciousness?](#)".

1. When we look deeply into the issue of consciousness, we come to realize the unimaginable possible varieties of life. Let us start with the issue of dimensionality. Humans live in a four dimensional world; in other words, humans are aware of four dimensions -three dimensions of space plus time.

- Even though we used to think time being different from spatial dimensions, with his Theory of General Relativity, Einstein demonstrated that space and time are interrelated. He showed that the force of gravity can be explained as perturbations in the space-time fabric due to mass.
- Can there be beings existing in higher dimensions that we are not aware of?

2. Of course, we cannot even begin to imagine more than four dimensions (or more than three spatial dimensions). However, it is easier to think of, and visualize, lower number of dimensions.

- Imagine a two-dimensional creature living on your kitchen table. An ant would be the closest real example, if we imagine that the ant cannot see above the table (a real two-dimensional creature would have only a length and width and no height). Now if we put a hand on the table, the 2D creature could see part of the projection of the hand on the table. Now if we take the hand off the table, as far as the 2D creature is concerned, the "hand" disappeared; it cannot "see" any part of the hand if it is off the table, and thus it has no "awareness" of that hand existing anywhere. It does not exist in its "2-D universe"
- For an amusing story of a 2D creature, see "Flatland: A Romance of Many Dimensions" by Edwin A. Abbott (2002). It was written in 1884 by Abbott, a mathematician.
- Here is a "fun video" from Dr Quantum which illustrates the idea:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?x-yt-cl=85114404&v=B5yxZ5I-zsE&x-yts=1422579428&feature=player_embedded

3. Therefore, the "awareness" of the 2D creature on the kitchen table surface is limited to its 2D world. It is not aware of anything outside the surface of the table (if it is a "2D world" the surface can extend to infinity and as far as our 2D creature is concerned it would not have "an end"). Furthermore, a 1-D world embedded in that 2D world would be a line on that surface. A 1-D creature in that 1-D world will not see anything that lies outside the line. Thus, the 2-D creatures can go in out of the 1-D world by crossing that line!

- It is clear that the consciousness of a 1-D creature is very limited, not necessarily by its mental capabilities, but just by the dimensions of the "world" that it is in. A 2-D creature has an expanded consciousness compared to the 1-D creature. We in the 3-D world have even farther expanded consciousness. (It must be kept in mind that one needs to incorporate the time dimension in all the above cases where only the space dimensionality was considered).

4. Therefore, if our world has more than three spatial dimensions, there may be other worlds that we are not aware of, since our consciousness is limited to the three spatial dimensions.

- Thus, there may be beings in different dimensions that we are not aware of. We may be able to see "projections" of them if there is some overlap in 1, 2, or 3 dimensions. If there is no overlap at all, then we will not be able to see them at all, i.e., we will not be "conscious" of the

presence of them.

- For example, in the low dimensionality case we considered above, if a 2-D creature crosses over the “1-D line world”, the 1-D creature will see a “dot” during the time when there is an overlap of the 2-D creature with the line. Yet, if the “1D world” lies above the table top, there is no overlap and the both creatures will not be conscious of the presence of each other’s worlds.

5. It is possible the “see” beings other than humans and animals by developing certain jhanic (abhinna) powers. There were many yogis even before the Buddha who could access and interact with such beings. One does not have to attain Nibbana to do that, and there are Arahants who have not developed such powers. In fact, the Buddha discouraged people from interacting with such beings, particularly with those in the lower realms.

- “Our world” is much more complex than what is grasped by our senses; see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”.
- And our lives do not end with this one; see, “[Evidence for Rebirth](#)”.
- Those two facts constitute the basis of the true nature of existence, and need to be thought about critically; one cannot comprehend the message of the Buddha until one at least has some idea about this “big picture”.

Next, “[Six Kinds of Consciousness in our 3-D World](#)“,

Six Kinds of Consciousness in Our 3-D World

Having looked into the issue of the “awareness” or consciousness issue related to dimensions, now we turn to our familiar 3-D space. Even here the possibilities are endless, as we see below.

1. We become aware of our surrounding “objects” (i.e., visual objects, sound, smell, taste, tangible objects) using the five “external senses” of eye, ear, nose, tongue, and the body. We see visual objects with our eyes, sounds with our ears, smell with our nose, taste with the tongue, and touch or feel with our body.

- Correspondingly, the Buddha stated that there is eye-consciousness, ear-consciousness, nose-consciousness, tongue-consciousness, and body-consciousness. The cognitive processes that involve those “five physical doors” are called five-door processes.
- In addition to the above mentioned five traditional physical senses, in Buddhism there is mind and the associated mind-consciousness, since we are also conscious about mind objects such as thoughts and visual images. The mind-consciousness is also involved in each of the five-physical-door processes.

2. Note that the Buddha did not mention brain in the mind-consciousness, and he used the term “mind element” without mentioning the brain. This is because the mind belongs to the “manomaya kaya” and the brain belongs to the “physical body”; see, “[Manomaya Kaya and Physical Body](#)”.

- Also note that five “indriyas”: “eye”, “ear”, etc are not the physical eye, physical ear, etc. The five indriyas are called internal rupa or pasada rupa that are extremely fine. The physical eye is different from the pasada eye rupa; but the physical eye is needed for seeing for normal humans.
- When one develops the mind, it is possible to see without the physical eye, and also much more (like beings in other realms). Similarly, the mind is not the brain, but the brain is needed for a normal human for the mind to work.

3. Therefore, our consciousness is limited by our six senses; we perceive the “world” as we sense it with our six senses.

- The “world” or “the universe” is much more complex than we perceive. This is one reason that we think everything around us is permanent, and is why it is so hard for us to understand the true nature of “this world”, i.e., *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.
- With our “enhanced consciousness” from our scientific and technological advances, recently we have realized that even our universe is not permanent; it came into being some 14 billions years ago and will eventually re-collapse or disintegrate.
- Furthermore, as I mentioned elsewhere, we can still “see” only 4%-6%% of the “stuff” in the universe. The other 96% or so is termed “dark energy” and “dark matter” by the scientists because we do not know what that 96% consists of; see, “The 4% Universe”, by Richard Panek (2011). Thus, even though we have vastly expanded our awareness, we are far from being conscious of the “world as it really is”.

4. In Buddha Dhamma, the above discussion with six sense bases applies specifically to humans, but in general applies to many but not all animals as well as other beings in the “sense sphere” (kamaloka).

- The Buddha categorized all the living beings that are subject to the rebirth process in the

sansara, and the categorization is according to the consciousness. Beings in the other planes of existence have totally different kind of consciousness compared to humans or animals.

- For example, beings in the Arupaloka (“form-less sphere”) have only the mind consciousness, since they do not have physical bodies. Before getting into that discussion, let us first discuss different aspects of consciousness that we see around us.

5. Even though the “beings” in the “sense-sphere” that includes humans and animals in general have five external sense-doors (eye, ear, nose, tongue, and body), there are many exceptions.

- For example, some animals do not have fully-developed five external senses. Others have different types of sense doors; a jellyfish has eyes, but no brain for information processing, so its visual consciousness is still very limited. It can distinguish between dark and illuminated areas, and that is about all. On the other hand, a dog has visual consciousness comparable to humans, and it can possibly catch a rabbit by chasing it.
- A bat does not have visual consciousness, so it cannot hunt during the day time, but has different consciousness using radar that enables it to hunt at night. So, it is clear that the “consciousness” or “awareness” has many different “avenues” (for example, humans become aware of their surroundings by using sight, hearing, smell, taste, touch, and thoughts).
- Lower life forms may have less avenues of consciousness, and the degree of consciousness can vary too (a jellyfish has minimal visual consciousness). In a few cases, we may be less conscious than an animal. For example, a bat would be much more conscious about surroundings in the dark, compared to a human.

6. Even though most of the animals have the same five physical senses as humans, they are “aware” of only their immediate environment.

- But the contemporary humans are aware of the existence of a huge Black hole at the center of our Milky Way universe that is millions of light years away.
- Humans used to have much limited awareness even a few hundreds years ago, before the advent of the telescope and the microscope. Since then humans have slowly built up our awareness by using technology; see, “[Expanding Consciousness by Using Technology](#)”.
- However, we need to keep in mind that a complete theory of consciousness (Buddha Dhamma) was described by the Buddha 2500 years ago. It had been hidden for possibly close to 2000 years, at least in its pure form.

7. Therefore, it is clear that “the awareness’ or the “consciousness” can come in different flavors as well as different levels of intensity, even within the “sense sphere” (kamaloka):

- The humans and devas in the kamaloka have the highest levels of consciousness (especially mind-consciousness).
- In the “form-sphere” (rupaloka), the consciousness level in general is higher, even though they have only visual, auditory, and mind-consciousness; their minds are at a much higher level.
- The beings in the “form-less sphere” (arupaloka) do not have physical bodies at all, and have highly developed minds and thus have even higher levels of consciousness.
- These three levels of consciousness are called lokiya (mundane).
- Beings in the three mundane levels have finite lifetimes, and a given “being” wanders through

possibly all these different planes in the unfathomably-long sansara. Even a sentient being born in the arupaloka may end up in the lowest level (apaya) in the kamaloka, depending on the unspent kamma.

8. The higher levels of consciousness are supermundane (lokuttara), and there are four levels of supermundane consciousness with Nibbana achieved by the arahants being the highest.

- The first three levels of supermundane consciousness are Stream Enterer (Sotapanna), Once-Returner (Sakadagami), and Non-Returner (Anagami).
- As one progresses on the Path, the consciousness starts to clear up, first by removing the five hindrances (panca nivarana) at the Sotapanna stage.
- Consciousness is totally purified by the Arahant stage; the pure mind becomes totally separated from any trace of matter (four great elements or satara maha buta) at the death of the Arahant, and thus the Arahant is not reborn anywhere in the 31 realms and his/her mind becomes free, Nibbana.
- All the suffering we experience is due to trying to satisfy the “body” that is attached to the mind. When attachment to that body (which is subjected to decay and death) is severed, the worldly bonds are broken (Nibbana) and the mind attains the complete “cooled down” (Nivana); see, “[How to Taste Nibbana](#)“, and “[Nibbana – Is It Difficult to Understand?](#)“.

Next, “[Expanding Consciousness by Using Technology](#)“,

Expanding “Consciousness” by Using Technology

Focusing on the human world, we can expand our “awareness” or consciousness in two ways so that we can be more “aware” of the “world” around us. One is using the scientific approach and by developing new techniques that enable us to “see” or “be aware” of things that are not directly accessible to our senses. For example, we have infrared sensors that allow us to see in the dark; we have constructed particle accelerators that allow us to “see” elementary particles; we can even “see” supernova explosions that happen millions of light years away using our sophisticated instruments. In the latter two cases, we do not actually see with our eyes, but we are aware of the existence of these events.

However, it must be noted that we can “see” only about 6% of the “stuff” that our universe is made of. Scientists don’t know what the rest of the “stuff” is made of and have labelled it as “dark matter” and “dark energy”. This means we are “not aware” of 94% of our own universe! For those interested, you can also do a Google search on dark energy and dark matter and learn more.

The scientific methods which have been developed over only the past few hundred years are still at a very early stage; even though science and technology has greatly expanded our “awareness” of the external world, according to Buddhism there is much more to be explored, i.e., our consciousness is still very limited. We have not been able to contact any life form outside the Earth, even though scientists now accept the existence of life outside the earth to be a certainty. Possible existence of life forms that exist in the “form-sphere” and the “form-less sphere” are not even contemplated at this time.

Next, “[Expanding Consciousness by Purifying the Mind](#)“,

Expanding “Consciousness” by Purifying the Mind

The other approach to expand our consciousness is by following Buddha Dhamma so that we can “see things as they really are”.

1. Twenty five hundred years ago, the Buddha achieved the ultimate state of the mind and became “all knowing” (or “perfectly conscious”). He came to know about the boundless universe, the endless cycle of rebirths, and about the complex process of cause and effect (paticca samuppada) which sustains everything in the universe.

2. By developing scientific instruments (starting with simple telescopes and microscopes we have now developed very sophisticated instruments), we have been able to expand our “awareness”. For example, within the past century, we have expanded our awareness of the vast space around us, and now we know not only that our universe is possibly infinite in extent, but there may be other parallel universes as well. Yet, what the science has achieved so far is nowhere close to the level achieved by the Buddha.

3. As humans, we may get close to the ultimate knowledge using the scientific approach some day well into the future (especially if we are able to take into account the consciousness, and mind in general, into science), but we can get there in a lifetime by developing our minds following the path laid out by the Buddha. Today’s Science and technology, for all their impressive “material achievements”, are still at very early stages.

4. According to Buddha Dhamma, one is said to achieve full and clear consciousness (anidassana vinnana), i.e., that person will be able to “see the whole world as it is”, when he/she achieves Nibbana. This does not mean that a person who achieves Nibbana will be an expert on relativity or quantum mechanics. Relativity and quantum mechanics provide only partial explanations, and even then just for materials aspects of the world. When one achieves the ultimate knowledge (Nibbana), by definition, relativity or quantum mechanics become irrelevant, since they account for only some of the behavior of impermanent and transient matter. Matter is secondary to mind.

5. Furthermore, even for people with good meditative skills, it is possible to expand their consciousness by accessing higher planes of existence for brief times using meditative states (jhanas), i.e., by controlling and focusing the mind. Even before the Buddha, ancient Yogis were able to access such meditative states via concentration meditation (samatha bhavana). For example, when Prince Sidharatha became an ascetic on the way to the Buddhahood, he first followed two well-known Yogis at that time, Alara Kalama and Uddaka Ramaputta, who were able to achieve very high states of jhanas (that belong in the rupaloka and arupaloka) via concentration meditation.

6. Even today, people from other religions also could experience such states when they get deeply absorbed in prayer or any type of deep mental concentration; this has nothing to do with a particular religion. However, like everything else, such states are transitory; none of these states is permanent other than Nibbana. And Nibbana is not possible to attain via concentration meditation alone, and for that the unique Buddhist system of insight meditation (vipassana bhavana) is needed whereby Paticca Samuppada (Dependent Origination or “cause and effect”) and the Four Noble Truths (that the existence in samsara is dukkha, attachment or craving as the origin of the dukkha, Nibbana is the cessation of dukkha, and the Eight-fold Path is the path to cessation of dukkha) are understood.

7. To recap, according to Buddha Dhamma, “beings” exist in different planes of existence with different levels of consciousness; different planes can exist in different dimensions as well as in

different physical locations (such as planetary systems in this or other universes, for example). Beings are categorized according to their level of consciousness, and the humans lie somewhere in the middle (but still at a very unique place, as is discussed in “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”)

8. Being “aware” or having consciousness is only one aspect of a living being’s mental composition; in Pali, consciousness is vinnana. The other mental constituents that makes up a living being are feeling (vedana), perception (sanna), and mental volitions (sankhara). Consciousness is nothing more than “being aware”. Based on consciousness, the other three, collectively called mental factors (cetasika), arise. For example, when we “see” an object that is pure visual consciousness. Based on the visual, we next recognize the object based on our familiarity with the object. This is perception (sanna). These are discussed more in, “[The Five Aggregates \(Pancaskhandha\)](#)”.

9. The chief characteristic of perception is the cognition of an object by the way of a previous acquaintance. It is perception that enables one to recognize an object that has been perceived by the mind through the senses. According to Abhidhamma, “Its procedure is likened to the carpenter’s recognition of certain kinds of wood by the mark he had made on each; to the treasurer’s specifying certain articles of jewelry by the ticket on each..”. It happens automatically since the mind compares the observed image with the stored images of people we know and quickly makes the “match”. (I was happy to see that scientist Jeff Hawkins has described this very well in scientific terms in his book “On Intelligence”; this book is a worthwhile read to see how scientists are slowly making progress!). Of course, the more frequently the memory is refreshed of the image, the easier it is to recognize. Sometimes people, especially young children, are able to recognize people and material objects from their past lives.

10. Modern neuroscientists and philosophers are struggling with how to even define these “mental characteristics”. They have come up with the term “qualia” to represent the subjective aspect of sense experience. In his book “Second Nature: Brain Science and Human Knowledge” (2006), Gerald M. Edelman, a neuroscientist, states (p. 14): “..The property most often described as particularly mysterious is the phenomenological aspect of consciousness, the experience of qualia. Qualia are, for example, the greenness of green and the warmth of warmth. But several students of the subject, myself included, go beyond these simple qualities and consider the whole ensemble of conscious senses or experiences to be qualia. Many consider explaining qualia to be acid test of a consciousness theory. How can we explain not only qualia but all the other features of consciousness? The answer I propose is to look into how the brain works, formulating a global brain theory that can be extended to explain consciousness...” **In Buddha Dhamma, the qualia are the mental factors (cetasika), and they are built-in to a sentient being and are strictly individualistic, so by definition they cannot arise just from inert matter; but the scientists are trying to derive them from matter.**

11. An interesting read on various ideas of different philosophers’ and scientists’ reasoning on how to explain consciousness and associated mental aspects such as qualia is given in the book, “Conversations on Consciousness” by Susan Blackmore (2006).

12. Let us consider, for example, the visual recognition of a person, say Joe Smith. With the recognition of Joe Smith “feelings” arise together with a whole host of mental volitions, which are fifty two in number in total, and we immediately feel a certain way about Joe Smith based on our past experience. For example, if hatred, one of the possible 52 mental volitions, arise when we see Joe Smith then we could be acquiring bad kamma as well if we let our mind cultivate those feelings further.

13. It needs to be emphasized that consciousness does not entail recognition of an object. It is only a sort of awareness- awareness of the presence of an object. When the eye comes in contact with a color, for instance blue, visual consciousness arises which simply is awareness of the presence of a color; but it does not recognize that it is blue. There is no recognition at this stage. It is perception (sanna) that recognizes that it is blue. The term “visual consciousness” is a philosophical expression denoting the same idea as is conveyed by the ordinary word “seeing”. Seeing does not mean recognizing. The same is true for other forms of consciousness.

14. Using a somewhat different nomenclature, a “being” in the sense sphere can also be represented by just five “heaps of things” or aggregates (skandha), i.e., pancakkandha (pronounced as “panchakkandha”, panca meaning five): consciousness (vinnana), feeling (vedana), perception (sanna), volitions (sankhara), and form or physical body (rupa); see, [“The Five Aggregates \(Pancakkhandha\)”](#). These five components co-exist; they are born together at conception. It is not possible to separate nama from rupa or the four mental aggregates from each other. Therefore, nama does not arise from rupa as scientists believe today; **nama and rupa arise together from the moment of conception in the mother’s womb.**

15. The Buddha did tell his disciples that what he taught them was just a minute fraction of his knowledge about “this world”, and what he has taught is sufficient to achieve Nibbana and cut short the sansaric journey filled with dukkha (unsatisfactoriness and suffering). He did not want people to spend their precious time in this human life studying things like the origin of the universe or the origin of life which would serve no purpose in achieving Nibbana. The following passages are from the Simsapa Sutta:

Once the Buddha was staying at Kosambi in the Simsapa forest. Then, picking up a few simsapa leaves with his hand, he asked the monks, “What do you think, monks: Which are more numerous, the few simsapa leaves in my hand or those overhead in the simsapa forest?”

“The leaves in the hand of the Blessed One are few in number, Lord. Those overhead in the simsapa forest are much more numerous.”

“In the same way, monks, those things that I have known with direct knowledge but have not taught are far more numerous [than what I have taught]. And why haven’t I taught them? Because they are not connected with the goal, do not relate to the rudiments of the holy life, and do not lead to disenchantment, to dispassion, to cessation, to calm, to direct knowledge, to self-awakening, to Unbinding. That is why I have not taught them”.

“And what have I taught? ‘This is dukkha... This is the origination of dukkha... This is the cessation of dukkha... This is the path of practice leading to the cessation of dukkha’: This is what I have taught. And why have I taught these things? Because they are connected with the goal, relate to the rudiments of the holy life, and lead to disenchantment, to dispassion, to cessation, to calm, to direct knowledge, to self-awakening, and to Unbinding. This is why I have taught them”.

16. But nowadays one may be justified to spend a little time to convince oneself that Buddha Dhamma is indeed compatible with the contemporary “scientific knowledge”, because that will enable one to build faith in Buddha Dhamma. **However, when one probes deeper into understanding the key concepts in Dhamma one realizes that it is not a matter of science proving Buddha Dhamma to be correct, but rather science is at a very early stage of discovering the true nature of the world as described by Dhamma.**

17. Let me close with an example on the difference between technological progress on expanding

consciousness versus that by the purification of the mind. The modern world was not aware of the existence of microscopic living beings until the advent of the microscope by Leeuwenhoek in the late 17th century: http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Antonie_van_Leeuwenhoek.

- However, a person who has developed meditation and attained higher jhanas can “see” such microscopic beings. There is this story in the Tipitaka about a bhikkhu who had developed abhinna, but not yet had attained Arahantship. One day he was about to drink a glass of water, when he realized that there were numerous microscopic living beings in the water. He tried to filter them out in vain and got depressed. The Buddha saw this and told him that, “it is not possible to live “in this world” without hurting other beings; the only thing we can do is to attain Nibbana as soon as possible and get out of this world”.
- Thus one can attain much more “knowledge” about this world by developing the mind. We can probe deeper into the microscopic world by using the scientific knowledge achieved over hundreds of years, but we can “see” much more by just purifying the mind in a lifetime.

Next, “[Infinity – How Big Is It?](#)“,

Infinity – How Big Is It?

1. What is the largest number you can think of? Well, just add one and you have a larger number! There are some large numbers that we are aware of. With record budget deficits of the developed nations in trillions of dollars (and the total nominal value of all the derivatives traded around the world approaching a thousand trillion dollars, or a quadrillion dollars), trillion and quadrillions are indeed large numbers.

- Even though a trillion rolls off the tongue not very different from a billion, a trillion is much bigger than a billion. If you spend a billion dollars a day, it will take a thousand days to spend a trillion dollars.

2. The number of molecules in a cubic centimeter of gas is 2.7×10^{18} (this a simple way to express big numbers; instead of writing 10000, we write 10^4). Since electrons are even smaller, you would think there would be a humongous number of electrons in the observable universe; the estimated number is around 10^{87} . This is of course a very large number, but is not infinity by any means.

- This should give you an idea of the power of an exponent. Each time the exponent goes up by one, the number becomes 10 times bigger. So, even though 10^{87} may not look that big compared to 10^{18} , it is a humongous increase. Another large number should be the distance from the Earth to the edge of the observable universe, and it is estimated to be about 46 billion light years or around 10^{23} miles. Even though such large numbers are hard to be contemplated in our minds, they are all finite.

3. There are some famous large numbers. A Googol is 10^{100} , which is unimaginably large compared to even the number of electrons in the universe (10^{87}). As an aside, the internet company Google was to be named Googol, but someone made a mistake and Google was the name that was given. A Googolplex is a whopper; it is 10^{Googol} or $10^{(10^{100})}$. There are many such “famous large numbers”.

- Yet, you can add one to any of these large numbers and always get a bigger number. Therefore, no number, however large, is still finite.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?list=PLsKaiDrVVQ-cBtqojFyPyAedPvIC8lrHE&v=0lFQOmb6mVs&x-yt-ts=1422579428&feature=player_embedded&x-yt-cl=85114404

4. So, the mathematicians coined the term “infinity” to denote an indefinitely great number; The word comes from the Latin infinitas or “unboundedness”. Since infinity is uncountable, it has some strange characteristics: whatever you add to (or multiply by) an infinity (even if it is another infinity), you still end up with infinity.

- The famous German mathematician David Hilbert illustrated the “abnormal” properties associated with infinity using the idea of a “infinity hotel”, which has an infinite number of rooms. The “infinity hotel” always has a vacancy: the management can always ask the the person occupying the Nth room to move to the (N+1)th room, (N+1)th room to move to the (N+2)th room, and so on, and thus give the Nth room to the new guest. In fact, even if an infinite number of new guests arrive, the hotel can accommodate all of them!

5. This is not to say that infinity is a useless or bogus concept. The arguments described above are totally valid. Mathematicians cannot do many integrations without infinity. Physicists use infinity all the time (but they try to end up with finite physical values). The concept of infinity is real (and weird).

For example, a line of any finite length has an infinite number of points, whether it is an inch in length or thousand miles in length. Invention of calculus by Newton and Leibniz helped handling some of the problems arising from such situations.

6. In the physical sense, infinity is a rather vague concept meaning, “larger than anything that could in principle be encompassed by experience”. For example, space is infinite, and as far as our sophisticated instruments allow us to “see”, there is no end.

- Our universe is possibly infinite in extent, since the scientists can “see” only to a finite extent. Besides there are possibly infinite numbers of universes as well. So, the space is infinite.
- What about time? If our universe started at the Big Bang, that inflationary theory says there are multiple, parallel universes. According to the “cyclic theory” model, which is an alternate theory, the same same universe comes to a “Big Crunch” which leads to another Big Bang, and whole process keeps repeating. So, there is no beginning to time either; time is infinite.

7. The Buddha used a great aeon as the measurement unit to help his followers visualize the enormous length of sansara. The length of a great aeon (*maha kalpa* or *maha kappa*) is said by the Buddha to be longer than the time it would take a man to wear away a mountain of solid granite one *yojana* (about 7 miles) around and one *yojana* high, by stroking it once every hundred years with a silk cloth. These days scientists use the word “aeon” to denote the duration of a universe (from the “big bang” either to a “big crunch” or just fading away).

- Just for fun, I estimated the mass of the material that needs to be removed by the silk cloth each time (this happens every 100 years). Using a 7 mile cube of stone with a density of 2515 kg per cubic meter, I calculate the mass of the mountain to be 3.5×10^6 kg. Assuming the lifetime of our universe to be 30 billion years, I calculate the mass removed by each stroke is about 12 grams or about 0.4 ounces. This appears to be a reasonable number! So, a kalpa in Buddhism turns out to be approximately an aeon as perceived by the scientists. When we try to visualize the wearing off a mountain we can imagine how long a time period that is. Yet, that is still nothing compared to the length of the samsara. As I said, infinity is a concept that is hard to wrap one’s mind around!

8. One day the Bhikkhus asked the Buddha how many great aeons had already passed and gone by. The Buddha told them, “Suppose, Bhikkhus, there were four disciples here each with a lifespan of hundred years, and each day they were each to recollect a hundred thousand great aeons. There would still be great aeons not yet recollected by them when those four disciples pass away at the end of hundred years. Because, Bhikkhus, this sansara is without discoverable beginning”.

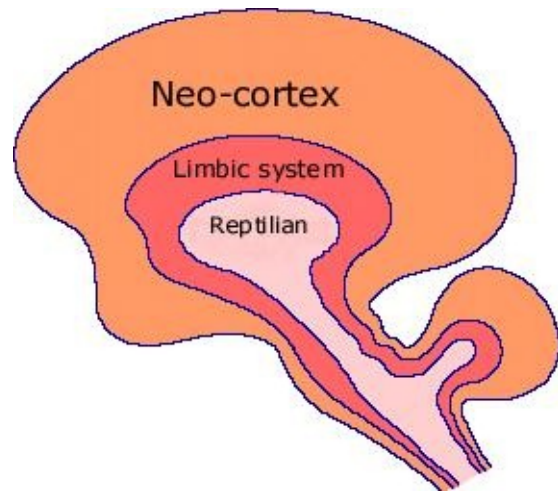
- An interesting book that talks about such hard to grasp ideas (in science) involving infinity is, “The Beginning of Infinity: Explanations That Transform the World” by David Deutsch.

9. Here is a bit longer video on why it is not possible to discover either spatial boundaries of our universe or find a “beginning” to time, because universes come into existence all the time.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?x-yt-ts=1422579428&feature=player_embedded&v=yaX4iGw-b_Y&x-yt-cl=85114404&list=PLsKaiDrVVQ-cBtqojFyPyAedPvIC8lrHE

Truine Brain: How the Mind Rewires the Brain via Meditation/Habits

Human brain, which is the most advanced for all animals, shows how different animals have “different levels” of consciousness. It has three distinctive regions (see the figure below): (1) brain stem (labelled “reptilian” in the figure), (2) limbic system, (3) cerebral cortex or just cortex (labelled “neo-cortex” in the figure).



1. The brain stem (lizard or reptilian brain) evolved first and all developed animals have it. It governs automatic physiological functions such as the heart rate, respiration, digestion, etc.

2. The limbic system (sometimes called the midbrain) is the emotional command center; that evolved in the next evolutionary phase in animals with higher intelligence. It coordinates sensory reception, memory, and unconscious emotional reactions. Most animals just react spontaneously to external influences.

- Humans tend to do that too. In case of a threat, the “fight or flight” decision is made instantaneously by the limbic system.
- It is quite clear from the definition of an Arahant that even this instantaneous response can be completely tamed by meditation.

3. The cerebral cortex (learning brain; neo-cortex in the figure) is the most recently evolved part of the brain; it can make “rational decisions” by contemplation but it is time delayed. This it is called the “thinking brain”. The cortex is responsible for language capability, logic, reasoning, learning and critical thinking, the good stuff. All primates have it, but of course the humans have the largest.

- A developed left brain (of the neo-cortex) indicates compassion for others and enhanced happiness for oneself, and a relatively larger right side indicates aggressive character.
- Here is a video clip showing the results of brain scans of an advanced meditator who had done loving kindness meditation for a long period of time compared to 150 non-meditators. As you can see, the data point for the meditator is way off the “Bell curve” to the left. The presenter of the video is Matthieu Ricard, a former French Biochemist who has become a Tibetan Monk.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?feature=player_embedded&v=vbLEf4HR74E

The full video can be found at: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vbLEf4HR74E>

4. Until about late 1980’s there was wide belief that one had just to live with the brain that one was

born with. But since then the ability of the brain to change (neuroplasticity of the brain) has been demonstrated and studies on the effects of meditation on the brain has become an active research field.

- Of course, 2500 years ago the Buddha said that mind is the precursor to everything, and that any body part (including the brain) is controlled by the mind. The mind does not arise from the brain; the mind controls the brain.

5. There is compelling scientific evidence that meditation improves both the cortex and the limbic system (see the references from scientific community below).

- Even the basic samatha meditation helps, but metta Bhavana (compassion meditation) is particularly effective.
- We also know that meditation affects breathing patterns (thus the brain stem). so the overall brain function is affected by meditation. An Arahant can stop breathing for up to 7 days in Nirodha Samapatti. It will be extremely interesting to see a brain scan of an Arahant.

6. Neural pathways in the brain are strengthened by:

- Repeated application (meditation included). Repeated activity forms both good and bad habits as we discussed in several posts, and is the key in molding the character (gathi); see, “[The Law of Attraction – Habits, Character \(Gathi\), Cravings \(Asavas\)](#)“, and other related posts.
- Dopamine (and other good chemical) production is enhanced by omega 3 and other good foods, and exercise, including interval running.
- Exercise and meditate! It will keep you healthy and alert.

7. Furthermore, it is clear that we are not programmed by our genes, environment, or even our past kamma, even though all these can affect our destiny. The most powerful is our mind, i.e., citta niyama can even dominate kamma niyama. As the saying goes, “you can do anything that you put your mind to”. This is the true basis of free will.

8. Even though the scientists are making some headways regarding the mind, brain is not mind, just as the physical eye is not the eye indriya; see, “[Manomaya Kaya and Physical Body](#)“, and other related posts. Yet it is essential to keep the physical eye (and other senses) as well as the brain in good condition for the whole body and the mind to work properly.

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Next, “[How Habits are Formed and Broken – A Scientific View](#)“,

How Habits are Formed and Broken – A Scientific View

1. We are lucky to be in an age when many of the Buddha's teachings are not only confirmed but also strongly supported with additional evidence that were not possible during the time of the Buddha. Here is another instance where the evidence is coming from research on the workings of the brain.

2. The Buddha basically said to follow the following procedure to break a bad habit and to instill a good habit:

1. (i) understand the reasons why a certain habit is bad,
2. (ii) stop engaging in activities that enhances the habit,
3. (iii) deviate the mind from such bad activities by focusing on opposing good activities,
4. (iv) contemplate on the “release” or “cooling down” that has already resulted by following the above procedure, strengthen the resolve to stay on course, and keep doing (i) through (iii).

With time, the bad habit(s) will go away and the good habit(s) will take hold. There comes a time when one will automatically follow this procedure; it becomes a “way of life”.

3. The reasoning behind is based on the key factors that we discussed in the previous posts:

- We do many things automatically (i.e., without being mindful or without deliberate thinking); these are done via our habits that we formed during this life or even coming from previous lives.
- There are both good and bad habits. We want to keep and cultivate good habits and discard bad habits.
- Changing (cultivating) habits first require some “external adjustments” like one's physical environment, friends, etc and, more importantly, the four steps listed above.

4. Beginning in the early 1990's or so, scientific investigations in several fields (effects of meditation on the brain, behavioral studies on animals and humans, neurology, etc) have come to similar conclusions. We will discuss these in detail in the future, but here I want to just point out the main similarities. Furthermore, discussing how the mechanism takes place in the brain provides an alternative way to visualize these changes. We are indeed fortunate to live at a time when we have evidence from science to provide additional evidence.

5. As I pointed out in the posts on the *manomaya kaya* and physical body, our physical body is “prepared” by the *kamma* seed that was the cause for this life. But the *manomaya kaya* is constantly making “adjustments” to the physical body based on the current status of the mind.

- Many *kamma vipaka* are “built-in” even at the conception; some may be avoidable by taking care of the body (exercise, food, etc), and the mind (contemplation, meditation, etc), but some may not be avoidable because they are so strong: We will never know when a cancer, an accident, or even a natural calamity can drastically change our lives; this is *anicca*, “the inability to maintain our lives the way we would like to”.
- Thus we need to spend at least sometime to work towards a meaningful solution to the “problem of existence”.
- Another factor we need to remember is that our “*sansaric* habits” are built-in to our brain. We

keep changing/adding such habits as we grow up, influenced by our family, friends, and the society in general. Thus one's "character" (*gathi*) are in constant flux, either by choice or influenced by the environment.

6. This is a key point: We need to make sure that we do not "go with the flow", i.e., let past kamma or our environment determine our future.

- As humans, we have the capability to change our destiny. We DO HAVE free will, unlike an animal. Since we do not know what our next existence is going to be, we need to make sure to get on the "right path" as soon as possible.
- This may sound like a broken record, but 100 years of this life is NOTHING compared to millions and billions of years life in "unknown territory" in the future; thus we need to make use of this opportunity.

7. As we discussed in the "[Truine Brain – How the Mind Rewires the Brain via Meditation/Habits](#)", only the humans have a developed neocortex, that makes possible 'thinking, and decision making'. The animals either do not have it, or have a primitive version of it.

- Therefore, the animals basically only use the "mid brain" or the "limbic system", where decisions are made FOR THEM according to their ingrained habits that have evolved over many, many lives (as we discussed, the physical body is formed based on the manomaya kaya). The response from the limbic system is instantaneous, and the animals can only REACT to external stimuli.
- All *sansaric* habits are built-in to the limbic system, and the animals react according to the way the limbic system is wired up; this may change some during growing up due to external environment, but the main "character qualities" (*gathi*) do not change very much. That is why you see adorable dogs as well as vicious dogs. Even our pets have "a personality".
- WE can change their personalities by teaching them things, but they are unable to do it on their own. It is easier to "teach" more evolved animals like monkeys because they have a bit of a neocortex.

8. But we humans have a neocortex that is well-developed and is capable of much more than we normally believe it to be capable of. **It is this neocortex that makes us, humans, different from animals (actually, it is more accurate to say that "our current *bhava*" is superior to an "animal *bhava*").**

- Even though we also REACT first, especially to a threatening stimuli, our "thinking brain" starts to kick in quickly, especially with training. Many people get into trouble because they are "REACTIVE", i.e., they do not try to develop the habit of using the "thinking brain".
- But we can be PROACTIVE. We can teach ourselves to "take corrective actions" even if we do some things on impulse. Even if the initial reaction to a sudden temptation is to "take it and enjoy it" or "hit him" or "kill that annoying dog", we can always take a breath, stop ourselves, and think about the consequences of such actions. This is what we call "mindfulness".
- Some people are more proactive than others even at birth (via *sansaric* habits). Some people change from being reactive to proactive or other way around even without knowing due to the particular environment they grow up in.
- The key point is that we can WILLFULLY change from being reactive to proactive; we all are

reactive at least to some stimuli: the one's we have "*tanha*" for! In other words, we like to get attached to certain things and like to dislike other things with PASSION; see, "[Tanha – How we Attach via Greed, Hate, and Ignorance](#)".

9. In terms of science the key is in the neurons in the brain, and how we can train our neocortex to fire the right sets of neurons more frequently. The "frontal lobes" of the neocortex is the command center for brain activities.

- The frontal lobes can be visualized as the boss. If it is a lazy boss, it will just assign duties to the limbic system to carry out things "as usual".
- But if the boss is energetic and always looking for ways to "improve things", then it will start investigating new approaches. And once better approaches are found, it will get them "hard wired" and they will essentially become the "new limbic system".
- This is the key to "developing a new you" by discarding bad habits and developing good habits. Essentially you need to get the frontal lobes to be an active, energetic boss for the brain.

10. Dr. Jeffrey Schwartz is a psychiatrist specializing in treating Obsessive Compulsive Disorders (OCD), and has pioneered in using "habit makeovers" to treat OCD. He has written several books, but I highly recommend the two books, "The Mind and the Brain" and "You are not Your Brain".

He has developed a "Four Step" method to change one's habits that give rise to OCD:

1. Identify the problem area.
2. Recognize the need to change.
3. Deviate from automatically "going along" with old ways and re-direct attention to "new paths".
4. Re-assess the situation, and keep working on accelerating the process.

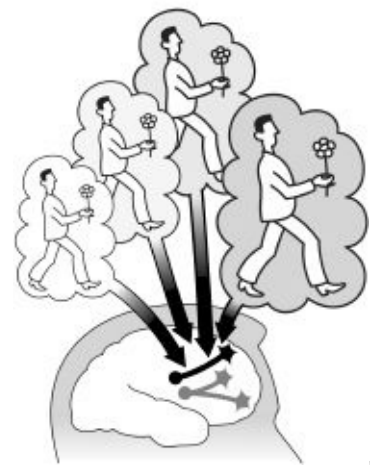
11. He has kept records of brain scans of his patients which clearly show the improvements in the brain with time, and of course most patients are able to get rid of their compulsive behavior.

- The key is to slow down the "firing of neurons" associated with a bad habit and to increase the firing of neurons associated with an opposing good habit.
- There is a rule called Hebb's rule that says, 'neurons that fire together, wire together'. The more one keeps doing a certain activity, a set of neurons start to fire together and that neural connection gets stronger by the day. It is just like strengthening one's arm by "doing more liftings" with it.
- In the same way, when one is decreasing the use of a certain activity, the set of neurons allocated for that activity gets weaker, fewer neurons participate, and eventually it loses being a habitual act.

12. Here is a figure from Dr. Schwartz's book, "The Mind and the Brain" (p. 362), that illustrates the "re-wiring" of a new network in the brain and the concomitant weakening of a network for an undesirable habit (click to open it):



4 The quantum rules allow both states—“release” and “don’t release”—to co-exist. Early in therapy, however, the wave representing “release neurotransmitter” in the OCD circuit has a higher probability than the wave representing “release neurotransmitter” in the garden circuit. The patient is much more likely to go to the sink.



5 By expending mental effort and thus unleashing mental force, however, the OCD patient is able, by virtue of the laws of quantum mechanics, to change the odds. Focusing attention on the “garden” thought increases the probability that neurotransmitter will be released in that circuit, not the “wash” circuit.

6 The OCD patient can now act on this thought and go to the garden. This increases the chance that, in the future, the “garden” circuit will prevail over the “wash” circuit.



7 If the patient regularly goes to the garden instead of the sink, neuroplasticity kicks in: brain metabolism changes in a way that strengthens the therapeutic circuit. As a result, future OCD urges are easier to overcome.

[Habit Formation Figure \(PDF file\)](#)

This figure explains how a patient who had an obsessive disorder to constantly wash his hand, got rid of that habit by **WILLFULLY** stepping outside to the garden when he got the urge to wash hands. As he kept doing it, the wiring to “wash hands” got weakened, and instead wiring for “stepping outside” got stronger, and eventually he lost the compulsive urge to wash his hands too often.

13. The same principle has been used to get rid of such annoying habits as well as serious disorders.

We can use the same procedure to stay away from immoral habits and cultivating moral habits; this is the basis of “*anapana*“, see, “[Key to Anapanasati – How to Change Character and Habits \(Gathi\)](#)“.

Second Law of Thermodynamics is Part of Anicca!

1. As we saw in the post, "[Anicca – True Meaning](#)", *anicca* describes one of the three basic characteristics of "this world", namely no matter how hard we try, "we cannot maintain things to our satisfaction in the long term".

2. What does the Second Law of Thermodynamics say? It basically says, "things in a closed system go from order to disorder, unless energy is put into the system to keep the order". Thus we can maintain a sort of stability (or "keep things the way we like them to be") by striving or working hard.

- But as we get old, our ability to do this wanes, and ultimately we become too weak to do anything or just die. It does not matter how much money we have accumulated. All sense pleasures lose their vigor as the body gets old, and money or will power cannot maintain them.
- A successful business person could say, "look at all the wealth that I created. I have achieved what I wanted". It is actually a good accomplishment, but can he really enjoy all that in the long term? Even all that money cannot maintain a simple thing like taste of food when he gets really old, not to mention the fact that all that wealth will be left behind at death.
- However, when we are young, it SEEMS that we CAN maintain things to our satisfaction. This is why it is hard to explain *anicca* to a young person. A young boy will say, "look at the muscles I built over the past year by working out at the gym! I am invincible". A young woman will say, "I look much more beautiful now than I was a year ago".
- Yet, blossoming at around twenty or so years is just the beginning of a slippery slope. In the end all those strong muscles will fade, and the beautiful figure will sag and decay. That is the reality.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?x-yt-ts=1422579428&v=Vv1J29jP4xY&x-yt-cl=85114404&feature=player_embedded

3. We can see the effects of the Second Law of Thermodynamics at different levels. A nice hot cup of coffee will cool down with time and we will have to re-heat to enjoy it again. An ice cream bowl will melt if not kept cold by putting it in the refrigerator which uses energy to run.

- Mom will come and clean a child's room, only to find the next day that it is back to the chaotic state; she will need to go through all that work again to get it back to presentable condition.
- We build a house with a nice garden, only to find that we will have to do repairs to the house and much work is needed to keep the weeds out of the garden and grass cut, etc.
- The Sun will power our planet for another few billion years, and then it will die. Long before the Sun dies, the Earth will get destroyed.
- Even our universe will "run down" in 15 billion or so more years.

4. Thus we can see that the concept of *anicca* is a universal characteristic of "anything that belongs to this world", which includes 29 more realms than the two realms that we can actually experience (the human and animal realms): Things can be maintained EVEN WITH EFFORT only up to a certain time, and NOT forever.

- The Second Law of Thermodynamics describes the impermanence or the "root cause" for *anicca*. Even though the scientists understand this impermanence, they do not necessarily PERCEIVE that in their minds. This is the difference between "impermanence" and *anicca*.

- Thus, like those young people mentioned above, we all have the wrong PERCEPTION that “we can maintain things to our satisfaction”, i.e., we have the wrong perception of nicca, not the actual reality of *anicca*.

5. Even when our universe die, there are many that come into existence. This process has been going on for eternity, and so have we. We have been in the rebirth process for ever. The problem is that most of those lives were not as good as this one; we have suffered unimaginably, and unless we get out of this predicament, such future suffering is not avoidable.

6. But the good news is that our minds can become free of this non-stop rebirth process by decoupling from this unstable material base. We are reborn in this “material world” because of our perception of “nicca”, i.e., we believe that we CAN find some suitable place with permanent happiness in this world. Once we grasp the reality of “*anicca*”, our minds will automatically start becoming free and we will start feeling the niramisa sukha arising from this detachment from the material world; see, “[The Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)”.

- This is another way to look at the reality and our choices.

The Double Slit Experiment – Correlation between Mind and Matter?

1. The failure of a materialistic approach to explain consciousness (i.e., attempts to explain mental phenomena arising from a brain that is composed of inert matter) is becoming ever more apparent; see Refs. 1 and 2 below.
2. A number of scientists/philosophers are hoping that quantum mechanics can come to the rescue (Ref. 3,4). They say that even though deterministic Newtonian mechanics is unable to explain consciousness, quantum mechanics can, because quantum mechanics does not have such an apparent deterministic nature.
3. Quantum mechanics (QM) is different from other branches of physics where one can get the intuitive idea of what is taking place. What we do with QM can be called a “black box” approach: when we apply the correct equations, we get the right results. Einstein did not like this at all. Yet, to his frustration, all his predictions of the inadequacy of QM did not materialize AND the predictions of QM have been correct to an amazing accuracy.
4. Those experiments, the results of which can only be explained by QM, APPEAR to be non-deterministic in nature; this has compelled some scientists to investigate whether there is a connection between QM and the mind, which IS non-deterministic. Two experiments in particular have been at the forefront of these discussions: the “double-slit experiment” and the “Schrödinger’s cat experiment”.
5. My intent in this essay is to challenge the two prominent assumptions on this postulated relationship between QM and the mind:
 1. Even if QM and the mind are non-deterministic in their own rights, there is no special reason to believe that there is an apparent connection between them, and
 2. There is nothing really “non-deterministic” about QM, other than the indeterminacy depicted by the Heisenberg uncertainty principle; that is just on the accuracy of a given measurement.
6. Let us look into (i) first. Henry Stapp is a leading physicist who argues that quantum theory will ultimately provide an explanation for consciousness. In his book, “Mindful Universe” he says (p.2), “... quantum theory itself is intrinsically psychophysical as designed by its founders, and as used in actual scientific practice, it is ultimately a theory about the structure of our experience that is erected upon a radical mathematical generalization of the laws of classical physics”.
 - My basic point is that quantum theory is NOT psychophysical; there is no way to accommodate “subjectivity” in QM. Where is the “mind connection” in the theory of QM?
 - There are others who work on theories that try to explain consciousness as arising from quantum effects in the brain; see, for example, “Conversations on Consciousness”, by Susan Blackmore (2006). No one has clarified how these theories make the connection between “psyche” and “physical” in “psychophysical”.
7. Let us review one experiment that has become the main demonstration for the “observer effect” in QM, the “double-slit experiment”. Here is a short video by Dr Quantum to illustrate the “paradox” of the double slit experiment:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=e_hGZVZds20&x-yc-cl=85114404&feature=player_embedded

8. The two main points of this experiment are:

1. the particles behave like waves when both slits are open, and
2. this “wave nature” goes away when the path of the particle is “observed” or monitored.

9. There is a version of QM called the Bohmian theory or the Pilot Wave theory that was developed by the late David Bohm. It does use the Schrodinger’s equation which is used to track the propagation of a “pilot wave”, and the theory is explicitly nonlocal, i.e., quantum entanglement is built-in. With this theory, each solution of the wave equation describes a DETERMINISTIC path for the particle, and statistical average agrees with the experiments and the results of the standard QM calculations.

- The actual trajectories have been harder to measure not because of a “mind effect”, but because an observation can disturb the particle trajectory itself. Recent experiments have been conducted to “weakly” measure a system without appreciably disturbing the trajectories, and have been shown to be consistent with the predictions of Bohmian theory (Ref. 5).

Thus the role played by Bohmian mechanics in these “QM experiments” is just like role statistical mechanics played in thermodynamics.

Here is a very short video of the INDIVIDUAL trajectories for a double-slit experiment calculated using the Bohmian theory. There is nothing “mysterious”: each particle has a definite trajectory; quantum aspects comes via the “guiding wave”:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?feature=player_embedded&v=CAwEPLWe7jM&x-yt-ts=1422579428&x-yt-cl=85114404

- When it is attempted to observe the path of an individual particle, the coherence of the system or the pilot wave is disturbed and the interference pattern goes away. Thus there is no “observer effect”, in the sense of bringing “subjectivity” in.

10. Another famous experiment that has been the subject of much discussion is the “Schrödinger’s cat” thought experiment. This experiment suggested by Schrödinger back in 1935, involves a cat in a closed chamber. A radioactive sample in the chamber, if undergoes decay within a given period of time, triggers the release of a hammer that breaks a vial of a toxic gas that kills the cat. If conscious observation is required to collapse the wave function, then the fate of the cat is not known until the box is opened. Unfortunately, both the consciousness-based and consciousness-free interpretations of quantum measurement are indistinguishable to the observer outside the box.

- In 2006, an actual experiment was conducted to simulate this experiment. It was reported that, “...measurement alone, rather than conscious observation of a measurement, is sufficient”; see Ref. 6.

11. Thus there is no real “observer effect” in the double slit experiments or in the Schrödinger cat experiment.

- In the double-slit experiment, what an “observer” does is to disturb the coherence of the system, if the disturbance is strong. It does not matter whether the “observer” is human or a mechanical device (in most cases it is non-human); one ALWAYS gets the same result. This is in contrast to real subjective situations, like in the stock market, where complex subjective decisions are made by thousands of people.
- So, where does the “objectivity” or “intention” – in the sense of the mind affecting the

experimental result – comes from? “Intent to monitor” is not really a significant subjective decision; just a simple “yes” or “no”.

12. Therefore, it is clear that there was no evidence for “subjectivity” in those experiments even before Bohmian mechanics or the Schrödinger’s cat experiment; those two pieces of evidence really make that point undeniable. There is no evidence of the mind affecting the outcomes of those experiments.

13. Even though mind affects matter and even CREATE matter, science has not advanced enough yet to confirm that. There has to be a paradigm change: [any theory based on matter and attempt to treat mental phenomena as a byproduct will not succeed](#). Mind is the more fundamental entity; mind takes precedence over matter.

- Some philosophers are beginning to sense this reality. Even though he does not appear to know anything about Buddha Dhamma, philosopher Thomas Nagel says: “The great advances in the physical and biological sciences were made possible by excluding the mind from the physical world....But at some point it will be necessary to make a new start on a more comprehensive understanding that includes the mind”. (Ref 1, p.8). Then on p. 15, “...The possibility opens up of a persuasive conception of the natural order very different from materialism – one that makes mind central, rather than a side effect of physical law”.

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Historical Background

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Historical Background – Introduction

Today, we have three main “sects” of “Buddhism” that include the Theravada Buddhism in Sri Lanka, Burma, Thailand, and few other South Asian countries, Mahayana Buddhism in the form Zen in Japan, China, and several other Asian countries, and Vajrayana Buddhism in Tibet. All sects are being practiced in other countries in varying degrees. How the original teachings of the Buddha got branched out over 2500 years is discussed in, “[Historical Timeline of Edward Conze](#)”.

The vast literature in Theravada Buddhism, which is contained in the Tipitaka (three baskets of Sutta, Vinaya, and Abhidhamma) are mostly self-consistent. Considering the vastness of the material in these documents, the consistency is amazing, and gives one confidence that any “contamination” would be small indeed.

When one reads the **correct** Theravada literature, it is quite amazing how consistent the teachings are. It is hard for me to fathom how a normal human being, regardless of how intelligent he is, could teach the doctrine in such different ways over forty five years, yet be so consistent in multiple ways (the discourses range from simple one-to-one question answer sessions with individuals to lengthy discourses delivered to audiences of thousands of people, not to mention the complex Abhidhamma material). Even with the help of a computer, it is hard for me to keep track of the intricacy of Abhidhamma. The complex workings of the mind has been analyzed in multiple ways, and they are all consistent within the Abhidhamma and also with the Suttas.

Teachings of the Buddha, as given in the Theravada Tipitaka, are confirmed and solidified with each new scientific discovery (in contrast, the mythical aspects introduced in various forms of Mahayana Buddhism are facing problems in light of scientific progress). Buddha Dhamma is like a diamond covered in the dirt of ignorance. The more we find about the world through scientific methods (thus removing more dirt from the diamond), the more of the diamond’s luster become apparent. Not too far into the future, Buddha Dhamma will shine brightly and will greatly help the humanity all over the world. It is ironic in a way how the “materialistic science” is helping to clarify and confirm the teachings of the “mind-based” Buddha Dhamma. Yet the humanity is still only enamored with the truly amazing materialistic advances based on scientific discoveries, and is for most part unaware of its primitive stage compared to ultimate knowledge contained in Buddha Dhamma.

The real breakthrough may come when science will be forced to embrace the mind as yet another fundamental property of nature. The discovery of quantum mechanics has clearly laid the foundation for this next breakthrough. It has been more than hundred years since the advent of quantum mechanics, but it is only within the past two to three decades that real progress has been made in this direction. I plan to discuss these developments in detail in the “Dhamma and Science” section.

Next, “[Methods of Delivery of Dhamma by the Buddha](#)“,

Methods of Delivery of Dhamma by the Buddha

1. Buddha Dhamma is undoubtedly the most complex “theory” in the world. It is truly amazing that such a deep philosophical doctrine has survived over 2500 years.
 - However, we can be confident that the pure Dhamma still survives, because the three baskets of *sutta*, *vinaya*, and *abhidhamma* were written down in 29 BCE when there were still numerous *Arahants* were present.
 - After about 100 -200 CE, people started translating the *Tipitaka* into *Sanskrit* and also the *Mahayana* sect started writing their own *suttas* in *Sanskrit*; see, “[Historical Timeline of Edward Conze](#)”.
2. Another important point to remember is that there is no single discourse in which the Buddha has drawn together all the elements of his teaching and assigned them to their appropriate place within some comprehensive system; see, “[Sutta – Introduction](#)”.
 - Therefore, the same material was delivered in a variety of different ways over the 45-year “ministry” of the Buddha. If some mistakes were made in the transmission of one of the *suttas* or discourses, that would become apparent when compared with the numerous other discourses or the *Abhidhamma*.
3. The Buddha tailored his discourses to his audience at hand. Thus his teachings that have been transmitted encompass a broad spectrum, ranging from one-to-one conversations with people who had particular questions in mind, to long discourses to audiences consisting of groups with wide ranging mental capabilities.
 - If the Buddha realized that it was not fruitful to explain a deep concept to an individual, he remained silent. One example cited is Buddha’s silence when a certain wanderer named Vacchagotta asked him whether there was an *atman* or *athma* (permanent soul) or not. Even though Buddha has clearly explained in *Paticca Samuppada* that there is no permanent soul, in this case he remained in silence when Vacchagotta asked him the question twice. After Vacchagotta left, Buddha’s personal attendant, Ven. Ananda, asked him why Buddha did not explain the concept of *anatta* to Vacchagotta. The Buddha told Ananda that he did not think Vacchagotta was mentally capable at that time to understand the concept, and that he did not want to confuse him. It turned out that Vacchagotta later on became a disciple and even attained *Nibbana* through his efforts.
4. Other times, he would enunciate invariable principles that stand at the heart of the teaching: for example, *Abhidhamma* is a complete description of the working of the mind. The Buddha delivered this *Abhidhamma* material in summary form to his chief disciple, Ven. Sariputta, and it was Ven. Sariputta and his followers who expanded that summary to the form that we have today in the *Tipitaka*; see, “[Abhdhamma – Introduction](#)”.
 - But in most cases, instead of trying to provide most thorough and intellectually deep answers, he tried to find the best way to steer people to the truth according to their mental capabilities. Some recent books have misrepresented such isolated one-to-one correspondence as indications that some fundamental issues have not been addressed by the Buddha. They are probably unaware that such questions have been answered in other *suttas*. I will point such instances as they come up in other posts.

Next, “[Misconceptions on the Topics the Buddha “Refused to Answer”](#)“,

Misconceptions on the Topics the Buddha “Refused to Answer”

Coming back to the literature on the Theravada Dhamma, the Buddha seems to have followed four ways of treating questions: (1) Some should be answered directly, (2) others should be answered by way of analyzing them, (3) yet others should be answered by counter-questions, and (4) there are questions that should be put aside. As mentioned in the above section, depending on the audience he chose the method that he deemed was appropriate.

He always told his disciples that they should not waste time worrying about such questions on the universe, since they should be using the precious little time on the Earth in pursuit of Nibbana. So, questions on the characteristics of the universe was one that Buddha chose to put aside in REGULAR question and answer sessions. A good example is when a monk named Malunkayaputta came to the Buddha and asked a number of questions regarding the universe and stated that he will leave the order if the Buddha refuses to answer them. The Buddha’s following answer illustrates the urgency with which he asked the followers to “follow the path” diligently instead of wasting valuable time on metaphysical questions.

The Buddha told Malunkayaputta, “Suppose Malunkayaputta, a man is wounded by a poisoned arrow, and the friends and relatives bring him to a surgeon. Suppose the man should then say: “I will not let this arrow be taken out until I know who shot me; whether he is a Ksatriya or a Brahmana or a Vaisya or a Sudra (i.e., which caste); what his name and family may be; whether he is tall, short, or of medium stature; whether his complexion is black, brown, or golden; from which village, town, or city he comes. I will not let this arrow be taken out until I know the kind of bow with which I was shot; the kind of bowstring used; the type of arrow; what sort of feather was used on the arrow and with what kind of material the point of the arrow was made”. Malunkayaputta, that man would die without knowing any of these things. Even so, Malunkayaputta, if anyone says: “I will not follow the holy life under the Blessed One until he answers these questions such as whether the universe is eternal or not, etc.” he would die with these questions unanswered by the Blessed One”.

We have to look at this from the perspective of the “knowledge base” that existed at the time of the Buddha. Think about the fact that starting with the Greek philosophers at the time of the Buddha (a coincidence), the Western science took over 2500 years to reach the current level of understanding of the universe. Even a mere two hundred years ago, the scientific understanding was limited to the Solar system and basically nothing beyond that. Now we know that there are billions of galaxies, each with billions of stars (most of which have planetary systems like our Solar system), and that all this started with the big bang. This transition was slow and took the genius and courage of people like Galileo who sometimes sacrificed their lives to bring out the truth.

Twenty five hundred years ago, there was no rational way that the Buddha could have “explained” concepts such as the origin of the universe, extent of the universe, etc. Therefore, even though he clearly stated the existence of “innumerable world systems” in order to lay down the basis of consciousness (see “[Consciousness – A Dhamma Perspective](#)”), he refused to discuss such concepts with individuals simply because it would have been a waste of time given the limited base knowledge existed at that time. If the Buddha was teaching his doctrine today, I believe that he would have answered such questions directly, because the vocabulary and background knowledge for doing so is available today.

However, Buddha’s perspectives on the universe is apparent in his teachings on Abhidhamma (and also in some main Suttas). This is because the fundamental aspects of the universe (infinite in space and

time) are inherent in the doctrine. Those principles are embedded in the teachings, but the Buddha avoided giving answers to specific questions, especially from individuals, because it would have totally confused those people.

Some people used examples as mentioned above to state that the Buddha refused to answer any questions related to the origin of the universe or that his position on the existence of a soul was not very clear. That is not the case at all. The Buddha's main concern at any given instance was to provide an answer that the audience at hand was able to comprehend. If the correct answer would have befuddled the audience, he remained silent on that particular question. He has described the evolvement of life on this planet in the Agganna Sutta. But please do not read the published translated versions, because the translations are embarrassingly flawed.

Therefore, one should not come to certain conclusions by reading just a few discourses, and needs to pay attention in what context the discourse was delivered. It is always possible to refer to Abhidhamma to clarify issues, since it is written in a methodical way. So, the texts of the oldest Pali texts contain Buddha's teachings in a variety of forms, ranging from simple interpretations of Dhamma to its very deep philosophical aspects in the Abhidhamma as well as some of the Suttas. Yet the contents in all this vast material remains self-consistent when one examines the contents with the correct perspective. We owe a deep gratitude to the Sangha of Sri Lanka for keeping this material intact.

Next, "[Preservation of the Dhamma](#)"

Misinterpretations of Buddha Dhamma

1. It is said that the Buddha advised not to translate the *Tipitaka* material word-by-word into any other language. Instead, commentaries were written to explain the Pali material in the *Tipitaka* in condensed form fit for listening, retention, recitation, memorization, and repetition – the five major elements in oral transmission.

- This is a very important point. For example, the Buddha orally delivered the main Suttas over many hours; the *Dhamma Cakka Pavattana Sutta* was delivered over several days to the five ascetics. For easy transmission, these discourses were SUMMARIZED in *Magadhi* (and that particular format of “lining up” was termed *Pali*); see, “[Sutta – Introduction](#)”.
- Each line, sometimes even a word in a *Sutta* needs a further explanation; see, “[Satipatthana Sutta – Structure](#)” and follow-up posts. Such “explanatory texts” or “commentaries” were originally written in *Sinhala* and were called “*Sinhala Atthakata*”.
- Commentaries in *Sinhala* accumulated for centuries and in the fourth or fifth century CE, these commentaries were translated to Pali (**and edited with his own ideas incorporated**) by Buddhaghosa. **Subsequently, most of the original *Sinhala* commentaries were lost, and today we only have the edited summaries of Buddhaghosa where he incorporated his own ideas.**
- Fortunately, three of the original commentaries have been preserved in the *Tipitaka*; see, “[Preservation of the Dhamma](#)”.

2. Among the commentaries to the *Tipitaka*, those on the Abhidhamma are dominated by the three commentaries of Buddhaghosa: (i) the *atthasalini*, “The Expositor”, the commentary to the *Dhammasangani*, (ii) the *Sammohavinodani*, “The Dispeller of Delusion”, the commentary to the *Vibhanga*, and (iii) the *Pancappakarana Atthakatha*, the combined commentary to the other five treatises.

- But it must be remembered that Buddhaghosa translated **and edited** only those commentaries that had been written over centuries by Sri Lankan Bhikkhus. **The original *Tipitaka* remains unaltered, including those three original commentaries mentioned above.**

3. In addition to the editing of the commentaries on *Tipitaka* while he was in Sri Lanka, Buddhaghosa also wrote the *Visuddhimagga* (The Path of Purification) around 430 CE, which is considered to be an important treatise on *Theravada* doctrine. This is a comprehensive manual condensing the theoretical and practical teaching of the Buddha, and some consider it to be the most important *Theravada* text outside of the *Tipitaka* Canon of scriptures.

- On the other hand, there have been many Buddhist scholars who have expressed doubts about Buddhaghosa’s interpretations of the *Tipitaka*.
- Among the recent Sri Lankan scholars who have criticized the commentaries of Buddhaghosa, I will point out two important works that I have been studying recently: Venerable Katukurunde Nanananda Thero has written extensively in his *Nibbana* series: <http://www.seeingthroughthenet.net/eng/gen.php?p=1&gp=books&cat=ms>.
- The late Venerable Amatha Gavesi’s sermons can be reviewed at, <http://www.basicbuddhism.org/index.cfm?GPID=80>. Another important work in this context is by the Thai scholar Venerable Bhikkhu Buddhadasa on *Paticca Samuppada* where he severely criticizes the works of Buddhaghosa:

- http://www.vipassati.ch/english/books/Paticcasamuppada-Practical-Dependent-Origination_ebook.html

4. It is important to take these criticisms seriously, since most current *Theravada* institutions teach mainly the works of Buddhaghosa, since those works are supposed to be reliable summaries of the teachings in the *Tipitaka*. Therefore, it is good to have the works of Buddhaghosa reviewed extensively.

- I will point out the most important misrepresentations on this website, based on what I have learned from two Arahants in Sri Lanka. The Dhamma that I present here is, in my opinion, the correct interpretation of the *Tipitaka*. I hope you will come to that conclusion on careful examination of the material.

5. After Emperor Asoka's reign, no further steps were taken to hold back the inevitable *Brahminic* influence on Buddhism in India, and Buddhism went through a gradual decline in India (despite or even because of the resurgent philosophical activity led by Nagarjuna, Asanga, Vasubhanudhu, and others around the beginning of the first millenium) and virtually disappeared from India during the first millenium.

6. The Mahayana version of Buddhism started with the works of Nagarjuna, who, in all likelihood had best intentions for the promotion of Buddhism (even though he was naive enough to assume that Buddha Dhamma can be refined for the "new ages").

- These refinements became major revisions by the time D. T. Suzuki's books were written in the early 1900's, and the original teachings were badly distorted. This is the reason why I am so obsessive about making sure that my essays are compatible with the original teachings of the Buddha.

7. All these distortions in both Mahayana and Theravada versions have their origins in various philosophers (such as Nagarjuna and Buddhaghosa) trying to interpret Buddha Dhamma in terms of mundane concepts; see, "[Buddha Dhamma: Non-Perceivability and Self-Consistency](#)".

- However, as pointed out in that post, it is easy to point out the inconsistencies with such mundane interpretations by Nagarjuana, Buddhaghosa, and others, especially with the evidence gained by the scientific advances made during the past few hundred years.
- And such scientific evidence and the ones that are yet to be discovered will only confirm the pure Dhamma that stays intact in the *Tipitaka* to the day, as also pointed out in that post.

Next, "[Preservation of Dhamma](#)",

Preservation of the Dhamma

1. The Buddha's teaching were handed down mostly verbally from one generation to the next over three to four hundred years before it was written down in a comprehensive manner. The reason that it survived almost fully in content is due to the way it was composed into a form that is suitable for easy verbal transmission, in SUMMARY form. I will discuss this point in detail below.

2. The discourses of the Buddha that were delivered in Magadhi were condensed and written down; this written form was called Pali. But Pali does not have its own script, so it was written down with Sinhala script.

- **This provides a clear way of sorting out the Mahayana literature, which was written in Sanskrit, and never written in Pali; thus all the Sanskrit suttas were written by Mahayanic philosophers.**
- Around the turn of the first millennium, translations of the Tipitaka to Chinese and subsequently to Tibetan also took place. Thus the original manuscripts in Pali can be expected to contain most of the original discourses delivered by the Buddha.

3. Today, it is hard to fathom (especially for Westerners) that such level of accuracy could have been maintained in a verbally-transmitted material. However, we need to understand the background traditions and also the determination of the monks over thousands of years that helped preserve most of the original teachings. Actually, another major reason for the assembly of the First Buddhist Council within three months of the Buddha's Parinibbana was to organize the vast material. Within the next two hundred years, two more Councils were held to recite and verify the teachings.

4. **A critical point here is that a sutta is a CONDENSED version of a discourse.** For example, the Dhamma Cakka Pavattana sutta was delivered to the five ascetics overnight. Imagine how many written pages that would be if written verbatim! Yet it was summarized in a few pages. The same is true for all the important suttas. Otherwise it would have been impossible to transmit all those thousands of suttas.

- [The Buddha delivered most of his discourses in the Maghadhi \(maghadhi = “maga” + “adhi” or Noble path\) language.](#) Tipitaka was written in Pali with Sinhala script; Pali is a version of Maghadhi suitable for writing down oral discourses in summary form suitable for transmission.
- Each Pali word is packed with lot of information, and thus commentaries (called “attha katha”) were written to expound the meaning of important Pali words.
- **Thus the Tipitaka was meant to be used with the commentaries.**
- Most of those Sinhala commentaries were burned down in the Anuradhapura era; see, [“Historical Timelines of Buddha Dhamma and Sri Lanka – The End of Sinhala Commentaries”](#).
- [Fortunately, three original commentaries written by the main disciples of the Buddha \(Ven. Sariputta, Ven. Kaccayana, etc\) during the time of the Buddha had been included in the Tipitaka \(in the *Khuddhaka Nikaya*\), and thus survived. The current revival of pure Dhamma by the two Theros in Sri Lanka is partially due to their perusal of these three documents \(Patisambhidamagga, Petakopadesa, and Nettippakarana\).](#)

5. With the loss of most of the commentaries and the non-prominence of the surviving three

commentaries mentioned above, people started translating the Tipitaka word by word. The problem was compounded by the increase usage of the Sanskrit language beginning around the first century CE.

- For example, “*anicca*” was translated first to Sanskrit as “anitya” and then the same Sanskrit word “anitya” was ADOPTED as the Sinhala translation for *anicca*. Similarly, “*anatta*” was translated to Sanskrit as “anathma” and again was adopted as the Sinhala word for “*anatta*”. **This itself has been responsible for preventing millions of people attaining Nibbana for all these years.**
- [The Buddha had foreseen this and warned not to translate the Tipitaka to ANY LANGUAGE, and particularly to Sanskrit.](#) There were two Brahmins by the names of Tepula and Yameru who were experts on the Vedic Texts; they became bhikkhus and asked the Buddha whether they should translate the suttas to Sanskrit. That is when the Buddha admonished them that Sanskrit was a language with musical overtones developed by the high-minded Brahmins and thus it was not possible to convey the true meanings of Maghadhi words in Sanskrit.
- Another good example is the translation of paticca samuppada to Sanskrit as Pratītyasamutpāda; see, [“Paticca Samuppada – “Pati+ichcha”+”Sama+uppāda”](#). I think it is NOT POSSIBLE to translate some key Pali words to Sanskrit or English or any other language without losing the true meaning. This is the reason that I am going to just keep the original words in some cases and just explain what it is; also see, [“Annantara and Samanantara Paccaya”](#) or words like tanha and Nibbana.

6. One grave problem we have today is the many people try to translate a given sutta word by word to another language. Thus the Dhamma Cakka Pavattana sutta that we mentioned above is translated to a few pages. That is why most of the existing translations are inadequate at best and erroneous in most cases, [“Sutta – Introduction”](#).

7. Finally, just before the Sinhala commentaries were burned down, Buddhaghosa translated AND EDITED those commentaries back to Pali in his Visuddhimagga and other books. Even though he had made many errors (like including kasina meditation and substituting the anapanasati bhavana with “breath meditation”), he had actually used the words *anicca* and *anatta* in the Pali version of the Visuddhimagga. Thus the incorrect translations of the words “*anicca*” and “*anatta*” cannot be attributed to him; it happened long before him probably in the first to second century CE.

Timeline of Preparation of Dhamma Suitable for Transmission

[The following a summary of the technical details that may not be of interest to many. It is for the sake of completeness.](#)

Shortly after the Buddha passed away, Elder Mahakassapa, the *de facto* head of the Sangha, selected five hundred monks, all Arahants (those who have attained Nibbana), to meet and compile an authoritative version of the teachings. This first Buddhist council was held three months after the Parinibbana at Rajagaha the capital of Magadha. The *cullavagga*, one of the books of the Pali *Vinaya Pitaka*, gives an account of how the authorized texts were compiled at the First Buddhist Council: On the basis of Venerable Upali’s recitation of *Vinaya*, the *Vinaya Pitaka*, the compilation on disciplinary matters was compiled. Venerable Ananda then recited “the Dhamma” or the Sutta Pitaka, i.e., the discourses, and on the basis of this recitation the *Sutta Pitaka*, the Compilation of Discourses, was compiled (Venerable Ananda was supposed to have an amazing memory and had memorized all the Suttas preached by the Buddha). The *Abhidhamma* was rehearsed by all the Arahants present at the

Council. Although parts of the *Abhidhamma* were recited at these earlier Buddhist Councils, it was not until the Third Council that it became fixed into its present form as the third and final *Pitaka* of the Canon.

The proceedings of the Third Council compiled by the Moggaliputta-tissa thera in the Kathavatthu, that became part of the *Tipitaka* (Three Baskets). It was during the Third Council that the final version of the Tipitaka (as available today) was compiled. It finalized the *Abhidhamma pitaka*, and added several books on the *Khuddhaka Nikaya*, in addition to the *Kathavatthu*.

The composition of the Tipitaka is as follows:

1. The Vinaya Pitaka is composed of five books: Major Offenses (Prajika Pali), Minor Offenses (Pacittiya Pali), Greater Section (Mahavagga Pali), Smaller Section (Culavagga Pali), and Epitome of the Vinaya (Parivara Pali).
2. The Sutta Pitaka consists of five Nikayas: Digha Nikaya (Collection of Long Discourses), Majjhima Nikaya (Collection of Middle-Length Courses), Samutta Nikaya (Collection of Kindred Sayings), Angutta Nikaya (Collection of Discourses arranged in accordance with number), and Khuddaka Nikaya (Smaller Collection).
3. The Abhidharma Pitaka consists of the following seven books: Dhamma Sangani (Classification of Dharmas), Vibhanga (The Book of Divisions), Kathavatthu (Points of Controversy) which was actually compiled by venerable Moggaliputta Tissa at the Third Buddhist Council, Puggala Pannatti (Description of Individuals), Dhatukatha (Discussion with Reference to Elements), Yamaka (The Book of the Pairs), and Patthana (The Book of Relations).

Again, all these 31 books are collectively termed the *Tipitaka* (Three Baskets) or the Pali Canon.

It is this enlarged Canon completed at the Third Council that was committed to writing in Sri Lanka in the first century BCE (29 BCE) at the Aluvihara Monastery at the Fourth Buddhist Council. The material in Pali was written down in Sinhala language (Pali does not have its own script). This huge collection was written down on palm leaves with a stilo, a pointed steel dagger-like instrument, which scratched the letters into the soft leaves. An ink made from berries was rubbed over the whole page and then gently removed, so that only the indentations retained the color. It is said that Tipitaka was also written down on gold leaves as well.

It must be mentioned that Theravada Buddhism was brought to Burma and Thailand from Sri Lanka in the first century CE; over the next two centuries it diffused into adjoining countries of Thailand, Laos, and Cambodia, and survives in its purity in those countries as well to the present day. (In Cambodia, the Khemer Rouge regime in the 1970's massacred most of the monks, and the Buddha Dhamma is virtually extinct).

While the *Sangha* (with the aid of most of the kings) in Sri Lanka took pride and honor in keeping the teachings intact, Buddhism went through many changes in India, as well as in China, Japan, and Tibet, and then finally disappeared altogether from India around 1200 CE.

Even though the Tipitaka was also written down in India, the canonical collections belonging to the most of the early mainstream Indian Buddhist schools were lost when Indian Buddhism was devastated by the Muslims that invaded northern India in the eleventh and twelfth centuries. So, it was extremely fortunate that the Tipitaka was kept intact in Sri Lanka. This collection of *Tipitaka*, or the Pali Canon, is considered by Theravada Buddhists as the word of Buddha.

Next, “[Historical Timeline of Edward Conze](#)“,

Historical Timeline of Edward Conze

Edward Conze was a Mahayana scholar, and translated the Mahayana Prajnaparamita or *Perfection of Wisdom* sutras from original Sanskrit to English. See, http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Edward_Conze

(It must be noted that any Sanskrit suttas are Mahayana suttas that were composed by Mahayana philosophers like Nagarjuna (who were just intellectuals, and not Arahants) and are NOT original suttas delivered by the Buddha).

Conze was impressed with those Mahayana suttas, and in the book, “On Indian Mahayana Buddhism” (1968) he compiled works of the Mahayana/Zen scholar D. T. Suzuki. Even though his bias towards Mahayana suttas are clear, I selected his timeline which clearly shows how Mahayana scholars wrote their own suttas and tried later to attribute those to the Buddha.

This historical timeline is discussed in detail by Edward Conze in his book, “A Short History of Buddhism” (1980). According to Conze, the history of Buddhism can be conveniently divided into four periods:

1. The old Buddhism, which largely coincided with what later came to be known as Theravada
2. Rise of Mahayana,
3. Rise of the Tantra (Vajrayana) and Ch’an (Zen),
4. No further divisions.

The first period is roughly 500 years; second and third periods roughly cover the first thousand years of the current era (CE); the last thousand years can be considered as the fourth period. During this whole period the Theravada Dhamma was kept mostly intact. In the following description, it is also clear some of the differences between the original teachings and the Mahayana ideology.

In the following I will present this story verbatim as told by Conze (starting at p. 45 of his book): [The Second Period: AD 0–500 page 31]

“.....About 100 BCE (roughly 400 years after the Buddha’s Parinibbana) a number of Buddhists in India felt that the existing statements of the doctrine had become stale and useless. In the conviction that Dhamma required ever new re-formulations so as to meet the needs of new ages, new populations and new social circumstances, they set out to produce new literature which ultimately came to known as Mahayana Buddhism. The creation of this literature is one of the most significant outbursts of creative energy known to human history and it was sustained for about four to five centuries. Repetition alone, they believed, cannot sustain a living religion. Unless counterbalanced by constant innovation, it will become fossilized and lose its life-giving qualities, they believed.

So far the Mahayanistic attitude seems quite logical. What is more difficult to understand is that they insisted in presenting the new writings, manifestly composed centuries after the Buddha’s Parinibbana, as the very words of the Buddha himself. They followed the Mahasanghikas in minimizing the importance of the historical Gautama Buddha, whom they replaced by the Buddha who is the embodiment of Dhamma (dharmakaya). In the “Lotus of the Good Law”, we are told that the Buddha, far from having reached his enlightenment at Bodhgaya, abides for aeons and aeons, from eternity to eternity, and that He preaches the Law at all times in countless places and innumerable disguises.

.....Not content with this, the Mahayanists tried to link their own writings with the historical Buddha

by a number of mythological fictions. They asserted that they had been preached by the Buddha in the course of his life on Earth, that parallel to the (First Buddhist) Council at Rajagaha, which codified the Suttas of the Theravada, the Mahayana suttas had been codified by an assembly of Bodhisattvas on the mythical mountain of Vimalasvabhava; that the texts had been miraculously preserved for five centuries and stored away in the subterranean palaces of the Nagas, or with the king of the Gandharvas, or the king of the Gods. Then, as Nagarjuna puts it, “five hundred years after the Buddha’s Nirvana, when the Good Law, after having gradually declined, was in great danger”, these treasures from the past were unearthed, revealed and made known, so as to revivify the doctrine.

What then were the main doctrinal innovations of the Mahayana? They can be summarized under five headings:

1. As concerns the goal there is a shift from the Arhat-ideal to the Bodhisattva-ideal;
2. A new way of salvation is worked out, in which compassion ranks equal with wisdom, and which is marked by the gradual advance through six “perfections” (paramita);
3. Faith is given a new range by being provided with a new pantheon of deities, or rather of persons more than divine;
4. “Skill in means” (upayakausalya), an entirely new virtue, becomes essential to the saint, and is placed even above wisdom, the highest virtue so far;
5. A coherent ontological doctrine is worked out, dealing with such items as “Emptiness”, “Suchness”, etc”.

We will now consider these one by one.

1. The goal of Arhantship is now relegated to the second place. The Mahayanists strive to to be a “Bodhisattva”. A Bodhisattva is distinguished by three features: (a) In his essential being he is actuated by the desire to win the full enlightenment of a Buddha, (b) He is dominated by two forces, in equal proportion, i.e., by compassion and wisdom. From compassion he selflessly postpones his entrance into the bliss of Nirvana so as to help suffering creatures,..... (c) Although intent on ultimate purity, a Bodhisattva remains in touch with ordinary people by having the same passions they have. His passions, however, do not either affect or pollute his mind.

2. A Bodhisattva’s compassion is called “great”, because it is boundless and makes no distinctions.... This enlightenment does not automatically entail the desire to assist others. Among the enlightened they distinguish three types, two of them “selfish”, one “unselfish”. The “selfish” types are Arhants and Pratyekabuddhas, who are said to represent the idea of the Hinayana, of the “inferior vehicle”. The “unselfish” ones are the Buddhas, and the pursuit of the unselfish quest for enlightenment on the part of a Bodhisattva is called the “Buddha-vehicle”, of the “Great Vehicle” (maha-yana).

A Bodhisattva must be a patient man. He wants to become a Buddha, but his distance from the transcendental perfection of a supreme Buddha, who both knows and is everything, will obviously be infinite. In one life it could not possibly be traversed. Countless lives would be needed and a Bodhisattva must be prepared to wait for aeons and aeons before he can reach his goal. Yet, he is separated from the Buddhahood only by one single obstacle, i.e., his belief in a personal self. To get rid of himself is the Bodhisattva’s supreme task. By two kinds of measures he tries to remove himself – actively by self-sacrifice and selfless service, cognitively by insight into the objective non-existence of a self. The first is due to compassion, the second to wisdom.

The unity of compassion and wisdom is acted out by the six “perfections”, or “paramita”, the six “methods by which we go to the Beyond”. A person turns into a Bodhisattva when he first resolves to win full enlightenment for the benefit of all beings. The six are: the perfections of giving, morality, patience, vigor, meditation, and wisdom”.

This ends the quotation from Edward Conze’s book. (I have not added or edited anything other than to skip some text in order to make it concise).

I agree with Conze’s analysis except for the statement in the very first paragraph: “The creation of this literature is one of the most significant outbursts of creative energy known to human history and it was sustained for about four to five centuries.” This literature, even though voluminous, only made a simple theory much more seemingly confusing, and contradictory. We will discuss this in a follow-up post. The only fortunate thing about is that it is written entirely in Sanskrit, and thus is easy to distinguish from the original teachings written in Pali Tipitaka.

In addition to the “improvements” that were added in India, further material associated with national customs were added when Mahayana Buddhism spread to China, Japan, and Tibet (and came to known by different names such Zen, Vajrayana, etc.).

So, the premise of the Mahayana re-formulation of the Buddha Dhamma was to “refine and improve” the Dhamma of the Buddha. This is in sharp contradiction with one of the most fundamental concepts in Dhamma that only a Buddha can discover these laws of nature and BY DEFINITION, it is not possible to improve upon them. They themselves admit that a Buddha appears in the world after long times, and [thus their attempt to change Buddha Dhamma is one of the basic contradictions in Mahayana.](#)

What we need to understand is the basic difference between Buddha Dhamma and any other human endeavor: All other human endeavors involve cumulative effort of many, whether it is science, philosophy, engineering, etc.; see, [“Dhamma and Science – Introduction”](#). And all those efforts are made within the system, using the knowledge acquired by the experience within the system; see, [“Gödel’s Incompleteness Theorem”](#). A Buddha transcends the human realm, and discovers the “whole existence” of the 31 realms; see, [“The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma”](#). The Mahayanists took that world view, which is not accessible to normal human beings but only to a Buddha, [and then added their own theories that only complicates that “already seemingly esoteric” picture.](#) This is why there are so many apparent contradictions in “Buddhism” today. Adding more “pluff”, which is wrong anyway by definition, only distorts the correct picture. My goal here is to provide a consistent picture using the accepted scientific methods.

Next, [“Background on the Current Revival of Buddha Dhamma”](#),

Background on the Current Revival of Buddha Dhamma

1. It is ironical that the current revival of Buddha Dhamma is also due to the same reason that led to the decline in Buddha Dhamma in most Buddhist countries for hundreds of years in the latter part of the second millenium, i.e., the colonization of Asia by the Western powers starting with the Portuguese and ending with the British.

- The civil servants of the British East India Company came across ancient Buddhist literature in various Asian countries and some of them realized the importance of these documents; some started deciphering the documents themselves (e.g. Thomas W. Rhys Davids, 1843-1922) and to do so, even learned Pali and Sanskrit languages.
- Others sent documents to Europe where mostly French and English philosophers (e.g., Eugene Burnouf, 1801-1852) studied them and translated them to French and English. A thorough account of the efforts by the British civil servants in India, Sri Lanka, and other Asian countries in uncovering the “lost knowledge” and also in the restoration of historical Buddhist sites in India has been given by Charles Allen in his excellent book, “The Search for the Buddha” (2003).

2. These Westerners realized that there was something profound in this ancient doctrine which exposed them for the first time to a religion that was not based on a Creator.

- Thomas Huxley captured the essence this new religion brilliantly as follows (Thomas H. Huxley, *Evolution and Ethics and Other Essays*, 1894, pp. 68-69): “A system which knows of no God in the Western sense; which denies a soul to man; which counts the belief in immortality a blunder and the hope of it a sin; which refuses any efficacy to prayer and sacrifice; which bids men look to nothing but their own efforts for salvation; which, in its original purity, knew nothing of vows and obedience, abhorred intolerance, and never sought the aid of the secular arm; yet spread over a considerable moiety of the Old World with marvelous rapidity, and is still, with whatever base admixture of foreign superstitions, the dominant creed of a large fraction of mankind”.
- It is amazing that even at that early stage, when there must have been some confusion about the mythical aspects of especially the Tibetan and Zen Buddhist practices, Huxley was able to express the essence of Buddha Dhamma.

3. Based on their interest in the documents from Asia on Buddhism and Hinduism, Madame Helena Petrovna Blavatsky and Colonel Henry Steel Olcott founded the Theosophical Society in New York City in 1875. They subsequently traveled to India and Sri Lanka, and became Buddhists.

- Olcott published “A Buddhist Catechism” in 1881. This book together with the “Light of Asia” by Edwin Arnold in 1871 (which went through 100 printings), led to much interest in Europe and America about Buddhism. Colonel Olcott opened several Buddhism-oriented schools in Sri Lanka in order to revive the religion. I was fortunate to be able to attend one of those schools.
- These efforts were subsequently augmented by a number of Sri Lankan intellectuals such as Anagarika Dhammapala, G. P. Malasekara, K. N. Jayatilleke, Narada Thera, Walpola Rahula Thera, David Kalupahana, and also by several more Westerners who were impressed by the Buddhist teachings to a point that they came to Sri Lanka, became monks, and wrote many excellent treatises on Theravada Buddhism; these include Nyanatiloka Thera, Nyanyaponika Thera, and Bhikkhu Bodhi.

4. Even though those early publications by Rhys Davids, Arnold, and Olcott in the late 1800's were mainly on the Theravada Buddhism, beginning in the early part of the 1900's, Zen Buddhism became an object of fascination in the West and continues to be a significant presence in the West.

- In contrast to the earlier introduction of (Theravada) Buddhism to the West by Westerners, Zen made its way into the Western consciousness via the efforts of an elite group of Japanese intellectuals – most notably D. T. Suzuki. Suzuki, who came to America in 1897, wrote several books including “An Introduction to Zen Buddhism”; this book emphasized the transcendent and mystical nature of Zen.

5. Here is an excerpt from the above book by Suzuki, which clearly states the belief of the Mahayana thinkers that the original teachings of the Buddha are “primitive” and Mahayana provided the needed improvements (p. 1, footnote 1):

- “..to be accurate, the fundamental ideas of the Mahayana expounded in the Prajnaparamita group of Buddhist literature, the earliest of which must have appeared at the latest within 300 years off the Buddha's death. The germs are no doubt in the writings belonging to the so-called primitive Buddhism. Only their development, that is, a conscious grasp of them as most essential in the teachings of the founder, could not be effected without his followers' actually living the teachings for some time through the variously changing conditions of life. **Thus enriched in experience and matured in reflection, the Indian Buddhists came to have the Mahayana form of Buddhism as distinguished from its primitive or original form.** In India two Mahayana schools are known the Madhyamika, of Nagarjuna and the Vijnaptimatra or Yogacara of Asanga and Vasubandhu. In China more schools developed: the Tendai, the Kegon, the Jodo, the Zen, etc. In Japan we have besides these the Hokke, the Shingon, the Shin, the Ji, etc. All of these schools or sects belong to the Mahayana wing of Buddhism”. (Highlighting is mine).

6. This is in sharp contrast with the basic presumption in Buddha Dhamma that only a Buddha can discover the laws of nature and those teachings CANNOT be improved upon:

- There is only ONE set of natural laws and those were discovered by the Buddha. As one goes through the content in this website, I hope one would be able to see that statement is justified. Also see, “[Dhamma and Science – Introduction](#)“

7. More recently, Tibetan Buddhism (Vajrayana) has gained prominence in the West. This is no doubt the result of the publicity of the Chinese invasion of Tibet in 1953 and the incredible personal charisma of the Dalai Lama.

- It is unfortunate that the Dalai Lama has to state that, “My confidence in venturing into science lies in my basic belief that as in science so in Buddhism, understanding the nature of reality is pursued by means of critical investigation: **if scientific analysis were conclusively to demonstrate certain claims in Buddhism to be false, then we must accept the findings of science and abandon those claims.**”(highlighting mine) – cited from “The Universe in a Single Atom: The Convergence of Science and Spirituality” (2005).

8. Both the Mahayana and Vajrayana sects are now realizing that some concepts in those forms of “Buddhism” have to change with the new findings of science. The fundamental teachings of the Buddha as stated in the Theravada Dhamma, in contrast, remain unchallenged because no such “improvements” were incorporated to “keep up with the times and cultures”.

- The **Pali Tipitaka** has remained the same since it was written down. The reality is that science is only now beginning to confirm many things that the Buddha stated 2500 years ago; see, [“Dhamma and Science – Introduction”](#) and the subsequent links.
- Regrettably, the translated AND edited versions of the Tipitaka, especially those by Acariya Buddhaghosa, have many misinterpretations.
- Therefore, while the Tipitaka contains the original teachings of the Buddha, books like “Visuddhimagga” that the Theravadins use today also have many incorrect interpretations. A good example is the misinterpretation of the three characteristics: *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*; see, [“Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta”](#), and [“Why Correct Interpretation of Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta so Important?”](#).

9. Beginning at the end of the twentieth century, there is a renewed interest in “Buddhism” in the West, based on several books by Western scientists.

- It seems to have started with the publication of “The Tao of Physics” by physicist Fritjof Capra (1975). In the book he describes how, one day quietly sitting by the ocean, he realized that there may be a connection between the subtleties of quantum mechanics and Eastern “mysticism”, in which he included “Hinduism, Buddhism, Chinese Thought, Taoism, and Zen”. It appears that he was trying to make a connection between the world of matter described by quantum mechanics and the “mind” that is predominant in “Eastern mysticism”. Even by the time of the 5th edition (2010), he had not realized that Zen was a branch of Buddhism, and had not been exposed to any Theravada literature. However, the connection he was trying to establish apparently made an impact on the Western audience and this trend will hopefully continue and be directed in the right direction.
- There are others who have contributed to the recent interest in “Buddhism” in the West: The Art of Happiness” and other books by Dalai Lama, “The Embodies Mind” by Francisco Varela et al., “Confession of a Buddhist Atheist” and other books by Stephen Batchelor, are some examples.

10. The books that I mentioned at the beginning of the essay and several other books by Ven. Ledi Sayadaw, Ven. Bhikkhu Bodhi, Ven. Walpola Rahula, and others (see the References below), are providing the much needed material on Theravada Buddhism to the Western audience, even though they themselves have some incorrect interpretations mainly due to the influence of Acariya Buddhaghosa’s Visuddhimagga.

11. My goal with this site is to provide some further guidance in this context, using what I believe to be “pure Dhamma” that I learned from the two Theros in Sri Lanka, from the vantage point of contemporary science.

References

1. “Light of Asia” by Edwin Arnold (1871),
2. “A Buddhist Catechism”, by H. S. Olcott (1881).
3. “Evolution and Ethics and Other Essays”, by T. H. Huxley(1894).
4. “An Introduction to Zen Buddhism” by D. T. Suzuki (1964).
5. “What the Buddha Taught” by Walpola Rahula (1974),

6. “The Tao of Physics” by Fritjof Capra (1975).
7. “A Short History of Buddhism” by Edward Conze (1980).
8. “A History of Buddhist Philosophy” by David J. Kalupahana (1992).
9. “The Manuals of Dhamma”, by Ledi Sayadaw (1999).
10. “The Search for the Buddha”, by C. Allen (2003).
11. “The Universe in a Single Atom: The Convergence of Science and Spirituality” by Dalai Lama (2005).
12. “In the Buddha’s Words” by Bhikkhu Bodhi (2005).

Next, “[Why is it Critical to Find the Pure Buddha Dhamma?](#)“,

Why is it Critical to Find the Pure Buddha Dhamma?

1. Recently I participated in an online discussion group on “Buddhism” for a few days. Couple of things that struck me were:

- There are a lot of people out there who see that there is something valuable in Buddha Dhamma. But there is lot of confusion, because there are so many conflicting ideas brought up and discussed without reaching a conclusion.
- Each person seems to have their own version, their own “theory” what Dhamma really is. In many forums, instead of having a honest discussion about what ideas are right and what are wrong, many people use the forums for “entertainment”. It is their “coffee break” to sit around and show off their “knowledge” and “wisdom”. **(I must say that I regularly participate in a couple of other discussion groups where people seem to be genuinely interested in having an open exchange of ideas).**

2. It is a good idea to first decide what the goal of such a forum is. I think the goal should be to find and confirm the core ideas that the Buddha taught 2500 years ago. Let us get rid of all these different labels, Mahayana, Theravada, etc.. Since it does not appear to happen any time soon, I have decided to just present what I have found. I call it Buddha Dhamma. And that is what was called until the term “Buddhism” came into vogue in the 19th century.

3. I have two key points to make:

- We can remove many bad ideas that crept into Dhamma by looking at the historical “evolution” of “Buddhism”; The main problem of “evolution” of Dhamma is that it is not a germ idea that needs to be nurtured and refined: **Buddha Dhamma is the set of ultimate natural laws that a Buddha DISCOVERS after long times.** Now, one can be skeptical about that, and that is perfectly fine. Confidence in that belief comes by critically examining the evidence, and it may come later. But let us make that assumption, because that is a key idea in Buddha Dhamma: That it is a rare event that a human being can discover the ultimate laws of nature; see, [“Power of the Human Mind – introduction”](#), and the follow-up posts.
- Modern science can be another useful tool in finding the truth or fallacy of some concepts involved; the “theories” of science are continually being tested and verified by thousand of independent scientists, so even though they are not infallible, they are better than many speculations by individuals. And there is a key difference in finding the nature’s laws via the scientific method and the way a Buddha finds them; see, [“Dhamma and Science – Introduction”](#).

I will use both these tools in presenting my case.

4. The goal (and the motivation) in finding true Dhamma (or any kind of true salvation for those who believe in any other religion or belief system) is different compared to a philosophical debate. One could possibly “win an argument” in a philosophical debate especially if “winning” means persuading more people in the audience. One could thus “win a debate”, but deep inside one knows the argument has flaws. It is like winning court case, and freeing a criminal. The criminal (and may be even the lawyer) knows that he/she committed the crime. Even though the consequences will not be paid in a prison, they will be paid according to the Dhamma or the nature’s laws.

5. If we can recover those correct laws that the Buddha taught, then we can gain the benefits of knowing those laws and following them for our benefit. It is not about winning an argument. It is ALL

about finding the truth for oneself. If what Buddha said is true, then this world is much more complex than most people think, and there is much more suffering to be had, if one does not use the remaining time in this life wisely.

6. Then there is this naive argument out there that says: “All religions work for the good of the mankind. Do not criticize any religion or any sect within Buddhism”. But some of those people also say, “Our sect of Buddhism is the best version because we are so compassionate that we will not attain Enlightenment until EVERYONE is ready”. As we will see below, this oath itself is against one of the five precepts in Buddha Dhamma, that of promising not to lie. I am not going to talk about other religions, but I am going to point out the flaws in many existing versions of “Buddhism” today, because **that is the compassionate thing to do**.

7. If one is truly compassionate, one should try to find the true Dhamma (because there is only one set of natural laws), and then SHARE it with anyone who would be interested. Dhamma is not something that anyone can GIVE to anyone else. Even the Buddha could only teach those who would listen to him. Some people even question the compassion of the Buddha when they hear this story from the Tipitaka:

- There was a butcher named Cundasukara who lived right next door to the Jetawanaramaya, where the Buddha resided for a long time. Some may wonder why the Buddha did not try to “save” Cundasukara by teaching him the right path. Actually, there were some bhikkhus who could hear the screams of the pigs being slaughtered and asked the Buddha why he would not try to teach Dhamma to Cundasukara. The Buddha told them that Cundasukara would accrue much more bad kamma if he tried to do that. Killing pigs leads to accumulation of much bad kamma, but unimaginable bad kamma could be accumulated by having hateful thoughts towards a Buddha: see, “[How to Evaluate Weights of Different Kamma](#)“. One could accumulate more bad kamma by hurting the feelings of a human being than by killing an animal, and hateful thoughts towards a Buddha can be infinitely worse than hurting a normal human being. Therefore, sometimes the true compassion can be hidden.
- In my way of thinking, I would not be acting compassionately if I did not point out these flaws in both Mahayana and Theravada, because I have experienced the benefits of the true and pure Dhamma.
- My goal is not to try to “convert” anyone to anything. The Buddha did not try to convert anybody. It is up to each person to make their own decisions, because one is responsible for one’s own future, and no one else is. Most of us are lucky to live in societies where we can make our own decisions.
- As I keep emphasizing, Buddha Dhamma describes the ultimate laws of nature. Anyone with any religious background, or an atheist, can follow Dhamma and should be able to see that it does describe the laws of nature. However, it is critical to find the true Dhamma. The only way to do that is to check for consistency at ALL TIMES, and to weed out the bad versions.

8. In the following few posts we will examine the problems in many different versions of Mahayana and also in Theravada. If you see any flaws in my arguments, please send me a comment. **It is possible that I could make a mistake, and if so I will correct them**. I hope all those who read these posts will keep an open mind, because all of us should have the same goal: finding the pure Dhamma which will be beneficial to us all.

Next, “[Key Problems with Mahayana Teachings](#)“,

Key Problems with Mahayana Teachings

1. The main problem is a conflict with a very basic tenet of Buddha Dhamma: That a Buddha comes to this world after very long times, and DISCOVERS the laws of nature by his own efforts. Mahayanists agree that it takes aeons of time to fulfill the “paramitas” and to become a Buddha.

- Then they turn around and say that Buddha Dhamma needed to be “refined” for the changing times; see “[Background on the Current Revival of Buddha Dhamma](#)“. How can the ultimate laws of nature discovered by a Buddha be “refined” or “revised”? **No one has answered this basic question.**

2. The first thing one is supposed to do in becoming a “Mahayana Buddhist” is to take the “Bodhisattva vow”: They say each being should endeavor to become a Buddha i.e., each person should become a Bodhisattva.

- Those who initiated this idea a long time ago probably did not have any idea that there are infinite number of sentient beings in this world. Each human’s body itself has amazingly large number of microscopic beings; see, “[There are as many creatures on your body as there are people on Earth!](#)“.
- There are 1000 trillion of just ants on this Earth: <http://www.ask.com/question/how-many-ants-are-there-in-the-world>. Or do they not count other living beings?
- If it is not possible to have a significant number of Arahants for 1800 years, is there any realistic way for trillions of beings to attain Arahathood, let alone Buddhahood?
- In this aeon (basically the time duration of a universe or about 30 billion years), there have been four Buddhas, and one more is supposed to appear; this is truly an exception. Before this aeon, there were 30 aeons that did not have a single Buddha appearing. So, how long would one to have wait to become a Buddha, i.e., remain a Bodhisattva? And will all beings (or even the human population today) be able to become Buddhas in the same aeon let alone at the same time? Are they serious?

3. Within 500 years of the passing away of the Buddha, the Indian Mahayanists started not only refining but incorporating concepts that were alien to Buddha Dhamma. If it needed refining just after 500 years, how come they have not kept up with the updating process? **One would think they would be doing a major revision these days with so much changes in science and technology.** Actually, what has happened is the opposite: Science and technology is consistent with the original Dhamma; what needs to be done is to abandon those alien concepts in Mahayana and embrace the pure Dhamma.

4. Those who started this revision process did not understand the main concept of Nibbana and the related concepts of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. So, they defined those in their own terms, and then got into a slippery slope in trying to explain those terms by inventing more concepts. It snowballed, and in the words of Edward Conze, who translated many Mahayana texts to English:

- “.....About 100 BCE (roughly 400 years after the Buddha’s Parinibbana) a number of Buddhists in India felt that the existing statements of the doctrine had become stale and useless. In the conviction that Dhamma required ever new re-formulations so as to meet the needs of new ages, new populations and new social circumstances, they set out to produce new literature which ultimately came to known as Mahayana Buddhism. The creation of this literature is one

of the most significant outbursts of creative energy known to human history and it was sustained for about four to five centuries. Repetition alone, they believed, cannot sustain a living religion. Unless counterbalanced by constant innovation, it will become fossilized and lose its life-giving qualities, they believed”.

- (see, “[Historical Timeline of Edward Conze](#)“).

For someone who is not familiar with the original teachings of the Buddha, those philosophical arguments could look impressive, as they did for Edward Conze. We will examine those concepts in detail in upcoming posts. I have discussed the concept of “emptiness”; see the link below.

5. None of the Mahayanist “authors” such as Nagarjuana, Vasubhandhu, Asanga, are documented to be Arahants; they were like philosophers of today. Not only that, they had an aversion to the concept of an Arahant. In fact, the last Arahant (up to now) is supposed to be Ven. Maliyadeva from Sri Lanka, who lived in the second century CE according to some sources:

<http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Maliyadeva>

- The Mahayana sutras are supposed to have their origin with Nagarjuna, who is believed to have lived 150-250 CE in India. Thus it is clear that the pure Dhamma went underground somewhere before 200 CE, within about 700 years of the Parinibbana (passing away) of the Buddha.
- **Thus those Indian intellectuals like Nagarjuana were just like the philosophers from the time of Socrates, who make all kinds of speculations consistent with the “knowledge” about the “world” at any given time.**
- Buddha did warn of this outcome: He said: “there will be other versions that look like Dhamma and feels like Dhamma. Just like when there are imitations of gold coming to the market, the real gold goes underground” (Saddhamma Patirupaka Sutta). That has been the case for over 1800 years.
- But the truth comes out eventually. That time could well be now. The correct interpretations of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* have been hidden for all this time, but within the past ten to twenty years, they have been uncovered and been explained in Sri Lanka. The details will come out in due time, but for anyone interested the correct interpretations are on this website for scrutiny.

6. So what are these revisions that the Mahayanists made?

There are five doctrinal “innovations” of the Mahayanists that have been listed by Edward Conze; see, “[Historical Timeline of Edward Conze](#)“. They are:

- As concerns the goal there is a shift from the Arhat-ideal to the Bodhisattva-ideal;
- A new way of salvation is worked out, in which compassion ranks equal with wisdom, and which is marked by the gradual advance through six “perfections” (paramita);
- Faith is given a new range by being provided with a new pantheon of deities, or rather of persons more than divine;
- “Skill in means” (upayakaushalya), an entirely new virtue, becomes essential to the saint, and is placed even above wisdom, the highest virtue so far;
- A coherent ontological doctrine is worked out, dealing with such items as “Emptiness”, “Suchness”, etc”.

We will point out the key contradictions of each of these revisions with the Buddha's original teachings (see i-v below), and will go into details later on.

1. The basic idea of Buddha Dhamma is that each human being has a unique mind. It is defiled by greed, hate, and ignorance. Because of that each person commits immoral acts and subsequently "pay for those actions", suffering is the net result in the cycle of rebirths. One gets out this cycle of rebirths by purifying one's mind; one who has accomplished this task is an Arahant. That can be done only by each person. NO ONE can purify anyone else's mind.
2. One attains Nibbana when one purifies the mind of ALL defilements. That is when one has ultimate wisdom, or panna. There is no way to equate compassion with panna. One can be as compassionate to the maximum, but that does not mean one has gotten rid of ignorance. In fact, those beings in the Brahma worlds do not generate any hateful thoughts; they have perfected the four Brahmavihara: metta, karuna, mudita, upekkha. They don't have a trace of hateful thoughts, yet they have ignorance (moha), and thus will one day be reborn in the four lower realms (unless they attain Sotapanna stage before that). Therefore, this is also a major contradiction.
3. Buddha said a human life is better than life in any other realm (other than the realm reserved for the Anagamis), because the easiest to attain Nibbana is from the human realm. While some beings in higher realms can be helpful to us, and we should share merits with them, a human is not supposed to worship any other being. One has to have faith only in the Buddha, Dhamma, and Sangha. No other being can help with our goal of attaining Nibbana.
4. "Skill in Means" or whatever other term anyone comes up runs into the same problem as compassion above in B. Such ideas run against the core teaching of the Buddha that says, even if one gets rid of greed and hate, but still has ignorance, then one will end up getting back greed and hate DUE TO ignorance. Nibbana is not attained until ignorance is completely removed from the mind.
5. E. Mahayana descriptions on all these philosophical concepts like emptiness or sunyata are just a lot of empty words; they have much simpler explanations that are consistent with original teachings. I will address these in upcoming posts. The Mahayanists had to re-invent alternate descriptions for these terms because the original meanings were in conflict with their "revisions" discussed in i-iv.
7. Those who follow the Mahayana version do that because either, (1) they are born into Mahayana tradition (just like I was born to Theravada), or (2) that is the version of "Buddhism" that one got introduced to. The problems with Mahayana versions are not due to their making. But it is time at least to start changing those features that are in stark contradiction not only with the original teachings of the Buddha, but also with the enhanced world view of science within the past several hundred years.
 - The oath in most Mahayana traditions to, "not to seek Enlightenment until ALL BEINGS ARE READY for Enlightenment" is the most visible contradiction. As I pointed out in A above, at least these days we know that this is a outright lie, and is an obvious break of the precept not to lie knowingly.
 - This should not be a debate about ideologies of sects; it should be an open discussion about how to weed out the inconsistent material from all sects, and to recover the pure Buddha Dhamma for the benefit of all.

Before discussing the problems with the wrong interpretations in Theravada, let us discuss the concept of sunyata. Mahayana Buddhism tries to make a big deal out of sunyata, because their forefathers (those who started Mahayana tradition) could not understand the concept of Nibbana. It is unfortunate that many people who are only introduced to Mahayana teachings believe that Nibbana is an abstract concept.

Also see:

[Saddharma Pundarika Sutra \(Lotus Sutra\) – A Focused Analysis](#)

[What is Sunyata \(Emptiness\)?](#)

Saddharma Pundarika Sutra (Lotus Sutra) – A Focused Analysis

1. This sutra was written by a number of Indian philosophers over hundreds of years, and led to the gradual formation of Mahayana Buddhism over that period. Note that I am NOT referring to it as a sutta; suttas are the original teachings of the Buddha and were delivered in *Maghadhi* language, were written down in *Pali*, and are available in the *Tipitaka*.

- In contrast, all Mahayana sutras were written after the *Parinibbana* (passing away) of the Buddha and were written in Sanskrit without an exception.
- Thus at least we have a clear way of distinguishing the original discourses by the Buddha (*suttas*) and those Mahayana *sutras* written by lay people hundreds of years after the Buddha.
- Other than this obvious language indicator, the question often arises as to which of many interpretations that are being given to key concepts even in the Theravada tradition. As mentioned in the *Tipitaka*, this problem was there even DURING the time of the Buddha.

2. Once Maha Prajapathi Gotami *bhikkhuni*, who was Prince Siddhartha's step mother, approached the Buddha and pointed out that some *bhikkhus* were providing incorrect interpretations of the Dhamma, and that she fears that the things will really get out of hand long time after the *Parinibbana* of the Buddha: "How can the future generations figure out the correct version of Dhamma?" she asked the Buddha.

- The Buddha agreed that it is inevitable that wrong interpretations will always be there, but said that there is a way to clarify identify the correct version. He said always to look for consistency with the Four Noble Truths as explained in the *suttas*, the cause and effect as explained in the *paticca samuppada dhamma*, and how to stay from getting indebted via *raga*, *dosa*, *moha* as laid out in the vinaya; any genuine teaching should lead to *ragakkhaya*, *dosakkhaya*, and *mohakkhaya* (getting rid of *raga*, *dosa*, *moha*).
- If a version of Dhamma does not have this internal consistency and does not lead to *ragakkhaya* (reduction of greed), *dosakkhaya* (reduction of hate), and *mohakkhaya* (reduction of ignorance of the three characteristics of nature *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*), then that should be discarded.

3. A bit of background material before we discuss this *sutra*: According to the Buddha, there are **three ways** to attain *Nibbana*:

- A **Samma Sambuddha** (like Buddha Gotama) discovers the Noble Eightfold Path and attains *Nibbana* through his own efforts, AND he is able to teach the doctrine to others.
- Thus a second way to attain *Nibbana* is to learn the Dhamma (or the Path) from a *Samma Sambuddha* or a true disciple of his; this is how **an Arahant** attained *Nibbana*.
- Then there are ***pacceka Buddhas*** who discover the Path by themselves but are not capable of explaining it to the other people.

4. Now let us discuss how this sutra paved the way for the *Bodhisattva* concept in Mahayana.

This *sutra* starts off by the Buddha saying that even though he had taught that there were three paths to *Nibbana* but now he is admitting that there is only one; when Ven. Ananda asked why, he says that he did not think people were "ready" for this higher doctrine. Thus instead of there being three vehicles (or paths) one can take, there is only one which is the great vehicle or the Mahayana ("*mahā*" is great and "*yāna*" is vehicle). And this is the path that he himself took by striving for aeons as a *Bodhisattva*

to become a Buddha.

- Continuing with this *sutra*, now he (the Buddha) was advising everyone to become a *Bodhisattava* and to attain the Buddhahood. Then he assures all those *Arahants* present there, including Ven. Sariputta, that they themselves will become Buddhas. This is a complete lack of understanding of the concept of an *Arahant* (even though the sutta itself says that those *Arahants* had removed all defilements). An *Arahant* is not going to be reborn and thus there is no way for an *Arahant* to become a Buddha.

Now let us go through a few more “obvious inconsistencies” in the *sutra*.

5. It is astonishing to see that the *sutra* opens with, “Thus have I heard...”, a big *musavada* (a lie) that Ven. Ananda is providing the details of the *sutra*.

First a brief background: When the Pali *sutta* in the *Tipitaka* were first summarized for transmission, Ven. Ananda, who knew all the *sutas* by heart, recited them at the First Buddhist Council; thus any given *sutta* in the *Tipitaka* starts off with his clarification, “Thus have I heard...” to indicate that this was what Ven. Ananda had heard himself. Trying to give the impression that this *sutra* was also one delivered by the Buddha, the authors of the Lotus *sutra* obviously tried to deceive the readers.

- As with all the other *sutras* written in Sanskrit, it has been generally accepted by the historians that the Lotus *sutra* was written much later after the passing away (*Parinibbana*) of the Buddha Gotama.
- The oldest parts of the text (Chapters 1–9 and 17) were probably written down between 100 BCE and 100 CE, and most of the text had appeared by 200 CE; see, for example, http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Lotus_Sutra. Thus it was written by several authors over 100 years or more. A translation was made from Sanskrit to Chinese in 255 CE, and this is the earliest historical documentation of its existence.

6. The middle of the *sutra* is devoted to describing the “universal accessibility” of the Buddhahood to anyone. Here it reads like a fairytale where astounding stories of accomplishments are described: For example, a daughter of the dragon king Sagara astonishes the assembly by performing various supernormal acts and says she can attain the Buddhahood “in an instant”.

- However, the *sutra* also stresses the importance of faith and devotion as means to realization of enlightenment, and minimizes the need for wisdom. Among other significant points, the stress on faith and devotion makes buddhahood more accessible to laypeople, who do not spend their lives in ascetic monastic practice; thus the Buddhahood is available to anyone.

7. Yet the problem is that since a Mahayana Buddhist agrees in advance to take the *Bodhisattva* vow (see, http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Bodhisattva_vow) to wait until “everyone is ready to attain the Buddhahood”, it is not clear how or who can determine WHEN everyone is ready.

- And all current scientific facts point to the possibility of there being an innumerable number of beings, this is a critical question how all these beings can attain the Buddhahood at the same time; see, “[There are as many creatures on your body as there are people on Earth!](#)”.
- Furthermore, it seems contradictory that Buddha Gotama and many other previous Buddhas did not wait for anyone else.

8. The story gets even more fascinating in Chapter 16 (presumably as a different writer of the *sutra* comes up with another idea), when the Buddha Gotama reveals that he is an eternal being: He

attained the Buddhahood an incalculably distant time in the past, and even though seems to pass away at times to *nirvana* (Sanskrit word for *Nibbana*), he periodically makes appearances in the world.

- This declaration makes the Buddha more like a Creator God who has been there at all times! And no mention (as far as I could see) has been made on the issue of whether there was a beginning to this world.
- It seems to me that the philosophers who wrote these Mahayana sutras had no idea of the concept of *Nibbana*! By the very definition, the whole idea of attaining *Nibbana* is to dissociate from this suffering-filled material world: There are several posts at this site ranging from, “[Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)” to “[What are Rupa? – Relation to Nibbana](#)” on the concept of *Nibbana*.
- Then there is the issue of there being other Buddhas present at that assembly too. And they all seem to be “at the same level”. Thus the question arises as to who was the first Buddha, and then why those other Buddhas “did not wait until everyone else was ready for the Buddhahood”.

9. With most of the sections of the sutra dedicated to hyperbolizing the value of the single, great vehicle (Mahayana) to attain the *Nibbana* versus the three vehicles of *Samma Sambuddha*, *Pacceka Buddha*, and *Arahant*, **there is no discussion on the actual distinguishing doctrinal concepts of the single vehicle, other than just saying that it has the advantage of “easy accessibility of the Buddhahood”**. What makes this “single vehicle” approach different from the original approach in terms of details in Dhamma? For example, does it have new way of the describing the Noble Eightfold Path, *paticca samuppada*, or the Four Noble Truths?

- In fact, the *sutra*, as many other Sanskrit *sutras*, only mention those key foundational concepts of Buddha Dhamma in passing. There is no discussion on them, let alone pointing out the differences from the original doctrine. **I am amazed that no one even refers to this glaringly obvious point. What sets the “single vehicle approach” apart from the original other than the name change?**
- But the real problem is that in changing some key concepts (for example, getting rid of the *Arahant* concept and making the Buddha effectively a Creator God), this sutra paved the way to distort the Buddha Dhamma for generations to come.
- In terms of the basic conditions set forth by the Buddha to see whether any teachings in this *sutra* lead to a reduction in greed, hate, and ignorance, can anyone point to such aspects? Other than the usage of grandiose descriptions, there is nothing substantial in terms of a doctrine, let alone a revised doctrine. In fact, all it does is to gravely distort the foundational concepts like *Nibbana*, *Buddhahood*, and *Arahanthood* with the concept of “a single vehicle”.

10. There are so many untruths, inconsistencies, and exaggerations in this sutra that I have space in this essay to point out only the gross problems that are vividly displayed; that is why the post is labelled as a “focused analysis”.

- Here is a English translation of the Sutra available online, so that anyone can peruse through and see the apparent difference between this sutra and any Pali sutta that is in the Tipitaka: <http://www.purifymind.com/LotusSutra.htm>
- One could compare this *sutra* with the actual Pali *suttas* that I started discussing; see, “[Sutta – Introduction](#)“, and the posts on the *Maha Satipatthana Sutta* below that.

- I must emphasize that one needs to evaluate this *sutra* in the context of the deep and self-consistent Buddha Dhamma. One can get a glimpse of this by examining the “Key Dhamma Concepts”, “Paticca Samuppada”, and “Abhidhamma” sections at this website, where I have only begun to lay out the teachings, especially in the Abhidhamma section.

11. I would be happy to respond (and to correct any legitimate errors in the analysis) if anyone can point out any problems with my analysis; please send me a comment.

- This analysis was done consistent with the main theme of this website, which is to point out problems with both Mahayana and Theravada versions as being practised today. It is for the benefit of everyone that we should remove (or at least be aware of) all inconsistencies and untruths so that the current and future generations will have a version of Buddha Dhamma that is close to the original version.

References

“Scripture of the Lotus Blossom of the Fine Dharma (The Lotus Sutra)”, translated by Leon Hurvitz (2009).

“The Lotus Sutra”, translated by Burton Watson (1993).

“Saddharma Pundarika or The Lotus of the True Law”, translated by H. Kern (1884). First Dover edition, 1963.

What is Sunyata or Sunnata (Emptiness)?

1. In Mahayana Buddhism, there are books written about sunyata (actually it is Sunnata in Pali) or emptiness. Mahayana Buddhism tries to make a big deal out of sunyata, because their forefathers (those who started Mahayana tradition) could not understand the concept of Nibbana. It is unfortunate that many people who are only introduced to Mahayana teachings believe that Nibbana is an abstract concept. However, it is a very simple concept if one understands the pure Buddha Dhamma.

2. What is emptiness?

- When an entity A is devoid of entity B, then it can be said that entity A is devoid of B, or empty of B. That is the emptiness or sunyata.
- Emptiness is relative. One has to say what it is empty of. There is no absolute “emptiness”. It is meaningless to say “this is emptiness” (whatever it is), because there may be something there that we are not aware of.
- For example, up until recently scientists thought deep space is “empty”. But now they know that it is full energy. Still, one could say that “deep space is empty of tangible matter” to a good approximation.

3. The Buddha said when the mind becomes empty of greed (raga), hate (dosa), and ignorance (moha) it becomes empty of those defilements: “*ragakkhayo Nibbanan, dosakkhayao Nibbanan, mohakkhayo Nibbanan*“, and that mind has attained Nibbana. That is emptiness, sunyata with respect to defilements. VERY SIMPLE.

- When one attains the Arahant phala, one’s mind becomes sunya of raga, dosa, moha. But one still has sanna, vedana, etc. and lives like a normal human being until death. At the death of an Arahant, “this world of 31 realms” becomes devoid of any trace of that lifestream, except for the Arahant’s nama goththa (mano imprint for previous lives; see, “[Difference Between Dhamma and Sankhara \(Sankata\)](#)“); there is no rebirth. So that is another sunyata.

4. There is a sutta in Tipitaka that is about sunnata (emptiness), and was delivered by the Buddha, called the Cula-Sunnata sutta. I actually wrote the original post before I knew about this sutta. When a friend of mine told me about the sutta, I was glad to see that the sutta described emptiness very similar to the way I described it. This does show that the Dhamma is internally self-consistent.

- Please click the link below for its translation that I extracted from, <http://www.accesstoinsight.org/tipitaka/mn/mn.121.than.html>. Normally, I come across many English translations that are bad and even erroneous, but fortunately this translation is fairly good.

The highlighting in the link below is mine, and I have made some comments:

[Cula-Sunnata Sutta \(PDF file\)](#)

There is no need to write books on emptiness that are full of meaningless words. The above sutta says it all.

5. In a recent online discussion forum, I saw a comment saying that emptiness describes paticca samuppada. This was really a surprise, because in Mahayana texts it is not explained what paticca samuppada is.

- I have not seen the paticca samuppada explained in an Mahayana text, Zen, Vajrayana, or any other form. If you know of such a book, please send me a comment giving the name of the book, and I would appreciate it.

6. The Buddha said, “*Yo paticcasamuppadam passati, so Dhammam passati*” or, “One who understands paticca samuppada, understands Dhamma”

- The Mahayana sects have moved so far away from Buddha Dhamma, I cannot fathom why they still call it Buddha’s Dhamma.
- It is very easy to get the idea behind paticca samuppada, because it is in the words; see, “[Paticca Samuppada – “Pati+ichcha”+”Sama+uppada”](#)“, and follow-up posts. Buddha Dhamma is all about cause and effects, and that is what is described in paticca samuppada.

Next, “[Theravada: Problems with Current Interpretations of Key Concepts](#)“,

Theravada: Problems with Current Interpretations of Key Concepts

1. This may also be a good time to look at the timeline of Buddha Dhamma and see whether we can discern when the pure Dhamma started going underground. There are a few historical facts that most people agree on (here, BCE = Before Current Era, CE = Current Era = AD):

- 563 – 483 BCE: Buddha Gotama
- 377-307 BCE: The city of Anuradhapura, Sri Lanka, was established by King Pandukabhaya. But there is evidence that human colonization in Sri Lanka goes back to 30,000 years; see the detailed article on Sri Lanka on Wikipedia:
[Wikipedia: http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/History_of_Sri_Lanka](http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/History_of_Sri_Lanka)
- 247 BCE: Buddha Dhamma was introduced to the Sinhala Kingdom in Anuradhapura, Sri Lanka by Ven. Mahinda Thero.
- 29 BCE: Tipitaka (the version recited at the Third Dhamma Sangayana around 247 BCE), was written down in Sri Lanka.
- 100-200 CE: Ven. Maliyadeva, Last Arahant by some accounts, lived in Sri Lanka : <http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Maliyadeva> (However, it is likely that there have been “jathi Sotapannas” who attained Arahant hood since then, but may not be that many)
- 100 BCE: It is likely that Mahayana Buddhism actually originated when the earliest Mahāyāna sūtras to include the very first versions of the Prajñāpāramitā series, along with texts concerning Akṣobhya Buddha, which were probably written down in the 1st century BCE in the south of India : <http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mahayana>
- 150-250 CE: Life of Nagarjuna; considered to be the founder of Mahayana Buddhism. Nagarjuna’s central concept was the “emptiness” (shunyata) of all dhammas. Most influential work is Mulamadhyamakakarika (Fundamental verses on the middle way).
- 409-431 CE: King Mahanama’s reign in Sri Lanka, when Buddhaghosa arrived in Anuradhapura, Sri Lanka, and wrote his commentaries on Sinhala Atthakatha, which themselves were commentaries on Tipitaka. Visuddhimagga is his most important work.
- Two major works that influence Theravada teachings to date are the Visuddhimagga of Acariya Buddhaghosa and Abhidhammattha Sangaha by Acariya Anuruddha. Both are believed to have lived in Kanicipura (Conjeevaram), South India, in the 5th century when Buddhism flourished in that area.

2. The Visuddhimagga of Buddhaghosa clearly defines *anicca* and *anatta* as impermanence and “no-self”. All Mahayana literature, at least starting with the Prajñāpāramitā series have even worse distortions, and Mahayana influence in Sri Lanka obviously started close to the time of its origins in India.

- Abhimattha Sangaha also contain the same problems as Visuddhimagga, and thus the radical change of the doctrine by that time is quite clear.

3. Therefore, it is safe to say that the misinterpretations of the Tipitaka by Theravada sect probably started around 100 CE or so and gradually took hold until they were firmly

established by Buddhaghosa's work, in particular Visuddhimagga.

- It is also clear that we still have the original Tipitaka that was written down in 29 BCE, and that at least for 100 years after it was written down, the correct interpretation of the Tipitaka helped many to attain Nibbana.
- However, after the 4th to 5th century in particular, Tipitaka was set aside and texts like Visuddhimagga and Abhimatthasangaha were used, as it is done to the date. The true and pure Dhamma has been hidden all these years.

4. Here are the major misinterpretations of the Tipitaka that are widely used at the present time in ALL countries where Theravada Dhamma is being practiced:

- Anicca is interpreted as “impermanence” and *anatta* as “no-self”. This is a major problem; either “self” or “no-self” both were labelled “ditthis” or wrong views by the Buddha (see, “[Kilesa \(Defilements\), Ditthi \(Wrong Views\), Samma Ditthi \(Good/Correct Views\)](#)”). Without understanding the three characteristics of nature (*anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*), **it is not possible to reach even the Sotapanna stage**. I have several posts on the site on detailing why this is the case. Please send me your comments if there is ANY valid reason to counter these arguments or any other on this web site. We NEED to get this straightened out for the sake of ALL.
- Most meditation techniques taught by Theravada institutions are incorrect; they teach Anariya versions; see, “[Power of the Human Mind – Anariya Mundane Jhanas](#)” and “[Power of the Human Mind – Ariya Jhanas](#)”. Breath meditation is NOT the Anapanasati bhavana taught by the Buddha, and kasina meditation was not taught by the Buddha at all.
- Only a pessimistic world view is presented, where there is hardly any mention about the better version of happiness, niramisa sukha that is achievable in this very life (see, “[Three Kinds of Happiness](#)” and “[How to Taste Nibbana](#)”), by following the Path even before attaining the Sotapanna stage. In fact, Buddha Dhamma is not a “pessimistic world view”, rather the “reality of the wider world of 31 realms”; see, “[Foundation of Dhamma](#)”, and the follow-up posts.

Now we will start to examine the historical timeline that will provide some clues on how these key Dhamma concepts went underground starting before the fourth century CE.

Next, “[Historical Timelines of Buddha Dhamma and Sri Lanka – The End of Sinhala Commentaries](#)”,
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Historical Timelines of Buddha Dhamma and Sri Lanka – End of Sinhala Commentaries

Here is a timeline compiled by Bhikkhu Nyanamoli, taken from his introduction to “The Path of Purification (Visuddhimagga)”, Bhadantacariya Buddhaghosa (translated by Bhikkhu Nyanamoli), Vol. 1, 1976. The following summary lists the significant events during the reign of various kings:

King Devanampiyatissa (307-276 BCE):

- Arrival of Ven. Mahinda in Anuradhapura and establishing Dhamma in the kingdom of King Devanampiyatissa.
- Mahavira monastery founded by Ven. Mahinda.

King Dutugemunu (161-137 BCE):

- For the first time in history, he united all of Sri Lanka under one kingdom.

King Vattagamini (104-88 BCE):

- Abhayagiri monastery founded by the King and becomes separate from Mahavihara monastery.
- Sensing insecurity, Mahavira monastery writes down Tipitaka (away from the royal capital).

King Vasabha (66-110 CE):

- Sinhala commentaries on Tipitaka ended being recorded at any time after his reign.

King Voharika-Tissa (215-237 CE):

- King supports both Mahavihara and Abhayagiri monasteries.
- Abhayagiri adopts Vetulya (Mahayana?) pitaka.
- King suppresses Vetulya doctrines.

King Gothabhaya (254-267 CE):

- King supports Mahavihara monastery.
- 60 bhikkhus in Abhayagiri banished by King for upholding Vetulya doctrines.
- Indian Bhikkhu Sangamitta supports Abhayagiri monastery.

King Jettha-Tissa (267-277 CE):

- King favors Mahavihara monastery; Sangamitta flees to India.

King Mahasena (277-304 CE):

- King supports Sangamitta, who returns from India.
- Persecution of Mahavihara by King; its Bhikkhus driven from capital for 9 years.
- Sangamitta assassinated.
- Restoration of Mahavihara.
- Vetulya books burned down.

King Sir Meghavanna (304-332 CE):

- King favors Mahavihara.
- Sinahala monastery established at Buddha Gaya in India.

King Jettha-Tissa II (332-334 CE):

- Dipavamsa composed.
- Some of Buddhadatta Thera's works.

King Mahanama (412-434 CE):

- Buddhaghosa arrives in Sri Lanka.

To quote (starting on p. xii):

“...Now by about the end of first century B.C. E. (dates are very vague), with Sanskrit Buddhist literature just launching out upon its long era of magnificence, Sanskrit was on its way to become a language of international culture. In Ceylon the Great monastery (Mahavihara), already committed by tradition to orthodoxy based on Pali, had been confirmed in that attitude by the schism of its rival, which now began publicly to study the new ideas from India.In the first century C.E., Sanskrit Buddhism (“Hinayana”, and perhaps by then Mahayana) was growing rapidly and spreading abroad. The Abhayagiri monastery would naturally have been busy studying and advocating some of these weighty developments while the Mahavihara has nothing new to offer.King Vasabha's reign (66-110 CE) seems to be the last mentioned in the Commentaries as we have them now, from which it may lie dormant, nothing further being added. Perhaps the Mahavihara, now living only on its past, was itself getting infected with heresies.in King Mahasena's reign (277-304 CE) things came to a head. With the persecution of Mahavihara with royal assent and the expulsion of its bhikkhus from the capital the Abhayagiri monastery enjoyed nine years of triumph. But the ancient institution rallied its supporters in the Southern provinces and the king repented. The bhikkhus returned and the king restored the buildings, which had been stripped to adorn the rival”.

“Still, the Mahavihara must have foreseen, after this affair, that unless it could successfully compete with the “modern” Sanskrit in the field of international Buddhist culture by cultivating Pali at home and aboard it could assure its position at home. **It was a revolutionary project, involving the displacement of Sinhala by Pali as the language for the study and discussion of Buddhist teachings, and the founding of a school of Pali literary composition.**It is not known what was the first original Pali composition in this period; but the *Dipavamsa* (dealing with historical evidence) belongs here (for it ends with Mahasena's reign and is quoted in the *Samantapasadika*, and quite possibly the *Vimuttimagga* (dealing with practice), was another early attempt by the Mahavihara in this period (4th century) to reassert its supremacy through original Pali literary composition”.

Thus it is clear that the historical tradition of compiling Sinhala commentaries (on Tipitaka) was abandoned somewhere in the 4th century or even before that, and a concerted effort was initiated by the Mahavihara to compile literature in the Pali language to counter the onslaught by Sanskrit Mahayana literature in India that was benefiting the Abhayagiri monastery. The appearance of Buddhaghosa on the scene in the early fifth century accelerated this effort to compile Pali literature.

Next, “Buddhaghosa and his Influence that was to Prevail for 1500 Years”,

Three Levels of Practice

1. According to Buddha Dhamma, people can be divided into three categories:

- Those who are on a downward path (mind fully-covered) or *moha* is strong. They are unable to even see the immorality of many of their actions.
- Those who are on the (mundane) Eightfold Path. They can distinguish moral from immoral in most cases and thus *moha* is reduced, but have not yet grasped the meanings of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.
- Those who are on the (transcendental or *lokottara*) Noble Eightfold Path. This starts at the *Sotapanna* stage of *Nibbana*, and the *moha* is reduced to *avijja*. *Avijja* is gradually reduced as one attains higher stages, and is removed at the *Arahant* stage.

2. One way to get an idea of how to distinguish the first two categories is to use the conventional five precepts as a guide. If one is engaging in any of the five (intentionally killing other beings, stealing, sexual misconduct, verbal abuse of others, and getting the mind “drunk”) then one belongs to the first category.

- The Buddha said that what matters in one’s intention. Some people take the “five precepts” in the literal sense and thus may get confused. Each of us unintentionally kill many small creatures when we walk or even boiling water to make a tea (because there are microscopic living beings in water). Such acts done without the intention of killing do not count; see, “[What is Kamma? – Is Everything Determined by Kamma?](#)”.
- Stealing does not have to be just taking something that does not belong to oneself. Even if one is abusing public property or damaging other’s property that is stealing because one is taking away the ability of others to enjoy something.
- Sexual misconduct is engaging in sexual activities that are harmful to oneself or others. The obvious are to have relationships outside marriage and with children.
- Verbal abuse is not just lying, but also to prevent from slander, hateful speech, and gossiping.
- Some people think even taking a sip of alcohol is breaking the fifth precept. Alcohol consumption is not good if it is a habit or it can lead to immoral activities. Drug use should be completely avoided, because it is easy to get addictive. Some people get “drunk” with power, money, beauty, etc and that is as bad.

3. Most religions (including conventional “Buddhism”) teach people how to live a “moral life”, i.e., how to stay in the second category.

- The goal of most religions is to avoid the hell and get to the heaven at death. In terms of conventional “Buddhism” this is equivalent to “seeking a good rebirth”.
- But the Buddha said birth in the hell is inevitable at some point in the future (rebirths) unless one comprehends the true nature of the “wider world” of 31 realms, and at least attain the *Sotapanna* stage of *Nibbana*. But one cannot even start on this Path, unless one is in the second stage.

4. Thus, the first thing is to make sure that one does not belong to the first category. The “Moral Living” section provides basic but critical information on what is “immoral” according to the Buddha. There are only a few things here that are not in other religions, including (intentional) killing of animals and the concept of *micca ditthi* (wrong perceptions about the world).

- In Buddha Dhamma, there is no permanent heaven or permanent hell. There are many heavenly worlds, but none is permanent. One may be born in such realms based on one's good deeds, and the "Seeking Good Rebirths" section explains how good rebirths result from a moral life.
- However, since we do not know what we have done in our past lives, there is no way to guarantee a "good rebirth". In fact, one is likely to end up in one of the many "hells" or "*apayas*" at some point in future lives unless one attains the *Sotapanna* stage. This is the key message of the Buddha. The "Seeking *Nibbana*" section is on how to seek *Nibbana*, focusing on the *Sotapanna* stage (i.e., to avoid rebirth in the hells or the "*apayas*").
- The difference between the second and third categories is described in the "[Maha Chattarisaka Sutta \(Discourse on the Great Forty\)](#)".

Moral Living

The Basics

- "[The Pale Blue Dot.....](#)"
- "[The Law of Attraction, Habits \(Gathi\), and Cravings \(Asavas\)](#)"
- "[Habits, Goals, and Character \(Gathi\)](#)"
- "[Wrong Views \(Micca Ditthi\) – A Simpler Analysis](#)"
- "[First Noble Truth – A Simple Explanation of One Aspect](#)"

Calming the Mind

- "[Key to Calming the Mind – The Five Hindrances](#)"
- "[Solution to a Wandering Mind – Abandon Everything?](#)"
- "[Right Speech – How to avoid Accumulating Bad Kamma](#)"
- "[Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)"
- "[How to Taste Nibbana](#)"
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[Working Towards Good Rebirths](#)

[“Sansaric Habits and asavas”](#)

[“Vagaries of Life and the Way to Seek Good Rebirths”](#)

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[“How the Buddha Described the Chance of Rebirth in the Human Realm”](#)

[“Kamma, Debt, and Meditation”](#)

[“Kilesa \(Defilements\), Ditthi \(Wrong Views\), Samma Ditthi \(Good/Correct Views\)”](#)

[“How do we Decide which View is Wrong View \(Ditthi\)?”](#)

[“Three Kinds of Ditthi, Eightfold Paths, and Samadhi”](#)

[“Implications of the Rebirth Process in Daily Life and in Society”](#)

[“What Does Buddha Dhamma Say about Creator, Satan, Angels, and Demons?”](#)

[“Patisandhi Citta – How the Next Life is Determined According to Gathi”](#)

[Seeking Nibbana](#)

[“Myths about the Sotapanna Stage”](#)

[“Why a Sotapanna is Better off than any King, Emperor, or a Billionaire”](#)

[“Gathi \(Character\), Anusaya \(Temptations\), and Asava \(Cravings\)”](#)

[“The Way to Nibbana – Removal of asavas”](#)

[“Why is Correct Interpretation of Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta so Important?”](#)

[“The Sotapanna Stage”](#)

[“How to Cultivate the Noble Eightfold Path Starting with Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta”](#)

[“Akusala Citta – How a Sotapanna Avoids Apayagami Citta”](#)

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The Pale Blue Dot.....

Even if some of us are not thinking about a “wider world view” or “what happens after death”, all of us want a better world for all of us.

I thought of sharing this marvelous video from the late Dr. Carl Sagan:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?feature=player_embedded&v=wupToqz1e2g&x-yt-cl=85114404&x-yt-ts=1422579428

When I read the writings of all those past scientists like Sagan, Feynman, Einstein, Bohm, Heisenberg, etc, I wonder how much more they could have accomplished spiritually if they were exposed to pure Buddha Dhamma. Yet, I am still impressed by their pure reasoning and compassion for the humanity; they were not just scientists with a narrow focus. They thought deeply about the “purpose of existence”.

Even though science has revealed the unimaginable vastness of space, it has not yet even approached the “depth of time for existence”. Not only is our place in the vast cosmos insignificantly small, our individual existence of about 100 years (in this life) is insignificantly small too.

- Yet, out of countless beings that live on this Earth, we are the only species that is capable of forging our own destiny.
- We need to be mindful not only of the welfare of family and friends, but for all other people and beings (seen and unseen).

Do you know why some actions are good and others bad? We may quote some ethical maxims or juggle with philosophical abstractions, but there is a very simple explanation that is called nature: “Good is good because it leads to happiness and freedom of the heart. Bad is bad because it leads to suffering, and it feels bad”. The Buddha said a moral deed (*punna kamma*) is one that makes one’s heart “pulsating with joy”; an immoral deed leads to a burdened heart.

Nature encourages morality and punishes immorality via its built-in reward-punishment system, which is none other than the laws of *kamma*. But the punishment is not immediate, and that is why it is hard for people to make the connection. Even if the punishment in question comes a few lives later, this “time lag” is really not that long since *sansara* is “beginning-less” and “endless”.

Humans innately know what is right and what wrong. Most bad actions are committed with a mind that is not calm, but is agitated. Therefore, we need to learn how to calm our minds: “[Key to Calming the Mind – The Five Hindrances](#)”.

By the way, Dr. Sagan’s books like “Pale Blue Dot: A Vision of the Human Future in Space”, “The Varieties of Scientific Experience”, and “Billions & Billions: Thoughts on Life and Death at the Brink of the Millennium” are very informative. These are likely to be available in local public libraries.

Next, “[Buddhism without Rebirth and Nibbana?](#)“,

The Law of Attraction, Habits, Character (Gathi), and Cravings (Asavas)

1. The saying, “Birds of a feather flock together”, is true and we can see that all around us.
 - We can put people into various categories: sportsmen/sportswomen, thieves, politicians, murderers, church goers, environmentalists, liberals, conservatives, etc.
 - In a school, kids tend to get in to different groups too: those who play sports, like partying, nerds, geeks, etc.
 - Of course, there may be some overlaps, but we can clearly see people tend to socialize with those who have common interests, likings, etc.
2. This is a universal principle. A basic rule in chemistry is that “like molecules” stay together. We all know that oil and water do not mix together; the two molecules are very different. On the other hand, water molecules (or oil molecules) stay together happily.
3. Buddha Dhamma describes laws of nature. So it is not surprising that the law of attraction comes naturally out of Dhamma. There are three key words in Dhamma that are relevant: habits, character (gathi), and cravings (asavas); see, “[Habits and Goals, and Character \(Gathi\)](#)“. Actually, some of the habits we take from life-to-life, see, “[Sansaric Habits, Character \(Gathi\) and Cravings \(Asava\)](#)”.
4. The law of attraction can be explained with Paticca Samuppada, the principle of cause and effect in Dhamma; see, “[Paticca Samuppada – Introduction](#)“.
 - “Pati + ichcha” means associate or bind with something one likes. “sama + uppada” means what results from that is something similar in kind; i.e., that association leads to an outcome of the same kind.
 - If a child hangs out willingly and enthusiastically with others who like to work hard and enjoy getting good grades, then the child will continue on that path to success. The more a child willingly hangs out with a criminal gang, his mentality becomes more attuned to criminal behavior, and becomes a criminal capable of doing atrocious crimes.
 - **Thus, in Dhamma it says, “gathi (character) attracts a similar gathi”.** We will see this developed into a very deep meaning.
5. However, Dhamma says this law of attraction does not need to be fatalistic, i.e., one with a set of bad habits/cravings does not have to go down a slippery slope. One CAN change those habits/cravings GRADUALLY and thus change one’s character (gathi).

However, a child is not capable of doing this on his/her own. That is why it is parents’ responsibility to direct the child:

- Parents can make a HUGE contribution in setting up good habits/cravings in a child starting from the point of conception. The love and care the parent feel towards each other IS FELT by the fetus. That is as important, perhaps more important, than the food consumed by the mother. A child born into an environment of abuse or violence may develop life-long problems.
- As the child grows, child’s behavior and habits are influenced HUGELY by the parents, friends, and the school environment. It is the responsibility of the parents and teachers to guide the child.

The reason is that the manomaya kaya of the child is aware of the surroundings even from the very

early stages, even though it does not have any control over the situation; thus it is affected by the “environment”; see, “[Manomaya Kaya and Physical Body](#)”.

6. When one becomes an adult, one has full control. Even if the child years were not good, and even if one has acquired a set of bad habits (or even sansaric habits that have molded one’s character in fundamental ways), it is POSSIBLE to change them.

- One can use the same Paticca Samuppada principle to change direction.
- All one needs to do is to change the “pati+ichcha” part, i.e., to change one’s likings or habits. Then “sama+uppada” will happen automatically. That is nature’s law.

7. First, though, one needs to convince one’s own mind that the current path will lead to a bad destiny; one needs to contemplate the bad consequences of staying on the same wrong path. AND one also needs to contemplate the benefits of cultivating good habits.

For example, a smoker cannot just make a New Year resolution and stop smoking (a few can, but most cannot). Instead, it is better first to look at all the medical evidence out there that show strong evidence that one could die early, and also may be burdened in old age with lung problems if one continued smoking. One could talk to someone who has given up smoking and listen to that person’s “success story”, or think about not having to see the annoyance of those who are around when one lights a cigarette, etc.

8. When one acquires “good habits” (initially slowly and with effort), one is attracted to people, settings, work places, environments that further nurture and grow those habits, which in turn change one’s character; thus the process becomes self-feeding once started. This is the law of attraction as embedded in Paticca Samuppada: “pati+ichcha” leading to “sama+uppada”. Thus it is critical to develop a liking (chanda) and desire (citta) for what one wants to accomplish, and to critically analyze the situation (vimansa), and make an effort (viriya); see, “[The Four Bases of Mental Power \(Satara Iddhipada\)](#)”.

- When one embraces certain ways and activities (good or bad), those become habits. In Sinhala, it is said that, “ganna deya gathi venava”. When one keeps doing this over and over and possibly over numerous rebirths, they get deeply embedded as deep-seated cravings (asavas). Those gathi (character) also become “bhava” as well; whatever that is liked becomes one’s existence (bhava) or reality; in Sinhala, “thibena bhava”).
- When one has certain character (gathi) it becomes easy to get into the corresponding “state” or existence; this is one meaning of bhava. For example, one with a “drinking habit” is easy to be “born” in that state, i.e., just the sight of a bar may cause that person to get drunk. **This is the concept extended in Buddha Dhamma: It is easy to be “born” with those characteristics in a new birth (uppatti bhava) or even in daily activities (pavutti bhava).** This a bit deeper concept discussed in the paticca samuppada section; see, for example, “[Akusala-Mula Paticca Samuppada](#)”.

9. The problem many people run into is that they would like to change quickly and that does not normally happen. Initial progress could be slow. However, when one gets traction, the process speeds up. It is like trying to reverse the direction of a moving car: one needs stop going in the wrong direction first. Then when one starts the car facing the right direction, it takes a little while to accelerate and ramp up the speed. See, “[Habits, Goals, and Character \(Gathi\)](#)”, and the links there. Let us consider two examples:

- If one wants to be a successful businessman, then one should try to “build up” habits that business people have: knowledge of the particular business, learning relevant skills, hard work, etc. THEN the law of attraction starts working and will pull one to others with similar interests and environments or conditions automatically.
- If a high-school kid wants to go to college, then he/she should make an effort to get into that mindset: Spending more time deciding what kinds of subjects to study, and then get “immersed” in it. The parent and teachers can make a big difference by encouragement and guiding in the correct path.
- If someone wants to attain “niramisa sukha” (see, [“Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?”](#)), one needs to spend some time and first learn the true Dhamma. **As one learns, one gets motivated to learn more, because one starts feeling the change in one’s character (gathi).**

In all cases, one will be attracting external influences (friends, other interests, etc.) conducive to that effort automatically. AND one will lose some of the old influences too. Obviously, the ideal settings for the above examples could be different from each other, but not contradictory. Before trying to attain Nibbana, a person with family responsibilities will need to fulfill those by making an income to support the family; a child needs to study well and find good employment. If one does not have the necessities of life (food, housing, clothing, and medicine) it is not possible to contemplate, let alone meditate.

10. Finally, the law of attraction works in the sansaric rebirth process too.

- Many are reborn to the same families, same geographic locations, etc.
- At the moment of death, one is automatically “pulled” to a “matching birth” according to one’s kamma vipaka and also one’s habits and tendencies. One who has lived an immoral life is likely get a similar outcome in the next life: one who “lives like an animal” is likely to become an animal. One who lives like a “Deva” (a being devoid of hate) or a “Brahma” (a being devoid of greed and hate), is likely to reborn a Deva, Brahma.
- Thus by cultivating good habits and getting rid of bad habits, one CAN change the direction of one’s current life (character) AND future lives too.
- The best way to do this is to be mindful all the time. See the bad consequences of bad actions and bad habits and avoid them; see the good consequences of good actions and good habits and embrace them. At the very basic level this is what is stated in the Anapanasati, Satipattana, and Sabbasava suttas (taking in what is good and getting rid of what is bad).

11. Currently, there are several books written on the subject of the law of attraction and how one can use certain procedures to attain goals, build relationships, etc. The Buddha described those and more 2500 years ago.

12. Many people think kamma is deterministic, for example if one is born to poverty that is one’s destiny, but that is NOT the case. Kamma is not deterministic; see, [“What is Kamma? – Is Everything Determined by Kamma?”](#) The human mind is very powerful, and if used right (by purifying it and then using it mindfully), the possibilities are endless: see, [“Power of the Human Mind – Introduction”](#) and the two posts following that for more details.

Habits, Goals, and Character (Gathi)

1. As I mentioned before, Buddha Dhamma can be interpreted at three levels; see, “[Foundation of Dhamma](#)“. But the key to making progress at ANY LEVEL is to get rid of bad habits and instill good habits, **because they mold one’s character even through the rebirth process.**

- The Pali (and Sinhala) word for character is “gathi”. One’s character can be changed (for good or bad) via changing one’s habits. These habits take deep roots when practiced over many lives, and becomes deep-seated cravings (“asavas”) that forms one’s character.
- Some habits are harmless. For example, some people have the habit of shaking their legs while sitting. It could be annoying to some, but it is not “morally wrong”, i.e., it is not one of the ten defilements; see, “[Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)](#)“.
- But there are other habits, such as drinking, stealing, sexual misconduct, etc that are morally wrong and do belong to the ten defilements. Generating greedy or hateful thoughts can be a bad habit too. Some have a tendency to easily “flare up”.
- Then there could some, like gambling, that could lead to immoral actions.
- There are good habits too: giving, helping others, teaching, and being compassionate in general.

2. For someone at the highest level, the [Sabbasava Sutta](#) explains how one can work towards Nibbana in a systematic way by developing good habits (“gathi”) and removing asavas; see “Key Points from the Sabbasava Sutta” under “[The Sotapanna Stage](#)”.

3. Here we are going to look at it to see how those recommended steps can be used in the day-to-day life, i.e., for a moral life. Those steps can be used to remove any bad habits, for example, from alcohol or drug use, smoking, to eating too much.

- They can also be used in achieving goals, say lose weight, getting rid of depression, or starting a new business. Achieving goals require building good habits.

4. A habit is something one gets used to by repeating it over and over. Good habits make a life easier to live with, and bad habits lead to bad results. Scientific studies have confirmed that our brains “can rewire its connections” (plasticity of the brain), thus getting rid of bad habits and instilling good ones. The trick is to “stick to a set procedure”. Many people give up before giving their brains enough time to “rewire”; this is why many “New Year resolutions” go unfulfilled.

One way to remove bad habits is to look at the bad consequences of such habits; see, “[The Law of Attraction, Habits, Character \(Gathi\), and Cravings \(Asavas\)](#)“.

5. The seven steps in the Sabbasava Sutta can be helpful for developing good habits for a moral life. These steps basically convince the mind of the benefits of good habits/downside of bad habits and set up a conducive environment.

The 7 steps in the Sabbasava Sutta (interpreted conventionally or “padaparama” interpretation):

- **Develop an understanding** (learn all about the direct and indirect benefits, what is involved, the best way to go about achieving the goal, etc)
- **Discipline** (Avoid getting distracted by things that provide “temporary pleasures”, like a drug addict thinking it is OK to “take a small puff” while working to be free of drugs).

- **Association** (associate with knowledgeable people who can help and get to know other helpful resources)
- **Patience and tolerance** (being thoughtful and not being agitated or “shaken off” by small inconveniences; having perseverance)
- **Avoidance** (dissociating with people who have negative attitudes and avoiding unsafe places, practices, etc.)
- **Removal** (suppressing discouraging thoughts by contemplating on the long-term benefits of the project)
- **Bhavana** or “immersing in the project” (bhavana or meditation is constantly thinking about the main objective; getting the mind to focus on it).

6. A careful overview of what one has in mind (the goal) is needed first. Just like one should not undertake a journey without learning about the destination, the path, and the reason for the journey, one needs a clear vision of the goal, how it can be beneficial to oneself and others (family, friends, and even to the society), and the way to achieve it.

- However, the steps are not to be followed sequentially. Once the overview is done and the decision to undertake the project is made, all steps should be used as appropriate. For example, the first and last items on the list (understanding and meditating) go hand-in-hand.

7. Those steps can be used by anyone to enhance the quality of life in general, a moral life with a “peace-of-mind”. They are the sensible things to do. For example, an important decision for anyone should be to live in a good area not prone to crime, floods, etc. Associating with immoral or people with negative attitudes is always to be avoided. Going out at inappropriate times, in inappropriate places, is just ‘asking for trouble’. If one carefully goes through the list, it will be clear why all those steps make common sense.

If you would like to read about how these habits develop into deep-seated sansaric habits or asavas, see, “[Sansaric Habits, Character \(Gathi\) and Cravings \(Asava\)](#)“. Also, “The Four Bases of Mental Power (Satara Iddhipada)“, can be helpful in achieving goals .

Next, “[Wrong Views \(Micca Ditthi\) – A Simpler Analysis](#)“,

Wrong Views (Micca Ditthi) – A Simpler Analysis

Micca (pronounced “michchä”) means wrong, and *ditthi* (pronounced “diththi”) means views. Here it is about the wrong views on existence. It is the most basic reason why people cannot grasp the message of the Buddha, and that is unfortunate. We all are looking at the world through “colored glasses”; each one has his/her own set of beliefs or “ditthis”, so we cannot see the real nature.

- Some facts about nature are hard to believe, and it took the efforts of many scientists to change two common wrong views (ditthis) that had been with the humans up to recently: that the Earth is flat and it is at the center of the universe.

1. These days, most of us believe that the Earth goes goes around the Sun. But it is quite clear that it goes against our experience, and the accepted views were the opposites even a few hundred years ago. We do not have any direct experience of the motion of the Earth, either its rotary motion around its own axis or in its orbit around the Sun. And we see ample evidence to the contrary, i.e., for the Sun rotating around the Earth, because we experience a sunrise and a sunset everyday!

- If one looks at the speeds involved it becomes even more harder to believe that the Earth is moving: The Earth moves around its axis at a speed of about 1,040.4 miles/hour (1,674.4 kilometer/hour or 465.1 meter/second) at the equator (and zero at the North and South Poles) and it moves along its orbit around the Sun at an average speed of about 67,062 miles/hour (107,300 kilometer/hour). Thus it is surprising that we have no direct perception of such movements.
- Of course, we do not feel it because everything around us is also doing exactly the same thing. When we travel in a car, we “feel the ride” because we can see the scenery passing by (and because the ride may not be smooth; luckily, the Earth is very smooth in its motions). It is the “relative motion” that we perceive.
- However, after Galileo invented the telescope, people made more precision measurements of the planets and the heliocentric model was needed to explain all those new findings.

2. But there are many people who still believe that the Sun goes around the Earth! To quote a passage from the Wikipedia article, http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Geocentric_model

- “..Morris Berman quotes survey results that show currently some 20% of the U.S. population believe that the sun goes around the Earth (geocentrism) rather than the Earth goes around the sun (heliocentrism), while a further 9% claimed not to know. Polls conducted by Gallup in the 1990s found that 16% of Germans, 18% of Americans and 19% of Britons hold that the Sun revolves around the Earth. A study conducted in 2005 by Jon D. Miller of Northwestern University, an expert in the public understanding of science and technology, found that about 20%, or one in five, of American adults believe that the Sun orbits the Earth. According to 2011 VTSIOM poll, 32% of Russians believe that the Sun orbits the Earth”.
- And, there are even some who believe that the Earth is flat: http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Modern_flat_Earth_societies

3. Thus sometimes it is very hard to get rid of certain “wrong views” because of our “experiences” and “gut feelings”. Yet, if one hangs onto such wrong views (in the face of contrary evidence) one cannot get a correct world view. This is why we always need to “look at the big picture”; the “bigger the picture”, the better it is. It is hard to see much details while walking on the ground, but one see a

whole lot better looking down from a helicopter.

- Luckily, nowadays, we have the advantage of technology to confirm that the Earth is not flat and that it moves around the Sun.

4. Similarly, it is very hard for many people to believe that humans could be reborn as animals. One argument that was given in a book that refuted rebirth was that “..in that case, the human population should not be changing, but we see an increase of the human population over the past centuries”. Apparently, the author did not even consider that a human could be born an animal. Again, it is matter of a very narrow world view.

- When Darwin presented his theory of evolution, it made a huge psychological impact on the society, which was not ready to accept that humans evolved from animals. It is said that Darwin did not publish his now-famous volume, *On the Origin of Species by Means of Natural Selection*, until 1859, more than 20 years after he had first formulated his theory because he knew that it would create an uproar.
- It must be noted that Buddha Dhamma does not require a theory of evolution. When conditions for a birth in certain realm are satisfied, the nature has come up with many ways to make that birth take place.
- Accepting the fact that human can be BORN in the animal realm is an even more shocking thing to contemplate for many people. But we should not just go by our instincts, because the world is much more complex than we perceive with our limited senses.
- Even though we consider the life of an animal as “useless”, life is the most important thing in the world for the lowest worm. All living beings have craving to continue the life they have, how pathetic it appears to us. Our “smelly bodies” are said to be repulsive to the devas who have fine bodies that are free of diseases as well.

5. When the Buddha said, “..those who depart from the human realm, those will be reborn as humans or *devas* can be compared to the few grains of sand that I pick up on my fingernail. Those who are reborn in the lower four realms are exceedingly many, compared to the sand on this great Earth”, it appears to most people as an exaggeration.

- But as described in the post, “[How the Buddha Described the Chance of Rebirth in the Human Realm](#)“, modern science is slowly proving that indeed the number of living beings, just in the animal realm, is unimaginably large, and that human population of about 7 billion is negligibly small. There are more living beings in your backyard soil.
- Of course we cannot see the beings in the other three lower realms. But, just because they are not amenable to our senses, we cannot say they do not exist. Human vision is restricted to an almost infinitesimal sliver of 400 to 700 nanometers in the wavelength spectrum. Our ears can detect only 20 to 20,000 Hertz audio frequencies. Other animals use their own “bands” above and below that. Human beings have one of the poorest senses of smell of all the organisms on Earth., etc; see, “The Meaning of Human Existence” by Edward O. Wilson, who is a leading biologist.
- We have only begun “see” other hidden parts of “our world” with the aid of science; see, “[Expanding “Consciousness” by Using Technology](#)“.

6. Even though scientific progress has been impressive, it takes generations to move the “knowledge

base” forward; see, [“Dhamma and Science – Introduction”](#).

- On the other hand, by PURIFYING the mind, one can discern EVERYTHING that is of importance in a lifetime; see, [“Expanding “Consciousness” by Purifying the Mind”](#), and the power of the mind in the posts starting with, [“Power of the Human Mind – Introduction”](#).
- That is how the Buddha knew about not only the existence of innumerable planetary systems in the universe (many other examples are discussed in other posts), but also about the fact that this life of about 100 years is insignificant in the rebirth process.
- And there is compelling evidence for rebirth; see, [“Evidence for Rebirth”](#).

7. Without the “correct view” of this world, we will be simply “groping in the dark”. When one has only a narrow and blurred vision, one cannot move forward. If one believes that this is the only life we have, then one could be making bad decisions, that could affect for billions of years to come.

- That is why it is worthwhile at least to examine the evidence of the “wider world view” of the Buddha, where both space and time are infinite. While modern science has confirmed the infinite extent of space, it has not yet “discovered” the fact that life does not end at physical death; it is just the end of one insignificantly small sliver of the time span of a sentient being.

8. Most people think the First Noble Truth is about suffering in the sense of just physical or mental suffering in THIS LIFE. But that suffering is NOT what the First Noble Truth is about. If it is that, then “suffering” is limited to only some people, because there are many who live fairly “happy lives”, and some of those even engage in immoral behavior.

- **The First Noble Truth is about the suffering that is hidden.** It is the unavoidable suffering for anyone in this cycle of rebirths, until one grasps the “correct world view”.
- This is why the Buddha said, “my Dhamma has never been heard before”. It is hard to grasp until one is willing to spend some time and examine the “bigger picture”. One should not just go by one’s instincts, but rather by the facts.

9. This is also why “*samma ditthi*” or “correct view” comes first in the Noble Eightfold Path. This is the “correct world view”.

- When one understands this world view, one “sees” that it is not fruitful to: think immoral thoughts (*micca sankappa*), utter inappropriate speech (*micca vaca*), do inappropriate things (*micca kammanta*), live an immoral life (*micca ajiva*), to strive to achieve unfruitful things (*micca vayama*), have an immoral mindfulness (*micca sati*), and thus get into an immoral state (*micca samadhi*). **Even if we can “get away” from paying for misdeeds in this life, we will have to pay with interest in the future lives. Similarly, any good deeds will be rewarded in future lives, if not within this life itself.**
- Thus, with correct views, one will be automatically following the Noble Eightfold Path: *samma sankappa*, *samma vaca*, *samma kammanta*, *samma ajiva*, *samma vayama*, *samma sati*, and thus get to *samma samadhi*. It all starts with *samma ditthi*, or the “correct views”.
- It is not a world view that is amenable to our “experience”, because our sense faculties are limited as we discussed above. But as we make progress, our minds will become clear and we WILL be able to see for ourselves the true nature of this world.
- There is a lot of evidence that what the Buddha said about “the wider world” 2500 years ago are

indeed true. We are lucky to be born at the time when efforts of many generations of scientists have confirmed many of his world views, and that should give us confidence (*saddha*) to take those views serious enough to spend some time examining the evidence. My goal is to present evidence from many aspects, because different people comprehend different aspects.

- Such a critical evaluation itself could be enough to dispel any wrong views. It is like lifting of a fog and being able to see clearly. When the mind becomes pure, one does not need “evidence from science” to confirm the worldview of the Buddha.

Next, “[First Noble Truth – A Simple Explanation of One Aspect](#)”

First Noble Truth – A Simple Explanation of One Aspect

1. One does not need to be a Buddhist or even heard about the Buddha to know what conventional “suffering” is. Anyone knows that getting sick, getting old, and dying is cause for suffering.
 - But then the Buddha said, “these four Noble Truths are not known to the world until a Buddha describes them”.
 - Thus the Buddha was talking about a kind of suffering that ANYONE in this world is destined to have either now or in the future. He was mainly concerned with the LONG TERM suffering, in the future rebirths and how to STOP that from taking place.
2. However, there are some sufferings in this very life that arise due to our current way of life, or what we do or think right now. In this post I want to address such “SHORT TERM” sufferings that also can be AVOIDED.
 - A significant part of our suffering comes from the mind. Whether one lives in a grand mansion or in a hut, this part of suffering is common to us all.
 - And even some famous and rich people that we know could not bear this mental pain to such an extent that they committed suicide. From Elvis Presley and Marilyn Monroe to Whitney Houston and Robin Williams, there are many well-known cases; see, http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/List_of_suicides for a long list that extends to the past.
 - Suicide Prevention, see : <http://www.helpguide.org/articles/suicide-prevention/suicide-prevention-helping-someone-who-is-suicidal.htm>
3. Obviously, one can have mostly everything that any one of us can only wish for (health, wealth, beauty, fame, etc), but still suffer. One could get a glimpse of what the Buddha meant by suffering if one could contemplate on this issue, and that revelation itself could lead to the avoidance of *that kind of suffering*.
 - We can get rid of a big part of suffering in the near future by controlling hate or displeasure towards other people. Even though the other party may have done something wrong to us, most of the suffering is inflicted by ourselves. This needs some contemplation to clarify.
4. Suppose I come to know that someone said a bad (and untrue) thing about me to others. The moment I hear this my mind gets agitated. And I could be spending the next hour or two or even the next day or two saying to myself and friends, “I cannot believe that so and so said this about me. Why would he do that?”, and may be even be thinking about how to retaliate. All this time spent on such activity was a burden to the mind. I caused more suffering to myself by just dwelling on it, and by generating more hateful thoughts.
 - I could have handled the situation better as following: If I know from past experience that he would not have said it without a reason, I need to talk to him and clarify the situation. If that failed or if I knew that he was “just that type of a person” I just need to stay away from him. We cannot control the behavior of other people. The best thing is to stay away from such people.
 - Staying away from “bad company” is critical especially for children. It is imperative for the parents to make sure that their children stay away from bad friends.
5. Another thing that is related is not to try to spend too much of your time and energy to convince other people to see “things your way”. For valid or invalid reasons, each person has a set of beliefs

and convictions. I have realized that it causes unnecessary mental suffering to myself and others if I try hard to convince the other party of my own views. I have no right to say my views are better than the views of the others; I just explain things the way I see them.

- Even the Buddha did not try to even advice certain people, because they could have caused long-term harm for themselves by generating hateful thoughts of the Buddha.
- One has to realize that getting rid of ditthi or wrong views is the first step in getting some “cooling down”. It is true that palpable “cooling down” can be attained by getting rid of the worst wrong views; see, “Wrong Views (Micca Ditthi) – A Simpler Analysis”.

6. Then there is extreme greed, that could also lead to unnecessary suffering. Here one needs to make a distinction between two extremes: It is really necessary to avoid physical discomfort on one extreme. But trying to “acquire fancy things” for the sake of pride is the other extreme.

- We do need food, clothes, shelter, and medicine to avoid living a miserable life. Therefore, we need to make a decent living to provide such necessities for ourselves and our families.
- However, if we try to acquire, for example a “bigger and fancy house”, that could cause anxiety and even suffering especially one is stretching one’s resources to achieve that “extra bit of happiness”. That “extra bit of happiness” could become a nightmare in some cases, for example if one loses employment or encounters an unexpected expense.

7. One does not need to feel bad about the wealth one has acquired legitimately and to use that wealth for one’s comfort. One has already paid for that in the past (a good *kamma vipaka*). In the same way, if one is poor, one needs to understand two things per Buddha Dhamma: First, one is in that situation because of a past cause (bad *kamma vipaka*). Second, and more importantly, one can work oneself out of that situation, because *kamma vipaka* are not deterministic; see, “[What is Kamma? – Is Everything Determined by Kamma?](#)”.

8. The key is to live within one’s means, and strive for a better living condition if one actually does not have enough for a comfortable living. There is so much of “peace of mind” in a simple life, even if one has a lot of wealth. Most people ruin their lives by trying to seek sense pleasures using money. That only gets one on a track that leads to seeking more and more such pleasures and eventually running out options.

- The sad thing is that they do not know there is so much “peace of mind” to be had just by living a simple life with less greed and less hate.

9. It is hard to fathom, but it is true that craving for valuable material things makes one’s mind temporarily happy at times but perpetually burdened. This statement needs a lot of thought for clarification.

- The perceived happiness comes from the perceived “value” of the item by one’s mind, and if that item is lost or damaged that can lead to much more suffering. Here is a hypothetical situation: A mother dies and her two daughters inherit a supposedly highly valued necklace. Each daughter wants it, and they get into arguments and both come to much mental suffering. Eventually, a wise elder suggests them to sell the item and share the money. When they try to sell it, they find that it is of low quality and is really worthless. They had each inflicted so much suffering because of a “perceived value” for that necklace.

10. The real happiness is not having anything to worry about. That does not mean one needs to give

away everything one has.

- Using things that are available to oneself and having a greedy mindset are two different things.
- One could be living in a mansion with a peace of mind knowing that all his/her wealth is not forever, and another could be living with a burdened mind in a hut with so much attachment to whatever little he/she has or with jealousy/hatred for what others have.
- On the other hand, one could be living in a mansion with a burdened mind and could even commit suicide, while a poor person who has learned Dhamma could be living in a hut with a peace of mind content with what he/she has and knowing that any hardship is just for a short time (in this life).
- The bottom line is that things happen due to causes, and by controlling our minds we have the power to initiate good causes (moral deeds) and to suppress bad causes (immoral deeds). Some will be effective for the short term and all will be effective for the long term.

Also see, “[First Noble Truth is Suffering? Myths about Suffering](#)“.

Next, “[Difference between a Wish and a Determination \(Paramita\)](#)“,

Difference between a Wish and a Determination (Paramita)

1. It is easy to just wish for things, but a real determination has a firm commitment attached to it. A determination is a wish accompanied by a plan to make the wish come true.
 - One can drop a stone in water can wish for it to come back up. That is NOT going to happen.
 - Some goals (wishes) can be attained in this life: quitting smoking, passing an exam, getting a good job, etc. But still one has to make an effort, i.e., one has to act with determination to achieve the wish.
2. Other goals can take many lifetimes to attain. These are called “*pāramitā*” (pronounced “*pāramithā*”). Depending on the goal, a *paramita* can take many, many lifetimes. It is said that to become a Buddha, one needs to have a firm commitment carried over billions of lives; that is a *paramita*. And it is not like that someone just makes a wish to become a Buddha; that “*gathi*” or the ‘tendency’ has to develop first over many lifetimes, initially starting with the habit of helping others and generally living a moral life.
 - Buddha Dhamma is all about causes and effects. If one can understand the causes for something to happen, and then work to make such cause to materialize, the effects WILL follow.
3. We can see that there are many people — some even may not have heard about Buddha Dhamma — making great efforts to help others even at the risk of their own lives. Those people have such *sansaric* habits and they do have goals, even if it may not be clear to even them at all times. They are just driven by that *sansaric* habit. If they come across pure Dhamma by any chance, they may be able to focus their efforts accordingly.
 - To become an *Arahant* one needs to make a commitment and maintain it over many, many lives. We all are likely to have made that commitment in one or more lives; of course we do not know. And if we had made such a commitment and have worked on it over many lives, it may be possible to fulfill it in this very life. Even otherwise, we can make a real effort to maintain that “*paramita*” and strengthen it.
 - Some make firm determinations to become a *deva*, a *brahma*, an emperor, or just to be rich; there are millions of things that people wish for, and sometimes make firm determinations on. Some of them can come true in this lifetime itself, especially if that is a firm commitment coming from previous lives. Normally the word “*paramita*” is reserved for those commitments that target *Nibbana*.
4. In physics, there is a simple law that says, “every action has a reaction”. In Buddha Dhamma, there is an even more generalized law: when one keeps doing something, an invisible energy buildup occurs that will result in a *kamma bhava* (a potential energy) that will bring about a result (even a birth) of similar kind.
 - During a lifetime, the brain will help achieve goals by rewiring neural connections in the brain when someone keeps trying to develop habits; see, “[How Habits are Formed and Broken – A Scientific View](#)”.
 - And such habits may be carried over future lives by embedding in one’s kamma seeds (beeja); see, “[Sansaric Habits, Character \(Gathi\), and Cravings \(Asava\)](#)”.
5. For example, if one keeps drinking heavily, it WILL become a habit; the brains neural connections

will get wired-up for it. If done long enough, it will get embedded in one's psyche (i.e., in *kamma* seeds), and one is likely to be matched up with a mother who has similar drinking habits, and then it is likely that habit to continue in that life too. It takes a determined effort to "unwire" those neural connections, more than just a wish.

- If one keeps doing activities that are suitable for a dog, one will increasingly act like a dog with such habits, and if that is kept up, eventually will be born a dog. It does not matter whether that person wished to be rich or powerful, what matters is what one habitually does. In his/her mind, one made that determination indirectly by acting accordingly.

6. In the same way, when one makes a determination to be "good", and starts helping out others, and start learning and living by Dhamma, one will be heading to "good births" whether one wishes or not. Then they become deeply-ingrained habits that are taken from birth to birth, and become "*paramitas*".

- Such dominant *paramitas* may manifest as one's character ("*gathi*"). As I mentioned previously, we can see such visible "*gathi*" in many people, regardless of their official religion or culture.

7. Thus habits cultivate character ("*gathi*"), and persistence of such strong character qualities or "*gathi*" through many rebirths develop into "*paramitas*".

- Especially in young children such "*gathi*" may manifest and then it will be easier to cultivate them. For example, in the post on "[Evidence for Rebirth](#)" there is a video of a child reciting complex *suttas*; if he was encouraged to follow that path, he could be able to attain a stage of *Nibbana* in this very life. Similarly, a child with any kind of natural talent can be encouraged to cultivate it easily, because those are *sansaric* habits.

8. Breaking a bad habit takes time too. It is best to cultivate an opposing good habit, or at least a neutral one so that one has an option of doing something when the urge comes. For example, if one wants to quit smoking, one could start chewing a gum instead.

- Both in developing a good habit or breaking a bad habit, one is bound to break the trend once in a while. A child learning to walk will fall many times. That is why one needs to have the perseverance to get back up with a renewed determination.

Whether one is making a determination on a mundane goal or to attain a stage of *Nibbana*, the posts "[Four Bases of Mental Power](#)", "[The Law Attraction](#)", and "[Habits, Goals, and Character \(Gathi\)](#)" could provide helpful information.

Calming the Mind

[“Key to Calming the Mind – The Five Hindrances”](#)

[“Solution to a Wandering Mind – Abandon Everything?”](#)

[“Right Speech – How to avoid Accumulating Bad Kamma”](#)

[“Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?”](#)

[“How to Taste Nibbana”](#)

[“Need to Experience Suffering in Order to Understand It?”](#)

[“Does Impermanence Lead to Suffering?”](#)

Key to Calming the Mind – The Five Hindrances

https://www.youtube.com/watch?feature=player_embedded&v=2VnguFhuefo

I was surprised to come across the following article in the prestigious journal “Science” which, using real time input from 5000 people all over the world, confirmed what the Buddha said 2500 years ago: that a wandering mind is an unhappy mind; see, [A wandering mind is an unhappy mind-Science-Killingsworth-2010](#).

1. Let us think about a few practical examples that we all have experienced.
 - When a child is crying due to any number of reasons, a mother uses a variety of “tricks” to soothe the child. If the child has a fever or headache, simply hugging the child and stroking child’s head makes the child fall asleep. If the child is throwing a tantrum just because he is unhappy with something, just by giving his favorite toy could calm him down.
2. Therefore, the easiest way to calm the mind is to deviate the attention to focus the mind on a different object. **This is based on the fact that there is only one thought arising at a time; if one keeps the thoughts focused on something neutral, then other bad thoughts do not have an opportunity to arise.** This can be done in many ways. Let us discuss a few below.
 - Especially when one gets angry, just by stopping and counting to ten at least slows down the javana (or the impulse) from running wildly. Do not let the bad thoughts to take over. They multiply very quickly, and then things get out-of-control; for a deeper discussion, see, [“Javana of a Citta – Root of Mental Power”](#).
 - Taking few deep breaths helps too. Or, in an angry situation, visualizing a Buddha statue and thinking about its serenity helps too.
3. A popular meditation technique to calm the mind is the “breath meditation”: Go to a quiet place (less bright and less noisy place), sit in a chair comfortably and concentrate on the in-and-out breath. Most people can feel the breath at the tip of nose or on the lips. If not, one can be aware of the falling of the chest or abdomen. Just fix the mind on any of these and do not let it get away. Initially it may be hard, but with practice it becomes easy. This is called samatha meditation and people can even get to meditative jhanic states with a lot of practice.
 - However, just like with the child’s examples mentioned above, these are just “tricks” to get a temporary solution. Just like the child is bound to do the same again, the relief from “breath meditation” is temporary.
3. Even *samatha* meditation becomes easier if one at least obeys the basic five precepts of not killing other beings, stealing, lying, engaging in sexual misconduct, or using excessive amounts of alcohol. If one can further abstain from harsh speech slandering, and vain talk, that makes it even better; see, [“Ten Immoral Actions – Dasa Akusala”](#), and [“Ten Moral Actions – Dasa Kusala”](#).
 - **These precepts are to be followed 24 hours a day; these are not rituals to be obeyed. One follows them to purify one’s mind. Don’t worry if a precept is broken once-in-a while.**
4. The reason that the mind becomes agitated easily is because of the “bad stuff” that we have in our minds: all these “bad stuff” arise due to greed, hate, and ignorance. If a mind is free from greed, hate, and ignorance (that is easily said than done), then the mind will be very calm and nothing in the

outside world can perturb that mind; see “[The Basics in Meditation](#)” and “[The Second Level](#)” for details.

5. In a simile, the Buddha compared a calm mind to a clear, calm, lake that made the surroundings serene. This lake could become undesirable, an eyesore, if one or more of the following takes place: (i) add a dark-colored dye, (ii) if the lake has boiling water, (iii) if the water is covered with moss, (iv) if the water is perturbed by wind, (v) if the water is turbid and muddy.

6. Similarly, a peaceful mind will become polluted due to five hindrances (*nivarana*). They are called “*nivarana*” because they cover the mind from seeing the right from wrong. Just like one cannot see the bottom of a lake if any of the above five factors are present, the mind loses its capacity for clear vision by these hindrances.

- Extreme sense desire (*kamachanda*) is compared to the dark dye. *Kamachanda* (“kama”+“ichcha”+ “anda” means blinded by sense desires). Here “*kama*” means the five sense faculties that belong to the *kamaloka*: eye, ear, nose, tongue, and the body. The attraction for something becomes so strong that one’s complete attention is given to that object. The mind can lose any control over what is sensible and what is not sensible.
- Extreme hate (*vayapada*) is compared to boiling water. You probably have seen someone so enraged that he/she is totally out-of-control. One could become “animal-like”, and actually one who develops such character (“*gathi*”) could end up in the hells (*apayas*). *Vayapada* (“vayā”+“pāda”) means travelling downward (in the 31 realms).
- *Thina middha* (“frozen mind”) is compared to moss covering the water. Sleepiness is just a symptom of it; it is the dull mind that has not been exposed to Dhamma. When one learns Dhamma, one’s mind gets energized. Those meditators who fall asleep during meditation can get rid of that problem by learning pure Dhamma.
- *Uddacca-kukkucca* (normally translated as restlessness and brooding), arise because of high-mindedness (*uddacca*) and low-mindedness (*kukkucca*); in most cases, because of the high-mindedness, one tends to DO lowly things. When one has *uddacca*, one is “drunk” with power, money, etc and when one has *kukkucca* one is willing to do “lowly things” suitable even for an animal. Both these characteristics lead to a scattered mind that is incapable of seeing right from wrong; **as a *nivarana*, they arise together.**
- *Vicikicca* (“vi” is twisted, “ci” is thoughts, and “kicca” is action) is the tendency to do unwise things because of the ignorance of the true nature of this world. For example, tendency to do any kind of immoral act to get one wants comes from *vicikicca*; one does not know, or does not care, about the bad consequences of such actions. Thus *vicikicca* is compared to muddy water.

7. In another simile, the Buddha compared the five hindrances to darkness that keeps one from seeing the true nature. For example, one who is extremely angry is not aware of the damage that is being done to the other person and for oneself; he/she is blinded by hate.

- A mind “blinded” by the five hindrances can keep on adding “more bad stuff” even without realizing it. If you take a glass of muddy water, and add more mud to it, you cannot see much difference. On the other hand, if you take a glass of clean water, you can see even if only a drop of muddy water is added.
- Thus when the mind is free of the five hindrances, one can easily see if any bad thoughts comes to the mind. Then it is easy to contemplate the possible bad consequences of such thoughts and to remove them. That will keep the mind from becoming perturbed. A mind free of the five hindrances is calm and peaceful.

8. It is important to note that while *samatha* meditation is good to be practiced on a temporary basis and allows one to have a peaceful state of mind, it does not remove any defilements. Gradual removal of defilements is done with *Ariya* meditation; see, “[Bhavana \(Meditation\)](#)”.

- The reason for these hindrances to be present is the bad habits (“*gathi*”) we have developed over many lives and have become deep-seated cravings (“*asavas*”). When one starts on *Ariya* meditation, such habits and cravings are gradually removed; this is like removing the dye, boiling water, moss, wind, and the mud from the lake in the simile we talked about in the beginning. When those ROOT CAUSES ARE REMOVED, the lake becomes calm and serene again.
- The five hindrances are completely removed only at the *Arahant* stage, via completely removing the *asavas* or all deep-seated cravings.
- However, removal of five hindrances gradually can bring the mind to a stable peaceful state over time, because the *niramisa sukha* that it brings; see, “[Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)”.

Next, “[Habits and Goals](#)”,

Solution to a Wandering Mind – Abandon Everything?

Our minds become agitated when we see, hear, smell, taste, touch, or just think about something that we really like or really dislike. Those are called thought objects (arammana/aramuna in Pali or Sinhala). If the thought object is to our liking, our mind starts the “wheeling process” on how to own it or at least to enjoy it for a while; if the thought object is something we dislike, the same “wheeling process” takes off on trying to figure out how to get rid of it; see, “[Nibbana – Is It Difficult to Understand?](#)”.

Living in a busy society, we are bombarded with multiple thought objects continuously. Of course it can be reduced by going to a quiet place, where there are less EXTERNAL objects that could give rise to multiple thoughts; many people do that to find a “bit of peace”. Better yet, we can go to a meditation retreat where we focus the mind on breath for example, and get a wonderful calmness.

But the problem is that peacefulness, calmness of the mind goes away when we get back to the “normal life” with normal distractions (multiple thought objects). Is it possible to have a “peace of mind” without going to seclusion?

To understand what actually happens in our minds, let us think about the following case:

1. If you go to a stream, disturb the sediment at the bottom until the water gets dirty, you can fill a glass with that dirty water. It looks brown when stirred well.
2. Now if you set the glass on a table and let it sit there undisturbed, in a little while the dirt will drop to the bottom and the water will become clear.
3. If you stir it again with a stick, the water will be brown again; this is analogous to a thought object that is of great interest to us. **BUT if you try to stir it with a thread**, it will not get stirred; the thread is too weak to stir it. Similarly, we are not disturbed by a thought object that is of no interest to us.
4. If you now take a fine strainer, remove the dirt from that water, and put it back in the same glass, it will now be clear. **Now, if you stir it as much as you want even with a stick**, the water will never become brown.
5. We all have “sediments” (or deep-seated cravings or “asavas”) in our minds that have been brewing/accumulating due to sansaric habits (“gathi”); see, “[Habits and Goals](#)”. Each one has a set of different “sediments” or different habits, i.e., one tends to like certain things AND also dislikes certain other things.
6. So, what happens is when we see something that we like OR dislike, our “sediments” get disturbed. How much it gets disturbed depends on how strongly we like OR dislike it. A strong disturbance may be the sight of a person you really like OR really dislike. But if it is something that does not interest you, it will be like stirring with a thread.
7. During the day, we have innumerable “inputs” coming in through the six senses; these stir up the sediments (“asavas”) inside us and bring out the five hindrances. Our minds are constantly agitated, but we may not even realize it because this is the “baseline state” that we have been used to. But we can at least suppress these five hindrances and make the mind calm; see, “[Key to Calming the Mind – The Five Hindrances](#)”.
8. What you are doing in samatha meditation (focusing the mind on the breath) is to let those sediments settle down. You feel peaceful. This is why you don’t get the same results consistently.

Some days your mind may be especially perturbed by something.

9. This is why people feel great at the end of a long meditation retreat. All the sediments are well-settled. But after coming back and getting back to regular routine, all external disturbances are back and the quality of that experience slowly wears out; may be not completely, if one keeps practicing at home.

10. However, an Arahant has removed all the sediments. Even if an Arahant is exposed to any type of sensual/hateful situation, his/her mind will not be disturbed: A male Arahant will not be seduced by the most beautiful woman in the world; he will not have any hateful feelings towards a person who just cut off his arm. So, an Arahant is like a pure glass of water that does not have any sediments at the bottom.

11. We don't have to become Arahants to improve the quality of our lives. What we can do is to try to get rid of some of the bad habits that are not good in the long term anyway:

- For example, if we really dislike someone, we can start cultivating metta (loving kindness) for that person in our mind first. Whenever angry thoughts about the person comes to the mind, try to counter that; think about something wonderful or peaceful instead.
- If we have a craving for alcohol, tasty but unhealthy food, etc, think about the possible bad results, and again try to steer the mind to something else, some other activity.

Of course this needs to be done gradually. People who make New Year resolutions sometimes abandon them because they try to just “give up” something in one big step. The mind does not like that; [it likes to change only when it actually experiences the benefits of changing the habit](#).

12. Finally, [living a simple, moral \(following the five precepts\), life go a long way to reduce such bad habits](#), and to have a peaceful mind in the midst of all the “possible distractions”.

Thus it is all about cleaning up one's defilements (bad habits) INSIDE; see, “[Introduction to Buddhist Meditation](#)”. Once that is done for all defilements, no outside influence can affect one's composure (see #10 above). One CAN even attain that ultimate stage while staying in the real world.

Next, “[Key to Calming the Mind – Five Hindrances](#)”

Right Speech – How to Avoid Accumulating Kamma

1. The fourth precept of the five precepts for a moral life is right speech. Most people literally take it to mean “not lying”. But since we know that intention (*cetana*) is at the root of deciding whether an action is right or wrong, we always need to be careful about what we intend to achieve by what we say.

2. If one does a wrong deed, one may be able to deny it in a statement worded in such way as to conform to legality. Yet it is registered as false speech in one’s own mind, and thus one is not able to escape the kammic consequences.

3. Ven. Ayya Khema, in her book, “Visible Here and Now” (p. 53), has nicely summarized what right speech is NOT:

- If you know something that is not helpful and is untrue, then do not say it
- If you know something that might be helpful, but is untrue, do not say it
- If you know something that is not helpful and is true, do not speak about it
- If you know something that is helpful and is true, then find the right time to say it

4. If you carefully examine the above four statements, they say to prevent from lying, gossiping, and hate or vain speech; these are the four ways one can accumulate immoral kamma with speech (see, [“Ten Immoral Actions – Dasa Akusala”](#)). Let us look at some of the examples from the Tipitaka on how the Buddha himself handled some situations.

5. When the Buddha was at the Jetavanaramaya for many years, there lived a “pig killer” Chunda right next door. When some monks suggested to the Buddha that he should preach the Dhamma to Chunda and get him to understand the consequences of his actions, the Buddha explained that if he were to go there and try to do that Chunda would only generate hateful thoughts (*patigha*) about the Buddha, and thus will commit an even worse kamma.

6. On the other hand, the Buddha walked a long distance to get to Angulimala just before he was to kill his own mother. Angulimala had killed almost thousand people, but that was on the prompting of his teacher, who was trying to get Angulimala into trouble. That morning, the Buddha saw what was about to happen and knew that he would be able to convince Angulimala of the bad consequences of his actions. Angulimala became an Arahant in a few weeks.

7. In the case of the wanderer Vacchagotta asking the Buddha about whether there is a “self” or “no-self”, the Buddha just remained silent. After Vacchagotta left, Buddha’s personal attendant, Ven. Ananda, asked him why Buddha did not explain the concept of *anatta* to Vacchagotta. The Buddha told Ananda that he did not think Vacchagotta was mentally capable at that time to understand the concept, and that he did not want to confuse him.

8. The Buddha was endowed with that capability to see other people’s mental status. We do not have that capability. So, we need to use our own judgement.

9. Lying to another human being may have even worse consequences (depending on the particular case) than killing a being of a lower realm. The kammic effects of such offenses depends on the status of the being in question and the consequences of the particular action. For example, killing an Arahant or one’s own parents is a much worse crime than killing a normal human, and killing any human is much worse than killing any animal; see, [“How to Evaluate Weights of Different Kammass”](#).

10. During the Nazi terror in Germany, many Germans lied to the Nazi's that they were not hiding Jews in their houses; of course the intention was to save human lives and thus it was the right thing to do. They acquired good kamma for protecting lives.

Next, "[The Five Precepts – What the Buddha Meant by Them](#)",

Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?

1. There are three kinds of happiness:

- Sense pleasures (āmisa sukha)
- Mundane meditative (Anariya jhanic) pleasures
- Nibbanic (nirāmisa) sukha

2. Āmisa means material; “āmisa dāna” is offering of material things. Thus amisa sukha is the pleasures that arise from material things. Sense pleasures are the ones all of us are familiar with. We like to indulge in sense pleasures. We like to see beautiful pictures or people; hear soothing music; taste good food, etc.

- The drawback with sense pleasures is that the pleasure lasts only while one is satisfying the particular sense faculty; as soon as we finish eating, for example, the pleasure goes away. Also, we cannot keep eating either, even if we wanted to; we will get sick of it soon enough no matter how good the food is.
- Same is true for any other sense pleasure. One cannot keep listening to music or watch movies for too long at a stretch.
- However, the craving for any sense pleasure comes back after a while. It is never permanently satisfied.

3. People who have been doing samatha meditation (for example, breath or kasina) know that it gives a pleasure that is different from any sense pleasure.

- One could meditate for hours (especially if one gets into a jhanic state), and can enjoy it as long as one wants. Furthermore, even after the session, the calming effect is there for a while. It gives a sense of peacefulness that can last for hours.
- If one dies while in a jhanic state, then one will be born in the corresponding Brahma world (either in the rupa loka or in the arupa loka depending on the jhanic state). However, a birth in one of the lowest four realms is not ruled out for births after that.
- The ability to get into jhanic states could be lost even in this lifetime if one commits a really bad kamma, or start indulging heavily in sense pleasures.
- Jhanic states are attained via TEMPORARY blocking of the defilements of greed and hate from the mind by focusing the mind on a neutral object such as breath, rising and falling of stomach, or a kasina object, for example.

4. The niramisa sukha is of more permanent nature even compared to jhanic pleasures, especially if one has attained at least the first stage of Nibbana, the Sotapanna stage.

- Niramisa is opposite of amisa that we mentioned earlier; thus niramisa sukha does not arise due to material things. It is totally mental, it is in fact the happiness due to release or dissociation from material things. It is more of a relief sensation rather than an enjoyment. It is like the feeling when a pulsating headache goes away; a sense of calm and peacefulness.
- Stated in another way, niramisa sukha is present when where there is no suffering.

- The niramisa sukha of a Sotapanna (or above) is never lost. A higher calm state of mind called a sammapatti can be summoned at any time, if Ariya jhanas are cultivated. The Sotapanna status is never lost even through future lives.
- Once the final stage of Nibbana is attained, there is nothing else to do. Just like at the Sotapanna stage, a higher state of sammapatti (including the sanna vedayita nirodha sammapatti) can be summoned at will during this lifetime.
- The four Nibbanic states are attained via PERMANENT removal of greed, hate, and ignorance in four stages. This involves insight (vipassana) meditation, most importantly on the three characteristics of existence: *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.
- Even before the Sotapanna stage, one can start feeling the niramisa sukha by systematically removing greed, hate, and ignorance; see, “[How to Taste Nibbana](#)“.

More information on niramisa sukha can be found at “[Niramisa Sukha](#)“.

How to Taste Nibbana

1. Elsewhere on the site, I have described *Nibbana* in a deeper sense. But we can look at early stages of *Nibbana* in a simple way.
 - In Sinhala language (spoken in Sri Lanka), *Nibbana* is also called “*nivana*” or “*niveema*”. This means “cooling down”. As one move towards *Nibbana* one feels cooling down, a sense of well-being.
2. Do you remember the last time when you got really mad? How did that feel? You get hot. Whole body becomes hot and agitated; blood pressure goes up; face becomes dark, because the blood becomes dark.
 - This “burning up” is called “*tāpa*” in Pali, and is due to greed, hate, and ignorance. “*Ātāpi*” means the opposite, “cooling down via getting rid of those defilements”. This is what is meant by “*ātāpi sampajāno*” in the *Satipattana sutta*; see the *sutta* section for details.
 - When someone can get to the “*ātāpi sampajāno*” state, one feels calm and “cooled down”.
3. Do you remember how you felt when you made someone happy, either via a good deed or word? You cooled down; felt good. Didn’t you feel the opposite of when you got mad?
 - When one acts with greed, “heating up” still happens, may be to a lesser extent than when one is angry. As a kid, when I was stealing something, I felt heated and uncomfortable.
 - Same is true when one acts with ignorance too. One is not certain whether that is the right thing to do; the mind goes back and forth: is this right or wrong? should I do it or not? This is called “*vicikicca*” in Pali. Because one does not really know, one is not certain, one becomes anxious, and the body gets heated up.
4. Thus, when one gives up acting with hate, greed, or ignorance, one becomes less agitated, at ease, with a sense of peacefulness. This is an early sense of what *Nibbana* is.
 - As one can see the benefits of cooling down, one will avoid actions done with hate, greed, and ignorance. And one will be looking forward to do actions of goodwill, generosity, and with mindfulness.
5. Also note the state of thoughts (*citta*) in the two opposing situations. When one acts with the defilements, thoughts run wildly; they come fast and they are energetic. The “*javana*” (impulsive power) of a thought is high when when acting with a defilement.
 - On the other hand, thoughts run more smoothly and the *javana* (impulsive power) of a given thought is calm when acting benevolently, with kindness, with generosity, and with mindfulness; they are powerful too, but only in making one calm. Thus one can experience a taste of *Nibbana* or “cooling down” even at the very early stages of the Path.
6. Now, one could get to TEMPORARY cooling down by not letting thoughts run wildly. The easiest to do is to keep the mind on a single focus. This can be done by focusing the mind on a religious symbol or just on the breath. Thus this “temporary relief” is felt by people of any religion when they contemplate on a religious symbol with faith, or by doing “breath meditation” or mundane “*anapana sati*” meditation.
 - However, the only way to achieve permanent sense relief is to REMOVE greed, hate, and ignorance gradually by cleansing one’s mind. This is done by “taking in” (*āna*) of good thoughts, speech, and actions and “getting rid of” (*pāna*) defiled thoughts, speech, and actions.

This is the Buddha's *anapana* meditation that can lead to PERMANENT happiness.

- When one does this correct “*anapana*” consistently, one’s bad habits (“*gathi*”) will be gradually removed and good habits (“*gathi*”) will be cultivated.
- When one has removed the defilements to a significant extent, then this relief becomes permanent and will not reduce from that state even in future births. **This first stage of *Nibbana* is called the *Sotapanna* stage.** A *Sotapanna* is guaranteed not to be reborn in the *apayas* or the four lowest realms; he/she has removed all “*gathi*” suitable for beings in the *apayas*.

7. However, it is impossible to remove greed and hate just by sheer will power, i.e., forcefully. For example, one cannot get rid of greed even by giving away one’s wealth; if that is done without understanding, then it could lead to remorse and hate.

- Rather, getting rid of greed and hate comes AUTOMATICALLY as one understands the worldview of the Buddha: that we cannot maintain anything to our satisfaction in the LONG RUN. This worldview is embedded in the Three Characteristics of “this world” or *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.
- Not knowing the Three Characteristics is the ignorance or *avijja*.
- This is why *Samma Ditthi* or “correct world view” comes first in the Noble Eightfold Path. When one comprehends the true nature of “this world”, one’s mind will AUTOMATICALLY start rejecting thoughts, words, and actions through greed and hate. Thus *Samma Ditthi* (correct vision) will automatically lead to *Samma Sankappa* (fruitful thoughts), *Samma vaca* (fruitful speech), *Samma Kammanta* (fruitful actions), *Samma Ajiva* (livelihood), *Samma Vayama* (efforts in those), *Samma Sati* (moral mindset) and then will culminate in *Samma Samadhi* (peaceful state of mind). This *Samma Samadhi* is permanent for a *Sotapanna*.
- Thus it is clear that such a *samadhi* cannot be attained with breath meditation or any other way of “focusing attention” on one thought object.
- Purification of the mind is the key, and that comes first through reading, listening, and comprehending the true and pure Dhamma.

8. As one follows the Noble Eightfold Path of the Buddha, one can EXPERIENCE a sense of well-being called *niramisa sukha* which is different from the sense pleasures; see, “[Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)”.

- If you did experience a sense of well-being just by reading this post, that is a good start. That sense of well being will only grow as the understanding gets deeper. I have gone through this process myself and that is what I am trying to convey to others.

Next, “[Need to Experience Suffering in Order to Understand It?](#)”,

Need to Experience Suffering in Order to Understand it?

1. It is a common misconception that one needs to experience suffering in order to understand what the Buddha meant by the First Noble Truth, that there is “suffering in this world”.
2. Thus some people deliberately live a miserable life, thinking that it will help understand suffering. This is actually one extreme that the Buddha said NOT to follow: “atta kilamatanu yoga”, or subjecting oneself to unnecessary suffering. The suffering that the Buddha talked about is mostly hidden: Anyone, rich or poor, undergo suffering even in this life; **if you have grasped the correct meanings of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, the real meaning of suffering can be examined:** [“The Incessant Distress \(“Peleema”\) – Key to Dukkha Sacca”](#). One does not need to make it worse.
3. If one needs to suffer more to attain Nibbana, then those who are in the apayas would be the first attain Nibbana! Most of the suffering is experienced when one is born in the apayas: the lower four realms, see, [“The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma”](#).
 - In order to actually realize the true suffering, whether in this life or in the lower four realms, one needs to contemplate (bhāvanā) with a clear mind. If one is hungry, one does NOT understand the causes of suffering; rather one will be generating hateful thoughts. Same is true for all four necessities of life: food, shelter, clothing, and medicine. We NEED those things to survive.
 - What we should NOT is to over-indulge in any of the above four necessities of life. That is the other extreme that the Buddha said to avoid: “kama sukallikanu yoga”, or indulging in sense pleasures.
4. Some people say that the Buddha advocated the “middle ground”. That is not quite true; there is a deeper meaning. The way to a peaceful existence (or to Nibbana) is to get rid of greed, hate, AND ignorance. The two extremes that we talked about above are to do with hate (when subjecting oneself to suffering) and greed (indulging in excessive sense pleasures).
 - Just because one stays away from those two extremes does not necessarily mean one is on the “correct path”. The path is not just a “middle ground” between those two extremes.
5. In between those two extremes, one needs to avoid being influenced by an “intoxicated mind”. In between the above two extremes, people also act in improper ways intoxicated by power, beauty, position, (book) knowledge, lineage, etc as well as by alcohol and drugs. This is due to avijja or ignorance. Thus, “majjima patipada” really means to follow a lifestyle without corrupting the mind with such things that can corrupt a mind and makes it unsuitable for contemplation on the deeper truth of suffering in “this world of 31 realms”.
 - To clarify: “majji” is intoxication, and “ma” is to get rid of. Thus majjima patipada is to follow a lifestyle that avoids the corruption of the mind by intoxication.
6. In summary, the Buddha recommended a “common sense” comfortable life that is conducive to meditation. Here meditation (bhavana) is not necessarily “formal meditation”. The Buddha said, “bhavanaya bahuleekathaya”, or “contemplate as often as possible”.
7. One can be contemplating the nature of the world as one goes through daily chores. Another aspect of this is the ability to calm the mind; see, [“Key to Calming the Mind”](#).
 - A bigger picture implied here is that we need to educate our children so that they can find good

employment and thus be able to live without having to worry about those four necessities of life. As they grow up we need to educate them in Dhamma (how to live a moral life) too, but not at the expense of them getting a good education.

8. Suffering is NOT the Noble truth on Suffering, i.e., Dukkha is NOT dukkha sacca (sacca pronounced “sachcha” and means “truth”).

- The Buddha said “This Dhamma is unlike anything that the world has ever seen”. The actual suffering is hidden WITHIN the apparent enjoyments. If you like to see a deeper meaning of suffering, see, “[The Incessant Distress \(Peleema\) – Key to Dukkha Sacca](#)”.

Next, “[Buddhist or a Bhauddhaya?](#)“,

Does Impermanence Lead to Suffering?

The following statements are in frequent use in most books in both Mahayana and Theravada:

1. “We suffer because our bodies is impermanent; they are subject to decay and death”
2. “We suffer because those things we get attached to are impermanent”
3. “If something is impermanent, that leads to suffering”
4. “Since everything in this world is impermanent, everything is suffering”, etc.

So, is there a direct correlation between impermanence and suffering? Let us examine those statements.

1. “We suffer because our bodies is impermanent; they are subject to decay and death”

- It is true that WE suffer because OUR bodies are impermanent and are subject to decay and death. But if it is an enemy, do we suffer when that enemy gets sick or die? We suffer if someone we LIKE gets sick or die, but it is cause for celebration for most people when someone they dislike gets sick or dies.
- Actually the suffering/happiness is directly proportional to the attachment/dislike we have for that person. Suffering due to a loss of one’s child is more compared to the loss of a distant relative. Happiness due to Bin Laden’s death was higher compared to the death of an unknown terrorist. (For a follower of Bin Laden, his death would have led to suffering).

Suffering arises only when things do not proceed as we like. It is the human nature to want the loved ones to be unharmed, and the enemies to come to harm. When either does not happen, that leads to suffering. That is what *anicca* means: the inability to maintain things to our liking.

2. “We suffer because those things we get attached to are impermanent”

- There are many things in this world that cause us suffering because they will not stay in the same condition or are destroyed; that is true. BUT there are many other “permanent” things in this world (at least relative to our lifetime of 100 years), AND if they cause us suffering that is NOT because they decay or are destroyed; rather it is because we cannot maintain them to our satisfaction.
- If a woman has a gold necklace it is not impermanent, i.e, it will last for thousands of years. But the woman could become distressed if the necklace is lost or if she has to sell it to raise money for food or some such necessity.

If ANYTHING causes US suffering, that is because we cannot maintain it to OUR satisfaction, OUR liking.

3. “If something is impermanent, that leads to suffering”

This is the direct (incorrect) translation of Buddha’s words: “ya da niccama tan dukkham”, i.e., “if something is not permanent, that leads to suffering”. But the correct translation is, “if something cannot be maintained to our liking, that leads to suffering”. Let us consider some examples:

- If we have a headache, and if it is not permanent (i.e, it goes away), does that cause suffering? No. However, if the headache becomes permanent, that will cause a lot of suffering.

- If we get cancer, wouldn't it cause happiness if it becomes impermanent?, i.e., if it goes away?
- If a relative that we do not like come to stay with us, would it lead to happiness if the stay becomes permanent or impermanent? Of course it will cause us happiness if the stay is not permanent and the person leaves.

4. “Since everything in this world is impermanent, everything is suffering”

The Buddha never said everything in this world leads to suffering. If everything is suffering then everyone will be looking to attain Nibbana as soon as possible. The reality is that there are sense pleasures to be had in this world. Most people do not understand why one should go to all this trouble to “give up all these sense pleasures and seek Nibbana”.

- Taking the “big picture”, out of the 31 realms in this world, there are actually many realms where suffering is much less than even the human realm; see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”.
- But there is unimaginable suffering in the lowest four realms, AND that is what we need to avoid. Even though there are 31 realms, MOST LIVING BEINGS (99.99%+) are trapped in the lowest four realms.
- Thus what is true is that this sansaric journey is filled with UNIMAGINABLE suffering. However, one cannot see that unless one learns true Dhamma.
- Even in this life there is much suffering, especially as one gets old, and the suffering is highest close to death if the death is due to an ailment. If one enjoys sex, that ability to enjoy sex will fade away as one gets old; it does not matter how much money one has. Even our taste buds will not give us the same enjoyment from foods as we get old. All our sense faculties will start performing less and less as we get old. This is *anicca*; we cannot maintain things to our satisfaction in the long run.
- Even if we are born in a higher realm where there is much happiness, that also cannot be maintained. One day, that life will be over and one WILL end up in a lower realm at some point, and then it will be very hard to get out of there. That is *anicca*.

In Pali (or in Sinhala), the word “icca” (pronounced “ichchä”) means liking. Thus *anicca* (pronounced “anichchä”) means not to liking.

Therefore, the correct translation of “ya da nikkam tan dukkham” is “if something cannot be maintained to our satisfaction, that leads to suffering”. You can take any example you like and verify for yourself that it is a universal principle, an unchanging characteristic of this world, as the Buddha stated.

Without understanding the three characteristics of “this world”, it is not possible to grasp the message of the Buddha. Those three characteristics are: *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. These are the words in the Tipitaka, that was written down more than 2000 years ago, in 29 BCE.

- The problem started when these words were translated to Sanskrit as *anitya*, *dukha*, *anatma*; this started probably as far back as in the first or second century CE.
- Then those Sanskrit words were translated to English as impermanence, suffering, and “no-self”. The two worst translations are impermanence and “no-self”.
- Those two Sanskrit words, *anitya* and *anatma*, are being used by many in Sri Lanka today as

Sinhala words representing the translations of the “Pali words”, *anicca* and *anatta*.

- However, *anicca* and *anatta* are “old Sinhala” words (i.e., not in use today, but when explained one can see the meaning) with completely different meanings than anitya and anatma.

The Buddha stated that those three characteristics, *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anatta* are related:

“ya da niccam tan dukkham, tan dukkham ta da natta”, or,

“if something is not nicca, dukha arises, and because of that one becomes helpless, i.e., *anatta*”.

As mentioned above, as one gets old or gets disabled, these three characteristics will be easier to see for oneself; but then it would be too late, because the mind gets weaker as we get old One needs to learn Dhamma BEFORE the mind (and the body) become weak. Here is a set of pictures that show this clearly : http://www.ranker.com/crowdranked-list/18-celebrities-who_ve-aged-horribly?format=SLIDESHOW&page=1

Also, see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta](#)“, and “[Why is Correct Interpretation of Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta so Important?](#)” for more details.

Next, “[What is Mind – How do we Experience the Outside World?](#)“,

Buddha Dhamma and Buddhism

[“What is Unique in Buddha Dhamma?”](#)

[“A Buddhist or a Bouddhaya?”](#)

[“Where to Start on the Path?”](#)

[“What Reincarnates? – Concept of a Lifestream”](#)

[“Recent Evidence for Unbroken Memory Records \(HSAM\)”](#)

[“Buddhism without Rebirth and Nibbana?”](#)

What is Unique in Buddha Dhamma?

1. When I hear the common statement, “all religions are the same, they teach you how live a MORAL LIFE”, I cringe. That is because I think about all those people who are unaware of the actual message of the Buddha.

- It is true that most religions teach how to live a moral life.
- However, Buddha Dhamma goes beyond that. The Buddha said, no matter how well we live this life that will not help one in the LONG TERM.
- Yet, even to understand that message of the Buddha, one needs to live a moral life first.

2. I have made a one-pager, “[Buddha Dhamma – In a Chart](#)” which should be referenced here. This chart can be viewed in a separate panel by clicking on it and printed for reference. There are a few key things that need explanation first:

- The “mundane Eightfold Path” is depicted by the set of boxes in red starting with “mundane *samma ditthi*“. The next box depicts mundane versions of *samma sankappa*, *samma vaca*, and *samma kammanta* (“think, speak, and act morally to avoid bad outcomes/seek good outcomes”) and so on until “mundane *samma samadhi*“.
- Most of these steps (not all) are in other religions as well as in conventional “Buddhism”, i.e., how to live a moral life. The goal of most other religions is to gain a (permanent) heavenly life at death. In traditional “Buddhism” the joys of heavenly lives are valued and often one is sometimes even encouraged to “enjoy such heavenly lives” before attaining *Nibbana*.
- This misconception in conventional Buddhism arises because the rarity of a “good rebirth” is not comprehended; see, “[How the Buddha Described the Chance of Rebirth in the Human Realm](#)“. This is why the Buddha said, “no happiness can be found anywhere in the 31 realms” (which is the true meaning of *anicca*).
- **Even if a heavenly rebirth is attained in the next life, a future rebirth in the four lowest realms (*apayas*) cannot be avoided without following the Noble Eightfold Path.**
- One actually starts on the transcendental (*lokottara*) or the Noble Eightfold Path when one comprehends the dangers of the rebirth process and BECOMES a *Sotapanna*.
- When one is trying to attain that understanding, one is on the *Sotapanna magga* (the path to become a *Sotapanna*; “*magga*” is “path”), and is also called a *Bhauddhaya* (one trying to stop the rebirth process); see, “[A Buddhist or a Bhauddhaya?](#)“.
- Until one comprehends *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, one always values future happiness in a permanent heaven (most religions) OR temporary happiness in heavenly worlds (Buddhists). It depends on one’s level of understanding.

3. Thus one starts on the Noble Eightfold Path starting with *lokottara* (transcendental) *samma ditthi* of a *Sotapanna* (set of blue boxes). One has seen a “glimpse of *Nibbana*“, i.e., one KNOWS that permanent happiness is not possible anywhere in the 31 realms and that whatever effort one makes to achieve such a happiness is like chasing a mirage.

- Note the difference in the box next to “*samma ditthi*” in the two cases. In the mundane path, “*samma sankappa*, *samma vaca*, *samma kammanta*” are “moral thoughts, speech, and actions” intended to avoid bad outcomes and to seek good outcomes.
- In the Noble path, “*samma sankappa*, *samma vaca*, *samma kammanta*” are “thoughts, speech,

and actions” intended to stop the rebirth process. **One does not do immoral things because there is “no point” in doing such things.** One knows that such things are not only unfruitful, but also dangerous, in the long run.

- And one becomes more compassionate towards all living beings (not just humans), because one can see that each living being is suffering because of ignorance of the Buddha’s key message. One also realizes that one needs to fulfil obligations to others in order to “pay back old debts”; one is bound to the rebirth process not only via cravings for worldly things, but also via unpaid debts from previous lives.

4. The decision to become a *Bhauddhaya* or to start on the *Sotapanna magga* (the path to the *Sotapanna* stage) can be made anytime after getting to the “red boxes”, i.e., while one is on the mundane Eightfold Path.

- The key is to comprehend the “true nature of this world of 31 realms” that the Buddha described, i.e., that it is not possible achieve/maintain anything that can be kept to one’s satisfaction (*anicca*), thus one gets to suffer (*dukkha*), and thus one is truly helpless in the rebirth process (*anatta*). This realization itself is like lifting a heavy load that one has been carrying, the first true taste of *Nibbana*.

5. This “change of mindset” for a *Sotapanna* is PERMANENT, i.e., it will not change even in future rebirths. One has attained an “unbreakable” level of confidence (*saddha*) in the Buddha, Dhamma, and Sangha.

- And a *Sotapanna* can follow the rest of the 7 steps in the Noble Eightfold Path even without help from others. Thus one will attain the next three stages of *Nibbana* (*Sakadagami*, *Anagami*, *Arahant*) successively by following those steps.

6. In the *Maha Chattarisaka Sutta*, the Buddha outlined how one needs to first follow the mundane (“*lokiya*”) Eightfold Path; see, “[Maha Chattarisaka Sutta \(Discourse on the Great Forty\)](#)“. This is a first NECESSARY step in order to get rid of the worse kinds “gunk” that have been built up over countless lives.

- With the unique message of the Buddha has been hidden for hundreds of years, what is conventionally practised today is just this mundane Eightfold Path. This is what we call “Buddhism” today.
- Since “Buddhism” not that different from what is advised by most other religions, it is easier for people to resonate with the mundane concepts in “Buddhism”, where *Samma Ditthi* , for example, is considered to be the “correct vision” of “how to live a moral life”.
- Of course that is a first necessary step. That will help one to be able to experience the benefits of moral behavior (even in this life as a “*niramisa sukha*“; see “[How to Taste Nibbana](#)“) and then to comprehend *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, and to embark on the Noble Eightfold Path to seek permanent happiness or *Nibbana*.

Next, “[A Buddhist or a Bhauddhaya?](#)“,

A Buddhist or a Bhauddhaya?

The terms “Buddhism” and “Buddhist” were invented by the English, French, and German historians in the nineteenth century when they first came across Buddha Dhamma in India and Sri Lanka. The discovery of the “Asoka pillars” in India was followed by the discovery of the Pali literature on Buddha Dhamma in Sri Lanka and other countries such as Burma and Thailand (together with translated Chinese scripts); of course there were no practicing “Buddhists” or any Buddhist literature in India.

Here are two key points that should be the basis of defining the terms:

- Up to that time it was “Buddha Dhamma” or the “Dhamma or Teachings of the Buddha”.
- And a person who diligently followed the Path advised by the Buddha was called a “*Bhauddhayā*” (= *bhava* + *uddha* + *yā* = one who strives to stop the rebirth process, i.e., to stop suffering).

However, many people today have been exposed to bits and pieces of Buddha Dhamma. Many people are just happy to follow the precepts of moral conduct, do some samatha meditation to relieve the stresses of modern life, and to see where that leads them. And that is a perfectly good approach, at least to start off.

Each person understands Buddha Dhamma differently, mainly based on the level of exposure to “correct Dhamma”.

- Some do not understand or do not believe any of the “axioms” of Buddha Dhamma (rebirth, the 31 realms, one’s actions do have kammic consequences. etc) and some of them are bound to be trapped in lowest four realms (apayas) in the long run. **They have *micca ditthi* (or wrong views) instead of *samma ditthi*.**
- Then there are those who understand, by *sansaric* habits, difference between what is moral and what is not; **their goal is to live a moral life.** But they either, (a) have not heard the true message of the Buddha or, (b) do not yet fully comprehend it. However, it is possible that most people in both groups have not been exposed to the true message of the Buddha. **Their version of *samma ditthi* is to lead a moral life, and may be to seek good rebirths.**
- Those who spend time and learn the key Dhamma concepts may realize the futility of staying anywhere in the 31 realms. **Their goal is to stop the rebirth process and to attain Nibbana.** They have a good understanding of the concepts like the 31 realms, rebirth process, true nature of the world (*anicca, dukkha, anatta*), the four Noble Truths, etc).

Many people initially become Buddhists because of either a desire to learn more about the “wider world”, contemplate on the “long-term existence”, i.e., the never ending rebirth process, or because they are interested in living a moral life that provides a sense of happiness.

- But in the very strict sense, if one really wants to follow the Path prescribed by the Buddha and become a “*Bhauddhaya*“, one needs to first understand what the rebirth process is, and why it is important to stop the rebirth process, i.e., they need to understand *anicca, dukkha, anatta*.

There are no rituals to become either a Buddhist or a *Bhauddhaya*. As one becomes convinced of the Buddha’s world view and starts seeing that it is fruitless to HARM ONESELF OR OTHERS to gain anything “in this world”, he/she starts becoming a better Buddhist or a *Bhauddhaya*.

- As one becomes a Buddhist/*Bhauddhaya*, his/her personality may start changing without forcefully changing it. That is because one starts seeing the world differently and reacting to outside events differently. It is all about changing perceptions about “this world”, i.e., it is all mental. Because of this, one cannot become a *Bhauddhaya* or even a good Buddhist by just following rituals. One becomes a good Buddhist/*Bhauddhaya* by attempting to comprehend the message of the Buddha, and by experiencing the benefits as one progresses.

”*Dhammo ha ve rakkati Dhammacari*”, i.e., “Dhamma will guide and protect one who lives by Dhamma”. If one really starts becoming a Buddhist/*Bhauddhaya*, one will be able to see the changes in oneself as time goes by (others will start noticing after a bit longer). One’s likings and associations are the first to change.

Next, “[Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)](#)“,

Where to Start on the Path?

This is a very important post. Please read the post through without clicking on any link first, in order to get the main idea that I am trying to convey. You may want to re-read the post several times, clicking on the links to find out more as you digest the key points. **Actually, this is true of all the posts: It is better to read through a given post first to get the main idea, and then to look into the details provided by the links as needed.**

- Anyone reading this website has been exposed to Buddha Dhamma in the past; by “past” I mean beginning-less time. Each of us have been “living” and “dying” innumerable times, in most of the 31 realms of existence; see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)“. Even though a Buddha appears in the world after very long times, there have been innumerable Buddhas too. Some of you may not believe this, and that is fine. It may make sense later on.

Each of us has listened to a Buddha delivering a discourse, attained the highest jhanas, and also been born in the animal and niraya (the lowest realm) too. Our character and habits may have changed from “good” to “bad” many times over. Infinite time is very hard to grasp with the mind; see, “[Samsaric Time Scale](#)“, and “[Infinity – How Big is it?](#)“. Also, you may want to read the excellent book, “The Beginning of Infinity” by David Deutsch (2011) IF you are interested in a “scientific opinion”; actually, the descriptions are very similar in both cases in the sense that many things that sound implausible are not scientifically implausible, and in fact are necessary to explain the scientific data.

- As in this life, it is easy to remember relatively recent events in the samsaric journey. Those who can remember past lives, remember only the past one or few lives; see, “[Evidence for Rebirth](#)“. The ‘habits’ and ‘tendencies’ that we have are the ones that we have had in the recent rebirths.
- Therefore, for some people, it may be easier to get into a jhana (or to have a good meditative experience) just because they have had that experience in more recent lives; for another person, it may be harder just because that person may not have had that experience for very many births in the recent past.

One should not be discouraged if one’s understanding of Dhamma or “meditation experience” seems to be different from what one hears from others. The important thing is to first determine where one is in the relative scale of things and start at the right place. Most times there is no correlation between this evaluation and one’s “book knowledge” either.

One could use the basic guidelines provided by the Buddha. There are five stages starting with dana and ending with nekkhamma:

- Dana (giving, generosity, caring for others’ well being)
- Sila (moral conduct)
- Sagga (literally heaven, but meaning calm and peaceful mind)
- Ādeenava (seeing the fruitlessness and the danger of the 31 realms or the rebirth process)
- Nekkhamma (losing attachment to “things” in the 31 realms, and working diligently towards Nibbana)

These are not clear-cut steps, but are guidelines.

1. Most people, irrespective of the religion, are generous and enjoy giving. Just like sila below, dana induces happiness in oneself.
2. In Pali it is sila (pronounced “seela”); in Sinhala it is “seelaya” (“laya” means heart, so cooled heart), and thus is a bit more explanatory.
 - Any act that makes one’s heart to cool down is an act of sila, i.e., it is moral conduct.
 - When we act with compassion, say give a meal to someone hungry or help out an elderly person to cross the street, it makes our heart cool down. On the other hand, when we do something immoral or inappropriate, our heart gets agitated and the heart rate goes up, and the whole body heats up; also see, [“How to Taste Nibbana”](#).
 - It is the same compassion, extended to other living beings as well, that makes up the basis of the five precepts: avoiding any act that is harmful to any living being; see, [“Five Precepts – What the Buddha Meant by Them”](#).
 - The humans are at a much higher “consciousness level” compared to animals, so we need to pay special attention not to even hurt the feelings of another human being; see, [“How to Evaluate Weights of Different Kamma”](#). It is a good habit also to cultivate metta (loving kindness) to all beings; see, [“Kamma, Debt, and Meditation”](#).
3. When one gets to the Sagga stage, it is relatively easy to calm the mind. One starts feeling the niramisa sukha (see, [“Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?”](#)) or the happiness of “cooling down” by voluntarily “giving up” (and sharing with others) things that one used to be quite possessive of. It is very subtle. One cannot just start giving everything that one owns; that will only lead to patigha or internal friction. In addition, one has responsibilities and debts to pay; see, [“Kamma, Debt, and Meditation”](#).
 - Different people get “agitated” due to different “triggers”. This is because we have very different sansaric habits: things we really like and things we really dislike; there are several posts on these habits and “asavas”. It is a good idea to make a self-assessment, figure out the “bad triggers” and make an effort to remove them.
 - For example, if one has an “explosive temper” it is a good idea to make an effort to restraint oneself and also to do metta bhavana. It is important to realize that the anger is within oneself; it is not in an outside person or thing. I could get mad by thinking about person A, but there are many other people who have loving thoughts about the same person A. Same with greed, it is inside of us, not outside. These all originate from our sansaric likes and dislikes.
4. While it is hard for some to even start thinking about the ‘bigger picture’ of the 31 realms, and the possible suffering in future rebirths, some others may have thought about this “in the recent past in the sansaric rebirths”, and thus may be motivated to explore more.
5. The last stage is for those who have “seen the big picture” and the dangers of staying “in this world of 31 realms”, or at least have some inkling of it. When one starts feeling the niramisa sukha strongly, and also start seeing the suffering to come in the lower realms, giving up the rebirth process becomes an urgent need, instead of being anxious about “giving up rebirth”. Again, this cannot be forced. One will feel it when one’s mind is ready.
 - This website has posts that could be helpful in any of the above categories. One needs to look around and find the suitable topics; [even though I have tried to put posts into different](#)

categories, there may be posts suitable for anyone in any category.

- My intention is to add material at all different levels, mainly up to the Sotapanna stage of Nibbana. I hope that will help a wide spectrum of people and also illustrate that Buddha Dhamma describes the ultimate natural laws not only about our human world, but of all existence. Buddha Dhamma is not just a philosophical theory; one can actually experience the improvement in one's quality of life as one follows the Path.

Next, "[The Pale Blue Dot.....](#)",

What Reincarnates? – Concept of a Lifestream

First, reincarnation is a Hindu concept, where the “*āthma*” or the soul remains the same but just takes a different form. In the *Rigveda* it is compared to a person discarding an old suit and wearing a new suit.

- In Buddha Dhamma it is **rebirth**, since there is no soul to reincarnate. In our long journey through *sansara*, we have accumulated many “*kamma* seeds” (*kamma beeja*) which contain various “habits” and “character” (called “*gathi*”); see, “[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka](#)”.
- At death, the *kammic* energy of the *kamma* seed for the present life is exhausted, and a new life starts off with a potent *kamma* seed (the selection of a new seed itself is a complicated process and depends on the potency of the available *kamma* seeds, but it happens within a thought moment).

1. The *pancakkhandha* (see, “[The Five Aggregates \(Pancakkhandha\)](#)” for details) or the five heaps (*khandas*) that makes a being and “its world” can be thought of as two inter-dependent entities: one is *rupa* (form) and the other is *citta* (pronounced chiththa).

- *Citta* can be crudely called thoughts, but a thought that we experience has billions of *cittas* in it; see, “[What is a Thought?](#)”.
- *Rupa* can be divided into two main categories of internal and external. The external *rupa* constitutes one’s external world. The internal *rupa* are not the physical body, but the very fine *pasada rupa* (*cakkhu*, *sota*, *ghana*, *jivha*, and *kaya*) which actually do the “sensing”. The physical eye, ear, etc are like physical instruments that help gather data from outside; see, “[Manomaya Kaya and Physical Body](#)” for details.

2. The combination of the two streams of *citta* and internal *rupa* can be called a “lifestream”; a lifestream is in constant re-generation moment-to-moment: The *cittas* re-generate very fast (billions in a second), and each *citta* has the other four heaps (*vedana*, *sanna*, *sankhara*, *vinnana*) associated with it. So *rupa* and *citta* basically represent the *pancakkhandha* (*rupa*, *vedana*, *sanna*, *sankhara*, *vinnana*). I am simplifying this a bit to make it not too complicated.

- In simpler terms, both internal *rupa* and *citta* are re-generated billion times a second, but of course visually appreciable “changes” occur over months or even years.
- All external *rupa* are “one’s whole world”.
- A *citta* rises and disappears in less than a billionth of a second; but there is a mental factor in each *citta* called *manasikara* that “remembers the contents in previous *citta*”. The two mental factors of *manasikara* and *cetana* are responsible for providing a sense of a “person” who remembers the past; see, “[Memory, Brain, Mind, Nama Loka, Kamma Bhava, Kamma Vipaka](#)”.
- Our memories have been kept intact from the beginning-less time; recently, evidence has started emerging that some people can remember astoundingly detailed accounts of their memories from many years back; see, “[Recent Evidence for Unbroken Memory Records \(HSAM\)](#)”.

3. *Citta* flow like a river (many billions a second), and are in discrete packets (like quanta in quantum theory; in fact, these are the smallest quanta anywhere in this world). Our internal *rupa* also change rapidly; this is why it is said that we change moment-to-moment.

- But the external *rupa* change at different rates, some lasting very long times (a gold bar, for example), while some change very fast.
- But NOTHING in the world remains the same over long times; even our universe came into existence some 14 billion years ago and will fade away at some point in the future. Our Solar system has a lifetime of less than five billion years.

4. As mentioned in 1, internal *pasada rupa* and *thoughts* for the present life run non-stop until the death. At the last thought-moment (called *cuti citta*, pronounced “chuthi chiththa”), a new *kamma* seed comes into play; see, “[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka](#)“. **Now both the *rupa* and *citta* for the new life contain brand new *rupa*, *vedana*, *sanna*, *sankhara*, *vinnana* (i.e., a new *pancakkhandha*);** it is a “being” that may look different, with its own “world”. For example, a “*deva* world” is very different from what we experience.

- The only things that are carried over to the new life are those *kamma* seeds, which contain the “character” or “*gathi*” of that lifestream, and even those are in constant re-generation; at any moment they could significantly change if the underlying conditions change.

5. Thus, at the moment of death, *pancakkhandha* makes a quantum jump.

- Let us take an example: A man has a physical body, which is part of his *rupakkandha* (we will make this as simple as possible); other four *skhandha* [*khandha*] determine his mental state (*vedana*, *sanna*, *sankhara*, *vinnana*), where *vinnana* is consciousness. Suppose he dies and is born as an elephant. Now all five *khandhas* die and the lifestream gets a new set of *khandhas*: the “new” physical body is different (external *rupa* are different too in the sense that it has a more restricted “world” which is only a part of the human world), and his “new” consciousness level is much lower than a human’s, now at the base level of an elephant.
- But the set of *kamma* seeds (*kamma beeja*) all got transferred to this new existence (*bhava*). Thus if there are many “good *kamma* seeds” there, there could later be a birth in a human or even higher realm.

6. Normally, the rebirth takes place in a physically different location (New scientific evidence for such “actions at a distance” are discussed in “[Quantum Entanglement – We Are All Connected](#)“).

- But there are a few cases where the rebirth happens at the same place. One example is the evolution of a butterfly from a caterpillar. A butterfly egg is laid by a female butterfly. The egg hatches and a caterpillar is born. It eats leaves and metamorphosis into a pupa that hangs like a small sack. The final stage is a butterfly that emerges from the sack.
- Now this butterfly is definitely not the pupa or the caterpillar or the egg; but it is not different from any of the above either. It is the same life stream. This is why both “soul” and “no-soul” (or “self” and “no-self”) are wrong views. Many people incorrectly translate “*anatta*” as “no-self” with the meaning of “no-soul” which is WRONG; see, “[Anatta and Dukkha – True Meanings](#)“.

7. Let us look at the caterpillar and the butterfly. The *rupas* defining their physical bodies are obviously different. Their *cittas* are different too. One thinks about eating leaves and the other thinks about drinking nectar. The only commonality between the two lies in the *kamma* seeds (which also keep evolving in a given life).

- Now that lifestream may have *kamma* seeds for a human, *deva*, or a *brahma* too. But none of

those got “selected”, probably because they were less potent. So, a butterfly is likely to be born in lower realms for very, very long times, before a less probable “human seed” being picked for a new life in a rare statistical event.

8. If there is anything that is carried from life-to-life that is one’s habits (*gathi*) that mold one’s character; of course these also keep changing even during a lifetime. I call this the “dynamic personality” of a lifestream in the sense that it is in constant flux. This is another reason why the Buddha rejected “no-self” as well as “self” or “soul”.

- There is nothing that remains the same (i.e., not “self”), but we cannot say “no-self” either, because there is an “identity” in the form of one’s *gathi* (and *asava*) that survives in the next life; see, “[Habits, Goals, and Character \(Gathi\)](#)” and “[Sansaric Habits, Character \(Gathi\), and Cravings \(Asava\)](#)”.

9. The *kamma* seeds (and associated *gathi*) of a given lifestream can be changed significantly during a human life.

- Out of the 31 realms of existence (see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”), in most other realms (especially those below the human realm), the mind has much less capability, if at all, and thus it is very difficult to get rid of bad *kamma* seeds and cultivate good ones. Thus one should make the utmost effort to get rid of the bad seeds and to cultivate good seeds during this short life span of 100 years or so. (If the *kamma* seed that led to his human life has left more *kammic* potential, the man in the example discussed in item #4 can be reborn a human again and again until that *kammic* potential is exhausted; see, “[Evidence for Rebirth](#)”).

10. However, *Nibbana* is attained NOT by getting rid of all *kamma* seeds; that is not necessary. *Nibbana* is approached by removing the “the tendency to grab things in this world (*upadana* [*clinging, grasping, attachment*])” by following the Noble Eightfold Path, and by lessening of this grabbing power in four stages.

- Thus an *Arahant* will have many good and less potent bad *kamma* seeds left, but his/her mind WILL NOT hold onto any of those at the dying moment (this happens when one truly comprehends the futility of staying in this world or craving for anything in this world; see, “[Anicca- True Meaning](#)”, and “[Why is Correct Interpretation of Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta so Important?](#)”). Thus, he/she will not be reborn “in this world”.

11. Still one would want to remove as many “bad seeds” as possible, and to cultivate as many “good seeds” as possible, since that will make it more probable of NOT getting a bad birth when we die; it will also make easier to attain *Nibbana* in a future life without being born in a bad realm (in case we do not make it in this life). See the “[Moral Living](#)” section on how to get started.

- I have made this complex process probably too simple. But I think it will help one to get the basic idea.

12. It is also important to realize that any lifestream does not have a “discernible beginning” as the Buddha said. Thus each one of us has been going through this process from “beginning-less time”.

- Universes come and go, but life will always find a suitable universe; see, “[Dhamma and Science – Introduction](#)”. Our life did not start on this Earth or in this universe. There have been innumerable universes and there will be innumerable universes according to the the inflationary theory on the Big Bang that started our universe.

13. In Buddha Dhamma (as well as in science) nothing happens without a cause: cause and effect. If there was a beginning, who or what gave rise to that beginning? And then what caused “that”? This is why “there is no discernible beginning”.

- Thoughts are more complex than described above; see, “[Vinnana, Thoughts, and the Subconscious](#)“.
- It is not possible to provide the “whole picture” in an a post or even several. You can use the “Search” box on the top right to locate posts on key words.
- For a more detailed discussion, see, “[Manomaya Kaya – Introduction](#)“, and the follow-up posts.
- See, also, “[What is Mind? How do we Experience the Outside World?](#)“
- One may wonder where one’s memory is stored: see, “[Memory, Brain, Mind, Nama Loka, Kamma Bhava, Kamma Vipaka](#)“.

Next, “[Recent Evidence for Unbroken Memory Records \(HSAM\)](#)“,

Recent Evidence for Unbroken Memory Records (HSAM)

1. A normal human being can remember some “significant events” even from very early day’s of this life. And these memories are not just a “summary”, but we recall a significant event in detail; it is like playing back a video tape. We recall the whole scene with pictures sounds, the background, everything. Just recall some past events and one can verify that for oneself.

- There are many cases of “memories from past lives” reported mostly by children, but also by some adults under hypnosis; see, “[Evidence for Rebirth](#)“.

2. Strong evidence is beginning to emerge that there is indeed a “complete record” of one’s past (in this life) just like a video tape. These studies started with Jill Price, who contacted a team of scientists in early 2000’s about her ability to recall anything from 1974 onwards. Here is a video of her with Diane Sawyer on an ABC News program:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?feature=player_embedded&v=aAbQvmf0YOOQ

3. Note that she says she can “see” what happened that day. It is not like she is recalling a “summary” or the gist of what happened. She can actually “see” the whole episode. And the day and date comes out effortlessly.

- A team of scientists has studied her for five years and published a paper providing their findings: [A Case of Unusual Autobiographical Remembering-Parker-2006 \(PDF file\)](#)
- She has written a book about her experience: “The Woman Who Can’t Forget”, by Jill Price (2009).
- Jill Price’s story led more people to come forward with their experiences, and ten more such individuals have been studied in detail recently: [Behavioral and neuroanatomical investigation-LePort-2012 \(PDF file\)](#).

4. These individuals have “highly superior autobiographical memory” or HSAM. They are not any smarter than average people, according those two papers above. They are just able to recall their past much more extensively; they can focus their minds to any date in the past and “watch” what happened: they can say what the weather was like, who they were with, whether any significant world event took place that day, etc.

- This phenomenon is also known as Hyperthymesia; see, <http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hyperthymesia>. Several other cases of HSAM are mentioned here.

5. Scientists believe that our memories are “stored” in the brain, in the synapses between neurons. I firmly believe that they will be proven wrong. This research is still in infancy, but there has been an explosion of activity within the past 15 years.

- While it is true that synaptic wiring are responsible for habit formation (see, “[How Habits are Formed and Broken – A Scientific View](#)“), it is a stretch to assume that “video-like recordings” of all past events are somehow embedded in neural connections!
- It is true that people without HSAM do have false memories (or have no memories) of past incidents that were not significant for them. But their memories about significant/traumatic memories are astoundingly accurate.

6. There are a couple of key significant facts that come out of these studies on HSAM subjects:

- They can instantly access a “time slot” from many years back that is arbitrarily chosen by someone else. They “re-visit” that time slot and describe, in real time, what took place with details.
- Since it has been confirmed in 11 subjects, it is not a “random event”.
- It is a stretch to assume that all such details for a period of over 20 years can be stored in biological membranes that regenerate undergo changes continuously.
- It is not a matter of being able to remember. Jill Price describes extensively that it is hard for her to remember any “learning material”; she was an average student.
- Rather, it is a matter of just having a brain that is “wired” to be able to access the “video recorder like” memory stream. It is not something one can develop by studying hard.

7. In Buddha Dhamma, a life of a sentient being is not restricted to the current life. As described in the previous post (“[What Reincarnates? – Concept of a Lifestream](#)”), any given sentient being has been born an uncountable number of times, with no “traceable beginning”.

- And a record of each of those lives is kept intact in the “mind plane”, and can be accessed to different degrees by different people.

8. According to Buddha Dhamma, the brain is just like a computer that helps extract these memory records from the “mind plane”. The mechanism is similar to a television extracting a broadcast signal; I will write a post on this later.

- These memory records are called “*nama gotta*” (pronounced “näma goththä”) and they go back for aeons and aeons and even a Buddha cannot see a beginning; see, “[Memory, Brain, Mind, Nama Loka, Kamma Bhava, Kamma Vipaka](#)”.
- We can recall only bits and pieces even during this lifetime; this is because our minds are covered by the five hindrances (*panca nivarana*); see, “[Key to Calming the Mind – The Five Hindrances](#)”.
- If one can get to the fourth *jhana* and develop *abhinna* powers, one could see many past lives. Ancient *yogis* who could get to the *eighth jhana* could see all past lives in the present aeon or *kalpa*. But the Buddha could see numerous aeons within a short time.
- This is why it is mostly children who can remember past lives. As they grow up their minds get “contaminated” more and more and these memories are lost. And those cases are different from the HSAM subjects.
- It appears that those individuals with HSAM have some of the capabilities of those who have developed *abhinna* powers. Since those with HSAM have been reported to have somewhat different brain structure, it will be interesting to see whether those with *abhinna* powers have similar brain structures as people with HSAM. I believe that it is a matter of the brain wiring to be able to “receive” more information from the “mind plane”.

Next, “[Buddhism without Rebirth and Nibbana?](#)”,

Buddhism without Rebirth and Nibbana?

I participated in several internet forums on “Buddhism” over the past year. One thing that clearly stands out is the fact that there are many people who like Buddhism, but they cannot understand what the big deal is about rebirth, and they cannot comprehend what Nibbana is. Thinking is: Why can’t we have Buddhism without rebirth (because I do not believe in rebirth) and Nibbana (because that seems to be too complicated)?

They are turned off by the concept of rebirth and are mystified by the concept of Nibbana.

- **Rebirth.** I think that the first issue lies in the fact that most major religions are based on three levels of existence: This life, and one of two eternal stages of life thereafter; committed to either heaven or hell for eternity based on what one does in this life. That model is very simple. Buddha’s 31 realms of existence with many “unseen beings” seems to be far fetched. Also, the possibility of being reborn as an animal is an abhorrent thought similar to the one people had about “evolving from the monkeys” before the theory of evolution.
- **Nibbana.** The second issue has become a problem mainly because of Mahayana doctrines. Mahayana sect arose basically out of the philosophical analyses of Nibbana by Nagarjuna, Asanga and other Mahayana forefathers. They could not understand the concept of Nibbana or what happens to an Arahant when the Arahant dies. So, they came up with concepts like sunyata (sunnata) or emptiness; see, “[What is Sunyata or Sunnata \(Emptiness\)](#)”.

1. There are two co-existing facets of Buddha Dhamma:

- The Buddha said, “This Dhamma is unlike anything that the world has ever seen”. [It really needs a paradigm change to get into the “new perspective about this world view of the Buddha”](#). One needs to be able to put aside all preconceived notions to understand the core message.
- However, the Buddha also said, “My Dhamma is good in the beginning, good in the middle, and good at the end”. [There is something to be gained from Buddha Dhamma for people who just come to know about it to those who have really grasped the core concepts](#). This is why I have separated posts into three categories on the site.
- In Bhikkhu Bodhi’s book, “In the Buddha’s Words”, there is a chapter on “The Happiness Visible in this Present Life”, where Buddha’s discourses to those who did not have aspiration to attain Nibbana, but were interested in pursuing moral lives, are described.
- The concepts such as rebirth and Nibbana are paradigm-changing concepts. But as one follows what one understands, these concepts will become clear; I have summarized these two concepts below.

2. If one is to benefit fully from Buddha Dhamma, one needs to understand its core message. And that core message is that this life is only but an insignificant time in the cycle of rebirths that we have been on from eternity, and that “our world” is much more complex than we see with 31 realms instead of the two (human and animal realms) that we see. Even more significantly, the suffering in many of the lower realms of existence is much worse than that in the human or even the animal realm.

- That is a LOT of things to accept as a basis. But we are fortunate compared to those who lived even a hundred years ago. Because now we have EVIDENCE to back up this wider world view of the Buddha; see, “[Dhamma and Science – Introduction](#)”.

- And both major Mahayana sects as well as Theravada Buddhism believe in rebirth and the concept of Nibbana. All Buddhists (except the type of Stephen Batchelor, who has written some popular books on Buddhism) believe in rebirth and Nibbana. I have seen the label “secular Buddhism” being used to describe those who like other aspects of Buddhism (basically moral living and meditation), but not necessarily rebirth and /or Nibbana.
- **Thus a Buddhist not believing in rebirth/Nibbana is an oxymoron.** The Pali or Sinhala word for Buddhist is “Bhauddhaya” meaning “a person trying to stop the rebirth process” (“Bhava+uddha”). One meaning of Buddha Dhamma is “path or method of removing bhava and thus stopping the rebirth process”. Buddha means, “one who has removed bhava (and attained Nibbana)”.

3. But that does not mean it is bad to be a “secular Buddhist”; that could be an intermediate state before becoming a Buddhist. **We just need to get the concepts clear.** Since there is no formal established way to declare oneself a “Buddhist” (or a need to do that), it is really in one’s own mind whether one is a Buddhist or not. The Buddha clearly stated that each person is at his/her own level of understanding. And there is no need to pretend; what one believes is what it is. **The critical thing is to make sure one is fully informed.**

- One does not become a Buddhist by reciting the precepts. One becomes a Buddhist gradually as the mind embraces the world view of the Buddha and realizes that the real happiness is attained by comprehending the true nature of this world: *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, and eventually by stopping the rebirth process.

4. In the mean time, it is important to realize that certain wrong views are bound to have adverse consequences according to Buddha Dhamma. Established (firm) view that there is no rebirth process is one included in micca ditthi, which is one of the (strong) *dasa akusala*, that makes a birth in the *apayas* (four lowest realms of existence) possible. It is not necessary to firmly believe in rebirth, one should at least leave that as a possibility. What is critical is not to have *niyata* (established) micca dithi.

5. Finally, it will take a real effort to sort through all different versions of “Buddhism” that are out there. Over two thousand five hundred years, just like now, people have tried to “mold” Buddha Dhamma to a form to their liking, and that is why we have so many versions. **But when that is done, the uniqueness, the real message, gets lost.** We need to keep intact this unique message, with the understanding that not everyone comprehends it right away.

- The key is to discard any version or aspect that does not provide a consistent picture. Buddha Dhamma describe the laws of nature, and there cannot be any inconsistencies. That is what I try to do with this website. If you see something inconsistent on the website, please let me know.
- I use the Tipitaka (Pali Canon) as the basis. It was written down over two thousand years ago (**by Arahants who had experienced Nibbana**), and is the oldest document encompassing the three main teachings: *suttas*, *vinaya*, and *abhidhamma*.
- I have documented the flaws in both Mahayana and (to a lesser extent) in current Theravada books by pointing out the inconsistencies with the Tipitaka. Also, I show that everything is self-consistent, which is the scientific basis to illustrate the validity of a theory. Newton’s theory on gravity had to be modified because they were not consistent with finer measurements.
- It does not matter what we believe personally. We need to find the true laws of nature that the Buddha discovered. Laws of nature, like gravity or laws of motion, do not care about what we

believe; see, “[Why it is Critical to Find the Pure Buddha Dhamma](#)”.

- Buddha Dhamma (in its pure form) has withstood all tests to date; see, “[Dhamma and Science – Introduction](#)”. Both current Mahayana and Theravada teachings need to be revised back to the original. It can be proven that there are self-contradictions within both sects in addition to contradictions with the teachings of the Buddha. I have a series of posts that point out these “problem areas” starting with, “[Key Problems with Mahayana Teachings](#)”.

Having established that rebirth and Nibbana are the “lifeblood” of Buddha Dhamma, now we can turn to the next question: What evidence is there to “prove” rebirth? What is the big deal about Nibbana, which sounds so esoteric?

A. REBIRTH

I have summarized some of the existing evidence for rebirth; see, “[Evidence for Rebirth](#)”. I am not sure what will qualify for “proof”, but one thing is very clear: A strong case can be made for it. There is evidence from many different areas, and that are consistent with the Buddha’s other teachings, for example, the existence of a *manomaya kaya*; see, “[Manomaya Kaya and Physical Body](#)”.

- If a person can believe even a SINGLE piece of evidence presented there, it is not possible to explain that without accepting that there is a link between such two lives. Since there is no physical connection between the two lives (that existed many miles apart), the connection must be outside the physical realm, i.e., the mental energy. There is new evidence from “quantum entanglement” that is consistent with the presumption that everything in this world is inter-connected; see, “[Quantum Entanglement – We Are All Connected](#)”.
- However, one can actually verify the rebirth process by developing *abhinna* powers via developing the fourth *jhana*. One can then “see” one’s previous lives; see, “[Power of the Human Mind – Introduction](#)” and the follow up posts. And there are some who have developed such *abhinna* powers, and this number can be expected to grow. When a significant number of people can verify the rebirth process, it will be accepted. Today, not everyone has traveled outside one’s own country. But everyone accepts that all those countries exist, because they believe the accounts of those who have made visits.

B. NIBBANA:

“*Bāna*” in Pali and Sinhala means “bondage”; thus *Nibbāna* means becoming free of bondage (to this world). We are bound to the unending cycle of rebirths via ten fetters called “*sanyōjana* = “*san+yōjana*”; see, “[What is “San”? Meaning of Sansara \(or Samsara\)](#)”; *yojana* means bond. This is also termed *samyojana*.

- The ten *sanyojana* (or *samyojana*) are removed via the four stages of *Nibbana*: three at [the Sotapanna stage](#), two reduced at the *Sakadagami* stage and removed at the *Anagami* stage, and the remaining five removed at the *Arahant* stage.
- Removal of the ten *sanyojana* also removes greed, hate, and ignorance from our minds; the *niramisa sukha* increases step-wise at each of the four stages, and the “cooling down” or “*nivana*” becomes complete; see, “[How to Taste Nibbana](#)”. There are many synonyms for *Nibbana*, and *nivana* (or *niveema*) is one of them. The Sanskrit name “*nirvana*” does not convey any of these meanings.
- When the mind becomes pure, a being is simply not reborn anywhere in the 31 realms. The

mind has attained full release, and unconditioned happiness called niramisa sukha. Thus *Nibbana* is stopping the rebirth process; the suffering stops. it is as simple as that. That mind cannot grasp even a fine form of a material body (which is subject to decay and death) anywhere in “the 31 realms”. **The mind becomes free of a body that is subject to decay and death (suffering).** That is Nibbana.

- The *Nibbanic* experience cannot be described by the terminology of “this world”; it is transcendental or “*lokottara*”, beyond “this world”. Also, all we can say about what happens to an *Arahant* at his/her death is that he/she will not be reborn in “this world” of 31 realms. There is no more suffering. The mind is free of bondage to a physical body that leads to so much suffering.
- Many people say, “What suffering? I do not feel that much suffering”. But the real suffering is in the lowest four realms; that is why the complete picture of 31 realms of existence is important. Furthermore, there is much suffering that is masked, especially when one is young. As one gets old, it is inevitable that one will start experience suffering at a higher degree, and then face death. Here is a video that illustrates this point:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?feature=player_embedded&v=4qILUJo4eLE&x-yt-ts=1422579428&x-yt-cl=85114404

However, the point is NOT to get depressed about this inevitability. Some people get depressed thinking about old age, and try to “give up” everything to follow the Path of the Buddha.

- It is not even possible for someone who is not familiar with Buddha Dhamma to start working on attaining *Arahanthood* straight away, and it is not advised either. It needs to be done with understanding. As one follows the Path, and learns Dhamma, one could start feeling early stages of *Nibbanic* pleasure (*niramisa sukha*) and thus will start having fact-based faith on concepts like rebirth and *Nibbana*: see, “[Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)”.
- Have you seen any depressed Buddhist monks? They have given up the worldly pleasures voluntarily, NOT with the mindset of a depressed person. Depression leads to hate; true “giving up” is done with wisdom.

This is only a summary. All these are described in detail with supporting evidence at this website. The key point is that EVERYTHING we observe, all we experience CAN be explained with the complete “world view” of the Buddha of which rebirth and Nibbana are essential foundations.

One does not need to know all that if all one needs is a peace of mind. One could follow the basic guidelines for a moral life that the Buddha provided. However, his key message was that this 100-year life can be only be compared to a “drop of water in a huge ocean” that is the cycle of rebirths filled with suffering. Thus one should at least critically examine the evidence to see whether that message needs to be taken seriously.

Next, “[Why a Sotapanna is Better off than any King, Emperor, or a Billionaire](#)“,

Dhamma Concepts

[“Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)”](#)

[“Ten Moral Actions \(Dasa Kusala\) and Ten Meritorious Actions \(Punna Kriya\)”](#)

[“The Five Precepts – What the Buddha Meant by Them”](#)

[“What is Kamma? – Is Everything Determined by Kamma?”](#)

[“How to Evaluate Weights of Different Kamma”](#)

[“The Four Bases of Mental Power \(Satara Iddhipada\)”](#)

[“Why is it Necessary to Learn Key Pali Words?”](#)

Ten Immoral Actions (Dasa Akusala)

One can do immoral acts with the body, speech, and mind (leading to *kaya*, *vaci*, and *mano sankhara*); see, “[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka](#)“. Actually, one starts committing *mano sankhara* first, some of which lead to *vaci* and *kaya sankhara*. These are called ten immoral acts (*dasa akusala*). The ten immoral acts are divided into the three categories as follows:

Three *mano sankhara* (immoral acts done with the mind):

1. *Abhijja* (covetousness; greed for other’s belongings)
2. *Vyapada* (ill-will, hatred)
3. *Niyata Micca Ditthi* (**established** wrong views)

Four *vaci sankhara* (immoral acts done with speech):

4. *Musavada* (Lying)
5. *Pisunavaca* (slandering)
6. *parusavaca* (harsh speech)
7. *Sampappalapa* (frivolous talk)

Three *kaya sankhara* (immoral acts done with the body):

8. *Panatipata* (killing)
9. *Adinnadana* (taking what is not given)
10. *kamesu miccacara* (sexual misconduct)

As one starts avoiding more and more of these ten actions, one will start feeling early stages of *Nibbana* or “*nivana*“, i.e., cooling down of the mind. The constant stress, excitedness of the mind will gradually ease.

First of all, it is important to realize that only an *Arahant* is totally free from doing any of these; even a *Sotapanna* may commit some of these at least once -in-a-while. There are six things that a *Sotapanna* is incapable of: killing mother or father, killing an *Arahant*, injuring a Buddha, knowingly causing schism in *Sangha*, and having ***niyata micca ditthi*** or **firmly-established wrong views**.

- Thus it is inevitable that some of these could be broken by anyone below or even at the *Sotapanna* stage. What is important is to realize that these are to be AVOIDED if at all possible. It becomes easier as one learns Dhamma and see the benefits of avoiding them.

Most terms above are clear, but many people may not be aware of what *micca ditthi* (wrong views) is. *Micca ditthi* is basically not comprehending the basic characteristics of “this world” of 31 realms; see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)“.

- Because of the ignorance of the complete world view, one is likely to have three main wrong world views: (i) everything has sprung without a cause (*ahetuka ditthi*), (ii) good and bad produce no effect (*akiriya ditthi*), and (iii) there is no after-life (*natthika ditthi*).

If someone has these world views, one is likely to carry out immoral acts and acquire *kamma vipaka* that will lead to rebirth in the *apayas* (the lowest four realms) at some point in the future, i.e., in future rebirths. **There are ten such specific wrong views or *micca ditthi* (sometimes just called *ditthi*):**

- View that no such thing as: (1) kammic benefits in giving, (2) paying back debts (for what

others have done for you), (3) benefits of respecting Noble Ones, (4) *kamma vipaka* or *kammic* benefits of taking care of (5) mother and (6) father, (7) possibility of rebirth in realms one does not see, (8) possibility of beings from those realms coming back to this world, (9) *opapatika* birth (instant full-formed birth) in realms other than the human and animal realms, (10) monks and yogis who can see past lives. For explanations on (7)-(10), see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”.

What is *akusala* is to hold “*niyata micca ditthi*” or “established wrong views”, i.e., one is not even prepared to consider, say, that there is a rebirth process. Thus if one has **unwavering** doubts about any one of the ten categories in the above paragraph, then one is said to have **established** wrong views (*niyata micca ditthi*).

- The key point is that when one has established wrong views, one looks at the world differently without realizing that there are consequences for one’s actions. Without a Buddha explaining the true nature of the world (rebirth process, life in other realms, uncountable number of planetary systems like the Earth, etc), one would not be aware of that fact.
- As scientists are finding out, there are many things in nature that we do not experience/understand. For example, scientists can only account for 4% of the mass of the universe; they cannot account for the rest (Google “dark matter” or “dark energy”). Thus one needs to keep an open mind and learn more Dhamma to see whether all these make sense.

Even a *Sotapanna* (Stream Enterer, at the first stage of *Nibbana*) may still not be truly convinced of one or more of the ten factors. But he/she has not ruled them out. However, it is said that if a *Sotapanna* attains the fourth *Ariya jhana*, then he/she will be able to “see” these other realms and to become convinced of the truth of all of them.

A lot of you may be thinking “How do I know all this is true? Is there any evidence for the existence of *rupa/arupa lokas*, *apayas* (hell), or spontaneous birth?”. There are a lot of things we do not know about “this world”. We cannot rely on just science to verify/confirm these. Only within the last 50 years or so that science has accepted that our world is bigger than a few galaxies (now science has confirmed that there are billions of galaxies). Whereas the Buddha stated that *chakrawata* (star systems or planetary systems) come into existence all the time, science has confirmed that only within the past 100 years; see, “[Dhamma and Science – Introduction](#)”.

- Furthermore, the newest findings (yet unconfirmed) in string theory indicate that we live in a 11-dimension world, not the 4-dimension world that we experience. For a look at different dimensions, see, “[What Happens in Other Dimensions](#)”. Thus, more of Buddha’s teachings will be confirmed with time.

It is easy to see that all immoral deeds start as *mano sankhara* (bad thoughts) in the mind. Any of the *vaci sankhara* (speech) or *kaya sankhara* (bodily actions) are done with greed, hate, or not knowing the true nature of the world (ignorance). In particular, the basis for moral behavior comes out of the correct world view. Let us examine this below:

- The fact that there is no discernible beginning to life (see, “[Sansaric Time Scale](#)”) means all of us have been going through this rebirth process for an unimaginably long time. Thus we have been born in most of the 31 realms of existence. Not only that, we have been born innumerable times in EACH of those realms (except the realm that is reserved for the *Anagamis*).
- The above fact means each sentient being had been related to any other sentient being at some point in this long *sansara* (rebirth process). **The Buddha said, “it is difficult to find ANY sentient being that was not you father, mother, or a sibling at some point in this long**

sansara“. Infinity is a concept that is hard to grasp; see, “[Infinity – How Big Is It?](#)“.

- An interesting book that talks about such hard to grasp ideas (in science) involving infinity is, “The Beginning of Infinity: Explanations That Transform the World” by David Deutsch.
- Therefore, we, meaning not only us humans but ALL sentient beings, are connected/related to each other. This is why it is wrong to kill any living being, steal from anyone, verbally abuse anyone, etc. **This is the basis for morality. This is WHY it is not good to do any of the ten immoral acts.**

Intention is An Important Factor

The Buddha said, “*Cetana ham Bhikkhave kamma vadami*“, i.e., “Bhikkhus, I say that *kamma* is intention”. We always need to look at the intention to pinpoint whether or what kind of *kamma* was committed.

- Let us take an example: if someone shoots a dog that is attacking a child, one’s intention there is to save the child. On the other hand, if someone is shooting a dog for “target practice”, then there is no excuse.
- Sometimes it is not possible to judge the *kammic* consequences just by looking at the particular act. Only the person committing the act will know whether it is a good or bad intention. Thus normally it is not wise to judge other people’s actions.
- If it is a *mano sankhara* (bad thoughts), the only person who even knows about that is the one who is committing it.

In many cases, it is possible for others to “see” when one is committing *vaci* or *kaya sankhara*. But not always. Disciplinary actions against a child by a parent may appear to be *kaya sankhara* (spanking) or *vaci sankhara* (verbal threats) , but the parent is likely to have good intentions for the child in most cases.

Also, in many cases, it is not possible for any person to advise another on what to do when conflicting issues are involved. Is it OK to steal some food to feed one’s own kids when they are crying in hunger? Is it OK to spank a child when the child is misbehaving? Only the parent can make that decision based on the circumstances.

Relative Weights of Kamma

One critical problem many people have is that they try hard to avoid actions with relatively small *kammic* consequences, while unknowingly doing things that have stronger *kammic* consequences. Let us take an example: Suppose we have a large tank of water which is losing water due to many holes at the bottom. Some holes are pin holes, some are a little larger, and there are a few holes that are big and losing water fast. Obviously, one would want to plug those large holes first. Then one would fix the medium-size holes and those pin holes are the last to be fixed.

- Relative weights of ten immoral acts are not easy to quantify. However, we can clearly see that *kaya sankhara* have higher “*kammic* potential” compared to *vaci sankhara* if they are directed to the same living being; hurting someone physically is worse than verbal abuse.
- Another example: Say someone has hateful thoughts of a particular person all day long. That could be worse than just saying something to that person and “getting the load off the mind”. However, even that is not necessary. The best solution is to develop *metta* (loving kindness) towards that person, and get rid of those hateful thoughts. We always need to realize that we all are trapped in this constant struggle to find happiness in a world that is not setup to provide

lasting happiness; see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta](#)“.

Kammic consequences also depend strongly on the “consciousness level” of the living being against whom the immoral act was committed. Killing a human will have far more stronger consequences compared to killing an animal. This is discussed in the essay, “[How to Evaluate Weights of Different Kammass](#)“.

Next, “[Ten Moral Actions \(Dasa Kusala](#)“,

Ten Moral Actions (Dasa Kusala) and Ten Meritorious Actions (Punna Kriya)

The immoral actions described in the previous post ([“Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)”](#)) are the ones that accrue “bad kamma” and will bring “bad results” including rebirth in the lower four realms.

- The word “*kusala*” (“*ku*+“*sala*” where “*ku*” is for “*kunu*” or defilements and “*sala*” means “drop” or “get rid of”) means getting rid of defilements. Thus *kusala kriya* are actions that help remove greed, hate, and ignorance.
- *Akusala kriya* do the opposite, i.e., they help accumulate greed, hate, and ignorance. Those are also called *pāpa kiriya*, or *pāpa kamma*.
- **There is another set of actions called *punna kriya*; such an action leads to the joy in the heart and are opposite to *pāpa kriya*; they help purify the mind.** They are meritorious actions like giving, but depending on the intention MAY NOT necessarily lead to the elimination of greed, hate, and ignorance. For example, one may give to charity, but may be hoping for a “return” by expecting good rewards for that action. Thus depending on the intention, a *punna kriya* may become a *kusala kriya* too. Either way, the Buddha encouraged *punna kriya*.

Avoidance of any *akusala kamma* is *kusala kamma*. **Thus the ten *kusala kamma* are those that avoid the ten *akusala kamma* without any ulterior mundane motive**, i.e., to attain rewards in the 31 realms. The *punna kamma* one does increasingly gain the nature of *kusala kamma* as one’s grasping of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* is enhanced.

- When one truly understands *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, one prevents from stealing or lying (for example) not just as a guideline for moral behavior, but because IT DOES NOT MAKE SENSE to gain anything in this unfruitful world by doing such harmful things: [the consequences are much more dire compared to any short-lived enjoyment that results from such activity.](#)

The following ten meritorious actions (*punna kriya*) will accrue “good kamma”, and will bring about “good results” including rebirth in the human and higher realms. When done with right intentions, they become *kusala kriya* and thus such acts can lead to [the Sotapanna stage](#); see, “[Kusala-Mula Paticca Samuppada](#)”.

These meritorious actions (*punna kriya*) can be divided into three groups: *dāna* (generosity), *sila* (moral behavior), and *bhavana* (meditation).

Dāna (Generosity) group includes:

1. *Dāna* (giving)
2. Transfer of merits to others (*pattidāna*)
3. Rejoicing (accepting or participating) in other’s merits (*pattanumodana*)

Sila (Morality) group includes:

- 4. *Sila* (morality), i.e., observing 5, 8, or 10 precepts
- 5. Reverence to elders and holy persons (*apacayana*)
- 6. Pay homage to religious places, take care of such places, etc (*veyyavacca*)

Bhavana (meditation) group includes:

- 7. Meditation (*bhavana*)
- 8. Listening to Dhamma discourses (*Dhamma savana*)
- 9. Teaching Dhamma (*Dhamma desana*)
- 10. Correcting one's wrong views (*ditthijukamma*)

Therefore, *dana*, *sila*, *bhavana* constitute the “base” of a life of a moral person.

- The “*dana* group” helps one overcome one's greed (*lobha*).
- The “*sila* group” helps removing hate (*dosa*) from one's mind.
- The “*bhavana* group” helps removing ignorance (*moha*) from the mind by learning Dhamma and getting rid of the wrong views (*micca ditthi*).

Since Nibbana is removing greed, hate, and ignorance from one's mind, it is clear how these ten actions pave the way for Nibbana. As one engages in these activities more and more, the “cooling down” or “niveema” can be experienced; see, “[How to Taste Nibbana](#)”.

In the *sila* group of activities, one starts by observing the five precepts, i.e., abstaining from killing living beings intentionally, stealing, sexual misconduct, lying, and getting intoxicated. This last one is normally taken to be intoxication with alcohol or drugs, but it also includes intoxication with money, beauty, power, position, etc.

It is always a good idea to keep in mind why these are supposed to be moral actions, i.e., because they help purify one's mind:

- Most people, in order to avoid breaking the five precepts abstain from drinking, but do not hesitate to show off their wealth, beauty, power, etc.; they are “drunk” too.
- Others pay a lot of attention not to lie, but do not hesitate to gossip, slander, or verbally abuse others.
- Also one should realize that a human life has much more weight compared to an animal life; see, “[How to Evaluate Weights of Different Kamma](#)”.
- Most of all, the tenth one is the most potent one that most people neglect to consider. Having established wrong views (*niyata micca ditthi*) is a very potent immoral action, and thus one needs to understand this clearly; see, “[Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)](#)”.

This is why learning Dhamma has a prominent place in the *bhavana* section. As one learns the deeper concepts of Dhamma gradually, wrong views are gradually removed. It is not enough to just say, “I will not have these views anymore”, even though making such a determination is good. The mind needs to see evidence to get rid of the wrong views it has. The feeling of the *niramisa sukha* when one starts on the Path will make it easier to remove wrong views; see, “[Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)”.

The High Value of Meritorious Acts Done with Understanding

1. If one performs a wholesome deed with the knowledge of *kamma* and its effects and also of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, then the wholesome consciousness is associated with understanding. The volition will be accompanied with all three wholesome roots: non-greed, non-hate, non-delusion. So three-

root (*tihétuka* or “*ti*” + “*hetu*”) wholesome kamma is acquired.

- On the other hand, if one performs a wholesome deed without any knowledge of Kamma and its effects or the basic unfruitful nature of this world, he is doing it without any understanding. Then the volition will not be accompanied by non-delusion, but only the two roots of non-greed and non-hate. So two-root (*dvihétuka* = “*dvi*”+ “*hetu*”) kamma is acquired. These are less meritorious compared to the three-root (*tihetuka*) kamma.

2. A detailed discussion can be found at, “[A Simple Way to Enhance Merits \(Kusala\) and Avoid Demerits \(Akusala\)](#)“. We will discuss these effects in detail in the Abhidhamma section too. But it is important to realize that the strength of the *kamma vipaka* for a given meritorious act will vary depending on the level of understanding. For example, while just writing check for charity will have its results, much more stronger results will be gained by someone who spends the same amount of money but involves more with giving by thinking about it before and afterwards, and “getting involved” in the process, for example preparing meals for the hungry etc.

3. To acquire this type of superior kamma, one should think of the moral action in advance and feel glad for having the chance to do it. Again after performing the action, one should reflect on it and be full of joy thinking about the good aspects of the deed. Furthermore, one can gain more merits by doing a *punna anumodana* or *pattidana* (transfer of merits to others, #2 kusala kamma above) because this amounts to paying off *sansaric* debts; see, “[Kamma, Debt, and Meditation](#)”.

- On the other hand, if one feels lazy or reluctant or jealous or stingy before a moral action such as giving charity, and regrets doing the moral action afterwards, then the moral volition of giving charity will be surrounded by other unwholesome intentions (*cetana*) and consequently its potentiality will be weakened. The wholesome kamma acquired in this case is inferior.

Thus is the importance of learning Dhamma in order to grasp such details and to realize the full benefits one’s meritorious actions. Plus, it is interesting to see how all these details “fit into the big picture”; see, “[The Importance of Purifying the Mind](#)”.

Next, “[How to Evaluate Weights of Different Kamma](#)”,

The Five Precepts – What the Buddha Meant by Them

1. The five or eight precepts, of course with different meanings, were there before the Buddha. It is said that on the day the future Buddha, Prince Siddhartha, was born his mother had observed the eight precepts.

- The ancient kings banned the so-called five immoral acts in order to maintain a peaceful society. These were: killing (of probably other people), stealing, sexual misbehavior, lying, and getting intoxicated.
- The vedic Brahmins expanded these to include killing of animals. They also expanded to eight precepts which enabled them to attain mundane jhanas.

2. Just like he did with many existing terminology at that time (kamma, the four great elements of patavi, apo, tejo, vayo, etc), [the Buddha adopted these precepts, but re-defined what he meant by them.](#)

- In Buddha Dhamma, all possible immoral acts are included in the dasa *akusala*; see, “[Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)](#)”.
- Therefore, all those are in the five precepts too. When one truly understands Buddha Dhamma, i.e., the nature of this world as embodied in *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, one sees that these precepts come out naturally from the nature’s laws. At that stage, one’s mind automatically rejects all dasa *akusala* and thus the five precepts are automatically obeyed; one does not even have to think about them.

3. For one embarking on the Path prescribed by the Buddha, the conventional five precepts (killing other beings intentionally, stealing, sexual misconduct, lying, and intoxication) are a good start.

- Furthermore, one needs to recite the five precepts with the understanding that it is not a promise but one’s intention is to do the utmost (otherwise the act will itself be a *musavada* or a lie). **This is because anyone other than an Arahant is bound to break them per their true meanings.**
- But as one proceeds on the Path and experiences the benefits (peace of mind or the early stages of *niramisa sukha*), one should try to expand the scope of those five precepts from the conventional meanings. This can be done systematically: when one truly understand the meanings of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* AND that our existence does not end with this life, one begins to have a more deeper insight.
- **When that happens, the precepts are not followed as a ritual or a set of rules. Rather, one realizes that there is no other moral way to live.**

4. For example, when one realizes that one has been an animal or worse in previous lives, one stops thinking of animals as “mere things” that exist for our pleasure. Furthermore, understanding the laws of kamma i.e., taking any life has consequences will make one re-think of just wantonly taking another life.

- But some people go to extremes. They start treating an animal life on the same level as a human life, and then freak out when they have to clear a spider web in cleaning their house. It is inevitable that we will unintentionally kill many small creatures while walking on the ground or even boiling some water. So, one need to get a sense of the relative weights of kamma; see, “[How to Evaluate Weights of Different Kamma?](#)”.
- What needs to be avoided first is those “pleasure killings” like fishing, hunting, etc.

5. Stealing is not merely acts like shop lifting, but also includes gains by immoral means. In order to live a functional society, we have to do transactions with each other. We just need to make sure we do not take advantage of another person and becoming “morally indebted” to that person.

- Vinaya rules (“vi” + “naya” where “naya” is debt and vinaya is becoming free debts) in Buddha Dhamma setup for the monks show how to live their lives by properly paying back for the sustenance they get from the lay people.
- When the Buddha said to test any act or concept with “Dhamma and Vinaya”, he meant that the concept needs to be consistent with paticca samuppada (cause and effect) and also consistent with “raga vinaya, dosa vinaya, and moha vinaya”, i.e., not getting into debt via greed, hate, and ignorance.
- If we gain from someone by unjust means, we will have to pay that debt if not in this life, but in future lives; see, [“Kamma, Debt, and Meditation”](#).

6. The third precept, “*kamesu miccacara veramani sikkha padan samadiyami*”, is commonly translated as “avoiding sexual misconduct”. But “*kāma*” is not just sexual activity; “*kāma*” includes all sense pleasures that are available in the *kama loka*. And “*miccacara*” (pronounced “michchächära”) means “misbehavior” in the sense of “going to extremes”. Thus the real meaning is to not to over-indulge in sense pleasures.

- In fact, excessive drinking, gambling etc are included in this precept.
- We have to use all our five physical senses to live in this world. But we need to have restraints so that we do not abuse them to the extent that we will hurt ourselves or others. Even a simple example of over-eating leads to health problems, which will hurt not only oneself but the whole family.
- **The first three precepts include all three *akusala kamma* done with the body.**

7. The fourth precept on musavada (lying) in Buddha Dhamma includes all abuses done by speech, including harsh speech, slandering, and gossip which WILL harm oneself and others.

- **Thus the fourth precept encompasses all four *akusala kamma* done with speech.**

8. The fifth is a big one that is almost always misinterpreted. If it included just drinking, it would have been, “*surameraya veramani.....*”. That was probably the original verse.

But in Buddha Dhamma it is, “*surameraya majjapama dattana veramani.....*”.

In the word, “*sura*”, “*ra*” means “*raga*” or excess greed, thus “*sura*” means with excess greed; “*meraya*” is delicious. “*Majja*” means intoxication and “*majjapama*” is getting delayed via intoxication. “*Dattana*” means that mindset. Of course, “*veramani sikkha padan samadiyami*” means “I make a determination to avoid doing such things willingly”.

Thus it should be interpreted as, “avoid the mindset of getting intoxicated by alcohol, drugs, money, power, etc”, anything that can make you “fall behind”:

- All this happen in one’s mind. **One gets intoxicated with greedy thoughts and when one does not get one’s way with them, one generates hate.** And all this happens because one does not understand the true nature of this world, i.e., one has micca ditthi or wrong views.
- One believes that either, (i) one’s actions will not have future consequences, and (ii) therefore, one just needs to think about how to get what one wants (because there are so many tempting

things out there to be had!); one does not realize all that is temporary.

- **Thus in order to really obey the fifth precept one needs to start working on one's mind. All three *akusala* kamma done with mind are included in this fifth precept; see, "[Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)](#)".**

9. The following scenario is given as an example to illustrate the futility of blindly following precepts: There are many people who live their entire lives without intentionally killing, stealing, engaging in sexual misconduct, lying, or getting intoxicated. But their minds are burdened with greed, hate, or ignorance. Depending on the state of their minds, they may not even get a human birth next time around.

- And if keeping those precepts will take one to Nibbana, then a cow or a horse living in isolation will be certain to attain Nibbana. They do not kill, steal, lie, or get intoxicated, and if their owners do not have any other animal of that kind, then there is no chance of sexually misbehaving either.
- It is all about purifying one's mind. A pure mind gains wisdom, and will not allow any harmful action by speech or by deed. Such a mind is not burdened, but has "cooled down"; that is the happiness of Nibbana.

Next, "[Three Kinds of Happiness- What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)",

What is Kamma? – Is Everything Determined by Kamma?

1. A key concept in Buddha Dhamma is cause and effect; anything happens due to a reason. Nature enforces this cause and effect via five main absolutely unshakable laws (*niyama dhamma* or sometimes called *dhammata*): *kamma niyama*, *citta niyama*, *utu niyama*, *beeja niyama* (also called *bija niyama*; but it is pronounced “beeja”), and *dhamma niyama*. We will discuss these in detail in another post, but the point here is that kamma is NOT deterministic, other than for *anantariya kamma* (killing one’s parents or an *Arahant*, injuring a Buddha, etc); everything plays out due to a complex process involving all five *niyama dhamma*.

- First of all, there are actions by individuals that lead to bad consequences right away: if one jumps from a tall building, one is bound to get hurt or worse. This is a consequence of *dhamma niyama* (law of gravitation is a *dhamma niyama*); here cause and effect can be easily seen. *Paticca samuppada* is the ultimate *dhamma niyama*; it explains **how and under what conditions** *kamma vipaka* produces results.
- When something appears in this world, it does not stay the same. It undergoes change (*viparināma*) and is eventually destroyed. Thus anything in the world (a *sankata*) is subjected to the *utu niyama*. Whatever results that *kamma vipaka* may bring in, they will eventually go away.
- *Beeja* (or *bija*) *niyama* is not relevant to the workings of the plant seeds as some books explain. It dictates how *kamma beeja* (seeds) lead to their fruits (*vipaka*): a “*punna kamma seed*” or a “good seed” will always produce good results; and a “*pāpa kamma seed*” or a “bad seed” will always produce a bad result. A *Sotapanna* would have made all those *kamma* seeds, that make it possible to have births in the *apayas*, ineffective forever; thus a *Sotapanna* will NEVER be born in the *apayas*.
- *Citta niyama* involves laws associated with the working of the complex mind and that can affect *kamma vipaka* in a major way; for example, by purifying the mind, one can attain the *Sotapanna* stage and thus make INEFFECTIVE all those *kamma* seeds that could lead to birth in the *apayas*.
- *Kamma vipaka* are the root causes for all that happen in this world, **but their effects can be altered and even stopped** by exploiting the other laws of nature. This is what a Buddha discovers when he attains Enlightenment. All *kamma vipaka* are made ineffective by attaining full *Nibbana* or the *Arahanthood*.

The main point here is that most bad consequences can be avoided by understanding Dhamma, living a moral life, and being mindful (*yoniso manasikara*).

2. **In this beginning-less long journey of rebirths called *sansara*, each of us have done an uncountable number of both good and bad things.** When we do a good or a bad act, the *kammic* energy associated with that act gives rise to a seed, called a *kamma* seed. It is an energy (not a physical thing) that stays with our minds until it gets a chance to come to fruition. Just like an apple seed will not germinate and grow into an apple tree until the right conditions (soil, water, sunlight, etc) appear, all our *kamma* seeds lie in waiting for the right conditions to appear, and at that time we have to experience the result of that *kamma* or *kamma vipaka*.

- Our *kamma* seeds (*kamma beeja*) are subjected to the *beeja niyama* mentioned above. In either case, a seed gives rise to a plant or a *vipaka* **according to the type of seed**. Someone, who did something bad that only an animal would do, will pay for that may be with a birth in the animal realm; someone who did an act of generosity may get rewarded accordingly.

- We can keep an apple seed (for example) in a dry, cool place for a long time; some seeds have been kept for thousands of years. It will not germinate until we plant it in a fertile soil and provide water and sunlight. In the same way, a kamma seed (good or bad) can lay dormant for a long time until conditions becomes right for it to germinate. We all have accumulated numerous kamma seeds over these repeated rebirths, and [what we need to do is to provide conditions for the good kamma seeds to germinate and NOT provide conditions for bad ones to germinate.](#)
- Thus *kamma* is the act AND *kamma vipaka* is the result of that act. **But since the right conditions need to appear for a kamma seed to “germinate”, the vipaka may not come until later in the same life, next life, or even many lives later.**
- This is why it is not easy for people to see that their actions will have consequences. *Kamma niyama* is not the only law that is in effect; there are four more as mentioned above and they all work together. It is a very intricate network. In particular, because there is a *citta niyama* (principle of thoughts), we also have some control over these kamma vipaka. **We cannot change any of the five *niyama*, but we can OVERCOME a cause (a power) due to a *niyama* by building an opposing power.**

3. We can take many steps to suppress the bad *kamma vipaka* coming to fruition and ALSO to get those good *kamma vipaka* to come to fruition. **As emphasized above, we all have basically unlimited number of both good and bad *kamma vipaka* waiting to bear fruit.** [Rather than giving in to bad vipaka and saying “what to do, this is my kamma“, we can find ways to suppress those. And rather than saying “I must not have done any good kamma, and this is my fate”, we can probe and locate those hidden good kamma seeds and cultivate them.](#) Let us consider some examples:

- If one does not take care of one’s physical body, it may become fertile ground for many bad *kamma vipaka* to come to fruition. If we eat healthy and exercise, the body will not be vulnerable to ailments or injuries.
- The brain needs good food and exercise too. A healthy body and mind exercises such as solving problems, even word puzzles, keeps the brain in good condition. But the best is meditation, and *vipassana* or insight meditation is better than *samatha* meditation. For example, even if one’s family has a history of Alzheimer’s disease, one can possibly avoid getting by keeping the brain active and healthy.
- One may be born to poverty because of a past *kamma vipaka* that came to fruition at the death of the previous life. But this is NOT a reason to give up. Any person has an unlimited number of good *kamma vipaka* waiting to come to fruition. It is true that a birth into a poor family did not set up optimum conditions. But one has control over the *citta niyama* that was mentioned at the beginning (see, [“The Law of Attraction, Habits \(Gathi\), and Cravings \(Asavas\)”](#)). One could use one’s mind to overcome this condition, and cultivate the background to achieve success.
- This is why the environment is critical to anyone. One needs to surround oneself with optimistic, moral people, who will help cultivate the good qualities that lie dormant. At the same time, one needs to avoid “bad company” that could pull one in the wrong directions. It is not that any person is intrinsically good or bad; rather, at any given phase of life or even through most of this life, some people may be displaying their “bad habits” that have come to the forefront. Associating with such people, one will be affected in the negative way, bring up one’s own bad habits (or “*gathi*” in Pali or Sinhala).
- The environment is CRITICAL for young children starting from the time when they are just

conceived in the mother's womb. Even the fetus in the womb is affected by, say a loving mother and father showing affection to each other or when the mother is being abused by the father. It is critical to have a nurturing environment within the family and also in the school and in any other activity. A significant part of an individual's character could be molded by the first 10-15 years of life. That is the time they can acquire habits and once acquired, it takes a lot of effort to change them. It is the duty of the parents to instill good habits: moral behavior, eating well, exercise, associate with good friends, avoid bad friends, study well, etc.

4. The world is VERY complex. Because all those five *niyamas* are acting simultaneously to enforce the "cause and effect", it is not possible to sort through each and every event in isolation and say, "this is THE reason for this particular event". There could be a dominant cause in some cases, but most times it is a combination of several, and most those are from the past.

- The main thing we have remember is that EACH and EVERY action by us will have consequences (law of *kamma*). There is nowhere to hide; even if we can fool the law enforcement sometimes, the nature cannot be fooled.
- We need to make a concerted effort to get rid of bad habits and to acquire and cultivate good habits. A habit can snowball into a *sansaric* habit, good or bad (related to law of citta and law of beeja). Environment is an important factor in getting rid of bad habits and acquiring/cultivating good habits.
- We need to be constantly aware that there are zillions of *kamma beeja* (good and bad) waiting to be germinated. We should not provide conditions for "bad seeds" to germinate (i.e., avoid bad company, bad environment, etc), and provide conditions for "good seeds" to germinate (i.e., study well, provide the necessary conditions to get a promotion or a job, and learn and practice Dhamma so that whatever good thing that is forgotten comes to the forefront of the mind). I am sure you can apply the principle to your own life; each one is different.
- Then there are things that happen due to apparently random events: floods, hurricanes, earthquakes, etc. These come under *utu niyama*: events that occur due to physical causes in the environment. When those happen, thousands of apparently "unconnected" people may be affected the same way. Again, this is partly due to the unimaginable number of *kamma* we have accumulated in this beginning-less rebirth process. There is ALWAYS something from the deep past that is going MATCH any circumstance.

5. Finally, there is a misconception out there that one needs to get rid of all *kamma* (more accurately *kamma vipaka*) in order to attain Nibbana. This is completely false. One attains *Nibbana* via removing deep-seated defilements, called *asavas*; see, "[The Way to Nibbana – Removal of Asavas](#)".

Some of the main concepts are discussed further in the "[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka](#)", "[Habits and Goals](#)", "[Sansaric Habits and Asavas](#)", "[The Way to Nibbana – Removal of Asavas](#)", and other related posts.

Next, "[How to Evaluate Weights of Different Kamma](#)",

How to Evaluate Weights of Different Kamma

In the previous essay, “[Ten Immoral Acts \(Dasa Akusala\)](#)“, we looked at the ten different types of acts that will have bad *kammic* consequences.

1. We can see that most of these “acts” are directed towards other beings, whether it is done bodily, verbally, or just by thought. In principle, a being could be in any one of the 31 realms (see, “[Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)“).

2. The severity of the consequence of any misdeed (ie., *kamma vipaka*) involving another living being depends strongly on the “level of existence” of the living being from lowest level of realm 1 (*niraya*) to the highest at the 31st realm (fourth arupa loka); Any “*Ariya*” or a Noble Person (who has attained one of the four stages of *Nibbana*), are at the highest levels regardless of the realm. A hurtful word against an *Ariya* carries thousand-fold bad *kamma vipaka* compared to killing thousand ants.

2. It is difficult to identify whether a given human is just an immoral human or an *Arahant* by just looking at that person. Human realm is unique in many ways.

Thus, we can try to sort out the *kammic* consequences of a given immoral act on the “level of consciousness” of the being that act was directed to:

- **Regardless of the realm**, the highest four levels are *Arahant*, *Anagami*, *Sakadagami*, and *Sotapanna*. Humans can attain all four levels.
- Out of the 31 realms we can directly experience only the human and animal realms. Thus, normally we need only to evaluate how our actions affect other humans AND animals.
- Since any animal is inferior to any human, we need to pay special attention to how we interact with other human beings.
- In particular, it is not possible to judge whether a given human has attained a *Nibbanic* state. Even by directing hurtful words to an *Ariya* (one who has attained at least [the Sotapanna stage](#)), one could be acquiring thousand-fold more bad *kammic* potential compared to doing the same to a normal human.
- In some cases, even the person in question may not know that he/she is a *Sotapanna*. There may be “*jati Sotapannas*“, i.e., those who had attained [the Sotapanna stage](#) in a previous life and thus born as a *Sotapanna*, and may not realize it.
- Thus we need to be very careful with dealing with fellow humans in particular.

3. When we say killing is immoral it is implicit that killing is taking the life of any living being. But killing a human has a *kammic* consequence that is much higher compared to killing an animal. Killing a *Sotapanna* has an even more drastic consequences, *Sakadagami* even higher, *Anagami* even higher, and killing an *Arahant* will have the highest, and is of the strongest kind at par with killing a parent (an *anantariya kamma* that will cause the very next birth in an *apaya*).

4. Similarly other immoral acts will have consequences depending on the “consciousness level” of the living being. It is not a matter of one particular living being is “better” than another.

- Rather it is a matter of how valuable that “level” is, and how difficult it is to attain that “level”. One has been born a human because of the merits one has acquired in previous lives; it is extremely difficult to get a human birth as we will discuss in a separate post; see, “[How the](#)

Buddha Described the Chance of Rebirth in the Human Realm“.

- One becomes a *Sotapanna* by cultivating moral behavior and by purifying one’s mind; thus a life of a *Sotapanna* is much more valuable compared to a normal human being.

5. Even among humans who have not attained any *Nibbanic* state, there are “different levels of consciousness”: One who has more wisdom (*panna*) is at a higher level than one with less wisdom.

- Here wisdom does not mean book knowledge, but knowledge of Dhamma; understanding of the true nature of “this world”, or *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. Thus the possibility of that person attaining a Nibbanic stage is more likely, compared to one who has less wisdom.

6. Another important thing is not to worry about things that one does not have any control over. Everyday, we kill so many small animals unintentionally: stepping on them while walking, cleaning the yard, cleaning the house, and even while boiling water.

- We need to remember that “*kamma* is intention”. We are not boiling water to kill any unseen life forms, rather we boil water to make sure we do not get sick by drinking contaminated water.

7. It is not even possible to live “in this world” without harming other beings unintentionally, even though we may be aware that our acts may lead to the destruction of many life forms.

- Once a bhikkhu who had developed *abhinna* powers was getting ready to drink a glass of water, and with his ability to “see” finer things saw that there were numerous microscopic beings in the water glass. He tried to filter them out, but they were too small. The Buddha then explained to him that it is not possible to live without doing things that are necessary to sustain one’s life.

8. What we need to do is to be careful not to do any harm to even the smallest of the creatures with a hateful or greedy mind. It is the intention, or the state of the mind, that counts.

- There is this story about an old woman who was very careful about not breaking the five precepts. But she was extremely greedy; she was quite stingy, did not give much to charity, and kept all her money under her pillow. Because of that greed, she was born a *peta* (a hungry ghost).
- It is relatively easy to keep the five precepts. What is harder is to purify one’s mind of greedy, hateful, and ignorant thoughts. This is what needs to be accomplished in true “*anapanasati bhavana*”; see, “[What is Anapana?](#)”.
- Even though we may not be greedy or hateful in this life, we may have acquired such bad *kamma* in previous lives. This is why the Buddha said even if one lives morally in this life that does not guarantee a good rebirth unless one has attained [the Sotapanna stage](#) of Nibbana; see, “[Why a Sotapanna is Better off than any King, Emperor, or a Billionaire](#)”.
- Buddha Dhamma is all about the mind. [Purifying the mind is the key, not just to follow set rules. Just following precepts will not be enough](#)

9. Finally, **it is important to remember that hate is worse than greed. Excessive hateful actions lead to rebirth in the lowest realm, the *niraya*. Excess greed lead to rebirth mainly as *petas* (hungry ghosts).**

- Mixture of hate and greed lead to rebirth in all four lowest realms, the *apayas*. Even if one does not carry over the hateful or greedy thoughts to speech or bodily actions, they still count especially if one thinks about them most of the time.
- This is why it is important to develop good meditation habits; see, “[Bhavana \(Meditation\)](#)”. A

mind free of hate and greed becomes less agitated and peaceful; then it leads to wisdom (*panna*).

Next, “[What Reincarnates? – Concept of a Lifestream](#)“,

The Four Bases of Mental Power (Satara Iddhipada)

I used to have this post titled, “The Four Factors of Accomplishment”. I changed it because those words do not do justice to these four mental qualities. They are called satara Iddhipada in Pali or Sinhala, meaning factors that are critical to accomplishing any goal, whether mundane or transcendental.

- Iddhi means magical powers. Those yogis who could see things that are far away, hear sounds that are far away, read minds of others, etc., were supposed to have iddhi powers. They acquired those powers by harnessing the power of these four factors to **KEEP THEIR DEFILEMENTS SUPPRESSED**.
- When one works towards attaining Nibbana, one can use the same factors to **REMOVE** defilements from the mind.
- One could use the same factors to attain mundane goals, such as achieving financial independence, excelling in academics or a sport, improving health, etc.

They are chanda (liking, but close to an obsession), citta (thoughts), viriya (effort), and vimansa (analyzing). Chanda is NOT greed, it is the determination to attain a goal.

Any innovator, business person, scientist, architect, in fact anyone who is an expert at his/her occupation, knows these factors are critical, even though they may not have thought about them.

1. One needs to have an liking (more like an obsessed liking) for the project; this is called **chanda** which we can translate as liking. It is not greed, but pure in quality and grows to become a life goal.
2. When one has this “obsession”, one keeps thinking about it all the time. When one gets up at night to go to the bathroom, one thinks about it; it is the first thing that comes to mind when one wakes up. This is called **citta**; we will call it thought or contemplation.
3. Thus one makes one’s best efforts (**viriya**) to achieve the goal. This is what makes swimmers get up early morning to do laps, a scientist/innovator forgets about his/her meal, an innovator stays awake thinking about how to make improvements to his products, etc.
4. One is always on the lookout for any faults or possible improvements in current efforts. If the concepts involved do not make sense, one is always looking for a better explanation, a better path. This is reasoning/investigating (**vimansa**).

These factors are mutually supportive of each other. Because of this, once getting started (slowly), **they can lead to explosive growth**; these factors feed on each other, and the project becomes self-sustaining. This is called exponential growth. Thus it is heard to calculate the time taken to finish the project by linear extrapolation.

The same is true for someone starting on the Path. Initially, it takes time to absorb the concepts. But IF THE CONCEPTS ARE CORRECT (i.e., no contradictions), then progress is made very quickly. The principle of paticca samuppada starts working and one will be attracting resources that will help in ways one would not have even thought about; see, [“The Law of Attraction, Habits \(Gathi\), and Cravings \(Asavas\)”](#).

I know this by experience both as a scientist and now as a follower of the Path. After working for over four years, up until 2013, I had made only slow, steady progress on the Path. But I progressed enough that I kept looking for better explanations, discarding many things on the way. Since the

middle of 2013, the growth exploded. That is when, just by the law of attraction, I came across the pure Dhamma.

By the way, this is process the Buddha called bhavana (meditation). One keeps contemplating, clarifying, investigating, etc. it all the time, i.e., “Asevitaya, bhavithaya, bahuleekathaya,.....”.

One can be meditating in all four postures: sitting, standing, walking, and lying down (on a bed). Of course one can concentrate better sitting down in one of the more formal sitting postures.

Deeper Meanings when Cultivating the Noble Eightfold Path

See, “[Javana of a Citta – The Root of Mental Power](#)” for an anlysis based on Abhidhamma.

1. Chanda (ca + anda, where “ca” is mind and “anda” is “anduma” or clothes) means wrapping one’s mind with appropriate “attire”, which here means samma vaca, samma kammanta, and samma ajiva. This is what fuels the “liking” for Nibbana with increased niramisa sukha.

2. Citta here means the mindset to attain Nibbana.

3. However, even if one has liking and mindset on attaining Nibbana, one needs to make an effort or viriya.

4. Even if one is exerting effort, it needs to be directed in the right direction. Thus one needs vimansa (investigation/reasoning) to comprehend *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, and to get to samma ditthi.

5. “Iddhi” means “grow”, and “pada” means “headed direction”. Thus with iddhipada one is accelerating in the direction that one sets one’s mind. Thus all four factors of chanda, citta, viriya, vimansa need to there.

Next, “[Right Speech](#)“,

Why is it Necessary to [Learn](#) Key Pali Words?

I had not given this issue much thought until someone at an online forum pointed out that I was using some Pali words and it was difficult to understand the meaning of those terms. This is an important point that has two aspects:

- In the *Arana Vibhanga sutta*, the Buddha advised bhikkhus to explain the Dhamma by providing the MEANINGS and not to emphasize a given language. As long as one comprehends the concept, it does not matter what language is used.
- However, on the other hand, we need to have a way to transmit the key foundational words for future generations without distorting the meaning of such words. And it is difficult to find suitable words in other languages for key words like *anicca*, *anatta*, and *paticca samuppada*.
- I have explained the meaning of any Pali term I use. But for a first time reader, this could be a legitimate issue. Please use the “Search” button on the top right to locate relevant posts for any key word. There is a “[Pali Glossary](#)” too.

1. Buddha Dhamma is the most complex theory in the world; it encompasses all of nature’s laws. Even though its basic premises are not hard to grasp, if one needs to dig deeper, one needs to spend some time “learning the basics”, or the “fundamental ideas involved”.

- Think about it this way: Can one learn algebra without knowing arithmetic?
- The key is to learn the basic ideas well, words like *anicca*, *anatta*, *bhava*, etc. It is said that one could understand the Buddha’s message about existence just by comprehending *anicca* (which will lead to understanding of *dukkha* and *anatta*), and that is true.

2. There is another aspect too. If one learns the basic concepts in addition/subtraction or even quantum mechanics, it does not matter what language one uses to learn it. The key is to get the IDEA, not just learn the words. One can learn addition/subtraction or quantum mechanics in ANY language, not by memorizing words but by understanding the key concepts.

- When a child learns how to add/subtract, he/she has to learn the basic multiplication table and the procedures on how to use that knowledge in handling big numbers. After that he/she can solve any arbitrary problem involving big numbers.
- In the same way, one needs to get the IDEAS embodied in some key Pali words, because many of those Pali words CANNOT be directly translated into other languages: They are highly condensed, each word packed with deep meanings.
- In quantum mechanics, the word “quantum” embodies the subject; regardless of the language one uses, one knows what a quantum is. In the same way, one needs to know what “*anicca*” is. There is no other word for it in English.
- **Once one UNDERSTANDS the meaning of a certain key Pali word, then one may even be able to find a suitable word in any language to keep it in mind. There is no need to memorize Pali words for the sake of memorizing. It is similar to learning any concept.**
- We just should not change the original Pali words in the Tipitaka. That is the “blueprint” that need to be transmitted intact so that Buddha’s original message will be kept intact.

3. Let us first examine the reasons why Pali is a special language.

- The Buddha delivered his discourses in *Maghadhi* language; a version of that language suitable for memorization (Pali) was used to SUMMARIZE those suttas. For example, *Dhamma Cakka Pavattana Sutta* was delivered to the five ascetics overnight. How many pages would it take to write all that down? Yet, it was condensed into a few pages.
- In the old days suttas were orally transmitted generation-to-generation, and that was the other reason to condense it into a special form like a poem that is easy to remember and recite. The origin of the word “Pali” comes from that particular way of organization of the words.

4. Therefore, it may take several words in a different language to express the meaning of some Pali words like *anicca*, *anatta*, *bhava*, etc. *Paticca samuppada* is another whole phrase that is best kept intact and just learn what is meant by that phrase; see, “[Paticca Samuppada – “Pati+ichcha”+“Sama+uppāda”](#)”.

- Thus most Pali words are impossible to be translated word-by-word to other languages.
- This is the reason that many commentaries were written in the old days to explain the meaning of key words and phrases; see, “[Preservation of Dhamma](#)” for details.
- Unfortunately, most of those original commentaries (*Sinhala Attakatha*) cannot be found today, except for three; see the above post.

5. Most of the problems we have today are due to such “word by word” translation of suttas into other languages.

- The most visible and disastrous translations are the translation of the words *anicca* and *anatta* into *Sanskrit* as *anitya* and *anathma*; these words were then ADOPTED in *Sinhala* language to express the meaning of *anicca* and *dukkha*. Then within the last two hundred or so years, those *Sanskrit* words were directly translated to English and now have become established to mean “impermanence” and “no-self”.
- Incorrect translation of just those words have kept the message of the Buddha hidden for over fifteen hundred years. It is not an accident that there have not been that many Arahants during that time.
- For the correct meanings of these words, see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations](#)” and the follow-up post.

6. In fact it is said that one can even reach the *Sotapanna* stage by just comprehending the true meanings of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, the three characteristics of the world. These three words have embodied in them a very broad message. Whole suttas were delivered to describe what was meant by those words! **It is WRONG and DISASTROUS to just translate them as impermanence, suffering, and “no-self”.**

- **But if one wishes**, and knows the correct interpretations, one can dig much deeper to unimaginable depths. For example, there is a process involving 9 steps where a given citta starts off as a pure (*pabhasvara*) citta and gets “contaminated” before dying as a vinnana citta within a billionth of a second!
- Even though I will eventually dig more deeper into Buddha Dhamma at the website, there is no need to go to that depth for most people (and many will not have enough time to do that anyway; but there could be a few who would really enjoy it).

- I just want everyone to appreciate Buddha Dhamma for what it is, and to help remove many misconceptions that are out there today.

7. To summarize, I cannot emphasize enough the importance of UNDERSTANDING the meanings of key Pali words. It may take some time to truly grasp those meanings. I keep revising those key posts, whenever a better way to express an idea comes to mind or when someone else points out a better way to express it. Please do not hesitate to send comments/suggestions.

- [Experience is a key factor in understanding](#). The word “elephant” may not mean anything to someone who does not understand English. But if it is shown to him what an elephant looks like, then he can associate the word “elephant” with the big animal. In the same way, it is important to UNDERSTAND what *anicca* means, by using one’s experience: for example, we cannot maintain even our body the way we would like for the LONG TERM, etc. Then you look at others, especially who are even older than us, or those who died of old age, and realize that it is true. Then you think about anything in this world, and realize that it is true, i.e., we cannot maintain ANYTHING in this world to our satisfaction, and that is *anicca*.

8. The following is a table with some key Pali words and links to a few posts that describe what those words mean. More posts probably can be found by using the “Search” button on the top right.

Word	Links
Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta	Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations , Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – True Meanings , Why is Correct Interpretation of Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta so Important?
Bhava	Bhava and Jati – States of Existence and Births Therein ; Bhava also related to Gathi.
Gathi and Asava	Habits, Goals, and Character (Gathi) , The Law of Attraction, Habits, Character (Gathi), and Cravings (Asavas) , Sansaric Habits, Character (Gathi), and Cravings (Asava)
Nibbana	See niramisa sukha below to get the basic idea. For deeper: The Four Stages in Attaining Nibbana , Nibbana – Is it Difficult to Understand?
Niramisa sukha	Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha? , How to Taste Nibbana , Niramisa Sukha (Happiness Arising from Dissociating from the 31 realms)
Paticca Samuppada	Paticca Samuppada – “Pati+ichcha”+”Sama+uppāda” , Paticca Samuppada – Overview
San	What is “San”? Meaning of Sansara (or Samsara)
Sankhara	Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka

Buddha Dhamma and Morality

[“Origin of Morality \(and Immorality\) in Buddhism”](#)

[“What does Buddha Dhamma \(Buddhism\) say about Contraception?”](#)

Origin of Morality (and Immorality) in Buddhism

1. Morality and immorality are both built-in to nature. A human can choose to become moral or immoral. This is because a human has a mind that can grasp right from wrong; on the other hand, an animal does not have a developed mind that can sort out good deeds from the bad most of the time.
2. In Buddha Dhamma, which describes nature's laws, the foundation of the moral code is the set of ten moral actions (*dasa kusala*), which are to avoid the ten immoral actions (*dasa akusala*); see, "[Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)](#)" and the follow-up post.
3. If one does not follow this fundamental moral code, one becomes indebted to other humans and also to the nature (which means all living beings, from which we "see" only a small fraction) in general. In this life as well as in previous lives, we have become indebted to other beings.
 - Thus getting out of that debt, as well not to get into new debts, is also a part of the moral code in Buddha Dhamma; see, "[Kamma, Debt, and Meditation](#)" for more details.
 - This is in the "*vinaya pitaka*" of the *Tipitaka*; it is also described in the *suttas* in the *sutta pitaka*. The third section of the *Tipitaka*, *Abhidhamma*, describes the ten moral/immoral actions in depth.
4. Now let us see how most of our conventional moral code(s), comes from these two foundational aspects of Buddha Dhamma.
 - Of the ten immoral actions three are done with body: killing, stealing, and sexual misconduct. The basic difference with "conventional code" is that killing of animals is not considered immoral in many societies.
 - There are four immoral actions done with speech: lying, slandering, harsh speech, and frivolous talk, of which the latter is not taken seriously as immoral in most cases; but one can experience the benefits of avoiding it for oneself.
 - Those seven immoral actions and speech ARISE due to **the three kinds of immoral thoughts: greed for other's belongings, ill will or hatred, and established wrong views (*lobha, dosa, moha*)**. In a way the last one is the root cause for all other nine, because one would not violate any of them if one knew the true nature of the "wider world" (of 31 realms of existence and the rebirth process therein): that it is unfruitful to engage in any of those nine immoral actions (called "*avijja*" or ignorance).
5. Then there is the other aspects of morality that comes from abstaining from getting into new debt and paying off old debts (from the *vinaya*).
 - As one can easily see, giving (*dana*) in general is an excellent way of "paying off debt". Since we do not know who we have becomes indebted to in this long cycle of rebirths, giving can be to anyone, including animals. For animals, the best giving is of course abstain from killing; not to take their lives. Even though they cannot think like us, they do have feelings.
 - This point of "being debt free" incorporate many of our "conventional moral actions": helping out others, being considerate to others, etc.
 - A big part of this is also making sure to fulfil one's responsibilities. All our associations have, at the root, "long term debts" in play even though we do not realize it. The biggest debts are those to our families and especially to children (and parents in return).

- We constantly benefit from the actions of innumerable others living in this complex society; we depend on each other for survival. Our food, energy needs, infrastructure needs, are hard to sort out. The best way to pay off such debts is to do “one’s own part”, honestly doing one’s own job and being a “good citizen”.

6. But the most important thing is to understand the true nature of this “wider world”. When one has that understanding it will become automatic to follow the moral code. One does not have to make an effort, because one’s mind clearly sees what is right and what is wrong. There are then such meritorious actions (*punna kriya*), which cultivate the “moral code behavior” and also purifies the mind; see, “[Ten Moral Actions \(Dasa Kusala\) and Ten Meritorious Actions \(Punna Kriya\)](#)”.

- The goal of this website is to clarify how people engage in immoral actions because their inability to REALLY understand the true nature of this “wider world” (*anicca, dukkha, anatta*) and thus to help get rid of such wrong views.
- If one understood the “long term consequences” (and unfruitfulness) of acting with extreme greed and hate, then one becomes automatically moral.

7. Finally, morality is not a one street. Unfortunately, the nature has both morality and immorality built-in. Even though we think, “how one can do a highly immoral act like killing another human and have a peace of mind?”, there are some who do ENJOY such acts. People like Hitler and Pol pot, as well as serial killers, are good examples. They PLAN and carry out such vicious deeds with pleasure.

- Thus the nature, at least on the surface (because the consequences are hidden and time-delayed), is neutral on the matter of morality and immorality. One can go the moral route or the immoral route. Humans have the ability to sort out which route is the correct one. However, it is not easy for children to figure that out. This is why the guidance of the parents and teachers is CRITICAL to point a child in the right direction.

Next, “[What does Buddha Dhamma say About Birth Control?](#)“,

What does Buddha Dhamma (Buddhism) say about Birth Control?

This question has a very clear answer in Buddha Dhamma. The “birth” of a living being as a human occurs not in a womb, but at the dying moments of the previous life.

1. Our bodies are just “shells” that are discarded at death. We are born human in this life due to a past good kamma, and until that kammic energy is exhausted we will remain in the “human *bhava*” or the “human existence”. Our physical bodies last only about 100 years or so, and if the *kammic* energy for the “human *bhava*” is not exhausted at the time of the death, a “human *gandhabbaya*” will leave the body and wait until a new womb becomes available; see, “[Ghost in the Machine – Synonym for the Manomaya Kaya?](#)”

- This “human *gandhabbaya*” has a very fine body and thus cannot be seen.
- The *gandhabbaya* may have to wait for a few days or even a many years until a suitable womb becomes available; at that time, it will be pulled into the womb by the *kammic* energy, and the *gandhabbaya* takes hold of the zygote in the womb that was created by a sperm fertilizing an egg. This is what the modern science calls a “conception”, and in Buddha Dhamma it is called “*okkanthi*” of a *gandhabbaya* in a womb.
- However, if the “kammic energy for the present human *bhava*” is exhausted at the time of death, then the transition to the next “*bhava*” or existence happens at the dying moment, and if that new existence is that of a cat, a “cat *gandhabbaya*” will emerge from the dead body; of course this *gandhabbaya* has a very fine body that cannot be seen.
- Here again the “cat *gandhabbaya*” will have to wait until a suitable “cat womb” is ready, and that time it will get of the newly formed “cat zygote” in the womb of the “cat mother”. And a baby cat will be born later on.

2. Thus in either case, what happens in a womb at the time of conception is just to provide the “material basis” for the *gandhabbaya* to form a physical body. The “blueprint” for that physical body or the *gandhabbaya* was created at the dying moment; this formation of a new *gandhabbaya* is the “real birth” or “*jati*” in Buddha Dhamma.

- All this is discussed in more detail in several posts, including “[Ghost in the Machine – Synonym for the Manomaya Kaya?](#)”, “[Manomaya Kaya and Physical Body](#)”, and a more technical description in “[Cuti-Patisandhi – An Abhidhamma Description](#)”.

3. Now let us see what the procedure of contraception does. Whether it is done via either the use of a condom or by the mother taking birth control pills, the outcome is that a zygote will not be formed for a *gandhabbaya* to start a new life. Thus it is clear that there are no moral issues involved here; terminating a life is not involved at this stage.

4. On the other hand, once the *gandhabbaya* “is in the womb” and has taken possession of the zygote, then there is a living being in the womb. Any procedure done after this “real conception” is equivalent to taking a human life; it does not matter whether the procedure was done a month before birth of the baby or just a day after the *gandhabbaya* came into the womb.

- Thus any procedure done to abort the birth after the “actual conception”, i.e., *gandhabbaya* taking possession of the zygote, involves the termination of a human life.

5. Thus Buddha Dhamma provides an unambiguous picture of the moral issues involved in the birth

control process.

- Of course, there are other moral issues that could be discussed. For example, on the use of birth control procedures, there are thorny questions associated with whether it is a good idea to make those available to school children.

6. It is important to note that science does not have an answer to the question of why all zygotes do not result in pregnancies, and some couples who could not have babies for many years all of a sudden have success. The actual conception time is also controversial; http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Beginning_of_pregnancy_controversy

- The steps in the conception process can be summarized as follows: During mother's menstrual cycle, one **egg (ovum)** is usually released from one of the ovaries and is swept into the funnel-shaped end of one of the fallopian tubes. If a **sperm** penetrates the egg there, fertilization results and the **fertilized egg (zygote)** moves down the fallopian tube toward the uterus. The cells of the zygote divide repeatedly as the zygote moves down the fallopian tube. The zygote enters the uterus in 3 to 5 days. In the uterus, the cells continue to divide, becoming a hollow ball of cells called a **blastocyst**. Inside the uterus, the blastocyst implants in the wall of the uterus, where it develops into an **embryo** attached to a placenta and surrounded by fluid-filled membranes; see, http://www.merckmanuals.com/home/womens_health_issues/normal_pregnancy/stages_of
- Thus conception happens during the time the life-less zygote transforms to the "live" blastocyst. It is during this time that a *gandhabbaya* enters the zygote. However, a *gandhabbaya* with "*gathi*" matching that of the mother (and father) must be "pulled in" by the kammic energy, for the conception to occur (do a search for "*gathi*" on the top right search box to find about "*gathi*").
- What matters most is the "*gathi*" of the mother at the time a *gandhabbaya* moves in to the womb. This is why in some cases, a child may have very different character ("*gathi*") compared to the parents; furthermore, this is also why mothers who could not get pregnant for years, get pregnant during a time period when the mother most likely had a "personality shift" or a significant change in her mental state.
- Furthermore, if the mother (and father) are prevented from having a child due to a previous kamma vipaka, the resulting zygote will be a "dud" and thus no *gandhabbaya* can "descend to the womb", i.e., pregnancy is not possible.

A deeper analysis of how the next existence is grasped at death is given in, ["Cutī-Patisandhi – An Abhidhamma Description"](#)

Working Towards Good Rebirths

[“Sansaric Habits and asavas”](#)

[“Vagaries of Life and the Way to Seek Good Rebirths”](#)

[“How to Avoid Birth in the Apayas”](#)

[“How the Buddha Described the Chance of Rebirth in the Human Realm”](#)

[“Kamma, Debt, and Meditation”](#)

[“Kilesa \(Defilements\) , Ditthi \(Wrong Views\), Samma Ditthi \(Good/Correct Views\)”](#)

[“How do we Decide which View is Wrong View \(Ditthi\)?”](#)

[“Three Kinds of Ditthi, Eightfold Paths, and Samadhi”](#)

[“Implications of the Rebirth Process in Daily Life and in Society”](#)

[“What Does Buddha Dhamma Say about Creator, Satan, Angels, and Demons?”](#)

[“Patisandhi Citta – How the Next Life is Determined According to Gathi”](#)

Sansaric Habits, Character (Gathi), and Cravings (Asava)

In the “Moral Living” section, we discussed how to get rid of bad habits, incorporate good habits, and thus achieve goals; see, “[Habits, Goals, and Character \(Gathi\)](#)”. We saw that one’s behavioral patterns or habits can form one’s character (gathi). Here we will see that some of these habits are not formed in this life, but may have origins in previous lives. In a way, these are only “discernible things” we carry from life-to-life; see, “[What Reincarnates? – Concept of a Lifestream](#)”.

1. **Habits (“gathi” in Pali and Sinhala)** are acquired by the repeated use. Habits can be neutral (one can make a habit of start brushing teeth on the top left), good (exercising at a scheduled time), bad (smoking).

- The more one can stick to a set habit, that habit becomes more ingrained in the mind. Riding a bike or learning to drive is a habit to learn. Initially it is hard, but once the habit is formed it is done almost automatically; it becomes an ingrained “gathi”.

2. Bad habits can be stopped by making a conscious effort to disrupt the habit. Initially this takes a lot of effort, and that is why assessing the consequences and convincing the mind of the dangers of a bad habit is important at the very beginning.

- Replacing a bad habit with a good (at least less harmful) habit is also important. Instead of smoking, one could chew on a chewing gum when one gets the urge.

3. Habits also help mold the character (gathi) of a person. We see very different qualities of character among people: kind and malicious, calm and agitated, thoughtful and easily-excitable, etc. It is easy to see that people with “bad character qualities” are those with one or more prominent bad habits.

- But the good news is that no one is “inherently bad”. There are causes (reasons) for a person to have bad habits/character, and once those causes are removed one becomes a person with good habits/character.
- The best example is Angulimala, who lived during the time of the Buddha and killed close to thousand people. The Buddha was able to show him the consequences of his behavior and he was able to attain the Arahantship within a few weeks!

5. It is not only humans that display such personal characteristics; animals have them too. Some dogs are vicious while others are adorable; some are more loyal than others, etc.

- These are habits/character (gathi) that have been molded over multiple lives; but most character (gathi) CHANGES happen only during a human life, because human mind is the most capable of CHANGING habits. Animals, for example, are more like robots (not completely).

6. Bad habits are formed via bad judgements arising from a defiled mind that is covered by the five hindrances. And bad habits lead to actions that further strengthen those same habits.

- Once a certain bad “gathi” becomes established it can even lead to a birth with that “gathi”, i.e., will be destined for “dugathi” (du + gathi) which is another name for the apayas (the four lowest realms). for example, someone who behaves and acts like an animal could well be reborn an animal.
- The cycle needs to be broken to stop this self-feeding process. But as long as the hindrances are there, it is likely that sooner or later new bad habits will be formed.

7. Those beings that are in the apayas can be put in to four major categories according to the proportions of greed and hate that are in their sansaric “gathi” (of course ignorance is in all of them) :

- Pretas [Sanskrit], Petas [Pali], i.e., hungry ghosts have “greedy” gathi.
- Those in the lowest realm, niraya (hell), have gathi dominated by hate.
- Animals have “gathi” with both greed and hate. Therefore, the Pali (or Sinhala) word for animals is “thirisan” (=“thiri”+“san” or three defilements). Remember that ignorance is there always.
- Those in the asura (“a”+“sūra”, where “a” means “not” and “sūra” means proficient or capable; thus asura means those who depend on others, and are lazy) realm have the habit of doing as least as possible and exploit others’ hard work.

8. Similarly, one who cultivates good habits is destined for a “good” rebirth (sugathi = su + gathi), i.e., human realm or above. For example, one who does not indulge in sense pleasures and cultivates compassion and loving kindness could be reborn in the Brahma realms where there is relatively less suffering, and mostly jhanic pleasures.

- Devas (realms 6-11) are full of compassion and do not have hateful thoughts. But they like to enjoy sense pleasures.
- Brahmas (realms 12-31) do not have either greed or hate.
- Humans (realms 5) COULD have all three. However, the unique aspect of the human realm is the ability to purify one’s own mind and REMOVE all three, and become an Arahant (attain Nibbana). This is done by following the Noble Eightfold Path and removing all “bad habits” one has.

Of course, Devas and Brahmas both have ignorance, and thus could be reborn in any realm when they die (unless they had attained [the Sotapanna stage](#)).

9. Once ingrained in the mind, habits can be carried over repeated rebirths, from life to life. One who is easily tempted by alcohol is likely to have had that habit in the previous lives. One who forms that habit in this life (even if he did not have it before), is likely to carry it over to the next life. Similarly, one who cultivates generosity in this life is likely to have that habit in the next life as well.

10. If those bad habits keep building up life after life, they get fermented and solidified and thus will become deeply embedded in one’s psyche. We all carry deeply ingrained sansaric habits associated with one or more of defilements. **These are called mental fermentations or deeply embedded cravings (“Asava” in Pali or Sinhala).**

- When one has an “asava” or craving of some kind, it comes up very easily; this is called “anusaya”. With the slightest “trigger” an ingrained asava for alcohol will induce thoughts (anusaya) in someone to have a drink of a sight of a bar.
- **So, it is a vicious circle: Asava (craving) induce anusaya (temptation), and when one acts on it one’s gathi (character) on that are strengthened, thus making the asava even stronger.**

11. Thus it is clear why breaking bad habits is critically important, not only for the benefit of this life, but also for future lives.

Next, “[Vagaries of Life and the Way to Seek “Good Rebirths”](#)“,

If you would like to read about how these asavas can be removed, see, “[The Way to Nibbana – Removal of Asavas](#)“.

Vagaries of Life and the Way to Seek “Good Rebirths”

1. Everything that we see around us can be roughly put into three categories: lifeless matter, plant life, and sentient beings (i.e., life with consciousness). Scientists have been mostly successful in explaining the behavior of inanimate matter, at least in the macroscopic scale. For example, a rocket can be launched with high precision to land on a given spot on the Moon. Complexity increases somewhat when going to biological matter without consciousness (plants).
2. However, the behavior of a sentient being is almost impossible to predict with any kind of precision. This is because the working of a mind with 89 types of cittas (thoughts) and 52 types of cetasikas (mental properties) is very complex; see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)” and the posts in the “Abhidhamma” section.
3. When we look around, we see that animals, in general, encounter more suffering than humans. Even among people, the range of suffering is enormous, and some people even seem to be enjoying life without any apparent signs of suffering.
 - Also, some are born rich, healthy, beautiful, etc. others are born to poverty, handicapped, ugly, etc.
 - The character of people also lies in a very broad spectrum, as we discussed above.
 - Furthermore, the “fortunes” of a given person could change drastically in a relatively short time. One could go from being penniless to a rich person or the other way around quickly.
 - When we look at animals too, some pets get treated even better than some humans, while others live under horrible conditions. They also have a wide range of personal characteristics.
4. Such apparent vagaries of life have perfectly good explanations in Buddha Dhamma. However, there are no simple one-to-one correspondences compared to the comparatively simpler rules that are available for tracking the behavior of macroscopic inert objects.
5. The behavior of (macroscopic) inert matter can be explained in terms of simpler cause and effect. If one knows the current conditions, one can predict the future outcome using scientifically-found natural laws (law of gravitation or laws of relativity). However, even this is beginning to change with the advent of quantum mechanics; we are now beginning to probe the realm where matter merges with the mind. We will discuss such instance in the future.
6. Similarly, the behavior of life can be explained in terms of kamma vipaka (results of one’s actions) together with habits (“gathi”) and asavas; see, “[Samsaric Habits and Asavas](#)“. However, unlike cause and effect regarding inanimate matter, the behavior of life is much more complex, because the MIND IS COMPLEX, see “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”. There are many causes (innumerable kamma vipaka and numerous types of habits and asavas) leading to many effects, versus just one or few causes leading one effect or a few effects.
7. In general, good habits and good kamma vipaka lead rebirth in realms at or above the human realm. We need to make sure not to commit any *akusala* (unwholesome) kamma that could lead to rebirth in the four lower realms, and to engage in meritorious actions. Another is to realize that asavas (mental fermentations or deeply embedded cravings) could lead to spontaneous actions (in a rage or a sudden mental weakness). Maintaining good habits, removing bad habits, and acting with generosity, kindness, and wisdom help cleanup the deeply embedded asavas, thus preventing such actions on sudden impulses as well as being able to be mindful.

8. Any type of meditation (samatha, metta, and vipassana) will also be quite helpful. Just contemplating on good thoughts and suppressing bad thoughts as they arise throughout the day is also meditation (this was the original definition of bhavana).

Next, “[How to Avoid Births in the Apayas](#)“,

How to Avoid Birth in the Apayas

1. There are five heinous kamma (acts) that GUARANTEE a rebirth in the lowest four realms in the *very next birth*. These are called the panca anantariya kamma or five acts that will bring a bad birth without “a gap” (unlike many kamma vipaka can come to fruition in later lives, i.e., their results are seen only later in sansara). These five are:

- Killing one’s mother
- Killing one’s father
- Killing an Arahant
- Causing an injury to a Buddha
- Causing schism in the Sangha (the monastic order)

2. The next level is “[niyatha micca ditthi](#)” or “an established wrong world view” (which means one is not even willing to consider the possibility that one could be wrong in holding onto such views) that will cause one to be born in the apayas at some point in sansara. This means that one with these false views could be reborn in the apayas in the next life or any future life. There are eight such views:

- No such thing as, (1) mother, (2) father, (3) Buddha, (4) rebirth, (5) kamma vipaka, (6) opapatika birth (instant full-formed birth), (7) apayas, and (8) rupa loka/arupa loka. For explanations on (6)-(8), see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)“.

It must be noted that Even a Sotapanna may not be fully convinced of the truth of some of the above. But a Sotapanna has not ruled out any of the above and is not adamant on holding onto a wrong view.

3. Thus the possibility of a birth in the apayas in any future birth is there until all **established (unshakable) wrong views (niyata micca ditthi)** are rejected by one’s mind. We all have committed both good and bad kamma in the past lives that we are not aware of; thus any of those could cause a birth anywhere in the 31 realms.

4. It is important to remember that those false views cannot be just memorized and pretended to be discarded. The mind needs to be convinced that those are indeed false views. This is why it is important to examine the world view of the Buddha. These are the key concepts discussed in the top menus, especially, “[What is Buddha Dhamma?](#)” and “[Key Dhamma Concepts](#)“.

5. The only guaranteed way to stay out of the apayas (the four lowest realms) in ANY future life is to become a Sotapanna.

What Happens at the Sotapanna Stage?

1. As I keep repeating, the Buddha is just the messenger; he discovered the true nature of this world. First of all, this world is much more complex than we perceive. In order to understand how to remove suffering, one has to understand the causes, and that requires the complete picture of “this world” (see, “[What is Buddha Dhamma?](#)” and in particular, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)“) and also why it is not possible to remove suffering without understanding the Three Characteristics of “this world” (see, “[Key Dhamma Concepts](#)” and in particular, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta](#)“).

2. When one “sees” the true nature of “this world”, the mind will automatically give up those false views mentioned in the above section (#2). **This is why it is first important to learn Dhamma first.**

No one, regardless of one's high intellect, can discover the complete set of nature's laws other than a Buddha.

3. From the discussion so far, it is clear what needs to be done to reach the Sotapanna stage. All that is needed is to carefully examine the world view of the Buddha as mentioned in #1 in this section. One needs to understand the "vision", and to become "dassanena sampanno" or "one with clear vision". This is why "dassanena pahatabba" or "removal by vision" is listed as #1 item in the seven items required to attain Nibbana in the Sabbasava Sutta; see, "Key Points in the Sabbasava Sutta" in "[The Sotapanna Stage](#)".

4. Thus essentially all that happens at reaching the Sotapanna stage is to get a clear world view. Now one has understood the true nature of this world, and thus "knows" that it is not possible to achieve lasting happiness anywhere in the 31 realms. One may not have removed any asavas other than the ditthi asava. Thus one still may have kamasava, bhavasava, and avijjasava, i.e., one still may have greed, hatred, and ignorance even though parts of all three have been permanently been removed by the clear vision. How the asavas are formed starting with habits is discussed in the "[Habits and Goals](#)", "[Sansaric Habits and Asavas](#)", and "[The Way to Nibbana – Removal of Asavas](#)" sections in that order.

5. Therefore, even though one may have greed, hate, and ignorance left, one knows what they are. And one knows how to remove them. After attaining the Sotapanna stage one does not need a teacher. One knows what needs to be done. As one gets rid of the remaining asavas, the vision becomes even more clear and full and complete Samma Ditthi is attained at the Arahant hood.

Next, "[How the Buddha Described the Chance of Rebirth in the Human Realm](#)",

How the Buddha Described the Chance of Rebirth in the Human Realm

Many people believe that if we live a “good, moral life”, a rebirth in the human or even higher *deva* worlds is guaranteed. This is a misconception because even if we do not accumulate any bad *kamma* in this life, we do not know what kinds of bad *kamma* we have accumulated in past lives and we have. **This is why it is very hard to even get a human rebirth let alone a *deva* or a *brahma* rebirth.**

- Evidence for rebirth is presented in, “[Evidence for Rebirth](#)“. Rebirth can occur not only in as a human, but in any of the 31 realms. Most suffering in the cycle of rebirth occurs in the lowest four realms: *niraya* (hell), *asura*, animal, and *peta* realms. Of those four, only the animal realm is visible to us. They are collectively called the *apayas*.
- The 31 realms of existence are described in “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)“.

1. From the Nakhasikha Sutta:

Reference: “[Nakhasikha Sutta](#)”

“Bhikkhus, those who depart from the human realm, those will be reborn as humans or devas can be compared to the few grains of sand that I pickup on my fingernail. Those who are reborn in the lower four realms are exceedingly many, compared to the sand on this great Earth”.

“From those who have expired their *kamma* in the lower four world, and are reborn in the human or deva worlds can be compared to the few grains of sand that I pickup on my fingernail. Those who are repeatedly reborn in the lower four realms are exceedingly many, compared to the sand on this great Earth” (This is because one can accrue only bad *kamma* while they are in the lower four world).

Let us make two points clear regarding the above simile of the Buddha:

1. When a being gets a human life, that “human *bhava*” has a certain kammic energy associated with it, say 1000 years worth. In that case, the person may be born 10 times consecutively with 100 years in each birth (this is the difference between “*bhava*” and “*jati*”). The *cuti-patisandhi* transition to a new “*bhava*” happens at the end of 1000 years; see, “[Bhava and Jati – States of Existence and Births Therein](#)“, and “[Cuti-Patisandhi – An Abhidhamma Description](#)“.

- What the Buddha refers to above is concerned with that new *patisandhi* at the end of the “human *bhava*“.

2. Even though the above simile seems to be out-of-proportion with the realities, it is not. This is why I am saying that modern science has given a boost to Buddha Dhamma, by making many things clear. Ordinary humans were not aware of the existence of innumerable microscopic living beings until the microscope was invented in the 1500’s. In 1676, Van Leeuwenhoek reported the discovery of micro-organisms: He observed numerous beings in a glass of water; see, <http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Microscope>

- If you go out and dig a bit of dirt, there could be millions of living organisms there. In a household there may be a few humans, but possibly billions or even trillions of living beings. The oceans cover two-thirds of the Earths surface, and the living beings there are much more densely-packed. And there are beings in other 29 realms that we cannot see. Seven billion or so humans in this world are indeed a thumbful compared to innumerable beings that live associated with the Earth. Thus, as in many cases, modern science has helped verify Buddha’s words.

- Some of these realms could be in other dimensions; see, “[Consciousness Dependence on Number of Dimensions](#)“. In the string theory, scientists say there could be 10 dimensions instead of the three that we experience.
- However, one can actually “see” beings in other dimensions as well as microscopic beings in a glass of water if one develops abhinna powers; see, “[Power of the Human Mind – Introduction](#)” and the follow up posts. One time, a *bhikkhu* who had developed *abhinna* powers but had not become an *Arahant*, saw the presence of a large number of microscopic beings in a glass of water. He tried to filter them out but was unsuccessful, and became distraught. The Buddha told him that “it is not possible to live in this world without harming other beings. It is necessary to live this life to attain *Nibbana*“, and to drink the water. The INTENTION there is to quench the thirst; see, “[How to Evaluate Weights of Different Kamma](#)“.
- With more sophisticated instruments, science is finding out that there are millions of living beings on a single human body (as well as on any other large animal); see, “[There are as Many Creatures on your Body as there are People on Earth!](#)“.

Thus modern science has indeed shown that the human population is negligible compared to just the animal populations (including microscopic beings). And we can experience only 2 realms (animal and human) compared to the 31 realms that the Buddha described.

2. Kanakacchapa Sutta

Reference: “[Kanakacchapa Sutta](#)“

“Bhikkhus, there is a blind turtle in the depths of the ocean. There is also a yoke of a cart that is floating on the ocean surface which is carried in away in all directions by tide, current, and wind. Thus these two go on throughout an incalculable space of time. One day when the turtle comes up to the surface, the yoke arrives at the same precise place and time when the turtle puts up his head, and yokes on to it. Now, *Bhikkhus*, is it possible that such a time might come as is said?”

“In ordinary truth, O Lord,” replied the *Bhikkhus*, “it is impossible; but time being so spacious [my comment: see, “[Sansaric Time Scale](#)“], and an aeon lasting so long, it may be admitted that perhaps at some time or other it might be possible for the two to yoke together, as said; if the blind tortoise lives long enough, and the yoke does not tend to rot and break up before such a coincidence comes to pass”

Then the Buddha said, “*Bhikkhus*, the occurrence of such a strange thing is not to be counted a difficult one; for there is still a greater, a harder, a hundred times, a thousand times more difficult than this lying hidden from your knowledge. And what is this? It is, *Bhikkhus*, the obtaining of the opportunity of becoming a man again by a man who has expired and is reborn once in any of the four realms of misery. The occurrence of the yoking of the blind tortoise is not worth thinking of as a difficult occurrence in comparison therewith. Because those who perform good deeds and abstain from doing bad alone can obtain the existence of men and Devas. The beings in the four miserable worlds cannot discern what is virtuous and what vicious, what good and what bad, what moral and what immoral, what meritorious and what de-meritorious, and consequently they live a life of immorality and demerit, tormenting one another with all their power. Those creatures of the *Niraya* and *Peta* abode in particular, live a very miserable life on account of punishments and torments, which they experience with sorrow, pain and distress. Therefore, *Bhikkhus*, the opportunity of being reborn in the abode of men is a hundred times, a thousand times harder to obtain than the encountering of the blind turtle with the yoke.”

- Many of these “hard to fathom” ideas about infinity are now being discussed by scientists who are unaware of the Buddha’s teachings. See, for example, “The Beginning of Infinity” by David

Deutsch (2011).

- Most human beings head to the apayas because they are not even aware of the ten immoral actions; see, “[Ten Immoral Actions – Dasa Akusala](#)“, and “[How to Evaluate Weights of Different Kamma](#)“. It is also important to know the baseline procedure to avoid such immoral actions and to cultivate moral behavior; see, “[Ten Moral Actions – Dasa Kusala](#)“.

Next, “[Kamma, Debt, and Meditation](#)“,

Kamma, Debt, and Meditation

“This world” of 31 realms is very complex; see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)“. Nothing happens due to a single cause and nothing happens just by itself: Multiple causes lead to multiple effects.

In a perfect world, everyone will share everything equally, and everyone will be happy. But people are born with different levels of not only wealth, but also different levels of health, physical appearance, capabilities, etc. These are the results of *kamma* (good and bad) accrued over very long periods in the past.

No one has everything “just right”. So, we try to get what we don’t have or like to have. **Every time we crave for something, knowingly or unknowingly we get into debt.** When the *kamma* involves another living being, we get into some kind of a “*sansaric* relationship” with that being; this is how we have friends, family, AND enemies. These things do not happen by chance.

NOTHING in this world happens by chance; everything happens due to a cause, a reason; **but since results (vipaka) can materialize later, even in future lives, we cannot see this “cause and effect” in most cases.** **When we do something harmful to another being we become indebted to that being; that debt will have to be paid with interest that is many many times over.** Think about the following:

- When we get a loan, we have to pay back the loan with interest. If we promise to pay back and do not fulfill that commitment, we will have to pay it with interest sometime in the future. Imagine how much interest we would have to pay on a \$1000 loan at 6% interest over, say just 200 years, which is insignificant in the [sansaric time scale](#). You can use the “72 rule” that says if you do not make any monthly payments, the amount you have to pay will double every (72/interest rate) years, i.e., every 12 years in this case. It will double again in another 12 years, i.e., after 24 years you will have to pay \$4000. After only 40 years, the amount will be \$10,000. Only after 200 years it will be a billion dollars!
- Can you imagine how much money we may have to pay to settle even small amounts that we neglected to pay a long, long time ago?
- We have to pay back not only monetary transactions. Imagine how much would it cost to bring up a child, as a mother does? It is unimaginable over long times.
- When we have such debts, the nature has set up many ways to pay off such debts. Many times same group of people are born to same families, paying back “old debts”. Or one may become a servant for another.
- Many relationships that we have in this life arise from “long-term debt” from many lives in the past. For example, people are born in the same family, same community, or same geographical locations, for many, many lives just paying back debts and claiming old debts. In Sinhala, relationships are called “*sanbandha*” (=“*san*” + “*bandha*” where “*san*” is defilement (*sankhara*), and “*bandha*” is connection; thus connection due to *sankhara*). Sometimes old debtors come back even in the form of annoying mosquitoes, ants, bugs, etc.
- Now if one takes another’s life, one may have to sacrifice one’s own life many times over. This is scary stuff, but we need to know that our actions will have consequences.

Instead of paying off such “old debts” that way, there is another way to pay back old debts. When one does a good deed, one could transfer merits of that good deed to old debtors called “*pattidana*” (this

is commonly called “*punna anumodana*”; see, “[Transfer of Merits \(Pattidana\)- How Does It Happen?](#)”). In this beginning-less *sansara*, we have been indebted to unbelievably many beings. Thus we just transfer the merits to all beings. We just think in our mind, “May the merits of this good deed be shared by all beings”. If one does this genuinely, it will be quite beneficial in the long term. The Buddha said that this is the most efficient way to pay back old debts. However, one needs to do this with sincerity, truly understanding the suffering caused by one’s actions to others.

One could accrue good merits not only by good deeds, but also with insight meditation. **The Buddha stated that if one cultivates vipassana meditation on *anicca, dukkha, anatta*, that leads much more merits compared to even donations or giving. After the meditation session, one simply transfers the merits to all beings.** The nice thing is that one does not “lose any merits” either. Giving merits itself is meritorious. Also, one should forgive old debts from other beings. The mind is very powerful. If done with right intention, also these thoughts will have beneficial consequences for oneself and other beings.

Even though we must try to alleviate the *kamma vipaka* from past *kamma* by using the above mentioned methods, **the main purpose of such methods is actually to purify one’s mind.** We can pay off past debts this way, but bigger chunks are paid off by attaining *Sotapanna*, *Sakadagami*, *Anagami*, and *Arahant* stages of *Nibbana* (Actually, the Buddha has said that if one does the [Ariya metta meditation](#) frequently, one could pay off the debts associated with the *kamaloka* (first 11 realms); more on that in a future post). When one attains [the Sotapanna stage](#), all those *kamma vipaka* that could have given rebirth in the lowest four realms (*apayas*) become nullified. When one attains the *Arahanthood*, only those *kamma vipaka* that get a chance to come to fruition during the remaining time in that life will be paid off. Since there is no more rebirth, all remaining *kamma vipaka* just do not get a chance to come to fruition.

An important thing is to avoid all *dasa akusala*; see, “[Ten Immoral Action \(Dasa Akusala\)](#)“. One does need to try to do all at once (especially for those who are new to Buddha Dhamma). It is a life journey, and one can start slowly, just doing things that can be done without much stress. There is no one watching, and no one else that will benefit from it but oneself. **The Buddha said one can become indebted in four ways:**

- **Engaging in *dasa akusala*.**
- **Getting someone else to do such acts.**
- **Helping another in carrying out such acts.**
- **Praising someone who is doing such acts.**

Thus one can become indebted in 40 ways. Avoiding all that will make one light in heart (*adhimokko* or sense of well being). This will give impetus to accelerate one’s efforts. Also, see, “[Habits and Goals](#)“, and “[The Four Bases of Mental Power \(Satara Iddhipada\)](#)“.

Another deeper analysis can be found at, “[Difference Between Giving up Valuables and Losing Interest in Worthless](#) “,

Kilesa (Defilements) , Ditthi (Wrong Views), Samma Ditthi (Good/Correct Views)

Kilesa in Pali or **Keles in Sinhala** (where “kelesana” means “make something impure”) are related to asava (in both Pali and Sinhala) and are the main reasons why we do things (sankhara) to perpetuate the sansaric journey; the closest English word for kilesa is probably defilements. There are several posts on sankhara, sansara, and how asava are accumulated due to bad habits.

1. Kilesa are of different types:

- Moha (delusion), greed (lobha), dosa (ill will) are of course the root causes of all defilements.
- **The others arise because of the main three, and are called upakilesas: ditthi (wrong views), vicikicca (distorted likes), mana (conceit), uddhacca (restlessness), thina (sloth or indifference), ahirika (shameless of wrong doings), and anottappa (fearlessness of wrong doings).**
- I am not sure why out of the 14 immoral mental factors (*akusala cetasika*), these ten are in a separate category as kilesa. The other other four *akusala cetasika* are middha (torpor or low energy), macchhariya (tendency to hide one’s possessions), kukkuccha (tendency to have lowly thoughts), and issa (envy or jealousy).

2. Ditthi means dogmatic belief in something(s) in the sense of “this alone is true and everything else is false”. **Even though micca ditthi (wrong views) is actually the correct term (“ditthi” means views)**, in Pali literature “ditthi” is used frequently instead of “micca ditthi”. In the Buddha’s time it is said that there were 62 such dogmatic views that were the topics of frequent discussions; they are listed in the Brahmajala Sutta. The ditthasava (asava for the 62 wrong views) is eliminated by ditthivissuddhi, i.e., cleansing of the wrong views.

3. Some of these dogmatic views that the Buddha had to frequently deal with were: there is a self, there is no self, reincarnation, no reincarnation, things exist, things do not exist, there are no laws of kamma, there are laws of kamma AND they are deterministic. The Buddha refuted those all. Unfortunately, some of those wrong views are back in most versions of “Buddhism” today. We have discussed some (the first four items were discussed in several posts, for example, “[What Reincarnates? – Concept of a Lifestream](#)“, and “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta](#)“), and we will discuss others in detail in the future.

4. Ditthi (or micca ditthi) is also one of the ten immoral actions (ditthi is done by the mind and also leads to immoral speech and deeds; see below), and has already been discussed in, “[Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)](#)“. You can see that such thoughts arise due to dogmatic beliefs, i.e., when one is not willing to even consider the possibility that one could be wrong and to critically examine the evidence. For example, some people refuse to even examine the existing evidence for rebirth with an open mind and that is ditthi. And one needs to know the “big picture of the 31 realms”, concept of kamma, *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, etc, to make a decision on rebirth; it is not enough to just to look at the accounts or evidence for rebirth as presented in, “[Evidence for Rebirth](#)“.

5. There are three layers in which micca ditthi is established and accumulates bad kamma:

- When one kills one’s parents with the ditthi that a parent is not a special being, and that such kamma do not have consequences; this is the coarse level. It can be compared to a fire that burns down a house.

- The second level comes to display when one vehemently defends such a wrong view in a debate, and do not even consider the facts presented by the other side. It is possible that one may genuinely believe in that position, BUT that is because one has not been exposed to the whole picture on existence. The problem is that “not knowing the facts” does not help at the end. One could jump off of a building not knowing how gravity operates, but will be subjected to the same outcome. This middle level can be compared to a fire that ignites when the match stick is struck on a hard surface.
- The third level is the anusaya level, where these views lay dormant as asavas (ditthi asava). This finer level is likened to a box of matches that has the potential to start a fire.

This is why the Sotapanna stage is attained just by understanding the true nature of “this world” of 31 realms. One needs to understand the full picture to see how it all ties up together.

6. Someone is said to have **micca ditthi** when one has wrong views at any of the three levels in #5 above. [On the other hand, Samma Ditthi, can be two kinds:](#)

- One knows that bad kamma have bad consequences and can lead to bad rebirths. One wants to live a moral life and strive for a “good rebirth”. This is “**mundane or conventional Samma Ditthi**“. Thus these are still defiled views (have “kilesa” in them) since they lead to extending sansara, and one has not yet eliminated the possibility of a future rebirth in the apayas (four lower realms).
- But when one comprehends to “true nature of this world”, one realizes that there can be no lasting happiness anywhere in the 31 realms of existence. This Samma ditthi is gleaned when one truly comprehends *anicca*; see, “[Why is Correct Interpretation of Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta” is so Important?](#)“. This is the “**transcendental or lokottara Samma Ditthi**” that leads to Nibbana; it is free of defilements or “kilesa” or “keles”. This view becomes complete at the Arahant Stage.

7. Thus **conventional Samma Ditthi** means the view to “do good things”; one understand kamma and knows the consequences of bad deeds. As we discussed in “[Foundation of Dhamma](#)“, “doing good things” is better but most of those things are done with the wrong intention of achieving something in return (good rebirth, winning a lottery, pass an examination, etc.). This kind of Samma Ditthi will perpetuate the sansaric journey, even though in the good direction.

- The danger is of course that we do not know what one will do in a future life (say another human birth): one could be born under circumstances where one is not exposed to Buddha Dhamma, may associate with bad people, and may commit kamma that will lead to rebirth in the apayas (lowest four realms). The other danger is that we do not know what kind of kamma we have done in previous lives, and we may already have some bad kamma seeds that could lead to a birth in the apayas.

8. Thus, by Samma Ditthi is meant the true understanding of the nature of “this world” of 31 realms and the round of rebirths: for example, that “there is a self” and “there is no-self” are both incorrect and things (both animate and inanimate) exist if the conditions for their existence are present (paticca samuppada). Even though one partially comprehends Samma Ditthi at the Sotapanna stage, the understanding becomes complete only at the Arahant stage. A Sotapanna may still do some apunnabhi sankhara, but only those that are not severe enough to make one destined to the apayas (the four lowest realms).

9. If one cultivates the “lokottara” Samma Ditthi and becomes a Sotapanna, then one will be free from rebirths in the apayas. In a Sotapanna, the four “[ditthi sahagatha lobha citta](#)” (the four greed-based immoral thoughts that arise due to wrong views) do not arise; see, “[Akusala Citta – How a Sotapanna Avoids Apayagami Citta](#)”.

Next, “[How do we Decide which View is Ditthi \(Wrong View\)?](#)“,

How do we Decide which View is Wrong View (Ditthi)?

A simpler, yet a fundamental, analysis on wrong views can be found at, [“Wrong Views \(Micca Ditthi\) – A Simpler Analysis”](#).

1. We all have our views about different things: politics, religions, sports, lifestyles, etc. And most times it is fun to talk about and debate whose views are the correct ones. But each one of us have views based on a limited knowledge about only a fraction of “this world”.

- A good way to figure out whether one view is better than another is to see whether that view provides more insight AND has more explanatory power about the world.
- In fact, that is the only way. Because anybody can just say, “my view is better than yours”.

2. When I refer to “*ditthi*” or wrong views, these are the wrong views per Buddha. **It must be noted that “*ditthi*” means views, but in Pali literature it has been common to call “*micca ditthi*” (pronounced “*michcha*”) or wrong views as just “*ditthi*”.** [It is critical to have the “right views” because otherwise we may be taking wrong decisions, and that could have very bad outcomes for billions of years to come.](#) In order to make right decisions we need to “see the whole picture” or the world view of the Buddha.

- Of course, one is entitled to have his own views. It is just that according to Buddha Dhamma certain views are not only wrong, **but could lead to disastrous outcomes**, and those are called *ditthi*. One either accepts this fact, or rejects it. It is a good idea to look at the “big picture” of the Buddha and THEN decide whether it makes sense or not. First let us see why one should even go through this exercise of looking at the big picture.

3. When one does not have a clear overall picture, one makes bad decisions. For example, a fish does not see the string or the hook, only sees the worm, and gets into trouble. If it saw the whole picture, with the string and the hook, it may realize that there is something wrong and would not try to grab the worm. If it saw the man standing on land holding the pole, that would have been another clue; but the fish can only see its “domain”. Just like that we can only see “our domain” within the wider 31 realms, and we do not see the level of suffering in other lower realms.

- We are inherently incapable of seeing the “whole picture” because our sense faculties are formed by our *kamma* to be aware of only a part of whole existence; you may get an idea of what I am referring to in the post, [“What Happens in Other Dimensions?”](#). Therefore, no matter how smart each of us is, we cannot even imagine this whole picture by ourselves. It takes a very special, very pure mind to see the whole picture, the mind of a Buddha; see, [“The Power of the Human Mind – Introduction”](#), and follow-up posts.

4. The Buddha described this in the parable of the “elephant and the six blind men”. Each blind man is feeling or exploring a different part of the elephant, and comes up with his view of what an elephant is: The one examines the tail says the elephant is like a rope, one examining a leg says the elephant is like a pillar, etc. Here is a funny youtube video that explains the parable:

[The person holding the tail is certain that the elephant is like a rope “because I know what I experience; you cannot tell me it is not like a rope”. He just does not realize that he is experiencing only part of the whole elephant.](#)

5. Until a Buddha comes to this world, any human can only see a very small part of the whole

picture. Like the little girl in the video being able to see the whole elephant, only a Buddha can see the whole picture about our true existence.

- Mathematician Kurt Gödel proved this mathematically in his Incompleteness Theorem, which says that it is not possible to discover complete truth of a closed system within that system; see, "[Gödel's Incompleteness Theorem](#)". Thus science will NEVER be able to discover a COMPLETE set of laws about the nature. It can only uncover parts and the parts that have been discovered are totally consistent with Buddha Dhamma.

6. According to the Buddha, *ditthis* are like that: some people say there is a rebirth process, and some say not. Some say when we die we will either go to hell or heaven. Some say, things really exist in a permanent way, and others say it is all a mirage. [All these are ditthis, because none of these fit the WHOLE PICTURE.](#) None of these can explain the vagaries of life; see, "[Vagaries of Life and the Way to Seek "Good Rebirths"](#)".

- For example, we can only see two of the 31 realms of existence: animal and human realms. We are not aware that most beings are trapped in the lowest four realms where there is much more suffering than we can see in the human and animal realms. We do not realize that our immoral actions from this life, AND from our past lives (that we are not aware of) could give us rebirth in those lower four realms; **this is "law of kamma" another part of the "big picture"**. There is evidence for rebirth; see, "[Evidence for Rebirth](#)".

7. Buddha Dhamma cannot be fully understood without having learned of that "big picture" from a Buddha or from a person who has learnt the correct version of it. Now, since the Buddha is not here and there are many versions of Buddha Dhamma, the question is how do we figure out which version to believe. The Buddha gave a solution to this problem: Find the version that satisfy the following conditions:

- All aspects should be consistent with the *Suttas* and *Vinaya* (and thus *Abhidhamma*); these were transmitted orally for about 500 years and then written down in the Pali *Tipitaka* about 2000 years ago (Pali *Tipitaka*).
- And all three descriptions in the *Tipitaka* (*sutta*, *vinaya*, *abhidhamma*) must be consistent with each other.

8. This second requirement is there to catch any mistakes made in the (especially oral) transmission from the time of the Buddha. It must be kept in mind that all three sets were formulated for easy oral transmission. I know several suttas by heart which I learned when I was little; they have been formulated to be easily remembered. And there were different groups of *Bhikkus* assigned the responsibility for different sections during the time of oral transmission. Also see, "[Preservation of the Dhamma](#)".

9. In a series of posts I have provided evidence that many versions of "Buddhism" being practiced today do not pass the above tests. All Mahayana versions are in blatant contradiction to the teachings in the *Tipitaka*, and some key concepts taught in Theravada are also inconsistent with *Tipitaka*; see, "[Why is it Critical to Find the Pure Buddha Dhamma?](#)", and the follow-up posts.

- Once one finds the key Dhamma concepts that are self-consistent, then one can easily figure out what is *ditthi* and what is not. If anyone can point out anything on this website that is not internally consistent, I would appreciate it. Because my goal is genuine: to find and document the original teachings of the Buddha.

10. Thus it is important to realize that *ditthi* is an **established view (a view one is not even willing to rethink)** about the world, that is inconsistent with Buddha Dhamma. Let us take a few examples:

- Two good examples are the two views of “there is a self” and “there is no self”; see, “[Kilesa \(Defilements\), Ditthi \(Wrong Views\), Samma Ditthi \(Good Views/Correct Views\)](#)“. Both are wrong views according to the Buddha: there is only an ever-changing lifestream that progresses according to cause and effect (*paticca samuppada*); see, “[What Reincarnates? – Concept of a Lifestream](#)“.
- Another *ditthi* many people have is that there is no rebirth process, or that there is a rebirth process but we will never be born as an animal because we have not done anything bad in this life. It is just a belief, there are no supporting evidence to back that up. On the other hand, the rebirth process involving all 31 realms and the natural law of *kamma*, together with *paticca samuppada*, and other key concepts like *Tilakkhana* can explain EVERYTHING that we experience. **What needs to be understood is that ALL THOSE PIECES MUST BE THERE to complete the whole picture.**

11. Just like a blind man holding onto a leg of the elephant and saying “This is what I experience and the elephant is like a pillar. I know what I experience, and I am right”, we hold onto *ditthis* that are inconsistent with the nature’s laws. Once one hears the message of a Buddha, one should at least examine the credibility of that message by looking at the evidence he presented. Ultimately, one has to make the decision to accept Buddha’s message or not. **This is why no one can lead anyone else to salvation. It is all in one’s own mind.**

- Let me give an example how limited our world view had been even two hundred years ago. People believed that Earth was the only planet with the Sun going around the Earth. So, when the Buddha said there are innumerable world systems with other Suns and Moons, people thought that was a loony idea. There are many such *ditthis* that have been proven to be wrong by science over the past hundred years or so; see, “[Dhamma and Science – Introduction](#)“.

12. Some of the views we have are deeply ingrained, and not easy to get rid of. The main thing is NOT to take a firm stand on things that the Buddha called *ditthi* and say, “I know this to be true, and only this to be true” and to cling to them. **Even a Sotapanna may not be fully convinced that, for example, there is a *arupaloka*, but he/she has not ruled that out, i.e., does not have a *ditthi*.** Only an *Arahant* has “complete” *Samma Ditthi*.

- As one learns pure Dhamma, one will have more and more confidence on the world view of the Buddha and will get rid of the wrong views. Since the mind cannot be forced to accept anything, this “change of vision” comes only through learning the pure Dhamma and through the enhanced life experience, which means purifying the mind; see, “[The Importance of Purifying the Mind](#)“.
- **We cannot pick and choose parts of Buddha Dhamma that we like if we want to reap the full benefits.** Of course one could decide to “live with” parts of Dhamma that one is comfortable with. The Buddha said to accept his teachings only if they make sense. To make sense though, one needs to look at the whole picture too. Otherwise, it will be like a blind man examining only the leg of an elephant and saying it really feels like a pillar.

13. *Ditthi* is one of 14 *akusala cetasika* and one of the ten *kilesa*; see, “[Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)](#)“, and “[Kilesa \(Defilements\), Ditthi \(Wrong Views\), Samma Ditthi \(Good Views/Correct Views\)](#)“. *Ditthi* have been described in many ways by the Buddha. At the Sotapanna stage, those *ditthis* that could lead to rebirth in the *apayas* (*sathkaya ditthi*, *vicikicca*, *silabbata paramasa*) are permanently removed; see, “[Akusala Citta – How a Sotapanna Avoids Apayagami Cittas](#)“.

- Thus it is important to realize that the Sotapanna stage CANNOT be reached until ***niyata micca***

ditthi or ESTABLISHED wrong views are removed. For example, one should not hold on to a firm belief that there is no rebirth process; one should at least keep an open mind.

- **Stated most succinctly, *micca dithi* is the wrong perception of *nicca, sucka, atta*, i.e., things can be maintained to one's satisfaction, thus lasting happiness is possible, and thus it is fruitful to stay in this world of 31 realms. One attains the first stage of *Samma ditthi* when one comprehends *anicca, dukkha, anatta* to a certain extent at the *Sotapanna* stage.**

14. The Buddha said his Dhamma is hard to understand, and it is not like anything that anyone taught before, except for another Buddha: It is “*Pubbe anunussetu Dhammesu*“, “A Dhamma that has not been heard before”. This is why the Buddha worried just after the Enlightenment whether he will be able to teach this difficult Dhamma to normal human beings. It takes a real effort to glean the message of the Buddha.

For a description of the ten *micca ditthi*, see, “[Three Kinds of Ditthi, Eightfold Paths, and Samadhi](#)“.

Three Kinds of Ditthi, Eightfold Paths, and Samadhi

1. Have you ever wondered how some people have any “peace of mind” while engaging in abominable actions day in and day out? It is easier to excuse someone who commits a bad act in a “moment of fury”, i.e, when such action was not pre-planned (and the common law accommodates for that).

- But some people (think Hitler, Pol Pot in Cambodia) plan evil acts for years, and they seem to thrive doing it; they do not feel any remorse; rather they enjoy what they do. This is because just like facilitating a journey towards Nibbana for someone who embarks on the Noble Eightfold Path, the nature also lets someone go in the opposite direction too. “*Dhammo ha ve rakkati dhammacari*” applies to both kinds of “Dhamma”.
- Dhamma is what one “bears”. If one “carries good Dhamma”, one will be guided in the “good direction” by nature. In the same way, one who “carries bad Dhamma” will be guided in the opposite direction. Both can get into “*samadhi*” doing it.

2. *Samadhi* (“*sama*”+“*adhi*” where “*sama*” means “same” and “*adhi*” means “dominance”) means the object becomes the priority and the mind gets focused on it; as we discussed in many posts, when the mind becomes focused on one object (*arammana*), no matter what the object is, the *ekaggata cetasika* takes over and make the mind latched “on to it”.

- When the minds gets to *samadhi*, the mind feels calm because it is stopped from jumping back and forth among many thought objects (*arammana*).
- This is how one gets to not only *samadhi* but also *anariya jhana* (a *jhana* is a deeper state of absorption or *samadhi*) using breath meditation, just by focusing the mind on the breath.
- Thus, a master thief gets to *micca samadhi* when intently focusing on the plan of a grand robbery in minute details. Not only does he get a joy out of it, his mind helps him work out the fine details; but someone with *micca samadhi* can never get into a *jhana*.
- It does not matter what the focus is, nature helps get it done if one really sets his/her mind to it. This is why “*Dhammo ha ve rakkati dhammacari*” can work in any situation. The human mind is very powerful, but it can be used in all three directions.

3. However, that does not change the fact that outcomes of “bad actions” will ALWAYS be bad in the long run. This is a universal law called “*beeja niyama*” which is one of five natures’ primary laws called “*niyama*” (“*niyama*” in Pali or Sinhala means “fixed”, “unchangeable”); even though most times it is pronounced “*niyāma*”, the correct pronunciation is “*niyama*”.

- Bad kamma result in “bad *kamma beeja*” which will ONLY bear “bad fruits”; also, the consequences will be proportional to the “size” of the *kamma beeja* (*kamma* seed). And the same holds true for good *kamma* seeds.

4. Now, when someone gets on the “wrong track” mostly through bad associates or bad environment, one has the “ten types of *micca ditthi*”, and one could get into the “*micca* eightfold path”. **The ten types of *micca ditthi* are:**

- giving (*dana*) has no merits, special types of giving (*maha dana*) do not have special merits, giving does have any effects in future lives (i.e., there is no way to “carry over” merits to next life), what we enjoy/suffer in this life is not due to *kamma vipaka* but they “just happen”, there

are no other worlds than the one we can experience, when one dies it is not possible to be born in other worlds, mother is not a special person, father is not a special person, there are no instantaneous (*opapathika*) births, there is no special person called a Buddha who discovers all of nature's laws by his own effort.

5. When one has **unshakeable** or ***niyata micca ditthi*** one gets on the ***micca eightfold path***; now one's mind is covered by the five hindrances (*panca nivarana*) to such an extent that one never gets to see the moral aspects. Then one tends to have *micca sankalpa* (wrong thoughts), *micca vaca* (wrong speech, i.e., lying etc), *micca kammanta* (engages in wrong actions (killing, stealing, etc), *micca vayama* (wrong efforts), *micca ajiva* (wrong livelihood), *micca sati* (focus on bad things), and thus one gets to *micca samadhi* (wrong *samadhi*).

- Since these factors feed on each other, once one gets into *micca* eightfold path, it is difficult to break out of it. The key is *micca ditthi*: “Wrong vision” is hard to break, when it is continually being reinforced by wrong speech, actions, etc. Thus it is inevitable that one keeps strengthening one's “bad *gathi*” or behavior. Then it is increasingly easier to get to “*micca samadhi*”.

6. The Buddha said that ***Samma Ditthi* is two-fold**: there is a **mundane (*lokiya*) *Samma Ditthi*** and an ***Ariya Samma Ditthi***. When one has mundane *Samma Ditthi*, one rejects the ten types of *micca ditthi* mentioned above, and one strives to be born in human or higher realms. One knows that bad actions will lead to birth in the *apayas* (lowest four realms).

- Thus one with mundane *samma ditthi* will develop **mundane versions of *samma sankalpa*** (good thoughts), *samma vaca* (abstain from lying, gossiping, etc), *samma kammanta* (engages only in moral acts), and so on and then it is easier for one to get to mundane *samma samadhi*. This is the **mundane *samma* eightfold path**.
- However, while someone following the ***micca eightfold path* cannot attain any *jhana***, one on the mundane *samma* eightfold path can attain *anariya jhana*; see, “[Power of the Human Mind – Anariya Jhana](#)”.

7. The critical difference between mundane *samma ditthi* and *Ariya Samma Ditthi* is that while one with mundane *samma ditthi* rejects immoral behavior based on one's fear of rebirth in the *apayas* and one's hope for rebirth in comfort-filled *deva* or *brahma* worlds (or even because it makes one feels good about the act), one **ATTAINS *Ariya Samma Ditthi*** when one comprehends *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* at least to a significant extent, i.e., one becomes a *Sotapanna*.

- Thus one starts on the Path by following the mundane *samma* eightfold path, and at some point enters the *Ariya Samma* Eightfold Path when attaining the *Sotapanna* stage.
- At that stage, one's mind **automatically rejects** immoral acts because **one's mind sees the futility** as well as the danger of such acts. What is the point of having some sense pleasure if it lasts only a short time AND could lead to much misery in the future for long times?

8. The critical point is that when one becomes a *Sotapanna*, **one's mind (and the brain) will be changed** so that one will not act even impulsively, let alone capable of pre-planning a an act that could yield rebirth in the *apayas*.

- Scientists do confirm that there are significant changes in the brain just due to breath meditation alone; see, “[True Brain: How the Mind Rewires the Brain via Meditation/Habits](#)”.

- Such future brain studies on people engaged in the correct *anapana* meditation can be expected to yield profound changes in a brain when a person attains the Sotapanna stage.

9. Thus one becomes a *Sotapanna* (enter the stream) from the mundane *samma ditthi* stage by comprehending the true nature of the world (i.e., it is fruitless to be born ANYWHERE in the 31 realms) by learning the meanings of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* from a Buddha (who discovers them), or from a true disciple of the Buddha.

- Once one becomes a *Sotapanna*, the Path to *Nibbana* becomes clear, and one does not need any more help. One will cultivate the next six steps and get to *Ariya Samma Samadhi* and to the *Arahant* stage of *Nibbana*.

10. I need to re-emphasize the difference between “living a moral life” which is promoted by most of world’s major religions, and the emphasize on “purifying the mind” and “comprehending the true nature of the wider world of 31 realms” in Buddha Dhamma.

- One needs to approach this extra step first by being “moral”, i.e., by following the mundane *samma* eightfold path and getting rid of some of the five hindrances. Then one’s mind is purified to an extent to be able to “see through the fog of ignorance” and comprehend *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.
- Buddha’s message about the “suffering hidden in the midst of apparent sense pleasures” is indeed a “Dhamma that has never been known”. It could be contrary to one’s instincts, because all we have known from the beginningless time is about enjoying the sense pleasures.

Note: The three kinds of eightfold paths, *micca ditthi*, and *micca samadhi* are described in the *Maha Chattareesaka Sutta* and the *Asathpurisa Sutta*, among other suttas.

Implications of the Rebirth Process in Daily Life and in Society

1. Unless one develops abhinna powers via meditation, the rebirth process cannot be “proven” with certainty. Yet, there is mounting evidence for it that cannot be ignored either; see, “[Evidence for Rebirth](#)”.
 - Putting that question aside, let us look at some implications IF indeed the rebirth process, as described by the Buddha, is correct.
2. The first thing to realize is how short this life of 100 years or so is. It is unimaginably small. Our universe has been there for about 14 BILLION years and that is just a blip in the cosmic time scale.
3. Looking at the world history, most calamities of war could have been prevented if people understood how short this life is. Where are those emperors and kings today, who sacrificed so many human lives to capture another country or to maintain their powers?
 - Because of the atrocities they committed, they are most likely to be in the lowest of the apayas.
 - For the briefest time of enjoyment and power, they accumulated so much bad kamma to spend billions of years in total misery.
4. What significance would race, color, ethnicity, religion, beauty, money, etc would have in one’s actions if one really understood that all those are not only temporary, but one could on the other side in the very next life? This is a topic that is worth contemplating a lot.
5. Let us take the struggle between the Palestinians and the Israelis, because it is making headlines these days; one could take any other conflict. According to Buddha Dhamma, there are two effects that come to play here.
 - One in either camp will develop a mindset to hate the other side, take revenge for some action, etc. If they have any kammic energy for the human “bhava” they will come back to the same place with matching “gathi”, looking for revenge; see, “[Paticca Samuppada – “Pati + ichcha” + “Sama + uppada”](#)”.
 - The other aspect is for any bad action one does in such a conflict is going to have consequences RELATED to that act. When person A kills or harms another person B, A becomes indebted to B. One way to “pay back this debt” is for B to be born as a child to A; see, “[Kamma, Debt, and Meditation](#)”. Isn’t that the biggest irony of all? A Palestinian (Israeli) becoming the child of an Israeli (Palestinian)?
 - Either way, the conflict will continue for a long time, unless both sides realize the folly of it all.
 - This is true for many other conflicts that have been going-on for generations. It is likely that most of the characters involved have been the same. They are too much “involved” in the conflict and are unable to free their minds from it.
6. Let us take another example of a slave owner in the old days. That person made a lot of wealth by exploiting those slaves, but for how long? At most 100 years. Where are those slave owners now? They would either be in one of the lowest four realms OR could be a slave himself somewhere, possibly to a former slave.
 - It is easy to extend this analysis to many other cases; it is good idea to contemplate on such things. It makes one understand the true meanings of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. That is unfruitful

to do immoral things to achieve a brief moment of sense pleasure, where the consequences can play out for much longer time in a future birth.

7. Yet we strive for a quarter of our lives to go through the basic educational process (which is the only part that makes any sense in the long term), and basically most of the rest of the life to “accumulate things and prestige”.

- We do not stop and think about how the last years of the life are going to be, let alone about future lives. By the time we have made much of those accomplishments, our senses start degrading, and no matter how much money we have, we will never be able to maintain our physical appearance or the level of sense pleasure to our liking.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?x-yt-ts=1422579428&feature=player_embedded&v=Vv1J29jP4xY&x-yt-cl=85114404

- The problem is that we are too busy to contemplate on such issues because we are in a frantic struggle to “make money for survival”, and whatever vacation time we get we would not want to spend that time for contemplation, but to go on trip or do some such activity to “enjoy ourselves”. But when one gets back from a vacation, it feels like one needs another to recover from those hectic activities.

8. There is another reason that people do not want to even think about such things; it could be depressing. But I can say with conviction that once one understands the “true nature of this world”, it WILL lead to a peaceful state of mind. It will also be easier to get into samadhi and jhanas.

- The reason is that as one understands *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* (the futility of doing immoral things to gain sense satisfaction in world that is INHERENTLY not setup for that), one GRADUALLY loses attachment to worldly things and this makes the mind peaceful; this is the root cause of niramisa sukha; see, “[Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)”.
- Nibbana or “Nivana” or “cooling down” is not like any sense pleasure. Rather, it is a relief. A good analogy is the following: suppose someone has a migraine headache; then the day that headache disappears, that person will get a HUGE sense of relief. It is not a sense pleasure, but rather a feeling of well-being that is hard to express.

9. I can give one example to make this point. Many people who start understanding *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, realize that they do not watch TV or go to entertainment events as much as they used to. This is not something they do deliberately, it just happens. They would rather enjoy a meditation session at home or read/listen to Dhamma. It may be already happening to some of you.

- The mind cannot be forced. It just takes the better path; **but the mind has to be exposed to the better, correct path.** This is why giving true Dhamma is the best giving.

What Does Buddha Dhamma Say about Creator, Satan, Angels, and Demons?

1. In my early stages of learning about other religions, I read a variety of books ranging from those by C. S. Lewis (“Mere Christianity” is a good introduction) to “The Language of God” by Francis Collins (2007) to understand the “case for a Creator”. From all those books, the books by these two authors better focus on the issue to provide a rational basis for believing in a creator God.

2. To briefly summarize the views of those two authors (as I understood), the most fundamental reason for believing in a Creator is the existence of Moral law: How can we know and feel the truth of the Moral laws unless God instilled those in us?

- On the other side, both authors struggled with issue of Satan (or Devil), and why there is suffering.
- Why would the God allow the existence of a Satan, and the associated immoral behavior by people? The main conclusion was that the God chose to give the man free will, and the man abused it.
- Lewis in particular worried about the existence of suffering. Why would the God allow that?

3. Let us see what Buddha Dhamma says about those issues.

- Of course, in Buddha Dhamma, there is no Creator. Everything happens due to (multiple) causes and by definition there is no first cause (i.e., a Creator). The “world” has existed as far as one (with supernormal powers or abhinna) can see; for details, see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”.
- Actually, even people without abhinna powers can remember one or a few past lives; see, “[Evidence for Rebirth](#)“. In some special cases, some can recall multiple past lives under hypnosis; see, the book “Many Lives, Many Masters” by Brian Weiss, who is a psychotherapist.

4. In Buddha Dhamma “the good” and “the bad” in this world are all built into the nature’s laws. Any sentient being experiences “the world” with its sense faculties, and that experience comes in the form of thoughts (*citta*).

- Based on those sense inputs, one generates various “good” and “bad” responses. These responses are first manifested in the mind as mere thoughts, but we may act on them further by speech and bodily actions.
- There are 52 mental factors (cetasika) that include both “good” characteristics (such as kindness, generosity, fear of wrong, shame of wrong, etc), and “bad” characteristics (such as greed, hate, shamelessness, fearlessness of wrong, etc). In the “[Abhidhamma](#)” and “[Tables and Summaries](#)” sections these are discussed, even though we are only at the early stage of such discussions at this site.

5. Thus there is no “God” or a “Satan”. It is each person acting on his/her own free will that is committing good or bad acts. But it is a complex issue, because what we are today is the kind of “cumulative result” of all our actions in the deep past through our previous lives. These can be condensed as our character (or “*gathi*”) or sansaric habits (or “*asavas*”). There are many posts on this issue at the site, starting with “[Habits, Goals, and Character \(Gathi\)](#)“.

- And these *gathi* and *asavas* are in constant flux; thus one could be a murderer one day, but then through sheer willpower can decide to be a “better person”. There is no “soul” or a fixed “self”. One cannot say there is “no-self” either, because one’s “*gathi*” or “*asava*” are unique characteristics and are “one’s own”; see, “[What Reincarnates? – The Concept of a Lifestream](#)”.

6. And no one else can make that change but oneself. Even the Buddha can only show the way to change: how to change these “*gathi*” and the “*asavas*” for the better. When one does that one can feel the “cooling down” or ‘*niveema*’ or the *niramisa sukha*. This is the real goal in Buddhist meditation; see, “[Introduction to Buddhist Meditation](#)”.

- The “moral code” comes naturally out of this big picture. One can lead a peaceful life by practicing “*dasa kusala*” (ten moral acts), and avoiding “*dasa akusala*” (ten immoral acts); see, “[Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)](#)” and the follow up post.

7. Let us also discuss briefly about “demons” and “angels”. Most Creator-based religions have such entities. And they are supposed to be able to influence humans. Are there beings like that according to Buddha Dhamma?

- Yes. In Buddha Dhamma, the world is much more complex than with just demons and angels. We can see and experience only two realms (human and animal) out of 31 possible realms in this world; see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”.
- If someone develops *abhinna* powers (see, “[The Power of the Human Mind](#)” and followup posts), depending on the level attained one could “see” some or many of these other beings. There are people who can do this at the present time.
- However, even the majority of people with *abhinna* power can “see” mainly some beings in the lowest 12 realms which comprise the “sense world” or the “*kama loka*”: mainly the beings with less dense bodies than ours that are in the 7 *deva loka* and some of the beings in the realms below the human realm.
- The beings in the *rupa loka* and the *arupa loka* have “bodies” even less dense than those in the *deva* realms, and it is even more difficult to “see” them.
- The 7 realms in the *deva loka* are the closest thing to a “heaven” according to the Buddha Dhamma. Those beings have bodies that are free from physical illnesses, and there is much more happiness there than in the human world. And they have long lifetimes. However, any being in any higher realm can end up in the lowest four realms (*apayas*) in the future unless they reach at least the *Sotapanna* stage of *Nibbana*.

8. Some of these beings can communicate with humans with or without *abhinna* powers. There are beings who are benevolent and there are others who are malevolent. As pointed out in the posts on “*gathi*”, a being normally communicates with a human with similar ‘*gathi*’ or character.

- Thus a malevolent being (we could say “a demon”) normally tries to communicate with a human with similar bad character. They may try to impress the human and try to get their own agenda fulfilled.
- A benevolent being (we could say “an angel”) is usually a *deva* from the 7 *deva* realms. They like to help out people with good character, but usually do not try to communicate directly. Normally, the person may not even know that he/she is being helped in certain ways.

9. I will mention two prominent cases in the West to illustrate these points.

- Jane Roberts wrote a series of books based on “Seth”, a being who could “possess” her body with her permission, and spoke to her husband about various things about the world; see, for example, “Seth Speaks” by Jane Roberts (1994). Seth commented on various issues and made many predictions too. I am not sure how those “predictions” worked out, but I am sure the success rate must be no better than any human making such predictions.
- Then there is more popular “Ramtha”, who speaks through J. Z. Knight; see, for example, “Ramtha -The White Book” by J. Z. Knight (2005). He is a very benevolent being, proving moral advice on how to live a better life. As I understand, there is a large following for Ramtha.
- There are many such beings who like to “show off” and also try to genuinely help people live a better life. But those beings themselves are “travelers of *sansara*” who just happen to have a good birth for a longer time period.
- Then there are beings that are malevolent. Even though I am not aware of any prominent cases like the two above, there are many reports on “hearing voices” and even committing crimes based on the instructions through such voices.

10. This world is very complex and we perceive only a tiny part of it. But the point is that there is no place anywhere in the 31 realms that can provide permanent happiness.

- There is no point in pursuing such demons or even angels. They themselves are in the same predicament, or worse, compared to us. Those benevolent beings will help us, even without seeking help, if they see the good in us.
- As humans, we have the unique advantage of learning the truth about the dangers of this rebirth process (*sansara*) and work towards getting out of it by seeking *Nibbana* or “cooling down”. That was THE message of the Buddha.

Patisandhi Citta – How the Next Life is Determined According to Gathi

1. The transition of a life stream from one kind of life to another takes place during the last *citta vithi* of the present life. For a fundamental description of this process, see, “[Cuti-Patisandhi – An Abhidhamma Description](#)”.
- But here let us look at how different types of kamma as well as one’s “*gathi*” lead to corresponding rebirths in different realms.
2. As discussed in “[Akusala Citta and Akusala Vipaka Citta](#)”, all 10 types of *akusala kamma* are done with 12 types of *akusala citta*. Except for the last *akusala citta* which is delusion-based and associated with *uddacca*, the other 11 types lead to rebirth in the *apayas* (four lower realms).
- All 11 types of *akusala citta* lead to just one *patisandhi vipaka citta* and it is called the “*akusala vipaka upekkha santirana citta*”. This is the type of *citta* that comes to the mind of the dying person.
3. Yet, that one *patisandhi citta* can lead to rebirth in an uncountable number of “*bhava*” in the four lowest realms. In the animal realm itself there are an uncountable number of varieties.
- Thus what really determines the actual “place of birth” in the four lowest realms is one’s “*gathi*”. Once the fate is determined by to be born in one of the four lowest realms due to an *akusala kamma*, the next step for nature is to match “*gathi to gathi*”. A greedy person is likely to be matched with a birth in the *peta realm* (hungry ghosts), and really vicious person is likely to head to the hell (*niraya*); see, “[How Character \(Gathi\) Leads to Bhava and Jati](#)”.
4. Now let us look at how rebirth takes place according to one’s *kusala kamma*. As we discussed in the post, “[A Simple way to Enhance Merits \(Kusala\) and Avoid Demerits \(Akusala\)](#)”, the merits of a *kusala kamma* is ENHANCED when it is done with understanding or wisdom (*panna*); what is meant here not “book knowledge”, but an understanding of the three characteristics, *anicca, dukkha, anatta*.
- Thus out of the 8 *maha kusala kamma* (great meritorious actions), 4 are done with knowledge or *panna* (in addition to *alobha* and *adosa*, i.e., generosity and loving kindness). Since they have all three *kusala* roots, they are called “*tihetuka*” (“*ti*” means three and “*hetu*” means roots). **They lead to the best kind of rebirths , called “*tihetuka patisandhi*” or “rebirth with three roots”.**
- The other four *maha kusala kamma* are done with generosity and loving kindness, but without knowledge of *anicca, dukkha, anatta* or wisdom. Thus the resulting kamma vipaka lead to “*dvihetuka patisandhi*” or “rebirth with two roots”. They also lead to birth in the realms 5 through 11 (i.e., in human and *deva* realms), but they will have less *kammic* power for that birth.
5. Thus it is those who have “*tihetuka patisandhi*” that normally have health, wealth, and wisdom in varying degrees. Those with “*dvihetuka patisandhi*” may have health and/or wealth but lack in wisdom. For example, it is easier for a person with *tihetuka patisandhi* to learn Dhamma or to attain *jhanas*. But it is impossible to say who has a *tihetuka* or *dvihetuka patisandhi*.
- There is one more *patisandhi citta* that is possible from a lower grade *maha kusala kamma*. This is also a *kamma* done without knowledge, but also with less enthusiasm. This is called a *kusala vipaka upekkha santirana citta* and is a “rebirth with no roots” or an “*ahetuka*”.

patisandhi”.

- Such an “*ahetuka patisandhi*” can lead to births only in the human or the lowest deva realm. Such a birth is comparatively easy to recognize (but not always): people with *ahetuka patisandhi* have low IQ, could be blind or deaf at birth, or be severely handicapped. However, such deficiencies COULD occur due to problems encountered in the womb (if the mother is a drug addict or had an ailment during the pregnancy); that is why in some cases you encounter people with above characteristics, but are smart. They are not really born with an *ahetuka patisandhi*, and could learn Dhamma and/or attain *jhanas*.

6. Thus we see that there is only **one *patisandhi citta* due to the 10 *akusala kamma* (from 12 *akusala citta*), and 9 possible *patisandhi citta* due to the 8 *maha kusala kamma*.**

- The remaining *patisandhi citta* lead to rebirth in the *Brahma loka* (16 *rupa loka* and 4 *arupa loka*). These arise due to *jhanic* states: rebirth in the *arupa loka* are due to the 5 *rupa jhanas* and rebirth in the 4 *arupa loka* are due to the 4 *arupa jhanas*.

7. Therefore, **only 19 *patisandhi citta* that lead to rebirth anywhere in the 31 realms.** As we have discussed, there are uncountable number of species (we ourselves can see numerous animal species). What differentiates different species are the “*gathi*”. You can see that each species has its own “character”: Even within a given species, there are differences in “*gathi*”. If you look at dogs, there are some who are vicious and then there are ones that are cuddly (poodles).

- In the days of the Buddha, it is said that when someone dies, relatives of the deceased usually ask the Buddha “what is the *jati* and what is the *gathi*” of the new birth. These days we don’t have the Buddha to tell us, but we ourselves can sort of guess what “*gathi*” we have and make sure to change them for the better.
- When one attains [the Sotapanna stage](#), any “*gathi*” matching those in the *apayas* are permanently removed (hate, greed, ignorance at the highest levels).
- At the *Sakadagami* stage, one’s liking to a “dense body” to enjoy sense pleasures is removed; such a “dense body” is one that can get diseases, and thus a *Sakadagami* is never born in human or lower realms where sickness and body aches are a fact of life.
- Then at the *Anagami* stage, one loses craving for enjoying pleasures with the nose and tongue, and thus one can find matching “*gathi*” only in the *rupa* and *arupa loka*.
- Once the *Arahant* stage is reached one loses craving for any sense pleasure with even a trace of matter or any connection to matter, and the mind attains the true freedom; no more “*gathi*” left.

Seeking Nibbana

1. This section is for those who are interested not merely in pursuing a good life or seeking better lives in future births. Other religions can also provide guidance for those goals to a certain extent. The uniqueness in the Buddha's message is that there is perpetual suffering in the unending cycle of rebirths in "this world", the root causes for that suffering, that there is possible release from that suffering (Nibbana), and there is a way to attain Nibbana.
2. The first stage of attaining Nibbana is the Sotapanna (Stream Entry) stage. In order to reach this stage, one needs to have a complete understanding of Buddha Dhamma (or the laws of nature). Since only a Buddha can discover these laws, it is not possible for anyone (no matter how intelligent) to discover these laws by oneself.
3. Once [the Sotapanna stage](#) is attained, one knows what to do next. Thus there is no need to get further information from anywhere else. My goal with this site is to provide necessary information to attain [the Sotapanna stage](#).

[“Myths about the Sotapanna Stage”](#)

[“Why a Sotapanna is Better off than any King, Emperor, or a Billionnaire”](#)

[“Gathi \(Character\), Anusaya \(Temptations\), and Asava \(Cravings\)”](#)

[“The Way to Nibbana – Removal of asavas”](#)

[“Why is Correct Interpretation of Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta so Important?”](#)

[“The Sotapanna Stage”](#)

[“How to Cultivate the Noble Eightfold Path Starting with Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta”](#)

[“Akusala Citta – How a Sotapanna Avoids Apayagami Citta”](#)

[“Difference Between Giving Up Valuables and Losing Interest in Worthless”](#)

[“Sotapanna Magga and Phala – How to Distinguish”](#)

[“Root Cause of Anicca – Five Stages of a Sankata”](#)

Sotapanna Stage of Nibbana

[The Sotapanna Stage](#)

[Why a Sotapanna is Better off than any King, Emperor, or a Billionaire](#)

[Myths about the Sotapanna Stage](#)

[Sotapanna Magga and Phala – How to Distinguish](#)

[How Does One Know whether the Sotapanna Stage is Reached?](#)

The Sotapanna Stage

A Simile for Samma Ditthi (attaining the Sotapanna Stage)

1. Suppose a man lives in an area that is normally full of sense pleasures. But there are occasional flooding, droughts, and also Earthquakes. When such calamities occur, he gets distraught and thus his mind is not at ease most of the time. Yet, he has accumulated some wealth and in the back of his mind, he believes that “everything will be OK” in the long run.
2. Then one day, an old friend (who has been on travel for many years) comes back and tells him that the reason he left was to find a better place to live. The friend says that he did some research and found out that this land is inherently unstable and within several years is going to be destroyed in an Earthquake. Furthermore, he says that he found a place that is very prosperous and that there are no worries about flooding, drought, or Earthquakes there. But it is a long journey to that place.
3. The man tells the friend that he had heard about such wonderful places from other people before. He had followed them at times, but everytime came back after trekking for some time, because he could not see any benefit. Plus, he says, “how do I know what you say is right? I know that everything is not perfect here, but can you show evidence for your theory that there is going to be a big Earthquake? Also, how can I believe you that this place you found is so wonderful?”
4. The friend shows him all the evidence that he had gathered why this area is unsuitable for living in the long run. He also shows evidence about the prosperity of the new place and also describes to him the the travel path.
5. The man spends a lot of time reading about and contemplating on all the evidence that he received. Then he begins to realize that what the friend is saying is true. He decides to take an exploratory trip on that path, and makes suitable preparations as suggested by the friend. Once in a while he wonders whether all these preparations are going to be a waste of time. But as he keeps on assessing the evidence he becomes more and more convinced that he needs to take that trip.
6. He starts on the trip and is encouraged by seeing some “landmarks” that the friend told him about. Even though once in a while he thinks about all the “pleasures” he could have had if he stayed home, these “landmarks” give him encouragement to go further and then reaches one of the four “major stopovers” that the friend told about. Once he gets to that destination, he becomes totally convinced about the truth of his friend’s conclusions. Now there is no going back for him. This is the *Sotapanna* stage.
7. Thus it is very important to first find out all about what the goal is (*Nibbana*), correct instructions to get there (the Path), and most of all why it not profitable or wise to stay home (i.e., to stay in “this world”). The last one is the critical one to comprehend first, because unless one sees the dangers of the status quo, one will not be motivated to take action (to start on the Path).
8. Realizing the inherent instability of “this world” is the true understanding of the Three Characteristics: *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. He realizes that there is no point in the current struggle in trying to make permanent peace in a place (“this world”) which is inherently not set up to provide that relief (see, [“The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma”](#)). And that *Nibbana* means ultimate, permanent peace of mind. Just this realization leads to the “point-of-no-return”, the *Sotapanna* stage.
9. One day the Buddha asked Ven. Sariputta to clarify what is meant by “sota” and “*Sotapanna*“. Ven. Sariputta said, “*sota*” is the Noble Eightfold Path, and a “*Sotapanna*” is one who follows the Path

correctly. To follow the Path, first one needs to have a map or the layout of “our existence”.

- What we observe with our limited sense faculties is only a very small part of a much more complex world; we are beginning see a bit more of that wider world with the technological advances made by science. But it is still an insignificant fraction of the whole picture.
- The whole picture is very complex, but we do not need to learn all about it (but if one has time one could learn *Abhidhamma* and learn minute details). The Buddha has condensed the very essence of the existence in this wider world by its Three Characteristics (*Tilakkhana*): *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. When one comprehends those characteristics, one can “see” what lies ahead, and what to do about it.
- **Thus one attains the Sotapanna stage with just Samma Ditthi, which is the correct view of the wider world.**

10. After attaining the *Sotapanna* stage, he KNOWS what needs to be done and HOW it is to be done. Then he diligently follows the Path and attains the next three stages, culminating in *Nibbana*.

The Way to the Sotapanna Stage

The key here is that without knowing about the Buddha’s world view (31 realms of existence and the suffering in the four lower realms, see “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”), one does not comprehend the “samsaric suffering”; **most suffering is incurred when one is born in any of the four lowest realms**. This is important because it is possible that (especially young and wealthy people) may not experience that much physical and mental suffering in this life. And in order to have faith in the Buddha’s world view, one needs to spend some time examining the evidence for it.

1. When one clearly sees why it is not fruitful to stay in “this world” of 31 realms, he/she has understood the true nature, the three characteristics *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, of “this world”. This clear vision or *Samma Ditthi* itself (the realization that there is nothing “substantial” to be had by staying in “this world”), makes the mind to determine that there is no point in doing immoral things (those that cause rebirth in the four lower realms).

2. We strive to gain or own “things” in this world because we perceive that we can achieve happiness eventually; this is *sakkāya ditthi* or *sathkāya ditthi* (both “*sakka*” and “*sath*” mean “good” or fruitful, and “*kāya*” means “*kriya*” or actions; *ditthi* means wrong view: thus both these mean our wrong view that our actions to acquire “things” or to “seek happiness” are good and fruitful. When one truly understands *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, this wrong view is removed. One realizes that nothing we do can lead to permanent happiness “in this world”.

3. Furthermore, for one who has clearly seen *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, the mind does not allow serious wrong doings (*vici* + *ki* + *ichcha* = liking for wrong actions or things) that could lead to birth in the lower four realms; there is no doubt regarding the “world vision” that he/she realized. Thus *vicikicca*, or the liking for unfruitful and harmful actions, is removed at the *Sotapanna* stage.

4. it is clear that all that is needed to be done is to contemplate on the true nature of the world. It is done by purifying the mind, and cannot be done just by following certain rituals, such as just obeying precepts on certain days. Thus the idea of “*silabbata paramasa*” or “*Nibbana* can be attained by following rituals” is removed at the *Sotapanna* stage. One realizes what the Buddha said by “*sanvarattena seelan*”, i.e., “*sila*” or moral behavior is achieved by constraint of eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind, at ALL TIMES, not by “observing precepts” for a given time interval.

5. For one who has become “*dassanena sampanno*” (one with true and clear vision), the mindset changes not by following formal procedures, but by understanding the futility of breaking any precepts or wrong doings. Even if one does a wrong act, the mistake is realized and one takes care to avoid it.

6. Please keep in mind that this is not to discourage people from observing precepts as a formality. This is a good thing to do for those who are starting on the Path, and also a good habit to create in children. It is customary in Buddhist countries for whole families to go the temple and observe “*panca sila*” of “*attangika sila*” on Poya (Full Moon) days.

Key Points from the Sabbasava Sutta

The key to attaining *Nibbana* is to remove the *Asavas* (residue from fermentation of bad thoughts/habits over many *sansaric* births). This will be discussed under the key Dhamma Concepts.

In the *Sabbasava Sutta*, the Buddha listed seven steps to remove the *asavas* and to purify the mind thus paving the way to Nibbana. These seven steps are listed below:

1. Removal by clear vision (“*dassanena pahathabba*”, where *dassana* is vision and *pahathabba* is removal). This is clear understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.
2. Removal by the restrained use of the senses (“*sanvarena pahathabba*”, where *sanvara* is disciplined use of the sense faculties: not to over-indulge in the senses).
3. Removal by good and frequent associations (“*patisevana pahathabba*”, where *sevana* is association: for example, with good friends and good deeds).
4. Removal by tolerance and patience (“*adhivasana pahathabba*”). For example, even if one is tempted to steal because one is hungry, one should contemplate the consequences and bear the hunger.
5. Removal by staying clear of “bad influences and environments” (“*parivajjana pahathabba*”). One needs to avoid bad friends, bad locations for living (due to floods, bad neighbors, etc), avoiding unsuitable times to go out, etc.
6. Removal by getting rid of certain things (“*vinodana pahathabba*”). One needs to get rid of bad thoughts that come to mind, for example, for excessive sense pleasure, hate, etc.
7. Removal by meditation (“*bhavana pahathabba*”). Here the meditation recommended is the development of the Seven Stages of Enlightenment (*Saptha Bojjanga*).

The clear vision is the first on the list. Just like one should not undertake a journey without learning about the destination, the path, and the reason for the journey, one needs to start getting rid of *asavas* by first having a clear vision of the Buddha’s world view (see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”) and understanding what these *asavas* are and how they arise. More on this topic will be discussed in the “[Key Dhamma Concepts](#)” section.

There are four *asavas*: *kamasava* (craving for sense pleasures), *ditthasava* (cravings due to wrong views), *bhavasava* (craving for existence), and *avijjasava* (cravings due to ignorance).

The *ditthasava* is removed by the *Sotapanna* through clear vision. Once one understood the true nature of “this world” by contemplating on *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, one would not commit any immoral acts to gain anything in “this world”; see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta](#)“. This alone saves one from future rebirths in the lower four realms.

A *Sotapanna* still has the other three *asavas* left. Those are removed mainly by the meditation on the *Saptha Bojjanga*.

The other five steps listed in the *Sabbasava Sutta*, as one can clearly see, are common sense things to do. They need to be followed at any stage. Actually those steps can be used by anyone to enhance the quality of life and to remove any bad habits that they have, for example, alcohol or drug use, to eating too much. A clear vision of why those are bad, and why they need to be stopped is an important step.

The *Maha Satipattana Sutta* covers all seven steps in a somewhat different fashion. The *Anapanasati bhavana* (not the breath meditation version) plays a major role here.

Next, “[How to Cultivate the Noble Eightfold Path Starting with Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta](#)“,

Why a Sotapanna is Better off than any King, Emperor, or a Billionaire

Most people think that Buddha Dhamma is a pessimistic “religion”. It is neither a religion nor is pessimistic. Let us discuss these two issues a bit first.

1. Buddha Dhamma describes the true nature of “this world”, which is far more complex than most people think.

- A religion makes a promise that if one abides by its tenets/doctrine and lives this life accordingly, then one will be rewarded accordingly. In most religions, one is promised birth in heaven for eternity if this is kept.
- But a basic tenet in Buddha Dhamma is that this life of about 100 years is just a blip compared to the countless lives one has had in the past. **Even if we live a perfect life during these 100 years, that does not guarantee one anything about the future lives**, because we may have done kamma in PREVIOUS LIVES that could give rebirth in even the lowest four realms, the *apayas*, including the *niraya* (hell).
- The only way to GUARANTEE that one will NOT be reborn in the *apayas* is to negate the causes (*lobha, dosa, moha*) that could give opportunities for all such bad *kamma vipaka* to come to fruition. And that is possible only via attaining the *Sotapanna* stage. Even though attaining the *Arahant* stage of *Nibbana* via complete removal of *lobha, dosa, moha* (and thus the ten *sanyojana*) will do that too, attaining the *Sotapanna* stage does not require all that. It just requires one to comprehend *anicca, dukkha, anatta* to the extent that only three *sanyojana* are removed.
- Removal of three (or ten) *sanyojana* cannot be achieved via following set rules/precepts. **One needs to purify one’s mind so that the true nature (*anicca, dukkha, anatta*) of this complex world of 31 realms is understood.** That is why Buddha Dhamma is not a religion per standard definition.
- On the other hand, if one just wants to take what is helpful to lead to moral life and use Buddha Dhamma as a religion, there is nothing wrong with that. That would be much better than living an immoral life. As one proceeds, it is possible that Dhamma will become more clear, and that may provide the incentive to “dig deeper”.

2. Now to the second issue: Because the Buddha emphasized the “suffering in this world”, many think that Buddha Dhamma is pessimistic. The Buddha did not say that this current life is necessarily filled with suffering (even though it has more suffering than people realize); rather, most suffering is encountered in the lowest four realms of the 31 realms. **Thus, this reality of suffering is to be understood in the context of this wider world view.** The Buddha just discovered this true nature of the (more complex) world.

- Furthermore, he showed how to be free from this inevitable suffering in future births, and to attain permanent happiness, *Nibbana*.

3. Please re-read the above material on those two key points. It is important to look at this “wider world view” when trying to make an assessment of what we should strive for in this life. This analysis leads to a whole new perspective if there is evidence to believe the “wider world view” of the Buddha with repeated rebirths in 31 realms that include the four *apayas* with unimaginable suffering.

- Does it make sense to spend 60 years of a 80-100 year life to accumulate wealth and fame, if one is to lose most of one's sensory enjoyments over the last few decades (and possibly have a major disease or memory loss)?
- Does it make sense to accrue unimaginable suffering in the *apayas* in future births by committing any of the *dasa akusala* (ten defilements) to make money, get a promotion, to live in a big house, get a prestigious position, etc (for less than 100 years)?
- The realities of old age, disease, and death hold true for a king, emperor, a billionaire, or a famous film star just the same as for an average person. At the old age, all these achievements actually become a mental burden because one constantly thinks about the "good old days" and become depressed of not being able to enjoy the sensory pleasures just because the whole sensory system is breaking down.
- Here is a video that summarizes what I tried to explain the above paragraph :

4. And this predicament is true for ANY being in ANY realm, unless at least the *Sotapanna* stage is attained. A *deva* or a *brahma* could enjoy millions of years of pleasurable lives, but WILL end up in the *apayas* at some point in the future unless at least the *Sotapanna* stage of *Nibbana* is attained. There are several incidents mentioned in the *Tipitaka* where the Buddha emphasized how important is the *Sotapanna* stage compared to any existence in the 31 realms:

- One time the Buddha was crossing a paddy field with 500 *bhikkhus* where many cattle were grazing, and smiled. A Buddha (or an *Arahant*) does not smile frequently, so Ven. Ananda asked the Buddha why he smiled. The Buddha said, "each one of these has been the king of the devas at some in the past". Ven. Ananda asked why that is a reason to smile. Then the Buddha said, "All these 500 *bhikkhus*, who are *Sotapannas* or above, will never be born an animal. That is why I smiled".
- Another time the Buddha and Ven. Ananda were walking and saw a piglet by the roadside, and the Buddha again smiled. Asked why, he said, "This piglet had been a princess in a life way back; she cultivated *anariya jhanas*, attained the highest (eighth) *jhana* and had *abhinna* powers. She was born in the highest *brahma* world, but now she is just an animal. On the other hand, those who have attained the *Sotapanna* stage in my *sāsana* will never be born in the *apayas*".

5. Many people do not believe in rebirth. But having a belief is not going to help if it is a wrong view. Considering the possible dire consequences IF one gets this world view wrong, it makes a lot of sense to spend some time and to critically examine the evidence for rebirth in particular (see, "[Evidence for Rebirth](#)"), and the wider world view of the 31 realms in general (see, "[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)").

6. The *niyata micca ditthi* (established wrong views) is one of the stronger ones of the *dasa akusala* that could lead to birth in the *apayas*; the key word there is "*niyata*", or "established", i.e., one firmly believes, for example, that there is no rebirth process. One could avoid this by at least having an open mind, and NOT rule out those possibilities. Even a *Sotapanna* may not be truly convinced of some aspects of the wider world view (but not rebirth): for example, he/she may not have any strong conviction on the existence of *deva* worlds, or may not even think about such matters.

- Another point to consider is how the standard world views have changed over time since the Buddha revealed his Dhamma about a very complex world with no discernible beginning. Philosophers since that time (Socrates was a contemporary of the Buddha) put forth many world views that have been discarded one by one: http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Superseded_scientific_theories#Astronomy_and_cosmology

- Within the past 100 years, the Buddha's world view has gained much support from science and that pace is accelerating with the new string theories as well as quantum mechanics. With all this impressive advances science has made, it cannot account for 96% of the mass of the universe; see, <http://science.nasa.gov/astrophysics/focus-areas/what-is-dark-energy/> and http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Dark_matter. This is because there is so much that we cannot "see" with our eyes or even with the current scientific instruments; see, "[What Happens in Other Dimensions?](#)".
- There are good reasons to believe that more of these currently hidden aspects of the universe will be revealed in the future by science. Just imagine that even a hundred years ago, scientists believed that the universe had only a few galaxies and that it was stable. Now we know that there are billions of galaxies in our universe, that there could be numerous universes, and all those universes are not stable, i.e., they are born and will perish in the future.
- Until recently, the humans also had the wrong impression that the Earth is at a special place in the universe. But now we know that it is an insignificant "speck of dust" in a vast universe; see the video in "[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)".

7. Please spend some quiet time contemplating on these issues. These posts are not for reading pleasure; these are issues that have far more serious consequences than making a billion dollars. Some of my friends tell me that I should "tone down" the content because many people are turned off by the "realities of the world". But my goal is not to have a huge readership. Rather, if I can convey the true message of the Buddha for even a few people I would have accomplished my goal. There is ONLY ONE set of natural laws and we cannot alter them, just like we cannot alter the laws of motion: If a car is headed to a brick wall, the car needs to be stopped or the consequences will not be good. Let me give a few examples of how the Buddha assessed this situation:

- Some brahmins complained to the Buddha that he was not spending enough time on debating them, but would spend a lot of time with even a few of his disciples. The Buddha asked this question: "Suppose a farmer has three paddy fields: one is extremely productive, another is OK but requires considerably more time to yield a good harvest, and the third field is of such a poor condition it is impossible to get any harvest. Which field would the farmer put his efforts on? He will first take care of the most productive field, totally disregard the third field, and spend whatever extra time he has on the second field. It is the same way with me. I want to help those who are interested and capable of learning my Dhamma. Debating with those who have closed minds is a waste of time".
- One day the Buddha and Ven. Ananda walked for many miles to a village to deliver a discourse. Everybody gathered and the Buddha was sitting there for a couple of hours without starting the discourse. Finally, a farmer who had lost a cow and was out in the forest looking for it found the cow, went home, took a bath, ate, and came hurrying to the event. The Buddha started the discourse right after he came in. When they were walking back after the discourse, Ven. Ananda asked the Buddha why he kept everyone waiting until that one farmer came in. The Buddha said, "Ananda, I walked all this way to give the discourse because of that farmer. I saw that he was capable of grasping the Dhamma, and he did attain the *Sotapanna* stage".

8. [The Buddha said, "This Dhamma is different from anything the world has ever seen"](#). And that is true. It takes time to grasp the complexity of this world, much of which is hidden from us (and only a Buddha is capable of finding them; see, "[Dhamma and Science – Introduction](#)"). There is no need to rush and embrace everything; one needs to spend time contemplating on the validity of Buddha Dhamma.

9. We can, in a way, compare this situation with the situation a parent faces with a teenager. The teenager wants to go out and have a good time with the friends. But the parent says, “do not just think about the immediate pleasures. If you do not study well and get good grades at school, you will not have a good job when you grow up”. It is the same here. We are trapped in a “rat race” to just keep up with day-to-day pleasures and activities. The Buddha’s message is that there is a much longer perspective to think about. This life is just a drop of water compared to the huge ocean that is the sansaric journey of rebirths. It is imperative to take some time and contemplate on the “bigger picture”. We may not get another chance of a human birth for millions or billions of years; this is NOT an exaggeration.

10. But the best part of the Buddha’s message, which has been lost for over thousand years, is that the *niramisa sukha* is better than any sense pleasures. We are under the illusion that sense pleasures are to be pursued. If one can taste the happiness from staying away from sense pleasures, one will NEVER value the sense pleasures. Those who have experienced even *anariya jhanic* experiences, will have some idea of such *niramisa sukha*.

- It is a feeling of huge release more than a pleasure in the sense of consuming a tasty food, for example. And it is not temporary, especially if one can get to the Sotapanna stage. Then that “base level” of relief is never lost, even in future births.
- When one starts on the Path by comprehending *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, the sense of peacefulness, the release from stresses, is clearly felt; and that gives an incentive to stay on the Path even before attaining the *Sotapanna* stage.
- The best part is the realization that one will never be born in the *apayas*. Any king, emperor, billionaire, is not assured of that; on the contrary, the efforts to attain such temporary status may CAUSE one be born in the *apayas*, if one engaged in *dasa akusala* to attain them.
- As Carl Sagan pointed out in the video in “[The Pale Blue Dot.....](#)“, it is worth while to contemplate “where are all those kings and emperors who gained fame through the suffering of so many people?”. They are likely to be in the *apayas* suffering for millions of years to come.

Next, ‘[Manomaya Kaya and Out-of-Body Experience \(OBE\)](#)“,

Myths about the Sotapanna Stage

1. First of all NO ONE ELSE can discern what magga phala one has attained: Sotapanna or a higher stage of Nibbana. Only a Buddha has that capability. Let me give an example to illustrate this point:

- One time, Ven. Sariputta was giving instructions to a bhikkhu. The Buddha came along and told Ven. Sariputta that the bhikkhu had already attained the Arahantship and thus there is no need to give instructions to him. It turned out that the bhikkhu in question did not say anything to Ven. Sariputta out of respect for him.
- Now, Ven. Sariputta is only second to the Buddha in this Buddha Sāsana. He and Ven. Moggallāna were the two chief disciples: Ven. Sariputta was second in knowledge to the Buddha and Ven. Moggallāna was second in psychic powers to the Buddha.
- Thus, if Ven. Sariputta was not able to discern whether that bhikkhu was an Arahant, it is NOT possible for anyone living today to determine the stage of Nibbana (Sotapanna, Sakadagami, Anagami, Arahant) of any other person.
- One could be of any race or even religion and still be a jati Sotapanna (and, even that person may not be aware of it). If one had attained the Sotapanna stage in previous life, he could in principle, be born anywhere. Buddha Dhamma describes nature's laws; it applies to everyone the same way.
- Those people who attained various stages of Nibbana during the early years had different religious beliefs. They sat down to listen to the Buddha and by the time the discourse was over, they had attained various stages of Nibbana. Some people came to debate the Buddha and left as Sotapannas. One does not need to formally become a "Buddhist" to realize the true nature of "this world".

2. This is why one has to be very careful when dealing with other humans, and not to offend anyone intentionally. It is very important to have at least some knowledge of the different weights of kamma; see, "[How to Evaluate Different Weights of Kamma](#)".

- Some people worry about inadvertently killing insects while cleaning the house, but do not think twice about saying a lie or a hurtful thing to a human. That is getting things backwards.
- The severity of the kamma depends on the "level of the being" that it is directed at. It is EXTREMELY difficult to get a human life; thus a human life could be millions times worth compared to any animal life. A Sotapanna is at a more than thousand-fold higher level compared to a normal human, and the subsequent levels are even higher. There is no being in the 31 realms that is at a higher level compared to an Arahant. That is why killing an Arahant is a Anantariya pāpa kamma, i.e., it will bring extremely bad vipaka in the very next life. And it is not possible to say whether a given person is an Arahant by looking at that person, or even associating with him/her for a short time.

3. How does one discern whether one has attained, say, the Sotapanna stage?

- A Sotapanna attains the first Ariya jhana coincident with the phala moment. But if he/she had not developed jhanas previously, that first jhana may or may not become permanent. However, if he/she had developed any jhana previously, then that jhana could be attained within a moment's notice anytime. Thus, for someone who had jhanic experiences this may be a clue.

- Also, if one can get into the fourth Ariya jhana, that means one is a Sotapanna.
- Another way is to contemplate whether one is capable of doing any acts that could destine oneself to the apayas (the four lowest realms). If one has ingrained characteristics or habits (gathi) of an animal, then it is likely that person will be born animal of that character. If one has extreme hate, and is capable of plotting to bring harm to other people, then that person may be destined to the niraya. If one does not have any of such extreme greed, hate, and ignorance, then one may be free of the apayas, i.e., one is likely to be a Sotapanna.
- The Sotapanna stage is attained purely via attaining Samma Ditthi, and removing 5 of the 12 possible *akusala* cittas: 4 lobha cittas associated micca ditthi and the vicikicca citta that arises out of ignorance of the true nature of “this world”. All these 5 cittas are removed via just comprehending *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* to a certain extent; see, “[Akusala Citta – How a Sotapanna Avoids Apayagami Cittas](#)”.
- Thus if one has any ESTABLISHED (niyata) wrong views (see, “[Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)](#)”), then it is unlikely that one is a Sotapanna. Attaining the Sotapanna stage is not possible until one sees the “unfruitful nature” of existence anywhere in the 31 realms; and that is not possible if one has **ruled out** rebirth or the existence of other realms; see, “[Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)](#)”.

4. Many people believe it is necessary to meditate a lot to attain the Sotapanna stage. While it is beneficial to meditate, one can be a Sotapanna without doing any meditation. I have given some examples in #1 above.

- There are basically two main methods to get rid of lobha, dosa, moha or to attain Nibbana: “Dassanena pahathabba” (removal by vision) and “bhavamaya pahathabba” (removal by meditation).
- Various stages of Nibbana are attained as lobha, dosa, moha are removed in stages. One attains the Sotapanna stage via “dassanena pahathabba” i.e., one removes those 5 *akusala* cittas associated with “wrong views” via discerning the true nature of “this world of 31 realms”, i.e., *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.
- Then, a Sotapanna removes the remaining 7 *akusala* citta in three stages via meditation, i.e., “bhavanaya pahathabba”.
- There is no harm doing meditation before the Sotapanna stage; actually it may be helpful to calm the mind and to contemplate on *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.

Next, “[Why a Sotapanna is better off than any King, Emperor, or a Billionaire](#)“,

Sotapanna Magga and Phala – How to Distinguish

1. The word *sangha* is used nowadays to refer to the bhikkhus. Yet *sangha* is “*san*” + “*gha*”, or those who have either gotten rid or are successfully getting rid of “*san*”, and by this definition, one does not have to be a *bhikkhu* to belong to the *sangha*; see, “[What is “San”?](#)”.

In the salutation to the *sangha*, they are referred to as “*atta purisa puggala*” (“*atta*” is eight, “*purisa*” here does not mean male, but with higher virtues, and “*puggala*” means person) or a person with higher virtues. Thus there are eight types of people belonging to the *sangha*. Who are the eight?

- There are four who have entered the path (*magga*) for the four stages of *Nibbana*: *Sotapanna magga*, *Sakadagami magga*, *Anagami magga*, *Arahant magga*.
- When they receive the fruits (*phala*) of that effort in a single thought moment (*citta*), they become *Sotapanna*, *Sakadagami*, *Anagami*, *Arahant*, in a thought moment. After that thought moment, they are in the *magga* stage for the next level, except for the *Arahant*.
- It is thus clear that what we call a *Sotapanna* is really one who is on the *Sakadagami magga*, i.e., on the way to become a *Sakadagami*.

2. Thus it is also clear that, for all practical purposes, “*atta purisa puggala*” consist of the four *Ariyas* (Nobles Persons), AND those who are on the way to become *Sotapannas*. **This does not mean any Buddhist is a “*atta purisa puggala*”**; rather, a person on *Sotapanna magga* has grasped the basic “map” to reach the *Sotapanna* stage and beyond. Let us discuss this in detail below.

3. A *Sotapanna* is someone who has seen *Nibbana*, not the full *Nibbana*, but a glimpse of it. One becomes a *Sotapanna* when one removes *avijja* (ignorance) about the true status of affairs in “this world of 31 realms”; with that understanding his/her mind is purified to an extent that will not allow him/her to do an immoral act that could lead to a birth in the four lower worlds (*apayas*); not only that, one will also not “latch onto” a *kamma vipaka* resulting from such an strong immoral act in the past. Thus a *Sotapanna* will never be born in an *apaya* again.

The other three stages have similar “demarcation thresholds”.

- A *Sakadagami* will be never again be born in the human or lower four realms. He/she can still be born in the deva worlds (i.e., still could be born in *kama loka*), but those *devas* do not have “flesh and blood” bodies that lead to physical discomforts and diseases. In the *deva lokas*, beings only have fine bodies that are not subject to old age and diseases.
- An *Anagami* has overcome any desire to be born anywhere in the *kamaloka*, i.e., the 11 lowest realms. He/she has no *kama raga* (desire for sense pleasures) or *patigha* (hate).
- An *Arahant* has no desire to be born anywhere in the 31 realms, and thus will never be reborn “in this world”. He/she has attained full *Nibbana*, full release.

4. **One on the way to become a *Sotapanna*, or on the *Sotapanna magga*, is someone has not seen *Nibbana* yet, but has grasped the basic ideas of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* (*Tilakkhana*), or the “true nature of this world with 31 realms”.**

- A *Sotapanna* is someone who has seen *Nibbana*, not the full *Nibbana*, but a glimpse of it. This means he/she “sees it” at a distance and now only has to follow the path to it; he/she knows exactly what to do.

- But someone on the *Sotapanna magga* needs guidance from an *Ariya* (*Sotapanna* or above) to get to the *Sotapanna* stage, i.e., needs to be directed in the right direction.

5. Let us take a simile to see what this “demarcation” between *Sotapanna magga* and *Sotapanna phala*.

- Suppose it is known that a very valuable treasure is at the peak of a mountain, but it is not generally known where that mountain is. This is pretty much the status of Buddha Dhamma today; most people know that it is valuable, but they do not know what the right version is, and there are a lot of different versions.
- As the Buddha said in his first sermon, “my Dhamma has not been known to the world before”. Thus one needs a Buddha or a true disciple of Buddha to show him/her what *Nibbana* is and how to get to the *Sotapanna* stage. This is an important and a critical point.
- Suppose someone gets directions to the correct mountain with the treasure; then he/she knows exactly which country to go to and which geographic location in that country the mountain is located. **This person is like one who is on the path to become a *Sotapanna*.** He/she knows exactly where to go and has a detailed map. And he/she has to get it from a Buddha or a true disciple of a Buddha who has at least seen the mountain (a *Sotapanna*), if not been to the top (an *Arahant*).
- Now he/she makes the journey to country and to the region where the mountain is located. On the way to there he/she can verify the landmarks given by the “instructor” (an *Ariya*).
- Thus with confidence the person gets closer and closer to the mountain and some point starts seeing the mountain. **At that point, the person has “crossed the boundary” to become a *Sotapanna*.** He/she has seen a glimpse of *Nibbana* for the first time. Now he/she can complete the journey without any help, even if the map is lost (i.e., even in a future life).

6. Going back to the simile of the mountain with treasure, different versions of “Buddhism” correspond to identifying the mountain to be in different geographic locations, all over the world. So different groups of people are making trips over long distances and with much effort to get to different mountains. All these are in remote places and the journey is hard.

- Obviously, a lot of people are wasting their time and effort by targeting a ‘wrong mountain top’. So, how does one know which “mountain” or version to pick? This is why it takes some effort to weed out the wrong/inconsistent versions Buddha Dhamma; see, “[Why is it Critical to Find the Pure Buddha Dhamma?](#)”.

7. In technical terms, one gets on the *Sotapanna magga* when one grasps *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* to a minimum level, where one begins to realize that there is nothing in “this world” that can provide meaningful and unconditioned happiness.

- When one comprehends *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* to the extent that one can “see” this concept, **one is said to have the “*anuloma nana*”**; here, “*anu*” means “through the understanding of *Tilakkhana*”, “*lo*” means “craving for worldly things”, and “*ma*” means “removal”, and thus “*anuloma*” means “removal of craving for worldly things to some extent via the comprehension of *Tilakkhana*”.
- We came across “*anu*” also in “*anupassana*”; see, “[What do all these Different Meditation Techniques Mean?](#)”. In a previous post I also discussed how “*lobha*” comes from “*lo*” + “*bha*” or “immersed in craving for worldly things”.

- Thus it makes a huge difference if one incorrectly interprets *anicca* as “impermanence” and *anatta* as “no-self”; see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations](#)”.

8. Let us discuss one way to contemplate on *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, using an example from this life itself; it is easier to see it in lower four realms (*apayas*) that are filled with suffering.

- When one is young it seems like one can get anything one wants by working hard. But we all have seen how our parents or grandparents or even famous people spent the old age suffering with various ailments, and finally dying helplessly.
- They may have “accomplished” many things. But they spent their whole lives working hard to achieve those and then they have to leave it all behind.
- One may have a beautiful body when young, but for how long? We can see how those old movie stars age now. Some of them commit suicide because it is depressing to remember the “good old days” when one had all the attention in the world, but now it all seem to be slipping away.
- This is *anicca* and *anatta*: no matter how much we try, whatever we gain in this world last only a short time (in the *sansaric* time scale), and one becomes helpless in the long run. At some point one realizes this and becomes distraught.

9. When one comprehends the true nature of this world, such sad thoughts do not arise. People who follow the Path, and even those who have wisdom from previous lives (*gathi*) can take things in stride and realize that “all things in this world” undergo this arising/destruction process without an exception. That understanding itself leads to an ease of mind. A stronger version of this “ease of mind” is the “*anuloma shanthi*” that one experiences when attaining the “*anuloma nana*” (pronounced “*anulōma gnana*”).

- The key to attaining the “*anuloma nana*” is to realize the fleeting nature of anything in this world, i.e., a *sankata*. This is discussed in the next post.

10. The next step for one with “*anuloma nana*” is to attain the *Sotapanna* stage and to become an *Ariya* in the true sense.

- When one attains the *Sotapanna* stage, one realizes WHY nothing in this world cannot be maintained to our satisfaction.
- Anything in this world (except *nama gotta*) is a *sankata*, i.e., it comes into being, stays in existence for a time, and then inevitably is destroyed. This arising of a *sankata* is called “*udaya*” in Pali, and the destruction is called “*vaya*”; thus “*udayavaya nana*” is the knowledge about that process.
- **Many people have even attained the Arahant hood without actually having heard about these terms like “*udayavaya*” or “*anuloma*”.** Thus it is imperative to realize that just having read about these concepts does not get one anywhere. One needs to “see” the *Tilakkhana* or the unfruitfulness of craving for *sankata* (through *sankhara*) by true meditation or contemplation.
- Thus a *Sotapanna* has the *udayavaya* (sometimes called *udayabbaya*) *nana*. I will discuss that in a future post.

Next, “[Root Cause of Anicca – Five Stages of a Sankata](#)“,

How Does One Know whether the Sotapanna Stage is Reached?

1. The most precious thing sought by a *Bhauddhaya* (or a practicing Buddhist) is the *Sotapanna* stage of *Nibbana*; see, “[Why a Sotapanna is better off than any King, Emperor, or a Billionaire](#)”.

It is really the *Arahanthood* that is the ultimate goal, but when one has attained the *Sotapanna* stage, *Arahanthood* is guaranteed to follow within 7 *bhava* (which can lead to many more than 7 births; see, “[Bhava and Jati – States of Existence and Births Therein](#)”).

Thus it is important to know how to figure out whether one has attained that stage. As we discussed in another post, other than that person him/her self, only a Buddha can say whether a given person has attained *magga phala*; see, “[Myths about the Sotapanna Stage](#)”.

As we discussed in that post, even Ven. Sariputta (who is only second to the Buddha in Dhamma knowledge) could not do that even though some people today claim they know whether another person has attained the *Sotapanna* stage (and make money doing that).

2. A *Sotapanna* is one who has seen the way to *Nibbana* (or a glimpse of *Nibbana*). He/she still has more work to be do, but can see a glimpse of *Nibbana* from far. The way to *Nibbana* has become clear, and one does not need further guidance from anyone else.

In another post I described how this can be compared to a traveller who, looking for certain mountain to get to the top of it, can finally see an outline of the mountain at a distance. He/she still has to travel to the base of the mountain and climb up. But most of the hard work was to find the location of that mountain and make it to the vicinity of the mountain; see, “[The Sotapanna Stage](#)”.

3. In terms of Buddha Dhamma (where the ultimate goal is to stop the rebirth process anywhere in the 31 realms of this world), this corresponds to realizing that there is only suffering to be had by staying in this rebirth process. In particular, one has to comprehend the dangers of the rebirths in the lowest four realms.

The ONLY WAY to come to this realization is to comprehend the true nature of this world of 31 realms: *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. And that is NOT impermanence, suffering, and “no-self”; see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations](#)”.

Rather it is to realize the unfruitfulness, suffering that one undergoes in striving to reach the mirage of happiness in this world of 31 realms, and thus convince oneself that one is truly helpless in this cycle of rebirths.

Thus one realizes that the only fruitful thing to do is to work diligently to stop the suffering by “giving up the cravings for anything in this world” and strive to reach the only oasis in this desert of *sansara* (cycle of rebirths) or *Nibbana*. To release the mind from the burdens of the material world.

4. Once that idea sinks in, one’s attitude, behavior, and outlook on life will change forever.

Let us take an example. Once a child really learns the way to add two numbers, there is no way that the child will ever forget that. There will be no second guessing. If an adult, even a teacher, tells that child that “two plus three is six”, there is no way that that child will ever agree to that.

Attaining the *Sotapanna* stage is like that. Deep down one will KNOW the dangers of the rebirth process, and that any type of happiness whether due to health, wealth, or fame that can be had in this life is of NO VALUE in the long term; he /she has truly understood the value of the Buddha Dhamma, and that **faith based on understanding** will prevail through future rebirths.

This is not a “magical effect”. A living being is a continuous flow of *cittas* that started at an untraceable time in the past; see, “[What Reincarnates? – Concept of a Lifestream](#)“. Thus what happens at the *Sotapanna phala* moment is to change the “*gathi*” of that lifestream irrevocably. **One would have permanently shed any “*gathi*” suitable for a hell-being (with *gathi* of strong hate), a *peta* (strong greed), an *asura* (freeloading mentality), or an animal (a mixture all those; “*thirisan*” or all three “*san*”).**

Thus one way to assess is to see for oneself how much of such “*gathi*” have changed over the time period that one has started working towards the *Sotapanna* stage. One should be able to see **significant** changes.

5. Let us take another example. When we look in a mirror and see our reflection we KNOW that it is not another person or oneself, but merely a reflection. We don’t need to think twice to realize that it is just a reflection.

But have you seen a dog barking at its reflection in a mirror or in water? A dog thinks it is another dog, and barks at it. A dog would not know the reality of a reflection.

In the same way, a normal human thinks very highly of the material wealth, and is willing to “do whatever it takes” to achieve such material things, titles, recognitions, etc.

But a *Sotapanna* instinctively knows the unfruitfulness of such struggles and desires. Even though he/she may still be tempted by material things (and thus may still likes to eat tasty food or engage in sexual activity, for example), he/she will not willingly go to extremes such as engaging in sexual misconduct having affairs outside the marriage or being excessively greedy.

At the *Sotapanna* stage *lobha* is reduced to *kama raga* and *dosa* (or *dvesha*) is reduced to *patigha*. In other words, greed or hate that was due to total covering of mind by the five hindrances would be reduced to less strong “attachments” and “dislikes”; see, “[Lobha,Dosa, Moha versus Raga, Patigha, Avijja](#)“.

The most important thing is that he/she will NEVER do any act that is immoral enough to lead to rebirth in the lowest four realms. Just like we all KNOW that our reflection in a mirror is not real and thus will not try to talk to that reflection, a *Sotapanna* INSTINCTIVELY avoids doing anything that is highly immoral. He/she does not need to think about consequences of such acts, etc.

6. If one has developed *jhanas*, it is easier to confirm the attainment of the *Sotapanna* stage. A *Sotapanna* who can regularly get into *Ariya jhanas* can easily verify that such *jhanas* cannot be “broken”.

A *Sotapanna* who gets into even the first *Ariya jhana* can think about anything at all, and that *jhana* WILL NOT be disturbed. At the extremes one could think about the most pleasurable experience one had or play back an adult movie one had watched in one’s mind, and that *jhana* will not be disturbed.

Therefore, this is a guaranteed way of confirming the attainment of the Sotapanna stage, and is consistent with *Nibbana* being *ragakkhaya*, *dosakkhaya*, *mohakkhaya* or the “wearing out of greed, hate, and ignorance”. It happens partially, but permanently, at the *Sotapanna* stage.

This is the critical difference between *Ariya jhanas* and *anariya jhanas*. **One could develop *anariya jhanas*, and they will be instantly broken by thinking such thoughts.**

This is why a *Sotapanna* could live with the same mindset either in a mansion or in a hut. And this is also why those *yogis* who can get into higher *anariya jhanas* tend to live in remote places, away from possible temptations.

7. Similarly, one could verify the attainment of the *Anagami* stage by being able to get to the fourth

Ariya jhana.

8. However, one could be a *Sotapanna* (or even *Arahanthood*) without being able to get to any *jhana*. *Upacara* and *anuloma samadhi* are sufficient for one to get to a *magga phala*. This is a technical detail that will be discussed in the *Abhidhamma* section.

This becomes clear when we look at the possible rebirths of a *Sotapanna*. A *Sotapanna* could be reborn at or above the human realm.

But if one has attained the first *Ariya jhana* then one WILL be born in the *Brahma* realm; thus a *Sotapanna* with any *Ariya jhanas* WILL NOT be reborn human.

A *Sotapanna* can attain *Ariya jhanas* with practice.

By the way, if one has attained *anariya jhanas* and had not lost that *jhana* at the time of death he/she will also be born in a *Brahma* realm. But the difference is that he/she is not free from rebirths in even the lowest four realms in the rebirths after that.

What I described above is consistent with the extension of 89 *cittas* to 121. The “additional 40 *cittas*” come about when attaining the four stages of *Nibbana* for people at various (*anariya*) *jhana* levels; see, “[The 89 \(121\) Types of Citta](#)“. However, these are technical details that may not concern most people. I just wanted to show the consistency.

9. Even before reaching the *Sotapanna* stage, one will notice changes in one’s behavior, attitude, and how one treats not only other humans but all living beings: all those will gradually change as one starts following the Path.

But there will be significant changes after attaining the *Sotapanna* stage. That change may not be noticeable in a day; it could take weeks or a few months to see some key differences in one’s lifestyle when one looks back.

The tendency to get together with a lot people will be reduced. One will be spending more and more time learning Dhamma and contemplating on concepts that are still not quite clear. One will start to enjoy finding more about the real nature of this world.

One will also start noticing things that one had not noticed before. One will see clear instances of people’s “self-induced” suffering as they try to enjoy life by “partying harder”, but only getting exhausted in the process.

10. Then there is this question of whether it is appropriate or even allowed by the Buddha for someone to declare the *magga phala* one has attained.

What is stated in the *Tipitaka* is that if one declares that one has certain *magga phala* falsely with the intention of gaining respect, money, publicity, etc., that is a very bad *kamma*. A conventional *bhikkhu* becomes “*pārājika*“, loses the priesthood automatically, and thus could be born in the *niraya* for doing that.

Even though declaration of a *magga phala* is not encouraged, it is specifically stated that, “a person attaining the *Sotapanna* stage may declare it if he/she wishes to do so” in particular for the benefit of others.

Most people who attain *magga phala* do not declare it; it is no longer anything to boast about. It is the same with *jhanas*. Many people start off developing *jhanas* with the intention of attaining supermundane (*abhinna*) powers, but once they attain them they have already seen the fruitlessness of even those powers.

In particular, it is said that when one develops *abhinna* powers to be able to see previous lives (this

needs at least reaching the fourth *jhana*), they become so disgusted with what they (and others) had gone through in previous lives, that they do not seek to look back much further.

11. Now let us discuss some episodes from the *Tipitaka* to clarify some of the points made above.

Even though Visaka (one of the chief female lay disciples of the Buddha) had attained the *Sotapanna* stage at a young age, she remained at that stage even without developing any *jhanas* or higher *magga phala* until death at age 120. The Buddha stated that she will be reborn many times (as I remember 11 times) as human.

Similarly, the wealthy businessman Anathapindika, who built the very elegant and expensive monastery *Jetavanaramaya*, attained the *Sotapanna* stage upon hearing his first *desana* from the Buddha. He died and was reborn in the Tusita realm (one of the seven *deva* worlds). Since those *deva* worlds also belong to the *kama loka*, it is clear that he never attained an *Ariya jhana*.

Mahanama was a wealthy person who was related to Prince Siddhartha's family. He was told by the Buddha that he had attained the *Sotapanna* stage. However, when he was engaging in his business activities he often got frustrated and angry with his servants and often yelled at them. After such an episode of outburst, he would think, "if I am still able become angry like this, I must not have attained the *Sotapanna* stage yet". So, he would go to see the Buddha, explained what happened and ask whether the Buddha was certain about the declaration. He still had doubts about his attainment of the *Sotapanna* stage until the Buddha confirmed it for a third time. **The key is that there is a difference between hate (*dvesha*) and getting angry (*patigha*); *patigha* is removed only at the *Anagami* stage.**

Then there was the Sarakani *brahmin*, who also belonged to a "high caste". He used to consume alcohol and get drunk on a regular basis. His relatives, who were *vedic brahmins*, disowned him from their lot, saying that he was unworthy to be one of them. He also attained the *Sotapanna* stage, but could not give up the habit of drinking even after attaining that. When he died, Mahanama (mentioned above) asked the Buddha where Sarakani was reborn. The Buddha said Sarakani had attained the *Sotapanna* stage and has been reborn a *deva*. Sarakani's relatives laughed out loud contemptuously upon hearing this and declared, "if Sarakani was a *Sotapanna*, then we all should be *Arahants*". When Mahanama reported this back to the Buddha, the Buddha said those ignorant *brahmins* would just go by outward appearances. **This is described in the *Sarakani sutta* (several descriptions of the *sutta* can be found by doing a Google search).**

Of course that episode does not imply that one could keep doing immoral activities and still attain the *Sotapanna* stage. What we need to understand is that drinking alcohol by itself is not one of the *dasa akusala* (ten defilements), but heavy consumption could lead to it. Sarakani probably continued with his long time habit to some extent, but was unlikely to have "got drunk". **Only strong greed (*lobha*) is removed by a *Sotapanna*; *kama raga* or attachment to sense pleasures is removed only at the *Anagami* stage.**

In the *Mahanama sutta* (delivered to Mahanama mentioned above), the Buddha described the *sila* (moral conduct) of a *Sotapanna*: "*panatipata pativirato hoti, adinnadana pativirato hoti, kamesu miccacara pativirato hoti, musavada pativirato hoti, surameraya majjapama dattana pativirato hoti*". It is important to realize the deep meanings of "five precepts"; see, "[The Five Precepts – What the Buddha Meant by Them](#)".

In the above "*pativiratō hōti*" does not mean "will not" but rather "will not do with liking". After all, a *Sotapanna* (unless had attained *Ariya jhanas*) is not yet released from the 6 realms of the *kama loka*, only from the lowest four realms.

12. Some to people try to remove the sense of “me” or sense “self” to get to the *Sotapanna* stage, but that is removed only at the *Arahant* stage.

As long as one is bound to the 31 realms, there is a “life stream” with certain “*gathi*” that gives a sense of “self”. **These “*gathi*” are removed in stages, starting with “*gathi*” suitable for rebirth in the *apayas* as discussed in #4 above.** Even an *Anagami* has a sense of “self” left, even though most of his/her attachments have been removed. One cannot pass a college exam without having graduated from high school.

One has to advance systematically through stages. These are discussed in “[The Way to Nibbana – Removal of Asavas](#)” and “[Conditions for the Four Stages of Nibbana](#)”.

As long as one is bound to the 31 realms or “this material world”, it is not correct to say there is a “self” or there is “no-self”; they are both wrong and extreme views. The incorrect interpretation of *anatta* as “no-self” has been a huge obstacle to attaining the *Sotapanna* stage; see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta](#)”.

Any meditation with the wrong concepts of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* “will not grow”. One should be able to “feel” one’s meditation “grow” if one is doing correct types of meditation; see, “[How to Select and “Grow” Meditation Procedures for Magga Phala](#)”.

13. Finally, since only a Buddha could discern whether another person has attained *magga phala*, we have many instances of people declaring their attainments by themselves when that declaration helped a noble purpose.

In the *Tipitaka* it is stated that all those who participated in the first four Buddhist Councils (*Dhamma Sangayana*) were *Arahants*. Even the very first *Sangayana* was held after the *Parinibbana* of the Buddha. Thus all those many thousands of *Arahants* who attended those four *Sangayana* must have declared the *Arahantship* by themselves.

It is stated that Ven. Ananda attained the *Arahantship* just the night before the first *Sangayana*. It is also stated that he came to the Council by air (with *abhinna* powers) just to dispel any doubts from the minds of the other *Arahants* of his attainment.

There are only a relatively few instances of *Arahants* or even the Buddha performing such supernormal acts. It was important to remove any doubts of others about the *Arahantship* of Ven. Ananda because of the key role he played at the First *Sangayana*.

Gathi (Character), Anusaya (Temptations), and Asava (Cravings)

We are going to tie up a series of posts that I have posted on Gathi and Asava with this post. See, [“Habits and Goals, and Character \(Gathi\)”](#), [“The Law of Attraction, Habits, Character \(Gathi\), and Cravings \(Asava\)”](#), [“Sansaric Habits, Character \(Gathi\), Cravings \(Asava\)”](#).

It is difficult to find English translations for some of the Pali words that the Buddha used. But the key is to grasp what is meant by those terms. Once the idea is grasped, that is all that matters; one could even just use the Pali term, and KNOW what is meant by it. It is like learning the meaning of the word “dollar” or “car”. The exact same words are used in different languages, but everybody understands what is meant by those words.

1. As a given sentient being traverses the “samsara” or the “rebirth process”, it makes uncountable number of transitions from birth to birth: It may be born as a deva many times in succession, then a human many times, then a dog...etc.
 - Through all these, the physical appearance will change drastically. Thus when it makes a transition from being a deva to human, or from a human to a dog, there is no resemblance of a “personality”.
2. The only thing that keeps at least resembling a “personality” is the manomaya kaya. This is because the mamomaya kaya has the asava, anusaya, and gathi of that being transferred from “bhava” to “bhava”, for example from a “deva bhava” to “human bhava”.
 - It is important, however, to keep in mind that all three parameters are NOT FIXED; NOT PERMANENT; they keep changing even during each ‘bhava’ or even “jati”, i.e., during not only through, for example, “human bhava” but also in each “human birth” during that bhava; see, [“Bhava and Jati – States of Existence and Births Therein”](#).
3. Now let us examine to roots of the words asava and anusaya. Actually the word “āsava” is a synonym for “āsaya”. In both Pali and Sinhala, “saya” means a storage place: “jalāsaya” means a water reservoir; “āmāsaya” means the stomach where the food we eat goes to; “gabbāsaya” is the womb where the baby is kept and nurtured until it is ready to come out, etc.
 - On the other hand, “asava” also has another meaning of “what one likes”. Now you see why the two words “asaya” and ‘asava’ are synonyms. Because “one keeps what one likes”.
 - Thus “asaya” or “asava” are the things we have liked for long, long times through uncountable lives in the samsara or the rebirth process. They keep changing, but there is an unbroken flow from birth to birth. They are the deep-seated cravings we have for certain things. Not only each of us, but also each animal has its own set of such deep-seated cravings or asava or asaya.
 - [The “immoral gathi” due to asavas is what makes the akusala-mula paticca samuppada to take place and create “bhava” for the sansaric process. These “immoral gathi” are the “san gathi” in “thinnan san gathi phasso”; see, “Tanha – How We Attach Via Greed, Hate, and Ignorance”](#).
4. The asava or asaya have a wider meaning than just “craving” in the sense of something one likes. It can be one’s own set of beliefs, dislikes for certain things, etc. It defines a “dynamic personality” in the sense of a personality “in flux”, changing and evolving. This is what keeps an unbroken flow in a “lifestream of a sentient being”; see, [“What Reincarnates? – Concept of a Lifestream”](#).
5. These asava (or asaya) are the ones that give rise to anusaya or our temptations. “Anusaya”

(="anu"+"saya") means what comes out (to the mind) is according what is stored in the asaya (see above for the meaning of asaya).

- The anusaya can be triggered by an external stimulus: a lady walking by a store may suddenly stop and spend five minutes (or longer) staring at a dress in a window. But her husband, who has a different set of asava may be itching to move on; he has no interest in it.
- On the other hand, an anusaya may "just pop up" in the mind. We may be sitting at home reading a book after a meal, and all of a sudden may get an urge to "go watch a movie" or start thinking about "that annoying guy at work", or "how anyone can come up with the crazy idea of a rebirth process", etc.

6. Thus both asava (asaya) and anusaya can include many broad categories. There are four broad categories of asava: Kamasava, Bhavasava, Ditthiasava, and Avijjasava.

- Kamasava is craving for indulging in sense pleasures via the five physical senses. Within this broad category. each person will have own set of cravings: some like music more than food, and food more than reading, etc. The combinations are endless.
- Bhavasava is a craving for existence. No matter where in the 31 realms one is born, one always wants to live. Again there are many possibilities: most like the kamaloka with all five senses, some who enjoy jhanic pleasures may prefer birth in an arupaloka with just the mind, etc.
- Ditthasava is the craving or attachment to certain views. This is why sometimes it is hard to accept or even consider other views. Again, there are views on numerous topics: religion, philosophy, politics, and many combinations thereof.
- Avijjasava is of course the root cause for all asavas: not knowing the real nature of this world, i.e., not comprehending *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, and thus not comprehending the Four Noble Truths.

7. Because of these four types of asavas, 7 types of anusaya can arise: kamaragaanusaya (temptation for sense pleasures), bhavaraganusaya (instinct for existence), patighanusaya (temptation for hatred), mananusaya (pride) , ditthanusaya (wrong views), vicikiccanusaya (tendency to do the unwise), and avijjanusaya (ignorance).

- Here we see that kamaragaanusaya and patighanusaya arise from kamasava.
- Bhavaraganusaya arises from bhavasava.
- Ditthanusaya and vicikiccanusaya arise from ditthasava.
- Avijjanusaya and mananusaya arise from avijjasava.

8. It should be obvious by now how our character (gathi) is defined by our asava and anusaya.

- All three, asava, anusaya, and gathi are reinforced by each other. One has a certain character because of the set of asava and anusaya he/she has. On the other hand, unless the character is changed WILLFULLY, none of the three is going to change.
- And there is the fourth parameter of habits (called "gathi" and "huru purudu" in Sinhala), that lies at the very bottom of the hierarchy. Our habits and character depend on each other; the word "gathi" depicts a combination of the two. One CAN change one's character/habits by changing the way of one's thinking.

9. There are two key aspects in dealing with changing one's habits:

- One needs to understand the negative consequences of the bad habits and positive consequences of good habits.
- And, one needs to WILLFULLY avoid the bad habits, and WILLFULLY engage in good habits.

10. There are two action items that results from the above two observations:

- One needs to CONTEMPLATE on the consequences of good and bad habits. For that one first needs a broader view of "this world". It is not possible to appreciate the LONG-TERM consequences of one's habits unless one understands that this life is only a short stop-over in a long journey.
- The second is to fully employ "anapana", i.e., "taking in what is good" and "discarding what is bad", or "engage fully in building good habits" and "avoid bad habits".

11. This is the Path advocated by the Buddha. One could proceed a little on the Path and achieve a "sense of peace"; one could go further to make the future lives better, or one could go all the way and remove all four asava thus attaining the Arahantship.

- This is why "asavakkhaya gnana" or the "way to remove asava" is the critical knowledge that the Buddha developed on attaining the Buddhahood. And that knowledge is in the Four Noble Truths, and the way to achieve "asavakkhaya" is the Noble Eightfold Path.

12. We are fortunate to live in a time when science is providing further evidence and ways to understand this process. There is a series of posts in the 'Dhamma and Science' section starting with, "[Truine Brain – How the Mind Rewires the Brain via Meditation/Habits](#)" and in the "Meditation" section starting with, "[Key to Anapanasati – How to Change Habits and Character \(Gathi\)](#)".

Next, "[The Way to Nibbana – Removal of Asava](#)",

The Way to Nibbana – Removal of Asavas

1. The night the Buddha attained the Buddhahood, three special knowledges (*tivijja*) arose in him, namely:

the special vision with which he was able to recollect innumerable former existences (*pubbenivasanussati nana*).

the special vision with which he was able to see beings passing away and being reborn according to their *kamma* (*chutupapada nana*); and

the special vision with which he was able to destroy all cankers or defilements (*asavakkhaya nana*).

2. With the attainment of the *asavakkhaya nana*, Sidharata Gotama became Buddha Gotama. This was the final step in purifying the mind. This was the fruit of all his efforts, the path to attaining *Nibbana* for any being. *Asavakkhaya* (*asava*+*khaya* = cutting off all the *asavas* or mental fermentations). Thus *Asavakkhaya nana* means the knowledge of cutting off *asavas* and thus freeing the mind from the ability to generate any defilement.

The term *asava* comes from “*āsraṇavāṭa āva*” in Sinhala or Pali, which means “came to association with”. Thus those habits (“*gathi*”) that one keeps associating with come even closer. As one continues and feeds those habits through successive rebirths, they become *asavas*.

Asava (in Pali, Sinhala, and Sanskrit) also means a distillation to get an extract or essence. Some medicinal concoctions are fermented by keeping a mixture of ingredients underground for many months.

Some habits (“*gathi*”) we have cultivated (or fermented) over innumerable lives and that is why they are hard to remove. Only through learning pure Dhamma and persistence in one’s efforts, one can break such bad habits and thus eventually *asava*. There are four types of *asava* and each may be associated with many bad habits.

3. The doctrine of *Paticcasamuppada*, which is made up of twelve factors, namely, *avijja*, *sankhara*, *vinna*, *nama rupa*, *salayatana*, *phassa*, *vedana*, *tanha*, *upadana*, *bhava*, *jati*, *jara*, *marana* became clear to him. Going over this Doctrine of *Paticcasamuppada* in forward and reverse order repeatedly, he attained the Eightfold Noble Path, *Ariya Magga*, which is also known as *Yathabhuta Nanadassana*.

4. *Paticcasamuppada* clarifies how ignorant beings accumulate defilements (and *asavas*), and get trapped in the round of rebirths (*samsara*); these *asavas* are fermented via repeated use of bad habits (“*gathi*”). And the Noble Eightfold Path is the way to remove those “*gathi*” (and thus *asavas*) from the mind.

How Four Stages of Nibbana are Connected to the Four Asavas

1. We all have four major types of *asavas*, even though there are uncountable minor varieties:

Ditthasava is the category that is due to all kinds of false beliefs (*micca ditthi*): for example, if someone does not believe in rebirth, there may be cravings such as “I need to enjoy everything before I die”.

Kamasava are associated with sense pleasures.

Bhavasava is the craving for particular kind of existence, say as a human, deva, or a brahma.

Avijjasava is all cravings that arise due to ignorance; ignorance of the Noble Truth of Suffering (which is NOT merely suffering itself), and the other Noble Truths.

2. The four types of major *asavas* are removed in a step-by-step process as one proceeds on the Path. Even before the *Sotapanna* stage, one will be reducing them, but those reductions do not hold to future lives.

When one attains the *Sotapanna* stage, all four types of *asavas* that could trigger “*apayagami*” actions are permanently removed from one’s mind, i.e., one will never be reborn in the four lowest realms. *Ditthasava* (those due to wrong views) are completely removed.

At the *Sakadagami* stage, *kamasava* and *bhavasava* are reduced, and a *Sakadagami* will be born only as a *deva* or above in future lives; *avijjasava* is also reduced.

Kamasava are completely removed at the *Anagami* stage, and thus one will never be reborn in the *kamaloka* (including the *deva* realm) again. *Bhvasava* and *avijjasava* are also reduced.

Bhvasava and *avijjasava* are removed without a trace at the *Arahant* stage. Thus *asavakkhaya* becomes complete.

Removal of *asavas* start with the removal of bad habits and cultivating good habits; see, “[Habits and Goals](#)“, “[The Law of Attraction, Habits \(Gathi\), and Cravings \(Asavas\)](#)“, and, “[Sansaric Habits and Asavas](#)“.

Is there a Connection Between Nibbana and Kamma?

1. Many people have the misconception that, “one needs to deplete all *kamma*” to attain *Nibbana*. First of all, *kamma* (or *sankhara*) are actions and that have been done (either in this life or in previous lives); while some of the *kammic* power associated with them can be removed by *metta bhavana*, for example, some *kamma beeja* (both good and bad) due to those *kamma* may still be there at the time of the attainment of *Nibbana*.

Even the Buddha had eleven *kamma vipaka* left that resulted in backaches and a stomach ailment close to *Parinibbana*, among others. Because in order to get rid of *kamma* seeds associated with a given *kamma*, the other being associated with that *kamma* seed need to be able to receive the merits of *metta bhavana*, i.e., that being need to have a state of mind with *alobha*, *adosa*, and *amoha*. But some of those beings may be trapped in the *niraya* for long times and may not even have a moment of “relief” to receive such merits. I will discuss this in a separate post, but the key idea is discussed in, “[Transfer of Merits \(Pattidana\) – How Does it Happen?](#)“.

2. What really happens is that when *asavas* are removed, the ***akusala-mula paticca samuppada*** at “*vedana paccaya tanha*” step changes to “*vedana paccaya adhimokko*” (in a ***kusala-mula paticca samuppada*** cycle) and there is no “*upadana paccaya bhavo*” step in the cycle. Thus when the *Arahant* dies, there is no “*bhava*” grasped by the mind, and thus there is no “*jathi*” or birth.

3. Thus an *Arahant* could have many unspent *kamma beeja* (both good and bad) left, but his/her mind has lost the craving (*asava*) to grasp any of them.

4. “Everything happens due to *kamma*” is a misconception. That is a *Vedic* concept, and is not in Buddha Dhamma; see, “[sankhara, kamma, kamma beeja, kamma vipaka](#)“. The *asavakkhaya nana* is the key to *Nibbana*.

Next, “[Why is Correct Interpretation of Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta so Important?](#)“,

Why is Correct Interpretation of Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta so Important?

The correct meanings of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* are explained under the top menu “[Key Dhamma Concepts](#)”.

1. *Anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* describe the true nature of “this world” of 31 realms; see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)“. Nowhere in the 31 realms can one maintain anything to one’s satisfaction over the long term; thus one gets depressed, unfulfilled, and distraught (suffering is the net result). Thus one becomes helpless (*anatta*).
2. A good analogy is someone attempting to fill a leaky vessel at home by carrying water to it from a nearby river. He makes a trip back from the river, fills the vessel and is glad to see that it got filled halfway. But soon enough he sees that water is running out and thus needs to make another trip to the river to bring more water. If he spent a bit of time examining the vessel, he would have discovered the leak, and could have fixed it. We are too much involved in the struggle to maintain an illusory happiness, and we do not take enough time to contemplate whether it makes sense to struggle against a system that is INHERENTLY unsuitable to provide lasting happiness.
3. Before the retirement, I was basically working seven days a week. I had deadlines to meet and responsibilities to fulfil and there was no time to even think whether I should take some time off and contemplate the sensibility of such a hectic life. Whatever vacation time that I had, I wanted to plan a “relaxing vacation”. But I did not realize that I was spending more time planning the vacation and then spent whatever the energy that I had on sightseeing etc. When I got back from the vacation, I was exhausted from the trip itself. The early retirement decision was the best decision that I ever made in my life.
4. If this existence is inherently flawed in the sense that it is not capable of sustaining stability at all, then all the struggles that we make are in vain. The Buddha discovered that everything in “this world” is in constant flux at a very high rate (see “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”). It is INHERENTLY impossible to achieve a lasting happiness. Now the question is how do we know whether this axiom in Dhamma is correct? This is where it takes a bit of time to look at the evidence. I have done a lot of work within the past several years and hopefully this website will help you cut down on that research.
5. After looking at the evidence, if one decides to spend a bit more time to carefully examine the three characteristics (*anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*), one may see that there is some truth to it. This will set one off on the Dhamma Path. If there is nothing substantial or long lasting to be had by harming other living beings, stealing from them, lying to them, indulging in excess sense pleasures, or not being intoxicated with power, money or position, one’s life will automatically change for the better. The five precepts or eight precepts are NOT to be just mechanically followed. The mind needs to SEE the benefit of following them.
6. This is why one MUST spend some time examining the evidence for the validity of Buddha Dhamma. The first stage of Nibbana, Sotapanna stage, is attained just with the clear understanding of the true nature of “this world”, i.e., *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. When one realizes the futility of the struggle for long lasting happiness in a world that is inherently not capable of providing it, one will automatically start moving away from clinging to “things in this world”. For example, one will say to oneself, “what is the point of stealing this from another person? What long lasting happiness can be

gained from it? Rather my mind will be in an agitated state if I do that”. There is no need to force oneself to obey the precepts. Moral behavior (*sila*) will automatically follow the true understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. Then, when one starts feeling a bit of *niramisa sukha*, there is no turning back, because one can see for oneself the benefits of a moral life.

7. Thus *Samma Ditthi* (*san + ma + ditthi* = vision to get rid of defilements) is none other than the true comprehension of the three characteristics, *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.

When one gains a bit of *Samma Ditthi* (vision), it will try to prevent one from having defiled thoughts (*Samma Sankalpa*), uttering false speech (*Samma Vaca*), doing wrong things (*Samma Kammanta*), pursuing wrong lifestyles (*Samma Ajiva*). One will also make efforts (*Samma Vayama*) to be on the Path, which will lead to be constantly be mindful (*Samma Sati*), thus leading to *Samma Samadhi* (peaceful and focused state of mind).

This is why the Buddha said, “*Dhammo ha ve rakkati dhamma cari*”, or, “once one sees the Dhamma, Dhamma will guide, protect, and direct”.

Thus, gaining *Samma Ditthi* via contemplating on *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* will automatically direct one on the Noble Eightfold Path. This is why removing *micca ditthi* via true understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, is so important.

7. When one proceeds in this manner, one will attain the *Sotapanna* stage of *Nibbana*, as these three basic concepts take hold in the mind. At that point, the mind will automatically reject doing things that will result in rebirth in lower four realms. These are the four greed-based *cittas* that arise due to *micca ditthi* (wrong vision), and the delusion-based *citta* that arises due to defiled *vinna* (*vicikicca*). This is why a *Sotapanna* is prevented from a rebirth in the lower four realms forever.

8. When one attains the *Sotapanna* stage, one may still have greed, hate, and delusion left in him/her. But a *Sotapanna* KNOWS about them, and KNOWS how to get rid of them. Then it is just a matter of time before getting rid of those defilements and attaining the other three stages, culminating in ultimate peace and permanent happiness, *Nibbana*.

Next, “[The Sotapanna Stage](#)“,

How to Cultivate the Noble Eightfold Path starting with Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta

1. Before one starts on a journey one needs to decide why one should take the journey, exactly where one is going to, and the correct path towards that destination. Thus it is worthwhile to examine why the Buddha said our goal should be to move away from this world towards Nibbana, why he said that, why one should believe that to be true, and what the correct path towards that goal is. The Buddha himself recommended that approach:

- One starts on the Noble Eightfold Path with Samma Ditthi, which means the needed “vision” on why, what to expect at the end, and an idea about the path to achieve it.
- Out of the twelve *akusala* cittas, five are permanently removed when one attains the Sotapanna stage: the four greedy cittas that arise with wrong view (“ditthi sahagatha”), and the delusion citta based on vicikicca. All five of these cittas arise because one does not know the true nature of the world; all kamma that lead one to rebirth in the apayas are done with these five cittas. Thus when they are removed by partially completing Samma Ditthi at the Sotapanna stage, one is permanently prevented from accumulating kamma that destines one to a rebirth in the lowest four realms (apayas).
- Furthermore, any such apayagami kamma seeds previously accumulated are prevented from proving a potent enough nimitta at the moment of death; thus birth in the apayas is automatically prevented.
- Looking at it from another angle, out of the 10 sanyojanas (those that binds one to sansara), three are removed at the Sotapanna stage: sathkaya ditthi (the idea that all actions one does with the six sense bases to achieve amisa sukha are beneficial), vicikicca (distorted mindset), and silabbata paramasa (the idea that Nibbana can be attained just by following precepts, without purifying one’s mind). All three are due to not having Samma Ditthi, or not knowing the true nature of the world: *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.
- In the Sabbasava Sutta, there are seven recommended methods for removing defilements for anyone starting on the Path. The first item on the list describes how one can get rid of a bulk of defilements just with correct vision of “this world”, i.e., “dassanena pahathabba”; this is what was discussed above.
- Once one understands the true nature of “this world” and understands how to remove the rest of the defilements, then the other six steps are taken, of which “bhavaneya pahathabba” (i.e., removal by meditation) comes last. Today, most people start meditating without clearly understanding what to meditate about.

2. Thus, first one needs to understand why we need to escape from “this world”.

- The three characteristics of “this world” (see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta](#)”) tell us that we can NEVER achieve AND maintain whatever we desire (characteristic of *anicca*), thus we mostly end up with suffering (*dukkha*), and thus one is not in control and becomes helpless (*anatta*). The Buddha merely DISCOVERED this true nature of the world. Many people take Buddha Dhamma to be pessimistic, but Buddha was just a messenger.
- Moreover, the Buddha gave us an optimistic message too. For those who are willing to examine the true nature of the world, there is a better version of happiness that comes from moving away

from “this world”, i.e., by voluntarily giving up craving for things in this world. This is the niramisa sukha of Nibbana (see, “[Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)”, which increases as one starts on the Path and becomes complete and PERMANENT at the Arahant stage. Even if one does not get to the first stage of Nibbana, the Sotapanna stage, one could experience this niramisa sukha, and may help shorten the path to Nibbana in the upcoming lives.

3. Therefore it is CRITICAL to understand *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, before we proceed further here. If you have not done so, please spend some time critically examining and contemplating on these concepts described under many posts on this website, in particular, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta](#)”, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)” and the links following that on “[Sansaric Time Scale](#)“, and “[Evidence for Rebirth](#)“, and “[Why is Correct Interpretation of Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta so Important?](#)“. It may be even helpful for many to scan through many other posts before reading those posts.

- That is a lot of reading. But “this world” of 31 realms is very complex. Please keep re-reading all posts until you understand the message. Most of these concepts have been hidden for thousand years, and have been badly distorted, especially *anicca* and *anatta*. **Think about the fact that all biological matter is constituted from just four bases of DNA, and all computer codes are based on two units, 0 and 1.** Thus, one could see how complex the “whole existence” with 31 realms is when there are 28 types of rupa, 89 types of citta and 52 types of cetasikas are involved!

4. The main conclusion from *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* is “asarattena *anatta*”, i.e., “*anatta* in the sense of it is fruitless to crave for anything in this world”. Thus the Buddha said, “anissitoca viharathi, na ca kinci loke upadiyathi”, i.e., “There is nothing in this world that is fruitful, there is nothing to be craved”.

- People “behave badly” in order to “get what they perceive to be valuable”. All immoral acts are done to “get what we want”. We crave for something and greed arise, and then when we don’t get what we wish for, we get angry and hate arises. We first think bad thoughts (*mano sankhara*), then follow through with bad words (*vaci sankhara*), and bodily action (*kaya sankhara*). We do all this because we do not have an understanding of the true nature of the world, i.e., *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, and related facts: knowledge of the rebirth in a wider world of 31 realms with suffering. Thus we do all other bad acts with established wrong views (*niyata micca ditthi*); see, “[Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)](#)“.

5. Now let us see what happens when one starts learning the true nature of the world including *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, and ALSO the consequences of immoral actions: Then one thinks, “Is it worthwhile to steal from someone to get what I want, which in the end will do me more harm than good (because nothing provides permanent happiness, AND one has to pay the price of an immoral action if not in this life but in upcoming lives?)”.

- Same for any other immoral act: to hurt someone by, uttering false, slandering, harsh, or frivolous speech; stealing, killing, or engaging in sexual misconduct (hurting other parties involved). AND all those start with covetousness, ill-will, and all those are done because of established false views that fruitful things can be had in this world by hurting others without any bad consequences for oneself.

6. Thus when one is about to think of doing such a bad deed or having bad thoughts, this “clear vision” or *samma ditthi* will help get rid of such thoughts and instead think, “this person is in the same boat, struggling to survive in a world setup for failure”. Thus instead of bad thoughts one will

have thoughts of fellowship and compassion for other beings. Also one will be working to learn more Dhamma and will be constantly thinking about Dhamma concepts like *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*; the joy from deeper understanding will provide incentive to dig deeper on concepts that are not clear. Thus Samma Ditthi leads to the next step in the Noble Eightfold Path: Samma Sankappa.

7. With such a mindset one will avoid the four forms of bad speech (lying, slandering, vicious talk, vain talk), because one realizes that such acts will only be one's own loss of peace of mind as well as hurting others. Thus one will start living with Samma Vaca; also see, "[Right Speech – How to Avoid Accumulating Kamma](#)".

8. Similarly, one will clearly see that there is no point in engaging in immoral bodily acts (killing, stealing, and sexual misconduct) in order to get some temporary satisfaction, which in the end will come back to haunt oneself with magnified bad consequences. This will AUTOMATICALLY guide one to act in a moral fashion, i.e., one will have Samma Kammanta.

9. In standard texts, it says one will not undertake the five lifestyles that are to be avoided:

- (a) Dealing and killing animals for meat trade.
- (b) Dealing in poisons.
- (c) Dealing in weapons and arms.
- (d) Dealing in slave trade and prostitution.
- (e) Dealing in intoxicants or liquors and drugs.

- Samma ajiva is more than that. Thus one's lifestyle will automatically change to not only moral living, but also to avoid any kind of act which will be harmful to oneself and/or others. One will take care of one's responsibilities towards one's family and the society, because otherwise one will get in deeper debt, and will not have the mindset to contemplate; see, "[Kamma, Debt, and Meditation](#)".
- **Following the Path is much more than just abandoning everything and becoming a bhikkhu or just following some guidelines or precepts. It needs to be done with wisdom gained through learning Dhamma. This is Samma Ajiva.**

10. As one feels the benefits of such a lifestyle, one will start feeling the niramisa sukha (see, "[Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)"). Then one will be motivated to stay on that Path, and also to learn more about the Buddha Dhamma and to contemplate more on the Three Characteristics (one is said to have a complete understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* only when one reaches the Arahant hood or full Nibbana). This renewed effort is Samma Vayama.

11. The above six factors will make one's mind purified and one will start "seeing" better. One will start working with "yoniso manasikara" (clear vision). It is more than clear thinking; even a master thief plans his work with clear thinking (on the wrong side). Here what it means is one always looks at any issue with *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* in the mind: that it is not possible to maintain things to our satisfaction in the long run; that the more we attach either via greed or hate, the more will suffer; that it is unwise to do immoral things for temporary happiness to become helpless at the end. This is Samma Sati.

12. When one starts meditating (and this does not have to be last; one can start slowly from the beginning), **one will be easily able to get to Samma Samadhi**, focused attention (ekaggata). The more one proceeds on the Path (i.e., the more the mind becomes purified), easier samadhi starts to grow in oneself; one starts feeling a "lightness" even when not doing formal meditation. If one

works on developing jhanas, one will be able to get to Ariya jhanas. Whether one will be using meditation on the Three Characteristics, Satipattana, or any other other type of mediation, that will eventually lead to the four levels of Nibbana.

13. It is important to realize that “Samma” in all these eight steps means “san” (adding things to perpetuate the suffering/rebirth process) + “”ma” (remove or get rid of). Thus Samma Ditthi is the vision (*anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*) that helps removing “san”; Samma Sankappa are the thoughts that help remove ‘san’; Samma Vaca is the kind of speech that helps remove ‘san’, etc. Thus, one adheres to the eight steps through the UNDERSTANDING of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, and not merely for the sake of following some guidelines or precepts. One understand the futility of continuing this rebirth process.

Next, “[Akusala Citta – How a Sotapanna Avoids Apayagami Citta](#)“,

Akusala Citta – How a Sotapanna Avoids Apayagami Citta

1. First I need to clarify the title. Of course *citta* (pronounced “chittha”) are thoughts. All *kamma* start as *mano sankhara*, i.e., one starts thinking about something and it escalates into speech and bodily action by the “wheeling” or “*riya*” process; see, “[Nibbana – Stopping of the Sansaric Vehicle](#)”.

- The complete cessation of doing *sankhara* happens only when one becomes an *Arahant*. But after attaining the *Sotapanna* stage, this “wheeling process” stops for certain types of initial thoughts or *citta*.

2. We have seen that *apaya* is a common word for the lowest four realms of existence, see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”. *Apāyagāmi* (“*apāya*” + “*gāmi*” means directed towards) *citta* are those that lead to potent *kamma* responsible for rebirth in the lowest four realms.

3. So, what *cittas* or thoughts gets one started on the “wheeling process” or a “thought process” that leads to speech or bodily action of very bad consequences, i.e., birth in the *apayas*? These are thoughts that arise because one does not have a full understanding of the “nature of this world”, i.e., the *Tilakkhana*, or *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.

Out of the 89 possible *citta* (see, “[The 89 Types of Citta](#)”) 12 are immoral *citta*:

- 8 with *lobha* (greed) roots
- 2 with *dosa* (hate, ill will) roots
- 2 with *moha* (ignorance) roots

ALL TEN immoral acts (*dasa akusala*; see, “[Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)](#)”) are done with these 12 types of *citta*.

4. We generate greedy thoughts because we “want to get possession of things that seem to provide happiness”. When we do not get what we want, we generate hate or ill will towards whoever is in the way.

- And we do both types of actions because we do not realize that it is not possible to achieve lasting happiness with anything in “this world”. Not only that, we do not realize that by doing those bad actions we accumulate bad *kamma* that are going to have bad consequences in the future, either in this very life or in future lives.
- Thus ignorance of the true nature of “this world” is the cause of all bad actions done with greed and hate. We also do certain bad actions just based on ignorance too, like comparing how one is “better” than another, etc.

A. The [two ignorance-rooted citta](#) are:

- One associated with *vicikicca* (*vichi+ki+ichcha* = liking based on distorted view, i.e., *ditthi*). Commonly *vicikicca* is described as “doubt”, which could be taken as “doubt about the true world view”. Just like a fish biting on a bait due to not “seeing” the hook, we just grab things without “seeing” the consequences, i.e., possible harm to others and the consequences of such harmful actions for ourselves.
- One associated with *uddhacca* (restlessness or agitation of the mind). This is opposite of *samadhi* or ability to concentrate and being able to think through consequences of actions. One could have *uddhacca* even if one knows the “true nature” of this world; it is sort of a

cumulative result of all defilements accumulated through beginning-less *sansara*. This is completely removed only at the *Arahant* stage.

All 12 types of *citta* have ignorance as a root (primary as in the above two types) or as secondary in the other ten *citta*. These ten *citta* can be divided into two categories in another way, i.e., based on whether such *cittas* arise mainly due to *vicikicca* (i.e., due to not knowing the true nature of this world) or *uddhacca* (i.e., the agitation of the mind due to all accumulated defilements).

B. Out of the [eight greed-rooted citta](#), four arise with wrong view (*ditthi*), i.e., due to lack of understanding of the “true nature of this world”, and that “this world” is much more complex than we perceive with our senses, and that our life does not end here, but what we do will have consequences for very long times into the future. The other four are done anyway, even with right view, because of the agitation of the mind due to all “gunk” accumulated over the long *sansaric* journey. Thus the eight greed-based *citta* can be divided into two broad categories:

- Four done with wrong views (*ditthi*) are removed at the *Sotapanna* stage.
- Four dissociated from wrong view (i.e., it does not matter whether one has right view if defilements still cloud the mind, for example even one who has attained the *Sotapanna* stage)

C. The [two hate-rooted citta](#) are also done regardless of whether one has right view or not:

- These two hate-rooted *citta* are dissociated with wrong views, but are due to the agitated mind (*uddhacca*). Thus they persist after the *Sotapanna* stage.

Now we can see the broad view:

5. Five *cittas* (*vicikicca* and the four greed-rooted *citta* associated with wrong view) arise because one does not know the true nature of the world, *Tilakkhana*, i.e, *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. They contribute to one of the four types of *asava* called the *ditthi asava* or *ditthasava*.

These are the same *citta* that could lead to *apayagami kamma*. [Thus when one attains the Sotapanna stage, these five citta cease to arise forever, and one WILL NOT BE ABLE to do any such grave kamma.](#) Thus, the *Sotapanna* stage is a very important stage of *Nibbana* where *asavakkhaya* happens to a significant level due to the removal of *ditthasava*:

- A *Sotapanna* attains that stage just by getting rid of *ditthi* or wrong views: *sathkaya* (or *sakkaya*) *ditthi* is the view that lasting happiness can be attained via pursuing things in this world. *Vicikicca* leads to tendencies and actions associated with wrong worldviews, and *silabbata paramasa* is the view that *Nibbana* can be attained by following specific precepts/rituals without cleansing the mind.
- The other seven *citta* are the ones that are harder to remove. They arise due to an agitated mind which is a result of other defilements (*asavas*) that we have accumulated over the long *sansara*; see. [“The Way to Nibbana – Removal of asavas”](#).
- Out of these, the two hate-rooted *citta* are lessened in strength at the *Sakadagami* stage and are removed at the *Anagami* stage.
- The remaining four greed-rooted *citta* (those dissociated from wrong views) contribute to *kamaraga* (greed for things in the *kamaloka*). *Kamaraga* is lessened at the *Sakadagami* stage and completely removed at the *Anagami* stage. Thus an *Anagami* is unable to generate hateful thoughts or lustful thoughts, and is free from rebirth anywhere in the *kamaloka*. An *Anagami* has removed *kamasava*, another part of the *asava*.
- Finally, it is only at the *Arahant* stage that those remaining four greed-rooted *citta* (which still

contribute to *bhavasava*) and the *uddhacca citta* (which still contribute to *avijjasava*) are completely removed. This is when all the defilements or *asavas* are completely removed from one's mind.

6. It is clear that all five *akusala citta* that are removed at the *Sotapanna* stage arise due to *micca ditthi*, i.e., not comprehending the Three Characteristics of existence: *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. Also see, “[Kilesa \(Defilements\), Ditthi \(Wrong Views\), Samma Ditthi \(Good/Correct Views\)](#)”.

7. This realization of correct views CANNOT be attained by following rituals, such as just obeying precepts. It comes naturally when one COMPREHENDS the true nature of this world of 31 realms: *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*; see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – True Meanings](#)“. That it is unfruitful to involve in any kind of activities to gain mundane pleasures by hurting other beings. Such an understanding makes irrevocable changes in one's *manomaya kaya*, and thus prevents one from doing such activities even in the future lives.

8. Now it is important to realize that a *Sotapanna* can be a parent taking care of a family. He/she will be doing a job, driving kids to school, and doing all other daily tasks. But one does all this with the clear understanding that one should NOT do certain things. One could live a moral life suitable for a *Sotapanna* without giving up ANY responsibilities as a regular “householder”. Actually one could even attain the *Anagami* stage without becoming a *bhikkhu*. And there were many “householders” that had attained *Sotapanna*, *Sakadagami*, *Anagami* stages at the Buddha's time; there are some even today.

Difference Between Giving Up Valuables and Losing Interest in Worthless

1. As long as one considers something to be valuable, it is not easy to give it up, It does not matter what ANYONE ELSE says. One will go to much effort and expense to make sure it stays with oneself.
 - But if one's own mind sees that something is useless and worthless, then what is the point of keeping it? One will gladly get rid of it.
 - One's perception of the "world out there" and "what is valuable and what is not" depends on one's mind. Even though we look at a pile of feces with disgust, a dog or a pig may eat it with relish. And a dog does not have any cravings for gold or money.
 - While some people gain pleasure by torturing animals, most are disgusted by such acts. It depends on the level or understanding. A purified mind will see things in a better perspective.
2. The common thinking about Buddhism goes like this: "The Buddha said that this rebirth process is full of suffering, and to stop the rebirth process we need to give up everything in this world to detach from it. But that is not easy to do. I like the stuff that I have and I enjoy life. May be I can attain *Nibbana* in a future life".
 - That is not a correct interpretation of what the Buddha said. The Buddha did say that "this rebirth process is full of suffering". He never asked anyone to give up anything that they had. His only advice was "learn the true nature of this wider world of 31 realms that is characterized by *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* and realize the dangers in staying in it".
 - If one truly understood the true nature of the world one's own mind will see the futility of hanging onto worldly things. *Nekkhamma* or "giving up" is not done forcibly, IT JUST HAPPENS when one comprehends the true nature of "this world".
3. If one understands the above few paragraphs, then one knows more about Buddha Dhamma compared to 90% of the "Buddhists". Even many *Theravada bhikkhus* say, "May you attain *Nibbana* after enjoying future lives in Deva realms", or "May you have much worldly pleasures and attain *Nibbana* when the next Buddha [*Maitreya* (Sanskrit), *Metteyya* (Pali), *Maithree* (Sinhala)] appears in the world". They apparently do not comprehend the dangers in staying in the rebirth process.
 - This is in sharp contrast with Buddha Gotama's last words, "*appamadena sampadeta*" or "strive diligently and comprehend *san*" (and attain *Nibbana*)", because this rebirth process is wrought with unimaginable dangers. Even if we live perfectly moral lives, we do not know what kind of kamma that we have done in past lives, and thus there is no way to guarantee a good rebirth unless one attains [the Sotapanna stage](#) and makes those worst *kamma beeja* ineffective.
 - This life of about 100 years is just a "blink of an eye" compared to trillions of years in future lives (unless one attains *Nibbana*); but it is also [unimaginably precious](#) because we very rarely get a chance to be born human and most living beings are in the lowest four realms; see, "[How the Buddha Described the Chance of Rebirth in the Human Realm](#)".
4. Buddha Dhamma is all about PURIFYING one's mind so that the mind can grasp the true nature of this world. The only actions one needs to take are to live a moral life, gradually adhere to a lifestyle that avoids the ten defilements (*dasa akusala*), AND learn Dhamma, in particular truly understand *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. Everything else will fall into place.

- When one purifies one's mind, it becomes clear that the things that one believes to be valuable are not valuable at all, AND such cravings can bring so much suffering in the future. But one cannot take that advice coming from even a Buddha and act on it forcibly; ONE'S MIND HAS TO SEE IT.
- One may take many precautions to safeguard a "gem" that one thinks has much value. But if the gem is assessed by an expert and is found to be worthless, then one will no longer have the same "attachment" for the "gem" and may throw it away. But until the perception is there in the mind that the "gem" is valuable, one will not part with it.

5. There is another aspect of this forcibly giving up. In addition to the fact that one will be under stress if one tries to do that, one may be accumulating bad *kamma vipaka* if one acts irresponsibly. For example, if one decides that he needs to become a *bhikkhu* and abandons his kids and wife, that is an unwise thing to do.

- We have to act mindfully and with wisdom, making sure that we do not hurt ourselves, our families, or anyone else. Buddha Dhamma is all about the mind, and not about mechanically doing meaningless rituals. As we discussed in several posts, it is the intention and the enthusiasm for doing good, that really matters.
- One can progress all the way up to the *Anagami* stage of *Nibbana* as a "householder", i.e., while fulfilling one's responsibilities as a husband/wife, parent, etc. While one should certainly give to charity, one needs to make sure that there is enough left to support one's family. And it is not possible to contemplate or meditate if one has to worry about the next meal or a place to stay.

6. As one makes progress, giving up will happen automatically **at the level of one's understanding**, and as needed. One does not have to make plans in advance about what to give up or anything like that: "*Dhammo ha ve rakkati dhamma cari*", or "Dhamma will guide and protect those who follow the Path". As the mind becomes clear of the hindrances, one will make better decisions, and will not hurt anyone in the process.

7. About 20 years after the Buddha attained Enlightenment, he had to start adding "*vinaya* rules" for the *bhikkhus*. When Buddha Dhamma started flourishing, many unscrupulous people started to enroll as *bhikkhus* to enjoy "a good life". The Buddha admonished that such *bhikkhus* accumulate much bad *kamma* by getting indebted to those people who make offerings out of *saddha*.

- *Vinaya* ("vi"+"naya" where "*naya*" means debt) means stay free of debts. The *bhikkhus* can do that by diligently pursuing *Nibbana* and also by explaining Dhamma to those people, while making sure not to abuse their privileged life where they are honored for these very acts.

8. Getting to debt is bad for lay people too. All our current responsibilities have their origins in the past where we became indebted to others. It may take a while to comprehend this, but we are really paying off debts to even our kids. And if we do not do a good job of it, we WILL have to do it in future lives. Any other relationship is the same way; see, "[Kamma, Debt, and Meditation](#)".

- One time a *bhikkhu* started sharing his food from the alms round with his parents, and other *bhikkhus* complained to the Buddha. The Buddha asked why he did that he said his parents had become beggars and that is why he did that. The Buddha praised that *Bhikkhu* and officially endorsed it as a *vinaya* rule, that *bhikkhus* can take care of their parents if the need arose. Even as a *Bhikkhu*, one is obliged to take care of one's parents.

9. When someone gets help from another, it is the obligation of the receiver to show his/her gratitude

for that kindly act, by doing a pattidana or “giving merits” to that person; see, “[Transfer of Merits \(Pattidana\) – How does it Happen?](#)”. If the receiver becomes able to pay back in kind, that should be done too.

- When we deal with people in everyday life, we are engaged in paying back debts even unknowingly. Thus it is a good idea to fulfil one’s responsibilities to the best of one’s ability. This applies to most everyday things we do. Our employment responsibilities needs to be done to the best of our ability. When we do not fulfil our responsibilities anywhere, we stay indebted and accumulate more debt with interest.
- When doing transactions, we need to make sure that everyone is compensated adequately; otherwise, such debts will have to be paid in the future. Again, intention and the “state of mind” are key factors: We may be able to fool other people, but we cannot fool our own minds.
- We have enemies because we have had conflicts with them before. And someone has to break that vicious cycle. This is why the *Dhammapada* verse, “*na hi verena verani....*” says: “Hatred never ceases through hatred, but through love alone they cease”. This is an eternal law.

10. Beings in the lower four realms DO NOT HAVE an advanced mental state to affect their future even short term, i.e., in this life; they are simply paying off debts and paying for their immoral acts in the past. They just “go with the flow” spending *kammic* energy that has been accumulated; unless they are fortunate to receive the benefits of a “good kamma beeja” from the past (when they were in higher worlds) at the time of death, they are stuck in the lower realms.

- On the other hand, HUMANS CAN totally change their future, within this lifetime (mundane progress), but also affect the future lives: If one wants to avoid the niraya (hell) one needs to remove the causes that could cause rebirth in niraya, i.e., deep hate. If one wants to avoid rebirth as a hungry ghost (*peta loka*), then one need to remove causes for that, i.e., excessive greed. If one don’t wants to be reborn an animal one needs to remove both greed and hate. To avoid birth as an asura, one needs to take care of oneself, and not depend on others.

11. Buddha Dhamma is a complete theory on existence. EVERYTHING can be explained in a systematic way. If everyone can grasp the basic message of the Buddha, our world will be much safer place.

- When a tree is growing all we need to do is to water it, provide nutrients, and generally take care of it; the fruits from the tree will come out naturally. No amount of praying or wishing is going to get the tree to give more fruits. In the same way, when we follow the Path correctly, everything else will “fall into place”. There is no need to pray or to make wishes or do anything else.
- This world, for all its drawbacks, plays by the rules. Things just do not happen; they happen due to causes. When one understands the causes for bad outcomes, one can work to stop such causes and make sure bad outcomes NOT TO ARISE in the future; this is the meaning of the “*nirödha*” (=“*nir*” + “*udä*“, where “*nir*” is stop and “*udä*” is arising; thus “stop from arising”).

12. The real message of the Buddha is that spending one’s whole life in making mundane progress is really insignificant in the [samsaric time scale](#); **why spend all that time to achieve a high status, earn a billion dollars, or anything else mundane if one has to leave all that behind within 100 years?** We have done this over and over countless times. This rebirth process can run into many more trillions of years into the future and this larger world of 31 realms is wrought with unimaginable

dangers.

- The ultimate solution is to stop the rebirth process (eliminate causes for future rebirths), and to release the mind from the material body that leads to much suffering.
- Thus the key message of the Buddha was to “attain the suffering-free *Nibbana* by eliminating the causes for rebirth: greed, hate, and ignorance”.
- But that message itself can only be grasped via purifying one’s mind to a certain extent by learning about the true nature of the wider world or existence: *anicca, dukkha, anatta*.

Also see, “[The Way to Nibbana – Removal of Asavas](#)“, “[Nibbana – Is It Difficult to Understand?](#)“, and “[What are Rupa? \(Relation to Nibbana\)](#)“.

Root Cause of Anicca – Five Stages of a Sankata

1. *Anicca* is the key to [the Sotapanna stage](#). Once one comprehends *anicca*, one can see how *dukkha* arises, and thus why one is totally helpless (*anatta*) in this rebirth process; then one “sees” that the only permanent happiness is attained via [seeking Nibbana](#).

- “*Uppada vayattena anicca*”, or “*anicca* because everything that arises in this world gets destroyed”
- Thus in order to understand *anicca* better, we need to realize that everything that we EXPERIENCE in this world has causes for its arising and when those causes (kammic energy) are depleted they are destroyed too. Anything in this world, except “*namagotta*”, is called a “*sankata*”; see, [“Difference between Dhamma and Sankhara \(Sankata\)”](#).
- A *sankata* can also be defined as something that arises due to causes. **Thus the only entity that is not a *sankata* is Nibbana, which is attained via removing all causes.**

2. A *sankata* (pronounced “sankatha”) is an entity arising due to a *sankhara*; a *sankhara* is also a *sankata*, because just like any other *sankata*, any *sankhara* arises and falls; thus *sankhara* is sometimes used to include both; see below.

- At the deepest level, anything in this world arises due to the mind. It will take us some more time to get to that, but that is what was meant by the Buddha when he said, “*manopubbangama dhamma.....*” or “mind precedes everything else...”.
- This was described in detail in the *Agganna sutta*, but please do not bother to look it up on the internet, because ALL existing translations are embarrassingly erroneous. In order to discuss the *Agganna sutta*, we need more background material.

3. In “*sabbe sankhara anicca.....*”, by *sankhara* what is meant is *sankhara* AND *sankata*, everything in this world except “*namagotta*”, which are just records of events.

- Thus all we experience are *sankata*. Thus anything included in *pancakkhandha* is a *sankata*.
- It is easy to see that all *vedana*, *sanna*, *sankhara*, *vinna* are *sankata*.

4. **However, here we pay special attention to material things, because those are ones that give us a perception of “valuable things worth taking possession of”, sometimes via “any means possible”. Until we get this perception out of our minds, intentionally or unintentionally we will be doing immoral things that will force us to be reborn in the lowest four realms.**

- Any *sankata* has a lifetime: a fly with a lifetime of a few days, a human with a lifetime of about 100 years, the Chinese Great Wall lasting tens of thousands of years, or a whole universe lasting billions of years, are all *sankata* (of course none of them made directly by *sankhara*; they are the end result. This cannot be explained even with many essays, and will take a while to get to). But we will take a few simple examples to explain the fundamental idea in this post.

5. What is the difference between a “material *sankata*” that is inert and another that is “alive”?

- For example, a tree is a *sankata*; it grows starting from a seed and eventually dies; that IS the end of the tree. The causes to form the tree that were embedded in the seed led to the growth of the tree, but as the causes got depleted the tree died.
- But when a human dies, of course the physical body decomposes, but death is not the end of that

being. Because a living being keeps making causes (*sankhara*) for its “continuation” after death. An *Arahant*, however, had stopped making *sankhara* and thus at death there is no continuation.

- All inert things in this world came into existence a long time ago, and how they come about **ORIGINALLY** from *sankhara* involves Dhamma that is very deep. But they all, and the whole physical universe will come to an end when the universe dies in billions of years.
- Yet the sentient beings have been in existence from beginningless time. Each time we die, we come back with a new existence (new *bhava*).

6. During the lifetime of a *sankata*, it goes through five loosely-defined stages; there are no clear-cut delineations in between adjacent stages. This is because a *sankata* is changing every moment.

- A good simile is the rising of the Sun and its disappearance at the end of a day. Since the cycle remains virtually unchanged through the year, let us consider this cycle in a country close to the equator. There from about 4 am to about 7 am it is called a sunrise; from that time to Noon the sunshine grows and is peaked around Noon. The “full Sun” is there from about 11 am to about 4 pm, where the power of the Sun is optimum. Then it starts going down and around 7 pm it starts to get dark; then the last part of the night takes over. Yet at each moment, the Sun is moving and the status keep changing.

7. In the same way, a *sankata* goes through five stages: *udayangama* (rising), *attangama* (growing), *asvada* (optimum), *adeenava* (decay starts), and *nissarana* (last stages leading to death).

- **Understanding these five stages of a *sankata* is the key to the *anuloma nana*, without which one cannot get to the *sammatta niyama*, and eventually to Nibbana.**
- For example, a seed germinates and starts a bud; this is the arising (*udayangama*) stage. Then it grows to a healthy young tree; this is the growing (*attangama*) stage where there are no flowers or fruits yet. Then comes the *asvada* (optimum) stage where the tree is flourishing is full of flowers and fruits. But then with time, the tree will give less fruits and is one the way down; this is the *adeenava* (decaying) stage where it can come down with various diseases too. This process continues as the *nissarana* stage until it dies.
- A human or animal (the only realms we can see) will go through the same process. A human life starts not as a baby but a single cell in the womb; from there to a baby of couple of years is the arising (*udayangama*) stage. Then comes the growth (*attangama*) stage until about 15 years or so. Life peaks from there to about 30-35 years, and that is the time one really enjoys life, the *asvada* (optimum) stage. But then inevitably, the decay process starts and one starts feeling aches and pains, diseases, etc in the *adeenava* stage. This stage is continued in the final stage (somewhere starting from 50-70 years depending on individual) of *nissarana* leading to death.
- Even an inert object like a house, a star, or even a whole universe goes through the same process.

8. This is the underlying nature of this anything in this world, and that is why it is *anicca*: no matter how much we try, we will not be able to maintain anything to our satisfaction over long times.

- **And the reason that this process does not stop for a living being is that during a life, a living being makes more than enough causes for this process to start all over.**
- Some of these causes are good and will lead to “good existences”, where there is relatively more happiness, but more often the causes are bad (due to ignorance of this basic fact), and will

lead to existences where the suffering is very great.

- Thus we can see how *dukkha* (suffering) arises due to the transient nature of *sankata*, which in turn leads to the conclusion that one is truly helpless (*anatta*) in this *sansaric* process. If one truly understands this fact, that itself leads to the Sotapanna magga stage of Nibbana (one of the “atta purisa puggala”).

9. These five stages in between the arising and perishing can be seen in anything or any event, and in order to understand the ever-changing nature of everything, we need see this in everything/every action around us.

- Let us take an example of eating a meal. Sitting down to eat is the *uadayangama* stage; then with a few bites one is into the *attangama* stage, and then one really starts enjoying the meal in the *asvada* stage. But then the hunger goes away, and one starts feeling full and getting tired of eating; this is the *adeenava* stage. Finally, one stops eating and that is *nissarana*.
- One develops an urge to listen to music, and start the playing device (*uadayangama*); one starts listening (*attangama*), and starts to enjoy the music (*asvada*). But after a while, the satisfaction wares away, and the enjoyment kind of fades away (*adeenava*), and finally one had enough of it and stops (*nissarana*).
- The more we start seeing this we can get rid of the two extremes of “something is there with a sense of long-lasting” and “there is nothing there at all”. Things have a transient existence; they exist for finite durations as long as the underlying causes are there, changing every moment.

10. This above analysis was given by the Buddha to help us realize that there are no “permanent” or “existing” entities “in this world”. But we cannot say “nothing exists” either. The Buddha rejected both “exists” and “does not exist” extremes, just as he rejected “self” and “no-self” extremes. **Things and living beings exist, not as enduring entities but as ever-changing entities; AND the suffering is real.**

- People who do not comprehend the message of the Buddha try to come up with “sophisticated looking” statements about the existence, suffering, and Nibbana.
- The message of the Buddha was profound (because it had never been known), but simple once explained: There is no reason to be arrogant because we are born human (may be with lot of wealth) or to be depressed if one is born to poverty; this life lasts only a fleeting moment in the *sansaric* scale. We should try to end this suffering-filled rebirth process without delay, because no one knows when the death comes, and in the next life we could be in a REALLY helpless existence.

In the next post we will discuss the CAUSES for *sankata* to arise: that knowledge embedded in the “*udayavaya nana*”.

Tables and Summaries

“[Pali Glossary](#)”

I will keep adding more words to the glossary. If you would like me to add any words to the glossary, please send a comment. You do not need to disclose your identity.

It is absolutely NOT necessary to memorize the following summaries. These are to be used as a reference. I normally look these up as needed from different sources, but thought of putting all that information here so that I or anyone else can just look them up conveniently.

“[The 89 Cittas](#)”

“[Cetasika \(Mental Factors\)](#)”

“[Rupa \(Material Form\) – Table](#)”

“[Rupa – Generation Mechanisms](#)”

“[Rupa Kalapas \(Grouping of Matter\)](#)”

“[Akusala Citta and Akusala Vipaka Citta](#)”

“[37 Factors of Enlightenment](#)”

“[Conditions for the Four Stages of Nibbana](#)”

“[Ultimate Realities – Table](#)”

Pali Glossary

Possible Confusion in Pronunciation

It seems that the following conventions were adopted in order to make the text shorter.

In many cases:

- “c” needs to be pronounced “**ch**” as in “**ch**arm” or “**ch**icago”.
- “t” needs to be pronounced “**th**” as in “**th**ud” or “**th**row”.
 - For example, *citta* pronounced “chiththa”, *cakkhu* is pronounced “chakkhu”, *anicca* as “anichcha”, *anatta* as “anaththa”, *jati* as “jathi”, *tanha* as “thanha”, *tilakkhana* as “thilakkhana”.
- “d” needs to be pronounced “**th**” as in “**th**is” or “**th**at”. Note the difference in pronouncing “**th**” between 2 and 3.

For example, *vedana* or dāna (as in giving) is pronounced this way.

Pronunciation Key

á rhymes like pat th → thin	â → care dh → this	ã → pay	ä → father	ê → pet	ë → bee
ö → toe	ü → moon	ch → chin	ng → thing		

Common Pali Words

I will keep adding more words to the glossary. If you would like me to add any missing words to the glossary, please send a comment. You do not need to disclose your identity.

Pali Word	Pronunciation	Meaning
akusala		immoral, unwholesome
adosa	adhösa	goodwill (not only non-hatred)
alobha	alöbha	generosity (not only non-greed)
amoha	amöha	wisdom (not only non-delusion)
Anagami	Anägämi	Non-Returner (to the human world)
Anariya	Anäriyā	One who is not yet a Noble One or Ariya
anatta	anaththā	not in-control, helpless

anicca	anichchā	inability to maintain to one’s satisfaction
annantara		being in storage until retrieval (kamma vipaka)
anupassana	anupassanā	Mindfulness of thought influxes
anusaya		defilements arising from latent cravings (asava)
apaya	apāya	common term for four lowest realms
abhijja	abhijjā	strong greed
Arahant		Never to be born in any of the 31 realms
Ariya	āriyā	noble one (Sotapanna or above)
arupa	arūpa	without rupa
avijja	avijjā	ignorance
ahirika	ahirikā	shamelessness
ahetuka	ahāthuka	rootless, without a cause
akasa	ākāsa	space (the void in between rupa)
aloka	ālōka	light, dissociating from “this world”
apo	āpō	cohesive element
arammana	ārammana	object of thought
asava =asaya	asāva	deep-seated craving
asevana	āsāvanā	repeated practice
bahiddha	bahidhdhā	external
bala		power
bhanga	bhangā	dissolution
bhava		existence level
Bhauddhaya (Buddhist)	Bhaudhdhayā	One striving to stop the rebirth process
bhavana	bhāvanā	meditation, constant contemplation & use
Buddha	Budhdha (not “Budhdhā”)	Buddha Gotama
bhavanga	bhavangā	life continuum
bhaya		fear
citta	chiththa	early stage of a thought (pure thought)
dana	dāna	giving
dasaka		decad
deva	dāva	a being in 6th-11th realms
dhamma	dhammā	Buddha’s teachings, phenomenon, mental object
dhammavicaya	dhammavichaya	investigation of concepts like anicca
dhatu	dhāthu	element
ditthi		view, wrong view unless specified

domanassa	dhomanassa	displeasure
dosa	dhösa	hatred
dukha	dhukha	suffering
dukkha	dhukhkha	suffering & it can be overcome
dvara	dhvära	door (to the outside world)
ekaggata	ekaggathā	one-pointedness (of the mind)
gandha		smell
gati	gathi	character
hadayavatthu	hadayavaththu	heart-base
hetu	hāthu	root cause
hiri		shame
iddhipada	iddhipāda	means to accomplishment
kamachanda	kāmachanda	greed stronger than abhijja
kamaloka	kāmalōka	first 11 realms with five physical senses
kamavacara	kāmavachara	belonging to kamaloka
kamma	kammā	action, deed
kasina	kasinā	meditation device (usu. a colored disk)
kaya	kāya	sensing (seeing, hearing, etc)
kaya	kaya	body
khaya		cutting off
khana		moment, sub-moment
khandha		aggregate, collection, heap
kilesa	kilāsa	defilement
kukkucca	kukkuchcha	tendency to do lowly things
kusala		removal of defilements
lahuta	lahüta	lightness
lakkhana	lakhkhana	characteristic
lobha	lōbha	greed
loka	lōka	world
lokuttara	lökuththara	supramundane, transcendental
maccariya	machchariya	extreme greed, hiding wealth
magga	magga	path
mana	māna	conceit
manasikara	manasikāra	memory
mano	manō	mind
manodhatu	manōdhāthu	mind element

manodvara	manödvära	mind door
manussa		human being
marana		death
metta	meththā	loving kindness
micca ditthi	michcha diththi	wrong views
middha	midhdhā	torpor
moha	mōha	delusion
mudita	mudhithā	appreciative joy
muduta	mudhuthā	malleability
mula		root
nama	nāma	name, mental
namarupa	nāmarūpa	name and form
nana	ngāna	knowledge
nimitta	nimiththa	sign
nivarana	nēvarana	hindrance
niraya		hell
niyama	niyama (not niyāma)	law of nature
oja	ojā	nutritive essence
paccaya	pachchayā	condition
pahana	pahāna	abandoning
pancadvara	panchadvāra	five sense doors
pancakkhandha	pancakkhandhā	five aggregates
pancaupadanakkhandha	pancaupādānakkhandhā	grasping/craving of five aggregates
panna	pangngā	wisdom
piti		zest
pannindriya		wisdom faculty
paramatta	paramaththā	ultimate reality
pasada rupa	pasāda rūpa	sensitive matter (internal rupa)
passaddhi	passadhdhi	tranquility
patavi		element of hardness
paticca	patichcha	bind to something willingly
patigha		aversion, dislike
pavutthi	pavuththi	during this life, current
peta	petā	hungry ghost
phala		fruit, fruition
phassa		contact

puggala		individual
purisa		masculine
raga	rāga	lust
rasa		taste
rupa	rūpa	matter, material phenomenon
rupa kalapa	rūpa kalāpa	material group unit
rupavacara	rūpavāchara	belonging to rupa loka
sadda	sadhdha	sound
sadharana	sādhārana	universal, common
saddha	sadhdhā	faith (through knowledge and understanding)
sahetuka	sahēthuka	with roots
Sakadagami	Sakadagāmi	Once-Returner (one more rebirth as a human)
salayatana	salāyathana	six sense bases
samadhi	saṁādhi	high concentration with pure mind
samma		quench (defilements)
sammapatti	sammāpaththi	meditative attainment
samanantara	samananthara	contiguity, matching with annantara
samatha	samathā	calming the mind
samauppada	samauppāda	birth of a similar kind
sankappa		ideas
sankhara	sankhāra	actions leading to defilements
sankhata	sankhatha	conditioned, formed by conditions
sanna	sangngā	perception
sansara (also called samsara)	sansāra	beginningless rebirth process
sasava	sāsavā	with craving
sati	sathi	mindfulness, deciding right from wrong
satipattana	sathipattāna	establishment of mindfulness
sanyojana	sanyōjana	bind to defilements, fetter
silā	seela	virtue, moral conduct
sekha	sēkha	trainee (the three stages below the Arahant)
somanassa	sōmanassa	with joy
sota	sōta	ear
Sotapanna	Sōthapanna	Stream Enterer (first stage of Nibbana)
tanha	thanhā	attachment (bondage) due to greed, hate, or delusion

tejo	thājo	heat element
thina		sloth
uddacca	udhdhachchā	tendency to be high-minded (restlessness)
upadana	upādhāna	clinging, like to hold onto
upekkha		equanimity, neutrality
uppatthi	uppaththi	birth
vaci	vachi	speech
vanna	vannā	color
vayama	vayāma	effort
vayo	vayō	fluidity
vedana	vādana	feeling
vicara	vichāra	sustained concentration on an object
vicikicca	vichikichchā	doubt
vimansa	vimansā	investigation
vinnati	vingngāthi	intimation
vinnana	vingngana	(defiled) consciousness
vipaka	vipāka	result
vipassana	vipassanā	insight (via analysis of parts)
virati	virathi	abstinence from indulgence
viriya		effort
visuddhi	visudhdhi	purification
vitakka	vithakka	initial application of the mind on an object
vithi		process (sequential)
vottapana	voththapana	determining
vyapada	vyāpāda	ill will, stronger than patigha

The 89 (121) Types of Citta

Citta for Kamaloka (in the 11 sense realms)- 54 in all

There are three main types of citta here: The differentiation is based on whether they have immoral roots (*lobha, dosa, moha*), *kammically* moral roots (*alobha, adosa, amoha*), or are *kammically* neutral, i.e., no roots.

- **12 immoral citta:** 8 with *lobha* roots; 2 with *dosa* roots; 2 with *moha* roots. All ten immoral acts (*dasa akusala*) are done with these 12 types of *cittas*. Because of these 12 types of immoral *cittas*, **7 rootless (*ahetuka*) vipaka cittas** can arise in the future. Thus altogether there are **19 cittas in this category**.
- **8 moral cittas:** 4 with all three moral roots and 4 with two moral roots (lacking in wisdom). They can give rise to two types of *vipaka citta*: **8 vipaka cittas with no roots**, and **8 vipaka citta with moral roots** (4 of them have all three moral roots and other 4 are lacking in wisdom). Thus **24 types of citta are mentioned here**, from which 16 have moral roots and 8 are rootless (*ahetuka*).
- When these same **8 moral citta arise in Arahants, they are called *kriya citta*** or functional *citta*. They just have the same moral roots as the 8 moral citta mentioned above, but do not have any *kammic* potential or *kammic* consequences.
- All those citta with moral roots (8 *kriya cittas* for *Arahants* and 16 for others) are called *sobhana* (beautiful) citta.
- Finally, there are **3 types of citta that are *kammically* neutral** and do not lead to any *kamma vipaka*. These are the 3 *kriya citta* without any roots, and thus are rootless (*ahetuka*) *citta*. Two of these perform functions of (i) five-sense-door adverting consciousness (*pancadvaravajjana citta*), and (ii) mind-door-adverting consciousness (*manodvaravajjana citta*). (iii) The third one arises in only *Arahants* (when they smile about sense-sphere phenomena).

Those **54 kamaloka citta** can be categorized in different ways.

Asobhana (Unbeautiful)		Sobhana (Beautiful)
Immoral- 12	Rootless – 18	Moral -24
<i>Lobha</i> (8)	Immoral <i>Vipaka</i> (7)	<i>Moral</i> (8)
<i>Dosa</i> (2)	Moral <i>Vipaka</i> (8)	Moral <i>Vipaka</i> (8)
<i>Moha</i> (2)	<i>Kriya</i> (3)	<i>Kriya</i> (8)

Citta for Rupaloka (in the 16 Rupa realms)- 15 in all

1. There are only 15 citta that are predominantly present in the *Rupaloka*. Five are *jhanic* moral *citta* and five are *vipaka cittas* due to those.
2. The five *jhanic* moral *citta* can be experienced by humans when they develop *samadhi* and attain these (first through fifth) *jhanas*. However, they can experience the corresponding five *vipaka citta* only when they are born in *Rupalokas*.
3. The five *jhanic* states are characterized by five *jhana* factors or mental concomitants: *vitakka* (initial application), *vicara* (sustained application), *piti* (zest), *sukha* (happiness), and *ekaggata* (one-pointedness). All five factors are present in the first *jhana*, and as one moves to higher *jhanas*, these

factors are lost one by one, and in the fifth *jhana* only *ekaggata* is left.

Piti (zest) is the happiness in the mind and *sukha* (happiness) is the tranquility of the body.

4. There are five more *jhanic kriya citta* experienced by *Arahants* when they attain these *jhanas*.

Thus there are 15 *citta* in all that predominantly belong to the *Rupaloka*.

Citta for Arupaloka (in the 4 Arupa realms)- 12 in all

1. There are only 12 *citta* that are predominantly present in the *Arupaloka*. Four are *jhanic moral citta* and four are *vipaka citta* due to those.

2. The four *jhanic moral citta* can be experienced by humans when they develop *samadhi* and attain these (fifth through eighth) *jhanas*. However, they can experience the corresponding four *vipaka citta* only when they are born in *Arupaloka*.

3. The first of the four *Arupaloka jhanas* is the attainment of the base of infinite space (*Akasanancayatana*). A human needs to master the fourth *jhana* (*Rupaloka*) in order to be able to attain this *jhana*.

The second is the base of infinite consciousness (*vinñanacayatana*). The third is the base of nothingness (*akincannayatana*), and the fourth is the base of neither-perception-nor-non-perception (*n' evasanna n' asannayatana*). In this last type of consciousness, the factor of perception (*sanna*) is so subtle that it can no longer perform the function of perception, i.e., one is unaware of the “world”. Yet perception is not altogether absent. This is another reason why the ancient *yogis* erroneously assumed this eighth *jhana* to be *Nibbana*.

4. There are four more *Arupaloka jhanic kriya citta* experienced by *Arahants* when they attain these *jhanas*.

Thus there are 12 *citta* in all that predominantly belong to the *Arupaloka*.

Lokottara (Supermundane) Citta – 8 in all

1. These pertain to the four stages of *Nibbanic* attainment: *Sotapanna*, *Sakadagami*, *Anagami*, and *Arahant*.

2. Each stage involves two types of *citta*: one is path consciousness (*magga citta*), and the other is fruition consciousness (*phala citta*). The *magga citta* has the function of eradicating or permanently attenuating defilements. The *phala citta* has the function of experiencing the degree of liberation made possible by the *magga citta*.

3. Each *magga citta* arises only once, and endures for one thought-moment. It is never repeated. The corresponding *phala citta* (which corresponds to a *vipaka citta*, but is not called a *vipaka citta*) arises immediately after the *magga citta*. This is in contrast to mundane *vipaka citta*s where they can occur even many lifetimes after the corresponding *kusala* or *akusala citta*.

4. The *phala citta* can be repeated any time after one attains it. With practice, it can be sustained for long times, up to 7 days for an *Arahant*.

Thus, there are 89 *citta* in all.

How 121 Types of Citta are Possible

It is possible to attain *Nibbanic* states via each of the five *Rupaloka jhanic* states. In that case each of the five *jhanic* states can lead to the four *magga citta*s and four *phala citta*s. Thus here there are 40 ways to attain *lokottara citta*s. Therefore, the total number of *citta* in this case would be 121 (= 89+40-8) instead of 89.

- It must be kept in mind that these are *anariya jhanas* that one goes through to attain *magga phala*. If someone has *Ariya jhanas*, they are likely to have attained at least the *Sotapanna* stage.

Let us consider some examples from the *Tipitaka*.

- There are many instances of people attaining the *Arahant* stage without developing any *anariya jhanas*. For example, a minister of King of Kosala, named *Santati* was riding an elephant and the Buddha was walking on the road. The Buddha, with his supernormal powers, saw that *Santati* was capable of attaining the *Arahanthood* and that he was going to die very soon. The Buddha delivered a discourse right there with *Santati* still on the back of the elephant, and he attained *Arahanthood*.
- On the other extreme we have Upatissa and Kolita (who became the top two disciples of the Buddha, Sariputta and Moggallana), were *vedic brahmins* who were likely to have attained higher *anariya jhanas*. They both attained the *Sotapanna* stage upon hearing the famous *gāthā*: “*ye dhamma hetu pabbava, tesaṃ hetuṃ tatagatho ahaṃ*..“.
- Like Upatissa and Kolita, many people in the days of the Buddha had developed various stages of *anariya jhanas*. They were able to attain various stages of *Nibbana* via those 40 possible combinations.

Cetasika (Mental Factors)

Cetasikas (mental factors) appear concomitantly with cittas (thoughts), and they cease together with cittas. They define the character (good or bad or neutral) of the cittas.

- The way to “[Lead a Moral Life](#)“, or to “[Seek Good Rebirths](#)“, or to “[Seek Nibbana](#)“, is to get rid of the bad (un-beautiful) cetasikas and to cultivate good (beautiful) cetasikas. This is done by changing one’s habits via learning Dhamma and practicing it: see, “[Habits and Goals](#)“, “[Sansaric Habits and asavas](#)“, and “[The Way to Nibbana – Removal of asavas](#)“, in that order.

1. There are 7 cetasikas that are in each and every citta. These are called **universals or sabbacittasadharana**:

- Phassa (contact); vedana (feeling); sanna (perception); cetana (volition);
- Ekaggata (One-pointedness) can become [samma samadhi](#); jivitindriya (life faculty); manasikara (attention).

2. Since they are universals, the above cetasikas appear in both kusala and *akusala* citta. All are important mental factors:

- Sanna and vedana are in pancakkhandha.
- Cetana determines kamma; it is the cetasika that “puts together a citta”.
- Ekaggata is the salient factor in samadhi.
- Consciousness cannot arise without phassa.
- Jivitindriya maintains life, and
- Manasikara can be either yoniso manasikara (important in attaining [the Sotapanna stage](#)), and ayoniso manasikara can lead to accumulation of *akusala* kamma.

3. There are six cetasikas that also CAN appear in both types of cittas: kusala and *akusala*. However, they are found in only particular types of cittas. They are called **particulars or pakinnaka**:

- vitakka (focused application) can become [samma sankappa](#); vicara (sustained application); adhimokkha (decision);
- viriya (effort) can become [samma vayama](#); piti (zest); chanda (desire, not greed).

4. Just like universals, these particulars can appear in either type of cittas, kusala or *akusala*. Vitakka, vicara, and piti are jhana factors.

- Viriya and chanda are two factors in the four bases of mental power; see, “[The Four Bases of Mental Power \(Satara Iddhipada\)](#)“.
- Adhimokkha is important in decision making. All these factors can go in the immoral direction too.

5. There are 14 asobhana cetasikas (non-beautiful mental factors) that appear only in *akusala* citta. Out of these, there are four universals that appear in ALL *akusala* citta:

- **Moha** (delusion); Ahirika (shamelessness); Anottapa (fearlessness in wrong); uddhacca (restlessness or agitation).

- Both shamelessness and fearlessness of wrong encourage doing immoral acts. Restlessness causes unwise decision making.

The other 10 are occasionals that appear in only particular types of *akusala* citta:

- **lobha** (greed); ditthi (wrong view); mana (conceit); **dosa** (hatred); issa (envy); maccariya (avarice, also pretending one does not have wealth); kukkucca (worry, also feeling low); Thina (sloth, sluggishness); middha (torpor); vicikicca (doubt arising from temptations).
- Lobha and dosa are two of the three immoral roots. Sloth and torpor normally rise together and are opposite of viriya; they are listed as one factor in Five Hindrances; see, “[Key to Calming the Mind](#)”.

6. There are 25 sobhana cetasikas (beautiful mental factors), and 19 of them appear in each and every kusala citta, and thus are called beautiful universals:

- Saddha (faith); sati (moral mindfulness) can become **samma sati** ; hiri (shame of wrong); ottappa (fear of wrong); **alobha** (generosity); **adosa** (loving kindness); tatramajjhata (neutrality of mind); kayapassaddhi (tranquility of mental body); cittapassaddhi (tranquility of consciousness); kayalahuta (lightness of mental body); cittalahuta (lightness of consciousness); kayamuduta (malleability of mental body); cittamuduta (malleability of consciousness); kayakammanuta (wieldiness of mental body); cittakammanuta (wieldiness of consciousness); kayapagunnata (proficiency of mental body); cittapagunnata (proficiency of consciousness); kayujjukata (rectitude of mental body); cittujjukata (rectitude of consciousness).
- There are three abstinences: **samma vaca** (right speech); **samma kammanata** (right action); **samma ajiva** (right livelihood).
- Two Illimitables (limit-less): karuna (compassion); muduta (appreciative joy; joy at other’s success).
- **Panna** or pannindriya (wisdom or wisdom faculty). **Samma ditthi leads to panna.**

7. Mental factors in the **Noble Eightfold Path** are highlighted in blue.

8. **Immoral roots are highlighted in red.** **Moral roots are highlighted in purple.**

Rupa (Material Form) – Table

For discussions on rupa, see:

“[What are Rupa? \(Relation to Nibbana\)](#)”

“[Rupa \(Material Form\)](#)”

Concretely Produced (Nipphanna)	Abstract (Anipphanna) Rupa
I. Great Elements (Maha Bhuta)	VII. Limiting Phenomenon
1. Patavi (Extension/Hardness)	19. Akasa dhathu (space element)
2. Apo (Cohesion/Fluidity)	IX. Communicating (Vinnati) Rupa
3. Tejo (Heat/Hotness)	20. Kaya Vinnati
4. Vayo (Motion/Pushing & Supporting)	21. Vaci Vinnati
II. Internal (Pasada) Rupa	X. Mutable (Vikara) Rupa
5. Cakkhu (eye)	22. Lahuta (lightness)
6. Sota (ear)	23. Muduta (Elasticity)
7. Ghana (nose)	24. Kammannata (weirdness)
8. Jivha (tongue)	XI. Material Qualities (Lakkhana Rupa)
9. Kaya (body)	25. Upacaya (production)
III. Gocara (Objective) Rupa	26. Santati (continuity)
10. Vanna (visible)	27. Jarata (Decay)
11. Sadda (Sound)	28. Aniccata (Dissolving)
12. Gandha (Smell)	
13. Rasa (Taste)	
* Pottabba (Tangibily) comes from 3 Maha Bhuta	
IV. Bhava (Sexual) Rupa	
14. Itthi (Feminine)	
15. Purisa (Masculine)	
V. Hadaya	
16. Hadaya Vatthu (heart base)	
VI. Life	
17. Jivitindriya (Life faculty)	
VII. Nutritional	
18. Oja (Nutriment)	

The 16 rupa that are highlighted in blue are fine ([sukuma](#)) rupa; the other 12 are coarse ([olarika](#)) rupa.

Types of Rupas Present in Different Realms

- Nipphanna rupa are caused by kamma, citta, utu (tejo), and ahara (oja). The other 10 (anipphanna rupa) are not caused or conditioned by kamma, citta, utu (tejo), and ahara (oja).
- All the 28 rupas arise in the kama-realms. Eight rupas comprising sadda, five vikara-rupas, jaratarupa and aniccata-rupa, do not arise at the moment of birth (patisandhi) whereas, during life time, there is no rupa which is not formed.
- In the 15 rupa realms, with the exception of Asanna-realm, 23 rupas arise (ghana-pasada, jivha-pasada, kaya- pasada, itthi-bhava and purisa-bhava being excluded).

- Only 17 rupas arise in the Asanna realm; they are 8 avinibbhogas (4 maha bhuta, vanna, gandha, rasa, oja), jivita, akasa dhatu, 3 lahutadi, 4 lakkhana- rupas;
- No rupa arise in the arupa-realms. But rupa still have a “foothold” in the arupaloka since any being in the arupaloka will be reborn in other realms in the future (unless at least the Sotapanna stage is attained); thus linkage to materiality has not been severed.

Rupa – Generation Mechanisms

1. Rupas can be generated by four causes: kamma, citta, utu, and Ahara (food). I will discuss these in detail later.
- Kamma here refers to volition (*cetana*). The 25 kinds of *kamma* that produce *rupas* are the volitions of the 12 *akusala cittas*, 8 great *kusala cittas*, and the five *rupaloka kusala cittas*.
 - The *rupas* produced by the *cittas* arise **at the same time as the *cittas*** themselves, and only at the rising part of the *cittas*. Out of the 89 possible *cittas*, 75 *cittas* can produce rupa (4 *arupaloka vipaka cittas* and the two sets of fivefold sense consciousness cannot produce *rupa*).
 - The great element *tejo* is responsible for producing *utu samutthana rupa*: Beginning from the moment of rebirth-linking, the internal *tejo* element found in the *rupa kalapas* born of *kamma* combines with the external *tejo* and starts producing organic material phenomena originating from *tejo*. Thereafter the *tejo* element in the *rupa kalapas* born of all four causes produces organic material phenomena born of *tejo* element throughout the life. Externally, *tejo* element also produces inorganic material phenomena, such as climatic and geological transformations.
 - The nutritive essence, *oja*, is present in all *rupa-kalapas* both inside the body (internal) and outside the body (external). The external food, which is eaten, is digested in the stomach and dispersed through blood to all parts of the body. So the internal *oja* and the external *oja* meet in every part of the body. The combination of internal and external *ojas* produce *aharaja-rupas*.
2. The 8 rupas of *patavi*, *apo*, *tejo*, *vayo*, *vanna*, *gandha*, *rasa*, and *oja* are ALWAYS found together. That unit or *kalapa* is the smallest rupa unit and is called the pure octad (*suddhashtaka*). **Those 8 rupas and the *akasa dhatu* are produced by all four causes.**
3. The four *lakkhana rupas* of *upacaya*, *santati*, *jarata*, and *aniccata* are not produced by any cause. They represent the nature of *rupas*.
4. The remaining 15 rupas are produced by different combination of the four possible causes as shown in the table below:

	Kamma Born	Citta Born	Utu Born	Ahara Born
Cakkhu (eye)	YES			
Sota (ear)	YES			
Ghana (nose)	Yes			
Jivha (tongue)	Yes			
Kaya (body)	Yes			
Sadda (sound)		Yes	Yes	
Itthi Bhva (femininity)	Yes			
Purisa (masculine)	Yes			
Hadaya vatthu (heart base)	Yes			
Jivitindriya (life faculty)	Yes			
Kaya vinnati (bodily intimation)		Yes		
Vaci Vinnati (vocal intimation)		Yes		

Lahuta (lightness)		Yes	Yes	Yes
Muduta (malleability)		Yes	Yes	Yes
Kammannanata (wioldiness)		Yes	Yes	Yes

Rupa Kalapas (Grouping of Matter)

1. The 28 types of rupa are not found separately in nature. They are produced by the four causes in the form of tiny material groups called kalapas. Kalapas have the following four features:

- 1. All the rupas in a kalapa arise together, i.e. they have a common genesis.
- 2. They also cease or dissolve together, i.e. they have a common cessation.
- 3. They all depend on the four great essentials present in the kalapa for their arising, i.e. they have a common dependence.
- 4. They are so thoroughly mixed that they cannot be distinguished, i.e. they co-exist.

2. It should be noted that kalapas are so small that they are indistinguishable from pure energy. The ultimate rupa is formless and massless.

3. There are 21 types of kalapas:

9 kammaja kalapas 6 cittaja kalapas 4 utuja kalapas 2 aharaaja kalapas as shown below:

	Kamma Born	Citta Born	Utu Born	Ahara Born
Cakkhu dasaka (eye decad)	Yes			
Sota dasaka (ear decad)	Yes			
Ghana dasaka (nose decad)	Yes			
Jivha dasaka (tongue decad)	Yes			
Kaya dasaka (body decad)	Yes			
Itthi dasaka (female decad)	Yes			
Purisa dasaka (male decad)	Yes			
Vatthu dasaka (base decad)	Yes			
Jivita navaka (vital nonad)	Yes			
Suddhattaka (pure octad)		Yes (cittaja only)	Yes (utuja only)	Yes (aharaja only)
Kayavinnati navaka (body intimation nonad)		Yes		
Vaci vinnati sadda dasaka (vocal intimation decad)		Yes		
Lahutadi eka dasaka (undecad of mutability)		Yes	Yes	Yes
Kayavinnati Lahutadi dva dasaka (undecad of mutability)		Yes	Yes	
Vacivinnati Sadda Lahutadi terasaka (tridecad of mutability)		Yes		
Sadda navaka (sound decad)			Yes	

4. Internal and External Kalapas

All the 21 rupa-kalapas mentioned above occur internally in living beings. Itthibhava-dasaka does not

occur in males. Similarly, pumbhava-dasaka does not occur in females. For those who are born blind or deaf, cakkhu-dasaka or sota-dasaka should be eliminated.

In the external (bahiddha) world, only the two utuja-kalapas are found. All inanimate things such as trees, stones, earth, water, fire, corpses, etc., are made up of utuja-suddhatthaka kalapas. The sounds produced by beating two sticks together or by rubbing of branches in the wind or by musical instruments such as violin, piano, radio, cassettes, etc., are utuja-sadda-navaka kalapas.

From the internal rupas, kaya-pasada, bhava-rupa (femininity and masculinity), cittaja-rupa, utuja-rupa and aharaja-rupa spread all over the body, and so they will be present in the eye, the ear, the nose, the tongue and in every part of the body.

5. Rupa in Kamaloka

All the 28 material qualities occur undiminished, if circumstances permit, in an individual during a life-time in kamaloka (sense-sphere).

In womb-born creatures, only three kammaja-kalapas comprising body-decad, sex-decad and heartdecad are manifested at the moment of conception (at patisandhi).

Here again the sex-decad may not be manifested in some particular individuals. After conception, during life, the eye-decad and the rest are manifested slowly in due order. Of the groups of material qualities which are produced in four ways, kammaja-rupa starts to form at the moment of conception and it goes on forming incessantly at every minor-instant. Cittaja-rupa begins to form from the second moment of consciousness, i.e. from the arising instant of the first bhavanga which follows the rebirth-consciousness. Cittaja-rupa continues to be formed at every arising instant of the subsequent cittas for the whole life-time.

Utuja-rupa starts to form from the existing instant of rebirth consciousness. The reason is that the tejo-dhatu (utu) present in the first kammaja-kalapas comes to the static stage (thiti) at that instant. From that time onwards, the tejo- dhatu then produces utuja-rupa at every minor-instant. Since tejo-dhatu is present in every kalapa, every kalapa, from the time it reaches the static stage, produces new utuja-kalapas at every minor instant. Add the new utuja- kalapas, from the time they reach the static stage, again produce new utuja-kalapas at every minor instant. So this process will go on forever.

Every kalapa also contains the nutritive essence, oja. But ahaaja-rupa starts to form when internal oja meets external oja at the time of diffusion of nutritive essence and the combination of internal and external oja comes to the static stage. From that instant, aharaja-rupa is also formed at every minor instant. As new groups of material qualities are incessantly produced, old groups dissolve and disappear when their lifetime of 17 conscious-moments is over. Thus, the material phenomena go on uninterruptedly in the sense-sphere till the end of life like the flame of a lamp, or the stream of a river.

Material Phenomena at Death: At the time of death, psychic life and physical life must cease together. This means that all kammaja-rupa which contains physical life must cease at the time of death. So at the arising instant of the seventeenth citta reckoned backward from the death-consciousness (cuti-citta), the last kammaja-rupa is formed. This last kammaja-rupa will cease at the dissolving instant of the death-consciousness. Cittaja-rupa is formed till the arising instant of the cuti-citta. This last cittaja-rupa will have lasted for a conscious- moment at the dissolution of cuti-citta, and thus will perish in another sixteen conscious-moments which happens almost instantly. aharaja-rupa is formed till the dissolving instant of the cuti citta, because the support required for the formation of

aharajarupa can be furnished by citta up to that time. So at death, that last-formed aharaja-rupa has lasted for only one minor-instant. However in another fifty minor instants (rupa-lifespan – 51 minor instants or 17 conscious-moments), that aharaja- rupa also ceases. Thus at the time of death, kammaja-rupa, cittaja-rupa and ahàraja-rupa cease almost instantly.

But utuja-rupa goes on forming and dissolving till the corpse is converted into dust. A corpse consists of only utuja- rupa.

So when a person dies and is reborn in another life, material phenomena similarly arise starting from the instant of conception and go on arising till the time of death.

Arising of Material Phenomena in Rupa-planes: In the rupa-plane, nose-decad, tongue-decad, body-decad, sex decad and aharaja-kalapas do not arise. At the time of opapatika rebirth, there arise four kammaja-kalapas namely, eye-decad, eardecad, heart-decad and vital-nonad. During life, however, cittajakalapas and utuja-kalapas also arise. To the Asanna brahmas, eye-decad, heart- decad and sound-nonad (sadda-navaka) do not arise. Also, cittaja-kalapas do not arise. Therefore, at the time of their opapatika-rebirth, only the vital-nonad (jivita-navaka) arises. During life, utuja- kalàpas, with the exception of the sound-nonad, arise in addition.

Thus in kama-loka and rupa-loka, the process of the arising of material phenomena should be understood in two ways, that is (1) at rebirth and (2) during life.

Akusala Citta and Akusala Vipaka Citta

All ten *akusala kamma* are done with these 12 *akusala citta*. There are 8 greed-rooted, 2 hatred-rooted, and 2 delusion-rooted citta. Of course *citta* (pronounced “chiththä”) are thoughts; any speech or bodily action starts with a thought.

- See, “[Conditions for the Four Stages of Nibbana](#)” for a list of 12 *akusala citta*.

Both greed-rooted and hatred-rooted also have delusion as a root.

	Root	Assoc. with	Dissoc. with	Feeling	With habit/Forced
1	Greed	Wrong view	-	Pleasure	Habit
2	Greed	Wrong view	-	Pleasure	Forced/Reluctant
3	Greed	-	Wrong view	Pleasure	Habit
4	Greed	-	Wrong view	Pleasure	Forced/Reluctant
5	Greed	Wrong view	-	Equanimity	Habit
6	Greed	Wrong view	-	Equanimity	Forced/Reluctant
7	Greed	-	Wrong view	Equanimity	Habit
8	Greed	-	Wrong view	Equanimity	Forced/Reluctant
9	Hatred	Aversion	-	Displeasure	Habit
10	Hatred	Aversion	-	Displeasure	Forced/Reluctant
11	Delusion	Vicikicca	-	Equanimity	-
12	Delusion	Uddacca	-	Equanimity	-

1. The first *citta* is described as, ” a thought rooted in greed (and delusion), associated with wrong views, accompanied by pleasure, and done with habit”. The others can be stated the same way.

- Those *citta* that are associated with wrong views are the worst, even though wrong views are listed as #10 on the ten immoral actions, see, “[Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)](#)”.
- *Citta* generated with pleasure means one is enthusiastic about it because of one’s habits (*gathi*) or one starts liking it. For example, one who likes to go fishing has a bad habit; he gets a pleasure by just thinking about it; thus it is stronger than one done with equanimity.
- The hateful *citta* are always done with displeasure.
- Habit-based means “it just comes out”, because of the “*gathi*” of the person; thus they are stronger than “forced”, which arise when someone else is encouraging to do it, or when one realizes it is a bad thought but thinking about the “pleasures to be had”, encourages oneself to do it.
- See, the notes at the end of the post “[Conditions for the Four Stages of Nibbana](#)” for details.

2. Since *vicikicca* is also due to wrong views, those five *cittas* marked in red are the strongest *akusala citta* done with “wrong views” or ‘*ditthi*’. They can condition one’s mind to a “*gathi*” suitable for birth in the *apayas*; see, “[What is in a Thought? Why Gathi are so Important?](#)”.

- There is an “*apayagami* strength” in the 4 *citta* dissociated with wrong views and also the 2

hate-rooted *citta*; this “*apayagami* strength” or “character associated with lowest 4 realms” is also removed from those 6 *citta* at the *Sotapanna* stage.

- Upon attaining the *Sotapanna* stage, such habits or “*gathi*” are removed, and thus no adverse *kamma vipaka* come to the mind at the dying moment, as we point out below. The “*pati+ichcha sama+uppada*” or what is born is similar to what is grasped, is at play at the dying moment. One automatically grasps things one has a habit of liking; they automatically come to the forefront of the mind at the dying moment.

3. The other 7 *akusala citta* are stopped from arising in stages as a *Sotapanna* cultivates the Path further.

- The two hatred-rooted *cittas* (together with some potency of the remaining 4 greed-based *citta*, i.e., *kama raga*) are reduced at the *Sakadagami* stage.
- Those two hatred-rooted *citta*, together with *kama raga*, are stopped at the *Aanagami* stage.
- Finally, the remaining 4 greed-based *citta* and the *uddacca citta* are removed at the *Arahant* stage. Thus an *Arahant* will never experience an *akusala citta*.

4. These 12 types of *citta* lead to 7 types of *vipaka* (resultant) *citta*.

- None of the ***vipāka citta*** has any unwholesome roots (greed, hate, delusion); of course they also do not have the wholesome roots. **Thus they are called rootless (*ahétuka*) *citta*.**

5. Five of these *akusala vipaka citta* are the ones that lead to (undesirable) sense events through the five physical senses. Thus they are responsible for eye consciousness (*cakkhu vinnana*), ear consciousness (*sota vinnana*), nose consciousness (*ghana vinnana*), taste consciousness (*jivha vinnana*), and body consciousness (*kaya vinnana*).

- Except for the body consciousness which is accompanied by pain, the other four are accompanied by equanimity.
- Thus any feelings of displeasure etc due to what is seen, heard, smelled, or tasted, are in the thoughts that follow this “event” experienced through one of the physical senses. We will discuss this in detail in the *Abhidhamma* section.

6. The sixth *akusala vipaka citta* is called receiving consciousness accompanied by equanimity (*upakkha-sahagata sampaticcana citta*). This is a *citta* that accepts the sense impression to the mind (we will discuss in *Abhidhamma* section).

7. The seventh *akusala vipaka citta* is called the investigating consciousness accompanied by equanimity (*upakkha-sahagata santirana citta*). This is the *citta* that is responsible for the birth in the *apayas* (lowest four realms), i.e., it acts as the *patibandhi citta* for the birth in the *apayas*.

8. One may wonder how a *Sotapanna* avoids the *apayas*, because he/she is still capable of generating the 7 *cittas* that are not associated with *ditthi* (see the Table above), and thus it is possible to generate this *apayagami-patibandhi citta*. The point is that after becoming a *Sotapanna*, such *vipaka* thoughts do not come to the mind at the last thought processes; **only the good *kamma vipaka* come to the forefront of the mind close to the dying moment because he/she no longer has the “*gathi*” suitable for a birth in the *apayas*.**

9. It is hard to give up one’s bad habits (“*gathi*”), mainly because one does not fully comprehend the true nature of the world, i.e., *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, and thus has wrong views about this world

with 31 realms. One needs to comprehend that one's actions have consequences not only in this life, but (mainly) in the future lives; also, whatever one gains by such harmful actions is just temporary, AND do not leave one with a peace mind.

37 Factors of Enlightenment

1. The 37 factors of Enlightenment (*Bodhipakkhiya Dhamma*) are the combined number of individual factors in:
- Four Supreme Efforts (*Satara Sammappadana*),
 - Four Bases of Mental Power (*Satara Iddhipada*),
 - Five Faculties (*Panca Indriya*),
 - Five Powers (*Panca Bala*),
 - Four Factors of Mindfulness (*Satara Satipattana*),
 - Seven Factors of Enlightenment (*Saptha Bojjanga*), and
 - Factors of the Noble Eightfold Path (*Ariya Attangika Magga*).
2. These factors are really mental factors (*cetasika*). They are labelled with different names under each category in the Table below to highlight its application.
- For example, the *panna cetasika* is labelled as *vimansa* in Four Bases of Mental Power, as *dhammavicaya* in *Saptha Bojjanga*, and as *Samma Ditthi* in the Noble Eightfold Path.
 - Under each category, I have listed the term used for that *cetasika* in that category. For example, in the Noble Eightfold Path, *Samma Vayama* is the *viriya cetasika*.
 - Thus even though there are 37 factors of Enlightenment, there are only 14 *cetasika* that will be cultivated while cultivating all seven above categories.
 - It is clear that those 7 categories are all inter-related, and thus all 37 factors may be cultivated by focusing only on *Satara Satipattana*, *Saptha Bojjanga*, or the Noble Eightfold Path.
3. The Four Supreme Efforts (*Satara Sammappadana*) are the efforts to purify the mind: (i) remove defilements that have arisen, (ii) prevent new defilements from arising, (iii) enhance wholesome states that have arisen, (iv) initiate new wholesome states.
4. All 37 factors of enlightenment are fulfilled at the Arahant stage.

Cetasika Involved	Four Supreme Efforts	Iddhipada	Five Faculties	Fiver Powers	Four Factors of Mindfulness	7 Factors of Enlightenment	Path Factors
Panna (wisdom)		vimansa	panna	panna		dhammavicaya	samma ditthi
Vitakka (initial application)							samma sankappa
Samma vaca							samma vaca
Samma kammanata							samma kammanata
							samma

Samma ajiva							ajiva
Viriya	four efforts (see #3 above)	viriya	viriya	viriya		viriya	samma vayama
Sati (mindfulness)			sati	sati	kaya,vedana, citta,dhamma	sati	samma sati
Samadhi (one-pointedness)			samadhi	samadhi		samadhi	samma samadhi
Saddha (faith)			saddha	saddha			
Chanda (desire)		chanda					
citta		citta					
Piti (joy)						piti	
Passaddhi (tranquility)						passaddhi	
Upekkha (equinimity)						upekkha	

Conditions for the Four Stages of Nibbana

The following Table shows the conditions to be fulfilled (i.e., factors to be eliminated) to attain each stage of Nibbana. For example, in order to attain the Sotapanna stage, three of the ten sanyojana are removed, *akusala* citta #1, 2, 5, 6, and 11 are removed with the apayagami strength in the other cittas also removed, etc.

	Sanyojana	Akusala Citta	Anusaya	Asava (Asaya)
Sotapanna	saccaya ditthi vicikicca silabbata paramasa	1,2,5,6,11 Also removes apayagami strength in the rest	ditthi vicikicca	ditthiasava
Sakadagami	kama raga (reduced) patigha (reduced)	weakens 9, 10 also weakens kama raga in 3,4,7,8	kama raga (reduced) patigha (reduced)	kamasava (reduced)
Anagami	kamaraga patigha	9,10 also removes kama raga in 3,4,7,8	kamaraga patigha	kamasava
Arahant	rupa raga arupa raga mana uddacca avijja	3,4,7,8,12 (see below for a list of <i>akusala</i> citta)	mana rupa raga arupa raga avijja	bhavasava avijjasava

Asava and anusaya are discussed in the post, “[Gathi \(Character\), Anusaya \(Temptations\), and Asava \(Cravings\)](#)“. I hope to write a post on the Dasa Sanyojana.

The 12 types of *akusala* citta are listed in, “[Akusala Citta and Akusala Vipaka Citta](#)“. But I thought it would be more explanatory to list them. The numbers below correspond to the numbers in the Table.

Lobha (Greedy) Citta (Also has the moha root)

1. Citta connected with wrong view, accompanied by pleasure, and done with habit.
2. Citta connected with wrong view, accompanied by pleasure, and done reluctantly.
3. Citta NOT connected with wrong view, accompanied by pleasure, and done with habit.
4. Citta NOT connected with wrong view, accompanied by pleasure, and done reluctantly.
5. Citta connected with wrong view, accompanied by neutral mind, and done with habit.
6. Citta connected with wrong view, accompanied by neutral mind, and done reluctantly.
7. Citta NOT connected with wrong view, accompanied by neutral mind, and done with habit.
8. Citta NOT connected with wrong view, accompanied by neutral mind, and done reluctantly.

Dosa (Hateful) Citta (Also has the moha root)

9. Citta associated with hate, accompanied by displeasure, done with habit.
10. Citta associated with hate, accompanied by displeasure, done reluctantly.

Moha Citta (only with the moha root)

11. Citta accompanied by neutral mind, associated with vicikicca (not aware of bad consequences)

12. Citta accompanied by neutral mind, associated with uddacca (unfocused).

Notes:

1. Even though recent Abhidhamma literature categorize lobha and dosa citta as asankharika (unprompted) and sasankharika (prompted), in original Abhidhamma, they were not categorized as such.

2. For example, the two dosa-mula cittas are:

1. Domanassa sahagata patigha-sampayutta citta.

2. Domanassa sahagata sasankharika patigha-sampayutta citta.

- The first citta arises due to sansaric habits and thus are more potent. For example, someone who has a tendency to flare-up, normally generates such potent citta.
- On the other hand, another person without such a habit, may not generate such a citta unless “forced hard”; it is done with reluctance, “when pushed to the limit”.

Ultimate Realities – Table

1. This Table lists the three kinds of ultimate realities (paramatta dhamma) in this world of 31 realms; they are conditioned, i.e., they arise due to causes and perish subsequently on their own; nothing in this world is permanent. They do not arise if there are no causes, and when that happens Nibbana is the result.

- Nibbana is the unconditioned reality. It is attained when the six causes (lobha, dosa, moha, alobha, adosa, amoha) are not there. Then the mind cannot get a “foothold” anywhere in the material world.
- Cultivating the three causes of alobha, adosa, amoha (together with removing lobha, dosa, moha) is needed in following the Noble Eightfold Path, and when wisdom grows, all causes will be rejected by the mind automatically at the end.

2. Ultimate realities can be compared to the fundamental particles in physics. Even though it was believed in the early stages that atoms were the fundamental particles, now there are about 32 of such particles; but now the “particle nature” is dissolving into “energy packets” in elementary particle physics. In Buddha Dhamma, the 28 types of rupa are very fine, and cannot be “seen” even with abhinna powers; they are “energy packets”.

3. The table also shows how “this world of 31 realms” can be described via the five aggregates, the twelve sense bases, or 6 dhatus and how they incorporate the ultimate realities. There are other ways too. They are all compatible and consistent with each other.

- For example, 89 citta and 52 cetasika are included in the four “mental” aggregates, or in the mind base and mind objects, or just in the vinnana dhatu.

Table: Analysis of the “world” and Nibbana in terms of ultimate realities.

Lokaya (World of 31 Realms)				Nibbana
Ultimate Realities (4 types)	Citta (89)	Cetasika (52)	Rupa (28)	Nibbana
Aggregates (5)		Vedana skandha Sanna skandha Sankhara skandha Vinnana skandha	Rupa skandha	
Sense Bases (12)	Mind base	Mind Objects (also includes fine matter or sukuma rupa)	5 internal (pasada) rupa 5 external rupa (vanna, sadda, gandha, rasa, pottabba)	
Dhatu (6)		Vinnana	patavi, apo, tejo, vayo, akasa	
	sankata include everything in this world (sentient beings have all six dhatu; everything else in the world, like inert objects and plants, do not have vinnana)			
Notes: 1. Number of citta can be 121 in the alternate scheme; see, The 89 (121) Types of Citta				asankata

2. Vedana, sanna are two cetasika; sankhara has the rest of 50 cetasika; for a list of cetasika, see Cetasika (Mental Factors)	
3. For fine (sukuma) rupa, see Rupa (Material Form) – Table .	

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Introduction – What is Suffering?

1. There are two opposing factors to deal with when one is trying to convey the message of the Buddha to others:
 - Foremost, the other person needs to be able to comprehend what I write. If I use too many Pali words some people, especially those in the Western world, may not understand fully and also may get discouraged.
 - On the other hand, I need to be careful not to distort the meaning of some key Pali words. Sometimes there is no English word that truly convey the meaning of a Pali word. Providing incorrect information is worse than doing nothing.
2. I would like to test this new approach where I will describe concepts with minimal Pali words. When one gets the basic idea, one could “dig in deeper” by reading regular posts.
3. **Buddha Dhamma is all about ending suffering and finding permanent happiness IN THIS VERY LIFE.** *Paticca samuppada* describes how root causes for suffering lead to suffering step by step. If we understand these root causes for suffering, we can avoid such causes and make sure suffering would not arise in the future.
 - The Buddha said, we suffer when we cannot maintain things to our satisfaction. Therefore, the main idea is to see whether there is ANYTHING in this WORLD that CAN BE maintained to our satisfaction.
 - However, before analyzing the steps in the *Paticca samuppada*, it is necessary to sort out what suffering is.

Three Categories of Suffering

1. What is our world? Our existence, our lives, are basically what we experience: we sense things through our five physical senses and then think about them using our minds. Thus our world can be summed up by saying that it is what we experience through our INTERNAL six senses (eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body, mind). If we can have “good experiences” we are happy, otherwise, we get sad and suffer.
 - Now what we experience depends on WHAT WE SENSE through our physical senses (visuals, sounds, smells, tastes, touchables) and also WHAT WE THINK ABOUT such experiences (thoughts and concepts).
 - Those twelve (six INTERNAL and six EXTERNAL) make up “our world”. Everything is included in those twelve.
 - **Mind is complex, so let us first focus on the body and the five physical senses.** Before the end of the essay we will inevitably get to the mind.
2. Let us start our analysis with the simplest ten out of twelve that make up our world:
 - Can we keep our internal senses (eyes, ears, nose, tongue, and the body) to our satisfaction?
 - Can we keep those that we like to experience that are in the outside world (visuals, sounds, smells, tastes, touchables) to our satisfaction?
3. Let us discuss these two issue one by one. First, let us think about whether we can keep our physical

bodies and its associated senses to our satisfaction.

- It is true that we can maintain our five physical senses to our satisfaction for many years. And this is why people do not even take time to think about these ideas. There are many temptations out there and we cannot wait to “get back to such senses pleasures”. This is why the Buddha said that the suffering is “hidden behind a veil of apparent pleasures”.
- We start feeling this hidden suffering when we pass the middle age. Our five physical senses start getting weaker. The eyesight start dropping, hearing may start decreasing, our tongues may start losing its ability to taste, our noses becomes less sensitive, and our bodies start sagging, we may start losing hair, teeth, etc.
- So, what do most us do? We start looking for ways to “prop them up”: We can take temporary measures by wearing glasses, hearing aids, adding more spices to food, and doing cosmetic procedures to try to maintain the body appearance. There is absolutely nothing wrong with some of these “fixes”; for example, we need to be able to see, so we need to take precautions to protect our eyes and start wearing glasses. Ditto for hearing aids, and even for adding spices to food. Even doing some cosmetic procedures (coloring the hair, for example) may be needed to maintain a level of self-confidence as may be the case.

4. But the point is that no matter what we do, there comes a time when nothing works. The whole body starts falling apart. We may lose all the hair, the skin sagging may no longer be prevented by surgery; we may lose all hearing; the food may become tasteless. The best way to realize this first hand is to visit a home for the elderly.

- We also tend to get sick and come down with diseases easily as we get old.
- But the worst part is that our brains will start getting weaker which will lead to memory loss and most importantly the ability to think.
- If we wait until we get to that stage, it WILL BE TOO LATE. By the time we realize that our minds are weak, then we become really helpless.

5. Some people just die of unexpected causes before getting to old age. But that is also the same thing: they could not maintain things the way they expected. We could have prevented at least some of this suffering if we understood the root causes for suffering, and focused our attention on doing “fruitful things” while doing some of those temporary measures to keep our sense faculties in good shape. We will discuss such ‘fruitful deeds’ after discussing the suffering associated with external things in this world.

- The suffering that we discussed so far arises due to one aspect of *anicca*: things are subjected to decay and destruction, and nothing in this world is exempt from that; this is part of what is called “*viparināma dukkhā*”.

6. Now let us look at the EXTERNAL things that make up “our physical world”: visuals, sounds, smells, tastes, touchables are experienced with our five physical senses.

- The suffering associated with external things arise NOT necessarily because they are “impermanent” as is incorrectly believed by many. There are many external things that are permanent, at least compared to our lifetime in this life. For example, a gold necklace will last for even millions of years. If there is any suffering arises in anyone due to a gold necklace that is definitely NOT because that necklace is “impermanent”. We will discuss some examples

below.

7. Of course there are many truly “impermanent” things that we use. And we do become distraught when they break down. For example, we buy a nice set of dinner plates and if they get broken we become distraught. But we can always buy another, and that is not a problem especially if one is wealthy. Even if a wealthy person’s whole house is burned down, that person can easily buy a better one. So, one would think that wealthy people will be subjected to less suffering.

- But that is not the case. Even though having wealth helps, as far as suffering is concerned, wealth is not a big factor. We hear wealthy and famous people even committing suicide all the time.
- Most of the suffering associated with external things arise due to “unfruitful thoughts” in our minds: Suffering arises mainly due to things we are attached to, and things that we like to hate. This is a **KEY POINT** and needs a lot of thought.

8. Let us consider some examples to clarify this important point.

- A hurricane lands and destroys a large cultivated area that results in a significant damage. Most people who live close-by would be just glad that their homes were not damaged but they will not become distraught over the loss to that particular land. The only one who suffers is the one who is the owner of that land. **Suffering arises due to a loss or damage or destruction of something one likes.** The suffering was not inherent in that external cultivated area; the only person who suffered was the one who had an attachment to it.

Let us take another example. A wealthy person A hires person B to live in his house and to take care of the house and the gardens. Person A may not even live in that house. Person B lives in the house and takes good care of the house and the gardens. Anyone who does not know the real owner would think that person B is the owner, the way he takes good care of the house. Person B goes out-of-town to visit his family for a few days and an enemy of person A burns down the house. Who is the one that suffers? Person B may feel bad about his employer’s loss, but it is person A who will mostly suffer due to the loss of the house. Even though person B may have lived in that house for many years on his own, he did not have any sense of “ownership” to the house; he may become somewhat distraught because of him having lived there and formed a lesser attachment to the house.

- In the case of the gold necklace that we mentioned earlier, someone may suffer if she lost it. The suffering was not due to an “impermanence” associated with the necklace; rather it was due to the inability of that person to “maintain it to her satisfaction”.

9. Does this mean a person who does not own anything is the happiest? Not at all. Even though one may not have ownership to anything valuable, that person still has cravings for pleasurable things. Much of his suffering is due to the **INABILITY** to GET what he wants. He may want a big house, a nice car, tasty foods, etc. He suffers not due to a loss of physical items, but his inability to get such items.

- Thus whether wealthy or poor does not matter. The real cause of suffering is in our **MINDS**. A wealthy person may suffer due to a loss of something he had, and a poor person may suffer to the inability get what he wants. Either person becomes distraught due to his/her mind activities: attachment to what one has or craving for what one desires. This is another aspect of the Pali term *anicca*. It is mostly mental and is called “**sankhāra dukkhā**”. It arises due to the wrong way we think about things in this world. We will discuss this in detail in *paticca samuppada* steps.

10. External things also include people. The amount of suffering due to a loss of a person is directly proportional to how close that person was to oneself. When person X dies, those who suffer the most are the closest family; for friends and distant relatives, suffering is less, and for those who do not even know X, there is no suffering.

- But it is important to understand that one CANNOT get rid of this suffering by abandoning the family; that would be an immoral act with bad consequences. The attachment becomes less as wisdom grows, when one starts understanding deeper aspects of Dhamma: **Basically, there is a difference between fulfilling responsibilities, paying back debts, and having attachment due to greed.** But this also will become much more clear as we proceed with *paticca samuppada*.

11. Of course *sankhara dukkha* also arises due to hate. This is a bit deeper, since hate arises as a “second aspect” of greed. Hate arises when something or someone gets in the way of us getting what we crave for. We will examine the root causes for hate in *paticca samuppada*, but for now we need to keep in mind that someone may be doing something bad (getting in our way), because we may have done something bad to that person in the past. Things ALWAYS happen for one or more reasons, and we may not be able to see the reason (or the cause) in many cases, because the rebirth process keeps things hidden from us.

- In any case, when we start thinking about a hateful person or a thing, it is ourselves that suffer. The mere mention of the name of someone that we despise, will immediately make us think about those bad things that the person did, and get “worked up”. We cause this suffering to ourselves. If we retaliate, then things get even worse.
- It is good to analyze some of one’s own experiences.

We discuss “[dukkha dukkhā](#)”, the third and final category of suffering, in the next post: [Introduction -2 – The Three Characteristics of Nature](#).

Introduction -2 – The Three Characteristics of Nature

1. In the previous post, we discussed two of the three main ways that suffering arises, the *viparinama dukkha* (suffering due to our inability to maintain things to one's satisfaction) and the *sankhara dukkha* (suffering due to our excess attachment for things). **Both these are experienced in this very life**, but unless we take time and contemplate on those, we may not even be aware of those.

- There is nothing much we can do about the *viparinama dukkha*, other than to eat well, exercise regularly, and keep up with healthy habits for maintaining a healthy body and a mind.
- We can lessen the *sankhara dukkha* by gradually losing excess attachment to worldly things. This happens automatically when we start grasping the Three Characteristics of nature, which we will discuss below.

2. The third category of suffering arises due to immoral deeds, and may not become evident in this life. For example, a person who made money by killing another or by stealing from another may live well in this life (at least outwardly), but will be subjected to much suffering in the upcoming births. This is the worst category of *dukkha dukkha*, **which can lead to rebirth in the four lower realms**.

- Therefore, the third category of suffering, *dukkha dukkha*, arises basically due to immoral acts; see below. The severity of suffering of course depends on the severity of the violation. We will discuss this in detail in the *paticca samuppada* (“*pati+ichcha*” leading to “*sama*”+“*uppada*”) steps in future posts; see, “[Paticca Samuppada – “Pati+ichcha”+“Sama+uppāda](#)“, where it is briefly discussed how one's actions lead to effects that are similar “in kind”.

3. All our acts (including speech and thoughts) are *sankhara*, thus *dukkha dukkha* arises due to the worst forms of *sankhara*, which we call immoral acts.

Everything happens due to a reason (cause). If one does a good deed, that will lead to good results, and bad deeds will lead to bad results. This is the basis of science and also how nature works. “Every action has a reaction”; it is guaranteed, sooner or later.

- This is why rebirth is a reality of nature. There are people who live lavishly with money earned by immoral deeds; the consequences will be realized in the future rebirths.
- It also explains why different people are born with different levels of health, wealth, beauty, etc., and also why there are innumerable varieties of animals with different levels of suffering.

The Three Characteristics

4. Most people can distinguish between moral and immoral acts. Immoral acts are killing, stealing, inappropriate sexual behavior, lying, slandering, gossiping, harsh speech, and getting “drunk” with not only drugs or alcohol, but also with wealth, fame, power, etc (The BIG EIGHT as discussed in the Meditation section).

- When we also include the wrong views/hate in the mind, there are ten, which are called the ten defilements or “*dasa akusala*” in Pali. These acts not only are inappropriate but also will have adverse consequences for the well being of everyone. Societies cannot function well if people act immorally.

5. Most religions teach how to live a moral life, may be with some exceptions for example of killing of animals as immoral. Basically all religions encourage “building better societies”. Therefore morality and moral laws are common to all cultures and religions.

- Without having this moral foundation, it is hard to comprehend the deeper aspects that we will discuss next, and analyze in the *paticca samuppada*.
- However, it is important to realize that one will be free of all ten defilements only upon reaching the *Arahant* stage. Keeping the five conventional precepts is a good start.
- When one starts following the Path, one is bound to break the trend once in a while. A child learning to walk will fall many times. Many people get discouraged when they do an immoral act occasionally; but just to realize that one did a mistake, and that it bothers one's mind, means one HAS MADE PROGRESS.

6. The uniqueness in Buddha Dhamma is to show that in the wider world view, building better societies (i.e., living a moral life) is NOT ENOUGH in the LONG TERM in the rebirth process. In this wider world view, anyone can be born anywhere in the 31 realms, including those dreaded lower four realms. It is a much bigger world than we normally experience.

- Doing immoral acts makes one eligible to be born the lower four realms, and be subjected to *dukkha dukkha*. **However, even if one does not do a single immoral act in this life, that does not guarantee avoidance of rebirth in the lower four realms, BECAUSE we all have done immoral deeds in our previous lives.** What we have in the past remain until that *kammic* power is exhausted OR until one attains *Nibbana*. Again this is part of the “bigger world view” now spanning time.

7. This was the core message of the Buddha: That no matter how well we live this life (and it is essential to do that), that does not guarantee a “suffering-free” future. Until one attains at the least the *Sotapanna* stage of *Nibbana*, one is not free from suffering in the four lower worlds.

- We can look at it this way too: Even if we live a good, moral life in this life, we do not know under what conditions we will be born in the next life, even if it is a human life. If we are born to an immoral family, or be exposed to immoral friends, in the next life we may commit acts that deserves birth in the four lower realms.
- This is why need to strive to attain the *Sotapanna* stage in this very life.

8. This is what is embedded in the three characteristics of “this wider world” of 31 realms. We may be born in the highest Brahma world, but one day that life will end and we will inevitably get to the the four realms at some point. The Buddha said, “there is no refuge” anywhere in these 31 realms.

9. In the previous post we discussed why we “cannot keep any part of our physical body to our satisfaction”. If we think through how *dukkha dukkha* arises, we can see that “we cannot maintain anything to our satisfaction” **anywhere** in these 31 realms in the long term. This is the first characteristic of “this world of 31 realms”: ***anicca***. Just one word says it all.

- Because of *anicca*, no matter how much we struggle to achieve sense pleasures, we will eventually encounter suffering, especially in the four lower realms. We always have *viparinama dukkha* and *sankhara dukkha* (both may be hidden in the apparent sense pleasures temporarily), and we cannot avoid *dukkha dukkha* without attaining the *Sotapanna* stage of *Nibbana*.
- Thus *anicca* leads to the second characteristic of ***dukkha***.
- Therefore, as long as we crave for existence and sense pleasures “in this world”, we are truly helpless in the LONG TERM; this is the third characteristic of ***anatta***. There is “no refuge” in this world of 31 realms.

10. At first it is difficult to see why these three characteristics are a such a big deal. They are the KEY to stop the causes for suffering.

- Just the realization that it is **harmful and unfruitful** to attach to things in this world leads to the first stage of *Nibbana*, the *Sotapanna* stage. Buddha Dhamma is a complete description of nature. **Just being able to comprehend the unfruitfulness of attachment to worldly things (and aversion, which arises from attachment as we will see), is the first and most important step in the Noble Eightfold Path, *Samma Ditthi* or “clear comprehension”.**

11. It is important to realize that attachment to worldly things CANNOT be done by forcing the mind. If someone tries to give away one’s wealth without truly realizing the benefits of that, one will likely to generate friction or remorse later, which could have adverse effects.

- It may be hard to believe, but the real happiness ARISES (and one will be able to donate things with joy, because one will automatically see the fruitless of craving for worldly things) as one starts comprehending the true meanings of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, and realize that it is possible to stop all three form of suffering. It is permanent sense of relief, and not like a sense pleasure that lasts only for a short time.
- As we go through the steps in the *paticca samuppada* cycles, the meanings will *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* will become clear. One could and should read other related posts too. At some point, things will start “clicking” into place and then it will become easier. Just a glimpse of the “light” will make it easier to “see”.

12. The lack of this knowledge (or even better stated as wisdom or *panna*), is called ignorance (*avijja*). Thus the whole *paticca samuppada* cycle starts with ignorance (*avijja*), and explains how *avijja* gives rise to *dukkha* under different conditions. There is another *paticca samuppada* cycle that explains how *dukkha* can be stopped from arising. We will discuss both starting with the next post. **Thus *avijja* leads not only to immoral acts, but also to unfruitful acts; both immoral and unfruitful actions are included in *sankhara*.**

13. I know I am using more and more Pali words as we proceed. But by now one should be able to grasp the meaning of those key words; one can always go back to earlier posts in this series to refresh memory. It is cumbersome to keep stating “it is not possible to maintain things to one’s satisfaction”; it is much easier to say, “*anicca*”. No other language can succinctly state the nature of the “whole world” in just three words: *anicca* (pronounced “anichcha”), *dukkha*, *anatta* (pronounced “anaththa”).

- As we saw above, *dukkha* has much deeper meaning than the “feeling of discomfort or pain”.
- Even *avijja* and *panna* do not have corresponding words in English to convey the exact meaning. As we discuss further, the meanings will become more clear.
- Thus my goal to is to first describe these key Pali words in plain English and then use them in the subsequent posts, while staying away from other Pali words that are not critical for understanding the core message of the Buddha.

Next, “[Avijja paccaya sankhara](#)“,

Avijja paccaya Sankhara

“Avijja paccaya sankhara” (Ignorance as root cause for immoral/unfruitful actions and thoughts).

1. *Avijja*, which is loosely translated as ignorance, is normally defined in many ways: not knowing the Four Noble Truths, not understanding the Noble Eightfold Path, not understanding the Three Characteristics of nature, not understanding *dukkha*, etc.

- All these are correct, but just reading about them is not going to help, until the mind clearly sees how suffering arises due to immoral and unwise actions (and thoughts).
- The *paticca samuppada* cycle clarifies how the three kinds of suffering arises because one does not comprehend the true nature of the world, and think (and do) immoral/unfruitful things.

2. If you are reading this without reading the first two posts, you may be wondering whether I was being untruthful when I said this series will be in “plain English”. I did describe these three terms in plain English, and there is no easy way to get the same meaning across without using such key Pali words.

- So, once I clarify them, I have to use these Pali terms in order to keep a post to a reasonable length, AND readable. One can always go back and read previous introductory posts to refresh memory.

3. The standard interpretation of “*avijja paccaya sankhara*” reads “ignorance leads to mental formations”, which does not get the underlying ideas across and also misleading. I believe that “ignorance as root cause for immoral/unfruitful actions” is a better translation, and I will explain why.

First let us look at the difference between immoral acts and unfruitful acts.

- We saw that *dukkha dukkha* in the four lower realms is the worst form of suffering. And we saw the cause of that as the immoral acts done with the ten defilements or *dasa akusala*. Thus worst forms of *sankhara* are responsible for *dukkha dukkha* in the lower four realms.
- Why do we do any of such strong immoral acts that give rise to *dukkha dukkha* of the worst kinds in the lower four realms? Because to a very high degree of ignorance of the consequences of such acts. For example, if one does not believe in rebirth, then it is hard to see how such immoral acts can have consequences. After all, there are many people engaged in immoral behavior who seem to be enjoying life.
- Such high level of ignorance is called *moha* (which means totally covered, totally blind mind), and the closest English word is delusion.
- A murderer who PLANS and kills another human is a good example. He thinks that if he can plan it well, he can avoid “getting caught” by the justice system and then will not have to pay for his act. He does not understand that there are MUCH WORSE consequences waiting for him, regardless of whether he is caught by the police or not. He does not know that he is likely to get killed thousand times in return in future births.
- Thus immoral acts like killing, stealing, etc are responsible for the worst outcomes, the worst kinds of future suffering; these are the worst forms of *sankhara*.

4. On the other side of the spectrum for *sankhara* are the unfruitful actions that lead to lower levels of *sankhara dukkha* in this very life. For example, when we get attached to things/people via strong attachments or strong dislikes, that can lead to mental suffering in this life as we discussed in previous posts.

- However, such unfruitful actions can also form bad habits that can grow into bigger problems with time. Someone acting with greed or dislikes habitually can tend to make those stronger and eventually grow into stronger forms of excess greed and hate, leading to immoral acts. We will discuss how this happens via the *paticca samuppada* steps.
- Of course the severity of the consequences will be according to the severity and nature of the act: “*pati+ichcha*” leading to “*sama*”+ “*uppada*”, as we will discuss in detail later. See, “[Paticca Samuppada – “Pati+ichcha”+“Sama+uppada”](#)” for the meaning of *paticca samuppada*. When one is even willing to do immoral acts to get what one wants, the consequences will also be stronger and “in kind”. Then there are “unfruitful acts” that can lead to comparatively minor forms of suffering in the near term, but can also add up to bigger effects in the long run.
- Thus one has to think beyond the five precepts to understand the origin of *sankhara dukkha*. I know I am repeating some statements, but I want to make sure to get these important ideas across.

I hope it is clear now why “immoral/unfruitful actions (and thoughts)” is a better translation for *sankhara* than “mental formations”.

5. Now let us discuss the other erroneous aspect of the translation of “*avijja paccaya sankhara*” as “ignorance leads to mental formations”. For further details, see, “[What Does “Paccaya” Mean in Paticca Samuppada?](#)”.

- Ignorance does not lead to *sankhara* all the time. Even the worst criminal does not do immoral acts or even unfruitful acts ALL THE TIME. **But when he does**, such actions are done with ignorance as a root cause.
- It applies to all of us: The more we get rid of ignorance, the less will we think or do either immoral or unfruitful things, i.e., any type of *sankhara*.

6. **A closely related issue to think about is what kind of control we have over *sankhara*.** There are three types of *sankhara*: *kaya sankhara* (those done with body, i.e., physical acts), *vaci sankhara* (those done with speech), and *mano sankhara* (those done with thoughts).

- If we know right from wrong, we can control MOST of our **physical actions and speech**. We may even start saying something bad and stop ourselves in the middle of the sentence.
- Yet, depending on the emotional state of the mind, it may be not possible to control our actions under extreme stressful situations. For example, even though a person who would not even hurt another’s feelings may get into a rage if he catches his wife is engaging in sex with another man, and may even kill that man in the heat of the moment. We also know “good people” who were tempted to do immoral things if the “payout or the perceived pleasure was big enough”. This is the danger of “not being free of the four lower realms”.

7. The third category, *mano sankhara*, are also hard to control by will power AT THAT TIME. I think we all can think about situations where it was hard to control greedy/hateful thoughts. We just get to think about something and the mind takes us all over the place thinking about “what we could have”,

etc and also fantasize about all kinds of sense pleasures.

- **These, and the *kaya* and *vaci sankhara* done on “impulse” or “temptations” discussed above, can only be lessened and ultimately stopped by changing one’s habits (“*gathi*”) and cravings (“*asavas*”).**
- And that comes about by realizing the unfruitfulness of any type of *sankhara*. This is strongly related to comprehending the Three Characteristics and we will be analyzing this in the upcoming steps of *paticca samuppada*.

8. Thus the key is to change one’s bad habits over time. Then, gradually, even such *mano sankhara* will STOP FROM ARISING.

- It may be hard to believe, but big part of this change of habits and cravings comes from comprehending the Three Characteristics of this world. When one realizes that it does not MAKE SENSE to hurt others (including animals) to get sense pleasure for oneself, that makes a BIG DIFFERENCE in one’s outlook about what a “good life is”.
- Contrary to what most people believe, a “good, peaceful, life” is not a life filled with sense pleasures. An extravagant life can eventually become a “burdened life”, because our body’s ability to accommodate sense pleasures goes down as we age. This realization itself leads to “cooling down” of the mind. Anyway, as we discuss further, and if one contemplates more along these ideas, these concepts will slowly become clear.

9. In summary, all three kinds of suffering arise due to *sankhara* that range from highly immoral acts to seemingly innocent unfruitful actions, and all *sankhara* arise due to *avijja*.

- This is why “*avijja paccaya sankhara*” is the first step in the *paticca samuppada* cycle, which ends with “*jara, marana, soka, parideva, dukkha,*” all kinds of suffering.

Thus we can see in an approximate way how suffering arises with immoral/unfruitful actions as causes, which themselves arise due to ignorance of the true nature of the world: *anicca, dukkha, anatta*. Here we discussed how ignorance gives rise to *sankhara*. in the next post we will discuss how *sankhara* leads to *vinna* or defiled consciousness as the next step leading to *dukkha* (suffering).

Next, “[Sankhara paccaya Vinnana – 1](#)“,

Sankhara paccaya Vinnana – 1

1. “***Sankhara paccaya Vinnana***” is normally translated something like, “with mental formations as condition, consciousness arises”. But I will show that a more accurate translation is, “Immoral/unfruitful actions and thoughts as root condition for **defiled consciousness**”.

- I will just keep the word *vinnana* without translating as “defiled consciousness” (which could become cumbersome to repeat also), because the word “consciousness” cannot fully embody the meaning of *vinnana*.
- *Vinnana* is a step in the *paticca samuppada* that describes how suffering arises; thus *vinnana* is NOT neutral or innocuous as the word “consciousness” or “awareness” implies; it is **DEFILED** consciousness, contaminated with immoral mental factors such as greed and hate.
- In contrast, an *Arahant* has undefiled, pure consciousness; thus an *Arahant* experiences the world without any defilements. He/she can see, hear, etc without making any type of judgement, attachment, or repulsion to what is seen, heard, etc.

Thus we need to realize that *vinnana* is DIFFERENT from “knowing” or “being aware”, which is what “consciousness” implies. This is very important.

2. For example, two people with opposing political views (A and B) may encounter a politician C on the street who has views compatible with those of A. Person A will be happy to meet C and may go up to C, shake his hand and talk to him enthusiastically. On the other hand, Person B will automatically have irritable thoughts about C and is likely to avoid C. In this case, A and B generated two very different kinds of *vinnana* upon seeing the same person.

- On the other hand, suppose there is a fourth person, D, who also knows the politician C AND suppose D is an *Arahant*. Now, person D will recognize C as that politician but will not generate any likes or dislikes about C. That is what “consciousness” is, just recognizing who or what it is without generating any biases.

3. The other main point is that *vinnana* is multi-faceted. **It has embedded in it one’s memories as well as one’s future hopes and plans**, and those lie under the surface. This is what Sigmund Freud called the subconscious. But there is no separate “subconscious”; there is only one *citta* at a time.

- The mind does this with the help of several mental factors (*cetasika*) like memory (*manasikara*) and perception (*sanna*). We will discuss that in the future.

4. For example, when I am looking at a picture I have what is called *cakku vinnana*, i.e., “visual consciousness”. However, if I have been planning a trip overseas that is still in the “back of my mind”; if I have been thinking about calling an old friend about whom I just thought of recently, that is also in the “back of my mind”. Thus at a given time there may be several or even many *vinnana* waiting to come to the surface.

- And some of those “subconscious” *vinnana* may disappear, if the reason for it to be there goes away for some reason. For example, if civil war breaks out in the country that I was planning to visit, I will abandon that trip and my “*vinnana*” for that will go away. If I stop thinking about my old friend, that *vinnana* for calling him up may also go away with time. Thus if a given *vinnana* stops getting “its food” it will die off gradually.

5. **Now we can see how “*sankhara paccaya vinnana*” works.** The more I think about my old friend,

the more *sankhara* I am generating; thus I keep “feeding that *vinnana*” and that *vinnana* for calling him gets stronger.

- The breaking out of the civil war in that country basically deprived the “*vinnana* for making a trip to that country” of any food (i.e., now it is not possible to visit that country), and thus the news effectively killed that *vinnana*.
- As always, it is best to think about your own situations and see how “*sankhara paccaya vinnana*” works, and also how one can have many types of *vinnana* at the same time, even though only one is at the forefront at any given time.

6. There is another way that *vinnana* can be divided into two main categories. One is the “base level” of *vinnana* for an existence or *bhava*. For example, if a deer is reborn as a human, then that lifestream will now have a “higher base level of *vinnana*” suitable for a human. Whereas a deer cannot sort out right from wrong, a human can. Thus at the end of a given “*bhava*” (say as a deer), that lifestream gets new, higher “base level” of *vinnana*.

- The other main category of *vinnana* is the numerous types of *vinnana* that arise in a given existence that we discussed above. What we perceive through the six senses (eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind) gives rise to six types of consciousness: vision, hearing, smell, taste, touch, and concepts. Based on those, we can have infinite types of *vinnana* as we discussed above. These types of *vinnana* are now in accordance with the type of existence or “*bhava*”. For example, a deer does not perceive what is seen at the same level of consciousness as a human, even if both are looking at the same thing. Sometimes there may be differences in sense faculties too: a bat cannot see but uses sonar to find its way around. Furthermore, as we discussed above, there are many types of “subconscious” *vinnana* as well.
- There are many new concepts introduced in these introductory posts that are critical. One may need to go back to previous posts and re-read in order to grasp these important concepts.

7. Based on those two categories, there are two main *paticca samuppada* cycles that describe life “in this world of 31 realms”:

- One describes how the “base level” of *vinnana* changes at the end of a “*bhava*”, say when a deer is reborn as a human. Here a given lifestream can make a transition from a lower base level of *vinnana* to a higher (e.g., deer reborn as a human) or vice versa (e.g., human reborn as a deer). This is the “*patisandhi paticca samuppada*” cycle.
- The other *paticca samuppada* cycle describes how a given lifestream accumulates conditions for suffering during a given “*bhava*”. This is where we experience *vinnana* through our daily activities. This is the “*pavutti paticca samuppada*” cycle.

Let us discuss the *vinnana* associated with this latter one first.

1. *Sankhara paccaya Pavutti Vinnana*

Let us first look at how our consciousness changes basically every moment in an active day. We are being bombarded with pictures, sounds, smells, tastes, body touches, and we think about all sorts of things throughout the day. In each single case, we experience a different *vinnana*. This is why *vinnana* is very complex and multi-faceted.

1. If we take a simple example of looking at a person, there are multiple events that happens in the mind: the physical eye captures an image of the mind which is processed by the brain and sent to the

mind (details of this will be discussed in the Abhidhamma section later). The mind instantly compares that image with previous experiences and recognizes that it is a close friend. Happy feelings may arise instantly too. If we had not seen him for a while, some old memories associated with him may also instantly pop into our mind. The sum total of all mental factors (feelings, perception, joy, etc) associated with that “seeing event” is the “eye consciousness” or “*cakku vinnana*” at that moment.

- And this is an example of a “*vipaka vinnana*”. We did not plan to see him, but just bumped into him.

2. But now based on this *vipaka vinnana*, we may decide to take some actions. We may run to meet him, give him a hug, and follow-up with even more actions. Most of these could be harmless *sankhara* and our experience, consciousness, or *vinna* is mostly harmless.

- However, if we instead ran into a person with whom we recently had a serious argument, that *vipaka vinnana* may lead to a series of “bad *sankhara*” in our minds and thus lead to a totally different *vinna* BASED ON those bad *sankhara*. we may decide to say something bad to that person. Now we are doing *vaci sankhara* that may have adverse consequences. Now our *vinna* is different and we feel differently from the above case. We have an agitated state of mind, and with the slightest provocation from him, we may say or do even more harmful things.

3. When a thought arises in the mind, it has associated with it many mental factors (*cetasika*) which characterize how we feel: joy, sadness, greed, generosity, hate, kindness, etc. *Vinna* encompasses all such relevant mental factors.

- In the previous example of persons A and B meeting the politician C, person A’s thoughts embody happiness while person B’s thoughts embody dislike.
- For a *vinna* to arise, there must be some interest in the sense object. For example, we are bombarded with millions of sense inputs in a day, but we “pay attention to” only a fraction of those. Each mind has a set of “preferred items” in the background or “in the subconscious” based on the person’s habits and cravings.

4. Then, the more we “feed a given *vinna*” by thinking, speaking, doing things related that, the more strong it gets. Thus we can see how “habit building” is tightly associated with *sankhara*. In the same way, we can “remove a habit” by depriving that associated *vinna* of its food, i.e., by stopping thinking or doing things related to it.

- And that can be done only realizing the benefits of a good habit or adverse consequences of a bad habit, which was the first step in the *paticca samuppada*, “*avijja paccaya sankhara*”. A bit of thought should make this clear. Comprehending Buddha Dhamma takes time to think deeply about how all these things fit together. Just being able to recite the *paticca samuppada* cycle does not bring any benefits.

5. A simple example is “building a *vinna* for getting drunk”: A teenager may not like the taste of his first drink, but if he keeps doing it due to “peer pressure”, he is likely to build a new *vinna* for it. As he builds this *vinna*, he will keep accumulating *sankhara* to “feed that *vinna*”. He will be thinking about it, talking about it, and of course whenever has the chance he will be drinking. The more he does any of those *sankhara*, that *vinna* will grow. AND even when he is doing something else, that *vinna* will be at close to top of the subconscious waiting for an opportunity to come up and induce him to get drunk.

- And it works the same way for any type of activity. A teenager studying for an exam, will have a *vinnana* for it. If he is serious about it, he will be thinking about it more, talking about it, and studying hard; all those are *sankhara* too, in this case for his benefit.

The idea is to first not to do any *abhisankhara* (strong immoral *sankhara*) that could lead to birth in the four lower realms. These kinds of *sankhara* are the immoral acts, speech, and thoughts. We will discuss this in the next post.

Next, “[Sankhara paccaya Vinnana – 2](#)“,

Sankhara paccaya Vinnana – 2

If you are reading this without reading the earlier posts, you may be wondering whether I was being untruthful when I said this series will be in “plain English”. I did describe any of the terms used here in plain English in the previous posts. There is no easy way to get the same meaning across without using such key Pali words.

- So, once I clarify them, I have to use these Pali terms in order to keep a post to a reasonable length, AND readable. One can always go back and read previous posts to refresh memory.

In the previous post, we discussed how *sankhara* can feed and build different types of *vinnana* during our lifetime. The *paticca samuppada* cycle which describes that process is the *pavutti paticca samuppada* and we discussed the step “*sankhara paccaya pavutti vinnana*” for that *paticca samuppada*.

- Now we will discuss how such *pavutti vinnana* can become strong and be “carried over” to the future lives; not only that, one of such strong *vinnana* can even determine the next birth. That is why such strong *vinnana* can become “*patisandhi vinnana*” by providing the “link” to the next next life (that is what “*patisandhi*” means: “*sandhi*” is connection and “*pati*” is bond or making the connection).

2. Sankhara paccaya Patisandhi Vinnana

1. When we build *pavutti vinnana* during our lifetime as described in the previous post, such *vinnana* can get very strong and even get carry over to the next lives.

- In fact, some of the *vinnana* that we easily get “attached to” very well could be coming from previous lives.

2. For example, different people have “natural tendencies” for certain tasks (music, art, science, business, basically any type of activity). Similarly, some people are attracted to gambling, drinking, sports, etc more than others. All these are *sansaric* habits, that have been cultivated by “feeding that *vinnana*” over many lives.

- Unless one reduces and eventually gets rid of one’s bad habits, they can lead to bad births in the lower four realms where one can get trapped for long times. Similarly, developing good habits can lead to good births, in case one is unable to attain at least the *Sotapanna* stage in this life.
- This is why it is very important to get rid of “bad habits” and to cultivate “good habits”. There are many posts at the site on this important topic. I cannot emphasize enough the importance of this need to change habits.

3. Following the Noble Eightfold Path is all about changing to a “good person” first; doing “*anapanasati bhavana*” does the same thing. When one does this, one **develops wisdom** to see through the Three Characteristics: *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. And that also leads to the *Sotapanna* stage, where one is guaranteed to be free of rebirths in the lower four realms.

- By the way, many people are introduced to the wrong concept of “there is no self” (incorrect translation of the term *anatta*). Thus they get stuck, saying the term, “good person”, does not make sense (because there is no “self”); that could become a huge obstacle to any progress. While the Buddha rejected the concept of “self”, he also rejected the concept of “no-self”, because there is definitely some key personal characteristics that “flow” from one life to the next; see, “[What Reincarnates? – Concept of a Lifestream](#)”.

4. Once one is free of the four lower realms (i.e., attains the *Sotapanna* stage of *Nibbana*), only then one will truly realize that it is unfruitful even to wish for or work to seek rebirths in higher realms.

- But, until one attains the *Sotapanna* stage, one MUST avoid immoral *abhisankhara* (strong immoral actions) to avoid immoral *vinnana* and also engage in moral *abhisankhara* in order to cultivate moral *vinnana*; this will keep one firmly on the Path and to avoid rebirth in the lower four realms until the *Sotapanna* stage is attained.

5. If we think deeply about the suffering that we encounter in this life, *dukkha dukkha* has arisen due to whatever immoral *sankhara* done in a previous life. An animal suffers more than a human, because the cause for an animal birth was a stronger immoral action done previously.

- *Dukkha dukkha* associated with higher realms (*deva, brahma*) is less than the *dukkha dukkha* for a human life, because the *sankhara* that led to the *deva/brahma* births were merely unfruitful, they were not immoral.

6. Any birth anywhere in the 31 realms is due to a *abhisankhara*. If it is due to a worst form of *abhisankhara* (immoral actions) then that leads to a birth in the lowest four realms via a strong and bad *patisandhi vinnana*. Lesser *abhisankhara* (unfruitful actions) lead to births in higher realms via “moral” *abhisankhara vinnana*.

- Thus cultivating “immoral” *abhisankhara vinnana* must be avoided by not engaging in immoral activities. Otherwise, “*sankhara paccaya patisandhi vinnana*” could lead to “bad births”, where *dukkha dukkha* is very intense.

7. *Viparinama dukkha* associated with the current life is also mainly determined by previous action (*abhisankhara*) that led to this life, and can be analyzed the same way as for *dukkha dukkha*.

- But the *sankhara dukkha* associated with this life is due to actions (*sankhara*) that we do in this life. Also, the same *sankhara* that could cause future *dukkha dukkha* or *viparinama dukkha* can also give rise to *sankhara dukkha* in this life as well. This is an important point to be realized; if not clear, you may want to go back and review the previous posts.
- Therefore, we CAN get rid of part of the *dukkha* (the *sankhara dukkha*) in THIS LIFE by understanding Dhamma and acting and thinking accordingly. We can also stop or reduce ALL types of *dukkha* in FUTURE LIVES by this process.

If you have forgotten what these terms mean, it is a good idea to go back and refresh memory, because otherwise it will be difficult to comprehend the upcoming posts in this series as well. And these terms are critically important for grasping the message of the Buddha. *Avijja*, *sankhara*, and *vinnana* are key terms that must be comprehended; they do not have corresponding English words.

More on *vinnana* can be found at, “3. *Vinnana*, Thoughts, and the Subconscious”.

Next, [Vinnana paccaya Namarupa](#),

Vinnana paccaya Namarupa

The *namarupa* involved in the *pavutti paticca samuppada* cycle has a somewhat different meaning than the *namarupa* in the *patisandhi paticca samuppada* cycle. Here “*pavutti*” means “during lifetime”. In contrast, the *patisandhi paticca samuppada* cycle operates when the lifestream makes a transition from one existence to another (say deer to human).

- At the end of an existence (*bhava*), a given lifestream is making a quantum transition (meaning a large jump) from one kind of an existence to another; for example, from a deer to a human or vice versa. The basic level of *vinnana* changes from that of a deer to a much higher level of a human in the first case.
- That transition happens in the latter part of the last *citta vithi* of the life of the deer. This is discussed in a bit more detail in the post “[Cuti-Patisandhi – An Abhidhamma Description](#)”.

Vinnana paccaya Namarupa at Patsandhi

1. The key point is that at the end of the last *citta vithi* of the deer, a very fine human body called *gandhabbaya* emerges from the dead body of the deer. This fine body cannot be seen with the naked eye. This *gandhabbaya* is formed by the *kamma vipaka* that gave rise to this new human life, and blueprint of the grown human is in that *gandhabbaya*. This is the new “*namarupa*” of that lifestream.

- This blueprint of the human physical body thus has all the important details of the new life (*jati*); for example, sex type, the height, shape, any major physical disability, etc. Some minor features such as skin color or hair color may depend on the parents, but even those may be influenced by the *kamma vipaka* that gave rise to this new existence.

2. Thus as soon as the *vinnana* for the next existence was determined at the last *citta vithi* by the step “*sankhara paccaya vinnana*”, the next step of “*vinnana paccaya namarupa*” gives rise to the *namarupa* for the next life.

- Thus here “*nama*” includes the basic level of *vinnana* for the new human existence, which is much different from the “*nama*” of a deer. Obviously, the “*rupa*” is that of a human form and not of a deer. Thus “*namarupa*” makes a huge transition at the end of the “*bhava*” as a deer.

3. I have discussed previously how a deer could be reborn many times as a deer until the *kammic* energy of the “deer *bhava*” is exhausted; see, “[Bhava and Jati – States of Existence and Births Therein](#)”.

- In such instances, at the death of the deer, another “deer *gandhabbaya*” emerges from the dead body and waits for a suitable womb for “deer mother” becomes available. Here the new “*namarupa*” may be somewhat different, but still that of a deer, so the any change would be minor.
- Therefore, the “*vinnana paccaya namarupa*” gives rise to a new set of “*namarupa*” only at the *patisandhi* to a new existence.

Vinnana paccaya Namarupa During a Lifetime

1. Let us now continue with the human *gandhabbaya* that formed at the death of a deer in the previous discussion.

- Once this human becomes active, he/she could influence his/her “*namarupa*” according to how

he/she leads the life. The changes in the “*namarupa*” via the *pavutti paticca samuppada* cycle can be subtle.

- Once the *gandhabbaya* is attracted to a suitable womb, that *namarupa* grows in the womb according the blueprint in the *gandhabbaya*, and when the baby born that process continues.

2. Here “*namarupa*” mainly refer to those visualized by the person during each activity, and depend on the *nama* or *vinnana* for the particular activity. This *vinnana* is NOT the *patisandhi vinnana*, but the *vinnana* associated with the actions, i.e, *vinnana* arising from the type of activity or *sankhara*.

- These *pavutti vinnana* are basically the six types of *vinnana* associated with the six senses: eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind consciousnesses, or *cakkhu, sota, gandha, jivha, kaya, and mano vinnana*.

3. Let us take an example. When a thief plans to steal something, the process starts with “*avijja paccaya sankhara*”; he starts thinking about the plan because of his ignorance of the consequences, and that gives rise to *vinnana* about the theft: “*sankhara paccaya vinnana*”.

- Initially, they are mostly *mano vinnana* involved in planning. Here, “*vinnana paccaya namarupa*” means he is visualizing the act: how to break in, how to extract what he wants, and how to flee without getting caught. Thus here, “*namarupa*” are the visuals he has in his mind. The more he thinks about it, the stronger those *vinnana* and *namarupa* get. He is solidifying the plan.

4. In another example, a politician may be donating money to build a hospital, but the intent may be to get elected. Thus he starts the process with “*avijja paccaya sankhara*”; he starts thinking about the plan, and that gives rise to *vinnana* about the how and where to build the hospital and also how he may be able to get elected; such thoughts are the corresponding *vinnana*: “*sankhara paccaya vinnana*”. Next, “*vinnana paccaya namarupa*” means he is visualizing the hospital buildings, and also visuals of how people will thank him for his generosity.

- The more he thinks about it, the stronger those *vinnana* and *namarupa* get.

5. Finally, let us take the case of a teenager who is influenced by his peers to drink alcohol at every opportunity. Because of his ignorance about the consequences, he engages in such activities and also in planning activities: “*avijja paccaya sankhara*”.

- Now he visualizes pictures of the whole scene, including friends, bottles of his favorite drink, any food that goes with it, etc. All these are *namarupa*: “*vinnana paccaya namarupa*”.
- Here *sankhara* including not only drinking activities but also planning. Even when he is not drinking, he may be thinking about it; it is also in the subconscious. This is “*sankhara paccaya vinnana*”.

6. In all three examples, it is clear that there is a reverse step also occurring”: “*namarupa paccaya vinnana*”, can happen, and does happen, together with “*vinnana paccaya namarupa*”. The more one visualizes related *namarupa*, the more strong that *vinnana* gets.

- This happens sometimes in other steps too and such is referred to as an “*annamanna paticca samuppada* step”. Here “*annamanna*” means “inter-dependent”.
- This is especially true also for the “*sankhara paccaya vinnana*”. The more stronger the *vinnana* gets, one is more likely to engage in same kind of acts, i.e., *sankhara*, i.e., “*vinnana paccaya*

sankhara”. They feed on each other. This happens a lot in habit formation.

In the next post we will discuss how these different kinds of *namarupa* lead to *salayatana* in both *paticca samuppada* cycles.

Namarupa paccaya Salayatana

1. First, let us discuss the difference between an *āyatana* and an *indriya*.

- We have six sense faculties: eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body, and the mind. These are the *indriya*. **There is no equivalent English word for *āyatana*, so we will keep using *indriya* and *āyatana* from now on.**
- Depending on how we use those *indriya*, they CAN BECOME *āyatana*. Our initial sense inputs (what we see, hear, etc) are due to *kamma vipaka* and when we experience them, we are using our sense faculties as *indriya*. But based on those initial sense experiences, we may INTENTIONALLY use those *indriya* to do more of those acts. Then those *indriya* become *āyatana*. Since there are six of them, they are called *salayatana*.

2. For example, I am walking on the road and see a nice house. I just happened to see it due to a *kamma vipaka*, and my eyes were working as *indriya*; they just presented a picture of that house to my mind. It is a neutral event.

- But now if I start looking at it for a while thinking how nice that house is and how nice it would be to live in a house like that, then I am using my eyes and mind as *āyatana*. I have formed greedy thoughts about the house and now I am accumulating new *kamma* (*sankhara*) via my eyes and mind by using them as *āyatana*.

3. In many cases, when we experience a sense event due to one *indriya*, we may start using some or all of the *indriya* as *āyatana*. In another example, someone offers us a piece of a tasty cake (which is a *kamma vipaka*), and like it so much we may use all six *āyatanas* to accumulate more *kamma* (smell and touch it and then ask for the recipe and think about how to make it or where to buy it). As a side note, these are not *abhisankhara* (those that could give a rebirth or *patisandhi*), but just *pavutti kamma* that can in turn give rise to *pavutti kamma vipaka*.

- Most of the time we use our sense faculties as *indriya*: we see, hear, etc many things in a day but ignore most of them. But when we experience something that have a craving (*anusaya*) for, then we start using our sense faculties as *āyatana*. The *akusala-mula paticca samuppada* cycle operates only when we use our sense faculties as *āyatana*.
- An *Arahant* ALWAYS uses his/her sense faculties as *indriya*; he/she will see, hear, etc just like us, but will not get “attached to” anything.

4. Just like for *namarupa* that we described in the previous post, *salayatana* has somewhat different meanings in the *pavutti* and *patisandhi paticca samuppada* cycles.

- At birth (especially in a new *bhava* or existence), we get a “new set of sense faculties” or *indriya*. For example, if a human is reborn as a *brahma*, that *brahma* will have only eyes, ears and the mind; there will be only three *indriya* (or *āyatana*), instead of six for the human. But we keep the term “*salayatana*” in the *paticca samuppada* as a generic term. Thus in *patisandhi paticca samuppada*, we are concerned with *namarupa* associated with strong built-up *kamma* that define the new existence; these are the *namarupa* that comes to the mind of the dying person at the moment of death.
- Now, when we consider the *pavutti paticca samuppada* series, we are concerned with how the six *āyatanas* for a human change from even moment to moment depending on the *namarupa* that cultivate in the mind at that moment; you may want to go back and read about the *namarupa*

involved in the *pavutti paticca samuppada* series.

Namarupa paccaya Salayatana at Patsandhi

5. At the end of an existence (*bhava*), a given lifestream is making a quantum transition (meaning a large instantaneous jump) from one kind of an existence to another. At that time, the base level of *vinnana* for the lifestream makes a quantum jump and this is basically the “*nama*” of the *namarupa*. The *namarupa* for the new existence also has the blueprint for the new physical body, which is the “*rupa*” part.

- As we did in the previous post, let us consider the case of a lifestream making a transition from a deer to a human. The basic level of *vinnana* changes from that of a deer to a much higher level of a human; this new level of *vinnana* together with the blueprint for the new human shape is in the new *namarupa* of the *gandhabbaya* that comes out of the body of the dead deer, as we saw before.
- Now when this *gandhabbaya* descends to the womb of a human mother, the human baby starts to grow. Six sense faculties (*indriya*) suitable for a human grows in the womb, which will become *salayatana* at times in the future after the birth.

6. Let us take another example of a human who exhausted his *kammic* energy for the human *bhava* at death, and becomes a *brahma* in one of the *brahma* realms. At the *cuti-patisandhi* transition in the last *citta vithi* of that human, the human *gandhabbaya* dies and a *brahma gandhabbaya* is born.

- Now in the *brahma* realms, all *brahmas* are born fully formed without the help of a mother’s womb. This is what is called an *opapatika* birth. The human dies, his body becomes inert like a log, and at the very instant a fully-formed *brahma* is formed in the appropriate *brahma* world.
- This *brahma* will have sense faculties appropriate for a *brahma*: only eyes, ears, and a mind. These are the *indriya* for the new existence. These *indriya* **can become** *ayatana* at times depending on the activities of that *brahma*.

Namarupa paccaya Salayatana during a Lifetime

7. During a given lifetime of a deer, human, or a *brahma*, that lifestream will have a basic set of *indriya* (that become *ayatana* at times) appropriate for that that existence: the sense faculties for a human are different from that of a deer or a *brahma*.

- But during that lifetime, those *ayatana* will have minor changes (compared to the drastic changes at *patisandhi*) depending on the activity. Such changes are described by the *pavutti paticca samuppada* cycle.

8. In the previous posts we discussed the case of a thief who is planning a theft. We saw how his *vinnana* about the theft leads to him generating *namarupa*, the visuals in his mind of how the theft is carried out.

- When he is planning the theft, he will use his sense faculties as *ayatana* to do the “preparatory work”. He may read about the place to be robbed, ask around for relevant information, etc. Each time he does a specific act (whether thinking, seeing, hearing, etc), a separate *paticca samuppada* cycle operates, and we will discuss this later, after going through all the steps in a number of more posts.
- Now when he is about to carry out the theft, his *indriya* transform or attune for the task and

become *ayatana*: all his sense faculties will be on high alert. He is watching and listening carefully for anything unexpected, and his whole body becomes tense pumped with adrenaline.

- He will use all his *ayatana* to carry out the task, as needed: To run away, if he is about to be caught or after getting what he wanted, using his body, eyes, and ears.
- There are many, many *paticca samuppada* cycles that were associated with each act at the planning and execution stages, and we will discuss that at the end of the series as mentioned above.

Difference between Phassa and samphassa

1. In most current explanations of *paticca samuppada*, *phassa* is translated as “contact”, and no differentiation is made between “*phassa*” and “*samphassa*“, at least not in a meaningful way.
 - However, as we will see below, “*samphassa*” has a very different meaning than “*phassa*” and makes the connection of how our instinctive reactions to external sense experiences arise based on our “*sansaric habits*” or “*gathi*“.
2. When our eyes make contact with an external object, that is not “*phassa*“. That is just like a camera taking a picture; that picture is sent to the brain, which processes and sends that “snapshot” to the mind. The mind then makes contact with this “snapshot” or “image” and this is what “*phassa*” really is: **It is the mental contact**.
 - When the mind makes that contact with that image of the external object, a *citta* (actually a series of *citta* called *citta vithi*; see, “[What is a Thought?](#)“) arises and that is what we experience; actually what we experience is the cumulative effect of many such *citta vithis* that arise in a very short time, and this cumulative effect we call a “thought”.
 - Some of the seven universal mental factors that arise with the *citta* instantaneously identifies the object and based on our “*gathi*” or “*sansaric habits*” help form an opinion on what is seen. For example, a young lady looking at a dress may form a liking for it. Another person seeing his enemy will form a dislike. A teenager, upon hearing a song may form a liking for it, etc.
 - This mental contact happens instantaneously. We do not have any control over it, and it is purely based on our “*gathi*“. But since our actions based on that initial reaction takes some time, we still have time to control our speech or bodily actions. Even if bad thoughts come to our mind, we can stop any speech or bodily actions. This is what is supposed to be done with “*kayanupassana*” in “*satipattana* meditation”.
3. Now, let consider what happens when an *Arahant* sees or hears similar things. He/she will see or hear the same thing any other person. But since an *Arahant* has removed all such *sansaric* habits or “*gathi*“, he/she will not be attracted to it or repelled by it.
 - An *Arahant* has removed all such defiled “*gathi*” which are closely related to cravings or “*asava*“. An *Arahant* has removed all “*asava*“; this is what is meant by “*asavakkhaya*” at the *Arahanthood*. This is a technical detail that may be clear to some; but don’t worry about it if it does not.
4. We can now see the difference between “*phassa*” and “*samphassa*“.
 - In the case of an *Arahant*, there is only “*phassa*” or mere contact with the external sense input. An *Arahant* will thus “see” or “hear” or “smell” or “taste” or “feel” the same things as any other person. But an *Arahant* will not be attached or repulsed by that sense experience.
 - For example, the Buddha identified different people. But he did not form a special liking for Ven. Ananda (his personal assistant) or had any hateful thoughts about Devadatta who tried to kill him. He treated the poorest person the same way as he treated a king.
 - The Buddha ate most delicious food offered by the kings and also ate the meager meals offered by poor people without any difference.
 - In all those sense contacts, it was just “*phassa*“, and not “*samphassa*“.

5. On the other hand, an ordinary person will form a like or a dislike for some of the sense inputs (but not for all).

- If a like or dislike is formed, then that sense contact is “*san phassa*” (“*san*” + “*phassa*”, where “*san*” is what we accumulate to extend the *sansaric* journey; see, “[What is “San”?](#)”). It is normally pronounced “*samphassa*”.
- Thus, when we see, hear, smell, taste, touch something, whether there is going to be any likes or dislikes towards that sense experience depends on the person, or more specifically the “*gathi*” of that person.

6. “*Samphassa*” is intimately connected to one’s “*gathi*” or habits most of which come from our past lives, even though some may be strengthened or weakened by what we do in this life. We may even start forming new “*gathi*” in this life.

- There are many posts at this site that discuss “*gathi*”, and at the very basic level both “*anapana*” and “*satipattana*” meditations are all about removing bad “*gathi*” and cultivating good “*gathi*”.
- “*Samphassa*” is also intimately connected to the relationships we have with other people and material things. Any kind of sense input on such people/things will automatically generate “*samphassa*”. On the other hand, an *Arahant* has removed all bonds with people/things, and thus will generate only “*phassa*”.

7. Let us discuss some examples to illustrate how “*samphassa*” arises. First let us look at the connection with those people/things in the world that we have special relationships with or what we “*upādāna*”, i.e., like to either keep close to like to stay away from.

- Think about the worst “enemy” you have. When you even think about that person X, you generate distasteful feelings. But that person’s family will have loving thoughts about that person. Here, you and X’s child (for example), would have generated very different “*samphassa*” when thinking, seeing, hearing, about X.
- When you travel by car or bus and looking out of the window, you may see zillion things, but those are just “seeing”; you don’t pay much attention to them. They are “*phassa*”. But now if you happen to see a beautiful house, it piques your interest and you may even turn back and take another good look at it, and may be even think about how nice it would be to live in a house like that. That is “*samphassa*”.

8. Our *sansaric* habits (“*gathi*”) play a key role in generating “*samphassa*”.

- Some people enjoy harassing animals; they pay to go see cockfighting. Others are repulsed by that. Those are *sansaric* habits. So, the scene of two animals fighting for life leads to the enjoyment of some and to the disgust of others; both are “*samphassa*”, but one is obviously immoral. The other is moral but still keeps one bound to *samsara*; this latter statement may take time to digest.
- Ladies, in general, like nice clothes, jewellery, etc. and men are more into sports. When a husband is watching sports on TV the whole day, the wife may not have any interest and may even get angry at him for not paying attention to other things that need to be done around the house.
- These and zillion other things come from our *sansaric* habits.

9. Now let us see how one's perception of what is "valuable" can lead to "*samphassa*". Suppose someone inherits a valuable gem from his father. Every time he sees it or even thinks about it, he becomes happy. But his mind is also burdened by it, since he is worried that he may lose it; he is keeping it in a safe and has put burglar alarms in the house just to protect that gem.

- Now, suppose one day he gets to a professional to evaluate the gem and finds out that it is really worthless. He may not even believe that initially, but once it sinks in that it is indeed a "dud", he will become "detached" from it. He will no longer keep it in the safe and may even throw it away in disgust.
- Now he may be generating either neutral or hateful thoughts about the SAME OBJECT that he once loved so much. Nothing changed about the "gem"; it is still the same object as before. What has changed is his PERCEPTION of the value of that object. Whereas he generated "*samphassa*" on thinking or seeing that object before, now he may generate just "*phassa*" (neutral feelings) or "*samphassa*" with quite opposite feelings of disgust.

10. Let us take another example that was given by one of my teachers, Therisa. This one clearly shows how transition from "*phassa*" to "*samphassa*" or the other way around can happen very quickly.

This story is based many years ago in Sri Lanka. A mother had to go overseas when her son was less than a year old. She had been overseas for many years and came back to meet her son. Apparently, she had not even seen any pictures of the boy, who was now a teenager. When she gets home, she is told that the boy is visiting a neighbor and she starts walking there. On the way she bumps into a teenager; the teenager apologizes and she resumes walking. But then another person on the street says, "Don't you recognize your son? Well. How can you? You have been away all this time". Hearing that, she says, "Oh, is that my son?" and immediately runs back and hugs him.

- She clearly saw the boy when he bumped into her and apologized. But at that time, he was just a teenager to her. That "seeing" event involved "*phassa*".
- But when someone pointed out that it was her son, the whole perception of the boy took a quantum leap in an instant. Now she looks at the same boy with the whole new set of "mental baggage". Now it is not just a teenager, but her son; there is attachment involved. Now when she looks at him it is "*samphassa*" that is involved.

10. Now we can also see how "*samphassa*" leads to vedana or feelings.

- She had neutral thoughts (may be even some annoyance) when the boy bumped into her and apologized. But when she learned that it was her son, her feelings turned instantly to joy.
- To take a bit more further, if that teenager then got hit by car after several minutes, that joy would turn instantly to sorrow.

More details on how "*samphassa*" leads to vedana (feelings) can be found at: "[Vedana \(Feelings\) Arise in Two Ways](#)".

Phassa paccaya Vedana....to Bhava

1. In the previous post, we discussed the difference between “*phassa*” and “*samphassa*“. To summarize:

- An *Arahant* will always have “*phassa*“, whether it is due to a *kamma vipaka* (i.e., a sense impression comes in due to a *kamma* done in the past) or whether he/she is using the sense faculties for a given purpose. Here “*phassa*” is pure mental contact; it is just seeing, hearing, smelling, tasting, touching, or just an arbitrary thought that comes to the mind without one’s own likes/dislikes.
- An ordinary person will also have “*phassa*” when sense inputs come in as *kamma vipaka*. For example, one may be walking down the street and happen to see an expensive ring on the road. That initial “seeing” is due to a *kamma vipaka*. But now he gets interested in it and picks it up and examines it; those follow-up acts may be done with “*samphassa*“, which in turn lead to more *kamma* generating future *kamma vipaka*.
- Thus the *akusala-mula paticca samuppada* involves “*salayatana paccaya samphassa*“, even though it is normally written as “*salayatana paccaya phassa*“.

2. “*Phassa*” is the pure mental contact. “*Samphassa*” is the mental contact that has incorporated one’s own likes/dislikes about the sense contact.

- In an earlier post, we also talked about the difference between “*indriya*” and “*ayatana*“, i.e., how our sense faculties can be used in either way. Note: These six *indriya* are different from the *indriya* in *panca indriya*, which are *sati*, *samadhi*, *saddha*, *viriya*, and *panna*.
- Our basic sense faculties are the “*indriya*“; when they are used with likes/dislikes they become “*ayatana*“. Since there are six of them there are six “*ayatana*” or “*salayatana*“.

3. In the *akusala-mula paticca samuppada* series that describe how our actions that start with ignorance (*avijja*) eventually lead to suffering, what comes to play is “*salayatana*“, i.e., “*namarupa paccaya salayatana*“. Thus, we are talking about instances where we use our sense faculties as “*ayatana*“.

- Therefore, it is clear that the next step should be “*salayata paccaya samphassa*” instead of the normally used, “*salayatana paccaya phassa*“.
- But conventionally “*salayatana paccaya phassa*” is used because it rhymes better that way. One is supposed to know that it is really “*samphassa*” that comes into play here.

4. Let us take an example to go over the steps of the *paticca samuppada* up to now as a review. Suppose there is a teenager who come to associate friends that belong to a street gang. They tell him that one needs to enjoy life and has to do “whatever it takes” to make money to enjoy life. If the parents do not have close contacts with the teenager, there is no one to explain to him the perils of such a way of life, and he embraces this wrong vision or “*micca ditthi*“.

- Thus due to ignorance (*avijja*), the teengaer starts doing, speaking, and thinking like those gang members: “*avijja paccaya sankhara*“.
- Then what occupies his mind most of the time is thoughts related to gang activities and seeking pleasures by using drugs and alcohol: “*sankhara paccaya vinnana*“. During gang activities his thoughts are focused on them, and what is in his subconscious during other times is also related

to such activities.

- This leads to “*vinnana paccaya namarupa*“. He thinks about and visualizes various gang activities: How to sell drugs to make money and how he will enjoy rest of the time hanging out with the gang.
- Thus all his six sense faculties become “*ayatana*“: they all are used to find ways to optimize the gang activities and to think about ways to “have to fun”: “*namarupa paccaya salayatana*“.
- Thus inevitably, the sense contacts he makes are attuned for such activities: “*salayatana paccaya phassa*” or more explicitly, “*salayatana paccaya samphassa*“. Most of his sense contacts are defiled with greed, hate, and ignorance.
- Accordingly, most his feelings are associated with such defiled sense contacts: He gets angry dealing with rival gangs, takes pleasure in beating them up, gets pleasure from drinking and using drugs, etc. Thus “*(sam)phassa paccaya vedana*” ensues.

5. Now we can see how he gets more and more absorbed in gang activities; he gets pleasure from them. Gang activities become regular habits. He gets “stuck”, or “gets attached to gang activities” via both greed and hate. This is “*vedana paccaya tanha*“; see, “[Tanha – How we attach via Greed, Hate, and Ignorance](#)“.

- The more he continues such activities, it will become harder to dissociate from them. He thinks about those activities even when not actively doing them. Those start working in his “subconscious”; he dreams about them, etc.

6. Such strong attachments to gang activities this lead to “*upadana*“: *Upadana* (“*upa*” + “*adāna*“, where “*upa*” means “close” and “*adāna*” means “pull” or “attract”; thus gang activities becomes very close him. Those are what he thinks, speaks, lives, all day long: “*tanha paccaya upadana*“.

- Among those gang activities, he may especially get attached to certain specific acts: could be alcohol, drugs, or even beating up other people or killing them. And such a specific thing would be his favorite, and that is what he will follow enthusiastically and others will also encourage.
- Within the gang there may be a sub-unit that mostly he hangs with. They will enjoy doing their favorite things together, and the gang may assign specific tasks to them which they are known to do well.

7. This leads to preparation of future “existence” or “*bhava*“. For example, suppose his sub-unit becomes notorious for hurting rival gang members. They take pleasure in beating up someone or in some cases even killing someone. He will acquire the mindset of a violent animal. He will become easily agitated and angry.

This is “*upadana paccaya bhava*“.

- His “*bhava*” has drastically changed from that of an innocent teenager to that of a violent animal at times.

8. This progression from “*avijja paccaya sankhara*” to “*upadana paccaya bhava*” does not happen in a linear sequence.

Some steps go back and forth. For example, “*avijja paccaya sankhara*” is inevitably also followed by the reverse “*sankhara paccaya avijja*“, i.e., the more wrong things he does, that also solidifies his

ignorance. When he starts enjoying those immoral acts, he will tend to think that is what will provide him happiness in the future. His mind will be more and more covered with *kamachanda* (strong greed) and *vyapada* (strong hate), the two main components of the five hindrances.

- His ability to think clearly will be suppressed by the five hindrances, and *avijja* (ignorance) will grow; thus “*sankhara paccaya avijja*” will also take place.
- There can be many such “inter-loops” that tend to strengthen the downward progression of that teenager.

9. Let us discuss the concept of a “*bhava*” in more detail. Since many people get confused with the terms “*bhava*” and “*jati*”, it is important to be able to distinguish between the two.

- Every time we do a *sankhara* (which can be a bodily act, speech, or a thought) a corresponding *kamma* (basically an action) is done. In Buddha Dhamma too, every action has a reaction just like in physics, but when dealing with mental phenomena the reaction (*kamma vipaka*) can come later, sometimes many lives later.
- This is why science has not yet realized the way to handle mental phenomena. Since most “reactions” come later in this life, or even in future lives, it is not easy to see these “action/ reaction” or “*kamma/kamma vipaka*” relationships.

10. Not all *kamma* are the same. Some *kamma* (and corresponding *sankhara*) are harmless, i.e., they are not potent. Anyone who lives in this world (even an *Arahant* until death) has to do *sankhara* to live: An *Arahant* has to walk, speak, think about things and all these can be considered to be *kamma* (*sankhara*). In some cases, they are put in the category of *kriya* to specifically separate them.

- But what we are concerned with *kamma* that involve greed, hate, and ignorance. Anytime that happens those *kamma* (*sankhara*) are potent. They can bring about significant results or *kamma vipaka*.
- The clearly strong *kamma* (*sankhara*) are called *kamma patha* (or *abhisankhara*). Killing one’s parents is a *kamma patha* or a *abhisankhara*; since it is immoral, it is called an *apunnabhisankhara* (*apunna+abhisankhara*). It will lead to very bad consequences (*kamma vipaka*).
- Saving the life of a human is also a *abhisankhara*; since it is a moral one, it is called a *punnabhisankhara* (*punna + abhisankhara*). It will lead to very good consequences.
- As we discussed above, those good or bad consequences may not be apparent even in this life; but they are likely to bear fruit in future lives.

11. How the consequences or “reactions” or *kamma vipaka* due to good or bad *kamma* are brought about involves the concept of a “*bhava*” which can also called a “*kamma beeja*” or a “*kamma seed*”.

- Every time one does a good or bad *kamma*, the potential to bring about its results remains with him/her. And the more one does the same, that potential (or energy) grows. It is said that such acts prepare a “*bhava*” or existence appropriate for that *kamma*.
- For example, as the above discussed teenager keeps doing his violent acts, he is making a “*bhava*” or a “*kamma seed*” appropriate for bringing about their consequences.
- During a lifetime, these “*bhava*” mostly bring about environments suitable for conducting similar acts. It becomes his “state of existence” or “*bhava*”. He keeps acting violently, and may

even act like an animal at times. His “animal-like *gathi*” or “animal-like habits” will grow.

- This “*bhava*” is called a “*kamma bhava*” and he may “born” in that existence many times during the lifetime.

12. It becomes easier to get that state of existence (*bhava*); he can be provoked easily and he can hurt someone without much remorse. Thus whole *akusala-mula pavutti paticca samuppada* cycle can run many times during a day as we will discuss in the next post.

- This is why stopping such actions early is important. If one has learned correct “*anapana*” or “*satipattana*”, then one would know not to keep doing such acts.
- This is also why the environment (parents, family, friends, teachers, etc) plays such a huge role in one’s life at young age. We all have both good and bad tendencies (“*gathi*”) coming from previous lives. Which ones get to grow further depends on how one’s life is directed by the environment especially at young age. When one is old enough one could of course make even drastic changes with effort.

12. As a given “*kamma bhava*” gets stronger with repeated actions, it can become a “*uppatti bhava*”, i.e., the *kamma* seed has now become strong enough to provide a *patisandhi* (rebirth) to a new *bhava* or existence at the end of the current existence (*bhava*) as a human; this is the *cuti-patisandhi* transition that happens in the last *citta vithi* of the human existence.

- Details of this have been discussed in other posts and will be discussed in the next post as well, but the important things here is the concept of a strong *kamma* seed that can give rise to a new existence (rebirth) or a “*uppatti bhava*”.
- Such strong *kamma* seeds suitable for *uppatti bhava* can grow over many lifetimes as well.
- It is likely that we all have many such good and bad strong *kamma* seeds that we have acquired in our previous lives. From all those good and bad *kamma* seeds that are potent enough to provide *patisandhi*, the most strong one comes to the forefront of the mind at death (if the *kammic* energy for the present *bhava* as a human is exhausted). We will discuss this in detail in the next post, but the difference between “*bhava*” and “*jati*” has been discussed in, “[Bhava and Jati – States of Existence and Births Therein](#)”.

We will discuss more details in the next post that will wrap-up this series.

Bhava paccaya Jati....Jara, Marana,...

1. In the previous post we discussed how repeated immoral actions of a teenager can bring about a specific type of existence (*bhava*) even during the current life and that this is called a *kamma bhava*.
 - We also discussed how such *kamma bhava* can get stronger with time and become strong enough to lead to a whole new existence at death; this is called a *patisandhi bhava*.
 - Thus there are two types of “*bhava*”: those that can bring about “experiences” during the current life (*kamma bhava*) and those that become strong enough to power a whole new existence (*uppatti bhava*).
2. Another way to look at the concept of a “*bhava*” is to treat it as a seed. As we discussed in the previous post, when we do any act with ignorance (and greed or hate), that leads to the generation of a *kamma* seed with some energy to bring about results in the future; this is the same as saying that a “*bhava*” was created by that action. The concept of a *kamma* seed is easier to comprehend.
 - Just like a normal seed **has the potential** to give rise to a plant, a ***kamma* seed has the potential to bring about a “jāthi” or a “birth”**, either during this life or in preparing a new life.
 - In most posts, I write it is *jati* (which is the conventional English term used), but it really is pronounced “*jāthi*”.
3. Let us take the example of the teenager that we discussed in the previous post. Because of the influence of his friends, the teenager starts dealing and using drugs and gradually gets drawn into the gang to become a gang member, and eventually starts doing violent acts of beating and killing people.
 - When he did the first beating his friends probably had to encourage or even force him to do it. Now let us suppose that he did not have a *sansaric* habit of doing that kind of violent acts. So, when he did the first act, a small *kamma* seed (or a “*bhava*”) was energized.
4. The next time he did something similar, this initial *kamma* seed made it easier for him to do the second act. Once he did that, the seed got bigger, and the next time he may not need much encouraging, and so on. The more he does it, the more easily he can get into that “*bhava*”, i.e., the stronger that *kamma* seed becomes.
 - This is another way of expressing “habit formation” that I have discussed in many other posts. The more one does acts suitable for a certain “*bhava*”, the *vinnana* for similar behavior grows, and it is easier for one to be “born” in a corresponding state; this is “*pati+ichcha*” leading to “*sama+uppada*” as pointed out in the introductory post, “[Paticca Samuppada – “Pati+ichcha”+“Sama+uppāda”](#)”.
 - Thus the more the teenager does violent acts, the more easier for him to be “born in that state”, i.e., the more easier for him to do similar acts.
 - In other words, repeated *sankhara* leads to strengthening the corresponding mindset or *vinnana*, and it propagates down the *paticca samuppada* series to make “*kamma bhava*”.
5. Now let us consider when that *kamma* seed or “*kamma bhava*” gives rise to a “*jati*” in *pavutti paticca samuppada*. One day, his drug deal is sabotaged by a rival gang member, and he gets angry. Now he is easily “born” in that “animal-like violent state”. He starts beating up that guy. This is “*jati*” in this case.

- When the beating is almost done, that “*jati*” is almost over with; it is at the “*jara*” (decay) stage and when it is done that is the end or death (“*marana*”) of that “*jati*”.
- Thus when that episode is over, that temporary “*jati*” of “a violent existence” is over.
- The rest of it, “*sōka, parideva, dukkha, dōmanassa*” or many forms of suffering comes later in that life or even in future births. The *kamma* seed that helped him do that act, itself got even stronger.

6. The *kammic* energy of that *kamma* seed was not spent giving rise to that *jati* that happened during that particular instance. That is because that was not a case of *kamma vipaka*. Rather, that *kamma* seed got stronger.

- Now, if during that confrontation with the other rival gang member he himself gets beaten up, then that becomes a *kamma vipaka*, and some of the *kammic* energy is spent on that.
- In either case, that “birth” or “*jati*” (the confrontation with the rival gang member) would give him only misery at the end: “*soka, parideva, dukkha, domanssa*”.
- Many such *pavutti samuppada* cycles can operate during even a day and he may be “born” repeatedly in that confrontational state. Some may be minor, like getting mad at his friends but some could be violent. He has prepared the “*bhava*” and he can get into “*jati*” or be “born in that *bhava*” easily. I am mixing up English and Pali words in order to make the meanings clear and to get used to those terms.
- Just like when a seed is made it is easy to get that seed to germinate, once we prepare a “*bhava*” it is easy to be born in that type of existence.

7. Now we can see that a “*bhava*” or a “*kamma* seed” is the potentiality for a particular kind of existence or a “state of mind” during the current life itself.

- But the important thing to remember is that “*bhava paccya jati*” **does not mean he is guaranteed to be born in that state**. It is likely that he will be born in that state under suitable conditions, for example with provocation.
- But if he comes to his senses and realizes the perils of such actions, he can make an effort and slowly degrade the potency of that *kamma* seed. The first thing is to stop doing the more violent acts. If the teenager has enough determination and if he has moral support from his family, he may be able to get into the moral path.
- If he makes a determination to change, it will be hard in the beginning. It is like trying to stop a moving car. If the car has a lot of speed, it takes a bigger effort to stop. It is easier to stop a slowly moving car, before it gains speed. In the same way, it is easier to revert back if one realizes that one is on the wrong path early.

8. If the teenager does not change his ways, but only gets involved more and more with the violent activities, then that *kamma* seed (or *kamma bhava*) will grow bigger and can become strong enough to energize a whole new existence (rebirth) or “*uppatti bhava*”. Or he can even make a single huge seed by killing someone.

- We all are likely to have acquired several or even many such large bad *kamma* seeds (i.e., many bad “*uppatti bhava*”) suitable to yield rebirths in the lowest four realms; we have no way of finding out.

- Of course, we are also likely to have many good *kamma* seeds (i.e., many good “*uppatti bhava*”) suitable to yield rebirths in the higher realms.

9. And we do not have any control over which “*uppatti bhava*” is selected at death. The strongest with the most “*upadana*” associated with it gets to the front automatically. The Buddha gave a simile to explain how this selection of a “*uppatti bhava*” or a strong *kamma* seed happens at the *cuti-patisandhi* transition at death.

- Imagine a barn that keeps the cows in for the night. In the morning, all the cows are anxious to get out and roam around. But when the gate opens, it is the strongest cow that has come to front and is out of the gate when it is opened. The weaker ones don’t even make an effort to be at the front.
- Just like that, it is the strongest “*kamma* seed” or a “*patisandhi bhava*” that wins at the *cuti-patisandhi* transition.
- In the case of the teenager that we discussed above, if the *kamma* seed that he nourished during this life as a violent person with “animal-like” behavior is the strongest one of all his accumulated *kamma* seeds, then it will bring about an animal existence at the *cuti-patisandhi* transition.

10. A Buddha could analyze such a *patisandhi paticca samuppada* cycle in finer details to pin-point even what type of animal would it be. This is because a Buddha can see not only a person’s whole history in the present life, but going back to many aeons; thus he could see which *kamma* seed will bring the next existence and exactly which kind of “*gathi*” are embedded in that *kamma* seed. We can only discuss the general trends, and here we have discussed only the main ideas of how these *paticca samuppada* cycles operate.

- Going back to the teenager, In this case it is the *patisandhi paticca samuppada* cycle that operates, and “*bhava paccaya jati*” here leads to the birth in a new existence as an animal using that *uppatti bhava*.

11. Once born in such an animal existence, that animal will grow and then start the old age (“*jarā*”), and eventually die (“*marana*”).

- At that death, it is likely that the *kammic* energy of that *kamma* seed has not been depleted. Since most violent animals have shorter lifetimes, only a fraction of that *kammic* energy is likely to have been spent and “he” will keep going through many of similar births (“*jati*”) until the energy of that *kamma* seed is spent. It is said that many animals keep coming back to the same life many hundreds of times.

12. This is the difference between “*bhava*” and “*jati*”. Once one gets a new existence or “*bhava*”, one could have many births (“*jati*”) in that existence until the energy of the *kamma* seed is totally spent.

- Thus we can see that the last step of “*jati paccaya jara, marana, soka, parideva, dukkha, domanassa*” will be with “him” for a long time to come. It is not just one birth but many that will correspond to that existence as that animal.
- For us also, in general, when one is in the human “*bhava*” one could be reborn many times before the energy of that “good *kamma* seed” is depleted. This is why those rebirth memories can be recalled from adjacent lives. However, it is very difficult to get another “human *bhava*”; see, [“How the Buddha Described the Chance of Rebirth in the Human Realm”](#).

13. Before closing this section let us discuss another important point. We mentioned earlier than everyone has accumulated numerous good and bad *kamma* seeds strong enough to give rise to good and bad rebirths. The the question arises: Does a person attain the *Sotapanna* stage (i.e., make bad rebirths in the lowest four realms void) by eliminating all those corresponding bad *kamma* seeds?

- While it is possible to reduce the potency of *kamma* seeds and maybe even eliminate some, it may not possible to remove all. Many *kamma* seeds may be removed by the *Ariya metta bhavana* discussed in the “*Bhavana* (Meditation)” section, but there could be left overs. It is said that the Buddha had 11 instances of bad *kamma vipaka* including a back problem. We will discuss this point in a separate post.
- Therefore, it is very likely that we all have many good and bad *kamma* seeds strong enough to energize many good and bad rebirths.
- What happens at the *cuti-patisandhi* moment involves the “*upadana paccaya bhava*” step in the *patisandhi paticca samuppada* cycle. As we recall, this is the step that is responsible for energizing “*uppatti bhava*” as well as “*kamma bhava*”.
- But this same step is involved in grasping the strongest “*uppatti bhava*” at the end of the current “*bhava*”. If a person dies and if that was the last possible human birth for him/her, then at the dying moment, that comes closest and he/she will willingly grasp it because that will match the dominant “*gathi*” of him/her.

14. Let us consider the case of the violent teenager again. Suppose he continued with his violent acts and built up an “*uppatti bhava*” suitable for a violent animal. Then at the dying moment, he could see in his mind (like in a dream), a rival gang member trying to “steal a drug deal”; he will also see a gun closeby. By his natural instincts he will get angry, grab the gun, and shoot that person. This is an example of a “*gathi nimitta*”.

- That is the “*upadana paccaya bhava*” step for the new existence. He has willingly grasped the mindset of an animal, and he will be born as an animal. His next thought moment is in that animal which comes out of that dead body of the teenager as a “*gandhabbaya*” with a fine body that cannot be seen.
- This is described in detail in other posts; it needs more background material in “*manomaya kaya*” for understanding the technical details, but that is not critical here. However, now we can get an idea of how a new existence is grasped at the end of a “*bhava*” in the *patisandhi paticca samuppada* cycle.

15. Let us now go back to the question of how a *Sotapanna* avoids such bad rebirths even if he/she has many bad *kamma* seeds. Suppose that *Sotapanna* has the same kind of *kamma* seed as that teenager (could be from a previous life), and that it is the strong enough to come to forefront of his/her mind at the dying moment.

- What happens is that a *Sotapanna* will not grab the gun and shoot that person even if it is his/her worst enemy doing something that could make him/her mad. His/her mindset or “*gathi*” have been permanently changed. Thus “*upadana paccaya bhava*” step will not be executed for that *kamma* seed.
- In that case now the next potent *uppatti bhava* will come to the forefront. If that is also a bad one suitable for rebirth in the lowest four realms, that will be rejected too. Eventually, he/she will grasp a rebirth that is compatible with his/her “*gathi*” at that dying moment, which for a

Sotapanna will never be the “gathi” of a being in one of the four lowest realms. This happens automatically and very quickly. We do not have conscious control over it.

- Thus one’s rebirth will be determined by the way one lives (and had lived previous lives). If one lived like an animal, one will be born an animal no matter how much one wishes to have a “good birth”. The real danger, as we discussed above, is that we do not know how we had lived our previous lives.
- This is why *paticca samuppada* means “*pati + ichcha*” leading to “*sama*” + “*uppada*” or what one grasps willingly and habitually is what one that will operate automatically at the dying moment; see, “[Paticca Samuppada – “Pati+ichcha”+”Sama+uppāda”](#)”.

Paticca Samuppada – “Pati+ichcha”+”Sama+uppāda”

“Yo paticcasamuppadam passati,
so Dhammam passati.
Yo Dhammam passati,
so paticcasamuppadam passati” (1)

One who sees *paticcasamuppada*
sees the Dhamma.

One who sees the Dhamma
sees *paticcasamuppada*..

(1. Majjhima-nikaya I, Nal. 241, PTS 191)

Thus it is critical to correctly understand what paticca samuppada is. It explains how causes lead to effects. NOTHING in this world happens without a cause; see, the next post for details: “[Paticca Samuppada – Overview](#)”.

Paticca samuppada is translated to English as “Dependent Origination” in many instances. This does not convey the true, complete meaning of the phrase. It is better to just keep the same name and understand what it means.

1. Paticca (pronounced “patichcha”) = pati + icca; here “pati” is bonding, and “icca” (pronounced “ichcha”) is liking.

- Thus paticca is “bonding to something willingly”. or “get attached to something through a liking for it or something related to it”.
- This bonding depends on one’s gathi (habits and likings), which in turn are due to deep-seated asavas (cravings).

2. Samuppada (pronounced “samuppāda”) = “sama” (same or similar) + “uppāda” (generation), i.e., an existence (bhava) of similar quality or kind.

Thus samuppada means leading to an existence or experience with similar defilements that used to drive the bondage in the first place.

3. For example, when we generate very powerful hateful thoughts about a person we could be in the mindset of an animal. At that moment, we may even act like an animal, hitting and clawing at that person if things really get out of hand. Even if we may not act physically we will have that mindset. **Thus in that moment we generate a “bhava” or existence similar to an animal in our mind, which in turn leads to a corresponding “bhava”, which in turn gives rise to a corresponding “jathi” or birth.**

Because we got “bonded” to that situation via hateful thoughtful thoughts, we generated a corresponding “bhava” in our mind. What is generated is similar to what caused it: cause and affect. As we generating same kind of “bhava” that leads to forming “gathi” or habits. All these are inter-connected.

4. Now if we keep incurring such situations frequently, i.e., get in to fights with that person (or with others) in similar manner, we will be building up that “bhava” and this could lead to the formation of very potent kamma seeds (“[Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka](#)”); it becomes a “gathi” as well (see, “[Sansaric Habits and Asavas](#)”). Then it is easier to get into such situations, and a vicious

cycle starts.

5. Now we combine the two terms: **“paticca samuppada” means “generating similar “bhava” (and thus “gathi”) that led to the attachment or involvement to something in the first place”, which in turn leads to a corresponding jathi or birth (for a short time or for a lifetime; see below).**

- Stated in a simple way: “when one gets attached, it sets up likelihood of a new birth of similar characteristics”. For example, when someone acts with greed out of habit, he/she is prone to act that way during the lifetime, and then it could manifested in a stronger way in a future birth by being born as a hungry peta (hungry ghost).

Thus “existence” (bhava) could be two ways:

- During a life when one is exposed to a similar situation: For example, the “gathi” formed via the above mentioned “fights” with other people, will tend draw oneself to a similar outcome even with the slightest provocation; this is a “pavutthi bhava” (and jathi) that lasts for a short time during an ongoing life.
- If this hateful “gathi” becomes deeply ingrained and becomes a potent kamma seed, that could be drawn to the mind at the dying moment, and could lead to a hateful “uppatti bhava” in the next existence, which could result in a birth (jathi) as an animal or even in the niraya (hell).
- Here one should also be able able to make a distinction between “bhava” (existence) and “jathi” (birth). For example, the potential of an uppatti bhava may give rise to many births until the kammic energy in that kamma seed is depleted; see, [“Bhava and Jati – States of Existence and Births Therein”](#).
- That is why, even though the human BHAVA is RARE, one may be reborn a human many times at a stretch; only those who were born in human in previous life (or a few lives) may be able to remember those lives; see, [“Evidence for Rebirth”](#).

It is good to know the correct pronunciation that comes out with the meaning: “pati ichcha sama uppāda” becomes, “patichchasamuppāda”.

The closest English translation is “Willful bondage generating an outcome/existence of similar kind”.

6. By perceiving an illusory happiness, we get ourselves willingly attach to pleasurable things. We also attach to things via hate, and the root cause for that is an attachment to something that is related. For example, if someone is blocking our access to something that we like, we get “attached” to that person with hate; we keep thinking how bad he is, etc.

- Thus attachment can be done with greed or hate. This is what “tanha” means.
- Tanha (pronounced “thanhä” where “tha” pronounced like thunder) = “thán” rhymes like in “thatch” and means something or someplace) + “hä” (fused, connected). **Thus tanha means getting connected or bondage to someone or something through either greed or hate.**
- **One generates greed or hate due to ignorance; thus tanha arises because of avijja (ignorance) of the three characteristics of this world; see, [“Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta”](#).**

7. Ultimately, both greed and hate arise due to ignorance. Ignorance of: not knowing the unfruitful nature of “this world” of 31 realms, i.e, [“anicca, dukkha, anatta”](#); that there is unimaginable suffering in the lower four realms (see, [“How the Buddha Described the Chance of Rebirth in the Human](#)

[Realm](#)“); that there is a better happiness called niramisa sukha compared to sense pleasures: “[Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)“, etc.

8. There is no one or no external force that is keeping us bound to “this world” of 31 realms; see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)“. We are in “this world” of 31 realms filled with suffering because we cling to everything in it like an octopus grabbing its prey with all eight legs. **Unless we see the true unfruitful and even dreadful (in the lower four realms) nature of ‘this world’ by comprehending “[anicca, dukkha, anatta](#)“, we will not let go of it.**

There is much more to discuss. This is just an introduction.

9. It must also be noted that this is a good example of the confusion caused by translating Pali to Sanskrit and then back to English or Sinhala; see the explanation of **Pratittyasamutpada** (the Sankrit word for Paaticca Samuppada) on Wikipedia:

<http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Prat%C4%ABtyasamutp%C4%81da>

I think you agree that it is confusing at best, with multiple possible meanings. On the other hand, for someone knowledgeable in Sinhala the meaning is very clear if the breakdown to pati + ichcha sama+uppada is shown.

10. Please read, “[Habits and Goals](#)“, “[Sansaric Habits and asavas](#)“, and “[The Way to Nibbana – Removal of asavas](#)“, before reading further postings as they appear below. One should also analyze one’s own life experiences to see whether they are compatible with this explanation. [This is part of vipassana meditation](#). It is really critical to understand Paticca Samuppada if one is truly interested in Buddha Dhamma.

Next, “[Paticca Samuppada – Overview](#)“,

Paticca Samuppada – Overview

1. Nothing can happen without a cause (“hetu” in Pali or Sinhala). Everything happens for reasons, or causes. Normally, many things simultaneously arise due to multiple causes. However, one cause or one effect could dominate and thus sometimes it appears that one thing happened due to one cause.
2. Due to our ignorance of the true nature of this world, we keep initiating new causes. If we do not add fuel to a fire, the fire will extinguish when the fuel runs out. We have been on this sansaric journey from the beginning-less time, because we have been adding “fuel to the fire” without any pause.
3. The paticca samuppada (let us shorten it as PS) describes all aspects of life moment-to-moment: how we suffer the consequences of our past deeds, and how we make new causes or add more fuel. When one attains Arahant hood, PS switches permanently to the kusala-mula PS (see below), and PS cycle stops when one attains Parinibbana.
 - Acariya Buddhaghosa understood only one aspect (the *akusala-mula* PS) of the innumerable applications of PS, and since the time Theravada sect adopted Visuddhimagga as the basis of Dhamma, this wonderful knowledge of PS has been hidden.
 - It is said that the Buddha described some 70 plus versions of PS in the suttas.
4. Here we will mainly focus on how PS operates in two main modes:

- Delivering the fruits of past deeds or kamma vipaka ([akusala-mula PS for bad deeds and kusala-mula PS for good deeds](#)).
- When we suffer due to our present actions, i.e., the suffering that is NOT due to kamma vipaka.

While an Arahant experiences that suffering due to the first, he/she does not suffer due to the second mode; see, “[Vedana \(Feelings\) Arise in Two Ways](#)“.

5. Even if there is a cause, its result (effect) does not manifest until right conditions (“paccaya” in Pali) appear. Let us consider some examples:
 - An apple seed has the potential to bring about an apple tree. But the seed does not germinate and grow into a tree unless it is given soil, water, nutrients, and sun light. Thus even if the cause (seed) is waiting there, those conditions must be present for the effect (tree) to appear.
 - A matchstick has the potential to bring about fire. But unless it is heated by striking on a hard surface, fire does not appear.
 - A bomb can explode and create much destruction. But it will not go off until triggered.
 - We all have bad habits, but they do not manifest until it is triggered by an object (a picture, sound, smell, touch, or a thought).

Therefore, if one acts mindfully, one can PREVENT many *akusala* vipaka and FORCE many kusala vipaka. We all have innumerable number of both accumulated in this sansara; see, “[What is Kamma? Is Everything Determined by Kamma?](#)“, and “[The Law of Attraction, Habits \(Gathi\), and Cravings \(Asavas\)](#)“.

6. But the root cause (hetu) for any PS cycle to be operative is that we have asavas and gathi (cravings and habits). Because of these asavas we have avijja (ignorance), and vice versa: Avijja and asavas are

inter-related (“annamanna paccaya”). Paticca Samuppada cycle formally starts at avijja, but it is implicit that avijja and asavas cause each other; see the Samma Ditthi sutta. Only a Buddha is capable of discovering the way of removing asava (asavakkhaya nana), via understanding PS; see, “[The Way to Nibbana – Removal of Asavas](#)”.

- We have discussed how asavas get started as habits (see, “[Habits and Goals](#)”); how they get fermented through “re-use” via many rebirths (see, “[Sansaric Habits and Asavas](#)”), and thus become ingrained.

Before we discuss the two PS cycles (akusala-mula and kusala-mula), let us see how we generate fuel for the sansaric journey via tanha:

Next, “[Tanha – How We Attach Via Greed, Hate, and Ignorance](#)”,

What Does “Paccaya” Mean in Paticca Samuppada?

Before we start discussing the various forms of *paticca samuppada* (let us abbreviate it as PS), it is important to be clear about what is meant by “*paccaya*” (pronounced “pachchayā”).

1. The PS cycle starts as: “*avijja paccaya sankhara, sankhara paccaya vinnana, vinnana paccaya nama rupa, nama rupa paccaya salayatana,...*”.

- And since PS describes the “cause and effect” in Buddha Dhamma, most people think “*avijja paccaya sankhara*” means “*avijja* causes *sankhara*” or “ignorance causes one to acts that generate bad kamma”.
- Even an ordinary person has *avijja*, he/she will not ALWAYS act accordingly; most of the time, people act appropriately or morally. However, as long as *avijja* is there, it is LIKELY that at times one WILL act with *avijja* and do inappropriate or immoral things.
- Similarly, many people think that “*sankhara paccaya vinnana*” means “*sankhara* causes *vinna*” or “bad kamma lead to corresponding consciousness”, and so on down the whole PS cycle.

2. It will clarify a lot of things down the line if one understood that PS does not refer to a “direct link”: Just because we have done many bad kamma (*sankhara*) DOES NOT mean they ALL lead to kamma vipaka causing either a rebirth *vinna* or a “*pavutti vinnana*” during a lifetime.

- This was pointed out in item #5 in the previous post “[Paticca Samuppada – Overview](#)”. But in case the point was missed, I wanted to emphasize the point in this post.
- Any effect has a cause. But there can be possible causes without leading to any effects. Otherwise, Nibbana would not be possible. This needs some contemplation, and I will give some examples below.

3. When causes are there, corresponding effects (results) are LIKELY if suitable conditions for the effects to take place. **This is why kamma is not deterministic**; see, “[What is Kamma? – Is Everything Determined by Kamma?](#)”.

- However, the key point in PS is that the effect – IF AND WHEN IT HAPPENS – is in accordance with the cause, and also the cause was one’s own choosing: “*pati ichcha*” leading to “*sama uppāda*” or stated in a simple way: “when one gets attached, that leads to a new birth of similar characteristics”. **If and when the causes bring forth the consequences, they will be of the corresponding nature.**

4. It is not necessary to get into further details unless one is interested in “digging deeper”, but there are 24 “*paccaya*” or “conditions” that can actually cause the effect to materialize. Let us briefly discuss three such *paccaya*, “*hetu paccaya*“, “*annantara samanantara paccaya*”, and “*annamanna paccaya*” to see what happens.

5. Nothing happens without a root cause or a *hetu* (pronounced “*hāthu*“; see the pronunciation key in “[Pali Glossary](#)“).

- For example, a bomb causes damage because of the explosives in it; but someone has to trigger it to go off. If the bomb sits somewhere for a long time, its explosives may degrade and then the “cause” may disappear; most kamma seeds are like that too.

- Still, without the root cause there will not be an explosion. **This is “*hetu paccaya*”.**

6. My favorite example of the “***annantara samanantara paccaya***” is the germination of a seed. Just because there is an apple seed, it will not cause an apple tree to appear.

- An apple seed can be kept for many years without germinating in a cool, dry place; but if it is planted in the ground with water and sunlight present, it will germinate and give rise to an apple tree; see, “[Annantara Samanantara Paccaya](#)” for details.
- Of course, just like with the bomb, if the apple seed sits there for too long it may lose its potency and may not yield an apple tree at all; thus the *hetu paccaya* is always there.

7. Third one, “***Annamanna paccaya***”, means dependent on each other: For example, Vinnana and nama rupa depend on each other:

- Normally it is stated that “*vinnana paccaya nama rupa*” or ‘depending on the vinnana, nama rupa arise’. For example, vinnana of the cuti citta at the moment of death causes a matching nama rupa to rise in the next birth: a hateful thought could lead to birth in the niraya or the animal realm.
- However, vinnana in turn depends on the type of nama rupa: with the nama rupa of an animal, it is not possible to get into jahana. Only certain types of nama rupa can “support” certain types of vinnana.

8. I just wanted to give a brief introduction to the complex “*pattana Dhamma*” which describes 24 such “*paccaya*” involved in *paticca samuppada*. In other words, the relationship between cause(s) and effect(s) can be complex. We can only discern the major relationships. Only a Buddha can sort out all such complexities.

- But there is no need to analyze everything in great detail in order to understand the message of the Buddha. One can become a Sotapanna just by comprehending the *Tilakkhana: anicca, dukkha, anatta*.

9. So why am I also providing information on these complex topics? It is for three reasons:

- One is that it helps build saddha (faith) in Buddha Dhamma, because anyone who takes time to examine these concepts can see that it provides a COMPLETE explanation for everything that we experience and more.
- Secondly, it is intellectually satisfying to see how all pieces nicely fit into the “big picture”: I hope I have been able to give the sense of joy that I have experienced in “seeing how these pieces fall into place”.
- Also, this “self-consistency” is critical in the process of sorting out which version of Buddha Dhamma is the correct one. As the Buddha himself pointed out, any version that is not self-consistent should be discarded; see, “[Saddharma Pundarika Sutra \(Lotus Sutra\) – A Focused Analysis](#)”.

Tanha – How We Attach Via Greed, Hate, and Ignorance

In the previous post, [“Paticca Samuppada – Introduction”](#), we discussed the origin of the term “tanha” (“thán” + “ha”, where “thán” rhymes like in “thatch” and means a place and “hä” means getting fused), as attaching to some place, thing, or a person (anything in this world) via greed and hate (and ignorance). Note that “tan” in tanha is pronounced like in “thunder”.

Here we will see how that happens according to the natural process of paticca samuppada.

This is discussed in the Cha Chakka Sutta. But in standard translations, the real meaning does not come out.

We get to know ANYTHING about the external world via ONLY six ways:

- we see vanna rupa (visual things) with our eyes.
- we hear sadda rupa (sounds) with our ear.
- we smell gandha rupa (odors) with our nose.
- we taste rasa rupa (food) with our tongue.
- we touch pottabba rupa (touchable things) with our body.
- we contemplate or think about dhamma (concepts) with our mind.

This is what the Buddha called “sabba” or ALL. **Our whole world is what we experience with our six senses.** Take a moment and contemplate on this. Is there anything else “in this world” other than those six listed above?

All our greedy, hateful, or ignorant thoughts arise when we make contact with the outside world with one or more of these six senses. **(Please take time to think and contemplate on these ideas as you go along. It is critical to get these ideas to proceed further).**

Let us examine how we get “bonded” to something that we experience. Let us take, for example, someone listening to a new song. In this case the sound (sadda) impinging on the ear (sota) leads to sound consciousness. There are several things that happen in a fraction of a second. This VERY FAST sequence is stated as:

1. “Sotanca paticca sadda, uppaddati sota vinnanam”, where, sota is ear; sadda is sound (song), uppaddati means gives rise to, sota vinnana is sound consciousness, and paticca (as we saw in the previous post) is to get bonded willingly. Thus,

“Due to sound of the song being willingly received by the ear, gives rise to sound consciousness”.

In order to experience anything, we need to have some liking for it. Everyday, we are exposed to million pictures, sounds, etc, **but we remember only a selected number, and these are the ones that lead to tanha.** Once a teenager hears a song he really likes, then comes the next step:

2. “Thinnan san gathi phassao”;

here, we need to spend a bit of time explaining the terms: “san” means defilements or fuel for sansaric journey (see, [“What is “San”?”](#)), and “gathi” are sansaric habits (see, [“Sansaric Habits and asavas”](#)); thus “san gathi” means sansaric habits; “phassa” means contact, and “thinnan” means three. Please go back and read those two links if you do not remember those terms.

Thus what the above line says is: those three things (sound, ear, and sound consciousness) make contact with one's sansaric habits, and **one's mind is instantly attracted to the subject (in this case the song) if it is something that matches with his "gathi" or "likings"**. Within a split second of hearing a few lines of the song, the teenager is "hooked"; his mind becomes totally absorbed in it. Then comes the next line:

3. "*San phassa ja vedana*", means this "contact with *san gathi*" leads to feelings. This is also written as "*samphassa ja vedana*", by combining the two terms.

- As long as one has these "*gathi*", the corresponding feelings arise automatically. This is why it is important to get rid of bad "*gathi*". In the *Satipatthana sutta*, it is described how one becomes a "*sampajanno*" by figuring out how to get rid of bad "*gathi*"; see, "[Kayanupassana – The Section on Habits \(Sampajanapabba\)](#)".

This is a VERY IMPORTANT step. The feeling depends on whether someone gets attracted to the subject matter via greed or hate. If it is greed (or liking) as in the case of the teenager listening to a song he likes, he gets a *sukha vedana* (happy feeling). On the other hand, if it was a heavy metal song and if his grandfather hears it, the grandfather may instantly form a *dukha vedana* (unhappy feeling) if he has a dislike for heavy metal songs. This is the reason that different people feel differently about the same "event" (a picture, sound, smell, taste, touch, or a thought about something).

Let us further analyze this example:

The teenage could be walking a noisy street, but if he really likes the song he may not even hear any other sound. He is absorbed in the song; he gets "attached" to the song. Even after the song, he thinks about it in many ways: he may want to find the identity of the singer, may want to see whether the singer has more albums, how he is going to tell his friends about this, etc. This is the "sansaric wheeling" process, see, "[Nibbana – Is it Difficult to Understand?](#)", where we discussed how one becomes an Ariya by taking the wheels off of the sansaric vehicle (*riya*).

Thus the teenager gets attached (forms *tanha*) as shown in the next step:

4. "*Vedana paccaya tanha*"

The song became his existence or "*bhava*" (i.e., total awareness, existence) while he was listening. He does not just listen, enjoy it while it lasts and move onto something else; RATHER, he wants to hear it again, may be hear more songs like that too. This is *TANHA*, he gets bound to it. Because of that he starts craving for it again and again, and also craves songs similar to that. May be he would form a liking for anything associated with the song: its composer, singer, and may join the singer's fan club. His mind spends a lot of time "wheeling around" or "thinking about" things associated with the song; temporarily, his existence or "*bhava*" becomes that song.

5. Now let us go back to #1 of the sequence:

"*Sotanca paticca sadda uppaddati sota vinnanam*", or "Due to sound of the song being willingly received by the ear, gives rise to sound consciousness".

Why did the teenager "willingly and attentively" listen to the song while there were many other sounds around him in the noisy street? Because he has a liking to this kind of songs; thus he enthusiastically chose to listen to it, ignoring all other sounds around him. That is what "*paticca*" (*pati* + *ichcha*) means there.

Thus we get attracted to something due to our "old habits" (see, "[Habits and Goals](#)"), which are even

likely to be habits formed over many lives (see, “[Sansaric Habits and asavas](#)“).

6. Now at the step #4 above, the sequence ends with further strengthening “his tendency (gathi)” to listen to this type of music; that is tanha. **This is a key point.** We get attach to things that we have an ingrained liking for and more and more attachments will strengthen such a liking or habit or “gathi”; this is the law of attraction (see, “[The Law of Attraction, Habits \(Gathi\), and Cravings \(Asavas\)](#)“). Thus it becomes a vicious circle. This is why it is hard to break habits (good or bad).

Please spend some time contemplating the above material. It is best if you can take your own situations and analyze those situations and see how tanha arises via greed (likes) and hate (dislikes). I will discuss more examples before moving on to discuss paticca samuppada in detail. It is VERY IMPORTANT to understand these fundamental ideas that are described in these initial posts.

In the earlier post, “[Paticca Samuppada – Overview](#)”, we pointed out that an Arahant experiences suffering only due to kamma vipaka; An Arahant does generate sorrow or happiness via the mechanism discussed in this post; there is no “pati +ichcha” in step #1.

We, on the other hand, generate “self-induced” suffering and happiness via this mechanism; the problem is that even any happiness generated is not long-lasting. This mechanism is, for example, the main cause for many “sleepless nights” or even depression. Let us discuss this next.

Next, “[Vedana \(Feelings\) Arise in Two Ways](#)“,

Vedana (Feelings) Arise in Two Ways

Vedana (feelings) are **three kinds** : *Sukha vedana* (pleasant or joyful feeling), *dukha vedana* (unpleasant or painful feeling), and *adhukkama asukha* (without being painful or joyful, just neutral).

It must be pointed out that upekkha is not a feeling; it is a state of the mind, and needs to be cultivated (one of the Saptha Bojjanga or Seven Factors of Enlightenment). But most times upekkha is used to indicate a neutral feeling.

Vedana (feelings) can arise in two ways:

1. As a consequence of a previous *kamma* (i.e., a *kamma vipaka*). The *kamma* or *sankhara* could have been done many lives ago.
2. As a direct consequence of a making *sankhara* (because of *tanha* at the present time).

Vedana Arising from Kamma Vipaka

- *Kamma vipaka* can happen to everyone, including *Arahants*. While everyone can avoid some *kamma vipaka*, there are others that are too strong to be able to avoid.
- For example, the Buddha himself had physical ailments later in his life as *kamma vipaka*. Moggallana Thero was beaten to death because of a bad *kamma* that he committed many lives before.
- However, *kamma vipaka* are not certain to happen. Some can be reduced in power (see, [“Kamma, Debt, and Meditation”](#)); all are reduced in power with time and some eventually die out if they do not get a chance to come to fruition within 91 *Maha kalpas*. Many can be avoided by not providing conditions for them to arise, i.e., by acting with *yoniso manasikara* or just common sense. For example, going out at night in a bad neighborhood is providing fertile ground for past bad *kamma vipaka* to arise: We all have done innumerable *kamma* (both good and bad) in past lives; if we act with common sense we can suppress bad *kamma vipaka* and make conditions for good *vipaka* to arise.

Also see the discussion on *kamma beeja* in , [“Sankhara, Kamma, Kamma Beeja, Kamma Vipaka”](#).

We will discuss how this type of *vedana* due to *vipaka* (from deeds in the past) arise due to the *kusala-mula* and *akusala-mula* PS cycles in following posts. First let us look at the “suffering we are initiating at present moment via *sankhara*”.

Vedana Arising from Sankhara (“San phassa ja vedana” or “Samphassa ja vedana”)

We described the PS mechanism that generates this type of *vedana* in the previous post. The *vedana* occurs due to attachment via greed or hate, at that moment; see, [“Tanha – How we Attach via Greed, Hate, and Ignorance”](#).

These are the *vedana* (feelings) that *Arahants* do not feel. Since they do not commit any (*abhi*)*sankhara*, an *Arahant* avoids any kind of feeling arising from *sankharas*. The easiest way to explain this kind of *vedana* is to give some examples:

1. Three people are walking down the street. One has ultra-right political bias (A), the second has ultra-left bias (B), and the third is an *Arahant* who does not have special feelings for anyone (C). They all see a famous politician hated by the political right coming their way. [It is a given that the sight of the politician causes A to have displeasure and B to have a pleasurable feeling.](#)

On the other hand, the sight does not cause the Arahant to generate any pleasure or displeasure. Even though all three see the same person, they generate different types of feelings. *It is important to realize that the feelings were created by A and B by themselves.*

2. Two friends go looking for treasure and find a gem. They are both overjoyed. It looks quite valuable and one person kills the other so that he can get all the money. Yet when he tries to sell the “gem”, he finds out that it was not that valuable. His joy turns to sorrow in an instant. *Nothing had changed in the object. It was the same piece of colored rock. What has changed was the perception of it.*
3. What could happen if an Arahant found the same gem lying on the road? (he would not have gone looking for one). He might think of donating it to a worthy cause. During the process, if he found that it was not valuable, he would not have worried about it at all.
4. A loving couple had lived for many years without any problems and were happy to be together. However, the husband slaps his wife during an argument. The physical pain from the slap itself did not last more than a few minutes. But for how long the wife would suffer mentally? Even the husband, who did not feel any physical pain, would suffer for days if he really loved his wife. *In both cases, the real pain was associated with the attachment to each other. The wife could have dropped something on her foot and would have suffered about the same amount of physical pain. But she would not have had any lingering mental pain associated with that.*

Thus it is clear that in all the above examples happiness or suffering arose from **within one’s own mind**. And tanha (attachment via greed or hate) was the cause of it.

We will discuss more examples as we proceed, but you should think about how to analyze situations that you face everyday, or have experienced. Let us further analyze the actual words of the Buddha when he described *dukha* in the *Dhammacakka Pavattana Sutta*:

1. It says, “*jathi pi dukkha, jara pi dukkha, maranan pi dukkha.....*”. Most people translate this incorrectly as, “birth is suffering, getting old is suffering, dying is suffering,....”.

2. However, “*jathi pi dukkha*” is shortened for the verse; **it is “*jathi api dukkha*”**; the other two “*jara pi dukkha, maranan pi dukkha*” are meant to have the “*pi*” suffix.

“*pi*” in Pali or “*priya*” in Sinhala is “like”, and “*api*” in Pali or “*apriya*” in Sinhala is dislike. Thus, “*jathi api dukkha*” means “birth of something that is not liked by one causes suffering”. “*Jara pi dukkha*” means, “decay of something that is liked causes suffering”, and “*maranan pi dukkha*” means, “Death of a liked causes suffering”. One can look at each case and easily see which one to use; see #4 below.

3. The reverse is true too: “Birth of something that one likes causes happiness”, “decay of something that is hated brings happiness” and “death of a hated person brings happiness”. *You can think of any example and this is ALWAYS true. It brings happiness to many people to hear about the destruction of a property of an enemy . Many people were happy to hear about the death of Bin Laden, except his followers who became sad.*

4. The Buddha further clarified “*pi*” and “*api*” in the next verse, where he explicitly said: “*piyehi vippayogo dukkho, appiyehi sampayogo dukkho*” means “it brings sorrow when a loved one has to depart, and it also brings sorrow to be with a hated person” (“*piya*” is same as “*pi*”, and “*apiya*” is same as “*api*”). We all know the truth of this first hand. When a man dies of in a plane crash, it causes great suffering to his family; less to his distant relatives; even less to those who just know him

informally; and for someone at the other end of country who has had no association with him, it is “just some news”.

Thus all these feelings arise due to *tanha*, some form of attachment: greed (craving, liking) or hate (dislike); all these are due to *sankhara*. **The feelings (or rather the perceptions that give rise to feelings) reside INSIDE oneself. It does not come from outside.** We use external things to CAUSE happiness or suffering by our own volition. There is no inherent suffering or happiness in ANYTHING external; the sense contact with an external thing CAUSES suffering or happiness depending on our *gathi* and *asavas*. An *Arahant*, who has removed all *asavas*, will be free of such emotional responses.

Now this DOES NOT MEAN we should not love our family or friends. These associations did not come without a cause. We cannot eliminate the cause for the current life; it was done long ago. Now we have fulfill the obligations that resulted from the cause in the past, i.e., we cannot give up our families. We have families, children etc, BECAUSE we have debts to pay to each other; see, “[Kamma, Debt, and Meditation](#)”. What we need to do is to eliminate NEW causes: stop such relationships from formed in future births, i.e., work to stop the rebirth process, while making sure to fulfill our obligations.

Here again, many people freak out: “how can I do that? if I do not reborn what happens to me?” We have this mindset because we do not think life can be much worse than what we have. But it definitely can be much, much worse; see, “[How the Buddha Described the Chance of Rebirth in the Human Realm](#)”. **It is not possible to comprehend this fact without fully understanding the “world view” of the Buddha by looking at the wider world of 31 realms and the process of rebirth.**

- It is also clear how accumulation of *sankhara* via *paticca samuppada* leads to such varied feelings: If we attach to something with a “like” or a “dislike”, we generate a mindset accordingly. This is *paticca samuppada* (*pati* + *ichcha* leading to *sama* + *uppada*; see, “[Paticca Samuppada – Introduction](#)”). in the first case, we generate “positive” mindset towards the object that we liked; thus if everything goes well with the object, we feel happy and if things do not go well, we feel sad. It is the other way for the object that we had a bad impression in the first encounter; we made a negative mindset about the object.
- In either case, the strength of the feeling is also proportional to the strength of the “like” or “dislike”: ***Sama uppada* or *samuppada* means both in quality and quantity**; the higher the strength of “*pati* + *ichcha*”, the higher the strength in “*sama* + *uppada*”.
- This is how we form habits (“*gathi*”) too. A teenager tasting alcohol with a bunch of friends gets attached to that setting and looks forward to have the same experience again; the more he repeats, the more he gets “bonded”, and thus forms a drinking habit. See, “[Habits and Goals](#)” and “[Sansaric Habits and Asavas](#)”.

Thus all what we experience arise in a complex web of inter-related multiple factors. Only a Buddha can “see this whole picture” and condense it down to a form that can be comprehended by only a motivated human being. If one really wants to understand Buddha Dhamma, one needs to spend time contemplating on these multiple but impressively self-consistent key ideas of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, and *paticca samuppada*.

Now let us consider the *vipaka* cycles of PS is described in, “[Akusala-Mula Paticca Samuppada](#)”.

Next, “[Bhava and Jati – States of Existence and Births Therein](#)”,

Akusala-Mula Paticca Samuppada

1. Akusala-mula version is the only version of paticca samuppada (PS) described in even the current Theravada texts, even though the other versions are in the Tipitaka.

Akusala-mula (pronounced akusala-mūla) PS describes the PS process for normal humans (*Anariyas*), who are trapped in the *sansaric* journey. It is also two fold:

- The **uppatti PS** describes how a “lifestream” or a being makes the *sansaric* journey via repeated births in the 31 realms.
- The **pavutti PS** describes moment-to-moment progression of a “lifestream” or a being.
- It is important to note that Buddhaghosa (in *Visuddhimagga*) described only the uppatti PS. In recent times several *Theros* have pointed out and discussed the pavutti PS.

2. Let us first discuss the *uppatti* PS, which describes how the PS cycle goes through a new birth at the end of current life. The steps in this cycle are:

“*avijja paccaya sankhara; sankhara paccaya vinnana; vinnana paccaya namarupa, namarupa paccaya salayatana, salayatana paccaya phasso, phassa paccaya vedana, vedana paccaya tanha, tanha paccaya upadana, upadana paccaya bhavo, bhava paccaya jati, jati paccaya jara, maranan, eva me tassa dukkhanan samudhaya hoti*”

Let us briefly translate them:

3. With ignorance as condition, one accumulates *sankhara*. It must be noted that these are really *abhisankhara*, i.e., they are done with ignorance.

- When we are born, we are born without ANYTHING material other than our tiny baby body, which actually started as a **single cell** in the mother’s womb. We grow up and start acquiring “stuff” both material and non-material: knowledge, material things, friends, spouse, children, fame, etc.
- While we acquire these “things” we also acquire new habits (*gathi*) or strengthen ones that we brought from previous lives; these take place according to the *pavutti* PS at every moment: “*pati+ichcha sama uppada*”, i.e., we do things that we like and get similar kind of results.
- When we die, we take with us only the *kamma* seeds (both good and bad) from our actions; the habits (*gathi*) and cravings (*asavas*) are embedded in them. **These are in the *manomaya kaya*, and the *manomaya* leaves the dead physical body with those “updated” *kamma* seeds; see the next post.** This is basically the “net result” of our life here.
- One of existing *kamma* seeds (from this life or from previous lives) gives rise to the next life, where we acquire more of them BASED ON the *gathi* and *asavas*. So the cycle perpetuates.

4. With *sankhara* as condition, a *patisandhi vinnana* arises in the new life.

- This *vinna* of the new life arises according to the nature of the *kamma* seed that gave rise to it. If that *kamma* seed was acquired by doing some hateful act(s), then the *vinna* will be matching: “*pati+ichcha sama uppada*”. If it is a seed due to an act of a generosity done with loving kindness, it could be the *vinna* of a Brahma.
- Thus the “base level of *vinna*” for an animal life is VERY DIFFERENT from that of a human

life, even for the same “lifestream”, i.e., when a human is reborn as an animal the “base level of *vinnana*” makes a huge downward transition. This is why it is NOT correct to say that “*viannana* is transferred from life to life”.

5. With *vinnana* as condition, *namarupa* arise.

- Again, the nature of the “*namarupa*” of the new life is according to “*pati+ichcha sama uppada*”. In the above mentioned cases, the new life form may be that of an animal or of a being in the niraya (hell) or that of a Brahma with a fine body.

6. With *namarupa* as condition, *salayatana* arise.

- The *salayatana* (six sense doors) arise accordingly too: In the above mentioned cases, all six sense doors suitable for the kind of animal form or just three sense doors (eye, ear, and mind) suitable for a Brahma.

7. With *salayatana* as condition, *phassa* arise.

- The being interacts or makes contact (*phassa*) with the external world through the sense doors; see step #2 in “[Tanha -How We Attach via Greed, Hate, and Ignorance](#)”.

8. With *phassa* as condition, *vedana* arise.

- Such interactions with the external world lead to feelings (*vedana*) of different kinds. Here, it is important to remember that the *vedana* depends on the *gathi* and *asavas*: see, “[Vedana \(Feelings\) Arise in Two Ways](#)”. Also, see step #3 in, “[Tanha -How We Attach via Greed, Hate, and Ignorance](#)”.

9. With *vedana* as condition, *tanha* arise.

- *Tanha* arise, when one gets “attached” or “fused” into a thing or situation: with *sukha vedana*, one attaches with greed; with displeasure, one attaches with hate; one also attaches with not knowing what to do (with a highly agitated mind); see, “[Tanha -How We Attach via Greed, Hate, and Ignorance](#)”.

10. With *tanha* as condition, *upadana* (attachment) arise.

- **At the moment of death**, in the last *citta vithi*, the dying person gets a *kamma nimitta*. This is normally a vision or a sound that depicts the nature of the strong *kamma* seed that came to the forefront of the mind. For example, if the *kamma* seed that is about to give the next birth was due to a killing, then the person may see a gun or hear the sound of it, or even see himself as getting ready to shoot; thus the person will have the same hateful thoughts arise and just like at the time the crime was committed, the person embraces that situation forcefully (*upadana*).

11. With *upadana* as condition, *bhava* arise.

- The next *citta vithi* starts with the new existence or “*bhava*” matching that state of mind: “*pati+ichcha sama uppada*”. Depending on the *kamma nimitta* that was grasped, a matching existence, a human, animal, deva, etc. arise; see, “[Paticca Samuppada – “Pati+ichcha”+“Sama+uppada”](#)”.

12. With *bhava* as condition, *jati* (new birth) arise.

- Then a birth matching the *bhava* starts. If the *bhava* is human realm, then a human birth will result. Now, here is the difference between *bhava* and *jati*: The duration of the selected “human

bhava” will last until the *kammic* energy associated with that *kamma* seed is exhausted. Thus if the *kamma* seed has potential for thousand years of life, when the current life ends the next birth will be still in the human realm. This is UNLESS one commits a *anantariya* kamma or even a very strong other type of *kamma*. For example, if one attains *Anagami* or *Arahant* stages, the person will not be reborn in the human realm; or if one kills a parent, for example; all these are *anantariya* kamma.

13. With *jati* as condition, “*jara, maranan, eva me tassa dukkhanan samudhaya hoti*” arise.

- *Jati* inevitably results in decay and eventual death, and this is how *dukkha* originates.
- No matter where one is born in the 31 realms, one ages and eventually dies; in between one goes through all kinds of suffering, in particular at human realm and below. Aging and death are certainties. And at death the whole cycle re-starts.

14. The above steps describe the *uppatti* PS. The other aspect, i.e., what happens during a given lifetime, is described in, “[Akusala-Mula Pavutti \(Pravurthi\) Paticca Samuppada](#)”.

Next, “[Kusala-Mula Paticca Samuppada](#)”,

Kusala-Mula Paticca Samuppada

1. *Kusala-mula* version of *paticca samuppada* (PS) is not described in even the current Theravada texts, even though it is in the Tipitaka. This is because since the time Buddhaghosa wrote *Visuddhimagga*, all Theravada texts followed that and his other books instead of *Tipitaka*.

- That means the PS process for attaining Nibbana has NOT been described for over 1500 years. No wonder the *Nibbana* has been hidden for all these years.
- *Kusala-mula* (pronounced *kusala- mūla*) PS describes the PS process for *Ariyas*, starting at the *Sotapanna* stage.

2. Here we need to understand three important distinctions between an *Ariya* (*Sotapanna* and above), and *Anariya* (a normal human).

- When one attains the *Sotapanna* stage, one gains a significant understanding of the three characteristics (*anicca, dukkha, anatta*); I have posted several essays on this. Thus an *Ariya* is automatically prevented from committing the worst kinds of *akusala*. However, until the *Arahant* stage is attained, *Samma Ditthi* is not perfect, and thus one still has *avijja*. But this *avijja* is less potent, because it is well below the *moha* (delusion) stage for an *Anariya*.
- Because of the above reason, the *sankhara* done with this type of less potent *avijja* does not become a cause for extending *sansara*; it is just *sankhara*. A *Sotapanna* (or above), truly understands the futility of being reborn anywhere in the 31 realms, and thus does not wish for anything in return for such meritorious deeds.
- In the *Abhidhamma* terminology, an *Ariya* does a *punnabhi sankhara* with a “*nana-sampayutta, somanassa-sahagata citta*” or with “the intention of conducting a meritorious deed based on knowledge and with a joyful heart”; he/she does it with the intention of being released from the rebirth process.
- Because of that, in *kusala-mula* PS, *tanha* does not arise as a result of *vedana*, as we will see below. Instead one’s mind becomes overjoyed (*cittapasadi*) due to the meritorious deed.
- It must be noted that a *Sotapanna* may do unmeritorious deeds because *avijja* is not fully removed; thus some actions of a *Sotapanna* are subjected to the “*akusala-mula* PS”. However, *apayagami* four “*ditthisampayutta*” (associated with wrong views) *akusala cittas* or the *vicikicca*-based *citta* do not arise; thus worst kind of *akusala* are not committed by a *Sotapanna*. It is a “higher baseline” mental state.

3. The steps in this *kusala-mula* cycle are:

“*kusala-mula paccaya sankhara; sankhara paccaya vinnana; vinnana paccaya namarupa, namarupa paccaya salayatana, salayatana paccaya phasso, phassa paccaya vedana, vedana paccaya cittapasado, cittapasada paccaya adhimokkho, adhimokkho paccaya bhavo, bhava paccaya jati, jati paccaya jara, maranan, eva me tassa dhammanan samudhaya hoti*”

Here I have marked in blue the terms that are different from the terms in the *akusala-mula* PS. Let us briefly translate the terms. Here I am describing both *pavutti* and *uppatti* PS together.

4. With *kusala-mula* as condition, one accumulates *punnabhi sankhara*.

- Here *kusala-mula* are deeds done with *alobha, adosa, amoha*, AND one does not wish for

anything because one's mind is automatically rejecting anything within the 31 realms.

5. With *punnabhi sankhara* as condition, a *punnabhi vinnana* arises. This *punnabhi vinnana* is accumulated as *kamma bhava* and could lead to corresponding "good" *namarupa* in *pavutti paticca samuppada* or a new "good birth" in *uppati paticca samuppada*.

- Because the *sankhara* was generated with a *kusala-mula* deed, *only a kusala-mula vinnana* arises: "*pati +ichcha sama uppada*". The characteristic of this *kusala-mula vinnana* is the desire (*chanda*, not *kamachanda*) for *Nibbana*.

6. With *punnabhi vinnana* as condition, *namarupa* arise.

- The *namarupa* are generated accordingly: one thinks accordingly and one's mind and body are attuned for meritorious deeds. At death, the *patisandhi vinnana* is again according to the *kusala-mula vinnana* and thus a birth in the lower four realms is avoided for a *Sotapanna*, and a birth in the lower 11 realms (*kamaloka*) is avoided for an *Anagami*, for example.

7. With *namarupa* as condition, *salayatana* arise.

- The *salayatana* (six sense doors) arise accordingly too: they are attuned for only meritorious deeds. At a new birth, the sense faculties arise accordingly.

8. With *salayatana* as condition, *phassa* arise.

- The contacts with the outside world are attuned for seeking *Nibbana*: learning dhamma and practicing dhamma.

9. With *phassa* as condition, *vedana* arise.

- Through such interactions, one enjoys the contact with dhamma, true knowledge and understanding.

10. With *vedana* as condition, *cittapasadi* arises.

- Tranquility of consciousness is the standard translation for *cittapasadi*; it is a type of joyous feeling, lightness of heart.

11. With *cittapasadi* as condition, *adhimokkho* arises.

- *Adhimokko* is normally translated as "decision" or "resolve" where *saddha* becomes peaked; here it means the mind is decisively attracted towards *Nibbana*. The mind cools down.

12. With *adhimokkho* as condition, *bhava* arises.

- The resulting existence or "*bhava*" matching that state of mind: "*pati+ichcha sama uppada*"; one "lives" that experience. If it is rebirth at *patisandhi*, an appropriate "*bhava*" is selected according to the *kamma nimitta*. Here any "*apayagami*" *kamma* seeds that may have been acquired in the distant past do not get a chance to come to forefront, and thus a rebirth in the lower four realms is prevented.

13. With *bhava* as condition, *jati* arise.

- The appropriate *jati* (*Sotapanna*, *Sakadagami*, *Anagami*) will result in an appropriate realm.

14. With *jati* as condition, *jara*, *maranan*, *eva me tassa dhammanan samudhaya hoti*".

- Any *Ariya* is also subject to decay and death as long as he/she is in one of the 31 realms. But

here the connection to *dukkha* is not shown, because one is destined to attain *Nibbana*.

Next, “[Manomaya Kaya and Physical Body](#)“,

Akusala-Mula Pavutti (or Pravurthi) Paticca Samuppada

1. As mentioned in earlier posts, paticca samuppada (PS) or “cause and effect” can describe various stages of life in multiple ways: from a very fast 16 PS cycles operating [inside a thought moment](#) to a [long-term PS process](#) that describes how a “living being” is born in one of an uncountable number of species in the 31 realms in the rebirth process.

- The Buddha said that the PS is deep as a deep ocean and it can be applied to any situation, because everything “in this world” obeys the basic principle of cause and effect. It is no wonder that only one PS has been studied for over thousand years while the true Dhamma remained hidden.
- In the previous post we discussed the **uppatti PS** which describes that latter process, i.e., how the PS cycle operates between lives. The other extreme of a very fast PS process involved within a thought moment is very complex and we do not need to examine it right now.
- In this post we will discuss the **pavutti PS** cycle, which describes phenomena in between those two extremes: [phenomena that occur within a lifespan](#).

2. As mentioned in the introduction to PS, whenever we willingly grasp something, whatever results from that action has a corresponding nature. Because one got attached willingly, a similar bhava will result: i.e., pati+ichcha leading to sama+uppada or paticca samuppada (PS).

- In the most fundamental sense, a “greedy state of mind” will result when we get attach with greed, i.e., one develops a **habit or gati or bhava** corresponding to that state of mind; a “hateful state” (habit/gati/bhava) results via hateful attachment; acts of greed and/or hate are always done with ignorance.
- Three examples of uppatti bhava for those three cases illustrate the principle: An excessively greedy person is like to get a “peta bhava” and be born as a peta (hungry ghost); a person who is often engaged in hateful actions towards other beings is likely develop a “hateful bhava” and is likely to be born in the niraya (hell) where there is lot of hate due to extreme suffering; an animal bhava is developed with both greed and hate. Since ignorance is always there, an animal bhava is cultivated with all three “sans”; this is the root of the word “tirisan = three sans” for an animal in Sinhala.

3. Now let us look at the pavutti PS, which describes how we develop certain habits or bhava or gati during a given lifetime. It is often easier to use an example to illustrate these PS cycles. Let us examine how a teenager becomes an alcoholic.

4. The teenager become friendly with a group of other teenagers who are into drinking. Initially, he may be reluctant to join in, but due to ignorance he joins them and starts drinking. If a good friend or a family member came to know about the situation they could have prevented the teenager from associating with such bad company, i.e., ignorance could have been dispelled by explaining to him the adverse effects of not only drinking, but also of associating with such a group.

5. The PS cycle thus starts with “avijja paccaya sankhara”; due to ignorance of the adverse results, the teenager starts drinking with that group (sankhara = “san +kara” or actions of accumulating, in this case bad kamma).

6. The more he is involved with such drinking activities, the more he thinks about it and develops a “mindset” or vinnana for that activity. This is “sankhara paccaya vinnana”.

7. When he really begins to like drinking, he starts thinking about it even while doing other things. This is “vinnana paccaya namarupa”. In this case, namarupa are the mental images associated with that vinnana, i.e., the names and shape of particular alcohol bottles, the places where he normally drinks, the friends who drink with him, etc. He thinks about the next “event” and visualizes the scene, **all these are associated namarupa. Thus, here namarupa are the mental images of “things” and “concepts” that one would like to enjoy.**

8. Now his six senses become “involved” to provide a reality to those namarupa; to provide the desired sense pleasures. In Pali terms, the six indriya (senses) become “ayatana”. For a lack of a single English word, I will call an “ayatana” an “import/export facility”, and really get involved in the actions associated with drinking events. His mind is often thinking about the next “event” (where, when, with whom, etc), he makes necessary preparations for the “event” using all six senses (now ayatanas), that are in accordance with the namarupa in the previous step, i.e., “namarupa paccaya salayatana”, where **salayatana means the six ayatana**: the eye is now not merely for seeing, it has become an assistant in the lookout for a “good drink” or a “good friend to chat with”, etc.

9. Thus we have “salayatana paccaya phassa”, i.e., all six ayatana become actively engaged making contact with relevant sense objects. His eyes are on the lookout for a favorite drink or a favorite person to chat with, etc. Here instead of phassa, it is (more appropriately) called “sanphassa” (= “san” + “phassa”), where “san” implies it not just contact, but a “san” contact; see, [“What is “San”? – Meaning of Sansara \(or Samsara\)”](#).

10. Such “sanphassa” lead to vedana (feelings), i.e., “(san)phassa paccaya vedana”. He experiences “good (but immoral) feelings” with all those sense contacts.

11. Because of such “good feelings”, he gets further attached: “vedana paccaya tanha”; see, [“Tanha – How We Attach via Greed, Hate, and Ignorance”](#).

12. Now comes, “tanha paccaya upadana”. Upadana means “grabbing or getting hold of something automatically” like an octopus grabbing its prey with all its eight legs. In the present case, the teenager wants very much to re-live this experience, and he gets immersed in it; when he is experiencing the event his mind is totally absorbed in it; he does not think, and does not have the mindset to think about, any adverse consequences. This is the critical “habit forming” or “bhava forming” step.

13. So, the next inevitable step is, “upadana paccaya bhava”; this particular state of getting drunk becomes more and more ingrained in his mind. It becomes “a bhava” or “existence” or habit that is of importance to him. He very much wants to re-live that experience.

14. And that is exactly what he gets: “bhava paccaya jati”. This “bhava” or the kamma seed is now well established, and he can be born in that state quite easily. All he needs is an invitation from a friend, or even a sight of a bar while travelling, for example. It is natural to get into that state, or be “born” in that state. So, he gets drunk at every opportunity. See, [“Bhava and Jati – States of Existence and \(Repeated\) Births Therein”](#) for more details.

15. However, like everything else, any birth is subjected to decay and suffering: “jati paccaya jara, maranan, eva me tassa dukkhanan samudhaya hoti”. This happens in many stages as we describe below. But in the case of a single drinking event, that state of intoxication comes to an end, possibly with a big headache and a huge hangover. That episode ends with nothing to show for it, but a hangover. Even worse, now he is “hooked”; he has formed a bad habit, which only strengthens even more if he does it again and again. Because each time, the PS runs, the vinnana for that habit gets

more fuel, and the bhava gets stronger.

16. It is important to realize that the above PS cycle does not run to its conclusion when the drinking “event” is over. Rather the cycle can repeatedly unless it is stopped willfully, deliberately. And the way to do that is to develop good habits and become a “*sampajannö*”; see, “[Kayanupassana – The Section on Habits \(Sampajanapabba\)](#)”.

- The more the teenager gets trapped in that bhava, the more jati that occurs, i.e., more frequently he will be drunk.

And it is not even necessary to participate in a “drinking event” to run another PS cycle. He may be sitting at a desk trying to study, and may start going through the PS cycle MENTALLY. He can start right at “*avijja paccaya sankhara*” and be generating *mano sankhara* and *vaci sankhara* (*vitakka/vicara* or planning), thus generating (and strengthening) the *vinna* for drinking, generating *namarupa* (visuals of places, friends, alcohol bottles, etc), and thus going through the rest of the cycle: *salayatana*, *sanphassa*, *vedana*, *tanha*, *upadana*, *bhava*, *jati* (“living it”), repeatedly until he has to be occupied with some other task, at which point it will end.

- Thus numerous such PS cycles can run at any time, probably increasing its frequency as the bhava or the habit builds up.
- The stronger the bhava or habit is, it will be harder to break it. This is why meditation together with another good habit to work on should be undertaken to replace a bad habit. While in meditation, one can contemplate the adverse consequences of the bad habit. Developing a good habit will keep the mind away from the bad habit. See, “[Habits and Goals](#)” and also “[Bhavana \(Meditation\)](#)”.

About Author

My name is **Lal Ariyaratna Pinnaduwa**. I loved physics from the school days and became a physicist. I was a Senior Scientist at the Oak Ridge National Laboratory and a Research Professor at the University of Tennessee, Knoxville. I was elected a Fellow of the American Physical Society in 2004. Since retiring in 2009 at age 55, I have been on a quest to uncover the pure Dhamma of the Buddha. Even though I am a Buddhist by birth, I did not really “practice” until I retired. Initially it was just to find out what “Buddhism” really was, and how it compared with other world religions.

What I have found is that Buddha Dhamma is really different from not only other religions, but also many forms of “Buddhism” that we have today, and that even the Theravada version has been contaminated by other religious and cultural influences.

In 2013, I accidentally came to know about two Theros from Sri Lanka who have been at the forefront in uncovering the pure Dhamma; their explanation of anicca, dukkha, anatta (true nature of existence) was “the main missing piece” that I had been looking for. I will never forget the ecstatic feeling while listening to that fateful desana from one Thero on July 30, 2013 on the internet. Then I made a trip to Sri Lanka and was able to meet one of them (could not meet one Thero as he was undergoing an operation) and some of their close followers. What I present here is this complete picture, with my own input from my science background.

As in science, here I am going to treat Buddha Dhamma as a theory and explore whether it provides a consistent picture of our world. Buddha Dhamma is a complete worldview and its principles are the laws of Nature. Scientists have uncovered only a fraction of these laws, and only those pertaining to matter. But mind precedes matter.

My only hope is that I can give you a taste of the exhilarating experience that I have enjoyed over the past several years in uncovering the pure Dhamma. Buddha Dhamma is indeed for those who seek to broaden their horizons. You will truly gain benefit from this site if you leave behind any pre-conceived ideas about “Buddhism”.

Above all, I wanted to convey the truth of the fact that one CAN experience the “cooling down” or “Nivana” or “Nibbana” at various levels as one LEARNS AND LIVES the pure Dhamma. This is not something to be attained in future lives, but is something that one CAN experience in this very life by cleansing one’s own mind. What I describe here is mostly what I have experienced.

11/7/14 update: When I was struggling to find the pure Dhamma, I made a promise to myself that if I ever experience any real progress I will be open about it. Most people do not like to talk about their “spiritual experiences” and that is understandable. But I think it could be beneficial to others if I describe my progress to get an idea of what to expect; a brief description of my progress is given in, “Ariya Jhanas via Cultivating of Saptha Bojjanga“. This will also provide a context for the material presented at this website. Please be aware that each person’s experience is different.

Please post your questions on anything that is not clear or inconsistent using the comments tab. Buddha Dhamma is a totally self-consistent description of the Nature's laws, and if there are any inconsistencies, they are due to my own mistakes and I should be able to correct them.

The Buddha said, "Sabba danan Dhamma danan jinati", or "Gift of Dhamma excels all other gifts". Please inform others about this site if you benefit from it.

Dhamma and Philosophy

[“Dhamma and Philosophy – Introduction”](#)

[“Philosophy of the Mind”](#)

[“Buddha Dhamma: Non-Perceivability and Self-Consistency”](#)

1. One may ask the question: “What does Buddhism have to do with philosophy?”.

The Merriam-Webster online dictionary defines philosophy as:

- the study of ideas about knowledge, truth, the nature and meaning of life, etc.
- a particular set of ideas about knowledge, truth, the nature and meaning of life, etc.
- a set of ideas about how to do something or how to live

Other dictionaries and books define philosophy in a similar manner. Therefore, Buddha Dhamma has a lot to say about philosophy. It can sort out the philosophical arguments that have gone back to the Buddha’s time (in the Western world); philosophical views have evolved over the intervening time, but Buddha Dhamma has not. Ironically, “the pure form of Dhamma” had been left out of the discussion mainly because Buddhist philosophy had been distorted by the “Mahayana forefathers” like Nagarjuna, Asanga, Vasabandhu.

2. Since Buddha Dhamma is a complete set of nature laws for its followers, it is logical to present it as a philosophy to those who are not familiar with it or who have not seen enough evidence to believe that claim. In presenting Buddha Dhamma as a philosophy the second definition is a more valid one, because these are not evolving ideas; rather, they were laid down 2500 years ago, and have been documented in the Tipitaka, the Pali Canon.

- It is a set of ideas about knowledge and truth not only about human existence, but ALL that exists in the seen and unseen parts of “this world”, which also encompasses not only the Solar system, but an infinite number of such planetary systems.
- This may sound as an arrogant claim, but it is not. One could scan the Buddha Dhamma section and see that there is a complete theory about the whole existence.

3. My basic incentive for creating this section is to make a request to the philosophy community: It is time to take a close look at Buddha’s world view, and see whether it makes sense. No one has done a serious study on the world view of the Buddha.

- It has been difficult to make a true assessment of what the “real Buddha Dhamma” is, because there are so many different versions out there.
- I hope to make a logical presentation to convince the philosophy community. Please make any comments/requests, and I will to address any serious request.

REFERENCES

For those who are interested on the subject, here are some references (both for philosophy in general and also on Buddhist philosophy; not in any particular order):

“Buddhist Philosophy – Essential Readings”, ed. by William Edelglass and Jay L. Garfield (2009).

“Mahayana Buddhism: The Doctrinal Foundations”, by Paul Williams (2009)

“Buddhism as Philosophy”, by Mark Siderits (2007).

“Buddhist Philosophy – A Historical Analysis”, by David J. Kalupahana (1976).

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“Nagarjuna – The Philosophy of the Middle way”, by David J. Kalupahana (1986).

“Causality and Chance in Modern Physics”, by David Bohm (1957).

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Next, “[Philosophy of the Mind](#)“,

Dhamma and Philosophy – Introduction

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2. [Since Buddha Dhamma is a complete set of nature laws only for its faithful followers, it is logical to present it as a philosophy to those who are not familiar with it or who have not seen enough evidence to believe that claim.](#) In presenting Buddha Dhamma as a philosophy the second definition is a more valid one, because these are not evolving ideas; rather, they were laid down 2500 years ago, and have been documented in the Tipitaka, the Pali Canon.

- It is a set of ideas about knowledge and truth not only about human existence, but ALL that exists in the seen and unseen parts of “this world”, which also encompasses not only the Solar system, but an infinite number of such planetary systems.
- This may sound as an arrogant claim, but it is not. One could scan different sections of this site and see that there is a complete theory about the whole existence; it may take another year or more to get even the “basics” of the Dhamma published.

3. My basic incentive for creating this section is to make a request to the philosophy community: It is time to take a close look at Buddha’s world view, and see how it compares with existing philosophical arguments on various topics. No one has done a serious study on the world view of the Buddha.

- It has been difficult to make a true assessment of what the “real Buddha Dhamma” is, because there are so many different versions out there.
- I hope to make a logical presentation to convince the philosophy community. Please make any comments/requests, and I will try to address any serious request.

4. Perhaps as important, I want anyone reading the site to appreciate the significance of what the Buddha told us 2500 years ago. Compared to the pure Dhamma, all philosophical theories are at very early stages. Any interested reader can learn about the current philosophical arguments (and those going back to the early Greek philosophers) and then compare with Buddha Dhamma presented at this site.

5. Within the framework of the Buddha Dhamma all standard philosophical questions have been answered.

- These include, “the relation between the brain and mind”, “the nature of death”, “whether we have free will”, etc. Thomas Nagel’s short book listed below gives an introduction to some of

such topics.

- Most existing literature on Buddhist philosophy says some of these questions are in the category of “questions that the Buddha refused to answer”, which itself is an incorrect statement; see, “[Misconceptions on the Topics the Buddha “Refused to Answer”](#)”. The Buddha refused to answer questions posed by a person who was not capable of comprehending the answers. But he has given the answers in other places.
- We will discuss how Buddha Dhamma provides answers to these philosophical questions one by one, as sufficient background material is added to site.

REFERENCES

For those who are interested on the subject, here are some references (both for philosophy in general and also on Buddhist philosophy; not in any particular order). Among those on Buddhist philosophy, I have not read a single book that provides a true description of the Buddha’s world view.

For those who are not familiar with the subject, I would recommend the first two introductory books on philosophy:

“What does it all mean?” by Thomas Nagel (1987) – Excellent introductory book and only 100 pages.

“The Making of a Philosopher”, by Colin McGill (2003) – Another excellent introductory book.

“Buddhist Philosophy – Essential Readings”, ed. by William Edelglass and Jay L. Garfield (2009).

“Mahayana Buddhism: The Doctrinal Foundations”, by Paul Williams (2009)

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“Causality and Chance in Modern Physics”, by David Bohm (1957).

“Conversations on Consciousness”, by Susan Blackmore (2006) – input from a number of philosophers.

“Mind – A Brief Introduction”, by John R. Searle (2004).

“The Character of Consciousness”, by David J. Chalmers (2010).

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Philosophy of the Mind

1. One nice thing about Buddha Dhamma is that there are no separate theories for the mind, meaning of existence, the physical world, or ANYTHING in this world. Thus I can refer to the section on [“Buddha Dhamma”](#) when I talk about the mind, the same way I refer to that section when I discuss [“Dhamma and Science”](#).
2. There seems to be three basic problems that the philosophers are trying to tackle regarding the mind (there are many others, but let us start with these):
 - How does the mental experience arise in a physical body? Most scientists and philosophers say that it originates in the brain, but they have not been able to make the connection. This is the “mind-body problem”.
 - How can non-physical mental states of consciousness cause something in the physical world? For example, how can your intention ever cause a movement of your hand? This is the “problem of mental causation”.
 - Finally, how your thoughts refer to something that is happening (or happened) in a distant city? This is called the “problem of intentionality”. If you are thousand miles away from home, you can take “tour” of the home, room by room, in your mind.
3. The philosophers are divided into two camps in addressing the above problems:
 - One camp says the “physical” and “mental” are two distinct realms. They do not think “mental” can arise from ‘physical’; This camp is mostly religious and attribute the “mental” to the concept of a “soul”. They are “dualists”.
 - The other camp is ‘materialistic’: they say the ‘mental’ arises from “physical”. In the worst case, some materialists deny even the existence of a mental reality, even though I cannot quite understand what that means. Because they are obviously thinking about these concepts, which is “mental”.
4. Let us look at the current status of these two camps:
 - Following the extreme dualism of Rene Descartes, there have been many dualists, including Stephen Jay Gould whose “non-overlapping magisteria” in the late 1990’s put matter and mind into non-overlapping disciplines: matter can be handled by science and morality and mind can be left to religion. However, these days only dualists left seem to be those who hold a dualist view for religious reasons, i.e., a soul.
 - These days most philosophers are materialists. With the amazing progress of science and technology, it is hard for most people to believe anything that is not “confirmed’ by science. And they think science, based on a purely materialistic approach, should be able to explain everything about ‘this world’. They believe that it is only a matter of time before brain activity will be able to explain the workings of the mind. Even those ‘moderates’ like Chalmers have a hard time going against the tide (see the reference list in [“Dhamma and Philosophy – Introduction”](#)).
 - The inadequacy of the materialist approach is detailed in a comprehensive manner by Thomas Nagel in his recent book, “Mind and Cosmos” (2012); it is an easy read with no fluff and only 128 pages. I was impressed by how close he came to advocating a “mind first” approach, just

like in Buddha Dhamma (apparently he does not know anything about Buddha Dhamma and does not even mention it).

5. Mind is the ultimate cause of everything in this world. The Buddha said, “mano pubbangama dhamma, mano setta manomaya...”. “Mind precedes all dhamma, all dhamma are mind made...”.

- This is in sharp contrast to both the “dualistic” and “materialistic” views.
- Most people translate the above Pali verse as, “mind precedes all mental phenomena...”. So, we need to examine what “dhamma” means here.
- In the Sabba Sutta, the Buddha clearly defines what “sabba” or “all” that in “in this world”: It is everything that can be experienced via the five physical senses and the mind. Specifically, eye and visible objects, ear and sound, nose and smells, tongue and tastes, body and touch, and the mind and concepts (these are the six internal and corresponding six external “āyatanas”), this is “the all”.
- Is there anything that is not included within those 12 āyatanas? There is nothing else in the whole world that is not included in those 12 āyatanas. Six of those are “internal”; eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind, and the other six are external, they exist “out there”.
- Therefore, it is NOT correct to say that “dhamma” in the above verse includes only mental phenomena, as many translators of the suttas have done. This is why I keep saying that we need to check consistency all the time. If one thing is not defined properly, then that error propagates and lead to contradictions.
- This “all” can also be expressed as the 31 realms of existence; of those 31 realms, normal humans experience only two realms (human and animal); see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”. But it is possible to experience other realms via developing mental power, i.e., jhanas: see, “[Power of the Human Mind – Introduction](#)” and the follow-up posts. Thus, the Buddha’s world view is much more expansive than the ones that are subjected to current scientific and philosophical investigations.

6. The reason that I started this website is that it is not possible to provide a reasonable explanation of the Buddha’s world view in an essay or even in several essays. At the website, I can make references to related posts. I hope it would be a rewarding experience for anyone who is willing to allocate some time to read AND contemplate.

- Another reason to start the website is that I want to have it all out in the open, so anyone can challenge any inconsistency. I want to find the truth myself, and the only way to do that is to get as many as possible to look at the emerging picture and make corrections to any errors anyone can find.
- Therefore, I would appreciate any comments pointing to any errors or inconsistencies anywhere on the site, in addition to suggestions for relevant topics to discuss.
- There is more to follow. This is an introduction.
- How “physical” arises from “mental” in the most fundamental sense is really complex and we may not get to that for a while. First we will concentrate on how physical bodies of the living beings arise *with causes from* the “mental”. I will be building up the Abhidhamma section and then will refer frequently to that section as we proceed.

7. It is time to make a paradigm change: Consciousness is not only an ontological fundamental, it takes precedence over matter. Mind can create matter. Right now we have evidence that the mind can change the brain; see, “[Truine Brain – How the Mind Rewires the Brain via Meditation/Habits](#)“. **If the brain creates the mind, how can the mind alter the brain?**

8. Here are a couple of papers on the subject related to the “mind body problem” for those who are interested (click on them to open):

[What is it Like to be a Bat – Nagel \(1974\) \(PDF file\)](#)

[All machine and no ghost- McGinn-2012 \(PDF file\)](#)

Buddha Dhamma: Non-Perceivability and Self-Consistency

1. Many people try to analyze and interpret Buddha Dhamma in terms of what is readily perceivable through our six senses.

- The Buddha said his Dhamma “had never been known to the world”. But many people try to explain the core teachings of the Buddha using conventional concepts. This has happened ever since Nagarjuana and other forefathers of “Mahayana Buddhism” tried to explain *Nibbana* in terms of various concepts such as “*sunyata*” or “emptiness”; see, “[Saddharma Pundarika Sutra \(Lotus Sutra\) – A Focused Analysis](#)” and “[What is Sunyata or Sunyata \(Emptiness\)?](#)”.
- The same thing happened to “Theravada Buddhism” too. Buddhaghosa, like Nagarjuana and others, was not even a *Sotapanna* and a *Vedic brahmin* before converting to “Buddhism” molded and twisted Buddha Dhamma to fit his *Vedic* concepts; see, “[Theravada: Problems with Current Interpretations of Key Concepts](#)”. Buddha’s *anapana bhavana* was replaced by the *Vedic pranayama* breath meditation, for example.
- **It is quite possible that Buddhaghosa, Nagarjuna, and others did not intentionally try to distort Buddha Dhamma, but just described Buddha Dhamma as they understood it with their background in *vedic* concepts. Even today, when people write books explaining what “Buddhism” is, they are also explaining it in terms of their own mundane frames of reference.**
- This is why, when you look at most of the books written today about Buddha Dhamma, it seems that there is not much difference between Buddha Dhamma and any other religion. They all teach “how to live a moral life”. There is very little discussion, if at all, on the foundational concepts such *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, *paticca samuppada*, *Anapanasati*, *Satipattana*, and whatever discussed is mostly incorrect.
- I think this single fact is the biggest obstacle for most people in embarking on the “correct Path” or even to get an idea of what real Buddha Dhamma is.
- We really need to contemplate what the Buddha meant by when he said, “my Dhamma has never been known to the world before”. It is not something one can grasp within the “conventional framework”, what is readily perceivable to a normal human with a defiled mind.

2. First let me clarify what I mean by “perceivable” or “comprehensible” to us as normal humans. Our six senses can “detect” only a tiny sliver of the “world”.

- At a base level, science today can account for only 4 percent of the mass of our universe; see, “The 4 Percent Universe: Dark Matter, Dark Energy, and the Race to Discover the Rest of Reality”, by Richard Panek (2011).
- There are many, many things that have not been “discovered” by science (or philosophy) yet, and basically nothing significant about the MIND has been discovered yet.
- Therefore, trying to gauge the validity of Buddha Dhamma **using only the known facts from science** is like a blind man trying to figure out what an elephant looks like by touching a leg of the elephant; see, “[How do we Decide which View is Wrong View \(Ditthi\)?](#)”.
- A frog living in a well does not know anything about the wider world. Similarly, a normal human, including all the scientists, face the problem of trying to figure out the “reality” by only

using data available through our limited six senses. Thus it is impossible for a scientific theory to be ever “complete” as proven by the mathematician Kurt Gödel; see, “[Gödel’s Incompleteness Theorem](#)”.

3. Most people think and believe that the only way to confirm what the Buddha taught is to see whether those teachings are compatible with science. However, it is not any different from believing that one can get an idea of what an elephant looks like by asking a blind man who has touched the leg of an elephant. OR asking a frog what the world outside the well looks like.

- This may sound ridiculous to many, but let us think back a few hundred years. Just 400 years ago, “science” believed in the geocentric model of the universe, i.e., that the Earth was at the universe and that the stars were embedded in a celestial sphere far above; see: http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Geocentric_model
- Not only science, but all other major religions tried to attune their religions to this model at that time, and most religions still adhere to those concepts; see the same Wikipedia article above.

4. But 2500 years ago, the Buddha clearly described our Solar system as a “*Chakkawata*” or “*Chakrawata*“, a planetary system. Not only that, he also said there are uncountable such systems in the universe and that it is a waste of time trying to find all the details about it.

- Through the years, and especially since the beginning of the 20th century, science has “re-discovered” some aspects of the Buddha’s wider world, including the existence of billions of galaxies EACH OF WHICH contains billions of planetary systems like our Solar system.
- But someone living in the 19th century was likely to ridicule the idea of innumerable world systems (*cakkawata*) and could have said, “where is the evidence from science?”. That aspect of Buddha Dhamma was not amenable to “science” at that time.
- **Just like that many aspects of Buddha Dhamma are not amenable to science at the current time. But with time, more and more will be shown to correct as science advances.**

5. If one is going to wait for the full confirmation of Buddha Dhamma by science, one is as foolish as that person who lived five hundred years ago, and embraced the geocentric model and dismissed Buddha Dhamma as “exotic” or “mystical”.

- We are fortunate to live in a time where science had made impressive progress and has confirmed many aspects of the Buddha’s world view.
- Just as the invention of the telescope led to the discovery of a much bigger cosmos, the discovery of the microscope (and its sophisticated versions) led to a previously unknown “microscopic world” teeming with innumerable microscopic living beings. There are billions of such beings in a single human body; see, “[There are as many creatures on your body as there are people on Earth!](#)”.

6. Science can accept only those phenomena that can be observed and measured with scientific instruments. Such scientific instruments are basically “extensions” for our six senses; see, “[Expanding “Consciousness” by Using Technology](#)”.

- For example, while we cannot see the moons of the Jupiter our naked eyes, we can see them with telescopes. While we cannot those microscopic creatures in our bodies with our naked eyes, we can see them with sophisticated microscopes. These are just two examples of many.

- When the Buddha said there are innumerable beings in this world, people looked around and laughed. The Mahayanists are still under under the impression that one could wait to attain the Buddhahood itself (not merely *Nibbana*) until “everyone” (presumably including all those billions of microscopic creatures on one’s body) is ready to attain the Buddhahood!
- **This is just the tip of the iceberg. While science has confirmed that there are uncountable planetary systems, it has not been able to find life on a single other planetary system yet. When that happens, the “wait for the Buddhahood” for the Mahayanists will become much longer.**
- **Similarly, the job of any “Creator” who looks after each and every being (even if just humans), will also become unbearably burdensome, since there are uncountable world systems with human beings as well.**
- I am not trying to make fun at the expense of others, but merely trying to get the point across that, for those who can think for themselves, it is time to get rid of all such nonsensical beliefs and wrong views.
- Getting rid of such wrong views comes way before starting any fruitful meditation. Purification through “correct views” comes before “purification through formal meditation”. *Samma ditthi* or “correct views of this world” comes first in eightfold Path.

7. By the time I cover enough of Abhidhamma material it will become more clear, but I want to point out another significant issue. In Abhidhamma, it is described in detail how all types of energies in the universe are “stored” in orbital motions (“*brahmana*” in Pali or Sinhala).

- For example, planetary systems are planets orbiting stars. The those planetary systems combine to make galaxies and those galaxies also undergo circular motion in shape of disks.
see: http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Retrograde_and_prograde_motion#Formation_of_celestial_sy
- Scientists discovered that atoms are basically electrons orbiting the tiny nucleus made out of protons and neutrons.
- But the Buddha taught all this and more 2500 years ago (of course not using the same terms): the smallest unit of matter is not an atom but a “*suddhashtaka*“. It is much smaller than an atom, and is “almost all energy”.
- This is basically what the scientists are finding out. They recently found evidence for the Higgs boson, which is believed to be the smallest mass unit ever detected.
- However, a “*suddhashtaka*” is even smaller. According to Buddha Dhamma, it is the motion of those “*suddhashtaka*” in various motion patterns (“*brahmana*“) that give rise to other material units, such as the “*kaya dasaka*“, “*bhava dasaka*“, etc. We will get to this later in the Abhidhamma section.

8. When we hear about something that cannot be explained with the CURRENT SCIENTIFIC KNOWLEDGE, we ascribe those to “esoteric” or “mystical”. But while there are many such “made up theories” that are out there without any substance, what is described in Buddha Dhamma can be SHOWN TO BE CONSISTENT with all our knowledge of the world.

- If we can bring back someone who had died before the 20th century, and tell him that we can “see” an event going on in a distant country in real time, he will not believe it. If we turn on a television and show him the actual event taking place, he will be flabbergasted; he will refuse to

believe it saying it is some sort of a magic trick.

- But now we know that the visuals and sounds of that event can be transformed and transmitted over long distances almost instantaneously, and can retrieve those signals by “tuning a television set” to the correct frequency.
- Working of *kamma vipaka* (energy stored) or rebirth taking place at a distant location work the same way. Even though we cannot “see” or perceive, that energy can materialize when the conditions become right; see, “[Annantara and Samanantara Paccaya](#)“. It will take some time to really sink in these concepts, but the more you read the more you will understand.

9. There are two key methods used in science to verify a given scientific theory: They have some basic axioms that appear to be inviolable, AND all other currently accepted scientific theories must be CONSISTENT with that theory.

- If a currently accepted scientific theory is proven to be inconsistent with a newly discovered phenomenon, then that scientific theory is discarded and a new theory is adopted.
- No scientific finding up-to-date has shown to inconsistent with pure Buddha Dhamma as given in the *Tipitaka*. If anyone can find any such instance, I would appreciate hearing about it.
- However, there are many things in Buddha Dhamma that have not been confirmed by science. More are being confirmed as new findings emerge.
- And, Buddha Dhamma is self consistent. Thus my obsession with making sure all my posts are inter-consistent.
- **Therefore, compatibility with “new findings” by science and self-consistency within the foundational concepts, such as *tilakkhana*, Four Noble Truths, Noble Eightfold Path, *Paticca Samuppada*, etc are the two ways to test the validity of Buddha Dhamma. Here “new findings by science” does not necessarily mean the explanations given by science, because scientific explanations can change with time (for example, the geocentric model had to be changed). If science finds evidence for life in outer space, that will be consistent with Buddha Dhamma, but what science proposes as how such life arose may not be the correct one.**

10. One needs to contemplate on the implications of these points (and there are many as I will mention in other posts). How can a human being who lived 2500 years ago can come up with such an elaborate way of describing material phenomena that are just beginning to be “re-discovered” by the efforts of thousands of scientists over many generations?

- It is quite clear that the Buddha was able to transcend all “normal human capabilities” by purifying his mind. Thus Gödel’s Incompleteness Theorem does not apply to Buddha Dhamma.
- Thus his Dhamma may not to “amenable” to the basic frame of reference that we all have as normal human beings. Concepts like rebirth and *kamma vipaka* may sound mysterious. The only way to see the truth in such concepts is to put them to the standard scientific method as discussed above.

11. The fact remains that the Buddha was able to see those and much more just by purifying his mind. And science has not yet figured out the “power of the human mind”.

- Even though a human can purify the mind to the level of a Buddha only once in many aeons on

the average, it is possible for each of to purify our minds to enough extent to see many facts about the nature that science is unaware of.

- **When that happens to a certain extent, then it becomes obvious that all these materialistic advances (and any type of sense indulgence that can be brought about by such advances) are insignificant compared to the sense of relief and well-being that one can achieve by purifying one's mind.**

12. For example, while one can enjoy the even the best food on Earth only while eating that food, even the *jhanic* experiences (*Ariya* or even *anariya jhanas*) can be long term. One could stay in a *jhana* for hours and enjoy that sense of relief.

- The “base level” of “cooling down” or *Nibbana* or “*niveema*” or “*nivana*” that comes at the *Sotapanna* stage is forever, and cannot be compared to any briefly-lived sense pleasure.
- If one can get to the fourth *jhana*, then one could develop *abhinna* powers to look back at one's own past rebirths and CONFIRM that the rebirth process is real. At that time one could even “see” many beings in other realms and also confirm their existence.
- Thus even though none of us will be able to “experience the complete reality” of this world like a Buddha can, with mental effort (purification of the mind), we could verify many aspects of the Buddha's wider world, and also be able to see what kind of suffering we had gone through in previous lives. Whatever suffering felt by a human under the worst conditions is nothing compared to the suffering encountered in the lowest four realms.
- And all that start with the correct understanding of *Lokottara Samma Ditthi* of comprehending *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* which is **beyond** the mundane *Samma Ditthi* of “how to live a moral life”; see, “[Maha Chattarisaka Sutta \(Discourse on the Great Forty\)](#)”.

Bhāvanā (Meditation)

Even for those who are practicing Buddhists, I recommend starting at the Introduction, and going down the list of topics at least the first time.

I am starting this section at the end of May, 2014. It has been almost 6 months since starting the website, and even though I am not anywhere close to getting the “base material” published, I think there is enough background material to get started discussing the actual practice.

- At this point there are just over 100 posts on the site, and it should be possible to refer back to those posts to clarify anything that is not clear in this section (of course you may send me a comment). I am going to avoid putting links in this section, because that could distract the flow.
- I have tried to make the titles self-descriptive, but you can also use the “search” button on top right to look for relevant posts on any keyword.
- I will start off with the basics so that even a person not much familiar with Buddha Dhamma can follow.
- After the 10th post, there are posts that I will keep adding which can be used as meditation topics. Of course one should be familiar with the basic Dhamma concepts first, in particular, *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.
- On the 10th post, I describe my own meditation procedures and my experience.

[Possible Outcomes of Meditation – Samadhi, Jhana, Magga Phala](#)

1. [Introduction to Buddhist Meditation](#)
2. [The Basics in Meditation](#)
3. [The Second Level](#)
4. [What do all these Different Meditation Techniques Mean?](#)
5. [Ariya Metta Bhavana \(Loving Kindness Meditation\)](#)
6. [Anapanasati Bhavana \(Introduction\)](#)
7. [What is Ānāpāna?](#)
8. [The Basic Formal Anapanasati Meditation](#)
9. [Key to Anapanasati – How to Change Habits and Character \(Gathi\)](#)
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Meditation Topics

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[What is Samadhi? – Three Kinds of Mindfulness](#)

[Panca Indriya and Panca Bala – Five Faculties and Five Powers](#)

Possible Outcomes of Meditation – Samadhi, Jhana, Magga Phala

1. As we discuss in the following posts, meditation is of two types: one is done at all times, being “morally mindful”, and then the other type is the formal meditation where one contemplates on a given “procedure” while sitting down or walking.

- In Buddhist meditation, the first is more important than the second.

2. Then there are three possible outcomes of meditation: *samadhi*, *jhana*, and *magga phala*.

3. One gets to *samadhi* by focusing the mind on one thing. Normally a mind jumps incessantly from one thing to another: a sound pulls the mind one way, a sight another way, smell, etc., and the mind itself likes to jump around. Regardless of the cause, this makes the mind tired, but unless one has experienced *samadhi*, or especially *jhana*, one may not even realize that one’s mind is constantly under stress; of course we do realize it when a deadline approaches and the mind goes to overdrive. One can truly appreciate this only after experiencing the tranquility of a focused mind. The mind gets “sensitized” as one gets to *samadhi*.

- Most people do not realize how “inherently stressed” our minds are. We get used to things, and do not feel even hardships. Only when we get to a “better state” we feel the difference, and then it is hard to go back to the “lower state”. For example, one who has lived a life of poverty has gotten used to it. Even though once in a while one thinks about the “better life” enjoyed by some others, one does not think about that all the time. However, if one is able to upgrade the lifestyle to a higher level, then one can FEEL the difference and now it will be very difficult to go back. One becomes “sensitized”. We will encounter this word “sensitized” in many cases when we discuss the *Satipatthana sutta*.
- Most people meditate to get some “peace of mind”, to get some relief from the pressures of hectic life. That is a form of *samadhi*. When one focuses on a neutral object, like breath, one gets to such a “neutral kind of *samadhi*”.
- There are three kinds of *samadhi* when categorized according to morality, i.e., what the focus is on: *micca samadhi* and two types of *samma samadhi*, one mundane (for living a better life) and one supermundane (focusing on *Nibbana*).
- There is a post on different types of *samadhi*: [“What is Samadhi? – Three Kinds of Mindfulness”](#).

4. *Jhana* is a deeper level of *samadhi*, where the mind really gets absorbed in the object (*arammana*). Then the tranquility is optimized, and there are eight levels of *jhanas*: the first four are the ones experienced by beings in the 16 realms of the *rupa loka*, and the last four in the 4 realms of the *arupa loka*.

- *Jhanas* CANNOT be attained via *micca samadhi*.
- The *jhanas* attained via *samma samadhi* are two types, corresponding to *Ariya jhanas* and *anariya jhanas*; see, [“Power of the Human Mind – Anariya or Mundane Jhanas”](#) and [“Power of the Human Mind- Ariya Jhanas”](#).
- Even though one can get to *anariya jhanas* by just focusing on the breath, it does require one to live a moral life. One who is not at least following the conventional five precepts will not be able to cultivate them.
- Of course the uniqueness of Buddhist meditation is the supermundane *samma samadhi*, leading to *Ariya jhanas*, and the four stages of *Nibbana*.

5. Thus the highest levels of “peace of mind” are at the four stages of *Nibbana* or *magga phala*: *Sotapanna*, *Sakadagami*, *Anagami*, and *Arahant*. However, it is not necessary to PRACTICE *Ariya jhanas* in order to attain *magga phala*. For example, one could attain [the Sotapanna stage](#) without practicing *jhanas*. At the moment one attains [the Sotapanna stage](#), one automatically goes through the first *Ariya jhana*, but unless one has practiced it before, a *Sotapanna* cannot automatically get into a *jhana*. However, it will be easy for a *Sotapanna* to attain *jhanas* with practice.

6. In order to clarify this point, let us look at the processes of getting to *Ariya jhanas* and attaining *magga phala*.

- In order to attain either one, it is NECESSARY to have some understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, the Three Characteristics of existence. If one does not understand these terms correctly, one will not be able to attain either *Ariya jhanas* or *magga phala*; see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations](#)”.

7. Now, in order to develop *Ariya jhanas*, one needs practice specifically with that goal. **In any order to attain any type of *jhana* one needs to have a single focus and stay on it.**

- In breath meditation for *anariya jhanas*, one focuses the mind on the breath: see, “[Power of the Human Mind – Anariya or Mundane Jhanas](#)”.

8. To get to *Ariya jhanas*, one focuses on *Nibbana* (or more precisely recall one’s own “cooling down”): see, “[Power of the Human Mind- Ariya Jhanas](#)”.

- Basically, one sits down in a quiet place, and first contemplates on *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, for a little while, and then keep repeating the following (or the English translation; what matters is one has to have the understanding): “*Ethan santhan ethan paneethan, sabba sankhara samatho, Sabbhupathi patinissaggo, tanhkkhayo, virago, nirodho, Nibbanan ti*”, which means, “It is the only peace, the only happiness: prevent *sankhara* from arising (via) eliminating *tanha* and excess greed, and thus stopping the arising of defilements, which is *Nibbana*”.
- The reciting of a certain phrase (meaningfully, with understanding) is called a “*kammasthana*”. A given meditation technique is also called a *kammasthana*.
- Two important points to keep in mind: (1). One can either say it out quietly, or say it in one’s mind, (2) This is not chanting; just saying the words will be just a waste of time. One needs to comprehend, to some extent, what is meant by *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, i.e., some idea of what *Nibbana* (or “cooling down” is).
- If one has experienced any kind of “cooling down” it is best to recall that while saying the above phrase. For example, if one does not flare up like one used to, or if one has less attachment to things, that is the best to recall.

9. If one is not interested in attaining a *jhana* first, one could just focus on doing insight meditation (on *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* or any other Dhamma concept) and *anapana* meditation, without doing the above procedure. Several of these are discussed in the posts below, and we will discuss the procedures in the *Satipatthana sutta* in the near future. It is possible that one may develop *jhana* this way too, especially if one gets to contemplate deeply about a certain point, or if one has “*sansaric* habits” of getting into *jhanas*.

- Also, one could develop the first *Ariya jhana* and then cultivate the above mentioned techniques to attain *magga phala*.
- It should also be clear that even to develop *Ariya jhanas*, one needs to do insight meditation and *anapanasati* meditation to some extent, because one cannot comprehend *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*

without doing that.

10. Thus there are many different ways to get to *jhanas* and *magga phala*; we will discuss how to tailor some techniques to suit oneself in a future post. But any of them REQUIRE the understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, the Three Characteristics of existence. Without the “correct vision” or *samma ditthi* at some level, the mind does not see the unfruitful nature of sense pleasures or the “superiority” of [*niramisa sukha*](#).

Next, “[Are you not getting expected results from meditation?](#)“,

Are you not getting expected results from meditation?

Some people try to attain Nibbanic bliss by trying to “give up all attachment to this world” in their minds during meditation. However, until the mind truly realizes the dangers of this world (the rebirth process), it is unable to give up those attachments. One has to attain at least the *Sotapanna* stage by “seeing the true nature of this world” before one’s mindset becomes amenable to “giving up”. This is the hardest part to understand.

1. During the time of the Buddha there was a *bhikkhu* named Pötıla, who was well-versed with deep Dhamma concepts and was a well known teacher; he had developed *abhinna* powers as well, but had not attained even the *Sotapanna* stage. One day he went to see the Buddha, paid respects, and told the Buddha that he had been a Dhamma teacher during the times of several earlier Buddhas too, and helped many to attain *Nibbana* (*Arahantship*).

- The Buddha asked him whether he has attained any *magga phala* and Bhikkhu Potila admitted that he had not. The Buddha just commented: “*Thucca* Potila” and turned his attention to other matters; *thucca* (pronounced “thuchcha”) in Pali means despicable or “lowly”.

2. So, bhikkhu Potila, who had expected praise from the Buddha for helping others, realized that he needs to work on his own salvation before helping others. He strived by himself and could not make any progress; he was trying very hard to “give up all attachments”, following the same instructions he was giving others. When he sought help from other *bhikkhus*, they were reluctant to become his teacher because everyone knew he was very knowledgeable in Dhamma. Eventually, he went to this very young *Arahant*, who was well-known for his teaching abilities, and sought help. The young *Arahant* agreed to help, only if *bhikkhu* Potila agreed to carry out everything as instructed, and Potila agreed.

- The young *Arahant* decided to use an unusual *kammatthana* (instructions). He took Potila to a large area covered by mud, and asked him to wade into the mud and keep going until told to stop. Potila started wading in mud and kept going until he was told to stop when the mud was all the way up to his chin; he was barely able to move at this point because mud was heavy.

3. The *Arahant* told him that, “if someone is stuck in mud like that any knowledge about cleaning oneself by taking a bath is not going to help. One needs to get out of the mud first”.

- Then he asked Potila to come back. Potila had great difficulty in moving forward initially, since he was all the way up to the chin in thick and heavy mud. While dragging himself out of the mud with great difficulty, Potila realized what the young *Arahant* was talking about. It is not possible to get out of mud until one realizes that one is stuck there, and getting out of mud required sheer will power. Similarly, he had not realized that he was stuck at a much lower moral level; he needed to cleanse his mind first. The “giving up” part comes with a mind that has removed the wrong visions (*micca ditthi*); and that comes via comprehending *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.

4. The simile can be made even better by looking at what happens to ants who get stuck in honey. Here unlike mud, the sense pleasures are appealing and there is no incentive to get out either. Those ants who get stuck in honey, would not even try to get out because they are too busy enjoying the honey. **Even when they are barely stuck, and can move out of honey, they would not because they like the taste of honey.** Just like that, any living being, whether a human or even the lowly worm, likes to indulge in the sense pleasures, and thus gets stuck..

- **And even when one realizes that one needs to get out of “the honey pot” it is hard, at least**

initially.

- For that one needs to see the perils of staying in this rebirth process, where birth in lower four realms will lead to unimaginable suffering. Even if one can strive to be born in higher realms, that will not last long. **This is “*anicca*”: no matter how hard we try to find refuge in the 31 realms it is not possible to do so in the long run.**

5. With much effort, Potila slowly made his way up to the waist level, and started feeling the lightness of being free of mud. He could now move faster too. He felt the relief when he was out the mud, and was asked to go and take a shower. Now, cleaning up with soap could be done; but while stuck in mud, there was no use of soap and water. Just like that the deep Dhamma that he had memorized was of no use to him while he was still stuck in mud.

- Eventually, when one comes out the mud that is like the *Sotapanna* level. One is still covered with mud, i.e., one still likes to enjoy sense pleasure. But now one KNOWS that one needs to take a shower, use soap and shampoo, and remove all that mud.

6. What Potila was doing was to give discourses on deep Dhamma that could help a *Sotapanna* attain higher stages of *Nibbana*. All those who benefited from *bhikkhu* Potila’s discourses were, ironically, *Sotapannas* or above. Potila was just reciting the Dhamma without real comprehension but those who benefited were capable of comprehending the true meanings. After that *kammatthana*, Potila was able to attain the *Sotapanna* stage and soon became an *Arahant*.

(By the way, one cannot attain the *Sotapanna* stage by taking instructions from an *Anariya*, i.e., one who had not attained at least the *Sotapanna* stage. But once one attains the *Sotapanna* stage, one can learn by himself or from anyone else and get to the higher stages. This is why it was only *Sotapannas* or above who could benefit from *bhikkhu* Potila’s discourses).

- I believe this actual incident involving *bhikkhu* Potila highlights a very important point. No matter how much one reads on deep concepts of Dhamma, it is hard to get the idea to sink in unless one’s mind is purified to a certain extent. It is critical first to break through the heavy fog of being covered by many wrong concepts and strong attachments. When one breaks through that initial “wall of resistance”, then it is easier to comprehend deeper concepts; see [“*Lobha, Dosa, Moha versus Raga, Patigha, Avijja*”](#).

7. Just like it is not possible to learn high school math without learning basic addition/subtraction, one MUST understand the basic concepts first. If one is engaged in killing, stealing, sexual misbehavior, lying, gossiping, getting “drunk” with alcohol, drugs, power, beauty, money, etc, it is not possible to calm the mind to a basic level. **And this is the hard part.** One is stuck in mud (more like honey, because it feels good to be stuck there).

- And while stuck in mud (or honey), no matter how much meditation one does, it is not possible to get LONG TERM relief. One may be able to go to a meditation retreat and be away from all those “honey-filled” attractions and enjoy some sense of calmness; but that goes away soon after coming back to “real life” with all those temptations.
- One needs to slowly work one’s way through the mud (or honey, because that is how it seems initially first). This is the HARDEST part. No matter how much one READS, that is not going to make much difference until one sets up the stage for the mind to see the reality.

8. Here is a rough step-by-step I would recommend (this is of course not for everyone; just for those who know they are stuck in honey):

A. If one is hurting others to get sense pleasure, that should be stopped first. It is double jeopardy; one is not only “getting stuck” due to excess greed, but also going to suffer consequences of harming others. One is not only getting attached to “pleasurable things” but also accumulating bad kamma by hurting others.

- For example, if one is killing animals for fun (sport), stealing valuables from others, having sexual relationships with other married people or young children, planning to hurt someone (even for retaliation), or spreading rumors about someone just to get some pleasure out of it, getting drunk and verbally/physically abusing others, all those would be included here.
- **Such immoral activities are the worst, and are called “*pāpa kamma*”. Both *lobha* and *dosa* (*dvesha*) are involved here and one’s mind is said to totally covered with ignorance (*moha*);** see, [“Lobha,Dosa, Moha versus Raga, Patigha, Avijja”](#).
- Thus someone in this stage is deeply in mud all the way up to the chin.

B. One notch lower is being capable to do things (of course not always) with EXTREME greed (and hate in the mind), even if it does not hurt others directly; here one is only up to waist to shoulder level in mud. These are normally the things one does to seek “perceived happiness” by going to extremes.

- When one cannot get “high enough” with alcohol one tends to try drugs, because one has been “de-sensitized”. We all know of many movies stars etc. who get into this trend and end up committing suicide because nothing at the end can bring more pleasure to a highly “de-sensitized” mind.
- Another indication of extreme behavior is living beyond one’s means. This is of course relative. If one is living a small (but comfortable) house and wants to move in to a bigger house just for the sake of that **by stretching one’s resources**, that is a sign of extreme greed. If one is already living in a mansion that one has inherited or earned, and there is no financial burden, then there is nothing wrong with that since that will not burden the mind. However, in general, the more fancier the item is, whether a house or a car or anything else, it normally takes more time and effort to “maintain”, and inevitably there is a degree of attachment because of the perceived value.
- Such extreme greed could also lead to actions of hate, when someone else gets in the way. Then one may do “*pāpa kamma*” here as well; it is possible that actions of hate gets one to the higher level.

It is not possible to discuss all possibilities, but one should be able to figure out many such cases. No one else can decide these for anyone. Only each person knows about one’s own status of mind. However, any sensible person can make some kind of a judgement for oneself, but not for others.

C. If one is at stage A or B above, one should read those posts in the “Moral Living” section. It could be helpful to go back and read those as one makes progress, and see the one understands more things than previously. This is hard to explain, but is true. A clear mind sees things much more easily.

- For those who are in stage A or B should read posts #1 through #3 below first.

D. Once one gets to the B stage, one should start reading the posts on the “Key Dhamma Concepts” and in particular learn and comprehend *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.

This is the real key step, to get started on the next stage. Once one gets some traction, there is nothing there to hold back someone from attaining the *Sotapanna* stage. It had been hard for hundreds of

years only because the correct concepts were hidden. Once one gets some traction, one can start doing any of the *bhavana*.

- As Carl Sagan said, “..think about all those emperors and kings who committed unmentionable atrocities just to have a sense of superiority and power for maybe 50 years. They are all gone”; see, “[The Pale Blue Dot.....](#)“. Even though Dr. Sagan did not know, that is another way to state what *anicca* is.
- All those emperors and kings will be stuck in the animal or lower realms for billions of years to come. On the other hand, a peasant who lived within his/her means and led a moral life could be living in a *deva/brahma* realm for billions of years.
- The main point here is that there is no point in trying to seek sense pleasures or accumulate wealth for 80-100 years maximum, because at the end we will not be able to KEEP ANYTHING to our satisfaction. We may have a billion dollars, but if our bodies are worn out, will we be able to get ANY sense pleasures? Will we be able to keep any part of our bodies to our satisfaction? Many people try to “beat the aging process” by using temporary fixes such as botox, but any such effect will also will be temporary.
- It is not possible to really grasp the meaning of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, if one is stuck in mud or honey.

E. When one comes out of the mud and start walking (with mud on the body), that is like the *Sotapanna* stage. Now one does not even need anyone’s help, even though that can help expedite the process; one can figure things out by oneself.

- There are many who know many *suttas* by heart or abhidhamma concepts, but nowhere close to the *Sotapanna* stage.
- We need to understand that Buddha Dhamma is not about JUST LEARNING concepts (even though learning plays a big part), it is all about using what is learned for purifying the mind. As the mind becomes clear, one will start seeing the reality better. In the Buddha’s days, illiterate people were able learn Dhamma just by listening, and even attained Arahant hood.

F. The final stage is to realize that even birth in such *deva/brahma* worlds will be temporary. At some point in the future, they are all going to commit some bad deed and end up in the four lower realms for long times; that is just the nature of this world, where sense pleasures can lure anyone to commit bad actions. But there is no point in talking about that stage, until one gets above the A and B stages, and become a *Sotapanna*.

G. The series of posts that I am writing on the *Satipatthana Sutta* goes through this process too, from stage A. Therefore, it may be a good idea to read those posts from the beginning as well. The first introductory posts are full of Pali words, but just go through them briefly even if you do not fully understand. They WILL become clear later, if not now.

- [When one starts following the Path, one is bound to break the trend once in a while. A child learning to walk will fall many times. Many people get discouraged when they do an immoral act occasionally; but just to realize that one did a mistake, and that it bothers one’s mind, means one HAS MADE PROGRESS. That is why one needs to have the perseverance to get back up with a renewed determination. Just like a child WILL learn to walk, one WILL get better with time.](#)

H. Of course I do not know the level of each person coming to the website. Only each person knows where he/she is relative to the above steps.

- If one truly can purify one's mind and comprehend *anicca, dukkha, anatta*, that is all it takes to attain the *Sotapanna* stage.
- There is material ranging from the basic level to very advanced levels and even more will be posted in the future. This is for the sake of completeness, and also to make sure that any scholar or interested person can gauge the depth of Buddha's true teachings.
- There are also people who really start comprehending Dhamma and start enjoying finding about further details; no other type of "pleasure activity" can match of the "enjoyment of Dhamma". Buddha Dhamma is the ultimate "book of nature".
- Furthermore, reading widely on different topics will help build *saddha* (faith), which is NOT blind faith but faith built on understanding. When one sees how little modern science knows in comparison to the Buddha, it helps build faith. **And *panna* (wisdom) and *saddha* grow together.**

Next, "[1. Introduction to Buddhist Meditation](#)",

1. Introduction to Buddhist Meditation

The top 11 posts in this section describe a way of using meditation in following the Noble Path and to attain *Ariya jhanas* and at least [the Sotapanna stage](#) of *Nibbana*. This series was put together using my own experience, and in the 10th and 11th posts I describe how the process can culminate in attaining *Ariya jhanas* (and possibly *magga phala*). The rest of the posts in this section are on possible meditation subjects and together with other posts at the site can be used to clarify unresolved questions, and to gain *samadhi*. It is recommended that the first 11 posts be followed in that order, at least initially.

1. We can get an idea of what “Buddhist Meditation” is, by looking at the Path described by the Buddha to achieve various stages of *Nibbana*. *Nibbana* is not an esoteric concept as many believe. That is why I like the synonyms “*niveema*” or “cooling down” because these terms do convey *Nibbana* as something that is approached systematically and can be EXPERIENCED in the early stages even before [the Sotapanna stage](#).

- “*Ragakkhaya Nibbanan, dosakkhaya Nibbanan, Mohakkhaya Nibbanan*”, gives the essence of how this “cooling down” is attained.
- The more one gets rid of greed, hate, and ignorance, the more one experiences *Nibbana* or “*niveema*” or “cooling down”.
- One does not, and one cannot, get rid of greed, hate, and ignorance in a few days. It is a gradual process. One can experience the “cooling down” to the extent one can purify the mind. And there will be ups and downs, especially in the early days, thus ONE MUST HAVE THE RESOLVE to stay on the Path.
- **Some people just stay with breath meditation for “stress reduction”, and actually avoid anything to do with *Nibbana*.** They equate *Nibbana* with extinction, but there is no need to worry; [the fact that one has that mindset means that one is nowhere close to *Nibbana*](#). I am not saying this in a derogatory way, but just as a fact. Until one experiences some “cooling down”, and get some idea about about *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, it is very difficult to get an idea of what *Nibbana* is.

2. Meditation provides ways to achieve this “cooling down” for the three types of people who are interested in meditation:

- Many people just want to practice some basic meditation that the Buddha advocated for achieving some “inner peace”.
- Some are convinced about the rebirth process, but are mainly concerned about getting a “good birth” in the next life.
- The main goal of this site is to provide enough material for one to attain the first stage of *Nibbana*, [the Sotapanna stage](#). After that, one does not need outside help to complete the rest of the journey. However, there are many people who are either not ready to take that task yet, or are not yet convinced about the existence of 31 realms, process of rebirth, or *Nibbana*.

3. In several posts I have tried to give an idea of what this “cooling down” is. You may want to read them again. They vary from a basic description to deeper details. Yet, they all deal with reducing greed, hate, and ignorance from our minds.

- The words greed and hate are clear, but many do not understand what is meant by ignorance. The post, [“What is Avijja \(Ignorance\)?”](#) gives a bit deeper description, but since it is really

important, I want to say a few words here about ignorance.

- The “traditional method” for achieving some “cooling down” or “calming sensation” is to do “breath meditation” or “*kasina* meditation”. **As I questioned in several posts, how can the greed, hate, or ignorance be removed via concentrating on one’s breath or some kasina object? Such meditation techniques DO NOT remove ignorance, and only SUPPRESS greed and hate.**
- Buddha Dhamma is for the wise; it is not to be followed by blind faith but with understanding. One needs to learn and “see” Dhamma first. A sustained “Cooling down” cannot be attained via following a set procedure like watching the breath.
- In fact, one could go a long way (up to [the Sotapanna stage](#)) just by learning Dhamma and comprehending the key concepts. When one grasps the key concepts, it begins dawn on oneself that it does not make sense to be too greedy, or to hate someone with a level of hatred that makes one’s heart to “heat up” to uncomfortable levels.
- Thus through better understanding of Dhamma (i.e., removing ignorance), one automatically “cools down”. [Removing ignorance via learning Dhamma leads automatically to reducing greed and hate.](#)

4. This is why “*Samma Ditthi*” or “Correct Vision” comes first in the Noble Eightfold Path. **Actually “samma” means “san” + “ma” or “removing defilements”; but for brevity we will use the word “correct”. But keep in mind that “samma ditthi” means “removing defilements through correct vision”.** I cannot emphasize enough the importance of learning Dhamma. This is the first BIG step. Without understanding the message of the Buddha, how can one follow his Path?

- When one starts to understand the key Dhamma concepts, one constantly tend to think about such concepts and how they should be kept in mind while going through daily chores. This is “*samma sankappa*” or “correct concepts”. This automatically lead to “*samma vaca*” (correct speech), “*samma kammanta*” (correct action), *samma ajiva* (correct livelihood).
- When these five steps are followed, one becomes attuned to correct mindfulness (“*samma sati*”). Yes. There is an “incorrect mindfulness” (“*micca sati*”, pronounced “michcha sathi”) too, like when a master thief plans a robbery. One needs to be “engaged” or fully focused to accomplish any task either good or bad.
- With cultivated “*samma sati*”, one will be able to “see” the consequences of any action very quickly and decide whether to go ahead with it (since only good can come out of that action) or to abandon it (because it is not good for oneself or to others).
- When one sees the benefits of these steps (i.e., “cooling down”) one will be motivated to work harder on all these steps, i.e., one cultivates “*samma vayama*” (correct effort).
- The culmination is “*samma samadhi*” (correct calm state of mind). Yes. There is a “*micca samadhi*” too: When that master thief is planning a big robbery, he gets into a kind of *samadhi* too; he feels a sense of calm too, but that will have very bad consequences down the road.
- Actually the latter three develop at the same time. In fact, one could get into “*samma samadhi*” just via “*samma ditthi*”. When one listens attentively to a Dhamma talk or gets absorbed in reading about a key Dhamma concept, it is possible that one could get into “*samadhi*”; a *jhanic* state is a deeper *samadhi* state.

5. This is why I recommend everyone to read these posts during a quiet time. [One will absorb more and just by contemplating on the material while reading one could easily get into samadhi.](#) This is

what meditation is all about. “Absorbing the good” will automatically force the “bad” out, and one gets into *samadhi* automatically; we will talk about this “*anapana*” process in the following posts.

- It will get to the point that one can sit down and get into a *jhana* within a minute or two. But that will take time.
- I hope you will be able to experience the LONG TERM benefits from the procedures we discuss in this post and the followup posts. Initially, it will be a bit slow, but if one sticks with it for a few months, one should be able to see a change in oneself that is not merely a temporary relief. For some it will be faster.

6. In this life we feel two kinds of suffering: bodily pains and aches as well as various diseases and mental suffering (disappointments to depression).

- Bodily ailments take time to recover; even those can be reduced by careful planning and being mindful too. If one engages in physical activity (walking to rigorous exercise) and be mindful of what one eats, many such ailments can be reduced over time.
- Mental suffering could have direct causes in greed, hate, and ignorance. While some are due to past kamma, most can be avoided or reduced by being mindful of what one thinks, speaks, and does. Any thought, speech, or bodily action arising from a greedy, hateful, or ignorant thought is going to cause mental anguish sooner or later.
- The easiest way to determine whether any action is bad is to contemplate on the consequences: if it is going to harm oneself or another being, then that action is rooted in greed, hate, or ignorance.

7. Thus Buddhist meditation is basically to cultivate the Noble Eightfold Path.

- By preventing from killing, stealing, verbal abuse, etc, what we are effectively is to “put out existing fires” in our minds and also prevent such “future fires” from starting. This is “*niveema*” or “cooling down” or *Nibbana*.
- We should also do things that will help with such moral behavior: associating with like-minded people and environments, actively engaging in opposite moral behavior that makes the heart joyful, etc.
- The most important thing is to learn Dhamma so that one can “see” how all this will liberate one’s mind on a PERMANENT basis. The change becomes “permanent” only when this step is achieved.

When perfected, one will be doing meditation all day long while doing daily chores; this is what the Buddha described as “*asevitaya, bhavithaya, bahuleekathaya*” or “associate and use what is good, and do that as much as possible”.

- In a formal meditation session one does the same. The best is to read a post or two on a given Dhamma concept just before (or during) the session and then contemplate on those ideas. It is important to compare those concepts with one’s life experiences, and things will become clear with time: for example, why it is unfruitful to “live life lavishly, especially if that involves hurting oneself or others”.
- You will be surprised that this process itself will get you to *samadhi*, and even *jhanas* in the long term. But we will discuss some other variations too.
- As I have mentioned in several posts, one could even get to [the Sotapanna stage](#) just via comprehending the key Dhamma concepts to some extent.

8. Buddha Dhamma is all about the mind; Anything we say or do also start with a thought. The Buddha said, “*manopuubbangama dhamma...*”, “the mind takes precedence over everything else..”.

- It should be clear from the above discussion that Buddha’s meditation techniques are attuned to Nature’s laws. They can be followed by anyone with most religious backgrounds or by an atheist.
- One becomes a “*Bhauddhaya*” or a “Buddhist” in his/her mind. If one understands some basic Dhamma concepts and lives by them, then one is automatically a Buddhist. After one gets started with a firm determination on the Path, “*Dhammo have rakkathi dhammacari*”, or “Dhamma will guide one to be on the right Path”.
- The foremost goal is to live a moral life without causing harm to oneself or others, and to seek some “peace of mind” from the modern hectic life. That is our starting point.

Next, “[2. The Basics in Meditation](#)“,

2. The Basics in Meditation

The top 11 posts in this section describe a way of using meditation in following the Noble Path and to attain *Ariya jhanas* and at least [the Sotapanna stage of Nibbana](#). This series was put together using my own experience, and in the 10th and 11th posts I describe how the process can culminate in attaining *Ariya jhanas* (and possibly *magga phala*). The rest of the posts in this section are on possible meditation subjects and together with other posts at the site can be used to clarify unresolved questions, and to gain *samadhi*. It is recommended that the first 11 posts be followed in that order, at least initially.

1. Those who are doing breath meditation or “watching the stomach rise and fall” know that it is relatively easy for some to calm the mind compared to others. Some cannot even keep a calm mind for more than few minutes; things start “popping up” in the mind.

- This “popping up” is due to the five hindrances that I have described in a post. These are the basic “residues” or “gunk” that we have deep inside our minds that start bubbling up to the surface when we sit down to meditate.

2. Let us take the simile of a water well that is contaminated with all the rotten stuff that have fallen into it over many years; our minds have accumulated gunk over repeated births, not just in this life. When we are engaged in stressful day-to-day activities, those activities stir up the ‘gunk’ and the mind gets clouded; it is like taking a long pole and stirring the well water; the “gunk” at the bottom come up.

- The two basic “rotten things” we have are the first two on the list of the five hindrances: *kammachanda* (excessive greed) and *vyapada* (deep hate).
- *Vicikicca* is a set of person “likings”, and these can be likings for material things OR things that one likes to “hate”; one does these because of the ignorance of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. *Vicikicca* is sort of like a “favorite list” from the main ingredients of excessive greed and deep hate, the first two hindrances. *Kanka vicikicca* is a worse form of *vicikicca* that arises due to wanton disregard of correct views, such as the rebirth process.
- The other two are more like “stirrers”, that stir up these bad habits and bring them up on their own: *thina middha* (“trapped” or “frozen” mind), *uddhacca-kukkucca* (tendency of the mind to be scattered; an excited mind).
- *Thina middha* or inability concentrate on dhamma concepts can be enhanced after a meal, but it can be a personal characteristic or a habit; we will call this the “lazy mind”. An “unsettled” or “excited” mind (*uddhacca-kukkucca*) is also personal, and arises when one feels “superior” or “inferior” compared to others: it must be noted that a “shrunk mind” associated with inferiority is not to be confused with an “unassuming character”.
- The five hindrances are discussed in detail in the Moral Living section.

3. When we are engaged in day-to-day activities, we see, hear, smell, taste, touch, and also think about all sorts of things; all these are ‘external stirrers’ that really make our minds look like whirlpools. All these gang up to get the mind to stress out and “heat up”. This is the tension that we feel in a busy day. We need to “cool down”; we need “*niveema*”.

- one way to “cool down” is to turn off those external stirrers temporarily. This is what we try to do in a breath meditation: we go to a quiet place, close our eyes; this will turn off mainly the five physical senses (i.e., we do not see, hear, smell, taste, touch). This really helps to calm the mind for some people, especially if they have practiced a lot.

- But it is not possible to turn off the sixth one, the mind itself. This is why we try to fix the mind on one object, say the breath or the rising of the stomach.
- Actually, some people try to “turn off the mind”, or try to stop thoughts. This is DANGEROUS. We need to PURIFY the mind. That is the way to ultimate peace of mind. The Buddha had the perfectly pure mind. He was able to deliver a very complex Dhamma in many different forms over 45 years because of that. When one follows the Path, one’s mind will become sharper, not inactive.

4. However, if we have too much gunk, then the mind will be contaminated even without the aid of a stirrer. It is like an old well that had been abandoned. It has dirty water, and one needs to REMOVE the existing dirty water first. Similarly, if one is engaged in immoral behavior (**the BIG EIGHT**: killing, stealing, sexual misconduct, lying, gossiping, slandering, harsh speech, and getting “drunk” with not only drugs or alcohol, but also with wealth, fame, power, etc), then the mind is like a well that has dirty water to begin with. Even if stays undisturbed, the water cannot get any cleaner by sitting in a quiet place and turning off the physical senses. **Thus it would be hard to even to achieve calmness with breath meditation if one is actively engaged in the BIG EIGHT (unless one has had a lot of practice, but even then the calmness lasts only until the focus is held).**

- This is basically *kayanupassana*, the first step in *Satipatthana*; see, “[Satipatthana – Introduction](#)”.
- Therefore, if someone is engaged in one or more of those eight activities, the first thing to do is to try to get rid of them. First start with the worst, and proceed gradually until all are removed. It is like emptying the well of the dirty water.
- This is a BIG STEP. It may take a little while, depending on how much cleaning to be done. But one thing is not to rush out and try to do much. That could be stressful too. The best thing to do is to abstain from one or two big ones, and experience the “cooling down” that results from it.
- Vain talk is a habit that should be gotten rid of early. It does not do any good to oneself or the others. It is inevitable that one will say something inappropriate (possibly slandering, and lying too, which are also in the BIG EIGHT) when one gets carried away during vain talk. Getting rid of it will help with being able to calm the mind quickly.
- The mind needs to see the benefits of doing something before it really gets on board. This is why initially it may take a lot of determination to stick with the plan.
- **It is important NOT to get used to the breath meditation; if you are used to it, I would urge you to gradually stop and try the procedures described here at least for a couple of months. We want LONG TERM results, and there are many people who get addicted to breath meditation to get temporary relief. THAT IS A MISTAKE.**

5. Getting rid of bad old habits and installing new good habits is a KEY in the meditation practice; we will talk about habits (“*gathi*” which become “*asavas*” over time) in more detail in the next section. Here are some basic ideas that would be helpful:

- To form a new habit, initially it takes some effort. I tried it out by making a new habit of peeling oranges with my left hand (I am right-handed). Initially it was hard, and the main problem was that I kept forgetting to use the left hand. I had to set an alarm to remind myself first. But after a few days, I started remembering, and after a week or two, the new habit was working. Now I automatically do it, and now it is a bit strange to try to peel oranges with the right hand!
- When we make a new habit, a set of neurons in the brain start to wire together for that task; the

more we do it, the stronger the neural connections become. This is what happens when we learn to ride a bike, drive a car, or zillions of other things that we do without even thinking about it; see, “[Truine Brain: How the Mind Rewires the Brain via Meditation/Habits](#)” and “[How Habits are Formed and Broken – A Scientific View](#)“.

- In breaking a habit one needs to do the reverse. When one starts to smoke less and less, the neural connections for that task will get weaker and weaker. After a while, it will become easier not to smoke; brain will stop giving that signal. So it is critical to have the determination to hold off the urge in the beginning. Try to replace that activity with something else at that time. Craving for a food item can be removed the same way, and much more, including our bad habits such as lying, gossiping, etc. It is the same principle.

6. The basic formal meditation technique is described in the next section. For those of who need to get rid of the BIG EIGHT, they can also monitor the progress by doing such formal meditation sessions. It is important to realize that all defilements are removed only at the *Arahant* stage. So, there is no point in getting discouraged if it takes time to stop bad habits; **the key is to make progress, and not to go backward.**

- Sometimes when one starts on the *Ariya Bhavana*, things may look worse before getting better. It is like trying to cool a hot iron by sprinkling water on it, when all that smoke comes out and may appear to be getting worse. But one needs to be persistent. One needs to keep in mind that uncountable beings have attained “cooling down” by having faith in the Buddha.

Next, “[3. The Second Level – Key to Purify the Mind](#)“,

3. The Second Level – Key to Purify the Mind

The top 11 posts in this section describe a way of using meditation in following the Noble Path and to attain *Ariya jhanas* and at least [the Sotapanna stage of Nibbana](#). This series was put together using my own experience, and in the 10th and 11th posts I describe how the process can culminate in attaining *Ariya jhanas* (and possibly *magga phala*). The rest of the posts in this section are on possible meditation subjects and together with other posts at the site can be used to clarify unresolved questions, and to gain *samadhi*. It is recommended that the first 11 posts be followed in that order, at least initially.

1. Let us go back to the example of the abandoned well. Now we have done a decent job of cleaning the dirty water that had been there for a long time, i.e., we have reduced at least some of the main immoral acts, the BIG EIGHT. [Now we need to make sure that things do not fall into the well while we try to make the water even more cleaner](#); if there is no barrier around it, when it rains mud water can fall into the well. As with the well, we need to make sure that we keep those BIG EIGHT out of our minds as much as possible. **This is ‘sila’ (pronounced “seela”) or moral living.**

2. In order to make sure that we will not drift back to the old ways, we need to cultivate moral mindfulness (“*sati*”): we need to be on the “lookout” for any temptations to break the BIG EIGHT. But there is a catch that most people do not comprehend: the bad habits and cravings or “*gathi/asavas*” that we have are not only from this life, but possibly from previous lives as well.

3. Again, we can use the old water well as an example: When we drained the water out of the well, the well starts filling up with water from underground fresh water oozing through cracks which is pure. However, if we have lot of rotten stuff at the bottom of the well that had been there for a long time, then that pure water gets contaminated. Our bad habits (*gathi/asavas*) are like the dirt at the bottom of the well. They give rise to the five hindrances, that we mentioned in the above section.

4. The water in the above well will now look relatively more clear if it is undisturbed, i.e, when we let the water to settle down. **This is effectively what we do in breath meditation or any such *samatha* meditation.** When someone is abstaining from the BIG EIGHT, it is relatively easy to calm the mind by going to a quiet place, closing the eyes, and then focusing one object, say the breath.

- Such meditations are *anariya* meditations; they provide only temporary relief. One could also get into *anariya jhanas* this way, with lots of practice, especially if one could live a secluded life. Ancient *yogis* who lived moral lives and stayed away from other humans in forests could attain higher *jhanas*.
- What happens here is that the five hindrances are kept SUPPRESSED. It is like the rotten stuff kept undisturbed at the bottom of the well.
- If one takes a long pole and stir the well, those contaminants start coming up.
- Same way, when someone comes out of the quiet place, one gets “disturbed” with external sense stimuli. For someone with a lot of lust, it could be a picture of a attractive person. If someone has a lot of hate towards another, then hateful thoughts can come to the surface just by someone mentioning that person’s name.
- This is why people who have a very calm and peaceful experience at a meditation resort come back to regular hectic life and see that experience fade away gradually. That is because it WAS a temporary solution. [What we have in mind here is a more permanent solution. But this approach takes a bit more time.](#)

5. So, how do we really clean the well? It is not enough to clean the dirty water; we need to remove

the gunk that has accumulated at the bottom of the well. There could even be toxic things down there. Thus it takes effort to remove all those. Once those are removed, there is nothing down there that can contaminate the fresh water coming out. When the well fills up we only need to make sure that things do not fall back in to contaminate the well.

- Similarly, what we need to do with our minds is to remove the bad habits (*gathi/asavas*) that have been accumulated over countless past lives and reinforced in this life. If we have hate in our minds, that hate can triggered easily. This is why some people are prone to “flare-ups” than others. If we have extreme greed, we can be tempted easily act immorally for sense satisfaction for any of the six senses.
- Even though the main ones are greed and hate, there are uncountable number of combinations (when included with ignorance). That is why we see uncountable number of habits/personalities/tendencies in different people. **No two persons are alike, even identical twins.**

5. Looking at the five hindrances, the main culprits are of course, greed, hate, and *vicikicca* (the particular set of things one has a liking for, which can be things liked or disliked). The other two help bring out these: the “lazy mind” will not take any effort to suppress bad thoughts; the “dispersed mind” is too dispersed to be focused, to think clearly. All these are intimately connected to the habits (*gathi/asavas*).

- By the way, if one can remove all the *gathi/asavas*, that is when one attains *Nibbana*. The Buddha realized the “*asavakkhaya nana*” just before attaining the Buddhahood. *Asavakkhaya* is “*asava*“+”*khaya*” or removing the temptations; “*khaya*” is the getting rid of “*san*”; see, [“What is ‘San’? – Meaning of Sansara \(or Samsara\)”](#).
- Here we are trying to remove some easily removable less potent habits, and at least try to reduce the big ones. The good news is that we can EXPERIENCE the relief or “cooling down” or “*niveema*” each time we either remove a small bad habit or lessen the severity of bigger ones. We don’t have to remove ALL bad habits/cravings in order to experience the “cooling down”.

6. After making a commitment to abstain from the BIG EIGHT as much as possible, we need to sort out our bad habits. Make a list with little things on the top and more serious things towards the bottom. We all have greed and hate; those are the “big ones”; what we need to do here is try to remove easily identifiable smaller bad habits; for example, explosive temper, stinginess, seeking too much sense pleasures (i.e., being addicted to alcohol, drugs, even excess eating). It is important to get rid of the ones at the top (the easy ones), and that will provide incentive to continue. If one tries to tackle the big ones straight away, one might get discouraged and give up the whole effort.

7. Of course, focusing on the BIG EIGHT is very important. If one is engaging in killing animals for pleasure (eg., fishing), then that needs to be stopped if one is serious about meditation. If one is making a living by stealing from others, that needs to be stopped. If one is engaged in sexual activities with other married people, that needs to be stopped, etc. Those are common sense things too. If one looks at one’s actions and see that it can cause harm for oneself AND/OR others, then one needs to seriously start thinking ways to initially reduce and eventually to stop such actions.

8. There are several posts on habits and *gathi/asavas*; you may want to find and read them. And contemplate on those ideas. As I emphasized at the beginning, one has to make an effort; even the Buddha could only show the way. We need to examine what he suggested, think through to make sure they make sense. Then the mind gets on-board, especially when it starts seeing the benefits, even small

benefits. The key is to get started; accomplishing things (no matter how small), and that provides the fuel to go further.

9. One could and should use the “four bases of mental power (*satara iddhipada*)” in accomplishing these goals. Tackle one goal at a time. As you accomplish more and more goals, the *iddhipada* (*chanda*, *citta*, *viriya*, *vimansa*) will grow as well. These are the critical factors that the *yogis* used to cultivate mundane (*anariya*) *jhanas* and gain extraordinary mental powers too.

- *Chanda* is the desire to achieve the goal. *Citta* is the determination one makes and the *viriya* is the effort that one puts in to get it done. *Vimansa* is careful examination of the benefits of breaking the habit and the possible repercussions of keeping the habit. As the four *iddhipada* grow (with accomplishment of more and more goals), the *vimansa* faculty grows in particular; this is a facet of wisdom (*panna*).

10. In trying to remove any bad habit, it is essential to look at the negative repercussions (called *adeenava*) from that activity. Let us take the bad habit of getting into a rage as an example:

- Think about the unpleasant feeling of getting “heated up” in a moment of rage. Of course, at the moment of rage one actually enjoys it: In extreme cases, this is why there are people dead with 30-40 stab wounds, when all it takes to kill a person a couple of stabs; such is the danger of getting into a rage. One feels bad about it only later, and then it is too late.
- Even worse are the *sansaric* consequences: If rage becomes a dominant characteristic of one’s personality, it is possible that this is what will be grasped at the moment of death and a birth of a “similar kind” could result (this is the principle of *paticca samuppada*: “*pati+ichcha*” leading to “*sama+uppada*”).

11. Let us take a few examples to see how some bad habits can be tackled:

- Many people have bad temper which is a result of *vyapada*. Yes. This is a *sansaric* habit, and unlike many other habits, this one is hard to control when triggered. This is one that needs to be dealt with when the anger is absent. The best is do the *metta bhavana*. We will use the *Ariya metta bhavana* later. For now, one could close the eyes at a quiet time, and sincerely say, “May all beings be free of suffering, free of ailments, free of anger, and be happy”. If you have a particular person that you are not in good terms, repeat with his/her name. We cannot remove the anger in the mind of that person. We can only remove the anger within ourselves. Do this a couple of times a day and if you do it sincerely it will give results (for YOU to have a peace of mind).
- If you are a person with cravings for sense pleasures (I do not mean necessities), your mind is likely to be frequently seeking such things. Try to cut down on such activities, and also try to do more giving. Donate to charities, give a few dollars to a homeless person. All these will make you feel better; this is called *piti* (“*preethi*” in Sinhala or joy). Also, when you simplify your life, the burden on your mind will be less, and you will get a different kind of joy than that from sense pleasures; this is “*niveema*” or “cool down”, or [*niramisa sukha*](#).
- Alcohol or cigarette addiction is another example. Instead of trying to stop such a habit “cold turkey”, it is better to cut down gradually. But one MUST have the discipline (the importance of cultivating the *iddhipada* comes here) to stick to the plan, and not go back. It also helps to find a replacement activity at that time (taking a less potent drink or chewing a gum, etc). One of the four *iddhipada* that is essential here is *citta* or determination.

12. Now we are at a point where I can introduce the real *anapanasati bhavana* that was described by the Buddha.

Next, “[4. What do all these Different Meditation Techniques Mean?](#)“,

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1. Buddha Dhamma is focused on purifying the mind of greed, hatred, and ignorance. A pure mind does not attach to even a trace of material form and has attained *Nibbana*. As the mind is purified, it gains [niramisa sukha](#) which can be experienced at various levels from the beginning. If one can “stick to” this program for a couple of months, and then one can look back and see the change in oneself; one should have a more peaceful, quiet mind that has “cooled down”.

- A mind is impure because it attaches to “things in this world” with the misconception that things in this world (31 realms) can be maintained to one’s satisfaction, i.e., with the perception of *nicca*. Thus the prevailing mindset is that happiness (*sukha*) should be attained by employing any means. And once attained it can be maintained and thus one is in total control of one’s affairs (*atta*).
- These three misconceptions of *nicca*, *sukha*, *atta* are the three culprits that keep us bound to “this world” of 31 realms, i.e., bound to the endless rebirth process in *samsara*. What the Buddha showed was that the actual reality of “this world” is described by the three characteristics of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*: No matter how hard we try, we cannot maintain things to our satisfaction in the long term (*anicca*), thus we get distraught (*dukkha*), and thus we are not in control (*anatta*).
- I am NOT saying that one should not work hard to get educated and get a good job. That MUST be done; one cannot have a peace of mind if one is hungry and homeless. But we also need to be aware of the FACT that all mundane achievements are temporary; even if we get a live this life without a major catastrophe, we have to leave all behind when we die.
- One acts with greed, hate, and ignorance and makes the mind impure because of the wrong perceptions of *nicca*, *sukha*, *atta*. One is willing to do immoral acts to get some temporary satisfaction, because one does not see the bad consequences of such actions. However, when one truly understands the reality, i.e., *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, one is automatically prevented from doing such immoral acts even compulsively.
- For that stage to be reached, one has to train one’s mind to “take in the good” and “reject the bad”; one needs to change one’s habits and this is done basically with the *anapanasati* meditation.

The following is a logical sequence for meditation:

2. First one needs to sort out what is good and what is bad, and the consequences of good and bad actions. This is why the vision, *samma ditthi*, comes first in the Noble Eightfold Path, and this is done by “sorting out the good from the bad”.

- *Vipassana* (*vi+passa* means sort and discard, where “*vi*” is to sort out and “*passa*” is to discard) and *vidassana* (*vi+dassana* means sort out by clear vision, where “*dassana*” means the vision) mean the same thing: understand Buddha Dhamma and acquire the vision needed to be able to

sort out the “good” from the “bad”.

- I cannot emphasize enough the importance of *vipassana* (*vidassana*) or insight meditation. [Without the “correct” vision, one could strive for the whole lifetime and not get anywhere](#): one has to understand the true nature of this world (*anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*), the Four Noble Truths, and the Noble Eightfold Path. It is not memorization, but understanding that counts.
- **A huge amount of defilements are removed from one’s mind with this insight meditation. It is the first type of meditation that is needed.** One can attain [the Sotapanna stage](#) without doing any other types of meditation discussed below. The Buddha once took a bit of soil to a fingertip and told the *bhikkhus* that, “if the amount of defilements a *Sotapanna* needs to get rid of is comparable to this amount of soil, then a normal human being has to get rid of an equivalent to the soil in the whole Earth”.
- That is not a misprint or an exaggeration. A *Sotapanna* is bound to attain *Nibbana* within a maximum of seven “*bhava*”, whereas a normal human being could be trapped in the rebirth process for trillions of years to come. We all have been through the rebirth process for uncountable trillions of years; see, “[Infinity -How Big is It?](#)”.
- Many people say, “I do like my life. Why would I not want to be reborn?”. **The problem is that future rebirths may not be in the human realm.** We have no idea what we have done in past lives. Thus even if we live a perfectly moral life, there are no guarantees that we will get a good rebirth. This is why understanding *kamma*, rebirth, etc via insight meditation is important.
- **How does one do the insight meditation?** Listening to discourses and reading Dhamma concepts are the two main forms of getting the correct information. Then one could contemplate on those concepts in a sitting meditation. [But reading up on Dhamma concepts during a quiet time itself is meditation.](#)
- Once some understanding is reached via *vipassana* (*vidassana*) *bhavana* or insight meditation, one can start the next two key steps: *metta bhavana* and various forms of *anupassana bhavana*, which we will discuss in the next two items.

But I hope I have been able to convey the idea that the bulk of work can be done with just insight meditation. However, doing the other two types of *bhavana*, i.e., *metta bhavana* and *anapanasati*, can be helpful for the insight meditation too.

3. This world is much more complex than even after much progress in science over the past few hundred years. Scientists can account for only 4%-5% of our universe; see, “The 4 Percent Universe; Dark Matter, Dark Energy, and the Race to Discover the Rest of Reality” by Richard Panek (2011), or Google the words, “dark matter and dark energy” to peruse a lot of information.

- Yet, “everything in this world’ was discovered by the Buddha 2500 years ago. The 31 realms of existence, analysis of the mind with 89 types of *cittas* and 52 types of *cetasika*, unfathomable suffering in the lowest four realms, how beings wander aimlessly in a rebirth process, and much more, that provide a consistent and complete world view. [My goal with this website is to show that we already know about this wider world that the scientists are trying to figure out.](#)
- The key idea the Buddha tried to convey is that it is useless to look for ‘better material things’ either in this life or any future life. That process ends up with only sorrow. The only real happiness is to get the mind released from “this world”, i.e, to seek *Nibbana*.
- Once one understands the true status of affairs in the wider world of 31 realms, one can really comprehend the amount of suffering that has been hidden from us. With that understanding

one can engage in the *Ariya metta bhavana*, which is an excellent way to pay back our old debts to other beings. **This is the second way to purify our minds too.**

4. The last and third way to purify the mind is via *anupassana*. *Anupassana* means “discard according to the principles learned” (“*anu*” means according to and “*passana*” means to get rid of). *Anupassana* can take various forms: *Anapanasati bhavana* is the foundation. Once “*ana*” and “*pana*” are sorted out by *vipassana* (*vidassana*), one needs to engage in *anapanasati* all the time. This means one needs to be mindful of what one is about to do, and make sure it is a “right thing to do”.

- When one starts understanding *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, one can start doing the *aniccanupassana*, *dukkhanupassana*, and *anattanupassana*, and four more related “*anupassana*”. I will elaborate on this later.
- *Satipattana bhavana* (with *kayanupassana*, *vedananupassana*, *cittanupassana*, and *dhammanupassana*) includes all the *bhavana* techniques that we have discussed so far. It is THE ultimate which encompasses everything that is needed to attain some stress relief all the way to attain the *Arahanthood*. *Anapanasati* is a big part of the *satipattana*, and that is all we need to attain [the Sotapanna stage](#).

5. Thus one could make things simpler by just doing insight meditation, *anapanasati*, and the *metta bhavana*. That is all one needs to do to have a “better state of mind” or even to become a *Sotapanna*.

Next, “[5. Ariya Metta Bhavana \(Loving Kindness Meditation\)](#)“,

5. Ariya Metta Bhavana (Loving Kindness Meditation)

The top 11 posts in this section describe a way of using meditation in following the Noble Path and to attain *Ariya jhanas* and at least [the Sotapanna stage](#) of *Nibbana*. This series was put together using my own experience, and in the 10th and 11th posts I describe how the process can culminate in attaining *Ariya jhanas* (and possibly *magga phala*). The rest of the posts in this section are on possible meditation subjects and together with other posts at the site can be used to clarify unresolved questions, and to gain *samadhi*. It is recommended that the first 11 posts be followed in that order, at least initially.

1. The standard *metta bhavana* (loving kindness meditation) goes something like, “May myself and all beings be free of suffering, healthy, happy, and be free of all suffering”, or some similar (longer) passages.

- Any type of such meditation is of course good. It makes your own mind calm down, and makes you think about the (mundane) welfare of the other beings.

2. However, the *Ariya metta bhavana* has a much more deeper meaning. It is done with at least some idea of the complexity of “this world” with 31 realms and the status of the beings in those realms. In order to cultivate true compassion and loving kindness one NEEDS TO FEEL the possible suffering in all those realms; see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”:

- The beings in the lowest four realms (*apayas*) undergo unimaginable suffering, both physical and mental.
- In the lowest five realms (the *apayas* and the human realm), beings have physical bodies that are subject to sicknesses, body aches, and getting old before dying.
- The sixth through eleventh realms are that of the *devas*. They have spontaneous births with fully formed (but less dense) bodies that are not subjected to sickness, aches and pains, and visible signs of old age until close to death. But they also have all five physical senses just like the lower five realms, and could be subjected to repulsive touch, distasteful/unpleasant tastes, smells, and sounds, and visuals.
- The higher 20 realms that include *rupa loka* and *arupa loka* have even less dense bodies than the *devas*, and do not have the physical sense faculties for taste, smell, and body touch. Thus any suffering they have is all mental, and not as intense as in the lower realms.

3. However, no living being is free of FUTURE suffering in any of the 31 realms, because unless [the Sotapanna stage](#) of *Nibbana* has been attained, even the beings in the highest realm can end up even in the *apayas* (lowest four realms) in future rebirths.

- And the only way to attain [the Sotapanna stage](#) of *Nibbana* is by comprehending the Three Characteristics of this world of 31 realms: *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.
- The first level of understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* leads to [the Sotapanna stage](#); when one attains [the Sotapanna stage](#), one becomes free from the *apayas* FOREVER. This happens via the inability of the mind of a *Sotapanna* to generate certain *cittas* with “*apayagami*” *kammic* power; see, “[Akusala Citta – How a Sotapanna avoids Apayagami Citta](#)” and “[Conditions for the Four Stages of Nibbana](#)”.
- When the next stage of *Nibbana* (*Sakadagami* stage) is attained, one becomes free of births in the lower five realms where suffering due to physical ailments and diseases are possible. Thus one PERMANENTLY becomes “healthy” by attaining the *Sakadagami* stage.

- At the *Anagami* stage, one removes more *akusala citta* (and other fulfil other conditions; see, “[Conditions for the Four Stages of Nibbana](#)”), and will never be born again in *kama loka* including the *deva* realm. Thus one becomes PERMANENTLY free of any physical suffering.
- Then at the *Arahant* stage, all defilements are removed from the mind and one will never be reborn in any of the 31 realms. The mind truly becomes free and one attains permanent *niramisa sukha*; see, “[The Three Kinds of Happiness – What is niramisa sukha?](#)” and other posts on *niramisa sukha*.
- As you can see, the *Ariya metta bhavana* is similar in structure to the conventional one, but the words have deeper meanings. For example, by saying “be healthy” now it is meant to be healthy forever, i.e., not to be born ever with a body that is subject to diseases and old age.

4. Now we can see how the *Ariya metta bhavana* is formulated:

- “May myself and all living beings attain the *Sotapanna* stage and be free from suffering in the *apayas*”
 “May myself and all living beings attain the *Sakadagami* stage and be healthy”.
 “May myself and all living beings attain the *Anagami* stage and be content (attain peaceful happiness)”.
 “May myself and all living beings attain the *Arahant* stage and be free from all suffering and attain the full *Nibbanic* bliss”.
- All four *Brahma vihara* (*metta*, *karuna*, *mudita*, *upekkha*) are cultivated with this *bhavana*.

5. What matters is not the particular set of word used, but what is felt in one’s heart. In order to do that one needs to truly comprehend that there is REAL SUFFERING in this world, not only at the human or animal realms, but in many other realms.

- The impact of the *metta bhavana* increases gradually with increased understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.
- The potential of the *metta bhavana* is enormous. The Buddha said one could attain the *Anagami* stage by correctly doing the *metta bhavana*. But that entails understanding *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, i.e., attaining [the Sotapanna stage](#).
- However, even before attaining [the Sotapanna stage](#), one could reap many benefits by doing this correct *Ariya metta bhavana*; see, “[Kamma, Debt, and Meditation](#)”.
- It is best to do *Ariya metta bhavana* and *vipassana bhavana* (meditation on *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* and other dhamma concepts) in a sitting meditation session every day; see, “[What do all these Different Meditation Techniques Mean?](#)”.
- Initially 10-15 minutes would be good for formal meditation, and can be increased as the *niramisa sukha* sets in one starts seeing the benefits; one could stay in mediation for hours. Of course *anapanasati* needs to be practiced the whole day, which means being aware of what is “taken in” (*ana*) and what is “discarded” (*pana*); see, “[What is Anapana?](#)” and other related posts in the meditation section.
- Listening to discourses and reading about Dhamma are also forms of meditation, and should be done during quite times so the key concepts can be absorbed.

Next, “[6. Anapanasati Bhavana \(Introduction\)](#)“,

6. Anāpānasati Bhāvanā (Introduction)

The top 11 posts in this section describe a way of using meditation in following the Noble Path and to attain *Ariya jhanas* and at least [the Sotapanna stage of Nibbana](#). This series was put together using my own experience, and in the 10th and 11th posts I describe how the process can culminate in attaining *Ariya jhanas* (and possibly *magga phala*). The rest of the posts in this section are on possible meditation subjects and together with other posts at the site can be used to clarify unresolved questions, and to gain *samadhi*. It is recommended that the first 11 posts be followed in that order, at least initially.

1. I hope that several key points are clear from the discussion in the post, [“The Second Level – Key to Purify the Mind”](#):

- Bad habits (*gathi/asava*) are associated with one more of immoral or unworthy acts, speech, or thoughts. We need to discard those.
- To counter the bad habits one needs to cultivate good habits. For this we need to cultivate moral behavior by engaging in moral activities that bring joy to the heart.
- AND we need to do this all the time; we cannot let bad habits come back, which means we need to be on the lookout for any lapses in our practice. And we need to be on the lookout for opportunities to do moral acts that are beneficial for oneself and others.

2. The Buddha described *bhāvana* as follows: “*āsevitāya, bhāvitāya, bahuleekathāya,...*” or “keep close association, use often, and use all the time (what is good).....”. [When one is making effort to form a new habit, one should be thinking about it and doing things to support that whenever possible. Trying to do it in a formal meditation session will not be enough.](#)

- We discussed the current scientific explanation of how repeated acts help form habits by strengthening a set of neural connections in the brain in an earlier post in this series. Same thing works to break bad habits by NOT doing it whenever that comes to the mind; existing neural connections will get weaker.
- What is to contemplate: To be mindful to “take in good things (*kusala* or moral things), and to “discard bad things (*akusala* or immoral things)”. This is the real meaning of *ānāpānasati bhavana*.
- In the wider sense, “*āna*” includes anything that needs to “taken in” for the betterment of life, and “*pāna*” the opposite. For example, we should eat only foods that are good for the body, and stay away from or discard foods are bad.
- Nowadays, “*āna*” is taken to be “breath in” and “*āpāna*” is taken to be “breath out”; “*sati*” means mindfulness so, the word “*anapanasati*” is interpreted as “mindfully breathing in and mindfully breathing out”. This is the conventional (or “*padaparama*”) interpretation of “*anapana*”, and that is only a very narrow use; see the post below that explains these terms.

3. These aspects are discussed in many suttas. I have a couple of posts that discuss the *Sabbasava sutta* (*sabba+asava* is all *asavas*), which point out seven specific steps that will help remove bad habits and develop good habits (*gathi/asavas*). Looking at the same goal from a slightly different viewpoint, five such steps are given in the *Vitakkasanthana* (*vitakka+san+thana* = removing defiled thoughts) *sutta*; I hope to write a post on this later.

4. Now, with all the discussion we have had up to this point, how can just a process of “breathing in” and “breathing out” mindfully GET RID OF either the bad habits (*gathi/āsāvas*) or the five

hindrances?

- Of course that is not possible.
- But it CAN do one thing, as we mentioned before. If we sit in a quiet place with the eyes closed (i.e., turn off the five physical senses in effect), AND fix the mind on the breath, we can get the five hindrances to settle down and not come up (assuming that we are staying away from committing the BIG EIGHT immoral acts).
- However, this calming down or getting to samatha is a TEMPORARY solution. The moment we come back to the real world with all its distractions and temptations, those habits take over.

5. The breath meditation needs to be used appropriately, with the understanding that it can provide only temporary relief. This breath meditation is the same meditation that was used by the Hindu yogis to attain mindane (Anariya) jhanas even before the Buddha.

- Since the time Buddhaghosa's Visuddhimagga was accepted as the basis of Theravada Dhamma (in the fifth century CE), this "literal interpretation" of the anapanasati has been used.
- The real anapanasati bhavana is not described in the visuddhimagga, and is not described in any Mahayana or even Theravada texts today. One needs to go directly to the Tipitaka to find it; it is described in many suttas, for example the Assasa sutta. I could not find an English translation of this sutta. Another one Ariththa Sutta, and the translation published at the Accesstoinsight site is not complete, even though it does contain Buddha's admonition to Ven. Ariththa that in and out breathing is only one version of anapanasati (in the sutta it says it is NOT the Ariya or Noble version) : <http://www.accesstoinsight.org/tipitaka/sn/sn54/sn54.006.than.html>
- Thus there are two interpretations of the anapanasati bhavana: one is the conventional "breathing" version and the other is the real version recommended by the Buddha, which has a wider interpretation, including breathing to a minor extent.
- The Anapanasati sutta is the condensed version of the Buddha's desana on anapanasati bhavana. As with most main suttas, the discourse was condensed in to the form for easy transmission. Other suttas, mostly by Ven. Sariputta, have explained the terms like "ana" and "apana" in detail (like the Assasa Sutta). Furthermore, Sinhala commentaries (atthakatha) were also written to explain the main suttas. Unfortunately, these atthakathas were burned down shortly after Buddhaghosa wrote his Visuddhimagga and other books. However, three important ones (Patisambhida Magga Pakarana, Pitakopadesa, and Netthipakarana) have survived because they had been included in the Tipitaka. What I describe here is from those books in the Tipitaka.
- Buddhaghosa was a Hindu before converting to be a Buddhist later on; see, "The Life and Work of Buddhaghosa" by B. C. Law (1927). Some say he became a Buddhist in order to introduce Hindu concepts to Buddha Dhamma. Either that or he just used whatever he understood to be the anapanasati without any malicious intentions. Either way, the correct interpretation had been hidden for all these years.

6. The key message of the Buddha was that we need to remove the greed, hate, and ignorance that we all have in our minds, and by doing that we can experience the [niramisa sukha](#) that is of better quality and of permanent nature. Let us now discuss the basic meditation technique that will start us on the correct path to achieve lasting happiness.

Next, "[7. What is Anapana?](#)",

7. What is Ānāpāna?

The top 11 posts in this section describe a way of using meditation in following the Noble Path and to attain *Ariya jhanas* and at least [the Sotapanna stage of Nibbana](#). This series was put together using my own experience, and in the 10th and 11th posts I describe how the process can culminate in attaining *Ariya jhanas* (and possibly *magga phala*). The rest of the posts in this section are on possible meditation subjects and together with other posts at the site can be used to clarify unresolved questions, and to gain *samadhi*. It is recommended that the first 11 posts be followed in that order, at least initially.

1. Satipattana bhavana is a more detailed version of the Anapanasati bhavana. Thus it is important to learn the correct version of the Anapanasati. If one does Anapanasati correctly, it can be easily turned to Satipattana bhavana.

2. First let us figure out exactly what the Buddha meant by “āna” and “pāna” in “āna+pāna+sati”; of course “sati” is mindfulness.

- “Āna” is taking in; In Sinhala, “ānayanaya” is “import”. “Āpāna” is discarding; In Sinhala, “apanayanaya” is “export”. Thus “āna”+“āpāna” or anapana is “taking in/discarding” or import/export.
- “Assa” is same as “āna”, and “passa” is the same as “āpāna”. In Sri Lanka, parents tell their child to clean his/her room by saying, “kāmaraya (room) assa passa (or aspas) karaganna”.
- When cleaning the room, the child needs to get rid of the clutter (passa), but also can take in (assa) something like a flower vase to make the room look more pleasant, or to take in a chair that can be useful.

3. During the time of the Buddha itself, auxiliary suttas as well as commentaries (“Atthakatha”) were written to explain the key words/phrases in the main suttas that were abbreviated for easy transmission; see, [“Preservation of Dhamma”](#). There are two important suttas, Assasa sutta and the Parama Assasa sutta that describe how one should “take in” kusala thoughts and “discard” akusala thoughts; that is “ana”+“apana” (anapana) or “assa/passa”, for cleaning up (the mind).

4. When one knows what kusala/akusala kamma are, the first thing to do is to prevent from doing akusala kamma and to make an effort to do kusala kamma by engaging in meritorious actions (punna kriya); see, [“Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)”](#), and [“Ten Moral Actions \(Dasa Kusala\) and Ten Meritorious Actions \(Punna Kriya\)”](#).

- Thus when one leads a moral life, one is automatically engaging in the basic form of Anapanasati.
- AND one cannot do a proper formal Anapanasati meditation and get to even samadhi, let alone a jhana, unless one leads a moral life. The five hindrances are too strong to be suppressed; see, [“Key to Calming the Mind – Five Hindrances”](#).

5. **Formal Anapanasati bhavana** can be done in a formal sitting or walking meditation session, while engaging in the basic version (taking in what is good/discarding what is bad) all the time.

- There is no need to do samatha bhavana separately. If one does a formal Anapanasati session with the eyes closed in a quiet place, one will automatically get into samadhi. **Let good thoughts grow, and discard bad thoughts. Very simple.**
- Another thing to do in a formal meditation session is to **contemplate on a particular dhamma concept like anicca, dukkha, anatta. This is really focusing on “ana”**.

- When one gets to samadhi, the mind goes on “auto pilot”; you will feel that your mind is taking charge and you need to exert less effort to keep the focus.

6. When one does the basic version while engaged in other activities, one is only being mindful of what one is engaged in, i.e., the task at hand. That task presumably does not involve any of the BIG EIGHT we discussed previously; see, “[The Basics in Meditation](#)”. It could be a technical task or a daily chore like washing dishes or driving. **Be mindful of just the task (washing, driving, etc).** Here one will NOT get into samadhi, so there is no danger in injuring oneself; Many people get into accidents while driving, because they are not being mindful of driving.

- However, if one does not have a specific task (say, when riding a bus or waiting at the doctor’s office), one could be engaged in anapanasati bhavana. When our minds are not focused on something (like in the above mentioned cases), all sorts of ideas bubble up. As we discussed in “[The Basics in Meditation](#)”. These are due to deeply-ingrained habits or asavas that we have acquired not only in this life but also from previous lives.

7. The more we keep reviving or re-living this habit (i.e., doing ana/apana or assa/passa), we strengthen that good habit (gathi).

- We have come all this way in the cycle of rebirths that are mostly filled with suffering because of our bad habits (gathi) that have been percolated to very dense state of deep-seated cravings (asavas). It may take some time to develop this “ana/pana”, but you will definitely see results in a few weeks to few months.

8. In the Anapanapabba of the Satipattana sutta, it says, “..so sato va assa sati, sato va passa sati. Digham va assasanto digham assasami ti pajanati, digham va passasanto digham passasami ti pajanati,” Here it DOES NOT mean “take long breaths in, expel long breaths out”; rather it means, “get rid of old bad habits, and cultivate the old good habits”.

- Similarly, the very next sentence (“..rassam va assasanto...”) is not about short breaths, but on those good habits that you started to work on recently, and those bad habits that started to creep in to the mind recently (if there is any).
- There is no way that one can purify one’s mind by breathing in/out, even though it can get one’s mind to calm down (samatha). The correct way of doing it does both samatha and vipassana together.

9. When we think a bit more about this, we realize that what needs to be discarded are micca ditthi (wrong views), micca sankappa (wrong thoughts or ideas), micca vaca (incorrect, harmful speech), micca kammanata (incorrect/harmful actions), micca ajiva (incorrect/harmful way of living), micca vayama (tendency to strive on immoral activities), micca sati (tendency to focus on immoral activities); when one does all that micca samadhi (tendency to get absorbed in immoral ideas/actions) is the result.

- In the same way, what we need to “take in” are samma ditthi, samma sankappa, samma vaca, samma kammanata, samma ajiva, samma vayama, samma sati, and when one keeps doing that one automatically gets to samma samadhi.
- Put it in another way, anapanasati is nothing but “taking in” the Noble Eightfold Path and “discarding” the opposite.

10. The longer one “takes in” or “lives” the Noble Eightfold Path and “rejects” the opposite, easier it becomes to get to samadhi in a formal meditation session. When samadhi grows little by little, one day one will automatically get into the first Ariya jhana. However, there is one more thing that is

needed before getting to the Ariya jhanas: an understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. We will discuss why in a future post.

- Keep practicing “anapana” as much as possible throughout the day. With time, you will feel the “cooling down” or ‘nivana” or “a taste of Nibbana”.
- Buddha Dhamma is NOT about following rituals. It is all about cleansing one’s mind and that takes an effort and concentration. Initially it could be hard, but as one gains samadhi bit by bit, one gets motivated. In few months one can look back at one’s life and see that it has changed for the better.

Next, “[8. The Basic Formal Anapanasati Meditation](#)“,

8. The Basic Formal Anapanasati Meditation

The top 11 posts in this section describe a way of using meditation in following the Noble Path and to attain *Ariya jhanas* and at least [the Sotapanna stage of Nibbana](#). This series was put together using my own experience, and in the 10th and 11th posts I describe how the process can culminate in attaining *Ariya jhanas* (and possibly *magga phala*). The rest of the posts in this section are on possible meditation subjects and together with other posts at the site can be used to clarify unresolved questions, and to gain *samadhi*. It is recommended that the first 11 posts be followed in that order, at least initially.

1. As we discussed in the previous posts of this series, it is important to live a moral life without engaging in the BIG EIGHT in order to achieve the full benefits of meditation. One could start even while making progress on the BIG EIGHT, and these formal sessions will help with those as well.
2. Now let us talk about how to do the correct anapanasati meditation as taught by the Buddha. First pick out a quiet time slot that you can allocate without having to worry about other tasks. Initially, 10-15 minutes a day would be fine and you can extend the time to several hours when the benefits of proper meditation becomes clear and you start feeling the [niramisa sukha](#).
3. Pick out a room away from external disturbances as much as possible. A room that can be darkened and the door can be closed would be ideal. Sit in a comfortable chair with arm rest, and this becomes important when one start getting into *samadhi*, because the body could become less rigid and tends to slide off (however, some people including myself tend to “freeze” just like in *samadhi* statues). Anyway, do not make the chair too comfortable because you may fall asleep. With practice this sleepiness will automatically go away, when the mind starts liking the meditation sessions, i.e., when one of the *pancanivarana*, *thina middha*, is automatically removed. One comes out of *samadhi* energized.
4. Sit in the chair with the hands on the lap and eyes closed. What we will be trying to do is to ward off any thoughts of lust, cravings, etc. (*kamachanda*), any thoughts of hate (*vyapada*) in particular, and also any stray thoughts such as on kids or other pending tasks. We want to experience the “cooling down” due to the absence of *kamachanda* and *vyapada*, and also to focus the mind on a Dhamma concept. For those who are starting out, it may be good to do the following first:
 - In order to keep the mind from running away, keep saying in your mind, “May all beings be happy and healthy”. Or, you could think about some act of generosity that you did recently. But all of a sudden you may drift to a thought of some type of a sensual pleasure (involving any of the senses). Deliberately get rid of that thought and focus the mind back on the original task.
 - If a hateful thought (towards someone or something) comes to mind, forcefully stop that thought as well. Here you should deliberately think about good thoughts about that person. It is important to remember that even the most vile person has friends/family that love that person. Sincerely say, “May X be happy and healthy”. Even if you have good reasons to despise that person, it is important to realize that our task is to remove the hateful feelings that WE have. When we do that, in the future we will not generate strong hateful feelings even if someone does something that may appear to be against us.
 - Thinking about the serenity of a Buddha statue helps in the case of both *kamachanda* and *vyapada* (and any stray thought).
5. Once one gets some practice to sit at one place with a focused mind for a little while, one should start meditating or contemplating on Dhamma concepts. [It may be a good idea to start with the](#)

introductory posts (posts above this post).

- After that, one could read one of the posts from the “Key Dhamma Concepts” on the top menu just before the meditation session and then contemplate on those concepts; for example, one could think about examples on “*anicca*”: We cannot maintain anything to our satisfaction over long term. If you are old enough you have many examples on your own. If you are young, you can still maintain your body, hair, teeth, etc to your liking but when you get to middle age, you will see that it is an impossible task. The easiest is to think about your parents/grand parents and see how their bodies have changed, how they are unable to keep their bodies the way they would like.
- For this purpose, I have also added new posts on how one can look at the world through Buddha Dhamma in this section. The posts that I have added after the “Myths about Meditation” are good ones read before the session and then to meditate on those ideas; for example, “[A Simple Way to Enhance Merits \(Kusala\) and Avoid Demerits \(Akusala\)](#)“. The other three posts below that one may be a bit advanced for some; if so, browse around and find ones that are suitable. Eventually, the key concepts in the “Key Dhamma Concepts” section need to be grasped. I encourage everyone to read the posts in the “Moral Living” section first.
- You could actually read any post from any area of the site and use that as a “focal point” on the meditation session later on. Not all sections are relevant to everyone. [Different people can get to samadhi focusing on different topics.](#) **The only posts that are absolutely necessary are the ones on *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. But if they are hard to grasp, one should probably start at the “Moral Living” section. It is a matter of getting used to new concepts. In meditation, one will automatically “drift to samadhi” when the concepts become clear; the mind becomes awake and clear.**

6. Inevitably, your mind will try to wander off during the session. Stopping lustful and hateful thoughts is the main task of this formal meditation session. **If any distracting thought comes to the mind, DO NOT let it “run wild”; this is what is called “being mindful”. Keep a sharp eye on such stray thoughts and put a stop soon as they surface.**

- The other three hindrances (*thina* *midha*, *uddhacca* *kukkucca*, and *vicikicca*) will automatically come down. You will be surprised how refreshed you feel after a “good meditation session”.
- Initially it may be hard, but if you are persistent you should be able to see the results within a week to a month depending on the situation with the BIG EIGHT. Those will also gradually diminish too.
- Once one gets the mind to calm down some, one could start focusing on the good/bad habits that one has, in addition to “taking in” Dhamma concepts.

7. In the *Anapanapabba* of the *Satipattana sutta*, it says, “..so *sato va assa sati*, *sato va passa sati*. *Digham va assasanto digham assasami ti pajanati*, *digham va passasanto digham passasami ti pajanati*,” Here it DOES NOT mean “take long breaths in, expel long breaths out”; rather it means, “get rid of old bad habits, and cultivate the old good habits”.

- Similarly, the very next sentence (“..*rassam va assasanto*...”) is not about short breaths, but on those good habits that you started to work on recently, and those bad habits that started to creep in to your mind recently (if there is any).
- This is why understanding how habits are formed and how they become *asavas* is important; there are several posts on this subject.

- There is no way that one can purify one's mind by breathing in/out, even though it can get one's mind to calm down (samatha). The correct way of doing it does both samatha and vipassana together.
- In the above verse, sati is a very important term; it is not mere concentration, but contemplation with an understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* (actually any form of meditation cannot be done effectively without at least some understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*).

8. The key to success is to do this as often as possible. You do not need to be in a quiet place either, even though it helps especially initially. As you make progress, try to do it while riding the subway or a bus (but not while driving!), while waiting at the doctor's office, during a lunch break, etc.

9. When one starts on Ariya Bhavana, sometimes things may look worse before getting better. It is like trying to cool a hot iron by sprinkling water on it, when all that smoke comes out and may appear to be getting worse. But one needs to be persistent. One needs to keep in mind that uncountable beings have attained "cooling down" by having faith in the Buddha.

- Understanding key Dhamma concepts is key to any type of meditation. Whenever you have time, try to read on different topics. Things will start "falling into place" at some point, if it hasn't yet. From that point on, one will start feeling the joy of Dhamma, and will be seeking to clarify things with enthusiasm. It is a good addiction to have!

Next, "[9. Key to Anapanasati – How to Change Habits and Character \(Gathi\)](#)",

9. Key to Anapanasati – How to Change Habits and Character (Gathi)

The top 11 posts in this section describe a way of using meditation in following the Noble Path and to attain *Ariya jhanas* and at least [the Sotapanna stage](#) of *Nibbana*. This series was put together using my own experience, and in the 10th and 11th posts I describe how the process can culminate in attaining *Ariya jhanas* (and possibly *magga phala*). The rest of the posts in this section are on possible meditation subjects and together with other posts at the site can be used to clarify unresolved questions, and to gain *samadhi*. It is recommended that the first 11 posts be followed in that order, at least initially.

Meditation is all about purifying one's mind. We all have individualized cravings and habits that we have acquired in our past lives that continue during this life unless we act to change or stop them. We need to build up on good habits and stop bad ones. The only way to do this is to be mindful of our actions and stop bad actions as they start as thoughts in our minds. Most bad thoughts arise due to bad habits; they just “pop up”.

[Introduction to Character or Personality \(Gathi\)](#)

[A Broad View of the “Person” Trying to be a “Better Person”](#)

[How Character \(Gathi\) Leads to Bhava and Jathi](#)

[How Habits are Formed and Broken – A Scientific View](#)

Next, “[10. Ariya Jhanas via Cultivation of Saptha Bojjanga](#)”

Introduction to Character or Personality (Gathi)

1. Here is a good place to see why the Buddha rejected both the concept of a “self” AND a “no-self” (or “soul” AND “no-soul”). We first need to realize that the task of purifying the mind is very personal; only you know about your mind and only you can purify it. The perception of a “no-self” is a bad starting point to do this cleansing.

- We can easily see that “a person” changes over time, both physically and mentally (see the next post). Thus it is easy to see that a concept of a “soul” or “self” does not hold water.
- However, each of us is DIFFERENT, and UNIQUE; no two are the same even at a fixed time. Even though each person changes, the change itself is unique to “that person” and CAN BE initiated by that person. What makes one person different from another is his/her character (gathi).
- For those people who say, “there is no-self” or “there is no real me”, I ask: “Then is it OK if someone hits you with a stick or hurt you badly in some way?”. Obviously, that is not fine. Just by denying something that is as real as suffering itself, will not make the problem go away. Just being philosophical is not going to make the problem disappear.
- This is why the Buddha said rejected both extremes of “self” and “no-self”.

2. Actually as one increasingly realizes the fruitlessness of struggling to seek sense pleasures, the feeling of “self” starts to decrease. An Arahant is the closest to a “self-less person”; but even an Arahant has some unique character qualities: nothing to do with greed, hate, and delusion, but more like kammically neutral habits.

- For example, there is this story about a very young Arahant. One day a man came to take this bhikkhu to his house for a “dāna”, which consists of a lunch followed by a gift (usually things that are needed for a bhikkhu like a robe, a towel, etc). On the way, they ran into some puddles on the ground and the young bhikkhu jumped over one. The man thought, “Oh, this bhikkhu is not even disciplined let alone having any magga phala; maybe I should not give him the gift”. They came across a few more puddles and the bhikkhu went around them. So, the man asked, “Why did you jump over only that one?”. The bhikkhu told him, “If I jumped over anymore puddles, I would probably lose my lunch too”. It turned out that the bhikkhu was an Arahant with abhinna powers and read the man’s mind! Also it is said that the bhikkhu was born a monkey for many lives in the recent past, and he still had that sansaric “monkey habit” of jumping over things.

3. Habits are formed via repeated use. The Buddha said, “*yā yan tanha pōno bhavitha....*” or “bhava or habits are formed by tanha for various things, activities. Remember that Tanha means “getting attached to something via greed, hate, of ignorance”; see, [“Tanha – How we Attach via Greed, Hate, and Ignorance”](#)“.

4. What we are concerned about is only getting rid of immoral habits and cultivating moral habits. This will make oneself a “better person” long before one even thinks about attaining Nibbana. This can be done with simple process called “āna-pāna” or “taking in good habits” and “discarding bad habits”.

- The Buddha said, “*bhāvē thabbancha bhavithan, pahee thabbancha paheenan*” or “keep doing what is good, get rid of those that are not good”. The meaning is a bit deeper than that because

“bhāvé” there refers to making “bhava”. The more one does something, it becomes one’s “bhava”. And the less one willfully stops doing, that “bhava” tends to go away. This is what the neurologists are re-discovering today; see, “[How Habits are Formed and Broken – A Scientific View](#)”.

5. The bad habits need to be stopped each time it surfaces, right there. The Buddha said, “*etté san uppajjamana uppajati, paheeyamana paheeyathi*” or “each time a “san” (a bad habit) resurfaces, it needs to be recognized and stopped right then”.

- Therefore, one must do this not only in sitting meditation sessions, but as much as possible, whenever possible.
- This is what the Buddha also meant by “*asevitaya, bhavithaya, bahuleekathaya*”, or “associate, use, and do as much as possible whenever possible” everything that helps with anapanasati. These are described in the post, “[Habits, Goals, and Character \(Gathi\)](#)”.

6. I cannot emphasize enough the importance of understanding what is truly involved in ānāpānasati. The recent findings on the workings of the brain really helps clarify and highlight some key points that the Buddha emphasized. I think it will help anyone understand the process much better. But first we will take a brief look at how these character qualities are inherited.

Next, “[A Broad View of the “Person” Trying to be a “Better Person”](#)”,

A Broad View of the “Person” Trying to be a “Better Person”

1. Let us see how and why we act with greed, hate, and ignorance. Stated simply, all we do during a day does not happen by chance. We act based on our “character” AND “our way of thinking about this world”.

- For example, if one does not believe in a rebirth process, or the law of kamma (that each action has consequences), then it may be easier to seek enjoyment at the expense of other beings.

2. What our character or world view today is due to a complex combination of many things, but the main factors are: (i) sansaric habits (also called gathi and asavas), (ii) biological parents who provide parts of the physical body (this is also related to kamma vipaka), (iii) the environment that one grew up AND the current environment (i.e., physical environment and people one associates with).

- Even though the complexity of a “person” cannot be reduced to simple things, these are major ones. As the Buddha pointed out in the Sabbasava sutta (see, “[Habits, Goals, and Character \(Gathi\)](#)”), the main things that CAN BE changed NOW are “physical environment and people one associates with” which is a part of (iii) above. If we are talking about a child, then (iii) applies in its entirety.
- Once these “external influences” are taken care of, next is to purify the mind by “taking in” good things and “discarding” bad things or “*anapana*”; see, “[What is Anapana?](#)”.

3. When we are conceived in the mother’s womb, a “blueprint” of the new life is in the form of a manomaya kaya (which is made of undetectably fine matter) descends to the womb and combines with the zygote formed by the combination of an egg from the mother and the sperm from the father. The manomaya kaya comes with three rupa kalapas called the kaya dasaka (blueprint for the physical body), bhava dasaka (the type of existence), and vatthu dasaka (mind element, which has the “gathi” in it) that were determined by the kamma vipaka that led to the birth; we will discuss these later in the Abhidhamma section.

- Thus the physical body of the new life is now going to be affected by not only the kaya dasaka, but also the genetic material in the egg and the sperm (DNA of the parents). As the fetus grows, it will also be affected by the food intake by the mother as well as her mental state, home environment, etc. After the birth until death, the physical body (as well as the mind) will be affected by many other factors including the diet and the environment.

4. Thus there is no “unchanging self” either mentally or physically; everything is in constant flux. But one cannot say “there is no-self” either because the character qualities (gathi and asava) that comes in with the manomaya kaya will keep “evolving”; even though they change, there is a continuation of a particular lifestream. Each person or animal that born is unique with a complex set of mental and physical parameters that evolve moment-to-moment like a flowing river; see, “[What Reincarnates? Concept of a Lifestream](#)”.

- We will discuss some of these factors in various sections, but the key point I wanted to get across is the fact that each person has a unique set of character qualities (gathi and asava) that have evolved over uncountable number lives in the past. And those are the key to one’s destiny.
One has the power to change those.

5. What makes one person different from another is this set of “gathi and asava”, which can be loosely translated as, “character qualities and deep-seated cravings”. Some people are calm and quiet

while others are rough and boisterous; some like music while other like to watch things or engage in physical activities; the possibilities are endless and there are innumerable combinations of them. That is why each person is different.

- Hidden in these apparently harmless “habits” and “cravings” are the defilements or the tendencies to engage in certain types of activities that are harmful oneself or the others.
- The key is to focus on the glaring character flaws first: if one engaged in activities such as fishing or hunting, that means willfully taking the life of other beings for one’s pleasure. Does that makes sense within the wider world view of any given being repeatedly born in any of the 31 realms? Within that broader view, we can see that any animal, how small or insignificant, has an attachment to its life; and we could have had that very life in the past.
- Take another example of a transaction between two people. The goal should be to make a decent profit for oneself making sure one covers the cost and make enough profit to “stay in business and provide for the family”, but not to make the transaction too burdensome on the other party. As we discussed in the post, “[Kamma, Debt, and Meditation](#)”, one could get into deep debt to other people and beings by exploiting them in many different ways.

6. The easiest way to deal with this is to look at each action mindfully and decide whether that act is “fair” to everyone involved. Of course one could check to see any of the ten defilements (*dasa akusala*) are committed by that action; see, “[Ten Immoral Actions \(Dasa Akusala\)](#)”.

- As I keep saying, one needs to focus on the more extreme violations first. There is no point in worrying about inadvertently killing some insects while gardening if one is engaged in lying and deceit or killing animals for pleasure. It is good to get an idea of the severity of different acts; see, “[How to Evaluate Weights of Different Kamma](#)”.

7. This is why it is important to learn Dhamma as much as possible, while engaging in meditation. The Path becomes clear as one learns the subtleties in key Dhamma concepts. I am amazed how much I learn each and every day; it is like a picture becoming clearer by the day. You start to see the even smallest detail, and instead of becoming distraught you get a sense of clarity and peacefulness by cleansing the mind. You realize that no one is perfect until the Arahant hood and the key is to make progress, no matter where you are. Each step in the right direction makes you feel better.

Next, “[How Habits are Formed and Broken – A Scientific View](#)“,

How Character (Gathi) Leads to Bhava and Jathi

1. One of the special knowledges that the Buddha gained at the Enlightenment was the asavakkhaya nana. This is the key to stop the suffering FROM ARISING via getting rid the deep-seated cravings (asava) that we all have. Asavakkhaya nana (“asava” + “khaya”, where “khaya” is the opposite of “san”; see, [“What is “San”?”](#)) is the knowledge on how to remove those cravings (asava).

2. Throughout the site, I keep emphasizing the importance of understanding (not memorizing) the meanings of the key Pali words like gathi, anusaya, asava, bhava, jati, sansara, and dukkha; they are intimately inter-connected in many ways including paticca samuppada. The way to stop future suffering (dukkha) from arising and reach Nibbana is to break the perpetual cycle that lead to a new jati (birth) at each death.

- Our problems do not go away at death (committing suicide is a bad idea); they merely get started in a new phase with a new body, which could be worse than what we have now; see, [“What Reincarnates? – Concept of a Lifestream”](#).
- The connections among bhava and jati on one side and asava, anusaya, and gathi on the other side are intimate, and need to be understood well; see, [“Sansaric Habits, Character \(Gathi\), and Cravings \(Asava\)”](#), before reading this the rest of this post.

3. And this understanding is needed even if one is not seriously thinking about Nibbana. The whole key to suffering in general is embedded in these intricate relationships.

- Bhava and jati also happen during this very life; jati could mean birth of a new desire; see, [“Akusala-Mula Pavutti \(or Pravurthi\) Paticca Samuppada”](#) and [“Bhava and Jati – States of Existence and Births Therein”](#).
- It may be a bit confusing at first for a new person to this site, but have patience and read the inter-connected posts; I have links everywhere to pertinent posts/material. Once you get an idea of the underlying connections, it will clarify everything, like a fog being lifted.
- I have set up links to open in new windows, so that you can go back forth between posts easily and try to “fill-in-the-gaps”.

4. A perpetual cycle that is ever-present in the sansaric cycle of rebirths is described in the following verse:

“uppado pavattan, pavatta nimittan

nimitta patisandhi, patisandhi gathi”

- “Uppada” means arising. When anusaya (temptations) arise due to asava (cravings), we need stop that temptation and break the cycle at “pavattan” (which means keeping it or go with it).
- If we go along with the temptation (“pavatta”), then it becomes a nimitta (literally a “sign”). A nimitta is a characteristic that is associated with that particular act. For example, for an alcoholic a picture of an alcohol bottle or a bar (or where one normally drinks), or even seeing a friend with whom one drinks often, can be a nimitta; when any of such a “symbol” comes to the mind, it reminds of the drinking act and gets one in the “mood”.

5. Most times, the patisandhi (linking of the next rebirth) takes place via a nimitta; this is what is meant by “nimitta patisandhi” above. At the dying moment, what comes to the mind is likely to be something

that one does often, and that could become the link to the next life.

- A drug addict, if he/she is lucky to be born human again, will be attracted to a mother who is a drug addict.
- For a person with lot of hate, what comes to the mind at the dying moment could be a picture of an arch enemy; then the kammic power shows him a gun or a knife and he will be likely to attack the person with that weapon (in a dream-like state); the next moment he will be in an apaya (hell), which is the “matching place”.

6. The worse thing is that the old habits continue and even strengthened in this new life; this is what is meant by “patisandhi gathi” above. Suppose that drug addict who was born to an addicted mother is adopted by another family and raised in a drug-free environment. Still, if that child becomes exposed to drugs later in his life, he could be tempted to use drugs because of his sansaric habit.

- This is the danger in the rebirth process or sansara; one keeps going down the slippery slope unless one changes one’s habits with effort. And reversing that trend can be done only in a human life.
- Sentient beings in most realms do not act willfully but according to their sansaric habits. We can see only the animal realm and clear that they do things mechanically (**almost like robots, but not quite only because they have FEELINGS**). Only the beings in higher realms have genuine free-will and it is optimum for the humans.
- You can see that many animals have unique characteristics: such characteristics and habits are associated with that particular existence (bhava). For example, some types of birds have been building the same type of nests from beginningless time through countless world cycles; **but they are unable to make it any better**. Migrating birds know exactly where to fly. New born turtles head to the sea right after the eggs are hatched; see the video:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?x-yt-ts=1422579428&feature=player_embedded&v=T8eGw1oyYoQ&x-yt-cl=85114404

7. However, humans can change their destiny. They have freewill and the ability to come up with “new ideas”. We keep building new things, discovering new things, and making progress.

- We need to keep in mind that we can also purify our minds and become free of this unending and suffering-laden rebirth process. If we ever get a birth in one of the lower realms, we will be stuck there for a long time to come.
- The way to purify our minds is to get rid of bad habits. Excessive greed (this include addictions to anything including food, money, property, alcohol, drugs, etc) and anger are the first two things one needs to work on.
- This does not mean one has to give away one’s wealth; just don’t be too attached to them. One has “earned” that wealth from previous good deeds, so one does not need to feel bad about it. But those things last only about 100 years, and who knows what we will inherit in the next life.

8. And the key to be permanently free of the apayas is to get rid of those bad character qualities (gathi) that can give us birth in those four realms.

- We can avoid the niraya (hell) by getting rid of hate; we can stay away from peta (hungry ghost) worlds by getting rid of greed, we can make sure to not get a birth in the asura realm by not

getting “free rides”, and making our own living honestly (“a”+”sūra” means “not able” or those who depend on others).

- An animal birth results from gathi that have all three roots of greed, hate, and ignorance; animal realm is called “thirisan” in Pali or Sinhala: “thiri” is three and “san” is greed, hate, and ignorance, thus an animal birth is caused by gathi that have all three immoral roots.
- In the same way, we can make it possible to be born a deva by being generous to others; we can make it possible to become a brahma by cultivating metta, karuna, mudita, upekkha; and we can optimize chances for a human birth by cultivating wisdom as well.

9. But no matter how well we live this life, we do not know what kind of “kammic baggage” that we carry from previous lives. Thus the only way to avoid the four lower realms (apayas) with CERTAINTY is to attain [the Sotapanna stage](#) of Nibbana. And we can do this by comprehending *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, the true nature of this world.

- When one truly comprehends *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, one’s mind automatically rejects actions that are bound to maintain and cultivate bad gathi, and will encourage actions that will cultivate good gathi. If this is done to the level of getting rid of the four greedy citta with wrong vision and the citta with vicikicca, then one becomes PERMANENTLY free of the apayas; see, [“Akusala Citta – How a Sotapanna Avoids Apayagami Citta”](#).

10. Finally, here is another interesting video from the animal world which shows how ants build sophisticated cities. But unlike humans, the ability to do that does not come from ingenious minds; ants have been doing the same from eternity. It is a “characteristic” that is naturally associated with the “ant bhava”. Each ant “knows” what to do, just like the baby turtles who race to the sea just after being hatched. It is the same with how birds know where to fly in their long migrations.

- There is so much that the Buddha explained to the world, but the world is still unaware of.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?x-yt-ts=1422579428&v=lFg21x2sj-M&x-yt-cl=85114404&feature=player_embedded

11. More details on the importance of gathi in the rebirth process are discussed in , [“Patisandhi Citta – How the Next Life is Determined According to Gathi”](#).

How Habits are Formed and Broken – A Scientific View

1. We are lucky to be in an age when many of the Buddha's teachings are not only confirmed but also strongly supported with additional evidence that were not possible during the time of the Buddha. Here is another instance where the evidence is coming from research on the workings of the brain.

2. The Buddha basically said to follow the following procedure to break a bad habit and to instill a good habit:

1. understand the reasons why a certain habit is bad,
2. stop engaging in activities that enhances the habit,
3. deviate the mind from such bad activities by focusing on opposing good activities,
4. contemplate on the “release” or “cooling down” that has already resulted by following the above procedure, strengthen the resolve to stay on course, and keep doing (i) through (iii).

With time, the bad habit(s) will go away and the good habit(s) will take hold. There comes a time when one will automatically follow this procedure; it becomes a “way of life”.

3. The reasoning behind is based on the key factors that we discussed in the previous posts:

- We do many things automatically (i.e., without being mindful or without deliberate thinking); these are done via our habits that we formed during this life or even coming from previous lives.
- There are both good and bad habits. We want to keep and cultivate good habits and discard bad habits.
- Changing (cultivating) habits first require some “external adjustments” like one's physical environment, friends, etc and, more importantly, the four steps listed above.

4. Beginning in the early 1990's or so, scientific investigations in several fields (effects of meditation on the brain, behavioral studies on animals and humans, neurology, etc) have come to similar conclusions. We will discuss these in detail in the future, but here I want to just point out the main similarities. Furthermore, discussing how the mechanism takes place in the brain provides an alternative way to visualize these changes. We are indeed fortunate to live at a time when we have evidence from science to provide additional evidence.

5. As I pointed out in the posts on the *manomaya kaya* and physical body, our physical body is “prepared” by the *kamma* seed that was the cause for this life. But the *manomaya kaya* is constantly making “adjustments” to the physical body based on the current status of the mind.

- Many *kamma vipaka* are “built-in” even at the conception; some may be avoidable by taking care of the body (exercise, food, etc), and the mind (contemplation, meditation, etc), but some may not be avoidable because they are so strong: We will never know when a cancer, an accident, or even a natural calamity can drastically change our lives; this is *anicca*, “the inability to maintain our lives the way would like to”.
- Thus we need to spend at least sometime to work towards a meaningful solution to the “problem of existence”.
- Another factor we need to remember is that our “*sansaric* habits” are built-in to our brain. We

keep changing/adding such habits as we grow up, influenced by our family, friends, and the society in general. Thus one's "character" (*gathi*) are in constant flux, either by choice or influenced by the environment.

6. This is a key point: We need to make sure that we do not "go with the flow", i.e., let past kamma or our environment determine our future.

- As humans, we have the capability to change our destiny. We DO HAVE free will, unlike an animal. Since we do not know what our next existence is going to be, we need to make sure to get on the "right path" as soon as possible.
- This may sound like a broken record, but 100 years of this life is NOTHING compared to millions and billions of years life in "unknown territory" in the future; thus we need to make use of this opportunity.

7. As we discussed in the "[Truine Brain – How the Mind Rewires the Brain via Meditation/Habits](#)", only the humans have a developed neocortex, that makes possible 'thinking, and decision making'. The animals either do not have it, or have a primitive version of it.

- Therefore, the animals basically only use the "mid brain" or the "limbic system", where decisions are made FOR THEM according to their ingrained habits that have evolved over many, many lives (as we discussed, the physical body is formed based on the manomaya kaya). The response from the limbic system is instantaneous, and the animals can only REACT to external stimuli.
- All *sansaric* habits are built-in to the limbic system, and the animals react according to the way the limbic system is wired up; this may change some during growing up due to external environment, but the main "character qualities" (*gathi*) do not change very much. That is why you see adorable dogs as well as vicious dogs. Even our pets have "a personality".
- WE can change their personalities by teaching them things, but they are unable to do it on their own. It is easier to "teach" more evolved animals like monkeys because they have a bit of a neocortex.

8. But we humans have a neocortex that is well-developed and is capable of much more than we normally believe it to be capable of. **It is this neocortex that makes us, humans, different from animals (actually, it is more accurate to say that "our current *bhava*" is superior to an "animal *bhava*").**

- Even though we also REACT first, especially to a threatening stimuli, our "thinking brain" starts to kick in quickly, especially with training. Many people get into trouble because they are "REACTIVE", i.e., they do not try to develop the habit of using the "thinking brain".
- But we can be PROACTIVE. We can teach ourselves to "take corrective actions" even if we do some things on impulse. Even if the initial reaction to a sudden temptation is to "take it and enjoy it" or "hit him" or "kill that annoying dog", we can always take a breath, stop ourselves, and think about the consequences of such actions. This is what we call "mindfulness".
- Some people are more proactive than others even at birth (via *sansaric* habits). Some people change from being reactive to proactive or other way around even without knowing due to the particular environment they grow up in.
- The key point is that we can WILLFULLY change from being reactive to proactive; we all are

reactive at least to some stimuli: the one's we have "*tanha*" for! In other words, we like to get attached to certain things and like to dislike other things with PASSION; see, "[Tanha – How we Attach via Greed, Hate, and Ignorance](#)".

9. In terms of science the key is in the neurons in the brain, and how we can train our neocortex to fire the right sets of neurons more frequently. The "frontal lobes" of the neocortex is the command center for brain activities.

- The frontal lobes can be visualized as the boss. If it is a lazy boss, it will just assign duties to the limbic system to carry out things "as usual".
- But if the boss is energetic and always looking for ways to "improve things", then it will start investigating new approaches. And once better approaches are found, it will get them "hard wired" and they will essentially become the "new limbic system".
- This is the key to "developing a new you" by discarding bad habits and developing good habits. Essentially you need to get the frontal lobes to be an active, energetic boss for the brain.

10. Dr. Jeffrey Schwartz is a psychiatrist specializing in treating Obsessive Compulsive Disorders (OCD), and has pioneered in using "habit makeovers" to treat OCD. He has written several books, but I highly recommend the two books, "The Mind and the Brain" and "You are not Your Brain".

He has developed a "Four Step" method to change one's habits that give rise to OCD:

1. Identify the problem area.
2. Recognize the need to change.
3. Deviate from automatically "going along" with old ways and re-direct attention to "new paths".
4. Re-assess the situation, and keep working on accelerating the process.

11. He has kept records of brain scans of his patients which clearly show the improvements in the brain with time, and of course most patients are able to get rid of their compulsive behavior.

- The key is to slow down the "firing of neurons" associated with a bad habit and to increase the firing of neurons associated with an opposing good habit.
- There is a rule called Hebb's rule that says, 'neurons that fire together, wire together'. The more one keeps doing a certain activity, a set of neurons start to fire together and that neural connection gets stronger by the day. It is just like strengthening one's arm by "doing more liftings" with it.
- In the same way, when one is decreasing the use of a certain activity, the set of neurons allocated for that activity gets weaker, fewer neurons participate, and eventually it loses being a habitual act.

12. Here is a figure from Dr. Schwartz's book, "The Mind and the Brain" (p. 362), that illustrates the "re-wiring" of a new network in the brain and the concomitant weakening of a network for an undesirable habit (click to open it):

[Habit Formation Figure](#)

This figure explains how a patient who had an obsessive disorder to constantly wash his hand, got rid of that habit by WILLFULLY stepping outside to the garden when he got the urge to wash hands. As he kept doing it, the wiring to "wash hands" got weakened, and instead wiring for "stepping outside" got

stronger, and eventually he lost the compulsive urge to wash his hands too often.

13. The same principle has been used to get rid of such annoying habits as well as serious disorders. We can use the same procedure to stay away from immoral habits and cultivating moral habits; this is the basis of “*anapana*“, see, “[Key to Anapanasati – How to Change Character and Habits \(Gathi\)](#)“.

10. Ariya Jhanas via Cultivation of Saptha Bojjanga

The top 11 posts in this section describe a way of using meditation in following the Noble Path and to attain *Ariya jhanas* and at least [the Sotapanna stage of Nibbana](#). This series was put together using my own experience, and in the 10th and 11th posts I describe how the process can culminate in attaining *Ariya jhanas* (and possibly *magga phala*). The rest of the posts in this section are on possible meditation subjects and together with other posts at the site can be used to clarify unresolved questions, and to gain *samadhi*. It is recommended that the first 11 posts be followed in that order, at least initially.

1. There are many ways to get to *Ariya jhanas*. My favorite is *Bojjanga bhavana*. I practice *bojjanga bhavana* in a sitting meditation and *anapanasati* (and *satipattana*) during other times, i.e., suppressing any thoughts/speech/actions that should be discarded and cultivating the opposite. Nowadays, It has become a habit and the moment something not appropriate comes to the mind, I become aware of it. As I keep saying, cultivating good habits (*gathi*) is key to progress.

- *Anapanasati* (and *Satipattana*) helps one to get rid of bad habits/cultivate good habits, and thus change one's *gathi* and *asavas*; see, "[Key to Anapanasati – How to Change Habits and Character \(Gathi\)](#)".
- *Bojjanga bhavana* helps the mind to get to *samadhi* (and attain *jhanas* with time) while also cultivating the *Bojjanga dhamma*. *Saptha Bojjanga* (Seven Factors of Enlightenment) are listed in the "[37 Factors of Enlightenment](#)"; a brief description is given below.
- The other part of my sitting meditation is *Ariya metta bhavana*; see, "[Ariya Metta Bhavana \(Loving Kindness Meditation\)](#)". This routine works well for me.

2. The key here is that once one gets into *Bojjanga bhavana*, one only does "*āna*" or "taking in good things"; see, "[What is Ānapāna?](#)". However, "*pāna*" or "removing the bad" happens automatically via wisdom gained, i.e., via enhanced vision or *samma ditthi*. One's mind is automatically focused on thinking about a Dhamma concept, and once one gets some traction, the mind will get "latched on to it".

- In the early days, when I started contemplating on a Dhamma concept I automatically got to *samadhi* (not *jhana*), i.e., the mind became concentrated on that and the body and the mind both became lighter. I also experimented with *anariya jhanas* (with breath meditation) at that time.

3. I was able to attain *Ariya jhanas* only after learning the true meanings of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. Furthermore, one of my teacher Thereros has explained how to systematically cultivate the seven *Bojjanga dhamma*: it involves first establishing *sati* (moral mindfulness) based on those correct interpretations of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*; see, "[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations](#)", and the follow-up posts. That is the process that I am going to describe here using my own experience, including how to distinguish among different *jhanas*.

4. The seven *Bojjanga Dhamma* are *sati* (mindfulness), *dhammavicaya* (investigation of dhamma concepts; pronounced "dhammavichaya"), *viriya* (effort), *piti* (joy), *passaddhi* (tranquility), *samadhi* (one-pointedness), and *upekkha* (equanimity). I will have post on this later, but I have discussed most of these terms in other posts.

- However, it is important to again clarify what *sati* is. Many people think *sati* is "concentration" or just "paying attention". It is much more than that. It is "paying attention" WITH a frame of mind based on some understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*: One has contemplated on the "big picture" of the Buddha with 31 realms and a rebirth process that has led to much suffering in the

long run.

- Even though one may be enjoying life right now, one knows that it will be of short duration compared to the [samsaric time scale](#). This is the theme of this website, and there are many posts that one can read.

5. During the whole time of the *Bojjanga bhavana*, *sati* must be there; that frame of mind must be there. *Dhammavicaya* is critical evaluation of a given dhamma concept. One can choose a topic or two for a given session and then contemplate on it. One could do this not only in a formal way, but also just while reading a web post or a book on the subject. Each individual is different, so one needs to figure out which is more suitable.

- One can compare the concept with one's own life experience, and also others' that one can see. For example, when contemplating on *anicca*, I have several video clips on various posts giving visuals on the inability of anyone to maintain anything, including one's own body, to one's satisfaction in the long run. One can contemplate on the rebirth process and see whether it makes sense, one can contemplate on different applications of *paticca samuppada*, etc.
- When one comprehends a given concept, that leads to cultivation of the *piti* (pronounced "peethi" or "preethi" in Sinhala) *sabbojjanga*. This is part of [niramisa sukha](#) that I have talked about; one starts feeling a happiness or a "lightness" making the mind serene. This gives one confidence, and thus one will be motivated to make more effort, i.e., it cultivates the *viriya sabbojjanga*.

6. Thus *dhammavicaya*, *piti*, and *viriya sabbojjanga* are cultivated together. At some point though, the mind and especially the body (head) may get tired. If one is making a lot of progress, one may start to experience some pressures in the head or body; not headaches, but just pressure. Some feel like "ants crawling in the head"; the brain and the body (including the nervous system) are adjusting and there is nothing bad about this.

- When this happens one is getting close to *jhana*, which ("dhyana") means "burning up" defilements. In the case of *Ariya jhanas* that happens when one gains wisdom, true comprehension of the nature of this world. And this burning of defilements lead to generation of contaminants that need to be expelled and cleansed, via proper breathing (this is not "*anapana*"). We should not focus on the breath like in the mundane "breath meditation". We are just getting rid of certain "*utuja rupa*" that had been in the body due to defilements of greed, hate, and ignorance.
- At this point one should stop the contemplation process and start breathing in and out to cleanse the body; sometimes the body itself automatically gets rid of those things via a long out breath. This will lead to *passaddhi* (tranquility) of both the body and the mind, and one gets to *samadhi* gradually. One needs to think about the lightness of the body and the mind (*passaddhi*) and the [niramisa sukha](#) (from *samadhi*) that results. One also should think about *upekkha* (equanimity) too.
- When the body and the mind calm down enough and when one feels relaxed, one should go back to cultivating the previous three *sabbojjanga*, i.e., start on the contemplation process of *dhammavicaya*.

7. Thus one should go back and forth between the two routines with three *sabbojjanga* each. The *sati sabbojjanga* must be there all the time. This is called the two-step cultivation of *Bojjanga dhamma*.

The Buddha compared to this process to the washing of a dirty cloth by hand. One needs to apply soap and wring the cloth to release the contaminants. But then one needs to soak it in clean water and

remove the dirt that came out. After that, if the cloth is still dirty, one applies soap again, and then again wash it. This process needs to be repeated until all the dirt is gone and the cloth becomes clean. And one needs to do it with mindfulness: if there is a stubborn stain left in one place, one may need to use a different chemical to get rid of that spot and wash in clean water again. Thus one needs to be mindful (*sati*) during the whole process.

- In the same way, one goes back and forth between the two routines with *sati* until *jhanas* are attained. Time taken to get to *jhanas* depends on the individual. Also, this cannot be done in isolation. One needs to do *anapana* at all times to get rid of bad habits and to cultivate good habits; cultivating this process itself is good habit too. Once one gains some traction and sees some benefits, one will become motivated.

8. Initially one should focus on *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* as the *dhammavicaya* subject. Then once some understanding is gained, one's mind attains a certain overall cleanliness. After that, like using different kinds of chemicals to get rid of coffee stains or a tar stain, one needs to choose different types of topics to broaden the understanding. Buddha Dhamma is all about cleansing the mind via wisdom, via understanding the true nature of this world.

- Also, if one has a specific deficiency, like tendency to get angry, then one could do some *metta bhavana*. If one has too many cravings, one could use the “*asubha anussati*”; if one tends to procrastinate, one could cultivate the “*marananussati*”. We will talk about these in the future.
- But first it is important to focus on *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. At the same time, it may be a good idea to get some idea of the “big picture”, i.e., the rebirth process, the 31 realms, etc and then some idea about *kamma*, *sankhara*, *paticca samuppada*, etc. All these are pieces of a puzzle; even though it may look daunting at the beginning, when the big pieces are in place, one starts to get a better idea as for where small pieces may fit in. *Anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* are the biggest pieces.

9. Once one gets to the first *jhana* (this depends on the individual and effort), one needs to practice it well and get familiar with its properties. Then one gradually moves up to higher *jhanas* using the same *Bojjanga bhavana*. Once one attains these *Ariya jhanas* they are not lost during this lifetime. I have heard that It may be difficult to get into them if one has an ailment or physical pain, but that they always comes back.

- When one is cultivating *Saptha Bojjanga* with the frame of mind of the unfruitfulness of anything in this world in the long run (*anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*), all mundane thought objects (based on greed and hate) are suspended from the mind. Such thought objects (*arammana*) are kept in the mind via *vitakka* and *vicara*, and they bring up the five defilements (*panca nivarana*); see, “[Key to Calming the Mind – Five Hindrances](#)”.
- When in the first *Ariya jhana* one's mind is absent of *vitakka* (turn the mind to mundane thought objects or *arammana*), *vicara* (keep the mind on such *arammana*); in the first *jhana*, *vitakka* and *vicara* are absent and thus said to have *savitakka* and *savicara* (basically with *Nibbana* or the reciting phrase in mind) instead. This leads to *piti* (joy), *sukha* (body lightness), and *ekaggata* (one-pointedness). These are the five *jhana* factors (*jhananga* = “*jhana*”+“*anga*”) of the first *Ariya jhana*.

10. By the way, once one gets to a *jhana*, it is easy to get back to it anytime. At that point *Bojjanga bhavana* is not necessary to get into the *jhana*. One can just close one's eyes and make a determination to get into the *jhana*, and use a phrase that reminds one of the *Nibbana*. I use the phrase, “*Etan santan etan paneetan, yadidan sabba sankhara samato, sabbupati patinissaggo, tanhakkhayo virago, nirodho*”

Nibbananti”.

- Here is a recording of the Pali verse by the Venerable Thero (recited 7 times; note the volume control on the right):

http://puredhamma.net/wp-content/uploads/054_Ethan_santhang_ethan_panithang_1111111.mp3

- One could say in English, “It is peaceful, it is serene, the expelling of all sankhara, breaking of bonds, removing greed and hate; Nibbana”.
- What matters is not the actual words, but the understanding one has in one’s mind.
- With more practice, one could just close eyes and think about the jhana one needs to get into and within a short time one is in the jhana.

11. One advances to higher jhanas by removing jhana factors successively.

- In the first jhana one is focusing on a verse or even a concept related to Nibbana, like *anicca*; that is *savitakka*, *savicara*. *Piti* (joy) is felt in the face, and *sukha* (body lightness) is felt over the rest of the body. The *sukha* is a bit stronger, but *piti* is more serene on the face. One also has the one-pointedness of the mind; it feels calm.
- When one gets into the second jhana, the jhana factors of *savitakka*, *savicara* are removed. If one has been reciting a verse like the above, the need to actually say the verse goes away (but not the ability to talk; the ability to talk goes away only in a *jhana samapatti* which we will discuss later), and it feels like jaws kind of “getting locked”. One could still think about it in the mind, but that is not necessary to maintain the *jhana*.
- At the third *jhana*, one loses *piti* and thus *sukha* takes control all over the body.
- The fourth jhana is supposed to be unique. one loses *sukha* also and left with only the *ekaggata* (one-pointedness of the mind). The body becomes almost weightless and one is soaked from head-to-toe in white light. According to the Thero, one sees a bright white light covering the whole body, like a big tube light. Apparently, this is the hardest one to attain, and I am not there yet.

12. **I have verified that Ariya jhanas cannot be “disturbed”, especially in the second jhana or higher.** Even if one deliberately start thinking about a sensual/hateful thought, it does not get any traction (i.e., “wheeling process” is stopped automatically), and one does not come out of the *jhana*. This is an important distinction from an anariya jhana, which is lost if a sensual/hateful thought comes to the mind; see, “[Power of the Human Mind – Anariya or Mundane Jhana](#)”.

- Furthermore, one’s ability to contemplate on any Dhamma concept is optimized in a jhana.
- One could stay in a *jhana* for hours at a time. One comes out of it energized.

13. The Buddha encouraged people to cultivate the first four *Ariya jhanas* for two reasons:

- They provide a better “platform” to contemplate on *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* or any other concept like *paticca samuppada* (one does not stop contemplating on *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* until the *Arahanthood*; that is when the “full effect” of it is grasped).
- Jhanic pleasure in the first four *jhanas* is the only pleasure that was not only allowed but encouraged by the Buddha. It is called “*Ihāthma sukha viharana*” or the [niramisa sukha](#) experienced within the lifetime. It is not of fleeting nature as sensual pleasures are.

14. [One way to verify the validity of Buddha Dhamma is to attain Ariya jhanas. If one can get to the first Ariya jhana, one can verify the uniqueness of it, and realize the “power of the mind” first](#)

hand. [One does not need to take anybody's word on it.](#)

- More importantly, this is also an indirect way to confirm the “big picture” of the Buddha: the beginning-less rebirth process and the beings wandering endlessly in the 31 realms and being subjected to much suffering.
- I can vouch that being able to verify the teachings of the Buddha first hand makes a huge difference in one's life. One is not only motivated to proceed further but one will be anxious to share this unique experience with others.

15. 5/9/15: I just published a post, “[How Does One Know whether the Sotapanna Stage is Reached?](#)“, which describes in detail the relationship between *Ariya jhanas* and *magga phala*.

The above post basically ties up the current post and the other previously published post on the attainment of *magga phala*: “[11. How to Select and “Grow” Meditation Procedures for Magga Phala](#)“.

11. How to Select and “Grow” Meditation Procedures for Magga Phala

1. One needs to make sure that the meditation “grows” with practice. In *Sinhala* it is called “*bhavanava vadenava*”.

- As we will discuss below, there are many meditation techniques in Buddha Dhamma. Obviously, no one has time to do all or even several. How does one choose the right ones for oneself?
- This is a long post, but it may be helpful in tailoring a shorter path to accomplish one’s goal, whether it is *samadhi*, *jhana*, or *magga phala*.

2. First, let us see WHY there are so many different techniques.

The major reason is that human mind is the most complex entity in the universe; no two people are alike, and no two minds respond to a given situation exactly the same way.

- Thus it is important to realize that a given person’s mind will respond differently to different meditation techniques (*kammasthana*). Thus, one should not “stick to” a particular technique from the outset just because it appears to be a popular technique.
- But it is also not productive to “jump around” among different techniques either. It is best to give a given technique some exclusive time to test out, and then try another one, and so on until one gets a feel for how one feels with each technique. In order to do this effectively, one’s mind needs to be “sensitized”; see below.
- Even after settling on one technique or a couple of techniques (I do *bojjanga* and *metta bhavana* mostly, but not exclusively), and after making some progress, one may want to try out a different one again, just to see whether it is more effective at the present time. As we make progress, our minds change too.

3. The second reason for having many different techniques is that *Nibbana* can be approached from different directions, and the “gap to close” may be shorter in some directions. This may become a factor only when getting close to [the Sotapanna stage](#), and even more for the higher stages.

- It should be emphasized that **culmination of Nibbana** (or *Arahanthood*) is NOT extinction, and there is no need to worry that one may “accidentally” get there during meditation. The fact that one has that mindset means that it is not going to happen any time soon until that mindset is changed by realizing the true nature of this world. I am not saying this in a derogatory way, but just as a fact. Until one experiences some “cooling down”, and get some idea about about *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, it is very difficult to get a real idea of even what *Nibbana* is.
- **It is important to keep in mind that when I refer to Nibbana (or “niveema” or “nivana”) at this site, I am normally referring to the “cooling down” process starting with just “peace of mind” to [the Sotapanna stage](#). The culmination of this “cooling down” process eventually leads to the Arahanthood.**

4. The techniques one needs to be using will depend on what one’s goal is. There are basically three stages: *samadhi* (state of tranquility) first and then *jhanas/magga phala*; see, “[Possible Outcomes of Meditation – Samadhi, Jhana, Magga Phala](#)”.

5. First, it would be very difficult to get to a state of *samadhi* if one is not practicing at least the “conventional” five precepts: abstaining from killing, stealing, sexual misconduct, lying, and using drugs or getting intoxicated. These things make the mind restless, and makes it hard for the mind to focus attention (the five hindrances “cover the mind”). It should be noted that just strictly obeying the

five precepts may not be effective if one's mind is full of jealousy, extreme greed, hate, etc.

- Just like one cannot see the bottom of a well if it is highly contaminated, the mind (and the body) will not “feel anything” in a formal meditation session if the mind is “highly contaminated”. And there is no point in trying to take out the “small defilements” (such as abstaining from taking a glass of wine) if one's mind is full of hatred, or excess greed. (Of course, even if one's mind is fairly “clean”, it may be difficult to get to *samadhi* if one is under stress from an upcoming deadline or has a physical ailment).
- When the “big defilements” are removed, one starts seeing a little bit further down the well; similarly, one's mind will become lighter, with less stress, even when not in a formal meditation session. When one sits down in a quiet place, it will become easier to get to some kind of “*samadhi*”, or tranquility.

6. To get to *samadhi*, contemplating on Dhamma concepts will make it easier and faster. Also, one will be able to stay in “meditation” for a longer time. This is called by different names: insight meditation (*vipassana*), many forms of “*anupassana*”, and cultivating the “*dhamma vicaya*” *sambojjanga*. Concomitantly, one needs to do the correct version of “*anapanasati*” at all times. This is what was described in the earlier posts in this section.

7. After getting to the *samadhi* stage, two different procedures are to be followed for cultivating *jhanas* and for attaining [the Sotapanna stage](#), but one could be engaged in either or both.

8. *Jhanas* need to be cultivated in formal (normally sitting down) meditation sessions using a *kammasthana*.

- When one sits down and follows a certain meditation procedure, it is called a “*kammasthana*”. But any meditation technique can also be called a *kammasthana*. Therefore, the “*anapana bhavana*”, which needs to be practiced all day long — being morally mindful all the time, i.e., taking in (doing) good things (thoughts, speech, actions) and discarding (abstain from) bad things — is also called a *kammasthana*.
- For anariya *jhanas*, one does breath meditation or a kasina meditation; see, “[Power of the Human Mind – Anariya or Mundane Jhanas](#)”.
- **By the way, all forty meditation techniques described in the *Visuddhimagga* can only result in anariya *jhanas*. The reason is that in order to attain Ariya *jhanas*, one needs to have *Nibbana* as the object (*arammana*). If one uses a mundane thing as the object (*kasina* objects or the breath) that can result only in anariya *jhanas*.**

9. For Ariya *jhanas*, one focuses the mind on *Nibbana* (or even more precisely recall the “cooling down” one has experienced), saying the verse, “*etan santan etan paneetan....*” or an equivalent phrase in any language; see, “[Possible Outcomes of Meditation – Samadhi, Jhana, Magga Phala](#)”.

10. Working towards [the Sotapanna stage](#) does not require any formal meditation techniques, even though they will be certainly helpful; there have been countless people who attained the *Sotapanna* or even higher stages of *Nibbana* just by listening to a Dhamma discourse. ***The types of kammasthana used here are different from those to get to jhanas; see below.***

11. Understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* to some extent is REQUIRED for both the Ariya *jhanas* and *magga phala*.

- Therefore, before one spends time on reciting the “*etan santan etan paneetan....*” *kammasthana* to attain Ariya *jhanas*, one needs to do other types of meditation and understand the true nature of this world (*anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*) to some extent. Otherwise, the mind will not be able to

focus on *Nibbana* as the meditation object. I have verified this from my own experience, as I describe below.

12. Now let us get back to the original question: How does one decide on the “effectiveness” of a given technique (*kammasthana*), i.e., how does one decide whether the meditation is “growing” or one is just wasting time? The answer is that one will “feel” the effectiveness as one engages in it, especially when one makes “traction” with the technique and makes progress.

- I think it is best to describe my experience, in order to give an idea of what kind of “indicators” are possible, and hope that it will be beneficial for others. But it MUST BE understood that meditation experiences are unique and personal (especially until one gets into *jhanas*), and no two people will follow the same path. My hope is that one could get a rough idea of what to expect.
- Furthermore, there may be people out there who have developed *jhanas* in recent human lives and may be able get to them easily, yet do not even know about it. Last year, in an internet forum, one person (likely European) described his/her experience and it turned out that he/she was likely getting into the second *jhana* without any real effort (just laying on the bed at a quiet time).

13. I was at the stage of just being able to get to *samadhi* for a while (3-4 years!), before I found the correct interpretations of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. It was truly frustrating, because I thought I was doing everything right. Even though I was learning Dhamma concepts and *Abhidhamma*, some critical concepts were just wrong. I was also doing breath meditation, because even most *Theravada* instructions say one needs to calm one’s mind with breath meditation first. I could get to a kind of *samadhi*, and I started seeing “lights”. Somehow I realized that it was not right, and did not proceed on focusing on such “lights”. (Actually it depends on what one focuses the mind on: some people can see religious objects or even a religious figure; the mind is good at “making up” such visuals; this is why the Buddha said *vinnana* is like a magician).

- I was “stuck” at this stage until I came across a discourse by one of my teacher *Theros* on the internet. With just that *desana*, I made a whole lot of progress. That was a good meditation session itself. If one gets absorbed in the material whether it is discourse or even written material, one CAN get to *samadhi* or even *magga phala*. But to get to *jhanas*, one needs to practice a *kammasthana* for some time.

14. After that, even listening to such discourses and then contemplating on them, it was very easy to get to *samadhi* and stay there longer. One can definitely get to *samadhi* while reading and contemplating on dhamma topics; this is the cultivation of the “*dhamma vicaya*” *sambojjanga* in the *saptha bojjanga bhavana*; see, “[10. Ariya Jhanas via Cultivation of Saptha Bojjanga](#)”.

- Actually, at this stage, one could start cultivating *jhanas* or just focus on attaining [the Sotapanna stage](#) of *Nibbana*.

15. Going back to my timeline, some time later I was able to get into *jhanas*; see #9 and #14 above for the procedure. Of course I was practicing “*anapana*” and thus *Satipatthana* all the time. I just started a series on *Satipatthana*; see, “[Satipatthana – Introduction](#)”.

- Even though in the initial phase of getting to *samadhi* the mind and the body become calmer, things *may appear* to go backward when getting close to *jhanas*. When getting close to *jhanas*, I started feeling some “pressure” mostly in the head initially, and later in the body too. This is NOT bad news, and luckily I had heard a few *desanas* by one of the *Theros* on this possibility. This happens when one starts “cleaning up” in a serious way; see also, “[Ariya Jhanas via](#)”.

Cultivation of Saptha Bojjanga“.

- But it may not happen everyday. Some days are calm, and most days start with “pressures” building and then go away. This is due to the effect of the defilements in the mind on one’s nervous system. I will have a post on this in the future. **As the defilements are removed (by *samma ditthi*), the nervous system adjusts itself and that shows up as bodily pressures.** This may not be significant for young people.

16. Sometimes there are “ripples” going through the head, inside the mouth, or even down the throat. Sometimes it is like tiny needles pricking the skin gently, and none of this is scary or anything like that. You KNOW that it is harmless. One is becoming “sensitized”; see, [“Possible Outcomes of Meditation – Samadhi, Jhana, Magga Phala”](#).

- Like a good wine taster should stay away from drinking coffee or any other “harsh” tastes, as one’s mind becomes clear it will be “more and more sensitive” to “good meditation techniques” and also to “catch any immoral thoughts as they start arising”.
- For example, if one adds a bit more dirt to a glass of water that is already dirty, one will not see a difference. However, if the water is fairly clean, the addition of some dirt will become immediately noticeable. If the water is pure, even the slightest contamination becomes noticeable.
- In the same way, as a mind becomes more pure, it will be more sensitive. We will talk more on “being sensitized” when we discuss the *Satipatthana sutta* in detail; see, [“Satipatthana – Introduction”](#)

17. This is how one judges whether a given technique is effective or not. But when comparing two techniques one needs to make the conditions as similar as possible (same place, same time if possible).

- For someone starting out, any of these indicators may not work for a while (depending on many personal factors, including the habit of doing it even in previous lives as I mentioned above). Therefore, one MUST have *perseverance* and *not to get discouraged*.
- Even then one should see some overall changes in oneself (one’s state of mind and even behavior) within a few months. It is not possible to make general statements about this because each person is different.
- Anyway, those are the “indicators” I experienced, and some may experience some of those, none of those, or somethings else. But I believe that there will be indicators.

18. The experience will be more “predictable” in getting into *jhanas*; one will feel that the mind will “take over” at some point. When I first experienced, I got startled. It was as if someone was taking control of the brain, and the whole nervous system was being squeezed gently. This happens clearly when one goes from the first *jhana* to the second, when one’s jaws get locked; one’s mind goes on autopilot; there is no need to recite a “*kammatthana*” after the second *jhana*. But one can still think about anything or say anything in one’s mind.

- This is the best time to do insight meditation for *magga phala*.
- Also, when one is in a *jhana*, one’s mind is well “sensitized”. It is much easier to gauge the effectiveness of a *kammatthana* when one is in a *jhana*.

19. It should be emphasized that one could attain *magga phala* before any *jhana*. I believe I was able to attain [the Sotapanna stage](#) even before I got to the first *jhana*. That was because I had been spending most of the time contemplating and reading and listening to Dhamma concepts, and did not focus my

efforts on cultivating *jhanas*.

- Even though one may realize that one has attained a *phala* at some point, it takes a while to convince oneself. One realizes key changes in how one thinks, how one's tendencies have changed, and also how one AUTOMATICALLY responds to various situations.

20. Thus, one could attain *magga phala* first, and then practice *jhanas*, or simply decide not to practice *jhanas*. There were many at the time of the Buddha who attained *magga phala* without attaining *jhanas* (even though one goes through the first *Ariya jhana* for a moment when attaining [the Sotapanna stage](#)). This is because one needs to **practice** *jhanas* to be able to “get into a *jhana*” and stay there.

- Basic understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* is the first stages of *Samma Ditthi*. This is where the Noble Eightfold Path starts and other seven stages grow culminating in ***Samma Samadhi***; see, “[How to Cultivate the Noble Eightfold Path Starting with Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta](#)“. This is a self-feeding system, whereby *Samma Ditthi* also grows concomitantly with the other stages. Thus, in the beginning one will only have an incomplete idea about *Samma Ditthi*; but that is enough to go a long way.
- According to the *suttas*, understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* (and thus the unfruitful AND dangerous nature of this world) becomes complete only at the *Arahanthood*. It is the understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* that takes one all the way to the *Arahanthood*. It is said that when one gets to the *Arahant* stage, one will feel the *dukkha* associated with even breathing. Even though we do not pay attention to it (because we don't feel it, unless one has asthma), breathing takes an effort. Thus one can get an idea how “sensitized” one becomes by the time one gets to the *Arahant* stage.

21. Later on, my body started “freezing” just a like a statue (I think it started gradually even before getting to *jhanas*); when I want to come out of it I just say that to myself and start moving my fingers a bit and within a minute or so everything is unfrozen. If this happens to anyone, do not try to move quickly, until “unfrozen”. This may not be of common occurrence.

- Each *jhana* (say the first *jhana*) has three levels: *heena* (low), *madhyama* (middle), and *praneetha* (high). With practice one goes from low to high, and then one can get into a *jhana* very quickly, in seconds, and get out of it quickly too. Initially, at the lowest stage, it may take a while for one to realize that one is in a *jhana*.

22. The critical ingredient in getting to *magga phala* and *Ariya jhanas* is the understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. This is why I could not make any significant progress for about three years even though I was totally absorbed in learning Dhamma (I had retired).

- And that is why I emphasize that it is critical to find the true and pure Dhamma. Only a Buddha can find the way to *Nibbana* (or even *Ariya jhanas*) by himself; all others have to LEARN it from someone who had learned that correct version. That is why I was not able to make progress for a while, but quickly made progress once learning the correct concepts.
- No matter how intelligent one is, there is no way one can figure out the truth about nature by oneself, which is condensed into three words: *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.
- This is why it is a waste of time to try to “mold Buddha Dhamma” to one's liking: The Buddha said his Dhamma had never been heard before, i.e., it cannot be grasped with the “conventional, restricted mindset” that does not see the Three Characteristics of “this world”: *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.

Myths about Meditation

1. Once I attended a meditation retreat. Everyone was sitting down on the floor with crossed legs, but after a while many people “could not endure the pain” and were stretching their legs out or were fidgeting. It was obvious (to me) that many people could not think about anything else but their pain due to the uncomfortable posture. This went on for two days. Other than those who were long-time meditators and were comfortable with the lotus position, I do not believe the others enjoyed the retreat that much.

- Such nonsensical “rituals” are part of the set of wrong views (this particular one is included in “silabbata paramasa”), that one needs to remove before attaining the Sotapanna stage.
- It is helpful to think about the goal of meditation. **The ultimate goal is to remove greed, hate, and ignorance from our minds and to attain Nibbana.** But even for those who are just interested in achieving some “cooling down” from everyday stresses, it is the same fundamental idea that is at work: **We need to keep greedy, hateful, and ignorant thoughts from arising in our minds; the more we do that the more relaxed our minds will become.**
- Purification of the mind is the way to achieve temporary relief to the mind as well as to attain the Arahantship. **There is no one else monitoring one’s progress; it is one’s own mind that is keeping tabs on the progress.**
- When one does a “formal meditation”, one should sit in a comfortable position (it could be the lotus position for those who have practised it), because one could be in that position for several hours when one gets really good at it and starts enjoying the session. For most people, it is just sitting in a chair; one that is not too comfortable that one may fall asleep!

2. **Getting rid of bad thoughts can be and should be done ALL THE TIME.** The Buddha said, “bhāvanāya bahuleekathāya”, or “meditate as much as possible, whenever possible”. And he said it can be done in all possible postures: sitting, standing, walking, and lying down.

- Ven. Ananda is the only known person to attain the Arahantship while not in any of those four postures. He was making an all-out effort to become an Arahant before the first Dhamma Sangayana (Buddhist Council); only Arahants were able to attend and since he was only one who had memorized the whole of the sutta pitaka, it was critical that he attained Arahantship before that. The night before the Sangayana, he had been exhausted by the effort, but he was still thinking about a dhamma concept while getting into the bed. He sat down on the bed and raised his legs, to lie down; but before his head touched the pillow, that particular point came clear to him and the “Arahant phala citta” was realized.
- Another story from the Tipitaka that is also relevant to #1 above is about a minister of King of Kosala, named Santati. He was riding an elephant and the Buddha was walking on the road. The Buddha, with his supernormal powers, saw that Santati was capable of attaining the Arahantship and that he was going to die very soon. The Buddha delivered a discourse right there with Santati still on the back of the elephant, and he attained Arahantship. What really matters is whether someone can grasp the Dhamma, NOT what one’s posture is.

3. I have seen many meditation programs that describe Nibbana as removing perception or sanna from the mind.

- Many people wrongly advise that one needs to remove ALL THOUGHTS from one’s mind to

attain Nibbana. One time a Deva came to the Buddha and said the same thing: “Isn’t Nibbana attained via removing all thoughts?”. The Buddha said, “No. Nibbana is attained via removing greedy, hateful, and ignorant thoughts”. It is in the Manovarana Sutta, a brief description of which is available online: <http://www.dhammadownload.com/Tipitaka/read.php?id=210>

- Some others say that when a thought comes to the mind about a loved one, a place, or anything material, just to say “that does not really exist”. Just because the Buddha said everything changes at a rapid pace, he did not mean phenomena did not exist. Phenomena do not exist in a concrete sense either, because they are constantly changing. This is the same argument that we discussed in the “Concept of a Lifestream”: the Buddha rejected both “self” and “no-self”. All phenomena are based on paticca samuppada; they arise due to causes and are not there when the causes are absent.
- If one develops any type of samatha meditation (breath, kasina, rising of stomach, etc), AND attains an Anariya jhana at or above the fifth, then one may be born in the realm of asanna brahmas with no mind for very long times, only to come back to human plane and start the rebirth process all over.
- **All the above meditation techniques are dangerous. As one develops them one may become forgetful; sanna or perception is a critical mental factor associated with recognition of external objects. If one starts losing memory, that will be a sign that one is on the wrong path.**

4. An Arahant has not removed the capacity to generate thoughts OR perceptions. **An Arahant has removed greed, hate, and ignorance from the thoughts that arise.** Thoughts arise in him/her with sanna, i.e., he/she can identify people or things. They can experience the whole world just as any other human: they can see, hear, taste, smell, touch, or think about any place. The only difference is that they will not generate any greedy, hateful, or ignorant thoughts about anything that is experienced. The concept of Nibbana is very simple: “ragakkhayo Nibbanan, dosakkhayo Nibbanan, mohakkhayo Nibbanan”. (**Extinction of greed (or desire), hatred (or aversion, anger), ignorance (or delusion) gives rise to Nibbana.**)

5. And one CAN experience the “cooling down” as one makes progress on removing greed, hate, and ignorance, even before the Sotapanna stage. Instead of becoming forgetful, one’s mind will actually become more sharp and alert. One will be able to remember things BETTER, not less. One will become happier, not gloomy or depressed. **It is hard for normal people to fathom how much stress is associated with a mind that is burdened with greed, hate, and ignorance.**

- The “baseline” state of a normal human mind is heavily burdened. That is why people seek sense pleasure, basically to get some relief. But the problem is that such relief is temporary AND many people do immoral things to achieve such pleasures. So it can make things much worse: not only that one does not get permanent relief, but one will have to pay for the bad kamma that were accumulated by such immoral acts (lying, stealing, sexual misconduct, etc).
- This is why one can feel the relief right away when one starts living a “clean, simple life”. That should be the “base” for starting meditation. It is not possible to make any progress, no matter how much time one allocated to “meditation”, if one is engaged in immoral behavior; one needs to start reducing the BIG EIGHT.
- What the Buddha prescribed was simple, yet profound. As one clears the mind of the five hindrances (pancanivarana) via living a clean life AND start doing the proper Anapanasati bhavana, the progress will accelerate with time, because one’s mind start being able to see more

clearly. One will be able to easily grasp the real meaning of *anicca, dukkha, anatta*.

6. Another series of “desana” that I listened to described how an advanced meditator can actually “see” the “formation/breakup” of the material world; that person says that one could see the “impermanence” that is described in the “[Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)” post. He described how he got so afraid when the “world disappeared” momentarily before re-formation!

- It is true that all material phenomena have a lifetime of 17 thought moments, and that there are many billions of thought moments per second. **However, only a Buddha can actually “see” such a fast time scale.** The Buddha described to Ven. Sariputta such minute details in summary form, and it took Ven. Sariputta and his immediate followers hundreds of years to finalize a detailed description of mental/physical phenomena based on such information provided by the Buddha. This Abhidhamma was not finalized until the third Dhamma Sangayana (Buddhist Council); that is when the Abhidhamma pitaka of the Tipitaka became complete.

7. The problems with Mahayana teachings can be readily seen, since they have such apparent contradictions with the advances made in science and technology. However, some of the “fake teachings” that I mention in this post originated in Theravada countries, in particular in Sri Lanka. This is why it is critically important to learn pure Dhamma before or, at least while one is doing meditation.

- How can one follow the path of the Buddha without knowing the actual path? “[Bhāvanāya pahāthabbā](#)” or [removal of defilements via meditation comes AFTER “dassanena pahāthabbā” or removal of defilements due to wrong views via understanding the true Dhamma. This is also why Samma Ditthi is first and Samma Samadhi is last in the Noble Eightfold Path.](#)
- I highly encourage everyone to read as many posts as possible to learn Dhamma. Regardless of one’s familiarity with Buddha Dhamma, one should read those posts in the “Moral Living” section at least once, because they provide the foundation. I know from experience that if one does not get the basics right, it is harder to comprehend the related advanced material. Please send me comments if anything does not make sense.

8. In “weeding out” the bad approaches, a key point to understand is that there are many ways to “feel better”. A drug user can instantly get into a “relaxed state of mind” by taking a drug. We don’t do that because, (i) we know it is a temporary solution, AND (ii) it has very bad consequences.

- Getting “addicted to” anariya meditations like breath or kasina meditation is only somewhat better. There are many who get addicted to them because it does not have any bad consequences in this life; even though that may be true, it does have bad consequences for the long term because one is wasting one’s precious time in this human life on something that does not help in avoiding rebirth in the apayas.
- Just because one starts feeling better using a certain technique does not mean it is the THE solution. This is why one needs to look at the UNDERLYING BASIS of that approach. I have come across several groups where they are convinced of their “technique” because their experience got better. But as we just discussed, a “experience” does not rule out a “better experience” with the correct approach.
- **The only way to make a good judgement of “any theory” or “approach” is to critically examine it and see whether it can explain the realities that we see around us.** Can it explain why people are born different, why some live relatively better compared to others, why do only

some people get horrible diseases, why do animals experience pain but still cannot do anything about it (i.e., why they have limited minds)? Only pure Buddha Dhamma can explain all these and more.

9. Finally, once one looks at the evidence and decides on the Path, meditation can be “formal” or “informal”. In formal meditation, one allocates a time and place and it could be any of the following:

- Conventional sitting or walking meditation session. But this is not the only formal way to meditate.
- Listening to a Dhamma discourse delivered by an Ariya (one who has grasped *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*) is an excellent formal meditation session.
- **Reading (and contemplating) on a Dhamma concept, say *anicca*, is also formal meditation.** If it can be done when the mind is calm, one will grasp more.

10. Informal meditation can be done at any time, anywhere.

- **Merely thinking about a Dhamma concept or trying to clarify a Dhamma concept is meditation.** This can be done while lying in bed trying to fall asleep, waiting at the doctor’s office, riding a bus or subway, any time one has time that is normally spent day dreaming or generating greedy, hateful, or useless thoughts.

In all these cases, the five hindrances are suppressed and one can experience a calming effect, which can be extended to even samadhi if one’s mind becomes focused on the Dhamma concept. One could develop a habit of doing informal meditations. **But avoid doing that while driving or even when concentrating on a task at work! That WILL have very bad consequences. One needs to use wisdom (being mindful of consequences) while cultivating wisdom.**

Next, [“Is Suffering the same as the First Noble Truth on Suffering?”](#),

A Simple Way to Enhance Merits (Kusala) and Avoid Demerits (Akusala)

1. This is an important post that should be read carefully. Grasping the basic concept here can prevent many *akusala* kamma (unmeritorious deed) and also boost the power of a kusala kamma (meritorious deed). In addition, it shows the consistency and universality of Buddha Dhamma.
2. The potency of a kamma (good or bad) depends on two key factors. First we need to clarify some basic ideas.
 - Any action or speech originates as a “thought”. As described in the Abhidhamma section, a citta is of duration much less than a BILLIONTH of a second. Such fast thoughts do not even register in our minds. Once in a while a burst of cittas on a given object gets latched on and stays long enough to register in our minds. Then we consciously think about it and make a decision.
 - For example, when I walked to the kitchen to make a tea this afternoon, it started as what seemed to be a thought of “having a tea”. In reality that “thought” itself was due to billions of citta going through my mind; the initial “vague idea of having a tea” very quickly got built-up by numerous follow-up cittas until I had to get up and walk to the kitchen.
3. Most such “initial thoughts” just do not cascade into strong enough thoughts to make us to move physically or even to speak out. If the “impulse of the thought” (or ‘javana’) is not strong enough, we just disregard it.
 - If you think about it, you will realize that there are thousands, millions of stray thoughts that pass our minds each day. When we ride a bus just staring out of the window, we see zillion things go by and each thing seen is a thought. We do not remember most of it afterwards.
 - On the other hand, some impactful thoughts prompt us to instantaneous action or speech. Sometimes, we just stay on that stream of thoughts: some people laugh out loud just thinking about a happy event. Other times, if a thought about a hated person comes to the mind, one’s face getting dark and muscles get tightened.
 - A mother hearing her child cry out is literally lifted out of her seat instantaneously: But what happens there is, she hears the cry in a series of “citta vithi” of “thought streams” coming through the ear-door. Subsequently millions of “mind-door” citta vithi run within a fraction of second identifying that it is a crying sound, and it is coming from her child. Subsequently, millions more citta vithi start running trying to analyze what could be the problem, and then more citta vithi will prompt her to get out of the seat and move towards the source of that sound. All this happens within a fraction of second, without her consciously aware of it.
4. Not all thoughts on the same subject have the same kammic power.
 - If some insects get killed while someone is walking on the ground or while cleaning the house, that will have no kammic consequences; because the intention associated with those actions was not to kill any living being.
 - As we will see below, several key things contribute to the kammic power: the intention, what kind of knowledge is behind that intention, and whether one does the act enthusiastically are all key factors.
5. Now let us take an example to see how these different factors contribute to the strength of a kamma.

Suppose a person who does not know that stealing is a bad thing to do and that it will have bad consequences, steals something from a shop. Since he does it with wrong vision (*micca ditthi*) he does not have any remorse for it. Thus the kammic strength is very high.

- But if he does it on the urging or prompting by another, then it will have less strong kammic consequences, since he did not think about doing it on his own, and thus the “javana” or the “impulse power” of the *citta* is less strong.
- Now, if he comes up with the idea of stealing by himself, AND enjoys doing it, that is the worst.

6. So, now we can see different levels of kammic strengths associated with the SAME ACT of stealing:

- If done with wrong vision, with pleasure, and without prompting will have the highest strength.
- If done with wrong vision, with pleasure, and with prompting will have the next highest strength.
- If done with wrong vision, with neutral feeling, and without prompting will have the next highest strength.
- If done with wrong vision, with neutral feeling, and with prompting will have the next highest strength.

Now in the next four cases, the same act was done by person who did know that it was a bad act and it will have bad consequences would do it with at least some hesitation, and thus the “javana” or the “impulse of the thought” would be less, and consequently the kammic power will be less. So, now we have the last four cases:

- If done WITHOUT wrong vision, with pleasure, and without prompting will have the next highest strength. (the point is that the pleasure will be reduced, and one will be hesitant due to the knowledge that it is a bad act, thus reducing the javana power).
- If done WITHOUT wrong vision, with pleasure, and with prompting will have the next highest strength.
- If done WITHOUT wrong vision, with neutral feeling, and without prompting will have the next highest strength.
- If done WITHOUT wrong vision, with neutral feeling, and with prompting will have the least strength.

7. Thus it is clear that just having an understanding of Dhamma (that it is unfruitful to gain anything at the expense of other beings) will automatically make the kammic power less potent; but this “knowledge” is not the “book knowledge”; it is not effective if one has read about it but the mind has not really grasped it. Wisdom and “book knowledge” are two different things.

- If you think about it some, it should become clear that it is the comprehension of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* that leads to true knowledge (*panna*) and helps get rid of *avijja* (ignorance). It is understanding the true nature of this world, and that one’s actions are bound to have consequences.
- It works in the other way too. Good actions will lead to good results.

8. Thus the same kind of reasoning is true for meritorious acts (*kusala kamma*). There are eight

levels depending on whether one does meritorious act with/without knowledge, with joy/with neutral feeling, and without/with prompting just like in the case of the greed-based *akusala* citta. Let us take the case of someone making a donation to build a shelter for homeless people.

- This kusala kamma (meritorious deed) done with knowledge, with joy, and without prompting has the highest merit.
- And THE SAME kusala kamma done WITHOUT knowledge, with neutral feeling, and with prompting has the LEAST effectiveness.
- The intermediate six are just analogous to the ones for the greed-based *akusala* kamma.

9. Let us examine how these categories play out in the real world for the above mentioned meritorious act of building a shelter for the homeless:

- If someone understands the value of giving, does it out of the kindness felt for those homeless people, does it without wishing for anything in return, will be doing it with knowledge. And thus it will be done without prompting and with natural joy in the heart realizing that one is making a difference for many people's lives. This is the highest merit.
- If a person did the same deed, but initially it took some prompting from others or even him/herself, it was not spontaneous and thus will have somewhat less "javana" in the thought process.
- Those two scenarios without joy would have even less "javana" in the thought process. Here one may write a check and may not think much about it afterwards. But in the above two cases, the person may stay engaged with the act of building the shelter and gains joyful feeling everytime he/she thinks about it.
- Now, those four cases can be repeated for a person who does not understand the true impact of that act. The kammic power will be reduced accordingly. Thus a person who does not have an understanding of kammic consequences, the true nature of this world (i.e., that we all may go through such hard times or worse in other lives, etc), just writes a check out of necessity, may be even with the intention of getting some votes (i.e., prompting by oneself after seeing the benefits for one's political career) will have the least benefits.
- Thus understanding Dhamma (true nature of the world) leads to spontaneous meritorious actions done with a joyful heart; this leads to saddha (true faith) , citta pasada (joy), and adhimokkha (resolve) to get the maximum impact of the impulse kammic power (javana). Adhimokkha (resolve) is a key factor in the kusala-mula paticca samuppada, see, "[Kusala-Mula Paticca Samuppada](#)".

Notes:

1. There are two *akusala* kamma rooted in hate and two rooted in ignorance. The way to sort those are different. I will write another post on them.
2. This above description is a simpler version of a post that I did recently: "[Javana of a Citta – The Root of Mental Power](#)". It may be a good idea read that too.
3. The eight types of *akusala* citta are also discussed in "[Akusal Citta and Akusala Vipaka Citta](#)".

Is Suffering the Same as the First Noble Truth on Suffering?

The main goal of meditation before the Sotapanna stage is to understand the message of the Buddha. Before following the Path, one needs to comprehend what it is about. It is better to get into satipattana bhavana after one fully understands what is going to be done in satipattana bhavana. Many people waste a lot of time doing what they perceive to be satipattana bhavana, and do not get much benefit.

I will have several posts here that one could use for contemplation in meditation. When the mind calms down some, one should think about validity of what is discussed; understanding itself lead to getting rid of defilements. One can even reach the Sotapanna stage just via “*dassanena pahatabba*” or “removal via clear vision”.

1. Many people have misconceptions about the First Noble Truth on Suffering or Dukkha Sacca (pronounced “sachchä”). In one of the internet forums, I was asked two questions that embody many of such misconceptions about Buddha’s message.

- “I understand what the Buddha meant by suffering because I came down with this ailment. How do other people understand Buddha’s message and how do they find out about his message?”
- Then there was this question from apparently by a young person, “With so many pleasurable things around us with the innovations from science and technology, why do people need to think about suffering? Isn’t Buddha’s message kind of outdated?”

2. Before discussing them, it is clear that they both have good and bad implications.

- People at least search the internet and find out about Buddha Dhamma because of the first, and those who are “enjoying life to the fullest” may not even hear about Buddha Dhamma at all because of the second.
- On the other hand, the assertion is wrong in the first question, and is correct in the second at least on the surface.

3. **The Buddha never said that** “there are no sense pleasures to be had in this world”. On the contrary, he said people are unable to SEE the hidden suffering BECAUSE of the apparent sense pleasures they are enjoying OR those that are within reach even if not available to one right away.

- Even a poor person can see all the sense-fulfilling offers all around; even if he cannot access them at the moment, his thinking is “if I work hard, I can access all these pleasures at some point”. Thus whether rich or poor, all are “under the illusion of a sea of apparent pleasures” to be had.

4. Buddha Dhamma needs to be understood with wisdom. Wisdom (panna) is a mental factor (cetasika) that needs to be cultivated mostly by reading (or listening) about the Buddha’s world view first.

- Most people just PERCEIVE suffering through the mental factor (cetasika) of feeling (vedana), like the person who asked the first question above. One can experience suffering, but that is NOT the Noble Truth ON suffering.
- The second questioner had not EXPERIENCED much of suffering, and does not think he needs to pay any attention.
- **Both need to look at world with wisdom within the worldview of the Buddha to see the**

HIDDEN suffering. This CANNOT be done without understanding what the Buddha was saying about a more expansive and more complex world than what we experience with our six senses (of course one will not BELIEVE it unless one is convinced; the real conviction will come only if one gets familiar with the whole message).

5. In his first sermon, Dhamma Cakka Pavatta Sutta, the Buddha said this about his new message to the world: “*pubbe ananussutesu dhammesu*” or “a Dhamma that has never been known to the world”.

6. Everyone can and will experience suffering during this life; there is nothing NEW in that.

What is new in the message of the Buddha can be briefly stated as:

- There is a wider world out there with many more beings living in 29 more realms than the human and animal realms that we experience, AND the real suffering is in the lower four realms.
- This life is only a brief stop in our long journey through the cycle of rebirths called sansara.
- Even in this life, there is hidden suffering even when one seems to be enjoying life, AND there is real suffering at old age and death that is inevitable for everyone. This last part of course is apparent to anyone, but is not thought about much at all. As one gets old, when the real suffering starts the mind could be too weak to learn Dhamma.
- MOST IMPORTANT part of the Buddha’s message is the one that is least heard about; That there is permanent happiness to be had, and that CAN be attained during this very life.

7. I have several posts on the “bigger worldview of the Buddha” and also on rebirth, nature of kamma, etc. Also, there are several posts on the niramisa sukha which is a happiness of permanent nature to be had during this very life by following the Path advised by the Buddha.

- Let us take a brief look at the third point on the ‘hidden suffering’ with a couple of examples next.

8. Example 1: When a fish bites the bait, it does not see the suffering hidden in that action. Looking from the ground we can see the whole picture and we know what is going to happen to the fish if it bites the bait. But the fish is unable to see that whole picture, and thus does not see the hidden suffering. It only sees a delicious bit of food.

- In the same way, if we do not know about the wider world of 31 realms (with the suffering-laden four lowest realms), and that we have gone through unimaginable suffering in those realms in the past, we only focus on what is easily accessible to our six senses.

9. Example 2: Suppose someone makes you an offer. He says, “I will put you in one of the best resorts with all amenities paid for a month. But there is a catch. The food will taste great but will have traces of poison that will become effective in a few months and will lead to death within the year”.

Will anyone take the offer, knowing that it will lead to suffering and death? Of course not.

- But if the host did not tell them, they would not know, and will have a good time, but will have the same consequences.
- In the same way, we are enjoying the sense pleasures without knowing the consequences of them, especially if we did immoral things to get those pleasures.

10. Here is another thing to contemplate: We all have seen how a parent, a grandparent, or even an

unrelated celebrity from past years transforms from a dynamic, self-confident, and sometimes imposing character to a feeble, helpless person in the latter years. Sometimes they die under pathetic conditions that would have been unimaginable for them when they were young. **But this change is gradual, and even they do not realize it until it is too late.**

- When one becomes too old, it may be too late to start thinking about these facts; one needs to spend even a little time contemplating on these “facts of life” now. Not to get depressed about this inevitability, but to DO SOMETHING ABOUT IT; this will enable one to enjoy the latter days of life with niramisa sukha, even if no stage of Nibbana is attained.

11. Now, this DOES NOT MEAN one should get away from all sense pleasures even if one becomes convinced of the core message of the Buddha. Abandoning everything may have even worse consequences if it is not done with true understanding. And it takes time to digest the whole message. It has taken me several years to come the stage where I am now. I have not given up anything with remorse; I do not “miss” anything that I have given up. The only things one may want to “forcefully give up” are things that directly hurt other beings like killing, stealing, etc which most people don’t do anyway.

- Giving up sense pleasures comes gradually with understanding, when one sees the benefits of giving up.
- There is no need to rush into taking drastic actions. The urgent task is to GET STARTED. Allocate a little time each each day to learn Dhamma, preferably when the mind is a bit calmer so that one can focus and contemplate. As the Buddha said, this Dhamma is really different from what we are used to.

12. As one begins to understand the message of the Buddha, the learning process will become easier. What I hope to do with this site is to basically present all the background material that I have gone through, so others do not have to repeat it all. Of course you may want to do additional research; each one may be looking at things a bit differently. I will be happy to address any issues that are not discussed on the site yet.

13. In summary, the First Noble Truth on suffering is NOT to be EXPERIENCED as a feeling (vedana), but needs to UNDERSTOOD with wisdom (panna). Actually, when one is experiencing any form of suffering that makes it HARDER to grasp the meaning of the First Noble Truth. One needs a clear, calm, and healthy mind to grasp it.

A not-so-deep analysis of Dukkha Sacca is given in the post, [“Does the First Noble Truth Describe only Suffering?”](#)

A deeper analysis of the Dukkha Sacca is given in the next post, [The Incessant Distress \(“Peleema”\) – Key to Dukkha Sacca](#).

What is Samadhi? – Three Kinds of Mindfulness

1. *Samadhi* (“*sama*”+“*adhi*” where “*sama*” means “same” and “*adhi*” means “dominance”) means the object becomes the priority and the mind gets focused on it; as we discussed in many posts, when the mind becomes focused on one object (*arammana*), no matter what the object is, the *ekaggata cetasika* takes over and make the mind latched “on to it”.

- This is how one gets to not only *samadhi* but also *anariya jhana* using breath meditation, just by focusing the mind on the breath.
- One gets to *samadhi* on whatever the one gets absorbed, focused, or mindful in.
- Being mindful depends on the situation. The kind of mindfulness one has when driving a car needs to be different from the mindfulness needed to design something (or read a book), and the mindfulness needed to attain a *jhana* needs to be totally different from those two.

2. Thus it is good to distinguish three types of *samadhi* or mindfulness:

- Momentary mindfulness (*khanika samādhi*)
- Access mindfulness (*upacara*, pronounced “*upachāra*“, *samādhi*)
- Absorption mindfulness (*appanā samādhi*)

Let us discuss each type separately.

3. We should always have the **momentary mindfulness or *khanika samadhi***. Here we frequently change the focus from one object to another based on the need.

- We can use momentary mindfulness during the day when we are active. When we talk to someone, we should be mindful about what we say. The more one practices, one will be able to control one’s speech by being mindful. It is the same with any bodily act too. When we are about to cross the street, we should be mindful of the traffic, etc.
- Many people take this the wrong way, and use it as a formal meditation. It is kind of silly to do the wrong “walking meditation” by saying “lifting the foot”, “putting it down”, etc like a robot. This is what happens when Buddha’s true teachings get lost due to external influences.
- For example, when driving, we need to paying attention to the road and then to apply brakes if the car in front gets too close; we need to keep an eye on the traffic in general to be prepared to take action. Thus it is important to keep extraneous thoughts from the mind (such as an argument with a co-worker or the tasty food at the party yesterday). Thus focusing the mind on the job at hand here translates to shifting the focus to different tasks in an optimum way to get the job done.

4. **Access concentration (*uapacara samadhi*)** is more focused. When we are reading a book we get absorbed in it (if we really need to, or like to, comprehend the material); we cannot be thinking about other things while we read. But we may have to flip the page, or look up a reference while we read.

- On the supermundane (*lokottara*) side, when listening to a Dhamma discourse or reading about a Dhamma concept one can get into access concentration or *upacara samadhi*. [Reading a web post on a Dhamma concept, if done at a quiet time, can calm one down; if read with understanding and focused mind, it is possible to get into a somewhat deeper samadhi.](#)

- Someone writing a computer code, a surgeon doing a surgery, an architect designing a building, a scientist thinking about a new theory, a businessman thinking about a new business plan, all these involve access concentration (mindfulness). These are all mundane samadhi. But one can still feel a kind of in a trance if one really gets absorbed in any task.

5. **Appana samadhi or absorption in mindfulness** can lead to a *jhanic* state with practice. Here one needs to find a quiet place and need to close one's eyes and concentrate on just one object.

- In *Ariya* meditations, the focus is something related to Nibbana; could be a Dhamma concept or Nibbana itself (focusing on the peacefulness of discarding sense pleasures; this can be done only when one comprehends *anicca, dukkha, anatta*); *Ariya metta bhavana* is another.
- In *anairya* meditations, this object is normally either a kasina object or the breath or the falling/rising of the stomach.

6. Now let us look at some general features of the three types.

- It must be noted that for someone with practice, it is possible to get into *appana samadhi (jhana)* very quickly. Thus the difference among the three is not in the time scale, but rather on the goal or the situation at hand.
- Workplace or home accidents happen when one loses momentary mindfulness: one can pull the wrong switch or cut oneself while cutting vegetables, or even tripping while walking, when attention is not paid on the task at hand.
- One can be reading something for hours and not get anything in, if the mind wanders off. One can be sitting in meditation for hours and not get into samadhi if the mind wanders off.

7. In all these three types, achieving mindfulness is easier if the five hindrances are not covering the mind; see, "[Key to Calming the Mind – The Five Hindrances](#)".

- If one has greedy or hateful thoughts (*kamachanda* and *vyapada*), it is very difficult to do any of the three.
- If one's mind is lethargic (*thina middha*), or feeling agitated by being high-minded or low-minded (*uddacca kukkuccha*), or does not have a clear idea of the task (*vicikicca*), again even a simple task can become aggravating and frustrating.

8. Thus it helps to live a moral life, i.e., avoid the ten immoral acts as much as possible. And it pays off to make preparations ahead of the time.

- Especially for the *upacara* and *appana samadhi*, one could make sure to get other tasks out of the way beforehand, so that meditation does not have to be interrupted in the middle. Simple things like going to the bathroom and making sure one does not have full stomach before sitting down to meditate, can make a difference.
- Preliminary procedures such as reciting precepts or offering flowers or incense to the Buddha before a formal meditation session is also a part of "getting the mind ready". As we will discuss later, attaining "*citta pasāda*" or a "joyful mind" has a valid reason behind it.

9. Samadhi is actually the end point of being mindful (*sati*).

- *Samadhi* is a synonym for the *cetasika* (mental factor) of *ekaggata*, i.e., having a focus. One can cultivate it by being mindful the correct way, i.e., via *samma sati*.

10. Finally, it is also possible to get into *micca samadhi*, the opposite of *samma samadhi*. A master thief plotting a grand robbery, or a serial killer planning a killing, can get focused and be absorbed in that immoral plan too.

- Thus there are three kinds of *samadhi* when categorized according to morality: *micca samadhi* and two types of *samma samadhi*, one mundane (for living a better life) and one supermundane (focusing on *Nibbana*).

11. If this post is read by paying attention to the material, not just scanning through it, one could get into *upacara samadhi*; one may need to read related posts or other material and/or stop reading and contemplating on a given point, etc. to absorb the material. When the mind gets “absorbed in the issue”, it is in a state of *samadhi*. Of course, that is possible only if the material is interesting for oneself.

- If correctly done, one will have a lower heartbeat, and a calmer and peaceful mind, by the time the reading session is done. People have attained even *magga phala* by attentively listening to Dhamma discourses.

Panca Indriya and Panca Bala – Five Faculties and Five Powers

1. These are included in the 37 factors of Enlightenment; see, [“37 Factors of Enlightenment”](#).
2. “*Indriya*” means leader; a leader has power or “*Bala*”. Thus these two sets of five factors each are very important in following the Noble Eightfold Path.
 - The five mental faculties (*indriya*) are *saddha* (faith), *viriya* (effort), *sati* (mindfulness), *samadhi* (concentration), and *panna* (wisdom), and there are five corresponding powers (*Bala*).
 - Eye, ear, nose, tongue, and the body are the five physical faculties (*indriya*). They are leaders in providing access to seeing, hearing, smelling, tasting, and touching. The *panca indriya* are the “mental” leaders helping with comprehending Dhamma.
3. Let us first discuss the five faculties.
 - ***Saddha*** is foremost; without faith (*saddha*), one does not have the conviction to follow the Path. However, faith has to be based on wisdom (***panna***), i.e., one’s faith is built upon seeing the truth of Buddha Dhamma, at least partially.
 - Blind faith is actually a hindrance to progress, since one will be following the wrong path. Furthermore, blind faith will not last long, since it is on a shaky foundation. *Saddha* of a *Sotapanna* is unshakeable, and will never be lost or even reduced.

Thus we can see the *saddha* and *panna* need to progress together.

4. When *saddha* and *panna* is developed to a certain extent (before the *Sotapanna* stage), one realizes the fruitlessness and the dangers of the *sansaric* journey. Thus one is motivated to make an effort (***viriya***).

Furthermore, one realizes that one needs to be mindful in one’s actions, and thus ***sati*** (mindfulness) starts to build. One realizes that one has to act with *yoniso manasikara*.

At the same time, one realizes that when the mind is not calm, one can make bad decisions; thus one starts working on calming the mind and to attain a level of concentration (***samadhi***). Concentration is not really a good translation for *samadhi*; one does not need to force concentration; rather *samadhi* comes about when one takes precautions to not to get into “bad situations”; see, [“What is Samadhi? – Three Kinds of Mindfulness”](#).

5. [Different people have the five faculties developed to different degrees \(developed in this life AND also carried from previous lives\), and normally one could stand out.](#) The Buddha has shown the following way to identify the predominance of different faculties in a person.

- If someone has a relatively more developed *saddha*, that person is likely to be peaceful and helpful to others with a kind heart. He/she will have no trouble in following the first precept of not harming any other being.
- Then there are people who can easily bear hardships and are very determined; they have a developed *viriya* (effort) *indriya*. They can easily keep the second precept (not taking what is not given), and be satisfied with one earns by one’s hard work.
- Those who do not pursue sense fulfilment aggressively have less *kamachanda* and are not likely to have any problems with the third precept. They are likely to have a developed mindfulness (*sati*) faculty.

- When the *samadhi* indriya is strong, that person is likely to be quiet and does not like to engage in idle chatter; thus keeping the fourth precept on right speech will be easy for them.
- Someone with *panna* (wisdom) will be able to comprehend *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* easily and thus to realize the fruitlessness and the dangers of the *sansaric* journey. Such a person will be able to keep the hardest fifth precept on controlling the mind; see, “[The Five Precepts – What the Buddha Meant by Them](#)”.

6. [Once one identifies the strong faculty, one should try to exploit that to move forward; the other faculties always pitch in to help, so they will grow too.](#) It is important to cultivate all five faculties until they become powers (*bala*), [but one needs to exploit the predominant one.](#)

- If someone tells a child, “this is not your actual Mom; she is somewhere else”, the child will not only refuse to believe that but will run to the mother and give a hug just to show how confident he is. In the same way, *saddha* based on *panna* can only make one’s resolve be strengthened by obstacles.
- For example, when one does not have *saddha*, one can be influenced to change the course by an outside influence. But if *saddha*, built on *panna*, is strong no matter how strong the influence is one’s faith will not be shaken.
- The Buddha gave a simile to understand the how indriya can become *bala* to overcome difficulties: When a river runs into an obstacle like a large boulder, it splits and goes around it, and merge together after the obstacle. But the indriya needs to be strong enough to do that.
- When *indriya* (faculties) are strengthened, they become *bala* (powers).

7. When the faculties are being cultivated, it is important to try to balance them, while utilizing the predominant faculty’s power.

- Some people have *panna* and may say, “it is useless to take precepts or chant “*Tisarana*” or chant/listen to *suttas*; it is better to learn Dhamma”. But those activities do help in getting the mind to be receptive Dhamma; see, “[Buddhist Chanting](#)”.
- On the other hand, just reciting those verses is not enough. In order to recite them with understanding, one needs to learn Dhamma and cultivate *panna*.
- Normally, *saddha* and *panna* go together and needs to be balanced. Similarly, *viriya* (effort) and *samadhi* (concentration) need to be balanced. For example, when doing formal meditation, too much of an effort can be a drawback for *samadhi*. As the Buddha told Sona the musician, the strings on a violin need to be just right, not too tight and not too loose.
- *Sati* (mindfulness) must be leading and must always be there.
- *Sati* can be compared to the steering wheel of a car; *saddha* and *panna* can be compared to one set wheels, and *viriya* and *samadhi* can be compared to the other set of wheels. The wheels must be in balance and the steering wheel must be kept at correct position all the time for the car to go forward. If the wheels are not balanced, the car will just go in circles; if the steering wheel is not managed, the car will go off the road.

8. These five (*saddha*, *viriya*, *sati*, *samadhi*, *panna*) are *cetasika* (mental factors). They help define one’s character (*gathi*) for the better, and these five are important ones to “take in” or “*āna*” in *anapana sati*.

9. The five faculties exercise control in their respective domains: *saddha* in the domain of *adhimokkha* (decision or resolve), *viriya* in *paggaha* (exertion), *sati* in *upatthāna* (awareness), *samādhi* in *avikkhepa* (non-distraction), and *panna* in *dassana* (view or vision). When they become *bala* (powers) , they become unshakable by their opposites – indecision, laziness, negligence, agitation, and delusion or ignorance.

- It is important to realize the value of *citta pasada* (joy) and *adhimokkha* (resolve) that results from *saddha* based on true understanding: *adhimokkha* is an intermediate step in *Kusala-mula paticca samuppada* on the way to Nibbana, see, “[Kusala-Mula Paticca Samuppada](#)“.
- Also, *citta pasada* and *adhimokkha* that arise in doing meritorious acts with joy in the heart are key to optimizing the merits; see, “[A Simple Way to Enhance Merits \(Kusala\) and Avoid Demerits \(Akusala\)](#)“, and “[Javana of a Citta – The Root of Mental Power](#)“.

10. The five indriya become five *bala* and are well balanced only for an *Arahant*. We can reap many benefits even before reaching that ultimate goal by cultivating them, making sure to try to keep them balanced.

- Even for an *Arahant*, there are some leftover “imperfections” even though they are not defilements; these are some “hard-to-get-rid-of” quirks in personal behavior. For example, there is this story about a very young Arahant who had the habit of jumping over puddles instead of going around them; he had been born a monkey for many lives in the recent past and had carried that habit over to this life.
- Only a *Samma Sambuddha* (like Buddha Gotama) is perfect even every respect. This is why he is called “*tatagatha*” (“*thatha*” for “what should be” or the “real nature”; pronounced “*thathagatha*“).

Abhidhamma

“[Abhidhamma – Introduction](#)”

“[Citta and Cetasika – How Vinnana \(Consciousness\) Arises](#)”

“[What is a Thought?](#)”

“[What is in a Thought? Why Gathi are so Important?](#)”

“[Javana of a Citta – The Root of Mental Power](#)”

“[Cuti-Patisandhi – An Abhidhamma Description](#)”

Abhidhamma – Introduction

1. “*Abhi*” means “higher” or “deeper”. Thus *abhidhamma* can be considered a more deeper, fundamental description of Buddha Dhamma.

- The end result is the same when compared with the material in the *suttas*, but *abhidhamma* provides a “bottom up” description of the existence, starting with 82 “most basic units” within the four ultimate entities of *citta*, *cetasika*, *rupa*, and *Nibbana*. This is a monumental task and that is why it took almost 250 years to finalize it at the third Buddhist Council.
- The 81 “basic units” that make up this world are 1 **pure *citta***, 52 *cetasika*, and 28 types of *rupa*. Depending on the combinations of *cetasika* that arise with *citta*, there will be 89 (or 121) types **contaminated *citta*** (or *vinna*) that can arise. This will become clear as we discuss further.

2. In the *suttas*, the Buddha explained the Dhamma concepts using everyday language. **And it is possible for most people to attain *Nibbana* without knowing anything about *Abhidhamma*.**

Let us take an example of making a cake:

- All one needs to know are the ingredients and how to mix them and proper procedure to bake it. That is what is done with the *suttas*.
- However, *abhidhamma* approach is comparable to starting at the atomic level of the ingredients, and then describing how those fundamental entities can combine to make flour, oil, eggs, etc and WHY those need to be mixed in a certain way, and WHY it all need to be baked at a certain temperature.
- It is truly mind boggling what *abhidhamma* can accomplish.

3. *Abhidhamma* provides the complete, consistent description of the whole existence (encompassing the 31 realms). With this description there can be no unexplained phenomena at any level. A logician like the late Dr. Kurt Gödel could have a great time with it; see, “[Gödel’s Incompleteness Theorem](#)”.

- The scope of *abhidhamma* can be appreciated to a certain extent by looking at what the scientists are trying to do with a Grand Unified Theory to describe the behavior of inert matter. Einstein devoted the latter part of his life to develop one and failed, and the scientists are still far from achieving it. And even if it is attained, it will be able to describe ONLY the behavior of inert matter, not the behavior of living beings, let alone the 31 realms of existence.

4. [Abhidhamma is the Grand Unified Theory of the Buddha](#). I gave an introduction to it in the post, “[Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”. In this *Abhidhamma* section I will try to give further details. My goal to is to describe it in an easy-to-grasp simple manner.

- When I taught physics to undergraduate students, I told them not to memorize anything, but to grasp the essence of the material. Many students (and adults) try to memorize descriptions of a concept, but have no idea how to apply the concept. I used to give them all the complex equations and any other hard-to-memorize material in the tests; what they needed to do was to apply them in solving problems.
- My approach is the same here. For example, all different types of *cittas* are listed in the “[Tables and Summaries](#)”; there is no need to memorize them. What I want to do is for someone to be able to understand a given Dhamma concept starting from the basics: for example, which *cittas* are immoral and can lead one to rebirth in the *apayas* and WHY.
- Dhamma can make one addicted to it, as I have become addicted to it. When one starts to grasp

how this complex world really works, understanding even a bit of it can bring joy to the heart.

5. However, I must say that even if one can memorize the whole of the *Abhidhamma* theory, one WILL NOT understand the Buddha's message **unless one understands the true meanings of *anicca, dukkha, anatta***.

- *Abhidhamma* can solidify and “fill-in-the-blanks” of Buddha Dhamma from the *suttas*, which can be exhilarating.
- On the other hand, I had so many unresolved questions on parts of *abhidhamma* until I listened to the first *desana* from one of my two teachers *Theros* almost a year ago, on July 30, 2013, on *anicca, dukkha, anatta*. It was like lifting a fog, and by the end of that *desana* I knew I will be able to “fill-in-the-blanks” to make my understanding much better.

6. Now to give a brief background on how the *abhidhamma pitaka* of the *Tipitaka* was developed over roughly 250 years by the lineage of *bhikkhus* started with Ven. Sariputta: Ven. Sariputta was one of the two chief disciples of the Buddha: While Ven. Moggallana excelled in supernatural powers, Ven. Sariputta excelled in Dhamma. He was only second to the Buddha in Dhamma knowledge.

- The minute details on the structure of a *citta vithi* (a basic thought process) of 17 thought moments, with each *citta* lasting sub-billionth of a second, can be seen only by a Buddha. The Buddha described such minute details to Ven. Sariputta, and it was Ven. Sariputta and his group of *bhikkhus* (and their subsequent lineage) that completed the monumental task of making a complete description of Dhamma theory starting with the fundamental entities.
- As I mentioned earlier, this is a million times more complex task than putting together a Grand Unified Theory to explain the behavior of inert matter, as scientists are attempting to do today. Because a living being has an inert body, but a complex mind which makes that inert body “alive”.
- Only a framework of the theory was recited at the First Buddhist Council just three months after the *Parinibbana* of the Buddha. More was added at the second Council, and the task was completed only at the third Council. It was this completed *Tipitaka* that was written down in 29 BCE at the Fourth Buddhist Council.
- A common misconception stated in many books is that *Abhidhamma* was “invented” by *bhikkhus* after the *Parinibbana* of the Buddha. The minute details of the very fast *citta vithi* are discernible only to the mind of a Buddha.
- It is important to realize that even the last part of the *Abhidhamma Pitaka* was compiled by *Arahants* at the Third Council, and the whole *Tipitaka* was also written down by *Arahants* at the Fourth Council. The absence of *Arahants* (in significant numbers) started around the second century CE, and coincided with the rise of Mahayana and the “contamination” of *Theravada* which culminated in the *Visuddhimagga* of Buddhaghosa; see, “[Historical Timeline of Edward Conze](#)”.
- As we discuss more topics, it will become clear that only *Arahants* with superior mental power can compile such a complex work in the absence of an easy way of recording, let alone having access to computers.

7. I have given a breakdown of the *abhidhamma pitaka* in the post, “[Preservation of Dhamma](#)”.

8. There is a section “Mind and Consciousness” under “Dhamma Concepts”. It is a good idea to read the posts there before reading further in the *Abhidhamma* section; “[Thoughts \(Citta\), Consciousness \(Vinnana\), and Mind \(Hadaya Vatthu\) – Introduction](#)”.

REFERENCES

1. “A Comprehensive Manual of Abhidhamma”, by Bhikkhu Bodhi (2000); this is a revised and updated version of Ref. 2 below.
2. “A Manual of Abhidhamma”, by Narada Thero (1979).
3. “[Buddha Abhidhamma – Ultimate Science](#)“, by Dr. Mehm Tin Mon; this is a very good FREE publication (click the link to open the e-book).

Unfortunately, some concepts in all three references are not correct: in particular the incorrect interpretations of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, come into play as in almost all existing *Theravada* texts (except the *Pali Tipitaka* of course). **Also, *anariya jhanas* using *kasinas* and breath meditation are presented as Buddhist meditation in all three.** I will try to point out such problems in relevant posts. Next, “[Citta and Cetasika – How Vinnana \(Consciousness\) Arises](#)“,

Citta and Cetasika – How Vinnana (Consciousness) Arises

When one learns *Abhidhamma* one can see why both “self” and “no-self” concepts were rejected by the Buddha. A “living being” is a momentarily changing entity. It is not possible to say “it does not exist”, because it obviously does exist; it is just that it continuously evolves ON ITS OWN PATH determined by “*gathi*” at each stage. Thus until *parinibbana* is attained, there is a “dynamic self” which has its own identity or personality or “*gathi*” which also evolve.

- It may be a good idea to read at least the introductory post on the *manomaya kaya* before reading this post: “[Manomaya Kaya – Introduction](#)”.

1. A living being experiences the “world out there” in a series of very fast “snapshots”; it grasps the “world” in a snapshot called a *citta* (pronounced “chiththa”) that lasts much less than a billionth of a second. As soon as the mind sees that “snapshot”, it is gone. But the mind gives us an illusory sense of a permanent “world”, **by combining that “snapshot” with our past memories as well as our hopes for the future.** Let us see how this process is described in *Abhidhamma*.

- The mind does this with the help of a *cetasika* (pronounced “chethasika”) in that *citta* called *manasikara*. We will discuss this later, but I am just trying to get across the basic idea.

2. The name *citta* came from “*chitra*”, the name for a painting in *Pali* or *Sinhala*. A pure *citta* has only 7 mental factors (*cetasika*). *Cetasika* provide “colors for the picture”, so to speak.

- But the 7 *cetasika* that are in each and every *citta* (universal *cetasika* or “*sabba citta sadharana cetasika*”) may be considered “colorless”. A pure *citta* is like a blank sheet of paper on which these “snapshots” are imprinted.
- There are a set of 14 “bad *cetasika*” and a set of 25 “good *cetasika*”. For a rough visual we may think of the “bad *cetasika*” as dark colors (black, brown, etc), and the “good *cetasika*” as pleasant colors such as green or yellow. Then there are 6 other “occasionals” that are also “colorless” and those can arise with either good or bad *cetasika*; see, “[Cetasika \(Mental Factors\)](#)”.
- *Cetasika* arise with a *citta*, decay with a *citta*, and take the same object (*arammana*) as the *citta*. But a given *citta* has either good OR bad *cetasika*; they do not mix.
- And a *citta* is of very short duration; it lasts much less than a billionth of a second; see, “[What is a Thought?](#)”.

2. Therefore, we can visualize each “moment of awareness” of the outside world by the mind as a very quick snapshot. [As soon as it comes, it is gone.](#)

Then how does our mind see the outside world as “permanent”? and also a given situation as ‘good’ or ‘bad’? When we look out we see mountains that have been there for thousands of years. People get old, but they are around for years and years. Also, two people could look at the same thing and perceive it differently (one as “good” and one “bad”).

- This “trick” is done by two of the universal *cetasika*: *manasikara* and *cetana*.
- As we discussed in other posts, a record of the “snapshot” that decays is permanently recorded in the mental plane, and these records are called *nama gotta*; see, “[Difference Between Dhamma and Sankhara \(Sankata\)](#)”.
- In the same way, our hopes and visions for the future are also in the mental plane. Of course the

past *nama gotta* are permanent while the imprints for the future keep changing. The *manasikara cetasika* brings in memories from the past and hopes for the future into the current *citta*, thus a “permanent like” view of the world is composed by the *cetana cetasika*, which is responsible for “putting together a *citta*”.

- Furthermore, in one person, “good” *cetasika* may arise due to a sense input, but if the “*gathi*” of the other person is opposite, a set of “bad” *cetasika* may arise in the other person. The *cetana cetasika* combines them to form a “good” or a “bad” awareness.

3. It is basically the same kind of process happens when we see, hear, taste, smell, touch, or think; let us explain the concept for vision.

- The basic sequence of events in capturing any “input” via the five physical senses was described in “[Manomaya Kaya – Introduction](#)”.
- If we keep looking at a picture on the wall, nothing changes because it is a static picture.
- Now let us think about what happens when we look at a water fountain. Since there is wind and other disturbances, we can see some changes, but the water fountain looks like a sort of a solid object. But what we see is a composite of trillions of water particles rising and falling each second. We do not “see” that but just the appearance of a “sort of solid object with a certain shape” as formed by the water nozzles. Here the *manasikara* and *cetana cetasika* help the mind put together a “composite” of what happened a few seconds ago and what is happening now to give a more or less solid appearance.
- Same thing happens in seeing a continuous “ring of fire” when one swirls a light in a circular motion. At a given moment, the light is at a fixed position (a “data packet sent by the brain to the mind shows the light at one point on the circle), but if we move the light fast enough, the mind keep seeing the light moving to successive points on the circle and we see a “composite picture” in the shape of a continuous ring of light.

4. Another example is a motion picture. When making a movie, what is actually done is to take many many static pictures and then play them back at fast enough speed. If the playback speed is too slow, we can see individual pictures, but above a certain “projection rate”, it looks like real motion. Here is a video that illustrates this well:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?feature=player_embedded&v=V8A4qudmsX0

5. When we see the outside world, what happens is very similar to the above. At the end of the video it is stated that the “movie” we see is an illusion, **and as the Buddha explained, that holds for real life as well**. In real life when we see someone coming towards us, what we actually see is a series of “static pictures” or *citta* projected at a very fast rate in our minds, giving us the illusion of a “movie like experience”.

- Even though in the above video it is suggested that all the information from the “previous static frames” were put together by the brain, that is true only to a certain extent.
- The brain does put together the individual frames, but without actual “memories” it is not possible to get the deep details about what is seen.
- We not only “see” the video, but we also RECOGNIZE what is seen (we identify a given actor, we can even remember previous movies with that actor, we KNOW all about the scenes in the background, etc); to have all that information instantly available to the brain is not possible.

This is a point that needs a lot of thought.

- What happens according to *Abhidhamma*, is that the brain periodically sends packets of acquired data put together by the cortex in the brain to the *hadaya vatthu*, which is basically the seat of the mind. There *citta vithi* arise in accepting that information from the brain, and it is the mind that does all the compiling (with the help of the *manasikara* and *cetana cetasika*) and that is how we EXPERIENCE it.
- I will go into more details later, but those are the key points.

6. We need to keep in mind that all animals have this capability too. A dog basically sees its environment just like we do and instantly recognizes the objects in the picture. Even an ant does too, even though its “world” is much more limited. Think about how a tiny ant can process all that information that allows it to move in a reasonable fast pace in hunting for food; it knows its territory, certain smells, and also remembers how to get back to its nest. All that information is NOT in that tiny body of an ant. More things to think about!

7. In the above video, it is shown that the slowest projection rate where the brain seems to processing data is about 20 frames per second; this correspond to a data packet of about 50 millisecond duration. This is consistent with a recent findings from MIT that says the *minimum* time needed is about 20 milliseconds: [Detecting Meaning in Rapid Pictures-Potter-2014 \(PDF file\)](#).

- This is consistent with the Abhidhammic picture of the brain capturing segments of visual data and transmitting that information to the *hadaya vatthu*, which is the “mind door”, via the *cakkhu pasada* that is located on the *manomaya kaya* close to the *hadaya vatthu*.
- Even though *Abhidhamma* does not mention how long the brain captures visual data for a “seeing event” before sending to the *hadaya vatthu*, it does say that this information is now converted by the brain to a format suitable for transmission to the *hadaya vatthu*, and is sent there via a “ray system”, which is extremely fast. I assume that this encoded information is sent at the speed of light and thus get to the *hadaya vatthu* (which is located on the *manomaya kaya*, but is close to the heart) almost instantaneously.

8. Of course we not only see things, but we also hear, smell, taste, touch, and think other thoughts all at the SAME TIME, it seems.

Even though the “sensing rate” is limited by the relatively slow processing speed of the brain (which appear to be in the millisecond time scale according to current scientific studies mentioned above), it is still more than fast enough for us to experience simultaneity in all sense inputs.

9. Since the scientific studies on the “minimum duration of a detectable event” are still at early stages (see #7 above), we may be able to put together a more precise sequence of events in the future. Yet we have enough data to put together a qualitative picture of what happens.

- This is an excellent example of how science can help us “fill in the blanks” of the overall picture that the Buddha provided; of course it was impossible for him to convey the magnitudes of these time scales 2500 years ago.
- Once the Buddha was in a *Simpasa* forest near *Kosambi*, and he took a few leaves into his hand and told the *bhikkhus*, “what I have taught you compared to what I know is like these few leaves compared to the leaves in this forest; but what I have taught you is more than enough for you to attain *Nibbana*”.

- Thus even though modern science can provide us with details about the “big picture” of the Buddha, and we should be grateful to all those scientists for that knowledge, we should use that knowledge wisely and should not get carried away in spending too much time on such details.

Next, “[What is a Thought?](#)“,

What is a Thought?

There are many confusing terms in *Abhidhamma* like *citta* and *mano* which have been differently interpreted in different books. In order to clarify these concepts, I am writing a few posts in “Dhamma Concepts” section under “Mind and Consciousness” starting with: “[Thoughts \(Citta\), Consciousness \(Vinnana\), and Mind \(Hadaya Vatthu\) – Introduction](#)”. I highly recommend reading those, and especially, “[Vinnana, Thoughts, and the Subconscious](#)”.

1. In Buddha Dhamma, a thought or a *citta* (pronounced “chiththa”), is the briefest moment of awareness experienced by a sentient being. In *Abhidhamma* it says that there are well over billion of *citta* in the blink of eye.

- Let us keep in mind that a *citta* is much smaller than a billionth of a second.

2. A *citta* only has seven *cetasika* (*phassa, sanna, vedana, cetana, ekaggata, jivitindriya, and manasikara*) in it; see, “[Cetasika \(Mental Factors\)](#)”. Thus it is the purest form a “thought”, but it is too brief for anyone to experience.

- **The first thing to note is that one will never be able to experience a single thought if we mean by a thought to be a *citta***, even though we say, “I just had a thought”. **The briefest awareness that we actually experience is probably a fraction of a second**; Scientists say it is about 20 milliseconds. But that 20 millisecond time is mostly spent by the brain in processing the sense input; one that is done a series of *citta* with 17 *cittas* flow in a very brief time (less than a billionth of a second), and that is what is registered in the mind. We will discuss this later in detail.
- This series of *citta* with 17 *cittas* is called a *citta vithi* (pronounced “chiththa veethi”); see below.
- Even a single *citta* has three phases: *uppada* (rising), *thithi* (reached peak but still changes), and *bhanga* (dissolution). Thus a *citta* arises and fades away very fast.
- **Only a Buddha can see such details as I pointed out in the Introduction.** Even people with highest *abhinna* powers (attained via *jhanas*) cannot even come close to seeing such details.
- This is why *Abhidhamma* is a special section of Buddha Dhamma that needs to taken “as is”, i.e., we just have to believe what the Buddha said. We cannot hope to verify these details by our own experience (for example that there are a certain number of *citta* in a *citta vithi* as discussed below). Yet, *Abhidhamma* is very valuable in clarifying any issue down to the minute detail.

3. A pure *citta* with 7 *cetasika* does not last. Even though it starts as such a pure *citta*, within the duration of the *citta* itself (less than a billionth of a second), it gets contaminated by either a set of bad *cetasika* like *lobha* (greed), *issa* (envy) or a set of good *cetasika* like *saddha* (faith) and *sati* (mindfulness).

- Before it starts decaying, it goes through NINE STAGES to become *vinnakkandhö* (this is NOT the aggregate as in the common usage of *vinnakkhandha*; rather, here the mind has coupled the information in the previous stages of this *citta* with past *vinnana* and future *vinnana* that are in the mind and has made a “composite”).
- **However, the convention is to call this whole process still a *citta*.**
- All this happens in less than a billionth of a second! This process keeps repeating in the *citta* to

follow and the process is cumulative, i.e., as more and more *citta* flow by, the *awareness of the event* gets stronger, and we actually begin to feel it.

4. Thus what we experience is the cumulative effect of billions of *citta*. That is why the Buddha talked about *kandhas* (which means “heaps” in Pali or Sinhala) as in “heaps” of feelings (*vedanakkhandha*), perceptions (*sannakkhandha*), volitions (*sankharakkhandha*), and consciousness (*vinnanakkhandha*); those are the “heaps” that we actually experience in a “thought”.

- If *citta* fly by that fast, and captures six kind of possible “inputs” (through the five physical senses and the mind itself), how do we “experience” seeing, hearing, etc “at the same time” but still sort them out?

5. This is because the mind is the most powerful entity in this world. All five physical senses just provide traces of inputs (“memory imprints”), and billions of them arise and perish each second. The mind keeps a record of all past events and **MAKES A COMPOSITE SENSE EXPERIENCE** moment-by-moment.

- For example when we hear someone say “apple”, even the letter “a” is comprehended by the mind via billions of *citta*; then “p” is captured, and by that time “a” sound is gone from the ear.
- When it has captured the whole word, “apple”, the mind automatically matches that with all the past memories and instantly produces an awareness or a mental picture of an apple; **past memories as well as hopes for future are recalled by the *mansikara cetasika* and the *citta* is “put together” by the *cetana cetasika*.**
- Now the mind “knows” what that person was referring to, and has a mental image of an apple.
- If someone hears the word, “lemon”, one could even feel the sour taste of lemon; the mind brings it back from the past memories.
- Even if we see just the outline of a familiar person at a distance, the mind “fills in the blanks” and flashes an image of that person in your mind so you know who it is.

6. The mind is capable of processing multiple inputs (received via the five senses), and also carry out its own mental processes (thinking and coming to conclusions about what is perceived through the five senses by comparing it with past memories) such a fast speed, that it appears to be done in “real time”.

7. Actually, one sensory “event” does not happen in one *citta*. (from one of the five physical senses is captured not by a single *citta*, but by a string of *cittas* with 17 *cittas* in it; this “string of *cittas*” is called a *citta vithi* (pronounced “chiththa veethi”). A *citta vithi* for “seeing” is referred to as a *citta vithi* at the “eye door” or the eye, one for “hearing” occurs at the “ear door” or the ear, etc.

- When one *citta vithi* provides a sensory input, that information is then processed by three *citta vithis* that involves only the mind; this *citta vithi* “at the mind door” is variable; it has around 12 *citta* normally. But in a *jhana samapatti*, which is solely a mind door process, there can be a very large number of *citta* without interruption.
- Thus there are two types of *citta vithi* involved in processing a sensory input: a long one with 17 *citta* to CAPTURE an input from one of the five physical senses (*pancadvara*) AND three *manodvara citta vithi* (at the mind door) with about 12 *citta*. Both types are thus involved in cognition (awareness) processes; there are other processes by the mind that we will discuss

later.

- Only one *citta vithi* runs at a given time; they do not overlap.

8. Thus it is mind boggling if we try to imagine the frantic pace the mind works at. At this point, it may be a good idea to look at an analogy to simplify things a bit.

- A movie is generated by a series of static pictures. When a movie is projected on a screen, static pictures are projected at a rate of about 30 frames a second, and we see the movie as a continuous progression of events; if the projection rate is low, we can see it frame by frame or as “packets of information” separately. When we watch the movie, we do not perceive those static pictures or “packets of information”, but we perceive a continuous progression without any gaps.
- In the same way, when we perceive that our mind is hearing a word, but in reality that word is the result of many *citta vithi* originated at the ear door; and the scene that appears simultaneous is the composite of many *citta vithi* coming through the eye door and none of it happens “at the same time”.
- Just like the movie projected at 30-50 frames a second, *citta vithi* are generated at many frames a second. (I had previously mentioned billions of *cittas* and that is not correct; the flow of *citta vithi* is subsided by the processing time of about 20 milliseconds needed by the brain to process each each sense input). Thus we feel that we are watching, hearing, tasting, smelling, touching, and thinking all at the same time.
- **To repeat for emphasis:** Our minds processes probably less than 100 *citta vithi* per second. However, each *citta vithi* with 17 *citta* (for five sense inputs) or about 10 *citta* (for mind inputs) and each of those *citta vithi* take less than billionth of a second. Even though it takes the brain to process a sense input about 20 milliseconds or so, that information is grasped by the mind in less than a billionth of a second.

9. Just like a movie reel, there is actually a tape (not a physical one) that is recorded in our mind as it captures all this information at a frantic speed; this is the origin of the “*nama gotta*” discussed in, [“Difference Between Dhamma and Sankhara”](#). That tape is there forever, and allows one with *abhinna* powers to look back to any time in the past.

- Therefore in order to verify rebirth or to look at really old memories, all one needs to do is to develop *abhinna* powers!

10. **And there are different kinds of consciousness (*vinnana*), and we will discuss these in another post.** There is only one *citta* at a time. But there is memory, as we just discussed. And that memory is normally hidden because the mind is covered up by the defilements, and when one develops *abhinna* powers what one is really doing is to clean up the mind so everything becomes clear.

- One who develops *abhinna* powers through *anariya jhanas* just let the gunk settle at bottom and see just the upper layers; but one who has developed *abhinna* powers through *Ariya jhanas* is doing that by “cleaning up” the gunk so a much more penetration to deeper past is possible; see, [“Solution to a Wandering Mind – Abandon Everything?”](#).

11. Thus any of individual sense experiences is VERY BRIEF (the duration of a *citta vithi*). **It is the mind that puts everything together and presents us with a “movie like” experience.** This what the Buddha meant when he told Bahiya Daruchiriya: “*Ditté ditta manatan, suté suta mantan, muté muta*

manatan, vinnaté vinnana mantan” or “seeing is just a trace of seeing, hearing is just a trace of hearing, enjoying is just a trace of enjoyment, experiencing is just a trace of experience”.

- It is the mind (specifically the *vinnana kandha* or the aggregate of consciousness) that put everything together and present it as a smooth movie-like experience.
- Here, *ditta, suta muta, vinnata* mean “seeing, hearing, enjoying (with smell, taste, and touch), and consciousness respectively; “*mantan*” means “a *mātra*” in Sinhala or “a trace” in English. Thus “seeing” is just trace of a visual event lasting only a billionth of a second, then it passes away and a new one comes in; there is nothing substantial in it. Mind makes everything appear solid, permanent, and stable. This is the deeper meaning of that verse.

12. If all this appear too technical, do not worry about it. It took me a long time to figure it out and I think I got the final details worked out recently by also combining information from recent scientific studies. The Buddha could not use today's technical terms, but what he said in summary form is completely compatible with science. But science is still way behind in terms of the bigger picture.

Next, “[What is in a Thought? Why Gathi are so Important?](#)“,

What is in a Thought? Why Gathi are so Important?

There are many confusing terms in *Abhidhamma* like *citta* and *mano* which have been differently interpreted in different books. In order to clarify these concepts, I am writing a few posts in “Dhamma Concepts” section under “Mind and Consciousness” starting with: “[Thoughts \(Citta\), Consciousness \(Vinnana\), and Mind \(Hadaya Vatthu\) – Introduction](#)”.

1. In the previous post we saw that a thought (*citta*; pronounced “chitha”) lasts much less than a billionth of a second. The more surprising part is that each *citta* has structure! Each *citta* “contains” multiple *cetasika* (mental factors); actually it is more accurate to say that each *citta* rises with a number of *cetasika* and they all perish together within a billionth of a second, only to be followed by another *citta*.

- Of course, here we are only taking about a *citta* in a *citta vithi* that is involved in “sensing the outside world” via the six senses.
- The *citta* flow CONTINUOUSLY within a life and then start a new stream at the next life; there is no break in between the two lives.
- The stream of thoughts we have, has been running non-stop since the beginning-less time; see, “[What Reincarnates? – The Concept of a Lifestream](#)”.

2. The *cetasika* (mental factors) provide different qualities to each *citta*. A *citta* is moral (*kusala*), immoral (*akusala*), or neutral (*kiriya*) depending on the what type *cetasika* rise with it.

A complete description of 52 *cetasika* are given in, “[Cetasika \(mental factors\)](#)”. A brief summary:

- There are 7 universal *cetasika* that rise with ANY *citta*.
- Six others CAN appear in any *citta*, i.e., only some of them may be in a given *citta*.
- There are 14 *asobhana cetasika* (non-beautiful mental factors) that appear only in *akusala citta*.
- There are 25 *sobhana cetasika* (beautiful mental factors), and 19 of them appear in each and every *kusala citta*, and thus are called beautiful universals.

3. Let us first discuss the 7 universal *cetasika*. These arise with ANY *citta*, and in fact a *citta* with just these is called a “*pabhasvara citta*”, because it is the “purest form” of a *citta*. It gets contaminated to become a “*vinnana citta*” as it develops in time within a billionth of a second! We would not get into those details for a while.

- **What we actually experience are “*vinnana citta*”, as *vinnana khanda* (aggregate of *vinnana* or a “heap of *vinnana*”).**

The 7 universal *cetasika* that arise with any *citta* are:

- *Phassa* (contact), *sanna* (perception), *vedana* (feeling), *cetana* (intention), *ekaggata* (one-pointedness), *jivitindriya* (life faculty), and *manasikara* (memory).

4. The *phassa* (contact) *cetasika* is what makes contact with the “object of the *citta*” whether it is sense input from one of the five physical senses or a concept that makes contact with the mind.

- In *paticca samuppada*, this is the *phassa* in the step “*salayatana paccaya phasso*”. Of course *salayatana* are the six senses. Thus it is *phassa* that makes possible for the mind to make contacts with the world.

- *Sanna* (perception) identifies the object by working with *manasikara* (memory), and *vedana* (feeling) arises.
- Depending on the object, one will generate good, bad, or neutral feeling, and also different types of *cetasika* (greed, shame, compassion, etc) can arise; *cetana* (intention) puts it all together and “prepares” the *citta*. Based on the types of *cetasika* in the *citta*, it could be a good or bad thought. This is why *cetana* can be good or bad, and the Buddha said “*cetana* is *kamma*”.
- *Ekaggata* is the ability to keep the mind on one object. *Jivitindriya* maintains life in the current life (keeps the body alive) until death. And *manasikara* is the all-important memory. *Manasikara* has ALL memories (or *nama gotta*) from the beginning-less time; see, “[Difference between Dhamma and Sankhara](#)” for a discussion on *nama gotta*.
- This is why the present *citta* is the precursor to the next *citta* and that next *citta* is NOT totally different from the previous *citta*; *manasikara*, for example, just keeps building up on the past *citta*. “Cause and effect” is at work from *citta* to *citta*, maintaining the “personality” or “*gathi*” of the given lifestream. This is why the Buddha rejected the notion of a “no-self”, as well as a “self”.
- Yet it is important to realize that “*gathi*” can change even in a *citta*, for example one attains the *Arahanthood* with a single *citta* (of course with billions of *citta vithi* making gradual progress towards it).

5. So, we can see the basic working of a *citta* with these 7 universals; they carry out the most fundamental and vital functions of recognizing the object, matching it with old memories and figuring out what it is, and also *sukha*, *dukha*, or neutral feeling arise because of that recognition.

- Yet all that does not happen in a single *citta*. When an “input” comes through one of the six senses, it is captured by a *citta vithi* containing 17 *citta* for a physical sense input and about 10 *citta* for a mind input as we discussed in the previous post. Then that “captured event” is discerned and analyzed by three follow-up “*manodvara citta vithi*”, i.e., by the mind.
- Even then we actually experience only the “net result” of millions of such *citta vithi*, as we mentioned in the previous post. But due to the extreme rapidity of these processes, we feel like we are using all six in real time. We are not. The mind is always analyzing a set of events that have already gone by, thus “*ditte ditta mantan*,”. What we experience NOW is what has already transpired.

6. But invariably other *cetasika* (other than the 7 universal) arise as the *citta* develops in time, and the *citta* becomes *kusala citta*, *akusala citta* or a *kiriya* (neutral) *citta* depending on the *cetasika* that arise with the *citta*.

- *Sobhana cetasika* arise with *kusala citta* and *asobhana cetasika* arise with *akusala citta*. These *cetasika* types do not mix, i.e., no *sobhana cetasika* arise with a *kusala citta* etc.

7. Now the question arises: If *citta* arise and fall and go by so rapidly, how do we willfully stop *akusala citta* from arising? Especially when exposed to a tempting external object like a eye-catching figure.

And the answer lies in a very simple concept that I have discussed in many posts:

- This is where one’s character qualities (*gathi*) and *asava* come into play. **One automatically responds with the “set of values” one has.**

- By changing one's habits one can change one's character (*gathi*) and eventually change one's deep-rooted cravings (*asavas*). Even though the answer is simple, it takes a long time to get rid of bad habits and cultivate good habits, at least initially.
- **When one gets rid of bad habits and cultivates good habits, the neural connections in one's brain get rewired. The brain changes gradually and that is how the thoughts change. This is the easy answer using the modern science.**
- But there is a deeper analysis. Not only the physical brain changes, but also our *manomaya kaya* is transformed. Eventually that is what controls the brain; see, the couple of posts on *manomaya kaya* and also, "[Neuroscience says there is no Free Will? – That is a Misinterpretation!](#)" for details.
- This idea of gradually changing one's habits holds the KEY in making progress on the Path or even on achieving mundane goals, as I have discussed in other posts.

8. Therefore, initially one responds with one's current set of values or *gathi*. But after a few moments, one CAN think about the consequences and make corrections to the initial automatic reaction.

- This is further explained in terms of the instant reaction coming from the limbic system in the brain and the "reasoned out" corrective action coming from the neo-cortex or "the thinking brain"; see, "[True Brain – How the Mind Rewires the Brain via Meditation/Habits](#)".
- And that is how we slowly change our *gathi*, by willfully making corrections to the initial "auto-response". This is what makes us different from animals. Animals do not have this ability, at least not to our level.
- **The more you "catch" such "inappropriate auto-responses", the more effectively we can get rid of bad habits, cultivate good habits and change our *gathi* (character) in the right direction. This is "*anapana sati*", i.e., one keeps good thoughts and gets rid of bad thoughts willfully; see, "[What is Anapana?](#)" in the Meditation section.**

9. As mentioned above, *cetasika* present in a given *citta* determine the quality and/or the function of the *citta*.

- An immoral (*akusala*) *citta* have one or more immoral roots; *avijja* (delusion *cetasika*) is in any immoral *citta*.
- A moral (*kusala*) *citta* will always have non-greed and non-hate *cetasika*. Wisdom (*panna*) *cetasika* rises only in *citta* with all three roots (*tihetuka citta*).
- We have come across many of the *cetasika* in the posts on various topics: the five hindrances are of course included in the 14 *asobhana cetasika*.
- The four bases of mental power (*sattara iddhipada*) are four of the *sobhana cetasika*, i.e., *chanda*, *citta*, *viriya*, *vimansa*. Here *citta* means "thinking about the goal" and thus is *samma sankappa* when fully cultivated. *Vimansa* is another name for *panna* and becomes *samma ditthi* when fully cultivated; see, "[37 Factors of Enlightenment](#)".
- Some of the factors in the Noble Eightfold Path are directly in the set of *sobhana cetasika*, for example, *samma vaca*, *samma kammanta*, and *samma ajiva*. Other *cetasika* like *sati* and *panna*, when cultivated become *samma sati* and *samma ditthi*.
- Similarly, *ekaggata* in the universal *cetasika* set becomes *samma samadhi*, and *viriya* and

vitakka in the set of particulars become *samma vayama* and *samma sankappa* when cultivated.

10. As we noted, we can control a bad series of thoughts like planning a robbery or even making a quick plan to steal an item from a store. There is enough time to think about the consequences of such a bad action and deliberately stop such thoughts. **But one needs to be in a fairly stable “state-of-mind” to be able to do that. When the mind is agitated, the mind cannot see “right from wrong”. The five hindrances are covering the mind.**

- Sometimes people commit horrendous crimes in the spur-of-the-moment. One can get into a rage and shoot someone with a gun that is close by. How do we stop such quick reactions?
- Unless one has reached the *Sotapanna* stage it cannot be completely ruled out. Each person has a “point-of-no-return”, i.e., a strong enough emotional impact may trigger a fast response heinous enough to make one destined for the *apayas*.
- When one’s “*gathi*” are irrevocably changed when one becomes a *Sotapanna*. When that is achieved, that mindset is maintained even in future lives. As we saw, a *patisandhi citta* in the new life arise based on the *cuti citta* of the past life, so it has all the “*gathi*” from the past life. Changing to a “*gathi*” of a *Sotapanna* is called a change in lineage (*gotrabhu*); one becomes an *Ariya* or a Noble person forever.

Next, “[Javana of a Citta – The Root of Mental Power](#)“,

Javana of a Citta – The Root of Mental Power

1. The power of the human mind has been discussed in several posts starting with “[Power of the Human Mind – Introduction](#)”. There different kinds of citta and the powerful ones are called javana citta (“javana” means an arrow in flight; it can be highly potent).

- Such javana citta are responsible for abhisankhara, sankhara that are potent and will lead to (good or bad) consequences. Punnaabhisankhara are the meritorious abhisankhara that will lead to good consequences and apunnaabhisankhara are the immoral abhisankhara that lead to bad consequences.

2. Out of the 54 types of citta in the kamaloka (the 12 lower realms including the human realm), 29 are javana citta: 12 *akusala* citta, 8 maha kusala citta, 8 maha kiriya citta, and the functional smile-producing citta (the latter 9 cittas only for an Arahant).

- A kusala citta generates power for rebirth in human or above realms, AND also helps with progressing towards Nibbana or “cooling down”.
- When one does an *akusala* citta, one is generating power to form kammic energy for rebirth in the apayas (lowest 4 realms).
- **Thus for normal human beings, there are only 20 cittas out of 54 that are javana citta: 12 for doing bad deeds and 8 for good deeds (here deeds means thought, speech or bodily action).**
- To re-emphasize, vipaka citta vithi do not have javana citta. Thus in the detection of any sense input (seeing, hearing, etc), javana citta are absent. But if we start making plans (buy that picture, re-listen to that song, etc) based on those visuals, sounds, etc, then those subsequent citta vithi will have javana citta in them, and lead to abhisankhara (GENERATE kammic power).

3. Not all ***akusala javana*** citta have same power.

- Out of the 8 greed-rooted citta, those 4 done with pleasure (somanassa-sahagata) are stronger than the done with neutral feeling.
- Next those associated with micca ditthi (or ditthi-sahagata) are more powerful than the 4 generated without wrong vision (or ditthi-vippayutta).
- Finally, those greed-rooted citta are sorted according to whether they arose spontaneously (asankharika) or via prompting (by others or even oneself after deliberating), i.e., sasangharika.
- The two hate-rooted *akusala* citta are always done with displeasure and are associated with aversion (dislike), and the one that is spontaneous (unprompted) is stronger than the prompted.
- The two ignorance-rooted *akusala* citta are always done with neutral feeling and the one that is based on vicikicca is stronger than the based on uddhacca.

4. The above list gives order of strength of the *akusala* citta and they are listed in that order in “[Conditions for the Four Stages of Nibbana](#)”.

- Thus the first lobha citta that is “connected with wrong view, accompanied by pleasure, and unprompted” or in Pali, “somanassa-sahagata, ditthi-sampayutta, asankharika citta” is the strongest *akusala javana* citta.
- The last of the 12 *akusala* citta is “one accompanied by equanimity and associated with high-

mindfulness” or in Pali, “upekkha-sahagata uddhacca-sampayutta citta”.

5. The power of the human mind can be directed both ways: for the good or the bad. Now let us see how the 8 maha kusala (wholesome) citta are sorted according to the javana power.

- Here again, there are 4 done with joyous heart (somanassa-sahagata) that take precedence over those done with neutral feeling.
- Next, those done with knowledge (understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*) called “nana-sampayutta” have higher power compared to those done without knowledge (nana-vippayutta).
- Finally, they are sorted by whether spontaneous (higher) compared to prompted.

6. Thus the most potent kusala citta is “one accompanied by joy, associated with knowledge, and unprompted” or in Pali, “somanassa-sahagata, nana-sampayutta, asankharika citta.

Here one does a good deed with full understanding of its benefits, and thus with a joyous heart, and without any prompting. It is done spontaneously and joyfully, BECAUSE one is fully aware of its benefit. Since it is spontaneous the knowledge must be there in one’s mind.

- The weakest kusala citta is, “one accompanied by neutral mind, dissociated with knowledge, and prompted” or in Pali, “somanassa-sahagata, nana-sampayutta, asankharika citta. Here one may do a good deed without knowledge either on the prompting by others or after some deliberation. Such deeds will bring benefits, but since the javana power is reduced, the benefits are less.

7. Let us take some examples for clarification.

- Some people are so deep in the wrong path, that they actually enjoy committing bad deeds. Or, they get into a mindset where such deeds become enjoyable. We have heard of instances where a person was killed by multiple stabbings or even where the body was mutilated; such an act is worst of the worst.
- It should be easy to imagine why the javana for citta associated with such “passionate” killings are very intense. The killer is absorbed in that act, and is generating potent mental power to carry out the physical act; by the way any physical act is done with citta; see, [“Neuroscience says there is no Free Will? – That is a Misinterpretation”](#).
- This is also why a kamma becomes “kamma patha” or a “strong kamma” when a bodily act is committed; one needs strong javana to carry out that task. If one is aware of the consequences of such acts (i.e., do not have micca ditthi or wrong vision), then even if one started stabbing, it is likely that one may catch oneself and stop.

8. On the other hand, even the smallest act of kindness can bring much benefits if it was done with full understanding and a joyous heart. Here the “mental power” or the javana comes from knowledge or understanding. We see these kinds of ‘small acts of kindness’ all the time, and we can even share in those merits when our hearts become joyful too.

- For a well-off person, it is easy to write a check for a lot of money, but if it was done just to get publicity, or due to “outside pressure”, it will not bring much benefit. If someone who is poor sees another person that is in even worse condition, and shares what he/she can with that person with joy, that will bring much more benefit.

9. The javana power of a mind is also described by the term “sanvega” (san + vega, where “vega”

means fast; see, “[What is “San”? – Meaning of Sansara](#)” for the meaning of “san”). Therefore, “sanvega” depicts a potent emotional condition. If it is to the “good” one will be doing punnabhi abhisankhara (meritorious acts), and a bad act done with “sanvega” will be a potent apunnabhi abhisankhara (immoral acts).

- In the literature “sanvega” is commonly written as “samvega”; as with many other such words, replacing “san” with ‘sam” leads to distortion of the meaning of the word. Other such misspelled words are samsara, samvedana, samyoga, samvara; see, “[What is “San”? – Meaning of Sansara](#)”.
- In Sinhala language, “sanvega” is commonly used to describe emotionally intense situations but mostly for sad situations. However, we can see that it should be applicable for all “potent” emotional situations.

10. The mind and the heart are in close contact. Even that person who derived pleasure by stabbing someone many times, will have a heavy heart until death, no matter how bad a person he/she is. It is in the human nature. Of course, when we do a meritorious act too, we feel the joy in our hearts.

- The reason that we “feel” at the heart is because the citta are generated in association with the “hadaya vatthu” that is located close to the physical heart. The hadaya vatthu is actually in the manomaya kaya which is like a “ghost” that is hugging the physical body; see, “[Manomaya Kaya and Physical Body](#)” and “[Ghost in the Machine – Synonym for the Manomaya Kaya?](#)”.

11. Getting back to the issue of mental power, it is clear that it makes a big difference on “how much engaged we are” in our thoughts. Potency of a good or a bad citta is critically dependent on our desire to get it done. Three out of four bases of mental power, chanda, citta, viriya originate due to this; see, “[The Four Bases of Mental Power \(Satara Iddhipada\)](#)”.

- And the fourth factor of vimansa (reasoning/investigation) is important because that is how one gains the all-important nana (wisdom); see #5,#6 above. When one truly comprehends *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, that is leads to the cultivation/growing of the panna cetasika reducing ignorance (avijja).

12. Another thing that comes out of this analysis is that it is good to contemplate on the past good deeds and “re-live” that experience to gain citta pasāda or a joyful mind.

- Similarly, it is NOT good to do that for past bad deeds; better to forget them and get a new start. If something like that comes to the mind, think of an opposite good deed and focus the mind on the good deed.
- This is part of “Anapana”. We need to keep and cultivate “good things” and “discard” bad things; see, “[What is Ānapāna?](#)”.
- Our thoughts are what ultimately matter, and they arise due to our character (gathi); the more we do “Anapana” correctly, the more our “gathi” will change for the better.

Next, “[Cutī-Patisandhi – An Abhidhamma Description](#)”,

Cuti-Patisandhi – An Abhidhamma Description

1. Many people believe that *patisandhi* or the linking to a new life happens in a womb (in human and animal realms). But that is not correct. *Patisandhi citta* is experienced in the next very *citta* after the *cuti citta* of the old life in the last *citta vithi* of the dying person.

- The new life form (*gandhabbaya*) emerges from the dead body right after the last *citta vithi* (However, if the next life is an *opapatika* one, the life form is fully formed right after the last *citta vithi*). Here we will discuss the case where the new life is either human or animal and thus a *gandhabbaya* is formed; see, “[Manomaya Kaya and Physical Body](#)” and “[Ghost in the Machine – Synonym for the Manomaya Kaya?](#)”.

2. *Patisandhi* (“*pati*” is bond and “*sandhi*” is joining in Pali or Sinhala, thus *patisandhi* means joining a new life at the end of the old) happens in a thought moment in the body of the dying person; if the next life is human or animal, then the *gandhabbaya* for that life comes out of that body at the end of that last *citta vithi*. Of course the *gandhabbaya* has a very fine body, and it can be seen only by a person with *abhinna* powers. let us discuss this step carefully.

- I must warn in advance that this analysis is highly technical, and is suitable only for those who are familiar with *citta vithi* processes in *Abhidhamma*. **However, the conclusions are informative, so you may want to go through it.** I will write introductory posts on describing various parts of a *citta vithi* in the future.

3. The last *citta vithi* of the old life with 17 *citta* run in the standard way: *atita bhavanga*, *bhavanga calana*, *bhavanga upacceda*, *pancadvara vajjana*, *cakkhu vinnana*, *sampaticcana*, *santirana*, *vottapana*, and then *javana* sequence (7 *javana citta*) starts. After the fifth *javana citta*, there are two more *javana citta* left. The sixth is the *cuti citta* and the seventh and last *javana* is the *patisandhi citta*.

- In the last *citta vithi*, a previous *kamma vipaka* provides an *arammana* (thought object) associated with that *kamma vipaka* through one of the five sense doors: it is normally a visual or a sound associated with the new existence (*bhava*). Even though the person’s physical faculties may be very weak, the person will see or hear very clearly whatever the *nimitta* presented by the *kamma vipaka*. Then at the *vottapana citta*, the mind makes a decision to act on that *arammana* based on the person’s *gathi*. The person has no control of it. It is called, “*kammaja pure jatha; cittaja pacce jatha*”, i.e., *kamma vipaka* comes first, and then accordingly the *javana citta* flow grasping that new *bhava*:

“*kamma vipaka vajjanti, vipako kamma sambhavo*

Tasma punabbhovo hoti, evan loko pavattati”

Or,

“*kamma vipaka* presents a new existence, the ignorant being grasps that existence

Thus the cycle of rebirths repeats, and that is how the world exists”

4. First there is the *vipaka citta*; then it induces *kamma sambhava*. “*Vipako kamma sambhavo*” is initiated at the *vottapana citta*. The *vottapana citta* decides how to proceed with the *arammana* (object) that came from the *kamma vipaka*, and the being normally gets attached to that object via greed/hate and grasps a new existence in the *javana citta* that follow. Thus “*vipako kamma sambhavo*” starts with the first *javana citta*. After 5 *javana citta* *kammic* energy is optimized, with

each subsequent *javana* strengthening via *asevana paccaya* from the previous *javana*. The sixth one is called *cuti citta*, and the next *citta* grasps the new *bhava*.

- *Cuti citta* happens in the last *citta vithi* just after the actual *cuti* (death), because it is *pacce jata* to *kammaja cuti* event. The seventh *javana* always is responsible for the next life.
- Now this linking to the next life happens at the 7th *javana citta* or the *patisandhi citta*, which is again *pacce jatha* to the actual *kammaja patisandhi* that starts at the *pancdvaravajjana citta* in this last *citta vithi*.

5. Now let us take a look at the last *citta vithi* of the old life in detail. This *citta vithi* was started by the last bit of *kammic* energy from the old life, and it will run its course of 17 *citta* before it comes to an end. It is like throwing a stone; even though the energy was fully spent by the time the stone was released, the stone will be travelling until its energy is all spent. In the same way, *even though the kammic energy for the old life has ended, the last citta vithi will run its course of 17 citta including the last two bhavanga citta after the 7 javana citta*.

- *Cuti* or death is not a *citta*; it is the end of the *kammic* energy of the old life. *Cuti* happens just at the moment of initiating the last *citta vithi*, and the *cuti citta* is in the last *citta vithi*. *Patisandhi* is not a *citta* either. It is also *kammaja* act.
- Here the old *bhavanga* has ended too; but there are two *bhavanga citta* left in the last *citta vithi*. The new *vatthu rupa* cannot be formed until this last *citta vithi* is done with, because as soon as one is formed, it will start its *citta vithi*, and no two *vithi* can be there at the same time.

6. In that last *citta vithi*, by the time *atita bhavanga*, *bhavanga calana*, and comes to *bhavanga upacceda*, the *kammic vipaka* from the old life are finished. Now what comes to the *pancadvara* is the *kamma nimitta*, *asanna kamma*, or a *gathi nimitta*; **it is the vipaka citta that powers the new life**: “*kamma vipaka vajjanti*”. It is received by the *sampaticcana*, *santirana citta* and then “*vipaka kamma sambhavo*” happens at the *vottapana citta*, i.e., a decision is made on what to do and this decision depends on the level of *avijja* (in the form of one’s *gathi* and *asavas*).

- This “*vipaka kamma sambhavo*” starts with the first *javana citta* and builds up gradually up to the fifth *javana citta*. Now the sixth *javana*, *cuti citta*, had been determined from the beginning of the *citta vithi*. The new *kamma beeja* starts working at the seventh *javana* in the new *bhava*.

7. When this last *citta vithi* ends, the old *hadaya vatthu* is dead too; it had exhausted all its *kammic* power. The next *citta vithi* starts with a new *hadaya vatthu* in the new life that is powered by a new *kamma beeja*. The new *hadaya vatthu* is formed by the new *kamma* seed that was grasped at the 7th *javana* (the *patisandhi citta*), and immediately the first *citta vithi* for the new life starts. The *gandhabbaya* is formed and comes out of the dead body.

- If a human died and the next life is an animal, the *gandhabbaya* with the corresponding animal figure comes out fully formed (of course it is very fine); **It is the blueprint for the new physical body**.
- This *gandhabbaya* now has to wait for a suitable womb. It is not that *gandhabbaya* decides which womb is good; rather, when a womb that matches the *gathi* of the *gandhabbaya* becomes available, *gandhabbaya* will be pulled into it by the *kammic* energy.
- When a sperm fertilizes an egg in a womb, a single cell called a zygote results. But there is no life there until the *gandhabbaya* enters the womb and is incorporated with that zygote. Now the

zygote becomes an embryo, then a fetus, and once out of the womb grows to a full-size human or an animal according to that blueprint.

- Science has been unable to explain how all the complex body parts of a human or animal develops starting from a single cell. This is how it happens. The blueprint for all the complex body parts is in the *gandhabbaya*, not in that single cell; see, “[What does Buddha Dhamma \(Buddhism\) say about Birth Control?](#)“.

Buddhist Chanting

[“Buddhist Chanting – Introduction”](#)

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Buddhist Chanting – Introduction

1. This section on Chanting may be helpful in cultivating saddha (faith). For those who believe that there is no value in these “ritual-like” procedures, it may be a good idea to read the post, “[Panca Indriya and Panca Bala- Five Faculties and Five Powers](#)”.

- If done with understanding, these are not rituals as in “silabbata paramasa”.
- Therefore, as I keep adding items to this section, I will try to provide the deep meanings behind these “seemingly ritualistic” chantings.
- In addition to the aspect on the deeper meanings, there are subtle benefits in listening to chantings, especially those by Ariyas or Noble Persons. This is why I decided to add the sound recordings by the Venerable Thero.

2. The Buddha said that the mind takes precedence over everything else. Our speech and bodily actions are controlled by our thoughts. And these thoughts get their moral power from wisdom (panna) and the joyful state of the mind.

- One can make a given meritorious deed much more powerful by doing it with joy and understanding. The most potent kusala citta is done with “joy and understanding” (a somanassa-sahagata, nana-sampayutta citta); see, “[Javana of a Citta – Root of Mental Power](#)”.
- Recent scientific studies are beginning to illustrate the power of the focused mind; see, for example, “The Biology of Belief” by Bruce H. Lipton (2008) and “Biocentrism” by Robert Lanza (2009).
- Thus chanting done with understanding can have benefits, especially for those who have a dominant “saddha indriya”, or have a high-degree of faith in the Buddha or Buddha Dhamma.

3. **However, one should not force anything on the mind.** If chanting is not something that appeals to someone, then it should not be forced. Different people start off with different tendencies (i.e., they have a dominant faculty or power, see, “[Panca Indriya and Panca Bala- Five Faculties and Five Powers](#)”). **Out of sati, saddha, viriya, samadhi, and panna, the dominant one should be the focus.** As one cultivates the Path, other four will also grow.

- This is also related to the concept of how one’s character (gathi) and habits change as one follows the Path. Then one’s tendencies, associations, etc will also gradually change; see, “[The Law of Attraction – Habits, Character \(Gathi\), and Cravings \(Asavas\)](#)”.
- Thus one may want to concentrate just on the topics on the site that are appealing to oneself. Once in a while, one can take a look at other sections and see whether their opinions on those sections have changed or not.
- The main thing is to stay on the path of least resistance and the topics that can be easily comprehended.

Next, “[Namaskaraya – Homage to the Buddha](#)”,

Namaskaraya – Homage to the Buddha

1. In the Theravada tradition, it is customary to pay homage to the Buddha (Namaskaraya; pronounced “namaskāraya), recite the Three Refuges (Tisarana, where “ti” is three and “sarana” means refuge or protection; pronounced “Thisarana”) and undertake to observe the five precepts (Panca Sila; pronounced “pancha seela”) on visiting a place of worship or before starting a meditation session.

- Some people just do the Namaskaraya if they do not have time to recite the Tisarana (Refuge in Buddha, Dhamma, Sangha) or the Panca Sila (five precepts; sometimes eight or ten precepts).

2. One can recite the following stanza three times by oneself or at more formal occasions (e.g., visiting a temple) a Buddhist monk administers them.

“Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa”

- A brief translation is, “I pay homage to the fully Enlightened One who found the truth about the existence and became free of all defilements”. The deeper meaning is discussed in, [“Namaskaraya – What does it Really Mean?”](#).

3. **Both interpretations are important.** For someone starting out, without much knowledge of Dhamma (but still sees the value in Dhamma) and thus wishes to pay respects to the Buddha, the conventional meaning itself is the dominant.

- But the Buddha himself said that the best way to pay homage to him is to learn Dhamma and to follow the Path. That is the more deeper meaning of the Namaskaraya. But they also have the reverence for the Buddha himself. As the knowledge in Dhamma grows, the second interpretation becomes clear, while not losing the first.

4. Here is a recital of the Namaskaraya by a Venerable Thero (volume adjustment on the right):

<http://puredhamma.net/wp-content/uploads/Namaskaraya.mp3>

Namaskaraya – What does it Really Mean?

“*Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa*”

This is normally translated to English as,

“I pay homage to the Blessed One, the Exalted One, the fully Enlightened One”

1. Most Pali verses have two (or more) meanings: one is the conventional (“*padaparama*”) meaning, and the other is the deeper meaning that helps understand the deeper idea behind the verse. Unfortunately, most times it is the conventional idea that that is brought out when translating even whole *suttas*.

- In the case of *suttas*, a *sutta* that was delivered over an hour (sometimes many hours, like the *Dhamma chakka pavattana sutta*) is normally translated word-to-word in a few pages. As I explained in the post, “[Preservation of the Dhamma](#)”, most existing *sutta* translations are incomplete at best, and erroneous most of the time.
- Even the conventional meaning can be useful in some cases, like in *namaskaraya*, *Tisarana*, and the five precepts. For those who do not have a deeper understanding, the deeper meanings may not serve the purpose of bringing “joy to the heart” or “*citta pasāda*” (pronounced “*chittha pasāda*”); for a deeper discussion on *citta pasāda*, see, “[Javana of a Citta – The Root of Mental Power](#)”.
- Thus for those who are new to the deeper meanings in Dhamma, the conventional interpretations may be a good start. As knowledge in Dhamma grows, the second interpretation becomes clear without losing the first, i.e., reverence to the person himself can also only grow as one learns how valuable his Dhamma is.

2. What we have here is a short phrase that can be correctly translated in a short essay. Let us see what is really meant by this verse.

- “*Namo*” means incline as in accepting something with this reverence because of its value; “*tassa*” means “to this”. This is why we bend our heads to signify this.
- “*bhaga*” is to separate and “*vata*” is the usually translated as body, but it has more wider meaning to anything in this world. The Buddha, in trying to show that uselessness of clinging to one’s body, advised to separate the body into 32 parts and see that there is nothing substantial in any of the parts. Even though we highly value our bodies, it will decay with old age, and will eventually give us only sicknesses and ailments. And it will last only about 100 years.
- In the wider sense, anything in this world can be divided into parts and be shown that there is nothing substantial in them.
- Once we see that it is unfruitful to cling our bodies (and anythings in general), we lose the craving (“*raha*” in Pali or Sinhala) and become “*arahant*”(from “*a*” + “*raha*”). The word Arahant also comes from this meaning, i.e., someone who has given up craving for worldly things, by comprehending the true nature.
- As we saw in the post, “[What is “San?” – the Meaning of Sansara](#)”, “*san*” means accumulating worldly things. “*ma*” means become free of doing that. Thus “*samma*” (*san+ma*) means “stop accumulating worldly stuff that will only cause suffering in the end”.

- The accumulation of worldly things lead to preparation of future births or “*bhava*”. *Sambuddhassa* (*san+bhu+uddassa*) means “remove from the root the causes for preparing bhava via accumulating *san*”, i.e., become free of the rebirth process or to work towards *Nibbana*.

3. Now we can see the whole verse:

“By analyzing my body and other worldly things with wisdom, I have come to understand the unfruitfulness of clinging to such things, and I incline to rout out the existence and attain *Nibbana*”.

- Here incline means one keeps “bent on attaining that goal”. With deeper understanding of Dhamma one’s resolve will be strengthened. As with most things in Buddha Dhamma, it is always about one’s mind.
- The resolve has to come through understanding. There is no one watching, and no one else monitoring the progress; it is one’s own mind that is doing all that.

4. Finally, the word *namaskaraya* (*nama+as+kāraya*, where “*nama*” is one’s name, “*as*” pronounced like “us” means remove, and “*kāraya*” means doing) conveys the idea that one is making a resolve to get rid of the attachment one has for one’s worldly things. It is a condensed version of the verse.

- Of course the conventional meaning of “*namaskaraya*” is “paying homage”.

Tiratana Vandana – Supreme Characteristics

At the time of taking precepts, many people like to recite the supreme qualities of the “Three Jewels” (Tiratana, where “ti” is three, and “ratana” is “jewel”; pronounced “thirathana”), i.e., the Buddha, Dhamma, and Sangha. Vandana means chanting with reverence.

I will write posts in the future describing these qualities. For now, only the Pali text is given in the document below.

[Here is a recording of the Tiratana vandana by a Venerable Thero \(volume adjustment on the right\):](#)

http://puredhamma.net/wp-content/uploads/Buduguna_Dahamguna_Sanghaguna.mp3

Pali text (click to open the pdf file):

[Tiratana Vandana \(PDF file\)](#)

The Five Precepts – Panca Sila

1. The five precepts (panca sila; pronounced “pancha seela”) are normally recited after paying homage to the Buddha (Namaskaraya), and then taking the refuge (Tisarana), i.e., one says nine times that one takes the refuge in the Buddha, Dhamma, and the Sangha. In the following they are combined, as customary; see the previous post for pronunciations and details.

- Even for a Buddhist, it is not necessary to recite the precepts.
- It is important to keep in mind that JUST BY RECITING PRECEPTS does not do anything to purify the mind. The Buddha said, “*yan samadanan tan vathan, sanvarattena seelan*“, or “reciting precepts is a ritual (“vatha”), moral behavior is attained by controlling one’s sense faculties”.
- However, it is good to recite Namaskaraya, Tisarana, and the precepts, to attain citta pasada or calmness and joy of mind especially before a formal meditation session. If one does it WITH UNDERSTANDING and RESOLVE, it can bring benefits.
- Furthermore, reciting precepts and suttas is preferred by those with developed saddha (faith) indriya; see, “[Panca Indriya and Panca Bala – Five Faculties and Five Powers](#)“. For those who lack saddha indriya, this may be something they want to consider doing.

2. It is important to realize that the five precepts have deep meanings, and thus should not be taken lightly; see, “[The Five Precepts – What the Buddha Meant by Them](#)“. The true meaning of the five precepts are discussed there.

- Only an Arahant is capable of strictly keeping those precepts (abstaining from all ten defilements or dasa *akusala*); thus one needs to recite with the intention of doing one’s best to keep the precepts. Otherwise, we will be lying from the outset.

[Here a Venerable Thero is reciting the Namaskaraya, Tisarana, and the five precepts with the audience repeating them \(volume adjustment on the right\):](#)

<http://puredhamma.net/wp-content/uploads/Pansil.wav>

Here is a pdf file with the text and translation:

[Panca Sila \(PDF file\)](#) (click to open)

3. To emphasize, these English translations are the conventional (“padaparama”) or mundane ones and the real meanings are discussed in “[The Five Precepts – What the Buddha Meant by Them](#)“. Also, while reciting, one needs to keep in mind that one is promising do one’s best to keep the precepts.

Sutta Chanting (with Pali Text)

Following are recordings of three popular suttas by a Venerable Thero and the corresponding Pali texts. At some point, I will make English translations. Most existing translations provide only the mundane (“padaparama”) meanings.

1. Karaniya Metta Sutta (volume adjustment on the right):

<http://puredhamma.net/wp-content/uploads/012-Karaniya-Metta-Sutta.mp3>

Pali text (click to open):

[Karaniya Metta Sutta \(PDF file\)](#)

2. Ratana Sutta (volume adjustment on the right):

<http://puredhamma.net/wp-content/uploads/011-Ratana-Sutta.mp3>

Pali text (click to open):

[Ratana Sutta \(PDF file\)](#)

3. Maha Mangala Sutta (volume adjustment on the right):

<http://puredhamma.net/wp-content/uploads/010-Maha-Mangala-Sutta.mp3>

Pali text (click to open):

[Maha Mangala Sutta \(PDF file\)](#)

Sadhu – Symbolizes Purified Hadaya Vatthu (Mind)

1. It is customary to say “Sādhu! Sādhu! Sādhu!” before and after taking precepts, chanting sutta, or a meritorious act (by oneself or another). Since anything is done for a purpose in Buddha Dhamma, it is good to understand why it is done.

- Sādhu comes from “sa” and “*hadaya*” or a purified heart (not the physical heart, but the *hadaya vatthu* where thoughts arise).

2. It is important to realize that our minds are associated with the *hadaya vatthu*, which is in the manomaya kaya and is aligned close to the physical heart; see, “[Ghost in the Machine – Synonym for the Manomaya Kaya?](#)” This is why in a traumatic or joyful event we feel it in the heart, and not in the brain. Brain is like a computer, and when it is overworked, it causes headaches. But our feelings of love, hate etc. are felt close to the physical heart, in the *hadaya vatthu*.

How is one’s heart (and mind) purified?

- “*Kāyena sanvarō sādhu, sādhu vācaya sanvarō; manasā sanvarō sādhu, sādhu sabbatta sanvarō*”
- “The heart is purified via moral discipline; one needs to act, speak, and think morally”

Thus when a meritorious deed is done by oneself or another, it is customary to say, “sādhu”. It reinforces the “goodness” of the deed and one makes a determination to do more; the lightness of the heart can be felt if one does it with understanding.

3. Our hearts are darkened with greed, hate, and ignorance of Tilakkhana. As we purify the mind, the darkness fades away and the “white light emerges”; it is like lighting a lamp gets rid of the darkness. Heart becomes joyful.

We get rid of greed, hate, and ignorance via staying away from the ten defilements:

- When we abstain from killing, stealing, and inappropriate conduct (including but not limited to sexual conduct), we are cultivating moral **discipline through bodily acts**.
- Abstinence from lying, vain talk, gossiping, and hateful speech leads to **moral discipline through speech**.
- When we forcefully control our bodily acts and speech, the mind will gradually calm down because we thus reduce abhijja (strong greed) and vyapada (strong hate). Then we can cultivate samma ditthi via comprehending the Tilakkhana; this leads to reduction of micca ditthi too (**abhijja, vyapada, and micca ditthi are the three akusala kamma done with the mind**). This is the step-by-step procedure that is discussed in the Bhavana (meditation) section.

4. Thus we can see that by saying “sādhu” mindfully, what we are doing is to make a firm determination to get rid of the ten defilements (dasa *akusala*) and thus to purify the mind and heart. Or, we are agreeing with a good deed done by someone else, and share the merits of that deed.

5. Now, what is the significance of putting the open hands together when saying “Sadhu!”?

- The gesture that we make by opening the hands fully, putting them together, and bringing them close to the heart or top of head also signify this determination. “With all my heart I make a commitment”, or “this commitment stands above everything else”, or “I agree wholeheartedly”.

The strengthening of the fingers versus making a fist embody two basic characteristics of human nature.

- One makes a fist when hitting someone in anger. Also, someone caught doing a misdeed has clenched hands in addition to a bent posture (you have seen pictures of criminals being hauled off to jail in such timid postures).
- In contrast, open hands indicate “I have not aggressive intentions” as when putting up hands indicating one has no desire to fight. Furthermore, as you may have noticed, people when say “Sādhu!” normally have their backs straight too, especially if they are doing with a joyful mind.

6. As mentioned above, one can make a given meritorious deed much more powerful by doing it with joy and knowledge; such thoughts should be there during that act and also when saying “Sādhu!” at the beginning and end. The most potent kusala citta are done with “joy and understanding” (“*a somanassa-sahagata, nana-sampayutta citta*”; see, “[Javana of a Citta – Root of Mental Power](#)”).

Dhammapada

“[Sabba Papassa Akaranan....](#)”

“[Appamadö Amata Padam....](#)”

“[Najajja Vasalo Hoti.....](#)”

Sabba Papassa Akaranan....

“Sabba päpassa akaranan,

Kusalassa upasampadä,

Sachitta pariyö dapanan,

Etan Buddhänasäsanan” (Dhammapada verse 183)

Let us see what is meant by the verse:

- Sabba = all; papassa = päpa + passa = discard immoral; akarana = (a + karana) = not engaged in
- kualassa = kusala + assa = “take in” moral, upasampada = upa + san + pada = sort out “san”
- sachitta = sa + citta = one’s own thoughts; pariyodapanan = pari +yö+dapanan = control at the onset (where “dapana” means control and “yö” means origin and “pari” means around)
- Buddha äna = All Buddhas’ niyama or principle
- etan Buddhänasäsanan = that is Buddha Säšana, were säšana is the doctrine.

Note: “assa” and “passa” same as “ana” and “pana”; see, “[What is Anapana?](#)“. For an explanation on “san”, see, “[What is “San”? – Meaning of Sansara](#)“.

Therefore, we can summarize as follows:

“Discard all that is immoral, what should not be done

Take in what is moral by sorting out “san”

Do this by controlling one’s own thoughts (mind)

This is the doctrine of the Buddhas”

Here is a recording of the verse recited by a Venerable Thero; it keeps repeating several times:

http://puredhamma.net/wp-content/uploads/Sabba_paapassa_akaranan.mp3

Appamadö Amata Padam....

*“Appamadö amata padam, pamadö maccunö padam
appamattä na meeyanti, ye pamattä yathä matä”*

(Dhammapada verse 21)

Let us see what is meant by the verse:

- Pamä or Pamäda is getting delayed; appamä or appamäda is opposite of that, i.e., quickness.
- Amata (“a”+”mata”) is deathless; amata padam means deathless state
- Maccuno is death; maccuno padam is being dead or as if dead
- Appamattä(“appama” + “attä”) means the person who is not delayed
- na meeyanti (“na”+”mee”+”yanti”) means not subject to death
- “ye” means those, pamattä means “pamä” + “attä” delayed person, “yathä” means state or characteristic, “matä” means dead.

1. Thus we can state the meaning of the verse as:

“Those who strive diligently reach the deathless state (Nibbana) and those who are delayed are in a state where death is an inseparable characteristic (i.e., in sansara);

those who make haste (become) not subject to death and those who procrastinate remain in a state where death is ever-present”.

2. This verse state the urgency for working towards Nibbana. There are two reasons for the urgency:

1. Time of death is unpredictable. Even a young, healthy person may die via an accident or other unforeseeable cause.
2. As we get old, our brains start to degrade and thus our minds will not be able to grasp the Dhamma.

3. Many Buddhists that I know say they want to “enjoy life while young” and then start focusing on Nibbana at old age long after retirement. But one may not reach the old age, and even if did, the mind may not be able to grasp the deep message of the Buddha.

- Most people come to the conclusion of postponing practice, because they think attaining Nibbana (or the Sotapanna stage) is a mere act of following some rituals that can be done any time. This would be a big mistake. The Sotapanna stage is reached via comprehending the true nature of this world, *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, and that needs a sharp mind and a lot of contemplation.

4. The Buddha was once travelling with some bhikkhus and they saw an old beggar couple. The Buddha told the bhikkhus that the man’s name was Mahädana (meaning rich), and he was indeed a very rich person, and the woman was his wife; they both were of “tihétuka birth”, i.e., they were born due to a very potent good kamma (done with all three good roots of non-greed, non-hate, and wisdom) from a previous life.

- Thus, the Buddha said, if they started on the Path when they were very young, the man could

have become an Arahant and the woman an Anagami; if they started when they were young (20's), they could have become Anagami/Sakadagami, and if they started on the Path in the middle age they could have attained Sakadagami/Sotapanna stages. Instead, they lived a very lavish life, wasted their wealth, and became beggars. Now they were too old to comprehend anything.

- It is unfortunate to see many people today postponing the practice to their “old age”. It is a good idea to start early and at least keep a slow pace.
- However, it must be noted that four factors contribute to the capability of attaining Nibbana: Ayusa (age), vanna (lively), sukha (comfort), bala (ability). Some people may have sufficient vanna and bala even at very old age. Thus a normal person cannot look at a given old person and say, “this person seems too old to attain Nibbana”. Only a Buddha can determine whether a person is too old to grasp the Dhamma. Yet, in general, as one becomes older the brain gets weaker.

5. Here is a recording of the verse recited by a Venerable Thero (note the volume control on the right):

<http://puredhamma.net/wp-content/uploads/Appamado.wav>

Najajja Vasalo Hoti.....

“Najajjā vasalō hōti, najajjā hōti Brāhmanō

Kammanā vasalō hōti, kammanā hōti Brāhmanō”

(Vasala Sutta)

When I started writing this post, I erroneously assumed that the above verse is from Dhammapada. But it turned out that it is actually from the Vasala sutta. However, I decided to put the post in the Dhammapada section, as it is a nice verse providing insight to the core message of the Buddha.

Let us look at the meaning of different key terms:

- “Ja” means birth and “jajja” means “by birth” or “related to birth”.
- “Vasala” or “vasalaya” is a derogatory term identifying someone as an “unworthy” person, not merely “useless” but “someone not to be associated with”, as if the person has a communicable disease. Even today, there are such “untouchables” in India even though their conditions have improved since 1995: <http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Dalit>.
- In those days, a Brahmin was supposed to be the opposite of a vasalaya, having the highest social rank. Of the 31 realms of existence, Brahmas occupy the highest 20 realms and are the beings with highest level of mental states (greedy or hateful thoughts normally do not arise in them). Thus a Brahmin is supposed to be of highest moral values.
- Kamma is of course action, and kammana means according to one’s actions.

So, the meaning of the verse is clear:

“It is not the birth that makes a noble person or an ignoble person, but it is one’s actions (the way one lives one’s life) that determines whether one is a noble person or an ignoble person”.

- Here one could substitute noble person with a Brahmin and ignoble person with an untouchable, AND that does not come about by birth but by one’s moral values.

We can make the following deductions using Buddha Dhamma:

- One is determined to be a noble person not by birth but by one’s character.
- One can change from being an ignoble person to a noble person and even a Noble person (Ariya) by changing one’s character (gathi). There are several posts on how to change habits; use the “Search” box on right to find the posts (just search for “habit” or “gathi”). This search box is a good resource to find relevant posts using a key word.
- Sometimes a noble person can change to an ignoble person too; but a Noble person (Ariya) never (even in future lives) changes to an ignoble person.
- Some people are very high-minded because of their birth, wealth, beauty, fame, among many other possibilities. But we need to be always aware of the fact that we have been born much worse than even the lowest human; there is no reason to be high-minded for a span of 100 years (or even few thousand years if one is born with a potent kamma seed making it possible to be reborn human many times in succession), in a rebirth process that has no beginning!
- Contemplating on the “bigger world view” with the 31 realms (with four realms of much

suffering) and the hard-to-comprehend time scale of sansara, can make one humble, and be compassionate; see, “[Implications of the Rebirth Process in Daily Life and Society](#)”.

- Also, we need to remember that even a lowly worm may have a potent kamma seed that could make it in its next life a king (even though chances are extremely low; see, “[How to Evaluate Weights of Different Kamma](#)”), and if we do not act with wisdom we could have a rebirth worse than a worm. Actually, high-mindedness (uddacca; pronounced uddachcha) can make one be born in a lower realm.

Book Reviews

“[“Why Does the World Exist?” by Jim Holt](#)”

“[“Waking Up” by Sam Harris](#)”

“[“The Language of God” by Francis Collins](#)”

“[“Spark” by John Ratey](#)”

“Why Does the World Exist?” by Jim Holt

1. I started writing this post while I was reading the popular book, “Why Does the World Exist? – An Existential Detective Story” by Jim Holt (2012). It is a good book with many thought-provoking questions. Here I would like to point out that most of those questions have answers in Buddha Dhamma.

- On p. 269, equating the Nibbanic bliss to annihilation of a person, he asks, “...But how can you enjoy something if you do not exist?”. I initially started the post with the title, “Does Nibbana Mean Annihilation of a “Person”?”, to address this question, but then I started addressing other issues in the book and eventually changed the title to be the same as the book title.
- Even many Buddhists are terrified of the idea of *Nibbana*, thinking that it means annihilation. This is why even many Bhikkhus like to give “blessings” to the effect, “May you attain *Nibbana* at the end of much pleasures in the heavenly worlds”. This illustrates a total lack of understanding of the deep message of the Buddha.

2. The problem is in the question itself. If a person is to be annihilated, a “person” need to exist in the first place. Now this is a very deep issue that needs some knowledge of Buddha Dhamma to understand. As the Buddha said in his first sermon, his Dhamma is, “*pubbe anumussutesu dhammesu.....*” or “a concept that has not been known to the world before..”.

- In order to annihilate, there must be something “concrete”, what the Brahmins of the day of the Buddha called “*āthma*”, or what the major religions of today call the “soul”. It is very difficult for all of us to get rid of the perception of “me” or “myself”. **In fact, that perception is totally removed only at the Arahant stage of Nibbana; it keeps decreasing as one advances on the Path.**
- Thus as long as one “belongs to this world of 31 realms”, one always thinks in terms of “me” and “the external world”. This is why the Buddha rejected the concept of “no-self” even though most people incorrectly translate *anatta* as “no-self”; see, “[The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma](#)”.
- On the other hand, the Buddha said that it is also incorrect to say there is “self”. This is because any “person” changes even moment-to-moment; see, “[What Reincarnates? – Concept of a Lifestream](#)”.
- In rejecting both “self” and “no-self” extremes, the Buddha said “this changing being” or “a lifestream” changes moment-to-moment due to changes in the causes that support that lifestream. This is not something that I can explain in one essay, and is explained via many posts at the site, including the important section on *Paticca Samuppada*.
- In the book there is a separate chapter on, “The Self – Do I Really Exist?”. I will discuss that chapter below, and point out a few more related facts.

3. The book’s main theme is “why is there something rather than nothing?” or “how did the world got started?”. It summarizes most of the arguments that have accumulated over thousands of years, and of course come to the inevitable question on “the nature of the Creator God who would not need a cause for being there”.

- However, regarding the two questions on existence as expressed above, the Buddha’s answer is the simplest: The world has existed forever and it is not possible to pinpoint to a specific first

cause. The proof is very simple: Suppose there is a first cause; then what caused that? QED.

- Thus in the scientific basis of cause and effect, the absence of a first cause is built in.
- On p. 82 of the book, Jim Holt did point out, “..Scientific thinkers by and large, have not shared such qualms about eternity. Neither Galileo nor Newton nor Einstein had any problem conceiving of a universe that was infinite in time. Indeed, Einstein added to his field equations a fudge factor – the infamous “cosmological constant” – to ensure that they would yield a universe that was static and eternal“.
- And a few philosophers have discussed the problem with “first cause” arguments, as Jim Holt noted. Talking about the late philosopher John Mackie on p. 206, “..Obviously, as Mackie observed, no explanation in terms of a “first cause” could answer the ultimate question of existence, for such an explanation would merely raise the the further question of why that first cause -whether it be God, an unstable chunk of false vacuum, or some still more exotic entity- itself existed”.

4. If one accepts that the world has existed forever, then many other questions discussed in the book do not even arise. Thus 100% of the questions discussed are answered if we start off with the premise that the world has existed forever AND the root causes (greed, hate, and ignorance) for the existence of the world given by the Buddha.

- For example, on p. 7, Leibniz’s Principle of Sufficient Reason is discussed: For every truth, there must be a reason why it is so and not otherwise; and for every thing, there must be a reason for that thing’s existence. This is basically “cause and effect”. The Buddha said that the world exists because of the greed, hate, and ignorance; and those causes have no beginning.
- This is related to the issue of the mind taking precedence over matter, and I am slowly building evidence for that in the website. There are some introductory posts in the “Abhidhamma” and “Dhamma and Philosophy” sections.
- On p. 188, Jim Holt discusses the fact that all science says about the “stuff that makes up our world” is that mass is equivalent to energy, “....but it gives us no idea of what energy really is..”. This is exactly what is explained in Abhidhamma, and I will get to it eventually. He goes on to say, “...As Bertrand Russell noted in his 1927 book, *The Analysis of Matter*, when it comes to the intrinsic nature of the entities making up the world, science is silent”.
- He also briefly discuss another big issue in philosophy on p. 192: “*The conclusion of the philosophersthat there is more to consciousness than the mere processing of information. If this is true, then science, insofar as it describes the world as a play of information states, would seem to leave out a part of reality: the subjective, irreducibly qualitative part*”. Actually, as we will see, Buddha’s answer solves both this and the issue above in one fell swoop.
- A world without a beginning also gives an answer to the question of “why do I exist” (p. 18). We all have “existed” forever; there is no beginning so the question has no meaning. Another frequently asked question is, “what is the meaning of life?”. There is no meaning to life: The bottom line is that we all suffer in this existence ON THE AVERAGE, IN THE LONG TERM while we meander aimlessly among the 31 realms of existence; see, [“Evidence for Rebirth”](#).

5. Now the only critical question is how do we know that the Buddha’s world view is correct? The answer is that it can explain the complex world around us; it has the “explanatory power”. Also see, [“Vagaries of Life and the Way to Seek Good Births”](#) and [“Good Explanations – Key to Weeding out](#)

[Bad Versions of Dhamma](#)“, among many other posts.

- Furthermore, one can EXPERIENCE the truth of Buddha’s teachings and the results for oneself. I have described part of my experience in following the Path in, “[Ariya Jhanas via Cultivation of Saptha Bojjanga](#)“. Do not be discouraged by the title of the post.

6. Now let me briefly discuss the late chapter on, “The Self – Do I Really Exist?”. Here Jim Holt comes across the answer himself (p. 256): Talking about the Descartes’ famous phrase, “I think, therefore I exist”, he says, “... ..*Did Descartes here infer more than he was entitled to? As many commentators have pointed out (beginning with Georg Lichtenberg in the eighteenth century), the “I” in his ultimate premise is not quite legitimate. All Descartes could assert with certainty was “there are thoughts”. **He never proved that thoughts require a thinker.**.....*” (bold face mine).

7. This is exactly what the Buddha said. There are thoughts, but no REAL thinker; there is the PERCEPTION of a thinker in “one’s mind” until one’s mind is purified to the level of an Arahant and it becomes clear that there is no “thinker”. [However, the irony is that until that wisdom is gained, “one’s suffering” is real.](#) The suffering is there simply because one thinks there is a real thinker!

- But one cannot honestly say, “there is no-self” as most people try to do, unless one is an *Arahant*; one is just trying to fool oneself in saying that. When something bad happens to “anything that belongs to oneself” one INEVITABLY feels the pain associated with it; see, “[Anatta and Dukkha – True Meanings](#)“.
- When the mind is purified (i.e., is absent of greed, hate, and ignorance) perception of “self” goes away at the *Arahant* stage, then the suffering associated with “one’s stuff” is not there anymore. When one comprehends the concept of *anicca* to some extent, this will become clear to some extent. In other words, *Nibbanic* bliss or *niramisa sukha* increases as one advances on the Path, with the mind being purified at each step; see, “[Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha?](#)“, and “[Niramisa Sukha](#)“.
- Thus we cannot forcibly get rid of the sense of “I”. Only through the true understanding of the Three Characteristics of this world, *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, that one can slowly start getting rid of that sense of “I” or “self”. Until then there is neither a “self” nor “no-self”, but just a stream of thoughts; see, “[What Reincarnates? – Concept of a Lifestream](#)“. Only at the death of an *Arahant* that stream of thoughts is ended and the mind becomes free of any attachment to the material world of the 31 realms; see, “[Nibbana – Is it Difficult to Understand?](#)“, and “[What are Rupa? Relation to Nibbana](#)“.

“Waking Up” by Sam Harris

Sam Harris, “Waking Up: A Guide to Spirituality Without Religion” (2014).

1. I am quite encouraged by the fact that many people are beginning to see through something that is contrary to the basic human instincts: That it is possible to find a different and more permanent form of happiness that is not related to material things.

- Right at the start of the book, when he talks about his first “meditation retreat” at the age of 16 under harsh conditions in wilderness, the author says he was puzzled by the positive reaction of the older people in the group, “...*How could someone’s happiness increase when all the material sources of pleasure and distraction had been removed?*” (p.2).
- But now with many years of experience in meditation and studies on human nature as a neuroscientist, he can understand it: “..*Unlike many atheists, I have spent much of my life seeking experiences of the kind that gave rise to world’s religions. Despite the painful results of my first few days alone in the mountains of Colorado, I later studied with a wide range of monks, lamas, yogis, and other contemplatives, some of whom had lived for decades in seclusion doing nothing but meditating. In the process, I spent two years on silent retreat myself (in increments of one week to three months), practicing various techniques of meditation for twelve to eighteen hours a day*” (pp. 13-14).

2. Harris, like many others, has found that there is something about human life that cannot be explained away just in terms of the workings of the material world, but cannot quite pinpoint to the source of that “something extra”.

- Modern science has obliterated the concept of a “divine influence” as has been put forth by various religions, as Harris explains. So I was quite interested to see what his conclusion would be as to the “source of this extra something”.

3. On p.8, he makes a very valid statement: “*Spirituality must be distinguished from religion – because of people of every faith, and of none, have had the same sorts of spiritual experiences....Nothing that a Christian, a Muslim, and a Hindu can experience – self-transcending love, ecstasy, bliss, inner light – constitutes evidence in support of their traditional beliefs, because their beliefs are logically incompatible with one another. **A deeper principle must be at work***”. (my highlighting).

- This is exactly what I have trying to emphasize at this website.
- In the next very paragraph, he says what he found that deeper principle to be: “*That principle is the subject of this book: The feeling that we call “I” is an illusion*” (p. 9). This is probably the “no-self” theory that is erroneously presented as Buddha’s concept of “*anatta*”; see, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations](#)”.
- However, on that same page, he also summarizes most of my own conclusions about religions in general, including “Buddhism” the way as it is practiced by most in both Theravada and Mahayana sects.

4. I am just going to quote the relevant sentences from pp. 9-10: “*I am often asked what will replace religion. The answer, I believe, is nothing and everything. Nothing need replace its ludicrous and divisive doctrines....But what about love, compassion, moral goodness, and self-transcendence? Many people will imagine that religion is the true repository of their virtues. To change this we must talk about the full range of human experience in a way that is as free as the best science already is*”.

- And through the rest of the book he does go through that process. I agree with most of it, except of course that while “Buddhism” may be a religion, Buddha Dhamma is certainly not (if religion is defined as one providing salvation via following set rituals or having blind faith in an entity or a supreme being).

5. The key to Mr. Harris not understanding of Buddha Dhamma becomes apparent on p. 28: *“We can also grant that Eastern wisdom has not produced societies or political institutions that are any better than their Western counterparts. In fact, one could argue that India has survived as the world’s largest democracy only because of institutions that were built under British rule. Nor has the East led the world in scientific discovery. Nevertheless, there is something to the notion of uniquely Eastern wisdom, and most of it has been concentrated in or derived from the tradition of Buddhism”.*

- The problem here is that Mr. Harris has not had exposure to Buddha Dhamma, the “non-religious” original teachings.
- The focus of Buddha Dhamma, as delivered by the Buddha, was not on enhancing the mundane life and on building a better society. It was focused on the fact that it is in fact a “waste of time” to try to build large cities, develop technology, and in general to spend too much time on “making things better for this life”, because this life is only a brief stop-over in a much longer journey.

6. If one really understood the key message of the Buddha, one would see that this life is too short to be “wasted” on such things. This is due to three key foundational aspects of Buddha Dhamma:

- Human life, even though wrought with some suffering, is the best in all of 31 realms of this world for attaining Nibbana; see, the description of the wider world of 31 realms in, [“The Grand Unified Theory of Dhamma”](#).
- In the process of rebirth we spend only a tiny amount of time in this life of about 100 years; see, [“Evidence for Rebirth”](#).
- And immersing in mundane sense pleasures becomes only a hindrance to attain the “true and permanent happiness” of Nibbana; see, [“Three Kinds of Happiness – What is Niramisa Sukha”](#), and [“Niramisa Sukha?”](#).
- Of course, especially the Mahayana version of “Buddhism”, or even the Theravada version, has veered away from this key message of the Buddha.

7. Yet, I must hasten to point out two additional points:

- The Buddha stated that not everyone is able to comprehend this key message. Thus, for those who did not wish to pursue Nibbana, and asked for advice on how to live a moral and fulfilling family life while enjoying sensual pleasures, he did provide advice. In Chapter IV of Bhikkhu Bodhi’s popular book, *“In the Buddha’s Words”* (2005), such advice from different sutta have been extracted to one place; this book also has other categories separated out like good rebirths, mind etc.
- The Buddha never tried to change or influence the political systems that were in place, even though he praised the democratic system that was in place in the small autonomous region of Vajji, which was really a republic similar to the one we have now in the United States. Other than openly criticizing the caste system, he stayed away from politics.

8. I am impressed that Mr. Harris has been able to catch at least a glimmer of the uniqueness in

Buddha Dhamma despite the fact that he has not been exposed to the true teachings of the Buddha: *“Buddhism in particular possesses a literature on the nature of the mind that has no peer in Western religion or Western science. Some of these teachings are cluttered with metaphysical assumptions that should provoke our doubts, but many aren’t. And when engaged as a set of hypotheses by which to investigate the mind and deepen one’s ethical life, Buddhism can be an entirely rational enterprise”* (p. 29).

- The author is highly impressed with the Buddhist “vipassana” meditation. However, what he describes is just breath meditation or “samatha meditation”; see, [“Bhavana \(Meditation\)”](#).

9. And he has the concept of Enlightenment (*Nibbana*) all wrong (this says a lot about the *Mahayana* “Buddhism” that he has been exposed to): *“...the state of “full enlightenment” – is generally described as “omniscient”. Just what this means is open to a fair bit of caviling. But however narrowly defined, the claim is absurd”* (p. 43).

- To understand the concept of *Nibbana*, one must understand the world view of the Buddha as described in the above mentioned posts, and then one needs to read other posts at this site on describing *Nibbana* (just do a search with the key word *Nibbana* at the top right box on Keyword Search).

10. Interestingly, there is no mention at all about purifying the mind of defilements, which is key to true Buddhist meditation; see, [“The Importance of Purifying the Mind”](#).

- I do not blame the author of course, but it is sad to see how far “Buddhism” has veered off from the original message of the Buddha.
- It is these three root causes greed, hate, and ignorance (and the counterparts of non-greed, non-hate, and wisdom) that clarifies the basis of morality that he has puzzled over in two other books, *“The Moral Landscape”* (2011) and *“Free Will”* (2012).
- As Mr. Harris correctly points out in *“The Moral Landscape”*, *‘there is no such thing as Christian or Muslim morality’*. There is no “Buddhist morality” either. Morality is universal and comes out naturally on the basis of benevolence, compassion, and wisdom having precedence over greed, hate, and ignorance; see, [“Origin of Morality \(and Immorality\) in Buddhism”](#).

11. Chapter 2 is on consciousness. The author has a good introduction and his own thinking about consciousness may be expressed here: *“I am sympathetic with those who, like the philosopher Colin McGinn and the psychologist Steven Pinker, have suggested that perhaps the emergence of consciousness is simply incomprehensible in human terms”* (p. 57).

- Consciousness has also been fully explained by the Buddha. I have several introductory posts on consciousness at the site; see, [“What is Consciousness?”](#) and follow-up posts.
- I hope those who are interested would read the comprehensive description of the mind provided by the Buddha in the *Abhidhamma* section of this site, which may not be ready for an comprehensive analysis for several more months. But there are a few introductory posts there.

12. The rest of the book is about the author’s experience with trying out different types of meditations. It is too bad that he was not exposed to real Buddhist meditation. On the other hand, even in countries where the *Theravada* Buddhism is practiced, it is the breath meditation that is widely taught.

- Overall, I am impressed by the fact that even with the minimum exposure Mr. Harris had to

Buddha Dhamma, he has been able to see there “there is something hidden there”. I am glad to say that the Buddha did teach a much more deeper doctrine, and I am sure he and many others in the West will be enthusiastic about finding the true message of the Buddha.

- The author knows that as an atheist, he was treading into unknown territory in talking about spiritual experiences: “.....*many of my fellow atheists consider all talk of spirituality to be a sign of mental illness, conscious imposture, or self-deception. This is a problem, because millions of people have had experiences for which spiritual and mystical seem the only terms available*” (p.11).
- However, once one understands the true message of the Buddha, one can clearly see that there is nothing in his doctrine that goes against the beliefs and convictions of most atheists; Buddha Dhamma describes the Nature’s laws at a fundamental level.
- The only difference between science and Buddha Dhamma is that science assumes that mind phenomena can be derived from material phenomena, while in Buddha Dhamma mind is at the forefront; see, “[Philosophy of the Mind](#)“.

13. I encourage those who are interested to read the book because the author has not only contemplated deeply about the subjects of morality, questions on existence, world religions, etc, but also has tried to experience different meditation techniques. I only wish he had been exposed to the true teachings of the Buddha, so that he could perhaps make more stronger statements about the value of the Buddha Dhamma in addition to finding much more benefits for himself.

“The Language of God” by Francis Collins

This is a very popular book (published in 2007), as apparent from the large number of reviews on Amazon. The author is a respected scientist, and is director of the National Institutes of Health (NIH). This post is based on a review that I posted at the Amazon site back in 2012.

- I have read numerous books trying to find solid arguments for believing in a Creator. The author has put together the best case he could also using previous ideas of C. S. Lewis and others. The main points in the book can be summarized as follows (not in the order presented in the book):
1. God is responsible for the “Big Bang”, i.e., the creation of the universe, and for creating the just right physical parameters (fine tuning) for the ultimate formation of planet Earth which is suitable for human evolution.
 2. The “Intelligent Design” theory needs to be abandoned, since it may actually damage the case for the existence of God.
 3. Darwin’s theory of evolution does account for leading to the appearance of a “human-like” creature, even though the evolution of more complex animals is explained by the theory.
 - Whether this creature further evolved by itself to be human or whether at some point God directly instilled human conscience to this creature, he leaves it open.
 - Either way, God is responsible for the existence of morality in humans. This is the theory of “Theistic Evolution”, which he prefers to call “BioLogos”.
 4. The existence of “Moral Law” (the ability to differentiate right from wrong) is the fundamental basis for his belief in God.
 5. The issue of “pain and suffering” was a difficult issue for C. S. Lewis, and the present author also runs into difficulties in addressing it.

My comments are as follows:

1. Credible evidence is emerging that Big Bang was not just one event, but such events are of common occurrence, and there is no need to invoke a higher power.
 - Stephen Hawking, whose book “A Brief History of Time” that the author quoted to make a case for God’s role, has since come out with a new book “The Grand Design” (2010) where he clearly states that the need for a Creator God is no longer there based on new evidence.
 - Also, in the inflationary theory, there are Big Bangs occurring all the time, and there is no need to invoke a fine-tuning of physical parameters; see, “The Beginning of Infinity” by David Deutsch.
2. Actually “Intelligent Design” is a somewhat better theory than the hypothesis of a God, in the sense that the proponents of that theory have actually put forth some formidable arguments for it.
 - Of course I do not subscribe to that theory (which some say is making the case for a Creator God without admitting it), but Collins does not make a better case for the Creator God hypothesis.
 - The problem with the “Intelligent Design” theory is that of course the question arises as to how

that designer came into being! This is why many people say it is the same as the God hypothesis.

- If anyone is interested in learning about the “Intelligent Design” theory, a good book is “Signature in the Cell” by Stephen Meyer (2009).

3. The big question here is “where in this sequence did the God instill moral values in the evolving creature?”. Is there a clear-cut transition from a robotic animal to a human with moral values?

- The “uniqueness of a human” according to the author is the ability to know right from wrong. It is true that humans have this quality more stronger than in animals. Yet some animals also have at least a glimpse of this quality. If you have a pet, especially a dog, you know that it has feelings and also its own mind to do things, i.e., it is not like a robot.
- While people sometimes sacrifice their own life to save others, there are also people like Hitler and Pol Pot who have committed unmentionable atrocities over long times (not just on impulse).
- In Buddha Dhamma, both moral and immoral choices are built into “human psyche”; based on many complex factors (*sansaric* habits or “*gathi*”, family, friends, and associates, etc) people choose to be moral or immoral at different times depending on the situation. Of course, greed, hate, and ignorance play a big role.

4. Now on the existence of “moral law”: From #3 it is clear that even though morality is built into human psyche, it does not have a “binding effect” on humans. Humans are, in general, more “moral” than animals but within the wider world described by the Buddha Dhamma, there are other sentient beings (*devas* and *brahmas*) who are more “moral” than humans.

- If man is to be judged by just one life, why is it that everyone not given the same chance (including “same morality”)? People are born poor, rich, healthy, unhealthy, etc., and some die even before getting a chance to prove their worthiness.
- This quite apparent “vagaries of life” are a strong argument for the case that this life is only one of many, and the diversity that we observe is due to effects of past actions (*kamma vipaka*); see, “[Vagaries of Life and the Way to seek “Good Rebirths”](#)”.
- The basis of morality (as well as immorality) comes out naturally in Buddha Dhamma; see, “[Origin of Morality \(and Immorality\) in Buddhism](#)”.

5. Of course, the issue of “pain and suffering” — not only in this life but in the cycle of rebirths — is the basic problem of existence according to Buddha Dhamma.

- Again, the issue of “pain and suffering” cannot be explained by any approach that is based on just one life. Just like modern science, Buddha Dhamma is based on “causes and effects”. Suffering — as well as happiness — arises due to past causes, and since most of these effects (e.g., disability at birth, poverty) are even apparent at birth, “past” means past lives.

“Spark” by John Ratey

1. There is a good book, “Spark: The Revolutionary New Science of Exercise and the Brain” by John J. Ratey (2013), which discusses new findings on the effects of regular exercise on the brain as well as the body. (Most of the books I discuss are likely to be available at public libraries).
2. The book discusses how exercise can keep the brain working at a higher efficiency, lower stress and anxiety, get rid of addictions, and even Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder, ADHD. It also talks about women’s hormonal changes and aging too.
3. The key is to do moderate exercises up to 6 days a week and to ratchet it up to high intensity once-in-a-while, even for a minute at a time. For example, if you jog, try to run fast for 30s to 1 min once-in-awhile. This is called “interval running”.
 - Max heart rate for a person is $220 - \text{AGE}$.
 - low-intensity exercise: 55%-65% of max rate
 - moderate: 65%-75%
 - high intensity: 75%-90%
4. There are “wrist watch type” heart rate monitors available. But you basically “know” when you are at low intensity (walking), moderate (jogging/slow running), and high (dashing to catch a bus or running a 100 meter race).
 - Should not do high intensity unless you have been active for a while.
 - In the anaerobic range (high intensity), the brain releases human growth hormones (HGH). **This is a natural way to “get high”.**
 - Many other beneficial chemicals are released even at low-intensity, but all get a boost at high-intensity. All these are good for the sustenance/growth of neurons so that your memory can be improved.
 - But should not do high-intensity on a regular basis unless one is in great shape.
 - He also mentions yoga as a good activity. Any exercise, i.e., just walking, is better than none.
 - He discusses how children in a school district in PA are avoiding obesity and health problems and getting good grades because the schools have good exercise programs.
 - I find that the best time to meditate is after a good workout and a shower. The body and the mind are refreshed and alert.
5. We are born with a body and a mind that is a result of a specific *kamma vipaka* in the past. But we are not bound by either. We can make conditions conducive to get other “good *kamma* seeds” and to prevent “bad *kamma* seeds” from bearing fruits; see, “[Annantara and Samanantara Paccaya](#)”. Do not be discouraged by those Pali words. The post is easy to understand.
6. Exercise and meditate! That is key to a long healthy life as well for “cooling down” in the sense of getting some long-lasting peace-of-mind or attaining one of the four stages of *Nibbana*.
 - As we get old, it is imperative to keep both body and mind in good condition. It is hard to concentrate, let alone meditate, with an aching body or a defiled mind.

- At least walking a mile or two a day can keep one fairly healthy, and at least solving word puzzles or reading a book is better than watching television for the mind.

Sutta Interpretations

[“Sutta – Introduction”](#)

[“Maha Satipatthana Sutta”](#)

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[“Kayanupassana – Section on Postures \(Iriyapathapabba\)”](#)

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[“Maha Chattarisaka Sutta \(Discourse on the Great Forty\)”](#)

Sutta – Introduction

1. Buddha dhamma is structured to be presented via a method called, “*uddesa, niddesa, patiniddesa*”. A fundamental concept is first stated (“*uddesa*” or “utterance”); then it is described in a summarized way (“*niddesa*” or “brief explanation”), and then it is described in detail (“*patiniddesa*” where “*pati*” or “difficult/key” points).

- For example, “*anicca, dukkha, anatta*” is a *uddesa*, where the fundamental characteristics of “this world” are just stated. In the *uddesa* version, *paticca samuppada* is “*avijja paccaya sankhara, sankhara paccaya vinnana,.....*” (all 11 steps).

2. Each concept was described in detail in various *suttas*. For example, “*anicca, dukkha, anatta*” is described in the very first few *suttas* themselves (*Dhamma cakka pavattana sutta*, *Anatta lakkhana sutta* were the first two). However, each *sutta* took many hours to deliver, and it was not possible to condense all that information in a *sutta* for mostly oral transmission that was available at the time. Each *sutta* was made into a condensed form most likely by the Buddha himself; see below.

- Thus the material in each *sutta* **as written in the *Tipitaka*** is CONDENSED. This is the “*niddesa*” version.

3. During the time of the Buddha, other *bhikkhus* then described in detail each *sutta* to audiences when they delivered discourses. This is the “*patiniddesa*” version. Especially after the *Parinibbana* of the Buddha, **many *Arahants* started writing “*attakatha*” or commentaries on important *suttas*, but a few were written during the time of the Buddha.**

- Three of original books with such early commentaries have been preserved in the *Tipitaka*: *Patisambidha Magga Prakarana*, *Nettipparakana*, and *Petakopadesa*. Of these, the *Patisambidha Magga Prakarana* consists of the analyses by Ven. *Sariputta*, one of the chief disciples of the Buddha, and the *Nettipparakana* by Ven. *Maha Kaccayana*. Thus we are lucky to have these three original commentaries still with us.
- These three books contain the “*patiniddesa*” versions of many of the important *suttas*, which describe in detail the key words/phrases in a given *sutta*. All other such great commentaries have been lost; see, “[Historical Timelines of Buddha Dhamma and Sri Lanka – End of Sinhala Commentaries](#)”.

4. By the way, there are many erroneous commentaries that are available today, and the best example is the *Visuddhimagga* of *Buddhaghosa*. It was written at a time (around 400 CE; where CE is “Current Era” or AD) when the “pure Dhamma” was already lost and the conventional meanings were common place, just as now.

- Actually, we have had a long period from about 200 CE up to now that the “pure Dhamma” had been lost; see, “[Theravada: Problems with Current Interpretations of Key Concepts](#)”. But the original *suttas* survived because people at least used and preserved them even if they used the “conventional” (“*padaparama*” in Pali) meanings.
- Thus we can see why people have been translating *suttas* “word for word” and just getting the conventional meanings. They are NOT supposed to be TRANSLATED; they are supposed to be DESCRIBED in detail by bringing out the deep meanings of some of the words/phrases in the *suttas*.

5. From time to time *jati Sotapannas* are born; they had attained the *Sotapanna* stage in a previous

life, possibly during the time Buddha was alive, and have had births in the *deva loka* for long times and are reborn human. Some of them have the special capability to interpret the key words/phrases in the *suttas*. This special knowledge is called “*patisambidha nana*”.

- There has been at least one time previously that the real meanings were brought out by a *Thero* with the *patisambidha nana*, but this is not the time to discuss that.
- However, we have a few *Theros* at this time who have this ability. I will leave it upto others to decide for themselves whether this is true or not. I have experienced the benefits of these clarifications, and I just want to make them available for anyone who could benefit.

6. Here is my personal belief of what happened: The Buddha knew that Buddha Dhamma will be going through periods of decline where *bhikkhus* capable of interpreting the *suttas* will not be present. Thus the *suttas* were composed in a way that only the “conventional” meaning is apparent. **And that was a necessary step to preserve the *suttas*, especially before writing became common place.**

- It is important to remember that Ven. Ananda had memorized all the *suttas* which he then recited at the First Buddhist Council, just 3 months after the *Parinibbana* of the Buddha.
- Ven. Ananda was Buddha’s personal assistant over the last few decades of the Buddha’s life. I believe that the Buddha condensed each *sutta* and Ven. Ananda memorized each of them. The Buddha synthesized each *sutta* in a “double meaning” way in order for them to survive the “dark periods”.
- All that was done at the first Buddhist Council was to recite all the *suttas* and to put them into various categories (*nikayas*). This is my theory and I believe that it will be proven to be true in the future.

7. And during the times when *bhikkhus* with the *patisambidha nana* are not born for long times, it is those conventional interpretations that are adopted by people. **And that serves the purpose of keeping the *suttas* intact, especially before the written form was not common.**

- A very good example is the *Anapanasati sutta* (some of which are also part of the *Satipatthana sutta*). As we discussed in “[What is Anapana?](#)”, the conventional meaning is to tie up “*ana*” with breath inhaling and “*pana*” with breath exhaling and that was consistent with the breath meditation that is there in the world at any time (it was practiced by *yogis* at the time of the Buddha, and he actually learned those methods from such *yogis* before attaining the Buddhahood).
- Another phrase is “*majjima patipada*” in the *Dhamma cakka pavattana sutta*. It is easy to interpret it as “middle path” since the *sutta* describes the two extremes of *kamasukallikanu yoga* and the *attakilamatanu yoga*. People just ASSUMED “*majjima*” means middle and it made sense. We have to keep in mind that Pali was just a spoken language and to date it does not have an alphabet. Thus it was easy to change the meanings of the Pali words. The Pali word for middle is not “*majjima*” but “*madhayama*”. We will discuss that *sutta* in the future.
- “*Majji*” is getting intoxicated (with not only alcohol/drugs, but also with power, beauty, wealth, etc) and “*ma*” is to remove that tendency. Thus “*majjima patipada*” is to stay away from the extremes and to maintain a purified mind.

8. Regardless of the validity of my claims about the Buddha purposely synthesizing the *suttas* with

“double meanings”, the following are the key points from the above discussion that I wish to emphasize:

- The *suttas* seem to be designed to convey “conventional” meanings while keeping the “deep meanings” embedded in them.
- It is those “deep meanings” that bring out the uniqueness of Buddha Dhamma.
- Word to word translations of the *suttas* (with incorrect interpretations of key Pali words (like *anicca* and *majjima*) do not convey the message of the Buddha.
- The surviving three original commentaries in the *Tipitaka* can verify the deep meanings of the key words/phrases.

9. I will first discuss the foundation of the *Satipatthana sutta* in a “bottom-up” approach, starting with the goal of the *sutta* in mind and developing the related concepts. I have discussed many of the concepts in other posts, so it will be a matter of tying them up together.

- I thought that would be a refreshing approach than to start with the Pali version of the *sutta* and try to discuss each line.
- But at the end I will show how the lines in the *sutta* tally with this description. As the Buddha emphasized, what matters is to get the IDEA across, and NOT to memorize the Pali *suttas* (other than for transmission purposes).

10. There are some benefits in reciting *suttas*, and that effect is much more amplified if one recites them with understanding and also in an appropriate tune without too much “dragging” (there are some recordings in the [Sutta Chanting](#) section).

Next, “[Satipatthana Sutta – Structure](#)“,

Maha Satipatthana Sutta

[“Satipatthana Sutta – Structure”](#)

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[“Kayanupassana – Section on Postures \(Iriyapathapabba\)”](#)

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Satipatthana Sutta – Structure

1. There are several web pages that provide Pali version of the *sutta* and/or its English translation. I believe that they all are incorrect translations, and as I proceed I will explain why.

- Here is a website that provides Pali and English translations of the *sutta* side-by-side: <http://www.tipitaka.org/stp-pali-eng-parallel>
- It is not the fault of those who took their time with good intentions to write those posts; that is how this *sutta* and others have been interpreted for more than thousand years.
- I will not follow the *sutta* sequentially, but you will be able to follow the relevant sections. Eventually, I hope to cover most of the *sutta*.

2. As I explained in “[Sutta – Introduction](#)”, there are three ways of presenting Dhamma: *uddesa*, *niddesa*, *patiniddesa*.

- Most suttas don’t have the very brief summary, or *uddesa*, but the *Maha Satipatthana sutta* has it in the very beginning; see the above link in #1 which provides the complete *sutta* in Pali and English.
- Then in the main body of the *sutta*, the concepts are **outlined**. In a verbal discourse (called a *desana*), the concepts are described in detail and with examples. This is what I will be doing in these series of posts, i.e., to describe the concepts in detail.

3. The *uddesa* (or *uddeso*) starts with, “*Ekāyano ayaṃ, bhikkhave, maggō sattānaṃ visuddhiyā, sokaparidevanāṃ samatikkamāya, dukkhadomanassanaṃ atthagamāya, nāyassa adhigamāya, nibbānassa sacchikiriyāya, yadidaṃ cattāro satipaṭṭhānā*”

- The translation of that is, “This is one *guaranteed way*, monks, for the purification of beings, for the overcoming of sorrow and lamentation, for the extinguishing of suffering and grief, the noble way for gaining wisdom, for the realization of *nibbāna*: that is to say, the fourfold establishing of **moral mindset**”.

The main difference from the translation (conventional interpretation) given in the link in #1 above are the two phrases as highlighted above:

- It is not the only way to *Nibbana*; people had attained *Nibbana* before the Buddha delivered this discourse, but it is a systematic, **guaranteed way**, of attaining *Nibbana* at any level from “just cooling down” to the *Arahant* stage.
- The translation of “*nāyassa adhigamāya*” and “*satipaṭṭhāna*”: “*Nāya*” comes from “*nāna*” or wisdom, and “*adhigama*” is “*adhi*”+“*gama*” or “higher way”. I will discuss “*satipaṭṭhāna*” in the next post.

4. The next phrase is, “*Katame cattāro? Idha, bhikkhave, bhikkhu kāye kāyānupassī viharati ātāpī sampajānō, satimā vineyya loke abhiijjhā domanassaṃ. Vedanāsu vedanānupassī viharati ātāpī sampajānō, satimā vineyya loke abhiijjhā domanassaṃ. Cित्ते cittānupassī viharati ātāpī sampajānō, satimā vineyya loke abhiijjhā domanassaṃ. Dhammesu dhammānupassī viharati ātāpī sampajānō, satimā vineyya loke abhiijjhā domanassaṃ*”

- Of course, “*Katame cattāro?*” is, “Which four? (*cattaro* pronounced, “chaththarō”).
- And then it lists the four: *kāyānupassana*, *vedānānupassana*, *cittānupassana*, and

dhammanupassana. Notice that the phrase, “*ätäpi sampajāno, satimā vineyya loke abhijjhā domanassaṃ*” appears after each of the four.

- In most *suttas*, there is a lot of redundancy. This was done to emphasize the importance and also for ease of remembering for oral transmission.

5. We will discuss “*kāye kāyānupassi viharati*” etc in subsequent posts, but let us look at the common phrase, “*ätäpi sampajāno satimā, vineyya loke abhijjhā domanassaṃ*”.

- “*Tāpa*” (pronounced “*thäpa*”) means heat; when we get really stressful we feel a “fire” in the heart. When it gets really bad, people say, “I could feel my heart burn” when an especially poignant news comes through.
- And “*atäpi*” is to remove that “fire” from the heart and the stress from the mind, and calm the mind. This is the “cooling down”, “*niveema*“, “*nivana*“ or early stages of *Nibbana*.
- When one develops *satipatthana*, one would not feel that “burning up” even upon hearing tragic news. One will be able to “handle things” appropriately without taking drastic actions on the “spur-of-the-moment”.
- *Sampajana* comes from “*san*” + “*pajana*” or sorting out “*san*” the things that makes a mind stressful; see, “[What is “San”?](#)“. The worst forms of “*san*” are the one’s that we instinctively know to be immoral: killing, stealing, sexual misconduct, lying, and getting intoxicated.
- *Sampajana* is closely related to “*sampādetā*” as in the Buddha’s last words: “..*appamadena sampādetā*” or “..*make haste and sort out san*“. Here *sampādetā* is “*san*”+“*padetā*” or again sort out “*san*”.
- When one has done “*sampādetā*” one becomes “*sampajanno*”: One knows what is right and what is wrong automatically; it has become a habit.

6. Then we have, “*satima vineyya loke abhijjhā domanassaṃ*“. This is a highly condensed statement about the nature of this world.

- The root cause of all suffering is extreme greed or “*abhijja*” (which comes from “*abhi*” + “*iccha*” or strong craving or attachment). When that is not attained (which happens sooner or later), one gets depressed, this is *domanassa*. It is important to remember that one does acts of hate with a *domanassa* mindset, because one is upset and deflated and angry.
- “*Vineyya loke*” refers to this world where we are “bound to each other” via debt to each other; see, “[Kamma, Debt, and Meditation](#)”.
- And “*satima*” comes from “*sati*” + “*ma*” (which means removal, but not the removal of *sati*) which combines “*sati*” with the rest of the phrase, “*vineyya loke abhijjhā domanassaṃ*”.
- Thus “*satima vineyya loke abhijjhā domanassaṃ*” means establishing moral mindset and moral conduct in order to be free from the debt-ridden world and to be relieved from *abhijja* and *domanassa*. This is the key to “cooling down”.

7. This “cooling down” is done in four stages: *kāyanupassana*, *vedānanupassana*, *cittānupassana*, and *dhammanupassana*.

- These are somewhat sequential, in the sense that one needs to start with taking care of major sources of *abhijja* and *domanassa* with *kāyanupassana*.

- With the mind clear of the worst hindrances, then it will be easier to learn Dhamma with *dhammanupassana*, be easier not to REACT to feelings (*vedananupassana*) but to take time and evaluate consequences, and to think with a clear head (*cittanupassana*).
- Thus it is gradual process. Each advance helps with gaining confidence in one's actions, helps not to just react to feelings, helps to think with a clear head, which in turn helps with the understanding process.

8. The real breakthrough comes in *dhammanupassana*, when one COMPREHENDS the nature of this world, i.e., *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. Once that has been accomplished to a certain extent, moral conduct will be increasingly automatic; one will “feel” when one is about to do something wrong; one will become “sensitized”. But initially, it takes an effort to pause and think of the consequences.

Next, “[Satipatthana – Introduction](#)“,

Satipatthana – Introduction

1. First we need to figure out what “*sati*” means. Bear with me as I use some key Pali words, because it is important to understand them correctly. Things will become clear as we proceed below. Again, first try to read the post through without clicking on links, and then come back and read any relevant other posts as needed.

- *Sati* is a “good” mental factor (*sobhana cetasika*). Therefore, “*sati*” arises only in moral thoughts (*kusala citta*), and DOES NOT arise in *akusala citta*. As discussed in “[Cetasika \(Mental Factors\)](#)”, “good *cetasika*” do not arise in *akusala citta* (similarly, “bad *cetasika*” do not arise in *kusala citta*).
- This is important to realize at the outset. Many people think “*sati*” is “attention” or “mindfulness”. But a suicide bomber has to be mindful in wiring up the bomb, or a professional thief making plans for a grand robbery in minute detail needs pay total attention to it; “*sati*” is NOT involved in either case. The *cetasika* involved there, are the two “neutral” *cetasika* (which can appear in both *kusala* and *akusala citta*) of *vitakka* (focused application) and *vicara* (sustained application); see, “[Cetasika \(Mental Factors\)](#)”.
- There are others who believe “*sati*” is the ability to remember or recall past events, but it is the “*manasikara*” *cetasika* that does that.

When a person stops and contemplates whether an action one is about to take has moral or immoral consequences, and carries out only those actions that have moral consequences, then that person is acting with “*sati*”.

2. *Patthana* can mean establishment, prepare, or “to mold”. Therefore, “*satipatthana*” means establishment of “*sati*”, or train the mind to act with “*sati*” as described in the previous paragraph.

- This training process comes in four steps, and that is why it is also called “*sattara satipatthana*” where “*sattara*” means four. Even though the four steps are interrelated, there is a sequence. The four steps are *kayanupassana*, *vedananupassana*, *cittanupassana*, and *dhammanupassana*.
- The meaning of “*anupassana*” is described in point #4 of “What do all these Different Meditation Techniques Mean?” in the Meditation section.

3. Buddha Dhamma is all about cleansing the mind; that is the key to real and lasting tranquility of the mind. A defiled mind generates defiled thoughts (*citta*). Defiled thoughts lead to defiled speech (with a time lag) and defiled actions (with even longer time lag).

- **The sequence of cleansing the mind is backwards:** First control bodily actions, then (or simultaneously) to control speech, and controlling thoughts (as they arise) is harder. This is important to understand, so let us look into the reasons.

4. As discussed in the Abhidhamma section, thoughts (*citta*) arise very fast; there are well over billions of *cittas* per second; but of course we “experience” only “bundles of *citta*” accumulating for at least about 0.05 seconds. **Even then it is not possible to control thoughts by sheer will power.**

- But our thoughts are dictated by our character and habits (“*gathi*”). And, these character qualities (*gathi*) can be changed with concerted effort by controlling one’s speech and actions. We have discussed “*gathi*” in many posts spread over different sections.

5. This is why *kayanupassana* comes first in *Satipatthana*. We first discipline ourselves by making sure

we speak only moral words, and do only moral actions. Both speech and actions arise from thoughts, but they come with a “time lag”. We first think that “this person has done something bad to me”, and then we start saying something bad to the person. But there is enough of a ‘time lag’ to stop saying it.

- We tend to take “bodily actions” with even longer delay than for speech. So, unless one is in a rage, there is enough time to catch oneself and stop any bad actions. Actually, when we get good at it, and control both speech and actions, such instances of acting with rage will diminish with time, and will go away. This is because the more we act with “sati”, the more that we give up bad “gathi” and cultivate good “gathi”.

6. Thus Kayanupassana basically means “catching ourselves before we say or do something wrong”.

- Put in another way, what we need to accomplish with kayanupassana is to be aware of our speech and actions AT ALL TIMES. By now it must be clear why satipatthana cannot be restricted to a “formal sitting down meditation session”.
- We say or do things in response to what we see, hear, smell, taste, touch, or think. The speech or actions have time delays from the time we get the “input” from outside or even if generated by the mind itself. Even if we start saying something bad, we can catch ourselves and stop (and apologize if we hurt someone’s feelings). Even if get up to hit someone, we can realize the bad consequences of such an action and immediately stop. That is how one starts.

7. With practice, one’s **gathi** will change, and such awkward instances will occur less and less. There are many posts on “gathi” at the site, and there are some in the meditation section under, “Key to Anapanasati – How to Change Habits and Character (Gathi)”. Satipatthana is basically a methodical way of doing anapanasati. A scientific view is discussed in, “[How Habits are Formed and Broken – A Scientific View](#)”.

8. Therefore, it is easy to see that kayanupassana is the first and most important part of the satara satipatthana.

- When kayanupassana is practised, one’s “gathi” will gradually change and one will start to calm down. And one will not REACT to feelings on an impulsive basis, and thus it will be easier to practice the next stage of “vedananupassana”, i.e., “think about how to respond when certain feelings arise”.
- When both those are practised, “gathi” will change to an extent that even initial thoughts will have “less venom”, and thus it will be easier to practice “cittanupassana” or “think morally” automatically.
- Finally, it will be easier to get into samadhi and to contemplate anicca, dukkha, anatta (or any other Dhamma concept), which is “dhammanupassana”.

9. Thus one starts with kayanupassana first and then move on to other three “anupassana”. When one completes all four one completes the process and will have “samma sati” in full, which leads to “samma samadhi” in full, i.e., Arahanthood.

- Of course, that is normally accomplished in four stages, the first of which is the Sotapanna stage.
- Just like it is not possible to attend middle school without attending the primary school, or to take college courses without passing high school, one needs to go through the four steps methodically. One needs to control one’s actions and speech first. That is what “kayanupassana”

is about. We will discuss that in detail in the next post.

- This does not mean that one should not do the other three while doing kayanupassana; it just means there is “not much benefit” in doing the other three unless one is actively engaged in stopping the “BIG EIGHT” done with speech and body; see, “2. The Basics in Meditation”.
- And one does not stop doing kayanupassana, ever. It is not something to be done forcefully, it will become a habit. When one sees the benefits, one would want to advance. One just keeps incorporating other three gradually and soon enough will be doing all four. But kayanupassana is the FOUNDATION.

Next, “[Kayanupassana – The Section on Postures \(Iriyapathapabba\)](#)“,

Kayanupassana – Section on Postures (Iriyapathapabba)

1. Let us first clarify what *kayanupassana* means. There are two interchangeably used meanings for “*kaya*”: one is the body, the other is whatever is involved in “*kriya*” or “actions”. In *kayanupassana* the latter is more general. This section on postures is based on body postures, but is still concerned with all “actions” done via all six senses. This will become clear as we proceed below.

- It is normally written as “*kayanupassana*”, but is ALWAYS pronounced as “*kāyanupassana*”.
- In interacting with the world, we see visuals (*rupa*) with eyes, hear sounds with ears, smell odors with nose, taste with the tongue, touch (*pottabba*) with body, and think about concepts (*dhamma*) with the mind.
- Thus there are six internal “*kaya*”, and six external “*kaya*” involved in experiencing the world. Thus we are concerned with both the internal sense faculties (*ajjhata*, pronounced “*ajjhaththa*”) and the six external entities (*bahiddha*), while we are in any of the four main postures of sitting, standing, walking, or lying down.

2. When one starts on the Path, one does not need to believe in anything that the Buddha (or anybody else) said about the true nature of the world. One can start with a simple goal of “getting some peace of mind” or “get some relief from the day-to-day stresses of this world”, i.e., get to the “*atāpi*” stage.

- One can keep an open mind on whether there is rebirth or not, whether the concept of *kamma* is correct or not (of course one should not rule out those either; that would be “*niyata micca ditthi*” and one WILL NOT be able to make any progress); see, “[How do we Decide which View is Wrong View \(Ditthi\)?](#)”.

3. The Buddha said that the mind is burdened by greed, hate, and ignorance. It is not easy to see “the truth” (i.e., to remove ignorance) because the mind is normally “covered” by strong versions of greed and hate called “*kamachanda*” (one becomes blind by greed) and “*vyapada*” (one keeps going downward with intense hate); **you can do keyword searches to find related posts.**

- And these two, *kamachanda* and *vyapada* are the main culprits for making a mind stressful, and for causing “inside fires”. Thus by forcibly removing any thoughts of extreme greed and hate as they come to the mind, one can get relief in real time. One does not have to wait for “effects of *kamma* to materialize”. Such benefits will be there too, but one WILL be able to experience more immediate benefits.
- This is the beginning of “cooling down” or experiencing *niramisa sukha*, as explained in the post, “[Three Kinds of Happiness](#)”.

4. As explained in the previous post, “[Satipatthana – Introduction](#)”, we start by disciplining our actions through speech and bodily actions, because they have a “time lag” and there is enough time to stop them willfully.

- We can start with the conventional five precepts. Without that basic discipline, one CANNOT get any kind of long-lasting peace of mind, no matter how much time one spends in meditation.
- If one is engaged in any of these five (intentional killing of living beings, stealing, sexual misconduct, lying, and using alcohol excessively or using drugs), and can abstain from them one should be able to experience the benefits of that in the near term.

5. After that one can tackle the BIG EIGHT (killing, stealing, sexual misconduct, lying, gossiping,

slandering, harsh speech, and getting “drunk” with not only drugs or alcohol, but also with wealth, fame, power, etc); see, “[The Basics in Meditation](#)”.

6. The *kayanupassana* of the *satipatthana* consists of five sections or “*pabba*”: *Anapanapabba* (section on “*anapana*”), *Iriyapathapabba* (section on postures), *Sampajanapabba* (section on habits), *Patikulamanasikarapabba* (section on contemplation of body parts), *Dhatumanasikara* (section on contemplation of elements), and *Navasivathikapabba* (section on contemplation of the decay of a body). We have already discussed *anapana* in several posts, starting with “[What is Anapana?](#)”.

The “*Iriyapathapabba*” section of the *Kayanupassana* in the *Satipatthana sutta* is all about how to abstain from committing an immoral act AT ANY TIME.

- We have four postures or “*iriya*”: sitting, standing, walking, and sleeping (laying flat).
- In any posture, we need to be vigilant on what we are about to do or speak. This is the beginning of “*satipatthana*”, being “morally mindful” at all times.
- When a thought comes to mind to say something or to do something (whether sitting, standing, walking, or lying down), we need to get into the habit of contemplating their consequences.

6. For example, we may be walking on the street and see someone, whom we do not like, coming our way. If we get the tendency to say something bad, we have enough time to contemplate the bad consequences and stop saying those words.

- We may be lying in bed and getting bored, and may decide to go and see a friend to do some “gossiping” for fun. We have time to think about it and see whether we can use that time more productively.
- Sometimes we get “nasty e-mails”; someone pointing out an allegedly bad deed that we have done. We get that immediate “*tāpa*” or “heating up” in our heart because we get so perturbed by that false accusation. We tend to fire up an equally nasty e-mail back to that person. But we need to take time and contemplate a better action. Give that person the benefit of the doubt; may be he/she did not do it to aggravate us, or truly was misled. Of course, there are people who do such things purposely to aggravate, but even then it is better to ignore it, rather than letting it develop into a worse situation. Learning to keep away from such troublemakers is a habit that we learn to develop. By responding in kind, it will not help quenching the “fires”.

7. We need to constantly ask ourselves “why am I going to do this? Why am I going to say this?”. If the outcome of that action could hurt us or someone else, we need to think about a different way, or totally abandon it.

- It is sad to see that many people waste their time “walking mindfully” one step at a time, just concentrating on taking each step, or “lifting their arm mindfully” This is the “*iriya*” that is being practiced in most places. How can that procedure lead to a long-lasting peace of mind? Of course, just like doing breath meditation, it can make a person calm for the time being; that is the ONLY benefit.
- And it is not enough to do this in a formal session. This needs to become a habit (a keyword search can be done to find more on habits; developing habits is the key to change those all important “*gathi*”). Buddha Dhamma is all about purifying the mind.

8. If one can do this for a week or so, one should be able to see a change in oneself; a sense of tranquility, a “peace of mind”. Of course some of you may be there already. We will discuss how to

take the next step in the next post.

- When one is at this stage, it will be easier to get into *samadhi*, even if one is just doing the “breath meditation”. A moral mind is easy to be calmed. Many people do horrible acts on the spur-of-the-moment because they do not have this mindset or habit. Also see, “[Possible Outcomes of Meditation – Samadhi, Jhana, Magga Phala](#)”.

Next, “[Kayanupassana – The Section on Habits \(Sampajanapabba\)](#)“,

Kayanupassana – The Section on Habits (Sampajanapabba)

This is really an extension of the section on postures (*Iriyapathapabba*) discussed in the previous post, going into finer postures and activities. The key point is ultimately to become “sensitized” to each and every action that we take thus leading to the formation of “good habits”, i.e., to become a “*sampajanno*”.

1. One cannot start on this section until one has acquired discipline with the “bigger activities”. For example, if one is killing animals for fun, then there is no point in worrying about kicking a dog.

- As one gets some practice with abstaining from major offenses, one will become “sensitized”, i.e., one will start seeing minor offenses that one is about to make.

2. The relevant paragraph on the *Sampajanapabba* in the *sutta* reads:

“*Puna ca param, bhikkhave, bhikkhu abhikkante patikkante sampajānakāri hōti, ālokité vilokité sampajānakāri hōti, saminjité pasārite sampajānakāri hōti, sanghātipattacivaradhārane sampajānakāri hōti, asite pite khāyite sāyite sampajānakāri hōti, uccārapassāvakamme sampajānakāri hōti, gate thite nisinne sutte jāgarite bhāsīte tunhibhāve sampajānakāri hōti*”.

Here is the conventional translation, which is word by word:

- “Again, monks, a monk, while going forward or backward, he does so with constant thorough understanding of impermanence; whether he is looking straight ahead or looking sideways, he does so with constant thorough understanding of impermanence; while he is bending or stretching, he does so with constant thorough understanding of impermanence; whether wearing his robes or carrying his bowl, he does so with constant thorough understanding of impermanence; whether he is eating, drinking, chewing or savouring, he does so with constant thorough understanding of impermanence; while attending to the calls of nature, he does so with constant thorough **understanding of impermanence**; whether he is walking, standing, sitting, sleeping or waking, speaking or in silence, he does so with constant thorough understanding of impermanence”.

3. Thus many possible “finer posture and actions” can be seen in the above direct translation, which are correct. The point is to be “morally mindful” in each and every such action, and not just to do those acts like a robot just in a formal setting as most people do.

- I am not sure where “impermanence” came from, apparently as the translation of the word, “*sampajānakāri*”. But as was explained in the post, “[Satipathana Sutta – Structure](#)”, *sampajano* means knowing right from wrong (“*san*”) via enhanced wisdom.
- Thus *sampajānakāri* means doing something the right way, and *sampajānakāri hōti* means becoming that.

4. When one goes into finer details on “being morally mindful” of one’s actions, one is not just concerned with killing, stealing, etc. One is also concerned about general welfare, that one should act with civility and be courteous to others: one should be wearing proper clothes appropriate for the occasion, when eating one should not be making inappropriate noises, while walking in a crowded street one should be mindful of the others and not throw one’s refuse on the roadside, etc.

- As I pointed out in the post, “[Sutta – Introduction](#)”, a *sutta* gives instructions in the “*niddesa*” or as a brief description. It needs to be EXPLAINED rather than doing a direct translation. Any

sutta was originally delivered over a number of hours, and then summarized in a special way to make it brief and suitable for oral transmission.

5. A case in point is the direct translation of “..*uccārapassāvakamme sampajānakārī hoti*”, as “while attending to the calls of nature, he does so with constant thorough understanding of impermanence!” (from the conventional translation in #2 above).

- What is meant there is to act with decency and not to relieve oneself in an inappropriate place. In all those cases, *sampajānakārī hoti* means acting with diligence and prudence.

6. There are many other aspects too. For example, if one is about to take a nap in the middle of the day, one should be asking oneself why one needs to take nap. Unless one had engaged in some strenuous activity and really needs to get some rest, it is not a good habit to take unnecessary naps. Then it could become a habit, a bad one.

- We should also develop good habits. While walking on the street, it is good to help out those who need help, and to be courteous to others. A small thing like not spitting in a public place or just dropping trash anywhere one pleases can cause discomfort for others.
- Of course with each minor act we should also make sure it does not pan out to immoral activities. A good example is drinking too much. Drinking alcohol is not an *akusala kamma* per se (and there is nothing wrong with taking a drink in a social setting), but there is danger in getting intoxicated. An intoxicated mind can be very dangerous; one could lose any sense of decency, and may get into situations that are immoral and offensive. Both drinking and smoking can be harmful to oneself and also to others.

7. As one develops good habits and gets rid of bad ones, one becomes more and more “sensitized” and catch even minor mistakes. At the same time, one will start seeing a big improvement in one’s “inside fires”, but one also becomes less prone to be aggravated or offended, and one becomes more forgiving to others.

- There are many posts at the site on habits, and how they can lead to *sansaric* habits and *asavas*; developing good habits and getting rid of bad habits is key to “cooling down” in the short term as well as in the long term.
- Parents, teachers, and friends play key roles in a child’s life, because a child’s mind can be influenced by others in a good or bad ways, and can lead to lifelong habits. If the foundation is set right, then it will be easier for one to become a “*sampajanno*”, one who is capable of “keeping fires under control”.

8. This is what was meant by being a “*sampajanno*”, being able to “quench fires”, i.e., “*atapi sampajano*”, which was a key phrase in the *uddesa* (brief description) of the *Satipatthana sutta*; see, “[Satipatthana Sutta – Structure](#)”.

Next, “[Prerequisites for the Satipatthana Bhavana](#)“,

Prerequisites for the Satipatthana Bhavana

As you may have noticed, I am not going to follow the *sutta* in the formal order. I would like to present it in a way that is conducive to the present day. However, at the end it will become clear that everything in the *sutta* has been discussed.

1. From the previous two posts it is clear that this meditation is **not just to be practiced in a formal session**, even though formal sessions can and should be done. In particular, *Dhammanupassana* needs to be done in formal sessions, which we will discuss shortly. With that in mind let us look at how the *sutta* begins (after the *uddesa* or the “brief description” section, to which we will get back later):

“*Kathaṃ ca pana, bhikkhave, bhikkhu kāye kāyupassī viharati?*”

- Here and many other other places, “*ca*” is pronounced “*cha*”.
- Here “*viharati*” means “to live”. Thus what it says is, “Bhikkhus, what is meant by living with *kayanupassana* of the body (*kaye kayanupassana*)?”.
- This should make it very clear that the *bhavana* is not just to be practised in a formal session; one has to “live it”.

2. Now let us look at the next phrase that describes how to prepare for the *bhavana*:

“*Idha, bhikkhave, bhikkhu aranna gato vā rukkhamūla gato vā sunnāgāra gato vā nisidati pallankaṃ ābhujitvā, ujum kāyaṃ paṇidhāya, parimukhaṃ satiṃ upaṭṭhapetvā*”.

- The conventional translation is something like, “Here a monk, having gone into the forest, or to the foot of a tree, or to an empty room, sits down cross-legged, keeps his body upright and fixes his awareness in the area around the mouth”.
- Of course, this is a good thing to do if one is going to do a formal session, except that one should focus the awareness not “around the mouth” but on the object of contemplation as we will discuss later.

3. I pointed out in the introduction how the *sutta* (like most other *suttas*) was apparently designed convey the above “conventional” meaning while keeping the deeper meaning hidden; see, “[Sutta – Introduction](#)”. This is a good example of how this was accomplished. Let us describe the above sentence in detail. However, I may not be able to go into such details for the rest of the *sutta*, because it will take up too much space.

Continuing with the interpretation of the phrase in #2, “*gatō va*” means “get in to” or in the deeper sense, “get into the mindset”.

- *Aranna* is a forest (or forest monastery). But the hidden meaning comes from “*rana*” which means “battle” and thus “*aranna*” means staying away from battles. Thus, “*aranna gatō vā*” means “get into a calm mindset leaving behind the everyday battles”. In the conventional interpretation is says, “having gone into the forest”.
- “*rukka*” is “tree” and “*mula*” is the “root”; even though the top of a tree sways back and forth with the wind, the tree trunk close to the root is very stable. Thus “*rukkhamūla gato va*” means getting to a stable mindset. In the conventional interpretation is says, “having gone to the foot of a tree”.

4. Next, “*sunnāgāra*” is an empty building or room. The deeper meaning is that the mind should be

empty of greed, hate, and ignorance. One should dispel any such thoughts that comes to the mind.

- Now comes, “*nisidati pallankaṃ ābhujitvā*”, which is translated as, “sits down cross-legged”. The key word here is, “*anka*” or literally “number”; in Pali or Sinhala, “reduce the number” or “*palla+anka*” means not giving importance. Thus “*nisidati pallankaṃ ābhujitvā*” means, “being modest” and getting rid of any sense of “superiority”.
- And, “*ujum kāyaṃ paṇidhāya*” is translated, “keeps his body upright”. In the deeper meaning, it is about being “straightforward” or forthright and honest.

5. Finally, “*parimukhaṃ satiṃ upaṭṭhapetvā*” is the KEY to *Satipatthana*: It is translated literally as “fixes his awareness in the area around the mouth”. What is actually meant is to keep the mind on the main object (called “*mukha nimittā*”), i.e., “*Nibbana*” or “cooling down”.

- Thus what is described in that sentence is the required mindset for the meditator, whether he/she is going to be “meditating” in any one of the four postures described in the previous post, not just in a sitting down formal meditation session.

6. Thus the “preparation instructions” in that opening phrase can now be stated something like, “get into a calm and stable mindset that is devoid of greed, hate, and ignorance; keep a modest attitude without any sense of superiority; be forthright and honest, and keep the mind on the main object of cooling down”.

- Such a state of mind needs to be cultivated for all times. That is the key to cooling down on a long-term basis.
- Of course the conventional interpretation can also be used for sitting down, formal, sessions **without** “fixing awareness in the area around the mouth”. One ALWAYS focuses on cooling down, and becoming an “*ātāpi sampajannō*”; see, “[Satipatthana Sutta – Structure](#)“, and “[Kayanupassana – The Section on Habits \(Sampajanapabba\)](#)“.
- Thus the idea is for one to become a “firefighter” (“*ātāpi sampajannō*“), who is always on the lookout not for actual fires, but for those mental events that CAN LEAD TO mental fires in the future. These are basically any immoral acts, speech, or thoughts.

7. There are five sections or “*pabba*” in the *kayanupassana*. The reason that I described the *Iriyapathapabba* (“section on postures”) and the *Sampajanapabba* (“section on habits”) in the previous posts was to emphasize the point that this *bhavana* cannot be restricted to a formal session. One could say, “How can I be meditating the whole day?”. This question arises only because of the misconceptions we have on what meditation or “*bhavana*” is.

- The Buddha said, “*bhavanaya bahuleekathaya*”, or “*bhavana* is what what one does all the time”. It is about getting into the habit of developing good habits and getting rid of bad habits.
- One can just make it a “formal session” in order to get into deeper levels of *samadhi* or *jhanas*.

8. Buddha Dhamma is not a religion in the sense of providing “salvation” by following certain rules or procedures. The Buddha said the only way to achieve long-lasting happiness is to purify the mind. It starts with avoiding the worst immoral acts of killing, stealing, etc. When one sees the benefits of that one can go a step further and include gossiping, slander, etc. and so on.

- The more one purifies one’s mind, the true nature of this world will become increasingly clear. One cannot read about it in one essay or even many essays. One has to put it into action. Even

though it is good to read about *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, it is not possible to “get it” until one purifies one’s mind to a certain extent AND experiences the “cooling down” that results from a purified mind; this will be discussed in the *Dhammanupassana*.

9. *Satipatthana sutta* describes a very methodical way of following the Path prescribed by the Buddha. **Initially, one does not even have to worry about whether rebirth is valid or whether there are 31 realms of existence.** One just focuses on realizing that there are “internal fires” (*ātāpi*) that we are not even aware of; see “[Satipatthana Sutta – Structure](#)”.

- As one purifies the mind, one can clearly see and FEEL these fires and how they start. When one clears up the “big fires” one is able to see and feel smaller ones; one becomes more “sensitized”. And then one tackles those smaller fires. It is a gradual, step-by-step process. That is why it is called the Path. The higher one climbs on the Path, the more one can “see” and get rid of, and more happier one becomes.

Next, “[What is “Kaya” in Kayanupassana?](#)“,

What is “Kaya” in Kayanupassana?

1. There are two meanings to “*kaya*”: one is “*kaya*” for the body, and the other “*kāya*” as in “*sabba kāya*”. **The first one is included in the second.** Thus, in general “*kaya*” refers to “*sabba kāya*” in *Kayanupassana*.

“*Sabba kāya*” can be mainly divided into two categories: *Ajjatta* and *bahijja*, or “internal” and “external”. “*Sabba*” means all and “*sabba kaya*” includes everything that is in this world, which can also be stated as “*pancakkhandha*”; see, “[Five Aggregates – Introduction](#)“, and follow-up posts.

2. The *ajjatta* or the internal means the six senses: five physical senses and the mind. *Bahijja* or the external world is what we interact with those six senses: pictures, sounds, smells, tastes, touch, and *dhamma* (things which we think about).

- Even though “*rupa*” is commonly used to pictures (which are really “*vanna*”) , *rupa* includes sounds, smells, tastes, and touch. **To avoid confusion, I will just use the term “*rupa*” to include sounds, smells, tastes, and touch as well as pictures for the rest of the post.**

3. Something is a picture or a visual object only when one is seeing it. A moment later it is only a memory, and it is now a “old picture”. If we visualize a house that we are building, that is also a picture in the memory plane, a “future picture”. As we discussed in *pancakkhandha*, *khandha* can be divided into 11 categories: past, present, future, near, far, likeable, distasteful, fine (not strong), coarse (strong), internal, and external.

- For example, feelings (*vedana*) *khandha* can be any in the 11 categories. Here, near and far means recent or way back in the past. Internal is one’s own and external is feelings of the others; one needs to be aware of other’s feelings in the sense that “if I do this, it could cause a feeling of grief to so and so”, as an example.

4. It is good to contemplate on these concepts and have a good idea how different representations mean the same things: *Pancakkhandha* is the same as “*sabba kaya*”, both include “everything in this world”. Please send me a comment if this not clear. Many people think “*kayanupassana*” is just about one’s body, and that is not correct.

- But we don’t think about the “whole world” out there either. We think about a tiny fraction of that “world out there”. **AND we get attached to (*tanha*) even a smaller fraction.**
- Thus even though *pancakkhandha* (five aggregates) is unimaginably large, the fraction of *pancakkhandha* that we interact with or think about is very small. [And we form attachments \(via greed or hate\) to even smaller fraction](#), and this is the *pancaupadanakkhandha*, the aggregates that we attach to with greed and hate (and ignorance). *Upadana* means “drawn to”, and that is what one grasps willingly because one thinks there is happiness in them.
- For example, we all know about the zillions of stars out there, or about the other planets in our Solar system; but do not generate any greed or hate about them. We only attach to **some of the pictures**, sounds, smells, tastes, and touch that we interact with daily, which is indeed a tiny, tiny fraction of the “world out there”. The biggest component of our “*pancaupadanakkhandha*” is the dhamma aggregate, the things we think about. Let us discuss this a bit more.
- [Thus here we are concerned with only a tiny fraction of “*sabba kāya*”: Only those that lead to greed, hate, or ignorance. This is the same as *pancaupadanakkhandha*, which is a tiny fraction of *pancakkhandha*.](#)

5. When we contemplate on this a bit more, we realize that most of pictures, sounds, smells, tastes, and touch we think about belong to the dhamma category. A long series of thoughts may start with an “old picture” that is in our memory (say an old friend), and then we start generating more thoughts about that person, and then we get into something altogether different: We may think about the nice neighborhood that person is living in and then start thinking about building a house there. Thus we may end up thinking (generating *sankhara*) about something totally different. Thus it now belongs to the *dhamma* category.

- Later, we need to focus about such thoughts and dhamma in the “*cittanupassana*” and “*dhammanupassana*”. What we need to do in “*kayanupassana*” is to mainly control our speech and actions first. This way we will be able to slowly change our habits (*gathi*) and start controlling our “automatic actions” that we used to do almost on impulse.

6. We already discussed how we need to be “morally mindful” while we are in any of the four main postures (*Iriyapathapabba*), and also in any of “sub-postures” or basically any movement (*sampajanapabba*). In both these, we are being aware of what is happening at the present moment with our six senses: basically only those external (*bahijja*) rupa using the six internal rupa (*ajjatta*).

- For example, we see a likeable picture (a person or an item) we need to immediately think about whether it is appropriate to take the action that automatically comes to our mind with our old habits. We may be waiting at the airport for the next flight and see a bar; instead of going there and have a drink, it may be more productive to get on to the internet and read something useful. If one is really tired, it may be more productive to take a nap.
- In another example, someone may come to you and accuse you of doing something wrong. Instead of just retaliating, it may be a good idea to calm down and listen to that person first to see whether you have indeed done something unknowingly to aggravate that person.

7. As we discussed in the post, “[What do all these Different Meditation Techniques Mean?](#)”, *Anupassana* means “discard according to the principles learned” (“*anu*” means according to and “*passana*” means to get rid of). We need to logically think of what would happen if a certain action is taken; if that seems to lead to a “bad ending” we need to discard it.

- Thus “*kayanupassana*” in the *iriyapathapabba* and the *sampajanapabba* means contemplate on the moral consequences of an act one is about to do and abstain from doing it if it seems to have bad consequences.

8. Now, there are three sections in the *kayanupassana* where one specifically contemplates on the physical body. These are, *patikulamanasikarapabba*, *dhatumanasikarapabba*, and *navasivathikapabba*. These sections involve just contemplating on the nature of our physical bodies.

In the *patikulamanasikarapabba* the 32 parts of the body are discussed. It is amazing how our perception of a hair in the dinner plate is so different from the admiration we have for our own hair that is attached to our head. The hair in the plate could be one of our own, but still we do not like it.

The nail on the finger is something we admire, take care and sometimes paint too. But as soon as it is cut, it becomes something not appealing.

9. What we form a liking for is the “whole complete package” with all 32 parts that are in “good condition”. We get distraught when hair starts greying, or the skin starts sagging. A beautiful person may become ugly in an instant if the face becomes disfigured due to some mishap.

The reality is that all the above IS GOING TO HAPPEN to us in the future. As long as there is birth, there is decay and death.

10. The section (*pabba*) on *dhatumanasikarapabba* is to contemplate on the fact that all our bodies are composed of just four entities: *patavi* (solidness), *apo* (liquidness), *tejo* (heat or warmth), *vayo* (wind). Out of the six *dhatu*s, *akasa* (space) is there too, but *vinna* (consciousness) does not belong to the physical body.

- Ours or anyone's else's body, whether beautiful or ugly, is composed on these four things. There is nothing special.

11. The third section (*pabba*) of the physical body, *navasivathikapabba*, is to contemplate on what happens to a dead body over the course of many months if left out on the ground to decay (as was commonly done at the time of the Buddha).

- Again, whether it is a body of a homeless person or an emperor, the same decay process will take place, and eventually all body parts will be absorbed to the ground or released to the air.

12. All three of those sections are to help us lose attachments to our physical bodies. The purpose is NOT to get distraught, but to develop wisdom to realize that it is common to us all and will happen.

- A major component of our suffering arises when we eventually realize that we cannot maintain things to our satisfaction. Most people do not like to think about this inevitability. They just want to “whatever it takes” to maintain a beautiful body. The more one does that, the more one will be depressed later.
- Instead what we should do is to try to maintain a healthy body by eating well and sticking to a good exercise program. It is not “eye catching aspect” that matters, but being able to enjoy life to extent possible but not letting it get sick or prematurely decayed.
- Eating healthy foods and exercising regularly (see, [“Spark” by John Ratey](#)) will keep the body and the mind in good condition, so that we will have enough time to at least get to the *Sotapanna* stage of Nibbana.

13. It is important to remember that in all these “*anupassana*“, we need to contemplate on the Three Characteristics of nature (*anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*) when we contemplate on the unfruitfulness in attaching to “things and concepts”.

- Also, it is important to examine the potentially “bad outcomes” of immoral and unwise actions as well as of the tiring and stressful attempts to try to maintain things in optimum condition forever. The sooner we realize this, the less stressful it will be.

14. Finally, in those three sections on the body, *patikulamanasikarapabba*, *dhatumanasikarapabba*, and *navasivathikapabba*, we need to contemplate on not only our own body (this is what *ajjatta* means in these three sections), but also on the bodies of others (this is what *bahijja* means in these three sections).

- We can not only contemplate on other humans (famous, poor, rich, young, old, etc), but also on animals. It does not matter who or what it is, we all will eventually become dust. But, for many, this realization comes only after going through much effort in vain to keep the body “beautiful” via artificial means; then it could be too late.
- Therefore, *ajjatta* and *bahijja* means somewhat different things in these three sections

compared to other sections.

Maha Chattarisaka Sutta (Discourse on the Great Forty)

1. All *suttas* in one way or another describe the Path to *Nibbana*; there are numerous ways to analyze the Path.
 - In this *sutta*, the emphasis is on the 20 factors that lead to *Nibbana* (*Cooling Down of the mind*) and the opposing 20 factors that directs one away from *Nibbana* (to be trapped in the four lowest realms or *apayas*).
2. The Path to *Nibbana* is normally abbreviated as *sila* (virtue), *samadhi* (moral concentration), and *panna* (wisdom).
 - Without some level of wisdom one will not even start thinking about the Path. There are some people, no matter how much they listen or read about the Buddha's message, cannot see any benefit from it. Such people have no *sansaric* habit ("*gathi*") built up from past lives, and their minds are totally covered; this is the strong form of *avijja* called *moha*.
 - However, without some level of wisdom it is not possible to "see the Path". When we talk about "seeing the Path", it is not meant seeing with the eyes; it is seeing with the mind.
 - Thus the correct order is *panna*, *sila*, *samadhi*, and back to *panna* start again. This is a cyclic process: when one completes one round, one starts the next round with enhanced *panna*, and can "see more". The "seeing" will be complete only at the *Arahant* stage.
3. There are three kinds of "seeing": *micca ditthi* (wrong vision), mundane *samma ditthi* (vision for progress in this world), and transcendental *samma ditthi* (vision for attaining *Nibbana*).

When one's mind is totally covered with defilements (when one has *moha*), one is likely to believe in all or some of the 10 types of *micca ditthi*:

- there is no special person called a Buddha who discovers all of nature's laws by his own effort,
 - there are no instantaneous (*opapathika*) births,
 - father is not a special person,
 - mother is not a special person,
 - when one dies it is not possible to be born in other worlds,
 - there are no other worlds than the one we can experience,
 - what we enjoy/suffer in this life is not due to *kamma vipaka* but they "just happen",
 - giving does have any effects in future lives (i.e., there is no way to "carry over" merits to next life),
 - special types of giving (*mahā dāna*) do not have special merits,
 - giving (*dāna*) has no merits.
4. The other 10 factors that contribute to one's downfall RESULT FROM the above wrong views.
 - One is not likely to see the consequences of immoral thoughts and intentions (*micca sankappa*) in 3 categories: sensual lust (*kāma chanda*), ill-will (*vyapāda*), violence (*hinsā*).
 - Thus one will utter 4 types of *micca vaca*: lying (*musavada*), slandering (*pisunavaca*), harsh

speech (*parusavaca*), and empty speech (*sampappalapa*).

- And one will engage in 3 types of immoral bodily actions (*micca kammanta*): in killing living beings (*pānātipātā*) , taking the not-given (*adinnādānā*) , sexual misconduct and other extreme sensual activities (*kāmesu miccācārā*).

5. The more one does those 10 defiled actions by the mind, speech, and body, the stronger one's conviction of the 10 types of *micca ditthi* will become. Thus one will be trapped in a downward Path.

- Thus one will be engaged in immoral livelihoods (*micca ajiva*), make effort in such activities (*micca vayama*), build-up that mindset (*micca sati*), and solidify that kind of mindset (*micca samadhi*).
- Those in turn will strengthen *micca ditthi*, *micca sankappa*, *micca vaca*, *micca kammanta*.
- And so it goes on and on, pushing one downwards.

6. Therefore, those two sets of 10 factors each will lead one in the wrong way towards unimaginable suffering in future lives, and it will be very difficult to break away from them.

- Sometimes acts of occasional kindness or charity could open one's mind to the truth. This is probably the reason for the order: *sila*, *samadhi*, *panna*. Even occasional acts of virtue (*sila*) can get one pointed in the right direction.

7. As one removes more and more types of *micca ditthi*, one will start gaining *samma ditthi*, which means not having those 10 types of *micca ditthi*.

8. The *sutta* explains that there are 2 types of *samma ditthi*: **mundane (*lokiya*)**, and **transcendental (*lokottara*)**.

Initially, one sees the perils of *micca ditthi* (and associated immoral acts), and starts turning to mundane *samma ditthi*: One sees that things happen for a reason, and one could get into bad situations and bad births by doing immoral acts. One is motivated to do moral deeds and to seek good rebirths. *Now one does not have moha, but just avijja.*

- Thus one starts thinking moral thoughts (*samma sankappa*), uttering moral speech (*samma vaca*), abstain from immoral deeds (*samma kammanta*).
- Thus one will be engaged in moral livelihoods (*samma ajiva*), make effort in such activities (*samma vayama*), build-up that mindset (*samma sati*), and solidify that kind of mindset (*samma samadhi*).
- This eight factors constitute the **mundane Noble Eightfold Path**. One will be making progress towards “good rebirths”.

9. Then some of those on the mundane Noble Eightfold Path will start seeing the unique message of the Buddha, which says that one can NEVER find permanent happiness in this world (*lōkaya*).

- This is because, even if one makes sure to avoid the four lower realms (*apayas*) in the next birth by following the mundane Noble Eightfold Path, one will not be assured of anything in the births after that. Because we have no idea under what circumstances we will be born in the next life even if it is human.

10. As long as one has not attained the *Sotapanna* stage of *Nibbana*, it is inevitable that one will be born in the *apayas* in (distant) future. One may be born in the human or higher realms for a long time

to come due to the moral acts done in this life, but once that “good energy” is spent, past bad *kamma vipaka* will come to the surface.

- Thus, as long as we are born anywhere in these 31 realms, it will eventually lead to *dukkha* (suffering).
- Thus it is unfruitful to strive for such mundane happiness as a human, *deva*, or *brahma*. In the long run, none of those births will provide permanent happiness. We cannot maintain anything to our satisfaction in the long run anywhere. This is the concept of *anicca*.
- This is in fact the concept of *anatta*: that there is no place in the whole wider world of 31 realms that one could find refuge.

11. The realization of these three characteristics (*anicca, dukkha, anatta*) of this world (*lokaya*) is the point at which one grasps the ***lokottara samma ditthi***.

- Then one starts thinking moral thoughts (*samma sankappa*) on how to remove suffering FOREVER. Now one is not interested in merely seeking “good rebirths” because one realizes the futility of such efforts in the long term. This is ***lokottara samma sankappa***.
- One stops uttering immoral speech (*samma vaca*) and abstain from immoral deeds (*samma kammanta*), because one realizes that there is NO POINT in doing those things, not just because they lead to bad births. They are now ***lokottara samma vaca*** and ***lokottara samma kammanta***.
- These in turn will lead to ***lokottara*** types of ***samma ajiva, samma vayama, samma sati, and samma samadhi***.
- These eight factors constitute the ***lokottara Noble Eightfold Path*** that will take one progressively to stages of “higher cooling down” or *Nibbana* starting with the *Sotapanna* stage and ending in the *Arahant* stage.
- *Avijja* is gradually dispelled starting at the *Sotapanna* stage and completely removed at the *Arahant* stage; simultaneously, wisdom (*panna*) grows and becomes complete at the *Arahant* stage.

12. The uniqueness of Buddha Dhamma lies in the ***lokottara Noble Eightfold Path***. Other religions are focused on “how to live a moral life” (even if that has implications of permanent happiness in heaven), and that and more is embodied in the ***mundane Noble Eightfold Path***.

- Buddha Dhamma says living a moral life is not enough to attain permanent happiness (because even heaven is not permanent according to Buddha Dhamma). Ultimately, it requires relinquishing all desires for worldly things. [But the mindset to seek *Nibbana* via “relinquishing all desires for worldly things” is not even possible until one makes progress on the ***mundane Noble Eightfold Path***. The mind needs to be purified to some extent even to realize the futility of existence anywhere in the 31 realms.](#)
- Through most of the recent past, the genuine ***lokottara Noble Eightfold Path*** had been hidden together with the true nature of the world as described by the real meanings of *anicca, dukkha, anatta*; most have been practicing the ***mundane Noble Eightfold Path***. It is easy for most people to connect with the ***mundane Noble Eightfold Path*** simply because it is mundane, i.e., concepts that we are already comfortable with.
- But as the Buddha said, his Dhamma “had never been heard before...”, as he emphasized in the

Dhamma Cakka Pavattana sutta: “pubbe ananussutesu dhammesu...”.

References

- “[Introduction to “Rebirth by Francis Story” – Ian Stevenson](#)”
- “[Thirty One Planes of Existence](#)”
- “[Reflections on 2014](#)”
- “[Mars Curiosity Photos Suggest Life May Have Existed on Red Planet](#)”
- “[Curiosity Rover finds Crater probably was once a Giant Martian Lake](#)”
- “[Recent Publications on Benefits of Meditation](#)”
- “[Laniakea: Our home supercluster](#)”
- “[Think Outside the Box!](#)”
- “[There are as many creatures on your body as there are people on Earth!](#)”
- “[News Article on Robin Williams and Buddhist Meditation](#)”
- “[World Historical Timeline](#)”
- “[Second Largest Religion by State in the US](#)”

Introduction to “Rebirth by Francis Story” – Ian Stevenson

The following are the scanned pages from the book, “Rebirth-as Doctrine and Experience” by Francis Story. The first scan is an inside cover page, and the rest are the Introduction pages by Ian Stevenson. Dr. Stevenson mentions that he is a Buddhist on page 3. The whole introduction is insightful.

[Introduction-Stevenson \(PDF file\)](#)

Thirty One Planes of Existence

Here is a video from Carl Sagan to get an idea how vast our “detectable universe” is:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5Ex_M-OwSA&x-yc-cl=85114404&feature=player_embedded

The “world view” of the Buddha is not merely about the living beings on this planet. Our Solar system is one of an infinite number of “world systems” (planetary systems). In EACH planetary system with life (scientists have not found even one yet; but they are out there!), there are 31 “planes of existence”. As we find out below, we can “see” only two of these realms: our human realm and the animal realm. Thus our “world” is much more complex than even the present-day science believes. As some of you may already know, science cannot account for 95% of the mass of the universe, which they label “dark energy” and “dark matter”. This is why I say that the Buddha transcended “this world”. He was able to “see” the whole of existence: see “Godel’s Incompleteness Theorem” under “Dhamma and Science”.

Now, it is not easy to describe the 31 planes of existence in a short essay. Therefore, I will use a visual to simplify things a bit.

Imagine a sphere with 31 shells, with a small sphere in the middle. Thus the total volume of the big sphere is completely filled by the center sphere and surrounding shells. The 31 sections represent the 31 planes of existence. I emphasize that this is just a visual. The reality is different. For example, animal and human realms co-exist in reality. Also, both time and space are infinite in reality.

1. The innermost sphere represent the Niraya (hell) where there is non-stop suffering; next is the animal realm. Going outward there are two more realms where suffering is higher than at the human realm (the fifth shell). The sixth through eleventh shells represent the realms of the devas (wrongly translated as gods by many), beings who enjoy higher level of mundane happiness and no suffering. These innermost 11 shells represent the kamaloka, where all five physical sense faculties are present.
2. The next 16 shells represent realms where only two physical sense faculties (eye and ear) are active. These beings have very fine (less dense) bodies. These are called rupa lokas.
3. The last 4 shells represent the arupa lokas, where beings have ultra fine bodies and only the mind faculty; no physical senses.
4. In rupa and arupa lokas, the beings are in jhanic states. These states can be attained by humans and thus a humans can “temporarily live” in those lokas by attaining jhanas. The 16 realms in the rupa loka correspond to the four lower jhanas, and the 4 realms in the arupa loka correspond to the higher four jhanas.
5. Any living being (including each of us) has been in all realms in this beginning-less samsara. We have been in the niraya (hell) and we have been at the highest (except on arupa loka which can be accessed only by Anagamis or Non-Returners). One time the Buddha pointed to a bunch of ants on the ground and told bhikkhus that each of those ants had lived in a Brahma loka. The sansara is that long; there is no discernible beginning.
6. Above the human realm, there is no suffering (except at death, which is inevitable). However, unless one has achieved at least the Stream Entry (Sotapanna) stage, even a being at the highest level can fall to any lower level, and thus will end up in the niraya (hell) at some point; once there one will spend a long agonizing time there and eventually come out. Each of us have done this many times

over. I will explain the cause of births in different realms in terms of “kamma seeds” in upcoming posts.

7. So, each living being just moves from one realm to another, but spends most time in the four lower worlds, mainly because once fallen there it is hard to come out. This “samsaric wandering” is the critical point to think about and comprehend.

8. As one moves away from the center the level of suffering decreases, and level of mundane pleasure increases up to the 11th realm. After that in the rupa and arupa lokas it is mainly the jhanic pleasures, not the sense pleasures.

9. The human realm is the only one from which one can attain Nibbana. Nibbana, in this model, corresponds to getting out of all 31 shells, out of the big sphere; no more rebirth in any of the 31 realms. Nibbana is where the permanent sukha or niramisa sukha, is. When one attains Nibbana or Arahantship, he/she looks just like any other human, but has no attachments to any worldly things. He still has some kamma vipaka to pay off from the kamma seed that he was born with. When that kammic power is used up, he dies and is not reborn because there are no kamma seeds left to start a new birth. He/she is in Parinibbana with niramisa sukha.

10. Can we taste Nibbanic “pleasure”? Yes. We can taste it in increments, even below the Stream Entry stage. This is niramisa sukha, the “pleasure of giving up worldly things”. This niramisa sukha has “quantum jumps” at the four stages of Nibbana: Stream Entry, Once-Returner, Non-Returner, Arahant. Thus when one is on the Path, one can experience niramisa sukha at varying degrees, all the way to Nibbanic bliss, during this very lifetime.

11. All these 31 realms are located in our solar system (Chakrawata), and are associated with the Earth. There are a great number of such Chakrawata (planetary systems) in existence at all times with living beings. These are in clusters of small (galaxies?), medium (universes?), and large (multiverse?) “world systems”. But none is permanent. They come into being and eventually perish. Within the past 100 years or so, scientists have confirmed the existence of billions of planetary systems within galaxies in our universe, and are now exploring the possibility of the existence of multiple universes (multiverse).

The other big factor to take into account is that we have been born in almost all of these realms in our samsaric journey that has no traceable beginning. All of us have been bouncing around “inside the sphere” (mainly in the inner ones) from a beginning that is not even discernible to a Buddha.

Next, “[Samsaric Time Scale](#)“,

Reflections on 2014

January 1, 2015

I started the website sometime in early January of 2014. Since there is no discussion forum at the site, I thought of making a summary on the 52 comments (excluding follow-up correspondence) that I received over the year (I did respond to all individual comments).

1. First of all, my heartfelt thanks for the many kind comments on the usefulness of the site.
2. Some people (mainly those I know personally) “complained” that once they start reading, they “got absorbed” in the material and they could not get to their “daily tasks”. This could be a concern for some others as well. The easiest solution is to set an alarm.
 - I assure everyone that once one gets a “foothold” one will become more responsible for their families, not the other way around. As one begins to understand the true message of the Buddha, one will start allocating one’s time wisely, taking time away from “entertainment” rather than from those tasks that are one’s responsibilities.
 - As some of you may have already noticed, one becomes more thoughtful and considerate, when one starts truly understanding the message of the Buddha. One realizes that we all are in the same boat, trudging along in this tedious rebirth process, and one feels true compassion for others. One will not shy away from one’s responsibilities to anyone let alone to one’s family.
 - If you do get absorbed in the material, it is not to my credit. From experience, I know that pure Dhamma is much more satisfying and fulfilling than any sense pleasure (even before the *jhanas*). Learning Dhamma is learning about nature in a way that had not been possible before the Buddha! And there is no other task that is more important than one’s own “long-term” future.
3. There were several people who made suggestions for new posts. Such suggestions are always welcome. If I have not responded to a couple of requests that is because of a reason. I do not want to “jump ahead” until the background material is presented. Please do not shy away from making suggestions.
4. Another important comment was that, “in the *Satipattana sutta*, didn’t the the Buddha recommend the “breathing meditation” contrary to what I described as *anapana*?”. If one is reading the *sutta* as commonly translated these days, that is indeed what the translations say. But we need to examine the Pali text of the *sutta* to get the correct interpretation. I plan to write a series of posts on the *Satipattana sutta* carefully going through the Pali text.
 - And we need to sort out the types of meditation recommended by the Buddha from those that have been practiced by *Hindu yogis* and are described in the *Visuddhimagga*. I think this is a “mental block” for even *Theravada* Buddhists. Unless one sits down and stay like a statue, it does not count as “meditation” for many people.
 - Those days, Buddha’s primary recommendation was to listen to Dhamma discourses. Many people attained *magga phala* just by listening to such discourses. The *Satipattana sutta* was delivered in the later years for *bhikkhus* who needed systematic guidance.

- If one pays attention, one can get to *samadhi* while listening (and also while reading) Dhamma concepts. I highly recommend reading posts at this site at a quiet time, and see whether it makes you more calm. It will help in getting to *jhanas* in the longer term.
- Whether listening or reading, one should fully concentrate on the subject, and may even want to stop reading and think about the material when a new concept is discussed. Then the mind focuses on that point and automatically gets to *samadhi*. This is the key to removing defilements from the mind (which are the biggest chunk that in turn trigger other defilements). When one focuses on a “worldly thing” such as breath or a *kasina* object, that just gets the mind to *samadhi*, without doing any cleansing.

5. One does not even need to do any formal meditation initially. If one can spend some “quality time” (quite times where one can think as one reads) a few times a week, that would be more than enough. As with anything with the mind, the mind will ask for more as needed (this is the *chanda* and *citta* part in the *Satara Iddhipada* of *chanda*, *citta*, *viriya*, *vimansa*). And when the mind asks for it, that is the best time to start getting absorbed in the material, making the effort (*viriya*) and critically examining the key concepts (*vimansa*).

- One can get all the way to the *Sotapanna* stage by just comprehending the main message that the Buddha was trying to convey: In the long run, it is unprofitable to strive for material things in this world. That there is a happiness of better quality when one loses craving for sense pleasures.
- **But that cannot be achieved by “forcefully giving up sense pleasures”, doing “breath meditation”, or just by following the five precepts.** Rather, by understanding the deep message of the Buddha about the “real nature of this world”, one’s mind gradually realizes the futility of seeking sense pleasures as one gradually comprehends *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*. Dhamma will be the guide.

6. I very much want to highlight the fact that Buddha Dhamma is not about hiding in a remote place and shying away from the society or subjecting oneself to harsh living.

- It is not those enticing or seducing things that make us do immoral things and make our minds stressed in turn; rather it is our own defiled minds (defilements can vary from vile to just being ignorant of the true nature of the world) making us do immoral things.
- One with a purified mind can live in the most seductive place and yet not be perturbed.
- But to get there, one needs **some self-control** to stay away from such extremes initially. **Learning pure Dhamma is the only way to break through that first barrier.** Once the *Sotapanna* stage is attained, one will never go back.

Happy New Year! May the Blessings of the Triple Gem be with you always!

Mars Curiosity Photos Suggest Life May Have Existed on Red Planet

“A careful study of images taken by the NASA rover Curiosity has revealed intriguing similarities between ancient sedimentary rocks on Mars and structures shaped by microbes on Earth. The findings suggest, but do not prove, that life may have existed earlier on the Red Planet”:

[Mars Curiosity Photos Suggest Life May Have Existed on Red Planet](#)

Here is the pdf of the paper just published that proposed the hypothesis:

[Life on Mars Hypothesis-Noffke-Astrobiology-2015](#)

Curiosity Rover finds Crater probably was once a Giant Martian Lake

According to Buddha Dhamma we are alone in the universe. These preliminary results from the NASA Curiosity Rover may not hold up in the end as evidence that life existed on Mars. But there will many more to come, especially if technology is developed to explore distant stars.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?feature=player_embedded&v=Y3GRXLkcoZg

Here is a report that came out today, Dec 9, 2014, which has another video by NASA:

<http://www.dailymail.co.uk/sciencetech/article-2865886/Mars-warm-wet-entire-PLANET-Curiosity-rover-reveals-crater-mountain-exploring-giant-lake.html>

Recent Publications on Benefits of Meditation

There have been an accelerated activity in studying the benefits of meditation on the brain and on physical health in general. Here are some very recent publications:

- Scientific American November 2014 (volume 311, Number 5) cover story is “Mind of the Meditator”, by M. Ricard et al. : [Ricard-Mind of the Meditator- Scientific American – November 2014](#)
- A paper that just came out online in early November (in the journal *Cancer*) reports that the [telomeres](#) – the protein caps at the end of our chromosomes that determine how quickly a cell ages – stayed the same length in cancer survivors who meditated or took part in support groups over a three-month period: [Carlson-Mindfulness based Cancer recovery-2014](#)

I have discussed the effects of changing habits on the brain (which is more related to insight meditation): see, “[Truine Brain: How the Mind Rewires the Brain via Meditation/Habits](#)“. Insight meditation can be expected to have much more significant changes in the brain as well as in physical health. But such studies have not been conducted yet. Selected references on research studies (2011-2012) and books related to meditation can be found in that post; there have been many more publications since then.

I was surprised to come across the following article in the prestigious journal “Science” which, using real time input from 5000 people all over the world, confirmed what the Buddha said 2500 years ago: that a wandering mind is an unhappy mind; see, [A wandering mind is an unhappy mind-Science-Killingsworth-2010](#).

Much merits to Neranga for sending me the second publication.

Laniakea: Our home supercluster

Superclusters – regions of space that are densely packed with galaxies – are the biggest structures in the Universe. But scientists have struggled to define exactly where one supercluster ends and another begins. Now, a team based in Hawaii has come up with a new technique that maps the Universe according to the flow of galaxies across space. Redrawing the boundaries of the cosmic map, they redefine our home supercluster and name it Laniakea, which means ‘immeasurable heaven’ in Hawaiian (from Nature Video)

https://www.youtube.com/watch?feature=player_embedded&v=rENyyRwxpHo

- It is amazing to see how unfathomably vast our “world” is, even though this is only a small part of even our universe. However, imagine this together with uncountable worlds teeming with life, that we are not aware of! This is why the Buddha said not to spend time exploring the details of this “world”. There is no end to it, either spacewise or timewise.
- But we need to keep in mind that only human minds can even comprehend such things. If we are to be born an animal or worse this kind of thinking is not possible, and we will get trapped in such worlds for unimaginably long times. Thus what we need to do is to take advantage of the brief time we have in this life to comprehend the true nature of ‘this world’, i.e., *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*, and to become free of it.

Think Outside the Box!

1. Here is an interesting presentation on the question of what motivates people. Embedded in this presentation is the fact that without self-motivation coming from self-satisfaction, it is hard to examine things from different perspectives. It works the other way too: new insights in turn provide motivation:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?list=PL70DEC2B0568B5469&feature=player_embedded&v=rrkrvAUbU9Y

- One of my goals has been to help others to achieve the same exhilarating experience that I have had learning and practising pure Dhamma. It cannot be matched by any other experience.

2. Many people do things just because others do, and follow the “standard practices”. In following Buddha Dhamma too, many just do what their parents or other “established authorities” do. It may be a good idea to pause and re-examine some deeply-embedded ideas. Each person may have his/her own set of “beliefs”.

- Some think it is enough to say some precepts and may be chant or listen to chantings to follow the Path.
- Others think it is silly to do those exact same things. And what needs to be done is to learn *Abhidhamma* at the deepest level.
- I think there is a value in each, if done properly. And what needs to be given priority in one’s practice should be in line with one’s own preferences, but the horizons need to be expanded to look into other aspects once-in-a-while and see whether there is something to be gained from those too. Our perspectives change as we make progress.

3. Yet, no matter what one does, real progress cannot be even STARTED without understanding the main message of the Buddha: the true nature of this world, i.e., *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.

- It makes a huge difference between the interpretation of *anicca* as “impermanence” or “not being able to maintain to one’s satisfaction”. Same with *anatta* as “no-self” or “one ends up truly helpless trying to seek happiness in this rebirth process”.
- See, “[Anicca, Dukkha, Anatta – Wrong Interpretations](#)” and the follow-up posts.

There are as many creatures on your body as there are people on Earth!

Before the simple microscope was invented in the late 1500's, people could see only those animals visible to the naked eye. Life seemed to explode when Van Leeuwenhoek reported the discovery of micro-organisms in 1676; he first reported numerous "microscopic creatures" in a glass of water.

With the new scientific instruments we can "see" even more minute lifeforms:

https://www.youtube-nocookie.com/watch?feature=player_embedded&v=QrmashOX5EU

The number of people on this Earth is insignificantly small compared to the number of other beings (seen and unseen), or even just the animals. As the above video shows, there are a huge number of living beings even on a human body; imagine how many would be on the body of an unclean animal. This is why the Buddha said it is extremely difficult to get a human birth; see, "[How the Buddha Described the Chance of Rebirth in the Human Realm](#)".

It must be noted that Buddha's disciples (and probably other *Hindu yogis*) were able to "see" such microscopic creatures with their *abhinna* powers. There is a story in the *Tipitaka* about a *bhikkhu* with *abhinna* powers (but not yet attained *Arahanthood*) once focused his powers to a glass of water that he was about to drink and saw a multitude of tiny creatures. He kept trying to filter them out and was getting distressed. The Buddha saw this and told the *bhikkhu* that it is not possible to live in this world without hurting other beings, but that does not count as an immoral act since the intention is not to hurt.

- For example, if we have a wound on the head, we have to apply medication and get it healed; otherwise one may even die from that. Yet, numerous tiny creatures on the wound die when we apply the medication. There is nothing we can do to avoid it unless we are willing to risk our own life.
- But the point is that this single human life is much more "worthy" than all those creatures multiplied many times over; see, "[How to Evaluate Weights of Different Kamma](#)".
- This is an important point because many people get stressed over even cleaning their house for the fear of killing insects. But if we do not keep the house clean, those insects will multiply and make the problem even bigger. One always need to look at things with a deeper understanding. The best thing to do is to keep the house clean so that insects are not attracted in the first place.
- It is important to clarify these concepts, because it is difficult to attain any kind of calmness (*samadhi*) in the mind if one's mind is agitated by such things as "Am I sitting on some unseen tiny insects and killing them?". As long as our intent is not directed to willfully taking another life with hatred, there will not be any negative consequences.

News Article on Robin Williams and Buddhist Meditation

I have not read the books written by the author of this following news article, so I cannot comment on his books. But I thought this sad news about Robin Williams illustrates the concept of *anicca* (that one cannot maintain anything to one's satisfaction in this world and that there is hidden suffering). He had more than enough money and fame, but apparently he was depressed in the latter years.

- Having a peaceful mind cannot be matched by any amount of money or fame; see, “First Noble Truth – A Simple Explanation of One Aspect”.
- According to the Buddha, the suffering is proportional to the craving. Getting old is more stressful for those who have enjoyed beauty, fame, power, etc. But the inevitability of old age and dying is common to us all.
 - Buddhist meditation is primarily on understanding the true nature of the world and that hidden suffering may come out unexpectedly; that understanding itself makes one have a peaceful mind; see, “[Introduction to Buddhist Meditation](#)”.
 - When depression or old age hits, the mind gets weak. Thus one should preferably start when the mind is sound and healthy.
 - Suicide can only make things worse in the “long term” in the rebirth process. It is never too late to start at any stage. Human life is rare and should not be wasted at any stage.

Article: [Meditation Isn't Enough: A Buddhist Perspective on Suicide](#)

World Historical Timeline

It will be convenient to have a timeline of the major world events that I can refer to in my posts. Please let me know any errors that you may see. My goal is to provide a consistent and accurate timeline.

Note: I used c. to denote *circa* or about

I have added descriptive links to some events, and will try to add more links in the future.

Date	Event
Before 10k BCE	Last Ice Age
3.1k BCE	First king of Egypt, King Menes
2.5k BCE	Mohenjo Daro civilization in India
2.1k - 1.6k BCE	The Xia Dynasty of China
Before 1.7k BCE	Abraham came to Jerusalem from Ur (Old Testament)
1.4k BCE	City of Troy, kingdom of Crete, and other Greek cities
1.4k - 0.9k BCE	Olmec civilization in Mexico
776 BCE	First Olympiad
558-530 BCE	Cyrus ruled North India
Until 536 BCE	Daries I, II, III ruled North India; until Chandagupta, Persian and Greek kings ruled North India
563-483 BCE	Buddha Gotama
470-399 BCE	Philosopher Socrates
538 BCE	Old Testament was written
424-348 BCE	Plato: First Western philosopher whose writings survived intact
384 - 322 BCE	Aristotle: student of Plato and teacher of Alexander the Great
c. 333 BCE	Emperor Alexander's Empire peaks
323 - 325 BCE	Alexander the Great in India
268-231 BCE	Emperor Asoka ruled North India
307-276 BCE	King Devanampiyatissa in Sri Lanka
247 BCE	Ven. Mahinda in Anuradhapura, Sri Lanka
41 BCE	Beginning of the Roman Empire
29 BCE	Tipitaka written down in Sri Lanka
6–4 BC to 30–33 AD	Jesus of Nazareth or Jesus Christ
31 BCE	Augustus becomes the first Roman Emperor and ruled until 14 CE
c. 150-250 CE	Life of Nagarjuna ; considered to be the founder of Mahayana Buddhism
After 200 CE	Roman empire starts to decline
4th century CE	Buddhism introduced to Korea
380 CE	Christianity became the official religion in Roman empire

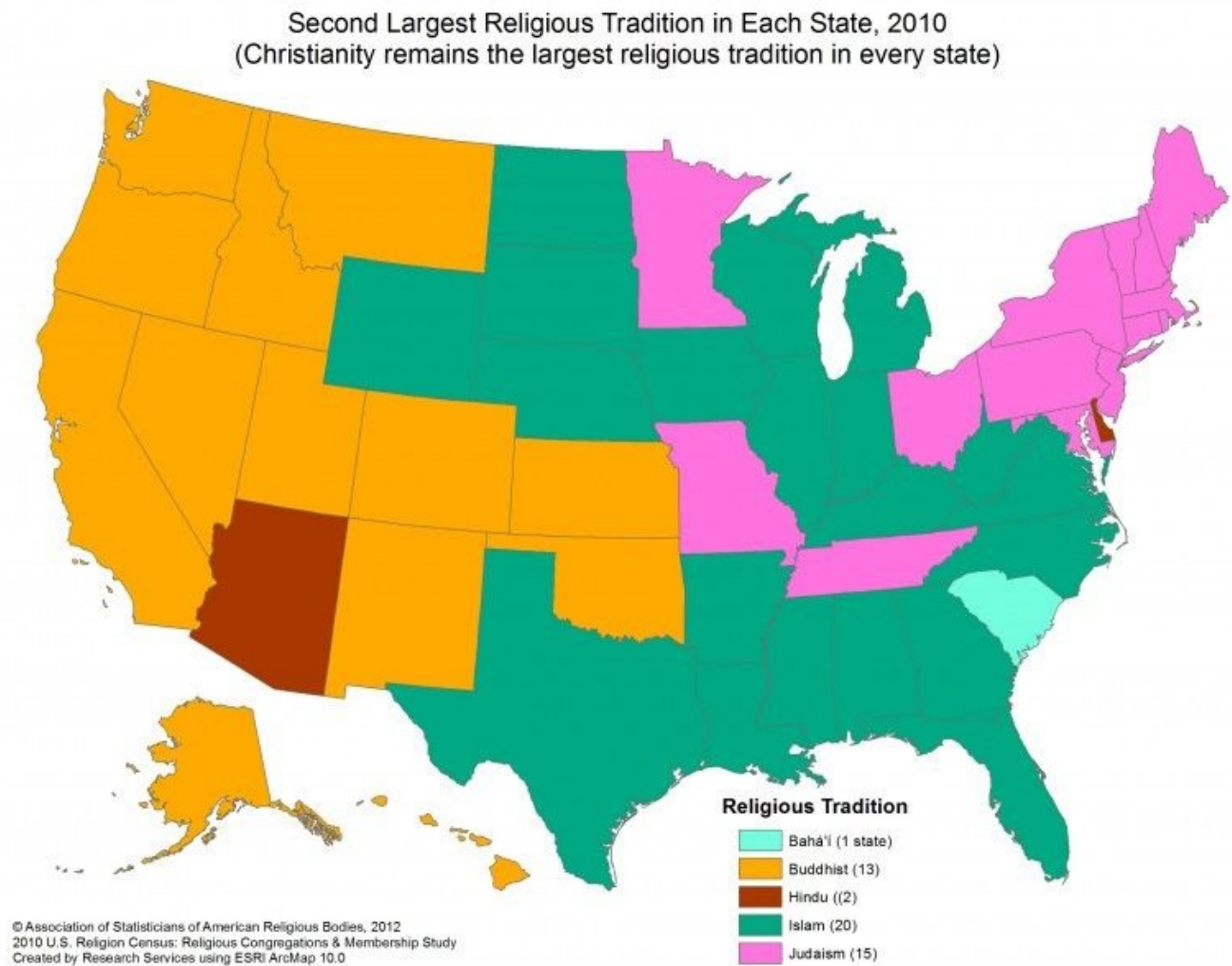
5th century CE	Burma adopts Theravada Buddhism
412-434 CE	Buddhaghosa arrives in Sri Lanka and writes Visuddhimagga
552 CE	Buddhism enters Japan from Korea
589 CE	First Chinese commentaries written
586 CE	Beginning of the Dark Ages in Europe with the decay of the Roman empire
6th century CE	First diffusion of Buddhism in Tibet
570-632 CE	Prophet Muhammad
622 CE - (1258-1492) CE	Islamic Golden Age
618-907 CE	Chinese T'ang dynasty; golden age of Buddhism in China
1215 CE	King John signs the Magna Carta granting rights to English citizens
1280	Eyeglasses invented in Italy
c. 1420 - c. 1600	Renaissance in Europe starting in Florence, Italy
1450	Gutenberg in Germany invents the printing press
1492	Modern Age begins with the arrival of Columbus in America
1610	Galelio announces observation of mountains on the Moon and the existence of four planets.
1642	Adding machine invented by Blaise Pascal
c. 1650 - c. 1800	European "Enlightenment"
1687	Newton published Principia Mathematica
1688	English revolution
1698	Steam engine invented by Thomas Savery
1774	Priestly isolates oxygen
1776	America declares independence from England
1789	French revolution period
1791	Steamboat invented by John Fitch
1798	Vaccination invented by Edward Jenner
1804	Locomotive invented by Richard Trevithick
1821	Faraday demonstrates the principle of the electric motor
1822	Charles Babbage designs his first mechanical computer
1826	Photography invented by Joseph Nicephore Niepce
1834	Refrigerator invented by Jacob Perkins
1835	Morse code invented by Samuel Morse
1837	American Samuel Morse invented telegraph
1842	Anaesthesia invented by Crawford Long
1843	Typewriter invented by Charles Thurber

1846	Rotary printing press invented by Richard M. Hoe
1859	Charles Darwin publishes The Origin of Species
1869	Mendeleev produces the Periodic Table
1873	Maxwell states the laws of electro-magnetic radiation
1877	Phonograph invented by Thomas Alva Edison;Microphone invented by Emile Berliner
1878	Edison invents the incandescent lamp
1883	First skyscraper built in Chicago (ten stories)
1888	Hertz produces radio waves
1893	Wireless communication invented by Nikola Tesla
1895	Diesel engine invented by Rudolf Diesel
1898	Remote control invented by Nikola Tesla
1900	Planck develops quantum theory
1901	Vacuum cleaner invented by Hubert Booth
1903	Powered airplane invented by Wilbur Wright and Orville Wright
1905	Einstein’s Theory of Relativit
1907	Color photography invented by Auguste and Louis Lumiere
1908	Henry Ford mass-produces the Model T
1919	London to Paris air service begins
1923	Sound film invented by Lee DeForest
1923	Edwin Hubble discovers the first galaxy other than Milky Way
1928	Antibiotics, penicillin invented by Alexander Fleming
1937	Jet engine invented by Frank Whittle and Hans von Ohain
1937	Alan Turing develops the concept of a theoretical computing machine
1945	The atomic bomb
1951	Nuclear power reactor invented by Walter Zinn
1957	Sputnik I and Sputnik II: Sputnik I and Sputnik II are launched by the Russians
1958	The first integrated circuit, or silicon chip, is produced by the US Jack Kilby & Robert Noyce
1960	Laser invented by Theodore Harold Maiman
1961	Uri Gagarin is the first man in space
1965	The Big Bang theory confirmed by Penzias and Wilson
1969	Neil Armstrong sets foot on the moon
1971	E-mail invented by Ray Tomlinson
1971	Floppy Disk invented by David Noble with IBM
1973	Ethernet invented by Bob Metcalfe and David Boggs

1973	Personal computer invented by Xerox PARC
1983	Camcorder invented by Sony
1990	World Wide Web invented by Tim Berners-Lee
2001	World center attack
2001	Digital satellite radio
2003	Completion of the Human Genome Project
2008	Discovery of ice on Mars
2014	First comet landing
2014	NASA completes a successful test flight of Orion spacecraft for future trips to Mars

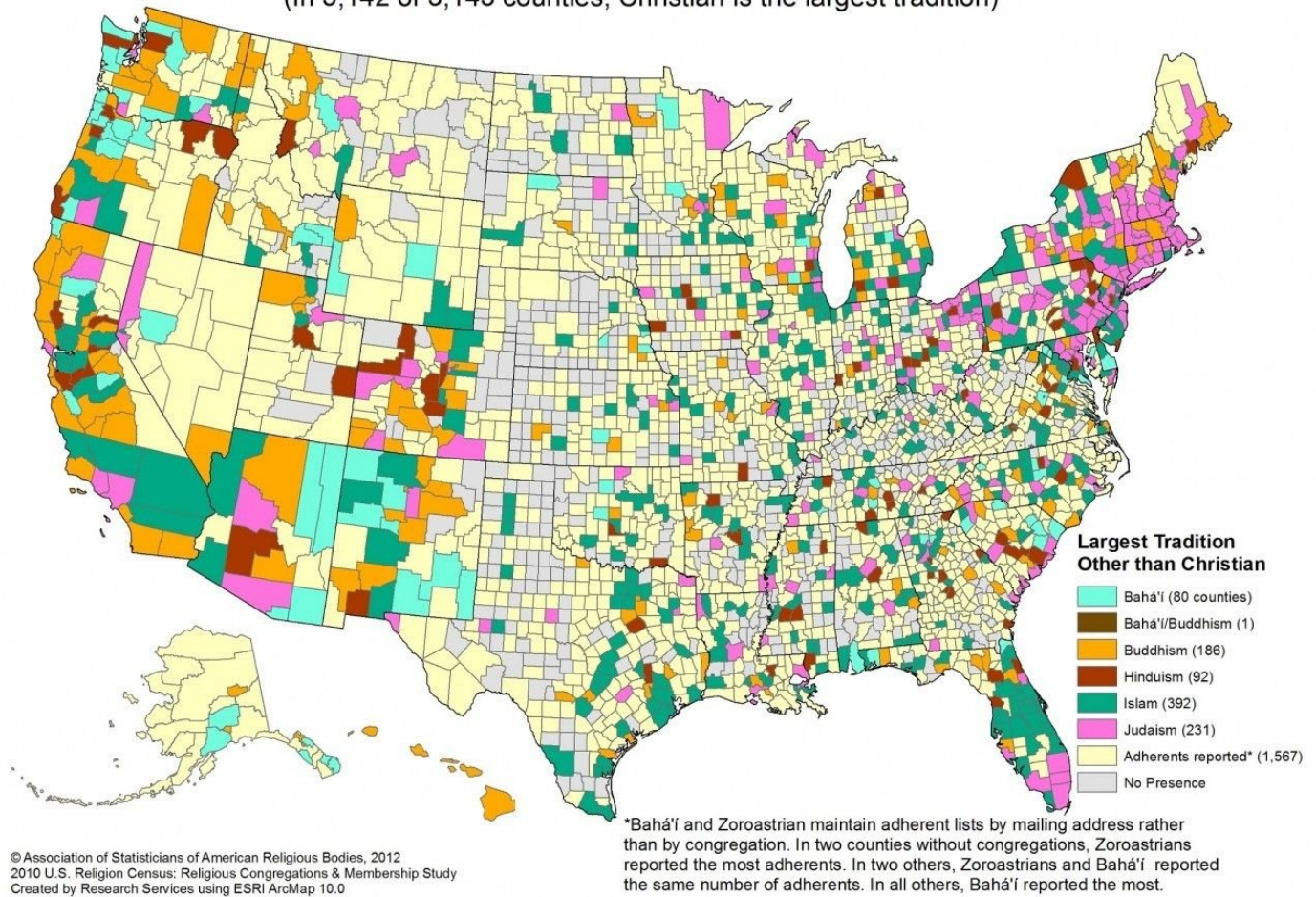
Second Largest Religion by State in the US

The second largest religion by state in the United States (2010):



http://boingboing.net/2014/06/05/christianity-is-the-top-religi.html/1999eastst?fk_bb

Largest Non-Christian Tradition by County
(In 3,142 of 3,143 counties, Christian is the largest tradition)



However, Buddha Dhamma is not a religion, in the sense of providing a set of guidelines to live by. It is about the natural laws of nature. Any person of any religious faith (or no faith in any religion, i.e., atheist) can follow Dhamma and benefit. All religions are about leading a good moral life, but Buddha Dhamma describes a much more comprehensive “world view” where this life of 100 years is just a blip.

If one becomes convinced of the truth of the Buddha’s world view, i.e., that this life is not the only we had or we will have, and that there are consequences to one’s actions, and the only way to get relief from inevitable suffering at least at the old age and death is to purify one’s mind, then the person is a Buddhist. It is all in one’s mind. No one else is tracking one’s progress, and no one else can purify one’s own mind.

Buddha Dhamma – In a Chart

[Buddha Dhamma – In a Chart](#)

Discussion of the chart is at:

[What is Unique in Buddha Dhamma?](#)